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Early Childhood

The Great Afternoon

Cartoons Are for Life: The Secret Password & The Afternoon Sanctuary

Date: 1994-05-18 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — The Secret Password

Three polite, measured knocks sounded against the painted wood of my closed bedroom door just as the red digital clock on the cable converter box ticked to 3:29.

"Cartoons are for life," came Katie's voice through the wood, hushed and completely serious.

The secret password was given. Immediately, I scrambled up off the dark low-pile carpet of my deep-blue bedroom and swung the door open to admit my twin sister just in time for our favorite afternoon block of cartoons. Having just turned nine years old back on April eighth, neither of us cared what the other kids on our street in Virginia Beach were doing after the school bus dropped us off. School was six straight hours of scraping desks, unpredictable bells, and teachers who tried to seat fraternal twins on opposite sides of the hallway just because I was a boy and Katie

was a girl. To the teachers at school and the adults in our extended family, I was Nathaniel, though Dad and Katie half the time just called me Nate; behind this door, I was simply the other half of Katie's perimeter.

Katie slipped inside, her long, straight platinum-blonde hair swinging past her shoulders as she pulled the door shut behind her until the latch clicked. We didn't need to explain to anyone else why we had a password for a room ten feet away from her own bedroom down the hall. Most weekday afternoons, our paternal grandmother, Grandma Ruth—Dad's retired mother, Ruth Prairie, who lived off her pension and Social Security right down the upstairs hall in our fourth bedroom—was downstairs in the living room watching us alongside our nine-year-old maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher whenever Brittany's parents, Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve, worked odd shift hours and drove her up from their farm down on Blackwater Road. On Wednesday afternoons, however, Aunt Karen had midweek shift swap off while Grandma Ruth went to her senior sewing circle until five—and out in the rest of the house, the afternoon air was already heavy. Mom had locked her bedroom door at two o'clock with another headache and a glass from the kitchen cabinet, and Dad wouldn't be home from work until five-thirty to start dinner. Behind my closed door, though, the rules belonged entirely to the two of us.

I rushed back across the carpet and pressed the power button on the front of the television and the cable converter box just as the Majestic Studios castle logo and the afternoon cartoon block bumper flashed across the curved glass tube.

The opening brass fanfare of the *Galactic Samurai Geckos* theme song burst out of the small speaker grille, and instantly, both of us got completely carried away. Katie grabbed both of my hands, and for the next sixty seconds we bounced on the balls of our feet in the middle of the carpet, belting out every single word of the intro theme in unison while the animated title cards rolled across the screen.

Then, just as quickly, the final drumbeat of the opening theme faded out, the episode title card appeared, and the two of us were brought gently back to earth.

Without letting go of my hand, Katie climbed up onto the sofa cushions right beside me and wrapped both of her arms tightly around my ribs, resting her cheek against my shoulder. I adjusted the volume knob down two notches so the dialogue wouldn't echo into the hallway, wrapped both of my arms around my twin sister in a close, steady embrace, and let the deep, familiar pressure of holding each other anchor us in place while the afternoon cartoons glowed across the quiet room.

Summer Camp at Virginia Dominion University

The Parallel Pair: Dominion Mall & The VDU Fieldhouse

Date: 1994-07-12 at 08:45 America/New_York

8:45 AM — Two Pairs on Dominion Mall

"All right, Youth Division, let's buddy up in two lines for the walk across Dominion Mall!" Counselor Brad announced over the splash of the circular concrete plaza fountain, tapping his wooden clipboard with a grin.

Standing on the wide, sun-bleached concrete plaza of Virginia Dominion University in Norfolk at eight-forty-five in the morning, wearing matching royal-blue VDU Summer Camp t-shirts over our shorts, Katie immediately tightened her fingers around my right wrist. When our dad, David Prairie, had signed the two of us up for this two-week, all-day camp block—running from nine o'clock in the morning until four o'clock in the afternoon—he had wanted to keep us safely out of the house in July while he was at work. Katie and I had our own rule for surviving six hours a day around fifteen noisy, unfamiliar kids: we were not letting go of each other.

Two paces ahead of us in the Youth Division line, I noticed we weren't the only brother and sister operating on that exact protocol.

A nine-year-old boy with reddish-blond hair and wire-rimmed glasses—whose name tag read *Michael*—and his seven-year-old sister *Rachel*, who had dark shoulder-length hair and glasses of her own, were standing hip-to-hip with their fingers laced together in a white-knuckled grip while their fourteen-year-old sister adjusted her backpack beside them before heading over to the Senior Division group. Just like Katie and me, Michael and Rachel didn't care about the cartoons or baseball cards the other campers were shouting about; they were holding onto each other like their lives depended on it.

Naturally, the two college-age counselors running our Youth Division—Counselor Brad and Counselor Kelly—looked at the four of us and reached the exact wrong conclusion.

"Look at this—we've got two brothers and two sisters right next to each other!" Brad called out brightly. "Let's mix it up today so the boys can hang out with the boys and the girls can hang out with the girls! Michael, step right back here and pair up with Nathaniel! And Rachel, you team up with Katie!"

Before I could protest, Brad guided me a step forward beside Michael, while Kelly gently steered Katie two steps back beside Rachel.

For four seconds, the counselors' geometry held.

I looked sideways at Michael through the thick Tidewater humidity. Michael looked sideways at me behind his wire-rimmed glasses. Neither of us had anything against the other—in fact, I could tell in half a heartbeat that his brain hated the sudden change in the line just as much as mine did. Behind us, Katie wasn't saying a word to Rachel, and Rachel wasn't saying a word to Katie; both of our sisters were staring straight at the backs of our blue camp shirts with their shoulders stiff and their jaws locked tight.

Michael and I didn't need to say a single word out loud. As soon as Counselor Brad turned his back and held his clipboard up in the air to lead the group across the light-gray concrete squares of Dominion Mall, Michael gave me a tiny, solemn nod, and I nodded right back.

I stepped half a pace to my left. Michael stepped half a pace to his right. In the exact same motion, Katie slipped forward to grab my hand again, and Rachel stepped right back into place on Michael's left flank.

By the time our sneakers clicked across the second concrete expansion joint past the circular fountain toward the precast-concrete and blue-glass facade of the University Library, the boy-and-girl experiment was completely over. It was brother and sister on the left, and twin brother and twin sister on the right.

9:30 AM — Terminal 4 and Terminal 5

At nine-thirty, the counselors ushered us out of the ninety-degree heat into the sixty-eight-degree air conditioning of the university computer lab.

Thirty beige desktop towers running *Quantum OS* and curved CRT monitors lined the walls, their cooling fans humming in a low, steady chord behind rows of mechanical *KeyMech* keyboards. I loved computers almost as much as I loved our afternoon cartoons, and Katie loved sitting beside me while we took turns with the mouse and keyboard.

Counselor Brad, however, still hadn't given up on his clipboard chart.

"Okay, campers, listen up!" Brad called out from the front desk, holding up a plastic tray of 3.5-inch floppy disks. "Boys on the left wall row—we've got *Wagon Train West* and *Where on the Map Is Scarlet Devereaux?* loaded up! Girls on the right wall row for *Digit Chompers* and *PixelPaint Junior*!"

Brad pointed Michael to Terminal 4 and guided me into the rolling plastic chair right next to him at Terminal 5. Across the blue carpet, Counselor Kelly led Rachel and Katie to Terminals 19 and 20 against the opposite wall.

The moment Katie's hand left my wrist, the hum of the computer lab stopped feeling calming and started feeling like a trap. Down the row to our left, a boy in a basketball cap was pounding his mechanical spacebar with both thumbs and yelling at the screen as his wagon sank in a river. I didn't touch my keyboard at Terminal 5. Instead, I twisted halfway around in my plastic chair and looked straight across the center aisle.

At Terminal 20, Katie was sitting completely motionless in front of the flashing five-by-five number grid of *Digit Chompers*, twisting the hem of her royal-blue camp shirt around her fingers while looking back across the carpet at me. Right beside her at Terminal 19, Rachel Ragsdale had pulled both hands off her desk and tucked her knuckles tightly against her chest.

Next to me at Terminal 4, Michael pushed his chair back six inches and looked at his sister. At the exact same moment, I tapped the open corner of my desk at Terminal 5 and motioned to Katie.

While Brad was kneeling beside the dot-matrix printer at the front of the room, Katie and Rachel slid off their chairs in perfect synchronization and walked three quiet steps side by side across the carpet.

Rachel squeezed onto the right half of Michael's seat at Terminal 4, and Katie pulled the empty rolling chair from the end of the row right up against my right side at Terminal 5, her long platinum-blonde hair brushing my sleeve as she exhaled a long, quiet breath of relief.

“Hey, girls, your computers are still running over on the right wall—” Counselor Kelly started, walking down the aisle before stopping short as she took in the two identical brother-and-sister teams sitting shoulder-to-shoulder at Terminals 4 and 5.

“She’s playing with me,” Michael told her quietly from Terminal 4, his left hand resting on the arrow keys while Rachel’s right thumb hovered over the spacebar for *Digit Chompers*. “I steer the square, and Rachel chomps the multiples. That’s how we play.”

I rested my left hand on the keyboard of Terminal 5 and placed Katie’s hand over the beige two-button mouse for *Wagon Train West*.

“Katie’s my twin,” I said, looking up at Kelly with quiet, unshakable certainty. “We always play together.”

Kelly looked from Michael and Rachel to Katie and me. Neither pair was making noise, neither pair was arguing, and the panicked stiffness had vanished from all four of us the second the sisters were back beside their brothers. Slowly, Kelly smiled, pulled an extra chair over for Rachel so both pairs had two seats pushed flush together, and jotted a quick note on her clipboard.

“Okay,” Kelly said gently. “Michael and Rachel on Terminal 4, Nathaniel and Katie on Terminal 5.”

For the next hour and a half, Katie and I guided our pixel wagon all the way across the western rivers without losing a single ox—trading turns with the mouse while Michael and Rachel cleared screen after screen of *Digit Chompers* two feet to our left.

1:30 PM — Pair 1 and Pair 2 at the Fieldhouse Pool

After eating our grilled cheese sandwiches side by side in the Monarch Commons dining hall at noon—just a few seats down from where Michael and Rachel’s fourteen-year-old sister Jessica used her written lunch exception on the camp roster to sit with them and quiz them on campus landmarks—our group walked down Hampton Boulevard to the VDU Fieldhouse.

The Fieldhouse was a massive brick athletic building where the Lady Admirals played women’s basketball during the school year while the men’s team played downtown under the concrete dome of the Norfolk Prism. Down the rubber-floored hallway, through the double doors of the Fieldhouse Natatorium, the indoor swimming pool echoed with splashing water and bouncing whistles.

As soon as I stepped out of the boys’ locker room in my swim trunks, Katie stepped out of the girls’ locker room door in her navy one-piece swimsuit, walked straight across the wet white tile, and grabbed my hand with both of hers. Right next to us on the bench, Rachel Ragsdale did the exact same thing with Michael.

Up on the deck beside the white plastic Buddy Board, Counselor Brad held up his thick black grease pencil and tried the gender split one last time.

“Every fifteen minutes when the lifeguard blows the long whistle and yells *Buddy Check*, you and your buddy have to find each other in the shallow end, grab hands, and hold them up in the air!” Brad called out over the echoing cavern. “Michael and Nathaniel, you guys are Pair Four! Rachel and Katie, you two are Pair Nine!”

Katie squeezed my fingers tightly as thirty kids splashed into the pool at once. I didn’t let go of her hand, and four feet to my left, Michael didn’t let go of Rachel’s. Together, both pairs walked down the wide fiberglass steps into the warm, three-foot shallow end along the side wall.

Two minutes later, the head lifeguard on the high white chair raised his silver whistle to his lips.

TWEEEEET!

“BUDDY CHECK!” the lifeguard shouted through his red megaphone. “Find your buddy and hands in the air!”

Out in the middle of the shallow end, kids who had been chasing each other in *Admirals and Anchors* pool tag splashed around in circles trying to remember who their assigned partner was.

Along the shallow wall, Katie’s left hand was already laced tightly through my right hand, and Rachel’s right hand was already laced tightly through Michael’s left. Before the whistle had even stopped echoing off the steel roof trusses of the Fieldhouse, all four of us raised our joined hands straight into the air above the water.

Up on the deck, Counselor Brad stared at our two pairs of raised brother-and-sister hands, looked at Counselor Kelly laughing softly behind her clipboard, and finally surrendered. Wiping his rag across the grease pencil on the white plastic board, Brad wrote two new permanent assignments at the very top of the list:

PAIR 1: MICHAEL + RACHEL PAIR 2: NATHANIEL + KATIE

Katie looked at me as we lowered our arms back into the warm water, a bright, triumphant smile breaking across her face, and across the lane Michael and Rachel shared the exact same quiet grin. For the rest of the two-week camp block—from the morning walk across Dominion Mall to afternoon *Four-in-a-Row Grid* and *Wild Draw* cards in the Fieldhouse multipurpose room—nobody at Virginia Dominion University ever tried to separate either pair of siblings again.

Big Family Christmas

The Newport News ARTS Train & The Downstairs Sofa Bed

Date: 1994-12-23 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — The Newport News ARTS Platform

The evening train pulled into the brick ARTS—American Rail Transit Service—station in Newport News with a long hiss of air brakes and a cloud of white steam rising into the cold December air.

Up on the concrete platform, Katie and I stood side by side in our winter coats right next to our paternal grandmother, Grandma Ruth—Dad and Aunt Liz's retired mother, Ruth Prairie, the widow of our Grandpa Walter Prairie, a World War II Navy destroyer veteran buried up at Arlington National Cemetery, who lived off her pension, survivor benefits, and Social Security with us in our fourth upstairs bedroom in Virginia Beach—watching the stainless-steel ARTS passenger doors slide open at the end of the all-day southbound train run down from Newport, Rhode Island, where both Dad and Grandma Ruth had grown up. Moments later, our Aunt Elizabeth stepped down onto the platform alongside our twelve-year-old cousin Chelsea, Aunt Liz's developmentally disabled daughter who was three years older than us, carrying their holiday suitcases as Grandma Ruth beamed and the whole family crowded together to exchange hugs and greetings.

True to form, before we had even walked ten feet past the station canopy toward the parking lot, Aunt Elizabeth wasted no time digging into her coat pocket and lighting up a cigarette.

Beside us, Chelsea immediately scowled and angrily plugged her nose with two fingers.

"Mom, that's gross," Chelsea stammered, waving a hand in front of her face as all of us were forced to stand on the cold curb waiting before we could load into the vehicles.

"Liz, put that out," our dad snapped, his breath fogging in the December chill as he hefted two suitcases into the trunk of our Holt sedan. "You know damn well that's not good for you!"

"Alright, alright," Aunt Liz snapped back, stubbing the cigarette out on the heel of her boot as we sorted ourselves into the two vehicles for the drive back across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Chelsea climbed into the middle of the back bench seat of the Holt sedan right between Katie and me, while Dad and Aunt Liz sat up front. Behind us, Mom—who was having a rare sober evening so Grandma Ruth and Aunt Liz wouldn't ask pointed questions at the ARTS station—drove Grandma Ruth home in the pickup truck following our taillights down Interstate 64.

As soon as our sedan cleared the tunnel and turned onto the familiar streets of Virginia Beach, Katie leaned forward slightly to look across Chelsea at me, her eyes bright with holiday excitement.

"Welcome to Virginia Beach!" Katie squealed happily, squeezing Chelsea's mittened hand. "Now, the three of us are going to have to squeeze into one room!"

8:00 PM — Downstairs Sanctuary

When we pulled into the driveway at home, Katie, Chelsea, and I pitched in right away to help Aunt Liz and Chelsea carry their overnight bags through the front door while Grandma Ruth hung her winter coat in the hall closet.

Standing at the foot of the stairs in the foyer, Dad laid out the holiday room assignments. Since Grandma Ruth already lived in the fourth upstairs bedroom closest to the hall bathroom and Mom and Dad had the master bedroom at the end of the upstairs hall, fitting two holiday guests upstairs meant giving up our rooms.

“You three kids will share the sofa bed,” Dad said to Katie, Chelsea, and me, gesturing toward the living room. Turning to his sister, he added, “Liz, Mom is already right next to the upstairs bathroom, so you get Nathaniel’s room, and we’ll stack the extra suitcases in Katie’s room.”

In a lot of houses, getting evicted from our upstairs bedrooms for the holidays would have felt like a punishment. To Katie and me, however, Dad had just handed us the greatest logistical gift of Christmas. With Grandma Ruth in her room, Aunt Liz in my room, and Mom and Dad behind their closed door at the end of the upstairs hall, all four adults were confined to the second floor—which meant the entire first floor belonged exclusively to the three of us kids.

“Chelsea, there’s a bathroom down here we can use,” Katie explained immediately, pointing down the short hallway off the living room. “It has a shower. We can stay downstairs while the adults are upstairs.”

“Okay,” our cousin replied, setting her backpack by the couch. “Where do we sleep?”

“The three of us will sleep down here. This sofa is a sofa bed,” Katie replied proudly as the three of us finished carrying the last of the adults’ bags up the stairs.

Because the train had arrived late in the evening, dinner was fast and simple—warm bowls of soup and buttered rolls around the dining table—and before nine o’clock, the adults retreated upstairs for the night, leaving the first floor completely to the three of us.

“I want to take a shower,” Chelsea announced to Katie and me once the upstairs footsteps quieted down.

Katie walked her down the short hall to show her how to turn the downstairs shower faucet on and where the clean towels were stacked, then came back out into the living room where I had already changed into my long-sleeved flannel pajamas and was busy pulling the heavy metal frame of the sofa bed out from inside the couch. Working together, Katie and I unfolded the mattress, smoothed out the clean cotton sheets, and spread two thick winter quilts across the top.

A few minutes later, the bathroom door clicked open. Instead of putting her pajamas on inside the bathroom, Chelsea wandered straight out into the living room wrapped only in a bath towel, making her way casually toward the sofa bed Katie and I had just finished setting up.

“CHELSEA!” Katie stammered, her hand shooting out in a flash to clamp firmly over my eyes. “Your cousin shouldn’t be seeing all of you!”

Before Chelsea could even blink, Katie spun her right back around by the shoulders and shunted her straight back into the downstairs bathroom to finish drying off and put her flannel pajamas on properly.

“You need to stop blushing,” my twin sister admonished me once the bathroom door clicked shut behind Chelsea—except she didn’t truly admonish me at all, letting out a quiet, bubbly giggle as she took her hand off my face. “You promise not to tell anyone?”

“Promise,” I replied, rubbing the bridge of my nose as we both climbed onto the left side of the wide sofa bed in our flannel pajamas and pulled the heavy winter quilt up to our chins.

“You know Chelsea sometimes forgets the rules when she’s in a different house,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder underneath the quilt and lacing her fingers through mine. “As long as we look out for each other down here, nobody upstairs is going to yell at anyone.”

“Not a word to anyone,” I whispered back, squeezing her hand.

Two minutes later, Chelsea came back out of the hallway wearing her full green flannel pajamas, fuzzy socks, and a sheepish grin, and climbed under the quilt on the far side of the sofa bed. With the living room lamp clicked off and only the colored lights of the Christmas tree glowing softly in the corner, Katie stayed tucked right against my side—the two of us holding down our downstairs sanctuary while the winter wind rattled the front windows.

All Summer Down on Blackwater Road

Two Sisters Through the Screen Door, Uncle Steve’s Red Cedar Post, & All Summer Sheltered on Blackwater Road

Date: 1995-06-19 at 09:15 America/New_York

Monday, June 19, 1995, 9:15 AM — Crushed Clam Shells, Two Big Duffel Bags, & Aunt Karen’s Voice Behind the Screen Door

Crunch-crunch-crunch went the tires of Dad’s Holt sedan as we turned off the narrow, ditch-lined asphalt of Blackwater Road onto the long white lane of crushed clam shells leading up to Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve’s farmhouse.

“Two whole months!” ten-year-old Brittany cheered, bursting through the wooden screen door of the wrap-around porch so fast the brass spring sang behind her and waving both hands as her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses flashed in the bright June sun. “Did Uncle David pack your sleeping bags and your cartoon tapes too?”

“Both duffel bags are stuffed to the zipper!” Katie called back happily through our open back window, holding my left hand across the bench seat as fourth grade—along with every noisy cafeteria bell and scraping desk at Northwood Elementary—officially vanished in the rearview mirror until September.

Down here in the deep rural southern end of Virginia Beach past Pungo, it felt like we had driven clean off the edge of the city map into another state. Every sidewalk, traffic light, shopping strip, and city bus stop had disappeared ten miles back. Flat, wide-open fields of ripening golden winter wheat and knee-high green field corn stretched out on every side to a dark wall of loblolly pines and bald cypresses along the creek line, smelling of warm clover, sun-baked dark peat dirt, and salt marsh wind blowing up from Currituck Sound.

While Brittany enthusiastically helped Katie haul our blue canvas book bag up the wide wooden porch steps, my left sneaker lace caught on a dandelion clump beside the hydrangea bushes at the corner of the porch lattice. Dropping onto one knee in the cool shade right below the open kitchen screen window to double-knot the lace, I heard Dad set our two heavy clothes duffels down on the kitchen linoleum inside—right as Aunt Karen hung up the beige wall phone with a firm, quiet click.

“I didn’t mince a single word with her, David,” Aunt Karen’s low, fierce voice carried softly through the window screen above my head, pitched quiet enough not to reach the front porch steps where Brittany and Katie were unzipping our cartridge case. “Brenda is my big sister. I shared a bedroom wall with her for eighteen years, and I know the difference between a summer sinus migraine and a glass poured out of that upper cabinet before nine-thirty on a Monday morning.”

Inside the kitchen, Dad let out a long, tired breath that sounded older than thirty-six.

“She swore to me last night it was only because she couldn’t sleep in the heat, Karen,” Dad murmured quietly. “I didn’t want Katie and Nate hearing the two of us argue over breakfast on their very first morning of summer vacation.”

“Which is the exact reason I told you on Friday to pack two months’ worth of their shorts and t-shirts and bring both of them straight down here to the farm,” Aunt Karen answered firmly, the protective warmth in her voice unmistakable. “I told Brenda flat-out on that phone two minutes ago that she isn’t fooling me anymore, and that if she thinks I’m letting ten-year-old twins spend their summer tiptoeing past a locked upstairs door in Kempsville, she doesn’t know her little sister. Between Steve and me swapping shifts and Ruth driving down after breakfast whenever our hours overlap, Katie and Nate are staying right here on Blackwater Road with Brittany all summer long where the only thing they have to worry about is grass stains.”

“I don’t know what we’d do without you and Steve, Karen,” Dad said thickly.

Sitting in the grass beneath the hydrangeas, my ten-year-old brain didn’t fully understand why pouring a glass out of our upper kitchen cabinet before nine-thirty would give Mom a locked-door headache, or why Aunt Karen sounded both angry at her sister and sad at the exact same time. All I knew was that back home in Kempsville, weekday afternoons when Grandma Ruth went to her sewing circle had started feeling tight and unpredictable—and hearing Aunt Karen declare that Katie and I got to stay down here with Brittany all summer made my whole chest unknot at once.

Standing quickly back up as Katie stepped over from the porch steps to reach for my hand again, I watched Dad and Aunt Karen walk out through the screen door wearing easy, sunny smiles—neither of them letting a single shadow touch the porch.

Monday, June 19, 1995, 10:30 AM — Uncle Steve's Red Cedar Post, Sixty Acres of Quiet, & Sun-Warm Berries From the Kitchen Patch

"All right, city slickers—eyes right here on that red cedar fence post at the end of the grass," Uncle Steve said cheerfully in his faded denim work shirt and dusty boots twenty minutes after Dad kissed the tops of our heads and drove north to work, pointing past the pecan shade tree where the mowed farmhouse lawn met the white crushed-shell equipment lane and the corrugated-tin tractor shed.

Katie, Brittany, and I stood in a neat row on the grass—Katie's fingers laced securely through my right hand while Brittany stood right beside my left elbow adjusting her silver oval glasses.

"How old are the three of you now?" Uncle Steve asked, resting both hands on his hips with mock solemnity.

"Ten!" all three of us answered at once—Brittany proudly adding, "Ten and three months!"

"Ten years old means you three have zero business helping with row crops," Uncle Steve declared, tapping two fingers toward his temple so we knew this rule was set in concrete. "Big cash-crop fields have deep drainage ditches, yellow jackets, and heavy machines whose drivers can't see ten-year-olds down in the wheat. Anytime you hear my tractor or a grain truck turn over—or anytime that red cedar post is behind you—your sneakers stay strictly on the house grass, under the pecan trees, or inside your Aunt Karen's fenced kitchen patch. Everything inside the yard oaks is your kingdom all summer. Deal?"

"Deal, Uncle Steve!" we promised together.

Thirty seconds later, Katie and I found out firsthand why we liked staying inside the yard oaks anyway.

When Uncle Steve walked down into the tin equipment shed and cranked the starter on his big green diesel tractor to go bush-hog the back ditch bank, the sudden, chest-rattling roar of unmuffled diesel cylinders echoed off the tin walls so loud that Katie and I both winced in unison, clamping our palms tightly over our ears.

Brittany noticed instantly—not teasing us the way kids at Northwood Elementary did whenever fire-drill buzzers hurt our ears, just tapping my elbow with a calm, practiced grin and pointing toward the screened porch door.

"Come inside the back screen corner until he clears the creek turn—the brick chimney blocks half the noise!" Brittany called out, holding the wooden screen door open for both of us.

Sure enough, huddled side by side on the wide painted floorboards behind the brick chimney while Brittany counted slowly down from twenty on her fingers, the diesel thrum faded steadily across the flat acreage until it sounded no louder than a bumblebee two yards over—and then vanished altogether.

Katie and I slowly lowered our hands from our ears and blinked out through the fine gray porch mesh in wonder.

Nothing in Kempsville was ever *this* quiet.

There were no delivery trucks hissing down Kempsville Road, no barking neighborhood dogs behind chain-link fences, no lawnmowers revving on six cul-de-sacs at once, and no shouted voices echoing down an upstairs hallway. Outside the screen, a warm south breeze rolled up off the North Landing River marsh and swept across sixty flat acres of waist-high golden winter wheat in long, shimmering ripples that looked just like ocean swells—making a soft, dry *shhhhhh* sound like pages turning in a giant library while purple-backed barn swallows swooped silently above the tassels of young green corn.

“Whoa,” Katie whispered, resting her chin on my shoulder as both of us watched the wind waves travel all the way to the cypress tree line. “It sounds like the beach without any crowds.”

“Told you guys,” Brittany beamed, picking up a bright yellow plastic colander Aunt Karen had left waiting on the porch picnic table beside an insulated blue jug of ice-cold homemade lemonade and three plastic cups. “Wait until winter wind pushes the sound water up across Pungo Ferry Road—then it’s *really* a pain trying to ride the bus to Blackwater Elementary. In June, though, we get Aunt Karen’s berry rows all to ourselves. Come on—watch out by the spigot so you don’t step in the black mud!”

Following Brittany single-file down the dry stepping-stones beside the clothesline—where Katie and I carefully steered our white sneakers wide around a patch of glossy, ink-black Pungo peat mud by the garden hose because both of us hated the squishy feel of mud on our shoes—we ducked through a little wooden latch gate into Aunt Karen’s fenced family kitchen garden right behind the house.

Unlike the giant cash-crop fields out past the red cedar post, everything inside Aunt Karen’s kitchen patch was built at ten-year-old height: two neat straw-mulched rows of late June strawberries still hiding plump, sun-warmed ruby berries beneath scalloped green leaves, a string trellis heavy with crisp green sugar-snap peas, and four fat bushes of early blueberries turning dusky blue in the heat. Halfway down the straw path, Brittany crouched down and pointed silently to the edge of the clover, where a domed eastern box turtle with bright orange-and-gold shell markings was calmly munching a fallen berry two feet from our toes before tucking lazily into its shell.

For the next two hours under that wide blue sky, nobody hurried us, nobody split Katie and me into separate lines, and nobody raised their voice once. Sitting side by side on the clean wooden steps of the screened porch afterward with pink berry juice staining our chins, crunching sweet snap peas out of the yellow colander and pouring second cups of Aunt Karen’s cold, tart lemonade while Grandma Ruth’s blue sedan turned smoothly up the white shell lane to make us grilled cheese sandwiches for lunch, Katie squeezed my hand and grinned from ear to ear.

Whatever grown-up storm Aunt Karen was holding back behind the telephone wire up in Kempsville never reached past that red cedar post all summer long.

The Blizzard of ’96, Blackwater Summers, Middle School, & Freshman Year

The Blizzard of ’96

Part 1: Snow Day in Virginia Beach & The Backyard Promise

Date: 1996-01-06 at 11:30 America/New_York

11:30 AM — Waiting for the First Flakes

“You think we’re going to have snow?” Katie asked, her breath fogging a small circle on the cold glass pane as the two of us stood shoulder to shoulder at my upstairs bedroom window.

“Hope so. SNOW DAY!” I said, practically vibrating with excitement as I pressed my palms against the wooden sill and looked out at our residential street in Virginia Beach.

Outside on the first Saturday of January 1996, it was bitterly cold, and heavy, slate-gray clouds were rolling in off the Atlantic until the sky looked like brushed steel. A step to Katie’s right, our ten-year-old maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher pushed her thin silver wire-rimmed glasses up the bridge of her nose, brushed her long medium-blonde hair back over the shoulder of her plum sweatshirt, and leaned toward the glass beside us. Because Brittany’s parents—Mom’s sister, Aunt Karen Fletcher, and Uncle Steve Fletcher—worked odd shift hours up in town while trying to keep up with an aging family farm way down in the rural southern end of Virginia Beach on Blackwater Road, Brittany had practically grown up at our house in Kempsville being watched after school by Dad or by our retired paternal grandmother, Grandma Ruth. Grandma Ruth was still stuck up in Newport, Rhode Island this week visiting Aunt Liz and Chelsea after New Year’s, and Aunt Karen had dropped Brittany off with Dad at ten-thirty that morning so she could squeeze in a quick grocery run in Kempsville before heading back down toward Blackwater ahead of the storm.

“My mom said the bread aisle was already wiped out completely clean,” Brittany said, squinting out past the eaves at the empty asphalt street. “Do you guys really think we’ll get enough to cancel school?”

Behind us on my bedroom stand, the local Norfolk GBS news station had cut into regular Saturday morning programming with wall-to-wall coverage beneath a bold winter graphic calling the approaching nor’easter the Blizzard of ’96. Standing in front of a swirling radar map that stretched from the Gulf Coast all the way past the Virginia Capes, the chief meteorologist pointed to bands of deep blue marching across Virginia—projecting two to three feet of powdery snow out in the

Shenandoah Valley and Blue Ridge Mountains while warning all of Tidewater and Virginia Beach to brace for heavy afternoon snow shifting tonight to driving sleet, freezing rain, thirty-five-mile-per-hour northeast gales off the ocean, and major coastal and wind-tide flooding from the oceanfront boardwalk down to the low-lying back roads around Back Bay and Pungo Ferry Road. Even starting on a Saturday, a real coastal blizzard meant Monday and Tuesday would be wiped clean off the Virginia Beach school calendar.

“Snow,” Katie replied hopefully, leaning her shoulder against mine as the news anchor read off rising tide tables for Lynnhaven Inlet and Sewells Point. All three of us were thrilled at the thought of the whole city shutting down.

At twelve-thirty, while Katie, Brittany, and I were sitting around the kitchen table eating our lunch sandwiches, the first white flakes began to drift past the dining room window. At first it wasn’t much—just fine, powdery crystals swirling across the dry grass—but within twenty minutes the northeast wind picked up off the coast and the flakes grew thick and steady, driving sideways across Kempsville until the wooden fence rails, the neighborhood cul-de-sacs, and the roof of Dad’s Holt sedan vanished under a deepening blanket of white just as Aunt Karen hurried straight down south to beat the rising water on the rural roads toward Blackwater, promising Dad on the porch that she or Uncle Steve would come back up for Brittany as soon as the squall eased.

“Wonder if it will stick,” Katie giggled, pointing her finger toward the patio as the wind sculpted crisp white drifts against the back steps.

By late afternoon, several inches of wind-packed snow had buried the entire backyard under a clean, silent blanket of white.

Inside the house, however, the quiet didn’t last. Around five o’clock, the familiar, sharp sound of Mom’s and Dad’s voices started rising from the upstairs hallway—first a slammed cabinet door, then the bitter, overlapping shouting match that always followed whenever Dad found another empty bottle hidden behind the pantry cans.

5:45 PM — The Backyard Bear Hug

Down in the living room, Brittany froze on the tan couch with a coloring book in her lap, her eyes wide behind her wire-rimmed glasses at the sudden angry shouting overhead. Making sure Brittany was tucked safely away from the bottom of the stairs, Katie and I didn’t wait for the yelling to reach the landing—we pulled on our heavy winter jackets and boots and slipped out the back door into the twilight snow so I could catch my breath.

Out in the backyard, inside the perimeter of our white wooden picket fence, the falling snow acted like a giant acoustic blanket over the neighborhood. The streetlamps glowed pale orange through the swirling flakes, and every footstep made a soft, muted crunch under our shoes.

Standing near the center of the yard with the snow settling onto my short blonde hair, the cold wind hit my face, and all at once the weight of everything we had been carrying over the past year caught up with me. My chest tightened, and before I could stop myself, I started sniffling in the cold air.

Katie turned around immediately. She didn't hesitate for a second—she stepped straight through the snow and pulled me into a tight, fierce bear hug, wrapping both of her blue-jacketed arms around my shoulders.

"What's wrong?" Katie asked softly against my ear, holding onto me with all her strength.

"I'm just so happy you're willing to do all of this for me," I whispered into her shoulder, my voice shaking slightly as I held onto the back of her winter coat, unsure of how to put the rest of the knot in my chest into words.

Katie didn't need me to explain it. Because she was my twin, she already knew the exact two things crushing my ribs.

"You're still upset with last year, and that girl everyone thought you had a crush on?" Katie asked gently.

"Yes, I am," I whimpered, burying my face against her collar, overwhelmingly grateful that my twin sister was hugging me instead of telling me to toughen up. All through the previous spring at school, a pack of kids in our grade had latched onto a rumor that I had a crush on a girl in our homeroom, turning every hallway change and cafeteria period into a relentless, mocking gauntlet that wouldn't stop no matter what I said. "And it does not help that Mom and Dad are arguing with each other again. I just want to enjoy the snow without the screaming."

"I'm right here, and I will never leave you," Katie replied fiercely, pulling me into an even tighter bear hug as the heavy January snow came down all around us in the twilight. "I'm your sister, and I would just never, ever leave you."

She held onto me for a long moment in the quiet yard, letting the steady pressure of her arms slow my breathing down, before she spoke again.

"Your classmates are mean," Katie continued, her voice firm against the cold wind. "Especially when they refuse to back down. When we go back to school, I will gladly play my part of pretend girlfriend so they leave you alone."

"Thank you, but I think everyone knows that you're my sister," I whispered, managing a small, shaky laugh even as my teeth started chattering from the twenty-degree air.

"Come on, let's head back inside before we freeze," Katie said, taking my hand and leading me back across the snow-covered grass toward the back door.

Inside the warm kitchen, the shouting upstairs had finally stopped—Mom had gone to bed for the night behind her closed door, and Dad was standing by the wall phone speaking quietly into the receiver while snow piled against the dining room glass. Standing beside the dark green laminate counter while we stomped the powder off our boots, Katie wrapped her arms around my neck for one more long, warming hug until the chill left my fingers—right as the soft whisper of falling snow outside abruptly turned into the sharp, staccato rattle of sleet pelting the windowpanes off the Atlantic.

Part 2: Sleet on the Glass, Glaze Ice Across Tidewater, & Brittany's First Group Cuddle

Date: 1996-01-06 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — Sleet on the Windowpanes & Brittany's First Group Cuddle

"Karen, don't you and Steve dare put that key in the ignition—stay right inside the farmhouse where you're warm," Dad said firmly into the beige kitchen wall phone, resting one hand against the doorframe while thousands of hard, frozen pellets of sleet rattled like flung gravel against the dining-room glass. "The news just reported wind tides pushing water right across Pungo Ferry Road on top of the sleet, and Kempsville Road up here is already a solid skating rink. Virginia Beach police asked everyone to stay off the streets, and Brittany's completely safe right here with Katie, Nate, and me for the weekend—heck, with my mom snowed in up in Newport with Liz and Chelsea until the rail corridor digs out, we've got plenty of room."

Hanging our damp snow coats over two kitchen chairs to drip onto a folded towel and pulling dry winter sweaters over our heads, Katie and I listened as the storm outside shifted into the signature fury that every Tidewater newscast had been warning about all day.

Out in the Shenandoah Valley and northern Virginia, the Blizzard of '96 was burying towns under two and three feet of light, powdery snow. Down here at the mouth of the Chesapeake Bay, however, the sprawling coastal low churning off the Virginia Capes was hurling thirty-five-mile-per-hour northeast gales straight off the Atlantic—pushing coastal floodwaters across Atlantic Avenue at the oceanfront boardwalk, backing wind-driven water over the low country roads down toward Blackwater, and driving a wedge of slightly milder ocean air high above Virginia Beach's twenty-degree ground. Instead of piling up two feet of fluff, the four or five inches of snow already blanketing our yard were now being pelted by hours of stinging sleet and freezing rain that welded every snowdrift, driveway, pine limb, and neighborhood cul-de-sac under a thick, treacherous armor of solid glaze ice.

"Go check on your cousin in the living room while I warm up three mugs of hot cocoa on the stove," Dad told Katie and me quietly after hanging up the wall receiver, giving my shoulder a gentle squeeze. "She's spent plenty of afternoons here with Grandma Ruth and me, but she's never been iced in overnight away from her mom and dad before."

Katie and I walked side by side out of the kitchen into the lamp-lit living room, where the television volume was turned down low over live Norfolk GBS storm coverage of waves crashing over the Virginia Beach seawall and snowplows sliding sideways near Lynnhaven Parkway.

At the far right corner of our tan living-room sofa, ten-year-old Brittany was sitting curled into a tight, anxious ball all by herself. She had both arms wrapped around a square throw pillow pressed to her plum sweatshirt, her thin silver wire-rimmed glasses sitting slightly crooked on her nose as she flinched at a sudden gust of sleet lashing the front windowpanes—rattled first by hearing Mom and Dad shouting upstairs earlier and now by the realization that every street between our house and hers was locked in solid ice.

Katie stopped beside the coffee table and glanced sideways at me.

Normally, when the world got too loud or unpredictable, Katie and I kept a strict two-person perimeter. Other kids at Northwood Elementary didn’t understand why we needed quiet or why we always sat pressed shoulder to shoulder, so we never invited anyone else inside our personal space. Looking at our cousin sitting small and scared at the cold end of the couch, though, I didn’t even need Katie to ask out loud—I gave my twin sister one small nod.

Crossing the carpet together, I sat down on the left cushion of the tan sofa while Katie settled right into the middle spot beside me, unfolding the heavy woven winter blanket across both of our laps. Instead of tucking the right edge down between herself and the empty cushion, Katie lifted the open corner of the blanket with her right hand and looked warmly over at Brittany.

“Come scoot over here with us, Brittany,” Katie said gently. “You don’t have to sit way over there by yourself while the wind’s blowing like that. There’s plenty of room under the blanket for all three of us.”

Brittany blinked behind her wire-rimmed glasses, looking from Katie to me in genuine surprise—as if she had been trying hard not to intrude on our twin bubble all afternoon.

“Really?” Brittany asked softly, setting the throw pillow aside. “You guys don’t mind?”

“Come on in,” I told her, sliding an inch closer so Katie had plenty of room to anchor the center. “It’s way warmer in a three-person pile.”

Letting out a long breath she seemed to have been holding since five o’clock, Brittany scooted across the tan sofa cushion right up against Katie’s right side. Katie draped the heavy woven blanket snugly across all six of our knees, wrapped her left arm around my shoulders, and wrapped her right arm warmly around Brittany’s shoulders—and after half a second, Brittany smiled, rested her long medium-blonde head gently against Katie’s shoulder, and reached across to hug both of us back.

Once the steady pressure of the blanket and Katie’s arm settled around her shoulders, the tension melted right out of Brittany’s frame. Outside, the northeast gale whistled around the brick chimney and coated the front porch railing in glistening clear ice, making the amber lamp beside the couch feel twice as warm.

“I wish our farm wasn’t way down in the country off Blackwater Road,” Brittany murmured from under the blanket as Dad walked in from the kitchen carrying a tray with three steaming ceramic mugs of hot cocoa and set them carefully on the oak coffee table in front of us. “Whenever the northeast wind blows like tonight, Pungo Ferry Road floods right across the pavement and my school bus to Blackwater Elementary takes forever just trying to get around the high water. Next fall I have to ride an even longer bus all the way to Pungo Ridge Middle School, while you two get to go to Northwood Elementary and Morrison Middle five minutes from your front door.”

“Your mom and Steve were just telling me last week how worn out they are trying to keep up with all that acreage on top of their shift hours,” Dad said with an encouraging smile from the edge of the rug, nodding toward the frosted front window. “Karen said they’re seriously hoping to sell the old farm place in a few years and move into a regular house right up here in Kempsville closer to us.”

Brittany’s eyes lit up behind her glasses as she looked from Dad to Katie and me. “Wait—if we moved up here to Kempsville before high school, would all three of us get to go to Northwood High School together every single day?”

“Every single day,” Katie promised warmly, giving Brittany’s shoulder a tight squeeze with her right arm while keeping her left hand tucked close against mine. “No flooded roads and no hour-long bus rides—just the three of us.”

8:45 PM — Downstairs Sofa-Bed Sanctuary & A City Sealed in Crystal

Because Aunt Karen had only dropped Brittany off for Saturday lunch without an overnight bag, Katie ran upstairs after dinner and came back down carrying two extra pillows and a clean, spare pair of her soft fleece winter pajamas that fit Brittany comfortably.

Just like we had done the Christmas before when Aunt Liz and Chelsea rode the train down from Rhode Island, Dad let the three of us unfold the heavy metal frame of the downstairs living-room sofa bed for the night. Keeping all three of us down on the first floor meant nobody had to tiptoe past Mom’s closed bedroom door upstairs, and the wide living-room window gave us a front-row view of the street the second the sun came up.

While Brittany brushed her teeth in the downstairs hallway bathroom and I smoothed two thick quilts over the unfolded sofa-bed mattress, Katie changed in the laundry alcove and tapped three quiet knocks against the living-room doorframe before stepping back out.

“Cartoons are for life,” Katie whispered with a grin so Brittany could learn our secret password too.

“Come on in,” I whispered back.

Five minutes later, with the brass table lamp clicked off and the orange glow of the corner streetlamp shining through the ice-sheathed windowpanes, all three of us climbed beneath the heavy quilts—me on the left, Katie right in the middle holding my hand, and Brittany tucked warmly against Katie’s other side, where she reached over and gave Katie’s arm one grateful goodnight hug before drifting off to sleep to the steady tick of freezing rain on the glass.

When Sunday morning broke cold and brilliant on January 7, the three of us scrambled up onto our knees at the living-room window together and gasped.

Overnight, the Blizzard of ’96 had turned all of Virginia Beach into a silent palace of solid crystal. Half an inch of glass-smooth glaze ice capped every drifted snowbank, sealed Dad’s car doors shut in the driveway, weighed the neighborhood pine branches down toward the lawn like chandeliers, and turned the asphalt cul-de-sac into an unbroken mirror sparkling under the pale winter sun—and right across the

bottom of the television screen when I clicked on the morning news scrolled the magic gold letters every kid in Tidewater had been praying for: *VIRGINIA BEACH CITY PUBLIC SCHOOLS — CLOSED MONDAY.*

“No school tomorrow—and the news guy just said the ice won’t even melt off the side streets by Tuesday!” Brittany cheered, throwing both arms around Katie and me right there on the unfolded sofa bed as the three of us collapsed laughing into another warm three-way hug.

Katie Is Dumped

No More Fighting & The Dinner Dance Promise

Date: 1997-10-16 at 16:15 America/New_York

4:15 PM — Tears Under the Blue Butterfly

“Leave me alone! You’d never understand,” Katie sobbed, turning her head half away as I pushed her bedroom door open and stepped onto the carpet.

I had just walked up the stairs after seventh grade when I heard the sound echoing right through her hollow wooden door into the upstairs hallway. Katie was standing near the foot of her bed against the bright magenta-purple wall beneath her framed blue morpho butterfly print, crying up a storm with her shoulders shaking inside her dark navy t-shirt and both hands pressed over her face.

For the first month of middle school—while I spent my afternoons quiet in my blue bedroom with my *Nova 64* video games and Katie tried her hardest to fit in with the girls from her English class and a seventh-grade boy named Donnie—the stress of the loud hallways and Mom’s worsening drinking at home had pushed the two of us into the stupid habit of bickering whenever we passed each other in the hall.

Hearing the ragged sound of her crying, I dropped every trace of that irritation at the door. Stepping quietly across her room, I placed my hand gently on her shoulder.

“What is it?” I asked softly.

Katie continued sobbing for several seconds, her chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath. I realized immediately that this wasn’t a small hallway argument—this was serious. It took her a long moment to realize that I wasn’t going to tease her or make fun of her for crying.

Slowly, she lowered her hands from her tear-streaked face.

“Donnie dumped me,” Katie choked out, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “I loved him, and he dumped me!”

I reached my hand out to gently wipe the tears from her eyes. Never having had a girlfriend myself—and never having been dumped—I didn’t fully understand the mechanics of middle-school romance, but I didn’t need to understand romance to see how badly my twin sister was hurting.

Katie reached out with both hands and took mine, holding onto my fingers tightly as if she were drowning and I was the only solid ground in the room.

“Please… don’t let go,” she whispered, her voice raw.

I closed both of my hands around hers and held on firmly. Looking straight into my eyes with a sudden, desperate seriousness, Katie asked the question that mattered most to survival in a middle-school cafeteria:

“Will you sit with me at lunch?”

The look on Katie’s upset face told me the only answer she needed to hear—and it was the exact answer I wanted to give her anyway.

“Yes,” I answered without hesitation. “I’ll sit with you at lunch.”

Katie burst into fresh tears of pure relief, letting go of my fingers only to throw both arms around my neck and pull me into a tight hug.

“Thank you,” she whispered against my shoulder.

I could hear how raspy and sore her throat was from all of her crying, so I offered to run downstairs and get her a cold glass of water, but she shook her head and held onto my shirt even tighter. As I wrapped my arms around her waist and hugged her back in the quiet room, I felt something shift permanently inside my chest. All the petty squabbling we had done over the past few weeks felt completely, utterly stupid. Katie didn’t want to stop hugging me, and I didn’t have a single problem with that.

“Please, no more fighting,” my sister sobbed softly into my shoulder.

“I understand,” I promised, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair as we continued to hold onto each other.

“I’m still upset, but thanks for this,” Katie murmured a minute later as I felt a few more warm tears soak into the shoulder of my maroon t-shirt.

“Katie, I’m here for you,” I told her. And as I said the words out loud, squeezing my arms around my twin sister, I realized just how much more I loved hugging her and keeping her safe than arguing with her.

5:00 PM — The Pretend Date & PB&J Sanctuary

When her crying finally began to subside, the two of us sat down side by side on the edge of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread, our shoulders pressed together and our hands still linked.

“Thank you,” Katie said quietly, wiping her eyes with the back of her wrist. “Thank you for being there for me. Someday, I know I’m going to repay this.”

She went quiet for a beat, looking down at our joined hands, before she suddenly whispered:

“Take me to the Dinner Dance this week.”

The seventh-grade Dinner Dance was tomorrow night in the school cafeteria, and half the reason Katie had been crying so hard was the thought of either staying home alone in embarrassment or walking into that room by herself while Donnie was there.

“Of course we can go together,” I said immediately, knowing I didn’t have a date of my own—and wouldn’t have wanted to go with anyone else even if I did. “Even though you’re my sister, we will go on a pretend date.”

“Oh, thank you. Thank you,” Katie breathed, the last of the heavy sobs finally leaving her chest as she leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Would you like it if I made you dinner tonight?” I asked, deciding right then and there to start playing my part as her protective pretend boyfriend.

“Let’s just have something simple, like sandwiches,” she said softly.

“Alright,” I replied, giving her hand a gentle squeeze as the two of us stood up and headed downstairs together.

In the quiet kitchen, I made us both thick peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches and poured two tall glasses of cold milk to soothe her sore throat. After we finished eating at the table, Katie looked across at me.

“Could we watch a movie together?” she asked.

“Sure,” I replied warmly. “Let’s pick something together.”

We walked back upstairs to my deep-blue bedroom, picked out our VHS tape of *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan* from the shelf beneath my television stand, and pushed it into the VCR. As the opening Majestic Studios credits began to roll across the CRT screen, Katie kicked off her shoes and climbed into my single bed right at my side, resting her head on my shoulder and pulling the blanket across our legs.

Near the end of the movie, when the closing music faded in, I glanced down and saw that my sister was fast asleep against my arm, her breathing slow and completely peaceful after an afternoon of crying her eyes out.

I reached carefully for the remote, clicked the television off, and decided right then to let her sleep. I decided that I would tell her that I didn’t mind after we woke up in the morning. Katie was exhausted, and the last thing I wanted was to see her become a grouch because she was woken back up without enough sleep. Part of me marveled at how natural it felt sharing my narrow bed with my twin sister again—just like we had during the Blizzard of ’96 and on the downstairs sofa bed at Christmas. We had chosen this close brother-and-sister bond together, and enjoying the warm, quiet company of the person who mattered most to me in the world, I slid down onto the pillow beside her and let myself drift off to sleep at her side.

The Pretend Boyfriend & Twins' Day

Twin Brothers Always Stay: Spirit Week & The Living Room Sofa

Date: 1997-10-17 at 07:30 America/New_York

7:30 AM — "Twin Brothers Always Stay"

The next morning, when the pale autumn sunlight filtered through the blinds of my bedroom, I woke up first—and sure enough, Katie was still fast asleep right at my side in the small bed.

"Katie," I whispered softly, gently prodding her shoulder so I wouldn't startle her in case she didn't realize right away that she had fallen asleep in my room the night before.

My sister stirred against the pillow, blinking her blue eyes open in the quiet blue room before looking from the wall to me in mild surprise.

"Morning, sleepyhead," I whispered with a small smile.

"I slept in your bed?" she asked groggily, rubbing her eyes.

"Yep, and I did not mind," I replied, looking her straight in the eye. "Let's play a game together."

For the first time since Donnie had broken her heart yesterday afternoon, Katie's face lit up with genuine excitement. While she sat up against the headboard, I slipped out of bed, walked across the carpet to the television stand, and powered on my *Nova 64* video game console. I was still in full protective-brother mode, determined to keep cheering her up until I heard her laugh again.

Before I picked up the controller, I turned back to face her.

"I'm your brother. I will always be here for you. Promise," I told her, my voice steady and earnest in the quiet room. I paused for half a beat, then added the truth I knew we would live by for the rest of our lives: "Boyfriends come and go, but Twin Brothers always stay. Always."

Before the console title screen had even finished loading on the CRT television, I found myself wrapped in Katie's arms again. She stood up from the edge of the mattress and hugged me with everything she had, making it unmistakably clear that she had no intention of letting go of me. She held onto my shoulders while the video game rolled through its opening demo sequence on the screen behind us, then sat down on the carpet right at my side.

"We should probably get dressed," Katie said after a moment, glancing down at her wrinkled shirt from yesterday. "Guess I will pop into my room real quick. Leave the game on this screen while we get dressed?"

"Sure," I replied, gently ushering her to the bedroom door. "I'll open my door when I'm dressed."

8:00 AM — Spirit Week: Twins' Day

Five minutes later, after I had pulled on a clean maroon short-sleeve t-shirt, medium-wash blue jeans, and my tan sneakers, I opened my bedroom door. Katie walked right back in from across the hall—and the second I saw what she had picked out of her closet, I had to grin.

Without planning it, she had put on the exact same shade of maroon short-sleeve t-shirt and medium-wash blue jeans with a dark belt.

"Next week is Spirit Week at school," I said as she stepped into the room. "Want to have a little fun on Twins' Day, since, well, we *are* twins?"

Katie giggled as I handed her the second black controller from the floor stand. "Yeah, we are twins! Wonder how many others will really be twins compared to how many will do it just for fun."

We both laughed out loud at that remark, and right there in front of my computer desk and television stand, we stubbornly made up our minds.

"I think it's settled, then," I declared. "We will dress exactly the same, and we will enter the contest."

We laughed again, already looking forward to seeing how the teachers and our classmates would react to actual fraternal twins walking into the Spirit Week Twins' Day assembly dressed identically and holding hands.

"Too bad we don't have matching shoes," Katie remarked, looking down at her grey-and-red sneakers next to my tan ones.

"Ah, well. Still, let's do what we can. I think these pants and shirts look close enough," I said, setting the controllers on the desk and pulling her into another tight, standing hug in the middle of the room. Both of us laughed into each other's shoulders, our matching maroon sleeves wrapped around each other's backs. Yesterday's tears were completely gone.

5:30 PM — Macaroni & Cheese on the Living Room Sofa

Later that evening, after spending the afternoon practicing our co-op levels and getting ready for the weekend, Katie and I walked downstairs and decided to sit together on the tan-brown living room sofa, curling up side by side while we waited for dinner to be made.

As usual in our house, Dad was in the kitchen working over the stove after a full day at his job, while upstairs Mom was already passed out drunk in bed behind her closed door.

"Mac and cheese is what I smell," I whispered as Katie slid flush against my right side on the sofa cushions, draped her left arm warmly around my shoulders, and rested her right hand across my forearm to hold me close to her.

“Our favorite,” she replied softly, resting her cheek near my shoulder as the two of us sat there, happily snuggled up together beneath the blue-framed underwater painting on the living room wall.

We had a few quiet minutes to ourselves before the timer on the stove went off, and neither of us wanted to get off the sofa. After years of feeling like we had to keep our guard up against loud classrooms and the unpredictable storms upstairs, snuggling together on the couch felt like the safest, most comfortable place on earth.

As we sat there in the warm glow of the living room lamp, Katie whispered, “Snuggling up is just so comfortable.”

“It is,” I replied quietly, leaning into the warmth of her arm around my shoulders. Neither of us moved an inch; we were both completely content holding onto each other and letting the rest of the house fade away.

A few minutes later, Dad stepped to the doorway of the dining room with a pot holder in his hand, looking over at the two of us curled up together on the couch before calling us in to eat.

When we sat down side by side at the dining table over our steaming bowls of macaroni and cheese, Dad looked across the table at the two of us, his tired eyes softening with genuine gratitude.

“I really appreciate that you both don’t fight and argue with each other,” Dad said quietly, his voice heavy with emotion. “Honestly, I wish your mother didn’t drink her life away. I want to do my best to not only be your father, but also be a proper dad to both of you. Your mother’s drinking is not your fault, and I don’t want either of you to think that. Please don’t let your grades suffer because of it.”

Underneath the edge of the dining table, Katie reached her hand over and laced her fingers tightly through mine, and I squeezed right back. Whatever happened upstairs, and whatever happened in the hallways at school, my twin sister and I had our sanctuary—and we were never letting go.

Summer 1998 on Blackwater Road: What’s Inside the Cabinet & Bleak Numbers on the Ledger

Tropical Brochures on the Counter, Aunt Karen and Dad’s Gentle Truth, & Bleak Numbers on the Farm Ledger

Date: 1998-07-18 at 15:00 America/New_York

Saturday, July 18, 1998, 3:00 PM — Glossy Ship Brochures, Connecting the Dots, & Aunt Karen and Dad’s Gentle Explanation

“Did she really say that at eleven o’clock in the morning?” thirteen-year-old Brittany asked quietly, pushing her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses up her nose as the rusted chains of Aunt Karen’s wide wooden porch glider creaked softly beneath the three of us.

“Ten-forty-five,” Katie answered in a small, tight voice, leaning her blonde head closer against my right shoulder while I sat wedged in my favorite middle spot on the cushioned glider with my right arm wrapped warmly around Katie and my left arm wrapped around Brittany. “Right before Dad came out of his study with his CCHR textbook bag and told us to grab our backpacks so we could ride down here to the farm for the weekend.”

Outside the gray mesh of the wrap-around screened porch, July in southern Virginia Beach hung thick, shimmering, and mercilessly dry. Cicadas buzzed in a high, relentless drone from the dusty pecan limbs, and across the flat fields past Uncle Steve’s red cedar post, forty acres of unirrigated field corn stood under a brassy ninety-six-degree sky with their green leaves rolled inward like tight gray straws, praying for rain that hadn’t fallen in three weeks.

Three summers earlier when we were ten, Katie and I hadn’t understood why Mom locked her bedroom door in the middle of the afternoon or why Aunt Karen’s voice got low and fierce on the kitchen telephone. At thirteen—especially after Grandma Ruth had packed up our fourth upstairs bedroom earlier that spring to move back home to Newport, Rhode Island so she could live near Aunt Liz and sixteen-year-old Chelsea, leaving no retired grandmother downstairs in Kempsville on weekday afternoons—there was no missing the clues anymore.

Yesterday morning when I carried the kitchen trash bag out to the garage bin, three empty clear glass bottles with torn tax seals had clinked together beneath a layer of folded grocery circulars at the bottom of the can, even though Dad never drank anything stronger than root beer or ginger ale. And at quarter to eleven this morning, when Katie and I walked downstairs looking for cereal, Mom had been sitting at the kitchen island in her bathrobe with an amber-filled tumbler sweating rings across three glossy, tropical-blue *Sunward Cruise Lines* travel brochures—her words sliding thickly together as she jabbed a fingernail at pictures of tiered pool bars and sunlit Caribbean decks, announcing loudly that as soon as Dad finished his community-college classes she was taking the whole family on a big seven-day ocean cruise where Katie would learn to wear sundresses and dance instead of hiding behind computer screens with her brother all day.

“I smelled the glass when I put our bowls in the sink,” I admitted quietly between Katie and Brittany, feeling my stomach twist the exact way it had back at ten-forty-five. “It smelled just like that sharp, sour stuff from the New Year’s toast on television—only way stronger. Mom doesn’t have summer migraines, does she, Brittany?”

Brittany bit her lower lip, glancing anxiously over her shoulder toward the open farmhouse kitchen window before squeezing my left hand tighter. “I heard my mom crying to my dad about it one night after dinner in May,” Brittany whispered. “I didn’t want to say anything and scare you guys.”

Behind us, the wooden screen door latch clicked softly—not snapping shut, because Dad was holding the frame with one hand while Aunt Karen stepped slowly out onto the porch carrying a tray of four chilled green cans of ginger ale, with Uncle Steve walking quietly right behind them in his sweat-stained Saturday work shirt.

All three adults stopped beside the picnic table the instant they saw our faces huddled together on the glider. Nobody had to ask what we had been talking about; Aunt Karen took one look at Katie's pale cheeks and Brittany's guilty eyes, set the tray gently down on the painted pine planks, and exchanged a long, sorrowful look with Dad.

"We're thirteen, Dad," Katie said softly, tightening her fingers around my wrist instead of looking away. "You and Aunt Karen don't have to pretend Mom just has headaches anymore."

Dad didn't try to change the subject, and neither did Aunt Karen. Pulling two wooden chairs right up facing our porch glider while Uncle Steve leaned quietly against the porch rail beside Brittany's end of the swing, Dad rested his forearms on his knees and looked straight into Katie's eyes and mine with steady, unflinching honesty.

"No, sweetheart—we won't pretend," Dad said gently. "Your mom has a drinking problem. It's an illness with alcohol that started getting worse a few years back, even when she tells herself and everyone else she has a handle on it."

"And I need all three of you—especially you two, Katie and Nate—to hear me say something right now and lock it inside your heads forever," Aunt Karen added, leaning forward to rest one warm hand over Katie's knee and her other hand over Brittany's while her voice stayed calm, clear, and deeply loving even with the ache of talking about her own older sister. "Adults who drink too much say sharp, unfair things when a glass is in their hand, and they look for reasons to blame everybody else in the house for why they're unhappy. Not *one ounce* of your mother's drinking is because of you two, or because you like computers, or because you're quiet, or because the two of you stick together. You didn't cause it, you can't tiptoe quietly enough to cure it, and it is never your job to fix a grown-up."

Katie let out a shaky breath against my right shoulder, blinking fast as a huge, silent weight lifted off her chest, and I felt my own throat loosen as I hugged both Katie and Brittany a little closer.

"Your Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve and I are handling the grown-up side of things," Dad promised quietly, reaching out to squeeze my knee and Katie's shoulder. "Anytime the house feels loud or Mom isn't acting like herself while I'm at work or evening lab at CCHR, you lock your bedroom door together, or you pick up the phone and call Aunt Karen or me on the first ring, and one of us will come get you right away."

"Wait—what about those *Sunward* ship brochures she had all over the counter this morning?" Katie asked anxiously, looking straight at Dad. "Dad, please tell me you aren't going to make Nate and me get trapped on a giant boat out in the middle of the ocean where there's music blasting and people drinking at pool bars on every deck and nowhere to walk home."

"Yeah," I seconded immediately, shuddering at the mere thought of seven days locked inside a floating hotel hallway with Mom in that mood. "We'd way rather stay home in Virginia Beach coding HTML or sitting right here on this porch."

Dad managed a tired, reassuring smile, rubbing the back of his neck. “Nobody booked a ship ticket this morning, guys—those were just free travel-agency pamphlets she picked up at the shopping center. For right now, the only place you two are sailing is this porch swing.”

Saturday, July 18, 1998, 5:15 PM — Curled Corn Leaves, Half-Price Grain Sheets, & Uncle Steve’s Green Ledger

When Dad and Aunt Karen went back inside twenty minutes later to peel potatoes and fry chicken for supper—leaving the three of us tucked close together on the shaded glider sipping cold ginger ale—the afternoon heat slowly began to ease across the yard, yet a second, quieter worry lingered inside the farmhouse behind us.

Through the screen window looking onto the dining room table, right beside Uncle Steve’s reading glasses and a solar pocket calculator, lay his thick green cloth-bound farm ledger—propped open across three yellow carbon-copy invoices from the Pungo farm-supply cooperative and a printed grain-market bulletin from Chesapeake.

Brittany followed my gaze through the mesh and let out a quiet sigh, resting her caramel-blonde head against my left shoulder while nibbling a handful of pretzels from the bowl beside her.

“Dad didn’t come to bed until almost two in the morning on Thursday,” Brittany murmured softly so Uncle Steve wouldn’t hear from the back steps where he was washing grease off his hands with orange pumice soap at the outdoor spigot. “He worked his regular maintenance shift up in town until eleven, drove all the way down Pungo Ferry Road in the dark, and sat at that dining table with the calculator for three hours.”

“Because it hasn’t rained since June?” Katie asked gently across my chest.

“Because of the drought *and* the grain prices,” Brittany whispered, pointing out across the white shell lane past the red cedar post. Even to two city-suburb kids who only knew HTML tags and library books, the farm looked exhausted compared to June of 1995. Half the white paint on the equipment-shed eaves had blistered and peeled in the sun because Uncle Steve didn’t have a free Saturday left to scrape and prime it; the back ditch bank had grown shaggy with trumpet vine; and out across the sixty flat acres, the unirrigated July corn stalks stood stunted at shoulder height, their lower blades burned crisp tan like autumn leaves three months early. “Dad told Mom that corn and wheat prices dropped almost in half since the year of the big ice storm. Even when a field grows okay now, the check from the grain elevator barely pays for the diesel fuel and the fertilizer sack—so Mom and Dad are working extra town shifts just to pay the farm bills instead of the farm paying for anything.”

Looking out past the pecan tree at Uncle Steve slowly shutting off the brass hose bib—his shoulders sagging with the bone-deep weariness of a man working two full-time lives at once and losing ground on both—Katie and I both tightened our arms around Brittany at the exact same moment.

“Well, if your mom and dad really do end up selling the acreage like Uncle David talked about during the ice storm,” Katie told her warmly, reaching across my lap to link her fingers with Brittany’s while I hugged both of them steady in the middle, “moving into a regular brick house up in Kempsville isn’t giving up, Brittany. Think

about next year after eighth grade—no flooded Pungo Ferry Road, no two-hour dark drives for your dad, and all three of us walking into ninth grade at Northwood High together."

Brittany smiled wistfully behind her silver frames, leaning snugly into my shoulder as the dry July wind rattled the curled corn leaves beyond the yard.

"One more winter crop," Brittany murmured. "Dad told Mom he wants to plant winter wheat one last October and see what next June brings before they call a realtor."

Two Dollars a Bushel: One Last Harvest & Goodbye to Blackwater Road

Two Dollars and Ten Cents a Bushel, Unhooked Soybean Drills, & One Last Sunset Across the Wheat Stubble

Date: 1999-06-19 at 16:30 America/New_York

Saturday, June 19, 1999, 4:30 PM — Golden Chaff in the Afternoon Sun & Two Dollars and Ten Cents a Bushel

Fine golden dust and sunlit flecks of wheat chaff drifted like warm snow past the screened porch on Blackwater Road as the hired harvester's faded red combine finished its very last pass along the cypress tree line, shut off its spinning header reel with a deep metallic clank, and rumbled empty down the white crushed-shell lane toward the road.

Usually, on harvest Saturday in mid-June down in southern Virginia Beach, the work was only half finished when the winter wheat came off. Every prior June we could remember, before the grain truck's taillights had even disappeared north toward the Chesapeake elevator, Uncle Steve would already be out under the tin shed greasing the bearings on his soybean planter drill to double-crop summer soybeans straight into the fresh wheat stubble before nightfall.

Today, the soybean drill sat pushed all the way to the back wall of the dark tin shed under a folded blue tarp. And tucked face-down behind the hydrangea bushes against the white porch lattice—where none of us had to stare at its red-and-blue brokerage letters until Monday morning—rested a newly painted wooden *FOR SALE* sign with two steel ground stakes taped to its post.

"Here comes my dad," fourteen-year-old Brittany whispered beside me at the screen door as Uncle Steve's dusty pickup truck turned slowly off Blackwater Road onto the crushed clam shells, parked beside Dad's sedan under the pecan tree, and clicked completely silent.

For ten long seconds, Uncle Steve didn't open his truck door. He just sat behind the steering wheel in his dusty baseball cap looking out across the sixty flat, cleanly shorn acres of pale-gold wheat stubble that his grandfather and father had plowed

before him, then took off his cap, wiped his forehead on his forearm, and walked slowly up the porch steps holding a single folded pink carbon-copy weigh ticket from the grain elevator.

Inside the bright farmhouse kitchen—where Aunt Karen and Dad stood waiting beside a fresh pitcher of iced tea while Katie, Brittany, and I sat quietly side by side on the three wooden stools along the breakfast bar—nobody spoke until Uncle Steve pulled out a chair at the oak table and flattened the pink settlement slip beside his green ledger book.

“Test weight came back good and dry—fifty-nine pounds to the bushel, zero dockage,” Uncle Steve said quietly, his voice steady and matter-of-fact without a trace of self-pity. He tapped the bottom right box of the pink slip with one calloused knuckle. “Cash board price at the elevator today was two dollars and ten cents a bushel.”

Aunt Karen closed her eyes briefly, letting out a soft, resigned breath as she stepped behind Uncle Steve’s chair and rested both hands warmly on his shoulders. Even Dad shook his head quietly in disbelief.

“Two-ten a bushel,” Dad murmured. “Steve, wheat was bringing well over four-fifty back in ninety-six.”

“World glut has every bin from Kansas to Norfolk overflowing, David, and diesel and fertilizer went up instead of down,” Uncle Steve said simply, looking down at the neat columns of pencil numbers he had already totaled in the margin of his green ledger. “After I hand custom-cutting their check for the combine and grain haul, pay off last October’s seed-and-nitrogen note at the cooperative, and set aside city land-use tax, eight months of growing sixty acres of winter wheat cleared four hundred and eighty-two dollars. If we sign another operating note on Monday to put double-crop soybeans in that ground at four-dollar bean prices—one August hurricane or dry spell puts us twenty thousand dollars upside down.”

Uncle Steve closed the green cloth cover of the farm ledger with a gentle, final pat and reached up to cover Aunt Karen’s hand on his shoulder.

“We gave the old place an honest last crop, Karen,” Uncle Steve said softly. “The numbers just aren’t there anymore. Call Mr. Holloway back on Monday morning—tell him we accept the offer on the acreage, and let’s go sign the closing papers on that brick ranch up on Earlton Court before July’s out.”

“You worked yourself half to death for ten years keeping this roof tight, Steve Fletcher,” Aunt Karen whispered, leaning down to kiss the top of his head with damp, proud eyes. “Nobody on Blackwater Road can ever say you didn’t do right by this land.”

On the stool to my left, Brittany ducked her chin hard, pulling off her silver wire-rimmed glasses for a second to press the sleeve of her t-shirt quickly against her eyes before Aunt Karen could see her cry. Right away, Katie nudged my knee under the counter, and the three of us slipped quietly out through the wooden screen door so Brittany’s mom and dad could have five minutes together in the kitchen.

Saturday, June 19, 1999, 7:45 PM — Walking Past the Red Cedar Post One Last Time & Our Promise for Ninth Grade

By quarter to eight that evening, after a quiet supper of Aunt Karen's baked ham, buttermilk biscuits, and the very last bowl of strawberries plucked out of the fenced kitchen patch behind the clothesline, the June sun sank low and copper-orange behind the distant cypress tops.

With every tractor, combine, and grain truck gone for good—retiring Uncle Steve's childhood safety rule on our final evening—Brittany led Katie and me right past the weathered red cedar post at the edge of the yard oak shade, across the white crushed-shell lane, and ten yards out onto the dry, open margin of the freshly harvested wheat field.

At fourteen years old, Katie's calves and mine had grown noticeably tighter after long walks than they had been back in fourth grade, making both of us step carefully over the uneven ridges of dark soil, yet neither of us would have missed walking out there beside our cousin for anything. Beneath our sneakers, the six-inch golden wheat stalks crunched crisp and clean, releasing the rich, toasted-bread scent of warm straw and Tidewater earth into the cooling evening air. Overhead, the sky turned deep violet-blue without a single shopping-center floodlight or highway glare anywhere on the horizon, and hundreds of yellow-green fireflies began blinking lazily above the ditch clover.

Brittany stopped beside the boundary furrow, hugged both arms across her ribs as she looked back at the white clapboard farmhouse and its glowing amber screened porch, and let two quiet tears spill down her cheeks behind her oval lenses.

"I know Pungo Ferry Road floods every time the wind blows wrong, and I hated riding ninety minutes on that rattling bus to Pungo Ridge Middle while everybody else lived near town," Brittany confessed thickly, trying and failing to laugh through the lump in her throat. "It's just—every summer memory I like from when we were little was right there inside those yard trees with you two. Once somebody else buys it, we can't ever come back down the shell lane again."

I didn't say a word first—I just stepped smoothly right between Brittany on my left and Katie on my right, lifted both arms, and pulled both of my favorite people in the world straight into a tight, steady three-way hug right there at the edge of the golden wheat stubble.

Katie immediately wrapped her left arm around my waist and reached her right arm all the way across my shoulders to hug Brittany's neck, resting her blonde head against mine while Brittany leaned her cheek gratefully against my left shoulder and let out a long, trembling breath until her shoulders stopped shaking.

"Somebody else only gets the dirt and the tractor shed, Brittany," Katie told her gently, squeezing Brittany's shoulder tight. "The good part wasn't the drainage ditches—it was the three of us having a quiet porch where nobody yelled at anybody. And Aunt Karen already showed Dad instant snapshots from the realtor listing of your new house up on Earlton Court."

"Do you realize how close Earlton Court is to Northwood High School?" I added warmly, keeping both arms wrapped firmly around Katie and Brittany as fireflies drifted past our knees. "Dad and I traced it on the Virginia Beach street map on Tuesday night. Your new driveway is literally right around the corner from

Macgregory Street and the back chain-link fence of Northwood High. Starting the day after Labor Day in ninth grade, there's no more Blackwater school bus and no more being split up across opposite ends of the city."

Brittany lifted her head off my shoulder, blinking away the last tear behind her silver glasses as a genuine, hopeful smile began tugging at the corners of her mouth.

"Every single day?" Brittany asked softly. "Same cafeteria lunch, same hallways, and you two can walk right through the back fence to our new house after school whenever Aunt Brenda's being mean?"

"Every single day of high school," I promised, giving both Katie and Brittany one more warm squeeze before taking Katie's hand in my right hand and Brittany's hand in my left hand to walk slowly back across the crunching golden stubble toward the glowing porch light.

Behind us, the sixty flat acres of Blackwater Road settled into quiet June twilight for the last time; ahead of us up in Kempsville, ninth grade and Earlton Court were waiting for all three of us together.

Freshman Lunch, Chicken Patty Bites, & The DeMarco Decree

Cramping Fingers, Cut-Up Chicken Patty Bites, & Two-Fifteen at the Dumpsters

Date: 2000-02-07 at 11:20 America/New_York

Monday, February 7, 2000, 11:20 AM — Three Round Blue Stools & Hands That Wouldn't Pinch

"Stop fighting the plastic knife and let me cut it before it gets cold, goofball," our fourteen-year-old maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher murmured warmly beside my left elbow, sliding my molded compartment tray half an inch closer across the royal-blue laminate tabletop so nobody across the noisy freshman aisle would even notice.

My right thumb and index finger unclenched around the flimsy white cafeteria utensil with a dull, burning tremor, dropping into my lap as I let out a quiet breath through my nose.

All morning long—through forty-five minutes of copying quadratic equations off the overhead projector in Algebra I and another forty-five minutes sketching cell diagrams in freshman Biology—the small muscles along the base of both of my thumbs had been tightening up like knotted shoelaces. Dr. Carter had jotted two pages of notes about grip fatigue in our chart back in January without having a clean name for it yet. On warm afternoons at home I could still type HTML tags on our keyboard as long as I rested my wrists flat against the desk pad, and Katie and I could still walk the hallways between bells alongside everyone else, even if the back stairwell left our calves tight by sixth period. By eleven-twenty on a cold February

Monday, however, trying to squeeze a thick sesame bun around a breaded school chicken patty—or saw through the crust with serrated cafeteria plastic—made my fingers shake and buckle as if my knuckles belonged to somebody else.

Having Katie and Brittany wedged right up against both of my shoulders turned what would have been humiliating anywhere else into a closed three-person fortress.

Northwood High School's cafeteria was packed wall to wall across the glossy tan-and-blue tiled floor with four hundred loud teenagers crammed along endless rows of long royal-blue folding tables mounted on chrome steel caster frames, each table flanked by individual round royal-blue backless stools bolted straight to the undercarriage. Ever since Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve Fletcher had sold their exhausting old farmstead down on Blackwater Road the previous summer and moved to Earlton Court right across the Lions Way fence, the three of us had claimed the exact same three adjacent blue stools on one side of a table near the edge of the room every single day of ninth grade, setting our three dark-blue compartment lunch trays side by side in a neat row along the tabletop—Katie perched on my right side, Brittany perched on my left side, and me always claiming the middle stool. Whenever we walked down a hallway or across the grass, being in the middle meant I got to hold both of their hands at once; whenever we sat together at lunch or on the couch, being in the middle meant I could wrap both arms out and hug my two favorite women in the world at the exact same time.

Pausing halfway through her own chicken sandwich and tater tots behind her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses, Brittany didn't sigh, didn't whisper about my hands, and didn't treat it like a big deal for half a second. Bracing her left fork neatly against my toasted bun right between her tray and mine, she used a plastic knife to slice my warm breaded chicken patty sandwich cleanly into twelve even, bite-sized squares while Katie set down her apple juice carton beside her own half-eaten tray on my other side, popped open the cardboard spout of my chocolate milk, slipped a paper-wrapped straw inside, and angled it right beside my wrist.

"Here," Brittany said casually, spearing a crisp corner square of chicken patty and bun onto a clean white plastic fork and lifting it straight up to my mouth. "Open up before Katie steals your tater tots."

"Hey, I traded him half my apple slices fair and square," Katie protested lightly on my right, resting her left hand over my stiff right forearm on the edge of the blue table to rub the cramp out of my wrist as I leaned forward and took the warm bite off Brittany's fork.

"Mmm-hmm, sure you did," Brittany teased, adjusting the sleeve of her plum sweater as she picked up a second square on the fork—making me grin while I chewed so I didn't have to stare down at my own uncooperative fingers in my lap.

Then a pair of scuffed sneakers skidded to a deliberate stop in the tiled aisle three feet from our chrome table frame, followed immediately by a loud, braying snort that cut right over the clatter of trays.

"Whoa, hold up—are you guys seeing this?" freshman loudmouth Josh Riley crowed, pivoting halfway toward the row of tables behind him with his baggy gray shirt hanging past his pockets and a greasy tray of French fries balanced on one hip.

“Look at Prairie! Dude can’t even hold his own sandwich anymore—he had to bring his chubby cousin to cut his crust off and spoon-feed him like a toddler in a high chair!”

Two boys sitting one table over glanced up awkwardly, while Josh leaned closer over the end of our royal-blue table with an ugly grin spreading across his face.

“Come on, Fletcher, make the little airplane sound for him!” Josh jeered, mimicking an exaggerated buzzing noise with his free hand right in front of Brittany’s glasses. “Open the hangar door for baby Natey—*nyeeeeow!*”

Brittany’s hand froze midair with the fork three inches from my chin, a hot, stung flush rising instantaneously up her neck and round cheeks at Josh’s swipe at both of us at once. On my right stool, Katie’s entire spine snapped taut; her blue eyes went blazing cold, her sneakers planted hard against the chrome footrest bar to vault straight off her stool into Josh’s face, and my own stomach dropped like lead.

Katie didn’t even get half an inch off the blue plastic seat before the air pressure in our corner of the cafeteria changed completely.

Monday, February 7, 2000, 11:24 AM — The DeMarco Decree & A Fresh Cookie on the Napkin

Across the three nearest blue tables, conversations didn’t merely quiet down—spoons stopped halfway to mouths, freshmen ducked their chins into their hoodies, and an electric, thrilled hush swept outward across the tile floor like an incoming tide. Even five months into ninth grade, every single freshman in the Class of 2003 recognized that sudden silence on instinct.

Josh Riley realized a fraction of a second too late that nobody behind him was laughing anymore.

“What?” Josh started, glancing over his shoulder—and nearly dropped his French fries onto his own shoes.

Standing eighteen inches behind his left elbow beneath the purple-and-gold Northwood Spirit lion banner was Mrs. DeMarco.

Northwood High’s cafeteria supervisor hadn’t hurried, hadn’t raised her voice, and hadn’t needed a whistle. Her salt-and-pepper hair sat tucked beneath a crisp white mesh hairnet over a burgundy-and-gold paisley blouse, her white canvas bib apron bore the honest smudges of three straight lunch shifts, and the handle of a heavy stainless-steel serving spoon gleamed upright out of her right front pocket like a magistrate’s gavel. Both of her forearms were folded squarely across her chest, and her dark, unblinking eyes were locked onto Josh Riley as if examining something unpleasant tracked in off a wet shoe.

By February of our freshman year, Josh Riley’s relationship with Northwood’s outdoor sanitation equipment was already established school legend. Back on the very first Tuesday after Labor Day in September, Josh had tried to crown himself king of the ninth grade by standing on a stool and bellowing a four-letter obscenity across the dining room—earning four straight afternoons hauling leaky trash bags at

the rear loading dock. He had gone back out to the dumpsters in October for flicking mashed-potato peas at the condiment counter, and again before Thanksgiving for cutting ahead of three seventh-period band kids in the pizza line.

Watching every drop of color drain out of Josh's face right beside our table, Katie slowly settled back onto her round blue stool and caught my eye, squeezing my forearm once as a tiny, triumphant spark lit behind her glare.

"Mrs. DeMarco!" Josh squeaked, his voice cracking half an octave as his shoulders caved inward. "I wasn't—we were just joking around! Ask Nate, I was just saying hi to—"

"Do not insult my intelligence on a Monday morning, Mr. Riley," Mrs. DeMarco said, her voice velvet-quiet yet carrying cleanly across forty royal-blue stools. "I stood six feet behind you while you elected to mock a classmate's hands and belittle a young lady showing basic family manners at my table."

Josh swallowed hard, staring fixedly at the linoleum between his sneakers while a bead of sweat appeared at his hairline.

"Evidently," Mrs. DeMarco continued smoothly, hitching her right thumb briskly back over her shoulder toward the heavy oak double doors at the rear of the room that led toward the kitchen corridor and the loading dock beyond, "your own hands are overflowing with far too much idle strength and theatrical coordination for an indoor dining environment. Fortunately for both of us, three lunch waves of milk cartons and sloppy-joe trays make for remarkably heavy bags."

Across the aisle, two sophomores silently mouthed the words right along with her before Mrs. DeMarco even delivered the sentence everyone knew by heart.

"You will meet me out at the dumpsters at two-fifteen sharp this afternoon, Mr. Riley—and at two-fifteen every afternoon for the remainder of this week," Mrs. DeMarco decreed, her tone as final as a courthouse stamp. "If you are sixty seconds late once the dismissal bell rings, we shall expand next week's curriculum to scraping gum off every blue stool frame in Section C, and I will phone your mother personally so she knows precisely when to pick you up. Are we crystal clear?"

"Yes, ma'am," Josh mumbled miserably into his collar. "Two-fifteen. At the dumpsters."

"Take your tray to the far end of Row Seven and eat in complete silence. Now."

Josh practically teleported down the aisle with his head ducked below shoulder height, while a ripple of quiet, satisfied grins broke out across the surrounding tables—including two quiet freshmen across the floor who caught Katie's eye and gave us a subtle, knowing nod, having watched the DeMarco Decree rain down on Josh Riley half a dozen times already that school year.

The instant Josh cleared our row, every ounce of icy courtroom severity melted right off Mrs. DeMarco's face.

Stepping gently up beside Brittany's stool, Mrs. DeMarco reached into the clean wax-paper pouch tucked flat in her left apron pocket, drew out three warm, oversize kitchen-baked chocolate-chip cookies wrapped in crisp deli tissue, and set them neatly on the clean corner of Brittany's tray.

"You never mind a loudmouth like him for half a second, sweetheart," Mrs. DeMarco said softly, resting a brief, maternal hand on the back of Brittany's shoulder before giving Katie and me an approving nod. "Looking out for your cousin without waiting to be asked shows real character. Take your time eating, all three of you—nobody's bothering this table."

"Thank you, Mrs. DeMarco," Brittany said, the embarrassed sting in her cheeks instantly warming into a genuine, grateful smile behind her silver oval frames.

"Thank you, ma'am," Katie and I echoed together.

Mrs. DeMarco offered us one warm wink and glided smoothly back out into the main aisle to resume her patrol, leaving the bustling hum of four hundred lunch conversations washing safely back around our three blue stools.

Brittany let out a long breath, adjusted her glasses with one knuckle, and looked sideways at me with a mischievous glint returning to her eyes.

"Two-fifteen in February wind behind the kitchen," Brittany whispered, lifting the plastic fork with that waiting square of breaded chicken patty right back up to my mouth while Katie slid her left hand down under the edge of the blue tabletop to hold my stiff right fingers gently in hers. "Hope he brought mittens in that backpack. Ready for bite number two?"

"Definitely," I smiled. Before taking the bite off Brittany's fork, I lifted both elbows —even with stiff fingers, my arms worked just fine for my favorite part of sitting on the middle stool—and pulled Katie against my right side and Brittany against my left side into a quick, tight two-armed hug right there behind our three lunch trays, getting an immediate warm squeeze back from both of my favorite women before leaning in happily for bite number two.

Sixteen & Summer Sanctuary

Earlton Court & Bonding With My Sister

Part 1: Through Smoker's Corner to Earlton Court, Aunt Karen's Couch, & Our Promise for Three

Date: 2001-05-24 at 14:00 America/New_York

Thursday, May 24, 2001, 2:00 PM — Officer Whitehead's Line & Holding Our Breath Through Smoker's Corner

"Deep breath on three before we step through the fence," our sixteen-year-old maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher warned, pushing her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses up the bridge of her nose with one finger as the heavy steel side doors of Northwood High School swung shut behind our backpacks in the warm May sunshine.

"Already holding mine," Katie laughed, tightening her left hand around my right hand as the two o'clock dismissal bell faded across the red-brick courtyard and forty diesel school buses roared to life in the afternoon loop behind us.

"Wait until we actually cross the grass to Lions Way, or you're going to pass out in the middle of the crosswalk," I told my twin sister as Brittany reached over to take my left hand in hers—putting me in my favorite spot right in the middle so I could hold both of their hands as we walked, just like sitting between them at lunch or on the couch let me hug both of my two favorite women at once—while we followed the sidewalk past the handicap spaces at the edge of the student parking lot and stepped straight out across the wide green grass lawn toward the perimeter road.

In Virginia Beach City Public Schools, high-schoolers couldn't just scribble a note and hop onto somebody else's yellow bus—every route out of Kempsville was packed three to a vinyl bench, and drivers didn't take afternoon bus passes. What regular afternoon buses also didn't take, however, was a roll-call clipboard. As long as your parents filed a standing written alternate-dismissal walker authorization with the attendance secretary in the Main Office—and listed your aunt right below your dad on the emergency contact card—you could walk right off campus at two o'clock whenever you didn't want to ride your regular bus home.

Ever since the summer before ninth grade, when Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve Fletcher had finally sold their exhausting old family farm way down in the rural southern end of Virginia Beach on Blackwater Road and moved into a neat brick ranch on Earlton Court, that five-minute walk off the edge of campus had been our favorite escape hatch of the week. Back when we were little kids, Brittany had practically lived at our house in Kempsville on weekday afternoons—watched by Dad or by our retired paternal grandmother, Grandma Ruth, who lived off her pension and Social Security in our fourth upstairs bedroom until Grandma Ruth moved back home to Newport, Rhode Island in 1998—whenever Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve worked odd shift hours up in town. Yet once school started each September, rural attendance lines had always pulled us apart, sending Katie and me five minutes down the road to Northwood Elementary and Morrison Middle while poor Brittany endured flooded wind tides across Pungo Ferry Road on her bus to Blackwater Elementary and hour-long rides to Pungo Ridge Middle. Moving to Earlton Court ahead of freshman year had put all three of us under the blue gabled roofs of Northwood High together every single day—and put Brittany's front porch less than a quarter mile from the campus fence.

There was only one catch standing between Lions Way and Earlton Court, and all three of us could smell it before we even finished cutting across the school lawn.

Whoever had laid out the back edge of Northwood High's grounds had painted a crisp white ladder-style crosswalk across two-lane Lions Way without bothering to pour a campus sidewalk to meet it—or a single curb cut on either side of the street. On our side of Lions Way, the wide green grass simply ended at an unbroken

standard concrete curb; on the far side, right in front of a tall gray cylindrical concrete light pole and two red-and-white striped road-end barricades, the crosswalk hit a second unbroken standard curb before a short, narrow strip of concrete ran straight through a gap in the galvanized chain-link fence and met the asphalt dead end of Macgregory Street completely level.

My left ankle twinged with the dull end-of-day stiffness that always crept into Katie's calves and mine by fourth block, so with Katie holding my right hand and Brittany holding my left hand, the three of us steadied each other as we stepped down off the grass curb onto the white crosswalk stripes, hurried across two-lane Lions Way, and stepped up over the opposite uncut curb onto the narrow concrete strip leading through the fence.

Behind us on the green grass of the school side of Lions Way stood School Resource Officer Whitehead with his arms folded across his dark navy uniform shirt. Fifteen feet ahead of us to the right, lounging where the flush concrete strip met the public asphalt dead end of Macgregory Street, stood a cluster of eighteen-year-old seniors everyone at Northwood called the Smoker's Corner crowd.

Every freshman learned the legal geometry of that concrete pole during the first week of September. Under Virginia law, eighteen-year-olds could legally possess tobacco once both shoes cleared school property, and the asphalt turnaround of Macgregory Street belonged to the City of Virginia Beach rather than the school board. As long as nobody under eighteen took a cigarette, nobody flicked anything across the property line, and nobody stepped back inside the chain-link opening during school hours, there was nothing Officer Whitehead could legally do except stand just inside the Lions Way fence like a hawk waiting for someone to slip up.

"Afternoon, Officer Whitehead," I murmured politely before sealing my lips shut.

Officer Whitehead gave the three of us a brief, approving nod—he knew Katie, Brittany, and me on sight as three quiet sophomores who never lingered on the asphalt for half a second—while Katie and Brittany both squeezed my hands tighter on either side and all three of us marched briskly through the narrow opening in the fence.

Even out in the open May breeze, a stale drift of burnt paper and ash hung near the edge of the turnaround from earlier in the afternoon. All three of us hated cigarette smoke with every fiber of our bodies; Katie and I had never forgotten watching our Aunt Liz light up outside the Newport News train station while our older cousin Chelsea coughed into her mittens, and nobody in the Fletcher house had ever touched tobacco either. Keeping our chins tucked and our lungs sealed tight, we cleared the Macgregory Street turnaround in twelve quick strides, followed the quiet residential sidewalk down to the corner, and turned right onto tree-shaded Earlton Court.

All three of us let our breath out in one loud, simultaneous rush and burst out laughing under the pin oaks.

"Ugh, I swear that corner smells like an old bowling alley carpet," Brittany groaned, fanning the collar of her plum-rose top with one hand as her caramel-blonde hair swung over her backpack straps. "If the city ever put a real gate lock on Macgregory Street, half the senior class wouldn't know where to stand at two-oh-five."

“At least your street is around the bend where the breeze stays clean,” Katie grinned, rolling her shoulders happily now that the noise of two thousand teenagers and forty school buses was behind us. “Is Aunt Karen working until four-thirty today?”

“Four-thirty, and Dad’s on the three-to-eleven maintenance shift, so we get the whole living room to ourselves for two hours,” Brittany smiled, pulling her brass house key on its beaded keychain out of her jeans pocket as we walked up the flat concrete driveway of her parents’ single-story brick ranch. “And Mom put a fresh twelve-pack of ginger ale on the bottom fridge shelf last night specifically because she figured you two would walk over with me today.”

Thursday, May 24, 2001, 2:20 PM — Cold Ginger Ale on Earlton Court & Our Floor Plan for Three

Inside the Fletchers’ house, the central air conditioning hummed quietly against the eighty-degree Tidewater afternoon, and the kitchen smelled faintly of lemon dish soap and the pot roast Aunt Karen had left simmering on low in the ceramic slow cooker on the counter. Right beside the fruit bowl sat a folded yellow sticky note in Aunt Karen’s neat cursive handwriting telling Brittany to make sure Katie and Nate stayed for supper if Uncle David wanted an extra hour to study for his community-college computer exam after work.

“See? My mom likes you two way better than she likes half our own relatives,” Brittany teased warmly as we kicked off our sneakers neatly on the hallway mat, set our heavy sophomore backpacks beside the coffee table, and carried three ice-cold green cans of ginger ale plus an open family-size box of frosted snack cakes and ridged potato chips into the sunlit living room. Years of lonely afternoons down on the Blackwater farmstead and shallow remarks from mean girls in the Northwood locker bays had left Brittany self-medicating stress with comfort food whenever the day wore her down, though around Katie and me nobody ever judged what was on a plate or how a shirt fit—the living room was simply safe ground.

Without anybody needing to call dibs on seats, the three of us settled onto Aunt Karen’s wide plaid sofa in the exact formation we had perfected over five winters and two years of high school. Katie curled up on my left side with her legs tucked under the soft cotton throw blanket and her head resting against my left shoulder, while Brittany set her cold soda can on a coaster, slipped off her wire-rimmed glasses for a minute to rub the bridge of her nose, and tucked herself snugly against my right side—wrapping her left arm warmly around my shoulders while reaching across my chest to tap Katie’s knuckles.

For a long, peaceful minute, nobody turned on the television. Just having four quiet walls, no raised voices upstairs, and the steady, familiar warmth of leaning against each other let every knot from four ninety-minute blocks of sophomore geometry, chemistry, and hallway crowds melt right out of my spine.

“Do you guys realize we only have three weeks left until sophomore year is completely done?” Brittany murmured against my right shoulder before sliding her glasses back on and picking up her ginger ale. “We’re sixteen now. Two more years at Northwood, and we actually graduate.”

“Don’t remind Mom,” I said dryly, taking a sip from my can while my left hand stayed laced comfortably with Katie’s on top of the throw blanket. “At our house, anytime anybody mentions the future, it turns into an argument before dinner’s even on the table. Half the reason Katie and I signed up to knock out an academic credit in summer school this July is just so we get Third-Block lunch and library study hall locked together next fall.”

Brittany shifted slightly on the cushion so she could look straight at both of us, her expression turning earnest behind her silver frames. Reaching down beside the armrest where her canvas backpack leaned against the carpet, she unzipped the front pouch and pulled out a glossy, magazine-sized booklet folded open to a page circled twice in purple gel pen.

“Look what I grabbed out of the free rack by the automatic doors at Market Square when I went grocery shopping with Mom on Tuesday,” Brittany said, spreading the *Hampton Roads Apartment & Townhome Guide* open across my lap so Katie and I could both see the black-and-white floor-plan diagrams.

Katie lifted her head off my shoulder, her blue eyes lighting up immediately as she traced the little architectural drawing with her fingertip. “Wait—is that a three-bedroom ground-floor flat?”

“Two bedrooms and a den, or a full three-bedroom right off Kempsville or over near Virginia Dominion University,” Brittany nodded eagerly, pointing to the monthly rent printed below the square-footage box. “I did the math during fourth-block study period. Once the three of us graduate in June of 2003 and turn eighteen, you two are going to be writing software and taking computer classes at CCHR just like Uncle David, and I’m going to get a full-time office or bookkeeping job while I take night classes. If the three of us split the rent and electric bill three ways, it costs less per person than a dorm room.”

I stared down at the little ink drawing of the living room—a wide rectangular space with a window overlooking a courtyard and zero stairs at the front entrance—and felt a genuine grin spread across my face.

“Look at the living-room wall right there,” I pointed out, tapping the center of the floor plan between Katie’s hand and Brittany’s sleeve. “That wall is fourteen feet wide. We could put a massive sectional couch right there, set up two computer desks along the opposite wall so Katie and I can code side by side without cords tripping anybody, and keep the fridge stocked with nothing but ginger ale, fruit punch, and Hearthstone leftovers.”

“Zero screaming upstairs,” Katie added softly, looking across my chest at Brittany with a bright, unguarded smile. “Zero cigarette smoke within a hundred yards of the windows. And nobody telling the three of us we have to split up or act like strangers.”

“Exactly,” Brittany said firmly, closing the apartment guide carefully so the dog-eared page stayed marked and resting her head right back down against my shoulder while Katie nestled back into my other side. “Back when we were stuck down on Blackwater Road and Grandma Ruth used to watch the three of us on your living-room rug while the tide came over Pungo Ferry Road—and that Blizzard of ’96

weekend when you guys let me climb under your blanket on the couch—your house with Uncle David and Grandma Ruth was the only place I never felt left out. When we grow up, we're getting our own place and living together as three. Deal?"

"Deal," Katie promised without a second's hesitation, reaching across my lap to squeeze Brittany's hand.

"Count on it," I agreed, resting my chin lightly over the top of Katie's platinum-blonde hair while keeping my right arm warm and steady around Brittany's shoulders—the three of us tucked safely together on the quiet Earlton Court couch with the whole summer stretching ahead of us.

Part 2: Summer Sanctuary: Hearthstone Pizza, The Sunlit Valley, & Katie's Room

Date: 2001-06-18 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — First Full Day of Summer

"Summer is here," I said, blinking open my eyes as the warm June sunlight filtered through the blinds of Katie's bedroom.

"Our first full day with the house to ourselves," my sister replied softly as we started waking up.

Having both turned sixteen back on April eighth, the two of us were curled up side by side in our pajamas on top of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread beneath the framed blue morpho butterfly artwork hanging on her magenta-purple wall, completely used to being pretend dates and full-time anchors for each other. With both of our parents already gone for their morning shifts and two quiet weeks stretching ahead of us before Summer School started, the entire house was finally calm.

Katie rubbed her eyes, then looked over at me and asked, "Get dressed and have breakfast?"

"Sure, I am getting hungry," I replied, giving her hand a quick squeeze as I climbed out of bed.

I stepped across the upstairs hallway into my own deep-blue painted bedroom to pull on a clean maroon crew-neck t-shirt and jeans while Katie changed in her room, and two minutes later we met right back at her doorway, exchanging a warm, familiar smile before making our way down the stairs together.

"Let's just have some cereal, then we will figure out what we want to do for the day," I said as we reached the bottom landing. "I want to spend the day with just you."

Our stomachs were calling us, as was our daily routine of taking our morning dose of medication before the day got underway. In the quiet kitchen, I pulled two ceramic bowls out from the cupboard and set our morning medication tablets beside

two glasses of water while we picked out our cereal from the pantry—being twins, of course it was the exact same box—and sat down at the kitchen table, pulling our chairs right up against each other so we were as close as possible.

After we took our morning medication and started on our cereal, my twin sister reached across the table, took my hand, and looked straight into my eyes.

“What would you like to do today?” Katie asked.

“I was thinking of snuggling on the sofa over a movie,” I suggested as we continued eating our breakfast side by side.

“I know just the movie I want to watch,” my sister said, squeezing my hand. She gave me that unmistakable look like she had a big secret and started giggling. She wanted me to ask what movie it was, but after sixteen years as her twin brother, I knew she wouldn’t tell me—I would have to wait and see what it was when she popped the tape into the VCR.

Since I had made breakfast, Katie took it upon herself to carry our bowls and spoons over to the counter and load our dishes into the dishwasher.

“I will get the tape, then will join you on the sofa,” Katie called over her shoulder as I headed toward the living room.

“Alright, Katie,” I replied, settling onto the cushions of our tan-brown living room sofa beside the coffee table, where Dad had neatly stacked the slightly outdated *Quantum Basic 5.0* programming textbooks—complete with clear plastic mylar covers and barcode stickers on the spines—that he had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall *Quantum Basic 6.0* class at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR. Over the past few weeks, Katie had started reading Dad’s library books cover to cover and teaching the programming exercises to me, and when Dad found out, he had beamed with pride and actively encouraged both of us to keep coding.

Even better, when Summer School started in two weeks, Katie and I weren’t going because we were behind. We had intentionally signed up to knock out an academic credit over the summer so that when our main high-school year started in September, our schedules would line up with a free period and lunch block together every single day. Until those summer classes began, I was looking forward to having unbroken time with my twin sister.

9:30 AM — *Hearthstone Pizza* & *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*

A minute later, Katie walked into the living room holding a familiar white clamshell VHS tape behind her back, slid the cassette into the VCR beneath the television, and walked over to sit on the sofa right next to me.

Immediately, she lifted her arm and made it clear she wanted me to snuggle up in her arms. I slid flush against her side and rested my head against her shoulder, glad that I got to curl up with Katie now that the two of us had become so close.

Across the room, the CRT television flickered to life. My eyes lit up as the sweeping orchestral welcome theme to one of our favorite companies—*Majestic Studios*—played across the screen, and then my eyes lit up even further as the previews transitioned and I recognized the exact childhood VHS movie that my sister had put on for us: *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*.

“I knew you would like it,” Katie whispered, resting her cheek against my hair as she looked down into my eyes.

“Of course,” I whispered back with a grin as the tape rolled through its iconic opening bumper before the feature presentation—the familiar, upbeat birthday party commercial from *Hearthstone Pizza* where the older brother was supposed to be nice to the little girl.

We happily stayed curled up together on the cushions as Sprout and his friends began their journey across the screen, wanting nothing more than to sit there quietly in each other’s arms watching the movie. Both of our parents were away at work, the house was completely peaceful, and we had decided that all we wanted was each other—just brother-and-sister time together in our sanctuary before Summer School was set to begin.

9:00 PM — Katie’s Room Beneath the Blue Butterfly

By the time evening rolled around and the June twilight faded outside the living room windows, we had spent the entire day side by side without a single argument, a single raised voice, or a single interruption from the outside world.

As we walked up the stairs together after dinner and paused on the second-floor landing between my blue-painted bedroom and her magenta-purple bedroom, Katie turned to me and took my hand.

“Share a bed?” Katie asked softly.

“Sure,” I replied without hesitation. “Your room or mine?”

“How about my room tonight,” Katie suggested with a gentle smile.

After I stepped into my blue room to brush my teeth and change into a comfortable t-shirt and flannel pajama pants, I crossed the hall and knocked lightly on Katie’s door. Inside her room, under the warm amber glow of the bedside lamp and the framed blue morpho butterfly on her wall, we climbed onto her bed together, propped our pillows against the headboard, and pulled the green-and-gold covers across our legs. Katie draped her arm around my shoulders and laced her fingers through mine, and as the house settled into quiet around us, we drifted off to sleep side by side.

End of Summer Cruise

Part 1: The I-95 Haul, The Quantum Basic Library Book, & Ditching Captain Barnaby

Date: 2001-08-19 at 09:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 18, 2001 — The Twelve-Hour Grumble Down I-95

“If *Command1_Click* calls the subroutine before the text box validates, the whole form throws a type-mismatch error,” Katie murmured beside me in the back seat of our Holt sedan, tapping her finger against page 142 of the thick paperback resting across our knees as another green Florida mileage sign flashed past the window on Interstate 95 South.

“That’s only in *Quantum Basic 5.0*,” our dad, David Prairie, called back from the driver’s seat, his eyes flicking warmly to the rearview mirror despite the fatigue of ten straight hours behind the wheel. “Wait until we test it on the *Quantum Basic 6.0* compiler at the CCHR lab next month. Though I’ll be honest with you two—I’d a whole lot rather be sitting at our kitchen table in Virginia Beach testing that code right now than driving to Port Canaveral.”

“So would we, Dad,” I grumbled, shifting my stiff legs on the bench seat while Katie laced her left hand through my right.

None of the three of us—not Dad, not Katie, and not me—had wanted to go on this seven-day Caribbean cruise at the end of August. Back in July, Katie and I had worked hard through our high-school summer school class, knocking out a required academic credit early so that when eleventh grade started in September, our main school-year schedules would free up for a shared lunch block together every single day. All the three of us had wanted for the final two weeks of summer was to stay home in peace so Dad could study for his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR.

To get a head start before classes began, Dad had gone to the Virginia Beach Public Library and checked out the newest programming manual they had left on the shelf—a slightly outdated, dog-eared copy of *Learn Quantum Basic 5.0 in 21 Days* wrapped in a clear plastic mylar library jacket with a barcode sticker on the spine. Within forty-eight hours of Dad setting that book on the dining table, Katie had started reading it cover to cover and teaching the event loops and form layouts to me on my bedroom computer. When Dad caught us working through his library book together, he hadn’t been upset at all; he had beamed with pride and started actively encouraging both of us to follow our dreams.

Up in the front passenger seat, however, our mother, Brenda, hadn’t cared about Dad’s CCHR classes, our summer school credit, or the fact that twelve hours crammed into a sedan was making Katie’s and my legs ache from hip to ankle. Mom had insisted on booking this seven-day Eastern Caribbean cruise—and when we finally rolled over the causeway into Port Canaveral on Saturday afternoon, the visual irony hit Katie and me right through the windshield.

Docked at the premier terminal across the blue channel stood a gleaming, navy-and-gold *Majestic Cruise Line* ship, its twin funnels shining in the Florida sun.

We didn't turn into the *Majestic* terminal. Instead, Mom directed Dad toward Pier 3, where a boxy, bargain-rate mass-market ship called the *M/S Sunward Tropics* was loading passengers.

By four o'clock that afternoon, standing packed shoulder-to-shoulder in bulky orange foam lifejackets out on the humid teak planks of the Deck 4 Boat Promenade for the mandatory twenty-minute safety muster drill—with all of the ship's elevators shut off—I felt the first warning tremor shoot down both of my calves. Beside me, Katie was leaning almost her entire weight against my right arm just to keep her knees locked. Both of us had lived with mild cerebral palsy since birth, which had always made our balance uneven, but standing on that hot deck before climbing two flights of metal stairs back to our cramped inside cabin left our legs shaking and our arms strangely weak on the brass banisters in a way neither of us had ever felt before.

Dad walked right behind us up every step of the stairwell, one hand braced behind Katie's back and the other steadying my elbow, his brow furrowed with quiet concern as he watched how hard our arms were straining just to pull ourselves up the railing.

Sunday, August 19, 2001, 9:30 AM — Ditching *Captain Barnaby* for the Deck 8 CyberCafé

"Look at the two of you—you're going to be late for the character breakfast!" Mom snapped at nine-twenty on Sunday morning, shoving two neon-yellow *"Camp Sunward Youth"* lanyards and a printed activity sheet into Dad's hand before disappearing out the cabin door toward the Lido Pool Bar. "And I put Katie's name down for the two o'clock beginner ballet and ballroom workshop in the Starlight Lounge!"

Katie stared at the pink dance slip in horror, her fingers tightening around my wrist as the ship rolled gently on its first full day at sea heading toward Nassau.

"Come on," Dad said quietly, his jaw tight as he picked up his canvas backpack—with the Virginia Beach Public Library *Quantum Basic 5.0* book tucked inside—and led Katie and me down the narrow corridor to the elevator. "Let's go see what your mother signed you up for."

Five minutes later, the three of us stood outside the double glass doors of the Starlight Lounge on Deck 6.

Inside, thirty screaming six- and seven-year-olds were banging plastic spoons against paper placemats while accordion music blared from the speakers. Waddling between the tables were two sweaty crew members zipped into bargain-bin polyester foam mascot suits—*Captain Barnaby the Buccaneer Parrot* and *Salty the Starfish*—whose faded fabric looked like it had been pulled out of a carnival trash bin.

At the podium by the door, a twenty-two-year-old youth counselor glanced down at her clipboard—where Mom had written *Prairie, Nathaniel* and *Prairie, Katie*—and then looked up at two sixteen-year-old high schoolers standing side by side in t-shirts and jeans. Her face turned bright red with second-hand embarrassment.

Dad took one look through the glass doors at the foam parrot, looked at Katie's and my mortified faces, and didn't hesitate for half a second.

"Take those yellow lanyards off, kids," Dad said calmly.

Stepping up to the podium, Dad handed the lanyards back to the relieved counselor, drew a clean line through both of our names on the character breakfast roster, and asked her to cross Katie's name off the afternoon ballet workshop sheet as well.

"Where are the computers and the arcade cabinets on this ship?" Dad asked the counselor.

"Deck 8 Midship, sir—right next to the quiet library and card room," she replied gratefully.

Ten minutes later, sitting side by side in two padded armchairs inside the air-conditioned quiet of the Deck 8 CyberCafé overlooking the deep blue Atlantic, Katie and I finally exhaled. Dad swiped his cabin card to buy two hours of desktop terminal time, pulled the thick, mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook out of his bag, and set it open on the desk right between our keyboards.

While Mom spent the entire Sunday at sea up at the pool bar, the three of us spent the afternoon right there by the ocean windows—Katie pointing out how to nest *For…Next* loops on the screen, my fingers typing the syntax into the editor, and Dad sitting right beside us smiling with genuine pride.

Part 2: The Nassau Pier, Guest Services, & The Last Straw

Date: 2001-08-22 at 14:00 America/Puerto_Rico

Monday–Wednesday, August 20–22, 2001 — The Nassau Pier & The Honest Question

"Hold onto my arm, Nate—don't look down at the concrete," Katie breathed against my shoulder as the ninety-two-degree Bahamas sun beat straight down onto the endless gray concrete expanse of Prince George Wharf in Nassau on Monday morning.

Ahead of us, Mom was already a hundred yards down the pier, marching briskly toward the duty-free liquor stores and open-air bars along Bay Street without once looking back to see where her children were. Halfway between the ship's gangway and the terminal gate, my right knee buckled without warning. When Katie tried to catch my weight with both hands, her own wrists gave out, and both of us nearly went down onto the hot concrete before Dad caught us under the arms and guided us onto a shaded wooden bench beside the port tram stop.

“Neither of you is walking another step in this heat,” Dad said firmly, kneeling down to check our trembling ankles before flagging down the port courtesy shuttle and hiring an air-conditioned island van driver to take just the three of us over the bridge to the step-free underwater glass aquarium tunnel on Paradise Island.

Over the next forty-eight hours—as the ship steamed south from the Bahamas toward Charlotte Amalie in St. Thomas and Philipsburg in St. Maarten—the gap between what Mom wanted and what our bodies could handle grew wider by the hour. Every time the ship rolled in the Caribbean swell, walking the long metal passageways felt like wading through wet cement, while Mom spent every afternoon running up the cabin bar tab and complaining whenever she passed us that Katie wasn’t attending the ship’s dance classes.

On Wednesday afternoon, Dad collected Katie and me outside the Deck 8 arcade, led us to a quiet, shaded alcove of deck chairs, and looked straight at the two of us.

“Please be honest,” Dad asked quietly. “Are you two not enjoying the cruise?”

When Katie and I looked at each other and struggled to come up with an answer, Dad leaned forward and rested his hands on his knees.

“I want to let you both in on how I feel,” Dad said earnestly. “Katie, this especially goes for you. I watched you teach your brother the *Quantum Basic* programming that I am learning in school at CCHR, and I am absolutely encouraging both of you to keep at it if you both like it. I see that your mother is trying to talk you into being a ballerina, but I get that you don’t want to.”

“I don’t have the balance to dance,” Katie said honestly, looking down at her sneakers. Mom still refused to accept that we had cerebral palsy—let alone whatever was making our arms and legs grow weaker this summer—insisting she saw two completely healthy kids. “I like this coding thing.”

“And I am encouraging you with this coding thing… I am encouraging both of you,” Dad said warmly.

“I didn’t appreciate that Mom tried booking us on the kid stuff,” I added, thinking back to the foam parrot mascot at Sunday morning’s breakfast door. “Katie and I are sixteen and already in high school, and I don’t want to meet the characters. It’s not even the characters that little kids want to meet, because it’s not *Majestic Cruise Line*! I want to play the computer games.”

“I get it,” Dad said, nodding firmly. He took a deep breath, his expression turning solemn. “There is something else I wanted to confide in both of you, and that is Mom’s drinking issue. Our next stop will be the front counter where I want to attempt to cut off the flow of alcohol to your mother.”

2:45 PM — Cutting Off the Flow at the Front Counter

The process at the Purser’s Desk in the Deck 5 Atrium Lobby seemed to drag on forever, and Katie and I found a padded seat across the lobby while we waited for Dad to be finished.

Because every bar on the ship operated on cashless plastic stateroom keycards—and because Dad's *Anchor Federal Credit Union* card was the sole payment method guaranteeing our cabin's Master Folio—Dad had the authority as the primary account holder to revoke all charging privileges on Mom's keycard and have the Watch Purser place a mandatory alcohol cut-off flag on her passenger ID across the ship's point-of-sale network.

When Dad finally walked back over to our bench, he held out three plastic cabin keycards, each newly stamped with a small holographic fountain-cup sticker.

"I bought the three of us a soda package, and we can get sodas and juice every fifteen minutes," Dad told us. "Your mother is going to be mad, but I don't care. I am so sorry to both of you that it is turning out like this, but I have to protect both of you."

Sitting down beside us for a moment, Dad lowered his voice to a quiet whisper.

"I know that you two have decided that you are inseparable, and I am okay with that, and I won't tell the world about your little secret," Dad whispered, looking at Katie and me with steady, unconditional protective warmth. "Yes, I know, and I think I've known for a while. Just don't go blabbing to everyone, and be careful with things."

3:30 PM — The Corridor Breakdown & The Ultimatum

The three of us rode the elevator down to Deck 4 and walked to our stateroom—and to our horror, though not to our surprise, when Dad opened the door, our mother was passed out drunk across the three-cushion convertible sofa that was supposed to unfold into the bed that Katie and I shared at night.

"Oh, I've had enough of your mother's nonsense," Dad said, pulling the door shut and turning Katie and me right around in the passageway.

We walked a long way through a narrow, windowless maze of identical stateroom hallways—our legs trembling and our feet stumbling against the carpet seams with every roll of the ship—until we finally reached a quiet stairwell seating alcove and sat down on the built-in bench.

Right there under the brass wall sconces, Dad buried his face in his hands and absolutely lost it, breaking down and crying.

Katie and I were completely at a loss for words. Our mental image of Daddy being tough and unbreakable came crashing down all at once, and for the first time in our sixteen years, we were seeing the exhausted, hurting human side of our father.

Katie and I sat close against his sides on the bench and just waited, holding hands because this was something neither of us knew how to respond to.

"I guess it will have to be a cruise for three," Katie whispered softly to me.

“Yeah, I guess,” I whispered back to my sister. We both looked over at our father, who was the most upset we had ever seen him in our lives. I didn’t even remember crying this hard when taking a bad fall on the pavement, and yet here the three of us were.

“I’ll try my best to handle this. Daddy needs us right now,” Katie whispered, resting her hand on Dad’s arm. “This is going to be a long and painful cruise.”

That was when we heard a screaming rage echoing down the metal hallway toward our alcove.

“The heck was that?” I asked, my heart jumping as a startled Katie looked up beside me.

“Where is my fucking beer?!”

Our mother had woken up from her drunken nap on our sofa, stormed up to the nearest deck bar, discovered that her keycard had been cut off at the register, and tracked us down the corridor—drunkenly screeching profanities at our visibly upset father.

Spotting Katie and me sitting on the alcove bench directly beneath the black dome of the stairwell’s ceiling security camera, Mom’s bloodshot eyes locked onto us.

“And you two ungrateful brats!” she slurred loudly, staggering forward toward our bench. “I signed you up for the character meet-and-greet and the dance class, and you ditched them and got your father to cut off my card!”

As she lunged toward our bench and swung her arm wildly in my direction, her balance gave out and she missed completely as Dad surged to his feet and stepped squarely between her and the bench, blocking her path in full view of the ceiling security camera.

“Don’t you ever raise a hand toward them!” Dad said, his voice turning to iron as he wiped the last trace of tears from his eyes. “I’ve had enough, and so have the kids. This cruise was supposed to be family time, and the three of us are tired of your drinking. Nathaniel, Katie, and I are giving you a choice right now: us, or the alcohol.”

Mom glared at us and slurred something bitter that none of us could even understand.

“Message received,” Dad said flatly. “You pick the bottle over your husband and children.”

Turning his back on her, Dad looked down at Katie and me and reached out both hands to help us stand up as our mother drunkenly stumbled away down the hall.

“Come on, you two,” Dad said gently. “I want you to show me what you two would like to do.”

As he supported our elbows and led Katie and me away down the passage, Dad made a vow that neither of us would ever forget.

“I’m making both of you a promise: I want to be a dad, and I want you both to help guide me through this,” Dad said quietly. “It will be painful, but your mother does not seem to want to be a mom. I’m sorry, but I have to do right by both of you.”

Holding onto Dad’s arms as our exhausted legs shook beneath us, the three of us stumbled through what felt like an endless hallway of cabins until we finally stumbled out into the bright light of the lobby.

Part 3: Stateroom 6004, The Loaner Wheelchairs, & Pizza for Three on the Aft Deck

Date: 2001-08-23 at 18:30 America/Puerto_Rico

Wednesday, August 22, 2001, 4:15 PM — Domestic Separation, The Brig, & Two Manual Wheelchairs

“My kids can barely stand up after walking down that Deck 4 corridor, and my wife is screaming profanities at us in the passageway,” Dad told the Chief Purser flatly as the three of us reached the front counter in the Atrium Lobby, my knees trembling so badly that I had both hands braced against the marble counter edge while Katie leaned against my side. “I am not putting my son and daughter back in Stateroom 4118 with her tonight. I don’t want her in the cabin with us anymore.”

The Chief Purser glanced down at the black security radio clipped to his lapel, took one look at Dad’s raw, red-rimmed eyes and one look at Katie and me struggling to stay upright on our feet, and immediately picked up a brass master key.

“Deck 4 Security just radioed up after reviewing the stairwell alcove security camera feed, Mr. Prairie,” the Chief Purser said quietly. “Our camera recorded your wife’s outburst in the corridor and her attempt to swing at your son on the bench before you stepped in. We hold two wheelchair-accessible contingency staterooms right off the Deck 6 midship elevators for medical and family safety emergencies. I am placing a confidential Domestic Separation Flag on your manifest right now and moving you, Nathaniel, and Katie into Stateroom 6004. Only your three soda-package keycards will open that door, and our staff is strictly prohibited from disclosing your new cabin number to your wife.”

Dad let out a long breath of pure relief, then glanced down at Katie’s shaking ankles and mine.

“Is there any chance the ship has two manual wheelchairs my twins can use for the rest of the cruise?” Dad asked, looking back at Katie and me to make sure we agreed.

Both Katie and I nodded immediately. Neither of us cared what strangers on a cruise ship thought—we were exhausted from fighting our own legs every time we crossed a deck.

“Consider it done, sir,” the Chief Purser replied. “I’ll have the Medical Center bring two folding *SwiftChair* manual wheelchairs straight up to Stateroom 6004 while our stewards transfer your bags and your library books from Deck 4.”

By five o'clock that afternoon, Dad, Katie, and I were safely upstairs inside Stateroom 6004—a wide, quiet room five steps from the elevator lobby with a clean double sofa bed that unfolded without a single obstacle and two folding manual wheelchairs waiting by the door.

At seven-fifteen that evening, while Katie and I were sitting together on the sofa bed reading Dad's *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book, a polite knock sounded on our cabin door. When Dad opened it, the Chief Purser stood in the corridor with a clipboard under his arm.

"I wanted to check on you and the twins in person, Mr. Prairie, and let you know that you won't have to worry about running into your wife on the decks for the rest of the voyage," the Chief Purser told Dad evenly, his voice carrying clearly to where Katie and I sat. "About an hour ago, Mrs. Prairie returned to Stateroom 4118, found your luggage gone, and came down to the Atrium Lobby after her keycard was declined at the Lido Bar. When we refused to disclose your new cabin number or unblock her alcohol privileges, she tried to climb over the Purser's counter and swung a fist at one of our Security officers. The Staff Captain has placed her in the ship's brig down on Deck 2."

Katie's hand tightened around mine on the sofa cushion as we listened.

"Because we have already cleared our final Caribbean port of call and are steaming north," the Chief Purser continued, handing Dad a thick, sealed manila envelope, "she will remain in security custody until we dock at Port Canaveral on Saturday morning, where she will be escorted off the vessel and handed a permanent lifetime ban from *Sunward Cruise Lines*. Inside this envelope is a certified copy of our Shipboard Security Incident Report along with a duplicate VHS tape from the Deck 4 stairwell security camera documenting the 3:30 PM corridor incident, in case your family attorney in Virginia needs official documentation. I also want to assure you, Nathaniel, and Katie that your names are completely clear—none of the three of you are excluded from sailing with us in the future."

Dad thanked him quietly and closed the door. Mom had managed to get herself banned from a cruise line yet again—not that Dad, Katie, or I ever wanted to set foot on a cruise ship again in the first place.

Thursday, August 23, 2001, 6:30 PM — Pizza & Soda Refills on the Aft Deck

"Two pepperoni slices, two extra-cheese slices, and three fifteen-minute fountain refills—two colas and an orange juice," Dad announced with a genuine smile on Thursday evening as he set a steaming stainless-steel pizza platter and three tall plastic tumblers down on our round table out on the open wooden aft deck.

Sitting side by side in our two ship-provided folding manual wheelchairs right at the back rail of Deck 9, watching the white foaming wake of the ship stretch out across the turquoise Caribbean Sea under a golden-orange sunset, Katie and I reached across the space between our wheelchair armrests and laced our fingers together.

Inside the main dining rooms tonight was Captain's Formal Night, where hundreds of passengers were crammed into noisy banquet halls in stiff suits and high heels. Out here on the breezy fantail deck, wearing comfortable t-shirts and jeans with zero

pain in our calves or knees thanks to the manual wheelchairs, the last two days of the voyage had finally become what Katie had whispered in the corridor alcove: a peaceful cruise for three.

“How do the chairs feel?” Dad asked softly, pulling his deck chair right up beside our wheels and picking up a slice of pizza.

“So much better, Dad,” Katie said, leaning her head briefly against my shoulder as she took a sip from her straw. “My legs aren’t shaking at all.”

“Mine either,” I agreed, looking down at our three soda-sticker keycards resting together on the table next to Dad’s library copy of *Quantum Basic 5.0*. For the first time all week, nobody was yelling, nobody was trying to force Katie to dance or shove us into a room with foam parrot mascots, and as the warm ocean breeze blew past the stern rail, the three of us talked for two straight hours about the programs we were going to write when we got home to Virginia Beach.

Part 4: Back on Dry Land & The Twelve-Hour Drive Up I-95

Date: 2001-08-25 at 08:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 25, 2001, 8:30 AM — Back on Dry Land

“Nathaniel. Katie. I’m sorry that your first cruise was wrecked, and somehow I want to make it up to both of you,” Dad said earnestly as two crew members helped us transfer out of the ship’s loaner wheelchairs onto the gray cloth back bench seat of our Holt sedan at the Port Canaveral pickup curb. Resting a steady hand on each of our shoulders through the open door, Dad continued, “Here is what we will do: neither one of you wanted to go on that cruise, but your mother insisted. I want to finish school at CCHR so that I can do a better job at being a dad without having to worry about money as much.”

Before Katie or I could answer him, an angry screech tore across the concrete baggage drop from behind us.

“You! You told the ship to stop my drinks!”

Looking through the open rear doorway, I saw our mother being escorted out of the customs terminal doors by two *Sunward Cruise Lines* security officers after being released from the ship’s brig, clutching a folded white sheet of permanent lifetime ban paperwork in her fist. Her face was flushed dark red in the morning Florida heat as she stormed up to the rear fender of our car.

Every muscle in Dad’s jaw tightened as he straightened up beside our open door and looked at her.

“If we were anywhere near Hampton Roads right now, Brenda, I would hand you twenty dollars for a bus fare and leave you standing on this curb,” Dad told her, his voice as cold and flat as steel. “The only reason I am unlocking this front door is because we are seven hundred miles from Virginia. Get in the front passenger seat, and don’t say a single word to the kids for the next twelve hours. The second this car pulls into our driveway in Virginia Beach, you are packing your bags and getting out of our house.”

Without waiting for her to reply, Dad closed our rear door securely, walked around to the driver's side, and pulled out of Port Canaveral toward Interstate 95 North.

12:15 PM — Exit 94 Near Savannah, Georgia: The Gas Pump, The Restrooms, & Brenda's First Angle

For the first three and a half hours heading north out of Florida across the Georgia state line, the inside of the car was dead silent except for the hum of the tires and the air conditioner. In the back seat, Katie and I sat pressed shoulder-to-shoulder with our inner hands laced together and Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook resting across our knees.

Just past noon, the low-fuel chime dinged on the dashboard, and Dad signaled right at Exit 94 near Savannah, pulling under the canopy of a highway travel plaza so we could get gas and use the restrooms.

That stop was when the physical reality of leaving the ship hit Katie and me all over again.

On Thursday and Friday aboard the *Sunward Tropics*, we had rolled everywhere in the Medical Center's two folding loaner wheelchairs. Those wheelchairs belonged to the ship, which meant they were still back at Port Canaveral. When Dad opened our rear door beside Pump 6 and I swung my sneakers out onto the ninety-degree Georgia concrete, my knees and calves trembled so violently that I had to grab the roof frame with both hands just to keep from sliding onto the pavement. Beside me, when Katie tried to push herself up off the bench cushion, the strength in her right forearm gave out halfway up, and she gasped softly as she sank back against the seat.

Up front, Mom didn't even glance back at our door. She slammed the front passenger door shut and marched briskly across the concrete apron toward the air-conditioned travel store restrooms on her own.

Dad saw us struggling immediately. Leaving the gas nozzle clicking in the tank, he stepped right between Katie and me, braced his left arm firmly around Katie's waist and his right hand under my elbow, and took half of our weight onto his own shoulders.

"Take your time, kids—I've got both of you," Dad murmured close to our ears as he walked us slowly, step by shuffling step, across the hot pavement and up the curb ramp to the restroom hallway. He stood waiting right between the men's and women's doors until both of us came back out, then supported us all the way back to the back seat of the Holt before topping off the tank and paying at the window.

When Mom finally strolled back out of the convenience store carrying a bottle of water and buckled herself into the front passenger seat, her furious scowl from Port Canaveral was suddenly replaced by self-pity. As Dad checked in the rearview mirror to make sure Katie and I were buckled securely into our back-seat shoulder belts, shifted into drive, and merged back onto I-95 North, Mom launched into a bitter, non-stop tirade about how "unfairly" she had been treated down in the ship's brig.

“David, honey, look—let’s be reasonable now that we’re off that awful boat,” Mom complained, turning slightly toward him in the front seat. “Do you have any idea how terrible life in a cruise ship brig actually is, or what I just went through for sixty-two straight hours? It was completely unfair! That purser had it out for me from the moment we boarded, and those security guards treated me like a common criminal over a couple of drinks!”

In the back seat, Katie and I glanced at each other and squeezed hands as Mom kept going, oblivious to the way Dad’s jaw was clenching harder with every word out of her mouth.

“They put wrist restraints on me and marched me down a steel freight elevator to the Deck 2 crew corridor below the waterline, right on top of the diesel engine room!” Mom ranted, her voice rising with indignation. “They confiscated my cabin card, my wristwatch, my belt, and even my shoes! For two and a half days I was locked inside a windowless steel box that vibrated twenty-four hours a day from the ship’s engines. No porthole, no clock, no television, no pillow—just a hard vinyl mat bolted to the steel floor with a stiff hook-and-loop tear-away blanket, an institutional stainless-steel toilet welded to the sink in the corner, and a blinding fluorescent ceiling light with a security camera staring at me that never turned off once!”

Beside me, Katie leaned her head close to my shoulder. Both of us could see the muscles in Dad’s neck and shoulders stiffening against the driver’s backrest. Mom thought she was winning sympathy, when in reality every single complaint she made was hardening Dad’s resolve like poured concrete.

“And the food!” Mom went on, gesturing with her water bottle. “While the three of you were upstairs doing whatever you wanted, they wouldn’t even let me have a soda! Every four hours the ship’s doctor or some nurse slid open the metal slot in the door to take my blood pressure and hand me paper cones of lukewarm tap water and salt packets while my head was splitting open! Three times a day a guard shoved a paper plate of bland crew-galley mush through the slot with a bendable plastic spoon, and every fifteen minutes day and night a guard slid the peephole open to write on a clipboard! Then yesterday afternoon they had the nerve to tell me that stewards had packed my clothes out of Cabin 4118 with red security tape and handed me a lifetime ban! I’ve been punished enough, David—there’s no reason to talk crazy about me packing bags when we get home.”

Katie looked at me and gave a tiny, unmistakable shake of her head. *Every argument she makes,* Katie’s eyes said to mine, *just weakens her case even more.*

I thought the exact same thing. For sixty-two hours down on Deck 2, Mom hadn’t spent a single minute worrying about her sixteen-year-old twins or her husband—she had only cared about her confiscated watch, her crew-galley trays, and her cut-off beer tab.

From the back bench seat, I watched Dad’s knuckles turn white against the top of the steering wheel. In the rearview mirror, his eyes met mine and Katie’s for a brief, steady second before he answered without even looking at Mom.

“You swung a fist at a ship security officer because they wouldn’t serve you beer at four o’clock in the afternoon, Brenda,” Dad said in a low, gravelly voice that carried clearly to the back seat. “That headache you had down on Deck 2 was sixty-two hours of forced sobriety. And while you were passed out drunk on the kids’ sofa bed before security locked you up, I had to hold our sixteen-year-old son and daughter

up by their elbows because their legs and arms were giving out on them. Just ten minutes ago at that gas pump, neither one of them could stand up out of the back seat without leaning on me, and you walked right past them to the store without looking back once. That brig wasn't unfair. It was the consequence of who you've chosen to be."

4:45 PM — Rocky Mount, North Carolina: Drive-Thru Dinner & Cementing the Lawyer Decision

By quarter to five that afternoon, as the green highway signs ticked past Fayetteville and into Rocky Mount, North Carolina, the three of us were starving and needed another restroom stop.

After Dad helped Katie and me carefully in and out of the roadside rest-area bathrooms just off the exit—where my wrists shook so badly I could barely push the heavy metal restroom door open by myself—Dad didn't make us walk inside a crowded highway sit-down restaurant and try to carry plastic food trays on trembling arms. Instead, he pulled the Holt sedan straight into the drive-thru lane of a *Penny's* hamburger restaurant next to the interstate ramp, ordered four cheeseburger meals, and handed a warm white paper bag of cheeseburgers and fries back to Katie and me before merging back onto the highway.

Buckled safely into our three-point shoulder seatbelts side by side on the gray cloth rear bench seat as the pine trees and green *I-95 NORTH* signs rolled past our rear window, Katie held the white paper *Penny's* bag on her lap while Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook rested open across mine, with our inner hands clasped tightly together on the cushion between us.

Up in the front passenger seat, as Mom finished her sandwich, I heard her abandon the brig complaints and try a second angle—cold financial bargaining.

"Think about this logically for two seconds, David," Mom said, her voice sharp and calculating in the quiet car. "You're taking classes at CCHR. How exactly do you think you're going to pay the house note in Virginia Beach, buy groceries, finish your degree, and take care of two sixteen-year-olds all by yourself without my income? Look—I'll cut back to drinking only on Friday and Saturday nights. We can put this behind us and go back to normal on Monday."

Beside me in the back seat, Katie squeezed my left hand with her right. Neither of us was even afraid that Dad would give in anymore—watching the back of Dad's shoulders, both of us could tell that Mom was digging her own grave deeper with every sentence.

"She doesn't get it at all," Katie whispered so softly that only I could hear her over the hum of the highway tires.

"Not even a little," I whispered back, looking down at our joined hands between my open *Quantum Basic* book and her lunch bag. Since the day we were born, Katie and I had been each other's anchor, best friend, and safe harbor—and in the lifelong bond the two of us shared, there was simply no room left for someone as bitter, selfish, and mean as our mother. All we needed was each other and our dad.

Up front, I watched Dad slowly set his cup into the center console holder, glance briefly toward the passenger seat, and speak in a calm, ironclad voice I had never heard from him in my life.

“Thank you for saying that out loud, Brenda—because if I had one percent of doubt left about seeking a lawyer’s advice when we get home, every argument you’ve made since Florida just erased it,” Dad told her evenly. “You spent three hours complaining about a steel bunk in the brig, and now you’re bargaining to drink on weekends—and you still haven’t asked Nathaniel or Katie a single time in eight hours why their legs and arms are failing them. I don’t care if I have to work double shifts around my CCHR classes to pay the bills. First thing Monday morning at eight-thirty, I am calling a divorce lawyer to file for divorce and full custody of the twins, and my very next call is going to be to Dr. Carter’s office to get both of them examined. We are never going back to ‘normal.’”

Mom opened her mouth, saw the look on Dad’s face, and snapped her jaw shut without another word for the rest of North Carolina and Virginia.

9:15 PM — Home in Virginia Beach: Packing the Bags

At nine-fifteen that night, after more than twelve hours on the road, the headlights of our Holt sedan finally swept across our driveway in Virginia Beach.

Before touching a single suitcase in the trunk, Dad walked around to our rear door, helped Katie and me out of the back seat, and supported both of us up the front steps and straight inside to the living room sofa, propping two throw pillows behind our backs and setting his *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book on the coffee table within easy reach.

Then, true to his word from Port Canaveral, Dad walked back out into the front foyer, folded his arms across his chest, and stood watch at the bottom of the stairs for forty-five straight minutes while Brenda packed her suitcases, dragged them out the front door to her car, and backed out of the driveway.

When Dad clicked the front deadbolt shut and walked into the living room to check on us, our house was finally, mercifully peaceful.

Part 5: Monday Morning in Virginia Beach — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

Date: 2001-08-27 at 10:15 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 10:15 AM — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

“Squeeze my fingers as hard as you can, Nathaniel, and hold it for five seconds,” Dr. Evelyn Carter instructed gently inside Exam Room 2 of her Virginia Beach family practice clinic on Monday morning.

Sitting side by side on the crinkly white paper of the padded exam table in our t-shirts and jeans, Katie and I kept our inner hands laced tightly together between our knees while I reached my left hand out to squeeze Dr. Carter's fingers.

Earlier that morning at eight-thirty, while Katie and I sat at the kitchen table eating cereal with the sealed *Sunward Cruise Lines* manila envelope resting beside the napkin holder, we had listened as Dad stood by the kitchen wall phone and kept the first half of his highway vow—calling a family law and divorce attorney's office off Independence Boulevard.

When Dad told the attorney on the line that he had a certified Shipboard Security Incident Report and a duplicate VHS security camera tape from Deck 4 showing Brenda's corridor outburst and her attempt to swing at me on the bench over the character meet-and-greet, we watched a wave of relief wash across Dad's face. Hanging up the receiver, Dad had turned to Katie and me and explained what the lawyer had just told him: under Virginia law, the one-year separation waiting period only applied to no-fault divorces. Because the ship's security camera had caught her attempt to strike a minor child and her subsequent detention in the brig, Dad qualified to file immediately on fault grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt—allowing the lawyer to petition the Virginia Beach court right away for sole custody of the two of us, exclusive possession of our house, and a protective order without waiting a single year.

The moment he finished writing down our afternoon appointment time with the lawyer, Dad dialed Dr. Carter, our Primary Care Physician, and explained how badly our arms and legs had been giving out on the cruise and at the Interstate 95 rest stops. Dr. Carter's nurse had told him to bring both of us straight in at ten o'clock.

For the first two seconds, my grip held around Dr. Carter's fingers—and then, no matter how hard I concentrated, the strength in my forearm and wrist drained away like water through a sieve. When Dr. Carter tested Katie's grip, her shoulder resistance, and the dorsiflexion in both of our ankles, the exact same drop-off happened.

Dr. Carter stepped back, slipped her reflex hammer into the pocket of her white coat, and looked gravely at Dad, who was standing protectively right beside us.

"David," Dr. Carter said quietly, "bringing them in immediately after you got back from Florida was the exact right call."

"They've had mild cerebral palsy since they were little," Dad said, his hand resting warmly on Katie's shoulder. "Brenda always ignored it and acted like they were two completely typical kids, so at first I assumed the ship's movement was just aggravating their balance. Why are both their arms and their legs getting worse at sixteen?"

"Because cerebral palsy does not degenerate over time," Dr. Carter answered clearly, looking from Dad to Katie and me with deep compassion. "Cerebral palsy is a static, non-progressive condition. When sixteen-year-old twins begin losing measurable motor strength in both their lower extremities and their upper extremities over the course of a single summer, something else is happening."

Beside me on the exam table, Katie squeezed my fingers with every ounce of strength left in her hand, and I squeezed right back.

“I’m ordering a full neuromuscular blood panel, nerve conduction studies, and a genetic workup this morning,” Dr. Carter continued gently, picking up her chart clipboard. “Until those test results come back and tell us exactly what condition we are dealing with, I need all three of you to prepare yourselves for the reality of what I’m seeing in their muscle tone today. When it comes to walking, Nathaniel and Katie are on borrowed time. Eventually, neither of them is going to be able to walk, and because their upper arms and wrists are fatiguing too, they are eventually going to need power wheelchairs.”

The quiet exam room seemed to hold its breath around those words—*on borrowed time*.

“How soon will the test results be back, Evelyn?” Dad asked quietly, his hand resting steady and warm on Katie’s shoulder.

“The genetic and nerve-conduction panel takes about two and a half weeks,” Dr. Carter answered, writing an appointment card at her desk and handing it to Dad. “Let’s schedule their next checkup for Friday afternoon, September fourteenth, at three o’clock—right after their two o’clock dismissal at Northwood High School. You can pick them up when the final bell rings at two, bring them straight here for their three o’clock appointment, and we’ll check how their arms and legs are holding up and go over every test result together.”

Yet as I looked sideways at my twin sister, and felt Dad’s steady, unwavering arm wrap around both of our shoulders at once, the fear didn’t break us. Whatever the test results showed when we came back for our three o’clock checkup after school on September fourteenth, Mom’s screaming was gone, Daddy was standing right beside us, and Katie and I were going to face every single mile of it together.

Junior Year at Northwood High & The Prognosis

Part 1: The Fault-Grounds Filing, The Protective Order, & Junior Year at Northwood High School

Date: 2001-09-04 at 10:55 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 2:00 PM — The Lawyer’s Office off Independence Boulevard

“Timestamp fifteen-thirty-two and eighteen seconds,” family law attorney Arthur Vance read aloud in his quiet, wood-paneled conference room off Independence Boulevard, pressing the pause button on his office VCR remote so the grainy black-and-white frame from the *M/S Sunward Tropics* Deck 4 stairwell camera froze on the television screen.

Sitting side by side on the leather sofa across from Mr. Vance’s desk with our inner hands clasped tightly together, Katie and I looked at the frozen image on the screen. Right there beneath the ceiling camera’s timestamp—*AUG 22 2001 15:32:18 CAM-04B*—was our mother lunging toward our alcove bench with her arm raised, and Dad standing like a shield squarely between her and the two of us.

“Mr. Prairie, in twenty-four years of practicing family law in Virginia Beach, I have rarely seen a cleaner, more airtight evidentiary packet,” Mr. Vance said, setting the remote down beside the Staff Captain’s notarized *Shipboard Security Incident Report* and permanent lifetime exclusion notice. “Normally in Virginia, when minor children are involved, a couple has to live separate and apart for one full year before filing for a no-fault divorce. You do not have to wait a single day.”

Across from us, Dad leaned forward in his chair, his hands folded on the edge of the mahogany table.

“How fast can we get the court orders in place so Brenda can’t come back to the house or show up at their high school when classes start next week?” Dad asked.

“This afternoon,” Mr. Vance answered firmly. “Because the ship’s security camera captured her attempting to strike sixteen-year-old Nathaniel while intoxicated—and because the ship’s brig and medical logs corroborate every word—we are filing a fault-based Complaint for Divorce on grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt under Virginia Code Section 20-91(A)(6) before the Circuit Court clerk’s office closes at four o’clock. Alongside it, I am walking an emergency *pendente lite* petition and family protective order straight in to the duty judge.”

Mr. Vance counted the points off on his fingers so Katie and I could follow every step.

“First, you get immediate temporary sole legal and physical custody of Nathaniel and Katie,” Mr. Vance said. “Second, you get exclusive use and possession of the marital home in Virginia Beach—meaning you are legally authorized to change every lock on the doors tonight, and Brenda cannot set foot on the property. Third, the protective order bars her from coming within five hundred feet of the twins or setting foot on the campus of Northwood High School. And fourth, because fault grounds of cruelty bar an offending spouse from receiving alimony under Virginia law, she won’t get a dime of spousal support.”

Beside me on the leather sofa, Katie tightened her fingers around my hand and looked across the mahogany desk at the attorney.

“Mr. Vance,” Katie said quietly, her voice trembling for just a heartbeat before steadying with the quiet resolve we had both shared in the back seat of Dad’s car on the drive over, “after what she did to us on that ship—dragging us onto a cruise we never wanted to go on, screaming at us in the passageway, and trying to force two sixteen-year-olds to go to a costumed children’s character meet-and-greet like toddlers—Nathaniel and I talked about it together. Neither of us wants her carrying the last name Prairie anymore. Is there a way in the divorce decree to make her go back to her maiden name?”

Dad turned in his chair and looked at Katie and me with deep, protective respect before facing the lawyer.

“You heard them, Arthur,” Dad said firmly. “After what she put my son and daughter through, they don’t want her carrying our family name—and I want their wishes respected in the final decree.”

Mr. Vance nodded thoughtfully, tapping his gold pen against his legal pad as a shrewd veteran litigator's smile crossed his face.

"Under Code of Virginia Section 20-121.4, the court restores a party's maiden name as part of the final divorce decree upon her signed request or stipulation," Mr. Vance explained, looking directly at Katie and me so we knew he was taking our request seriously. "A judge can't force a name change in a vacuum—but under Section 20-109.1, we can make reverting to her maiden name a binding condition of the financial property settlement. Remember, she secretly ran up more than six thousand dollars on the marital credit card to book that cruise behind your father's back, and under equitable distribution, I can petition the court to saddle her with half of that cruise debt plus your attorney's fees. When her lawyer calls me to beg for a walk-away release from the cruise debt and a small relocation check so she can get an apartment of her own, I will tell them your father's non-negotiable condition: she only gets the debt release and the settlement check if she signs the Section 20-121.4 stipulation in the divorce decree restoring her maiden name, Walsh, and surrendering the name Prairie on her driver's license and Social Security card. Knowing her pride—and her wallet—she'll sign it before the ink is dry."

Beside me on the leather sofa, Katie let out a long, quiet breath and leaned her shoulder against mine. That evening before dinner, Dad bought three brass deadbolt kits at the hardware store, changed every lock on our front, back, and garage doors, and handed the shiny new keys to Katie and me.

Tuesday, September 4, 2001, 10:55 AM — Junior Year at Northwood High School

"We actually pulled it off, Nate—third-block lunch and study hall together on both Purple Days and Gold Days," Katie said with a relieved smile the Tuesday after Labor Day as the two of us eased down side by side onto the bench of a quiet, sunlit corner table near the tall windows of the Northwood High School cafeteria.

Back in July, when we had given up half of our mornings to sit through high-school summer school and knock out a required academic credit early, this exact ninety-minute sanctuary in the middle of Northwood High's alternating Purple and Gold Day four-block schedule—forty-five minutes of lunch in Mrs. DeMarco's cafeteria followed by forty-five minutes of quiet study hall inside Mrs. Periwinkle's library—was what we had worked for. Earlier that morning before the seven-fifteen first bell, Dad had walked into the Northwood High main office with us to hand-deliver a certified copy of the Virginia Beach judge's custody and protective orders to the principal's secretary, removing Brenda's name from our emergency contact cards for good while keeping Brenda's sister—our Aunt Karen Fletcher, who had stood firmly behind Dad, Katie, and me from the hour she heard what happened on the cruise ship—listed right below Dad.

Across the loud cafeteria, our maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher—who had eaten at this exact corner table with Katie and me every single day in ninth and tenth grade after Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve sold their Blackwater farm and moved to Earlton Court, before Brittany started drifting toward a loud group of hard-partying seniors—gave us only a quick, distracted wave from Tyler's crowded table near the vending machines before turning back to their laughter.

Yet as grateful as Katie and I were to be sitting together with our brown paper lunch bags, juice boxes, and our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook open on the tabletop between us, getting through the first two ninety-minute blocks of eleventh grade had been a sobering wake-up call for our bodies.

Even without the roll of a cruise ship beneath our feet, the long linoleum hallways and concrete stairwells of Northwood High School had pushed our legs and arms to the brink before eleven o'clock. Halfway up the B-Wing stairs to second-block Chemistry, my left calf had cramped and given out so suddenly that I would have gone down on the steps if Katie hadn't grabbed my belt loop—and when she tried to pull my weight upright against the handrail, her own right wrist and forearm had trembled so violently that she dropped her binder across the landing. By the time we reached the cafeteria doors at ten-fifty-five, my thighs felt like lead weights and Katie's fingers were shaking so hard at the milk cooler that Mrs. DeMarco—the formidable cafeteria supervisor whom every loudmouth since Josh Riley's freshman-year dumpster sentence feared like the wrath of God—had quietly stepped out from behind the serving rail in her white apron, steadied Katie's carton without drawing a single stare from the line behind us, and murmured a gentle *"Take your time, sweetheart"* before letting us head to the window table.

Reaching across the table between our lunch bags after I helped Katie pinch open the top of her straw wrapper, I laced my right fingers through Katie's left hand and rested our joined hands flat on the cool laminate tabletop so neither of our wrists had to work to hold them up.

"How bad are your legs shaking right now?" I asked her quietly beneath the chatter of the cafeteria.

"From my knees down to my ankles," Katie admitted softly, her thumb brushing against the back of my hand as she glanced down at the event-loop diagram in my notebook. "And my right shoulder still hurts from carrying my backpack down the upstairs hall. At least when the eleven-forty bell rings, we have our passes for Mrs. Periwinkle's library so we don't have to stand around in the Commons. Our next scheduled checkup with Dr. Carter is next Friday afternoon after school, right?"

"Friday at three o'clock," I nodded, squeezing her hand gently. "Dad's picking us up right at the two o'clock dismissal bell so Dr. Carter can see how our arms and legs are doing. Whatever happens, we've got Dad on our side now, and we've got this lunch table and the library together every day. We'll get through eleventh grade together."

Part 2: When Borrowed Time Runs Out — The Collapse at School, The Emergency Room Escalation, & Time for Powerchairs

Date: 2001-09-14 at 13:15 America/New_York

Friday, September 14, 2001, 1:15 PM — When Our Legs Finally Gave Out at School

“Just forty-five more minutes until the two o’clock dismissal bell, Katie, and Dad’ll be waiting for us right out front in the pickup loop,” I whispered at a quarter past one on Friday afternoon as the two of us walked slowly down the quiet first-floor B-Wing hallway of Northwood High School on our way back from the guidance office.

All week long, all I knew was that Friday afternoon at three o’clock was our next scheduled checkup with Dr. Evelyn Carter. Dad had arranged his Friday schedule at the Community College of Hampton Roads so he could pick Katie and me up right when school let out at two o’clock and drive us straight over to Dr. Carter’s office for our three o’clock appointment to see how our arms and legs were doing and go over whatever test results had come back from the lab.

All we had to do was make it thirty more feet down the waxed linoleum corridor to our fourth-block classroom door.

We were holding hands between us for balance, walking close to the lockers so we could brush our free fingertips against the metal doors if our ankles wobbled, when the sensation below my knees suddenly vanished.

It wasn’t a slow cramp like on the stairwell the week before, and it wasn’t just our calves getting tired. Halfway past Room 112, it felt as though someone had reached inside our spines and pulled the electrical plug on both of our lower bodies at the exact same second.

My right knee buckled inward without an ounce of resistance. Beside me, Katie let out a sharp gasp as both of her ankles folded underneath her at the exact same instant, and before either one of us could catch the locker handles, the two of us collapsed straight down onto the hard linoleum floor.

“Nathaniel! Katie!” Mr. Rutledge, our eleventh-grade U.S. History teacher, called out in alarm from his open classroom doorway ten feet ahead of us, dropping his dry-erase marker onto his podium and hurrying out into the hallway. “Are you two all right?!”

My heart was hammering against my ribs from the shock of going down so fast, and my instinct—the stubborn sixteen-year-old instinct that had kept both of us forcing our legs down hallways all week—was to get right back up before the rest of the class saw us on the floor.

“We’re okay, Mr. Rutledge—just let us stand back up,” I gasped, planting my left palm flat on the cold floor while Katie braced her hands against the tiles beside me.

Straining with every muscle left in our shoulders, wrists, and thighs, Katie and I tried to push ourselves back up onto our feet.

We didn’t even make it halfway to our knees.

The moment we put weight on our legs and trembling forearms, both of our legs and arms crumpled completely out from under us a second time—sending both of us pitching forward and sideways with nothing left to break our fall.

Crack. Thud.

The right side of my forehead slammed hard against the unforgiving linoleum-over-concrete floor, sending a bright, stinging flash across my vision, and six inches away I heard the sickening thud of the left side of Katie's head striking the tiles right beside the locker base.

Before the ringing in my ears even settled, my very first instinct—and Katie's—was the exact same one we had had since the day we were born. Lying flat on the cold linoleum floor with a hot, throbbing knot rising on my forehead, I reached my right hand blindly across the six inches of tile between us, and Katie's left hand met mine in midair, our fingers locking together in a vise grip so neither of us was alone on that floor.

"Stay down! Do not try to get up again!" Mr. Rutledge shouted, his voice dropping an octave in urgent alarm as he saw both of our heads strike the floor and our hands clasp together between us.

He sprinted three steps to the classroom wall intercom just inside his doorway and pressed the red emergency call button. "Main Office, get Nurse Callahan to the first-floor B-Wing hallway outside Room 112 immediately! I need a Clinic Emergency escalation right now—Nathaniel and Katie Prairie both collapsed in the hallway, their legs gave out a second time when they tried to get up, and both of them hit their heads on the floor!"

Friday, September 14, 2001, 1:18 PM — Manual C-Spine Stabilization & The Emergency Room Escalation

Within forty-five seconds, Nurse Callahan, the school's registered nurse, arrived at a dead run with her orange trauma bag, followed closely by Assistant Principal Brooks and the clinic aide.

One look at the two of us lying flat on the hard tile floor holding hands with red, swelling contusions rising on our foreheads—and Mr. Rutledge's report that our arms had given out on the second collapse so nothing had cushioned our heads—was all Nurse Callahan needed to escalate the protocol straight to the Emergency Room.

"Nobody lift them and nobody let them sit up!" Nurse Callahan ordered immediately, dropping to her knees behind my head while her trained clinic aide knelt behind Katie's head. Gently but firmly, Nurse Callahan placed both of her palms along the sides of my head to hold my neck in manual inline cervical stabilization, while her aide stabilized Katie's head the exact same way so neither of us could turn or nod our necks.

"Mr. Brooks," Nurse Callahan commanded, "we have an unbroken dual head strike against concrete-backed tile plus acute bilateral lower-extremity paralysis. Under school division head-and-spine protocol, they cannot be lifted into clinic wheelchairs and they cannot go home in a passenger car until an Emergency Room CT scan clears their heads and cervical spines. Call 911 right now for Virginia Beach EMS transport straight up Kempsville Road to Crossroads Memorial Hospital Emergency Room, put B-Wing on a temporary Hold in Place so the hallway stays clear when the bell rings, and call their father to meet the ambulance at the ER!"

“Calling 911 and Mr. Prairie right now,” Assistant Principal Brooks said, unclipping his radio and telephone handset as Mr. Rutledge closed the classroom doors along the corridor.

Down on the floor, even with Nurse Callahan’s hands cradling the sides of my head so I couldn’t turn my neck, I kept my right hand laced tightly through Katie’s left hand on the tiles between us.

“Nathaniel, Katie—keep looking straight up at the ceiling tiles so your necks stay completely still, and keep holding each other’s hands,” Nurse Callahan said calmly as she checked my pupils and then Katie’s with her penlight. “Can both of you hear me and tell me your full names?”

“Nathaniel Prairie,” I answered clearly, squeezing Katie’s fingers twice so she knew I was okay.

“Katie Prairie,” Katie answered right after me, squeezing my hand back just as tightly.

“Did either of you black out when your heads hit the floor? Do you know where you are, what day it is, and what happened right before you fell?” Nurse Callahan asked.

“No, ma’am, neither of us blacked out,” I said, my voice steady despite the throbbing ache over my right eyebrow. “It’s Friday, September fourteenth, and we’re in the B-Wing hallway at Northwood High School. Our dad was supposed to pick us up at the two o’clock dismissal bell to take us to our three o’clock appointment with Dr. Evelyn Carter to see how our arms and legs were doing—and while we were walking down the hall, our legs just gave out all at once.”

“And when we tried to push ourselves back up,” Katie added clearly from beside me, “our legs and arms crumpled again and we hit our heads.”

“Can either of you wiggle your toes or push your feet forward against Mr. Rutledge’s palms?” Nurse Callahan asked.

I concentrated with everything I had, ordering my ankles and calves to move. Nothing happened. Neither of my feet moved a fraction of an inch, and neither did Katie’s.

“All right, don’t strain,” Nurse Callahan told us gently as the distant wail of sirens approached up Kempsville Road outside. “Your dad is already on his way to the Crossroads Memorial Emergency Room to meet you, and I had the front office call Dr. Evelyn Carter’s clinic too—she has hospital privileges at Crossroads Memorial and she’s bringing your test results straight over to the Emergency Room to meet your dad there.”

Four minutes later, four Virginia Beach EMS paramedics wheeled two ambulance stretchers through the B-Wing double doors, where Nurse Callahan handed the lead paramedic two printed clinic sheets from her clipboard.

“Both patients are sixteen-year-old fraternal twins on the autism spectrum, Glasgow Coma Scale fifteen, with an unbroken dual head strike and acute bilateral lower-extremity motor loss,” Nurse Callahan briefed the lead paramedic right beside us so I could hear every word. “Look at their hands right now—they ground themselves and prevent sensory panic by holding hands and hugging. Obviously they can’t sit

up or hug while they're in C-collars on backboards, but please keep their stretchers close enough together in the rig and at triage that they don't have to let go of each other's hands, and brief the ER Charge Nurse before you roll in."

"Copy that, Nurse—we'll keep them side by side in Squad 14 and call it in to Crossroads Memorial Triage on the radio," the lead paramedic nodded.

Working with practiced precision so our spines never bent or twisted, the paramedics fitted soft foam cervical collars around our necks, unclipped two-piece aluminum scoop stretchers that slid underneath our backs and hips from both sides on the floor, and lifted Katie and me smoothly onto the two padded gurneys—locking the two stretchers side by side in the back of the dual-patient squad rig so my right hand and Katie's left hand stayed clasped between the rails the entire four-mile ride straight north up Kempsville Road to the hospital.

Friday, September 14, 2001, 2:10 PM — Hospital Rules, The CT Doorway, & Dr. Carter's Verdict in the ER

Because the Community College of Hampton Roads campus was only ten minutes from Crossroads Memorial Hospital, Dad actually beat our ambulance to the Emergency Room entrance by two minutes.

When the rear doors of Squad 14 swung open at the ER bay, Dad was already standing right beside the ER Charge Nurse, having briefed her himself that we were sixteen-year-old twins on the autism spectrum who grounded ourselves through physical contact—and that Dr. Evelyn Carter had already called down from her clinic across the medical plaza to let the ER team know she was bringing our neuromuscular lab packet over in person.

Even with Nurse Callahan's handoff and Dad's briefing, however, there were still real hospital rules for sixteen-year-old minors that the Emergency Room couldn't bend.

First, because Katie and I were opposite-sex sixteen-year-old minors, hospital policy required the triage team to wheel us into two separate adjacent trauma bays—Bay 3 and Bay 4—divided by a heavy fabric privacy curtain while the ER nurses checked our spines and stuck cardiac monitor leads under our shirts. While we lay flat in our rigid foam cervical collars unable to sit up or hug, the Charge Nurse compromised by leaving a six-inch gap at the bottom of the curtain between our two bays so I could reach my right hand under the curtain hem and hold onto Katie's left hand while the monitors beeped overhead.

Second—and hardest of all—was the hospital's radiation safety rule at the CT scanner.

"Mr. Prairie, I know they ground themselves by holding hands, but federal radiation rules only allow one patient inside the CT scanner room at a time," the radiology tech explained gently when the orderlies arrived at two-twenty to wheel us down the hall for our head and cervical spine scans. "We'll scan Katie first while Nathaniel's gurney waits right outside the lead glass door with you, and then we'll swap them. They'll only be apart for five minutes each."

Letting go of Katie's fingers outside the heavy lead-lined doors of the CT suite while my own neck was strapped flat in a foam collar was the longest five minutes of my life. As the sliding door closed behind Katie's gurney, my heart rate monitor began to beep faster—until Dad stepped right up beside my stretcher, took my right hand in both of his warm palms, and stood where he could see through the control-room glass.

"I'm looking right at her through the window, Nate—she's lying totally still inside the scanner ring and giving us a thumbs-up with her left hand," Dad narrated calmly, squeezing my fingers until my breathing steadied. "Ninety more seconds and she's coming right back out, and then I'll watch you through the glass while Katie waits right here."

True to his word, ten minutes later both of our CT scans were finished. By three-ten that afternoon, when the radiologist called down to confirm that neither Katie nor I had a skull fracture, concussion, or cervical spine injury, the ER trauma doctor unstrapped our foam cervical collars, the Charge Nurse pulled the dividing curtain between Bay 3 and Bay 4 all the way open, and the orderlies pushed our two hospital beds right up against each other with the inner side rails lowered.

The instant the beds locked together and the doctor raised the heads of our mattresses to forty-five degrees, Katie and I didn't just hold hands—we leaned across the narrow seam between the two hospital mattresses and wrapped both of our arms tightly around each other's shoulders in the long, deep grounding hug we had needed ever since we hit the hallway floor at school.

Seconds later, walking into the combined ER bay alongside the emergency physician was Dr. Evelyn Carter, wearing her white coat and carrying the thick manila lab folder from her clinic across the medical plaza.

"First things first—the head and cervical spine CT scans for both Nathaniel and Katie are completely clean," Dr. Carter announced with a warm, relieved smile as Katie and I eased back against our pillows with our inner hands locked together between our beds and fresh ice packs resting against the matching goose eggs on our foreheads. "Nurse Callahan followed the exact right protocol calling EMS after a dual head strike on a concrete school floor, and thank goodness neither of you suffered a fracture or intracranial bleed."

Then Dr. Carter stepped to the foot of our two ER beds and tested the reflexes and motor response in our knees, calves, and ankles.

Just like on the hallway floor outside Room 112 at Northwood High School, when she tapped our patellar tendons and asked us to lift our shins against her fingers, our lower legs didn't budge.

Dr. Carter pulled a rolling stool up beside our two beds, opened the thick manila lab folder containing the genetic sequencing and nerve-conduction studies that had arrived from Norfolk that morning, and looked at Dad, Katie, and me with deep, solemn compassion.

“David, Nathaniel, Katie,” Dr. Carter said quietly, “two and a half weeks ago, when you came to see me the Monday morning after your cruise, I told you that Nathaniel and Katie’s legs were walking on borrowed time—and that they would eventually need power wheelchairs. We had scheduled your three o’clock checkup today to review these test results and talk about transitioning to powerchairs.”

She looked straight into my eyes, and then into Katie’s.

“What happened in the B-Wing hallway at Northwood High School at one-fifteen this afternoon wasn’t a temporary spell, and it wasn’t just end-of-the-week fatigue,” Dr. Carter said gently. “Your borrowed time is up. Neither of your legs can support your body weight anymore, and from this afternoon forward, neither of you can ever try to stand or walk again—because trying to push yourselves up will only cause another collapse like the one that sent you to the Emergency Room today. It is officially time for powerchairs.”

Even though Katie and I had known in our hearts from the second we reached for each other’s hands on that linoleum floor that our walking days were over, hearing Dr. Carter say the words out loud made everything real. Beside me, Katie’s fingers tightened around mine between our two hospital beds, and I squeezed her hand right back with everything I had.

“Tell us what the test results showed, Evelyn,” Dad said steadily, standing right between our beds with one hand resting on my shoulder and the other on Katie’s. “Why did their legs give out completely today, and what does it mean for their arms?”

“When you two were toddlers,” Dr. Carter explained clearly, “your uneven balance was diagnosed as mild spastic diplegic cerebral palsy. Because mild CP is static and non-progressive—and because your mother always brushed off any new symptoms—nobody realized that your early balance issues were masking a second, genetic condition that both of you inherited as fraternal twins: a juvenile-onset progressive axonal motor neuropathy.”

Dr. Carter pointed to the nerve-conduction graphs inside the folder.

“In this condition, the longest motor nerves in the body—the ones running from the lower spine down to the feet, ankles, calves, and quadriceps—lose their electrical signal amplitude first, and the sixteen-year-old adolescent growth spurt pushes those nerves past their threshold,” Dr. Carter said. “Today at school, those lower-extremity motor nerves finally dropped below the threshold required to keep your knees locked upright. And as you both felt when you tried to push yourselves up off the hallway floor and crumpled the second time, the neuropathy is also causing progressive weakness in your shoulders, biceps, and forearms—which is why standard manual wheelchairs that you have to push with your hands are out of the question.”

“What about our fingers, Dr. Carter?” Katie asked, her voice small but brave as she held onto my hand. “Are we still going to be able to type on our computers and write *Quantum Basic* code?”

Dr. Carter’s face warmed with an immediate, reassuring smile.

“Yes, Katie—and that is the best news in your entire lab packet,” Dr. Carter answered. “As long as we stop you from straining your shoulders and wrists trying to lift your body weight or push manual wheelchair rims, your fine finger dexterity at a keyboard will remain intact for years to come. You will both be able to type, write computer code, use a mouse, and hold hands—and with a fingertip joystick on your power wheelchair armrests, you’ll be able to glide through Northwood High School all day without tiring your arms at all.”

Dr. Carter pulled three prescription and accommodation forms from her folder and signed them right on the bedside tray table.

“First,” Dr. Carter said, “I have signed an urgent hospital prescription for two SwiftChair compact, portable take-apart power wheelchairs—small-footprint motorized chairs with ten-inch drive wheels, right-hand armrest joysticks, and removable battery boxes and seats that you can break down to fit inside the trunk of your sedan, David, along with a smooth composite transfer sliding board so Nathaniel and Katie can slide horizontally from their wheelchair seats onto the back seat of the car or onto their beds without ever putting weight on their legs. Second, Hospital Physical Therapy is bringing up two loaner wheelchairs and a transfer board right now so Dad can take you home safely tonight until the custom powerchairs are delivered in two weeks. And third, here is your updated Section 504 Plan for Northwood High School: elevator keys, duplicate classroom textbooks so you never lift a heavy bag, and full-time wheelchair access starting Monday morning.”

Dad picked up the signed forms, then leaned down between our two hospital beds and wrapped one arm around Katie and one arm around me, kissing the top of Katie’s head and then mine just above our bruised foreheads.

“I was never so scared in my life as when Mr. Brooks called me and said you two were headed to the Emergency Room,” Dad whispered, his voice thick with emotion as he held us both close. “Wait until you see how fast I learn to break those two powerchairs down for the trunk of the car. Your legs may have run out of borrowed time today, but as long as the three of us have each other, nothing is going to stop you.”

Part 3: Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk, Downsizing to Military Highway, & CVTA Route 15

Date: 2001-10-06 at 13:10 America/New_York

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:10 PM — Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk & Our New House off Military Highway

“Unclip the two under-seat battery boxes first, pull the quick-release pins to lift both padded seats off their posts, fold the backrests and footrests flat, and set the two compact motorized drive bases side by side in the trunk with two inches to spare under the hinges,” Dad said with a proud grin on the first Saturday of October, wiping his brow as he demonstrated how both of our brand-new SwiftChair compact portable power wheelchairs broke down to fit inside the open trunk of our silver-blue Holt sedan.

Sitting side by side on the back bench seat of our Holt sedan with the rear passenger doors swung wide open to the concrete driveway of our new rental house and our inner hands clasped together, Katie and I watched Dad practice the disassembly routine he had timed with his wristwatch all morning.

Four days earlier, the seating clinic had delivered the two compact, take-apart power wheelchairs Dr. Carter had prescribed for us after our legs gave out for good in the hallway at Northwood High School—nimble, small-footprint power bases with ten-inch solid drive wheels, under-seat battery packs, and feather-light right-hand armrest joysticks that let us glide down the long corridors of school with a gentle nudge of one finger without ever straining our wrists or shoulders on manual hand rims. Because Dr. Carter had documented our progressive axonal motor neuropathy down to the millimeter, Dad's health insurance had covered ninety percent of the chairs.

What health insurance didn't cover, however, was a vehicle to carry them assembled.

A full-size conversion van equipped with a hydraulic wheelchair lift or fold-out side ramp cost upwards of thirty-five thousand dollars—an astronomical sum that might as well have been thirty-five million on Dad's tight budget. Between trying to finish his computer science degree at the Community College of Hampton Roads, losing Brenda's paycheck—meager as her income had been—and getting stuck with the crushing credit card debt from the seven-day Caribbean cruise that Brenda had booked behind his back, Dad was scraping by to make every dollar count.

Thankfully, because the seating clinic had ordered portable take-apart power chairs whose battery packs, seats, and drive bases separated into manageable thirty-five-pound components—and had supplied us with a smooth composite transfer sliding board that bridged the gap between the wheelchair seat and the back seat of our family Holt sedan—we could still get around by car without a lift van. Whenever we drove somewhere, Katie and I would roll our compact power chairs right up to the open rear passenger door, switch off our joysticks, flip up the inner armrest, and slide horizontally across the transfer board onto the back bench seat with Dad's steadying hands before buckling our three-point seatbelts while Dad broke both chairs down like a pit crew and loaded the bases, battery boxes, and folded seats into the trunk.

Even so, Dad had been completely honest with Katie and me around the kitchen table two weeks earlier when he opened his budget ledger.

Without a second income—and with the cruise credit card bill and legal fees hanging over our heads—we couldn't afford the mortgage on our old two-story house anymore. More importantly, even if we could have paid for it, our old house had a cramped downstairs stall bathroom too narrow for a wheelchair or a transfer bench and fourteen steep wooden stairs leading up to all four bedrooms and the main hall bath—stairs that neither Katie nor I could ever climb again now that the borrowed time in our legs had run out.

So Dad had put the two-story house up for sale—using the modest equity to wipe out Brenda's cruise debt completely and fund the small walk-away settlement check that Mr. Vance was conditioning on Brenda signing the Code of Virginia Section 20-121.4 divorce stipulation reverting to her maiden name, Walsh, so that just as Katie and I had asked, she could never show up at a medical office or school flashing the Prairie name, while still making sure she had apartment money and

wouldn’t end up on the street—and spent every evening for two weeks poring over rental listings, Virginia Beach school-zone boundary maps, and printed bus schedules from the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority. Even Brenda’s own younger sister, our Aunt Karen Fletcher, along with Uncle Steve, had spent six long years since that summer of 1995 trying to get Brenda to face her drinking and had been so appalled by what she did to us on the cruise ship that they stood squarely in Dad’s corner—with Uncle Steve hauling our furniture in his pickup truck and Aunt Karen quietly pressing an envelope into Dad’s hand to help cover our rental security deposit and utility hookups whenever Dad’s student budget got stretched thin. Out of quiet decency toward Aunt Karen, Dad kept one unspoken rule under our roof from day one: he never gloated about the divorce papers and never badmouthed Brenda in front of Karen, remembering that Brenda was still Karen’s older sister and that Karen was grieving who her sister used to be.

What Dad found was a stroke of pure logistical genius: a small, single-story brick ranch house for rent on Arvin Road at the corner of Indian River Road just off Military Highway, right where Virginia Beach met Norfolk and Chesapeake.

First, the rent was nearly four hundred dollars a month less than our old mortgage, bringing our monthly bills comfortably inside Dad’s budget while he finished school at CCHR. Second, every single room in the little house—the living room, the eat-in kitchen, the hallway bathroom with its roll-up sink and shower transfer bench, and our bedrooms—sat on one flat ground floor, with a gentle aluminum ramp Dad had bolted over the two brick front porch steps. Third, because the house sat just inside the western edge of Northwood High School’s zoned attendance boundary, Katie and I didn’t have to change high schools in the middle of our Junior year, and a lift-equipped Virginia Beach school bus could pick us up right at the end of our driveway every weekday morning.

And fourth—the detail Dad was proudest of as he reassembled our two compact power wheelchairs beside the open rear doors of the car, locked the seats onto their posts, and dropped the battery boxes back into place—was what ran right along Indian River Road and the massive eight-lane corridor of US-13 (Military Highway) at the end of our block.

“Slide back into your chairs and let’s head out to the corner on Military Highway before the one-twenty-five bus gets here,” Dad said, closing the trunk lid of the Holt sedan, helping Katie and me slide across the transfer board from the back seat into our waiting power chairs, and holding up a yellow-highlighted paper pamphlet folded in his hand. “Since Route 15 stays strictly out on Military Highway and doesn’t turn into the neighborhood streets, I want to show you two how fast we can get out to the main road without having to break your power chairs down at all.”

Clicking our lap belts shut and flipping our armrests back down, Katie and I pressed the green power buttons on our armrest joysticks and hummed side by side down Arvin Road to Indian River Road behind Dad. In less than three minutes, we reached the corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road, where four lanes of northbound traffic and four lanes of southbound traffic roared past a raised center median.

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:25 PM — Catching CVTA Route 15 on Eight-Lane Military Highway

“Look at the timetable right here under Military Hwy. & Indian River Rd.,” Dad said over the steady hum of eight-lane highway traffic as the three of us stopped beside the metal bus stop post in the crisp October sunshine, unfolding the printed CVTA Route 15 — *Naval Base Norfolk / Robert Hall Blvd.* schedule so both Katie and I could read it.

Holding Katie’s left hand with my right hand between our two compact power wheelchairs, I leaned in with my sister to follow the yellow highlighter line Dad had drawn across the grid of numbers.

“Wait a second,” Katie said, her eyes widening as she traced the columns from left to right. “It runs every thirty minutes all day Monday through Saturday?”

“Like clockwork,” Dad smiled, tapping each column with his index finger. “Going northbound up Military Highway, Route 15 stops right across the highway at Military Highway and Indian River Road at :01 and :31 past every hour from six-thirty-one in the morning until six-thirty-one at night, and then once an hour until ten-thirty-one. In exactly fourteen minutes—at :15 and :45 past the hour—it drops you right at the doors of Glenrock Mall, where you can transfer to Routes 20, 23, 25, or 27, or stay right on Route 15 past Glenrock Shopping Center, Little Creek Road, and Hampton Boulevard all the way to Naval Base Norfolk.”

“And what about going southbound on our side of the road?” I asked, looking at the lower table where Dad had highlighted two alternating rows in yellow and green.

“That’s the best part,” Dad said, pointing to the bold route note printed across the center of the timetable: *On arrival at Old Emerald Creek Rd. and Military Hwy., every other trip will alternate between Robert Hall and Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday.* “Southbound buses leave Glenrock Mall at :15 and :45 past the hour and get right here to Military Highway and Indian River Road ten minutes later, at :25 and :55 past every hour. Every bus that stops here at :25 past the hour—like the 1:25 PM bus coming down the right-hand lane right now—turns onto the Emerald Creek Mall branch and puts us at the mall entrance twenty minutes later at 1:45 PM. And every bus that stops here at :55 past the hour goes straight down to Robert Hall Boulevard and Tidewater Square by :15 past the next hour.”

Right on cue, signaling across the four southbound lanes of US-13 (Military Highway) toward our curb was one of the classic forty-foot high-floor workhorses of the fleet: a 900-series Beacon V transit bus (Fleet #914) that operated alongside the agency’s high-floor MetroCoach buses. Because Tidewater Regional Transit (TRT) on the Southside and Peninsula Transit (PenTran) across the harbor had only merged two years earlier in October 1999 to form the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority (CVTA), Bus #914 was still wearing its original 1990s TRT paint scheme—a crisp white body banded with horizontal navy-blue and green stripes down its flanks—with a rectangular CVTA logo vinyl decal sticker applied right next to the front boarding doors below the *15 EMERALD CREEK MALL* destination sign.

As Bus #914 hissed to a stop parallel to the concrete curb, the bi-fold front doors swung open. Because the 900-series Beacon V was a true high-floor bus whose main passenger deck sat three full feet above the street at the top of a three-step stairwell, there was no sloped ramp. Instead, standing high up on the elevated driver’s

platform, the uniformed operator pulled the parking brake knob, flipped up the two forward priority benches behind the driver's area, and switched on the Elevate-U electro-hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift.

"Afternoon, folks! Welcome aboard The 15," the operator called down warmly from the elevated doorway as the three deep front steps flattened into a level horizontal steel elevator platform, telescoped outward on twin vertical hydraulic lift arms with yellow-and-black tubular side handrails, and lowered straight down to rest flat on the concrete sidewalk before dropping the yellow outer safety barrier flap flush against the curb. "Come on onto the elevator platform one at a time—I've got both wheelchair bays folded up and ready for you!"

Katie and I glanced at each other with identical grins. Nobody had to struggle with a car transfer, and Dad didn't have to unclip battery boxes or lift thirty-five-pound power-chair bases into a trunk. Giving Katie's hand a quick squeeze before letting go for thirty seconds, I nudged my right-hand joystick forward and rolled my compact power chair onto the flat horizontal steel platform between the two side handrails first; the outer yellow safety barrier flipped up behind my rear wheels to lock me in, the twin vertical hydraulic arms raised my chair straight up three feet in the air like an elevator to the high interior floor of Bus #914, and I backed neatly into the right-hand securement bay. Seconds later, the elevator platform lowered straight back down to the sidewalk for Katie and lifted her power chair right up to the high deck across the aisle from me before folding seamlessly back into three staircase steps so Dad could climb up into the bus and drop our fares into the farebox.

Once the operator had clicked the four-point floor straps onto both of our power-chair frames, the front doors hissed shut and Bus #914 merged back into the four southbound lanes of Military Highway.

Across the center aisle of the high-floor bus, Katie reached her left hand out over her armrest, and I reached my right hand out to meet hers, our fingers lacing together in the warm afternoon sunlight streaming through the tall transit windows.

"We don't need a thirty-five-thousand-dollar van to go wherever we want, Nate," Katie said softly over the deep diesel rumble of the Beacon V engine as we cruised south toward Emerald Creek Mall. "Between the school bus on weekdays, breaking our chairs down for the trunk of Dad's car, and Route 15 out on Military Highway at the end of our block, we've got the whole city back."

"And a house with zero stairs," I agreed, squeezing my sister's hand as Dad smiled at the two of us from the seat beside her. "We're going to be just fine."

Part 4: Purple Day Lunch, Josh Riley's Lane Toll, & The DeMarco–Periwinkle Tag-Team

Date: 2001-10-09 at 10:55 America/New_York

Tuesday, October 9, 2001, 10:55 AM — The Cafeteria Court & Josh Riley's Lane Toll

"Hold it right there, Prairie—two motorized rigs taking up a whole traffic lane? That's a wide-load violation," Josh Riley drawled loudly near the condiment island at ten-fifty-five on Tuesday morning, stepping sideways in his baggy jeans to plant

himself squarely in front of Katie's and my front casters as we rolled our brand-new compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs out of the Northwood High School lunch line.

My right index finger eased back to neutral on my armrest joystick, bringing my powerchair to a smooth stop beside Katie's chair with our plastic lunch trays balanced across our laps.

It was a Purple Day on Northwood High's alternating Purple and Gold Day four-block schedule, and only our second morning back at school since our legs had given out for good in the B-Wing hallway three weeks earlier. Ever since the start of our sophomore year—when the school had switched to four ninety-minute blocks running from seven-fifteen in the morning until the two o'clock dismissal bell—Third Block had served as the ninety-minute anchor in the middle of every school day: forty-five minutes of lunch in the cafeteria, followed at the mid-block bell by forty-five minutes of mandatory study hall.

Even before Josh opened his mouth, a faint, unmistakable cloud hit our noses from four feet away—stale dumpster cardboard, damp paper napkins, and old deep-fryer oil.

Everyone in the Class of 2003 knew Josh Riley, and everyone knew why that particular scent followed him down the hallways like cologne. Back on the very first Tuesday of our freshman year in September 1999, Josh had decided to make himself famous during lunch by standing up and bellowing a juvenile four-letter anatomy word at the top of his lungs—Attempt Number 253 in the official mental ledger of Mrs. DeMarco, Northwood High's legendary cafeteria supervisor—earning himself an immediate four-day enrollment in Advanced Sanitation Techniques out by the back loading dock dumpsters at a quarter past two, followed that February by another full week at the dumpsters when he mocked my cramping hands while Brittany cut up my chicken patty sandwich and fed me bites at our blue stool table. By sophomore year, after trying to extort a freshman for tater tots in the serving line, Josh had graduated to scrubbing the deep-fryer grease traps behind the kitchen doors.

Clearly, two straight years of dumpster liners and fryer grease hadn't taught him when to leave people alone.

"Way I see it," Josh smirked, glancing back over his shoulder for approval from his increasingly weary-looking sidekick Mark before eyeing the two warm chocolate-chip cookies sitting on napkins beside Katie's apple juice carton and my chocolate milk, "first month of school you two were holding up the stairs wobbling around like toddlers, and now you're cruising the lunchroom in matching bumper cars. Parking permit for a double wide-load costs one cookie per chair. Call it the Northwood transit tax."

Beside me, Katie didn't shrink back an inch in her seat. Her blue eyes locked straight onto Josh's smirk with pure ice.

"Take a step back from my tray and get out of front of our wheels, Josh," Katie said evenly.

Josh let out a harsh snort and reached two fingers toward the edge of Katie's plastic tray anyway. "Relax, Prairie, I'm just collecting the—"

He never finished the sentence.

Around the condiment island and the three nearest lunch tables, the deafening roar of two hundred hungry juniors didn't cut off all at once; it rippled outward into a sudden, pressurized hush, as if all the oxygen had just been vacuumed out of the room beneath the exposed blue steel roof trusses.

Josh froze with his fingers hovering three inches above Katie's tray, his shoulders stiffening as a shadow fell squarely across his sneakers.

"Mr. Riley," a calm, velvet-smooth voice said directly behind him.

Josh turned around slowly, the color draining out of his face.

Standing two paces behind him beneath the purple-and-gold Northwood Spirit lion banners was Mrs. DeMarco.

She wasn't raising her voice, and she wasn't reaching for an administrative referral slip. Wearing her white mesh hairnet over her salt-and-pepper dark hair, her burgundy-and-gold paisley blouse, and her crisp white canvas bib apron with a heavy stainless-steel serving spoon resting like a holstered sidearm in her right front pocket, Mrs. DeMarco stood with both arms folded across her chest and a laser gaze that had broken varsity linebackers in half.

Every student at Northwood knew the unwritten Shadow Law of Mrs. DeMarco's cafeteria. You did not cut the line. You did not breathe a word, pull a face, or flare a nostril in criticism within fifty feet of the Mystery Meat Loaf or the rectangular pizza. And above all, you never tried to outsmart her in another language—a lesson cemented into school folklore after freshman year when Kevin Schmidt muttered an insult in terrible German right after Chloé Mason had chewed Josh out in French, and Mrs. DeMarco had seamlessly addressed Chloé in flawless Parisian French before verbally dismantling Kevin in razor-sharp German, followed months later by sophomore transfer Kevin O'Malley earning grease-trap duty and a five-page essay in fluent Irish Gaelic for insulting the meatloaf.

"Mrs. D!" Josh stammered, snatching his hand back from Katie's tray as if the plastic were glowing red-hot. "I—uh—I was just directing traffic! Making sure nobody bumped into their new chairs by the ketchup!"

Mrs. DeMarco didn't blink. When she spoke, her diction rose to that terrifying, glass-cutting academic register that made sixteen-year-old bullies feel three inches tall.

"Directing traffic," Mrs. DeMarco repeated softly. "Do I appear to have deputized a habitual sanitation apprentice as a highway toll collector in my dining room, Mr. Riley? Or were you under the grotesque misapprehension that mocking two classmates' medical mobility equipment while attempting to pilfer baked goods from a young lady's lunch tray constituted a clever use of your morning?"

Josh's mouth opened and closed without a sound, a bead of sweat rolling down his temple while Mark quietly edged two steps sideways toward the napkin dispensers, pretending he didn't know him.

"Since you possess such a sudden, burning passion for unobstructed right-of-way and wheeled mechanics," Mrs. DeMarco continued, her voice dropping to a lethal purr that carried cleanly across five tables, "allow me to channel that enthusiasm

into a structured curriculum. You will report to me at the back service entrance by Dumpster Number One promptly at two o'clock this afternoon—adjusted, as you well know, for our block schedule—and every afternoon for the next two academic weeks. On Purple Days, you will consolidate exterior refuse and scrape every piece of petrified chewing gum from the undersides of the window tables. On Gold Days, you will reacquaint yourself with the grease traps behind the deep fryers."

A low, collective *oooooh* rippled softly along the serving rail before dying instantly at a single flick of Mrs. DeMarco's eyelashes.

"Furthermore," Mrs. DeMarco added crisply, "during your mandatory forty-five-minute study hall periods for the next two weeks, you will compose and deliver to my desk a ten-page, double-spaced essay titled *The Physics of Courtesy: Unobstructed Right-of-Way and Basic Human Decency in Shared Public Spaces*. One word of protest, Mr. Riley, and I shall gladly hand this matter directly to Principal Thompson instead. Am I understood?"

"Y-yes, Mrs. DeMarco," Josh croaked, his shoulders slumping in complete, soul-crushing defeat. "Two o'clock. Dumpster Number One."

"Move along, Mr. Riley. Quietly."

As Josh shuffled away with his head down, Mrs. DeMarco turned toward Katie and me—and in the span of a single breath, we witnessed the other half of the legend that upperclassmen whispered about during Unofficial Orientation: the *Sweet Angel* Proviso.

Every trace of arctic steel vanished from her eyes. Unfolding her arms, Mrs. DeMarco stepped beside our two compact powerchairs with genuine, unhurried warmth.

"Did he bump either of your controllers, sweethearts?" Mrs. DeMarco asked gently.

"No, ma'am—thank you, Mrs. DeMarco," I said sincerely, and Katie nodded right beside me. "Thank you for stepping in."

"You two never need to thank me for keeping the riffraff clear of my floor," Mrs. DeMarco said with a small, warm smile. She gestured toward our usual sunlit corner table by the tall windows—where, to our astonishment, two of the bolted blue plastic cafeteria chairs at the end had already been unfastened and removed by the custodian, leaving a wide, clear dual-wheelchair bay right under the laminate tabletop. "I had Mr. Jenkins unbolt those two end seats before first block on Monday so you and your sister can roll straight up together without waiting on anyone. Oh—and it looks like the line shorted each of your trays a dessert."

Before either of us could say we already had cookies, Mrs. DeMarco produced two fresh, warm paper-wrapped chocolate-chip cookies from a clean wax sheet on the rolling cart beside her, set one gently onto Katie's tray and one onto mine, gave us a brisk, protective wink, and resumed her patrol down the center aisle.

Rolling up side by side to our newly cleared window table, Katie and I clicked off our joysticks, reached our inner hands across our armrests to lace our fingers together on the tabletop, and glanced down the sunlit window row—where two other juniors in powerchairs who knew Mrs. DeMarco's courtroom justice by heart caught our eyes over their lunch trays and shared an amused, silent grin of solidarity.

Tuesday, October 9, 2001, 11:40 AM — The Sanctuary of the Stacks & The DeMarco–Periwinkle Tag-Team

At eleven-forty sharp, the mid-block transition bell rang overhead, splitting Third Block from lunch into forty-five minutes of mandatory study hall.

Out in the cavernous hub of the Commons beneath the blue steel roof trusses, three hundred teenagers poured onto the wide, bumpy quarry tiles—their voices echoing off the glass wall of the permanently locked interior courtyard with its bronze Lion statue. Across the edge of the Commons near the vending machines, Katie and I caught a brief, bittersweet glimpse of our maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher standing in a noisy circle with Tyler and several hard-partying seniors. Back in ninth and tenth grade—once Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve had sold their Blackwater farm and moved to Earlton Court the summer before freshman year so Brittany could finally attend Northwood High with Katie and me after elementary and middle school apart—all three of us had eaten together at that corner cafeteria table every day and walked straight into the library afterward, talking about how the three of us were going to rent an apartment and live together when we grew up. Lately, though, Brittany barely waved before turning back to Tyler's crowd in the Commons.

For two autistic sixteen-year-olds whose ten-inch drive wheels rattled like jackhammers over the deep grout lines of the Commons tiles, forty-five minutes in that roaring echo chamber was out of the question.

Thankfully, clipped behind our brass elevator keys were two laminated Section 504 library passes. Steering side by side across the Commons to the tall glass-walled entrance of the Northwood High School Library, I pushed the accessible door plate, and Katie and I glided inside.

Crossing that threshold was like rolling through an airlock into outer space.

The roar of three hundred teenagers cut off instantly behind the heavy glass, replaced by the scent of paperbacks, lemon polish on oak shelves, and the low, steady hum of the air conditioning beneath two enormous purple-and-gold wall banners hanging side by side over the stacks: *NORTHWOOD HIGH SCHOOL LIBRARY* with the golden Lion crest on the left, and *SILENCE IS OBSERVED - SHHH!* in unmistakable gold block letters on the right.

Seated squarely behind the high circulation desk beside her beige desktop card-catalog computer and her brass *HEAD LIBRARIAN* nameplate was Mrs. Periwinkle.

If Mrs. DeMarco ruled the physical territory of the cafeteria through swift custodial labor, Mrs. Periwinkle governed the academic wing through pure, uncompromising psychological order. Perfectly coiffed silver-gray hair framed an unblinking gaze, a button-up pastel periwinkle cardigan sat smoothed to mathematical symmetry over her shoulders, and a pair of tortoiseshell reading glasses hung on a gold chain at her collarbone.

As Katie and I rolled silently past the circulation desk, Mrs. Periwinkle lifted her chin and scanned both of our wheelchair lap trays for contraband—food wrappers, chewing gum, soda cans, or leaking headphone cords. Finding nothing except our spiral *Quantum Basic 6.0* coding notebook and two sharpened pencils, her tight-lipped expression softened by a fraction of a millimeter.

“Good morning, Prairies,” Mrs. Periwinkle whispered, her voice no louder than dry autumn leaves brushing together.

“Good morning, Mrs. Periwinkle,” Katie and I whispered back in unison.

She gave a single, approving nod toward the wide oak reference table near the oversized world atlases and the *005* computer-programming shelves—our favorite quiet refuge in the entire building. Parking our compact powerchairs side by side at the end of the oak table, Katie and I laced my right hand and her left hand together while using our free hands to sketch a menu-loop subroutine in clean, uninterrupted peace.

Fifteen minutes later, the glass entrance doors clattered open a notch too fast.

In shuffled Josh Riley, clutching a crumpled yellow cafeteria study-hall pass and an empty spiral notebook—evidently banished from the Commons to begin drafting page one of his ten-page courtesy essay. Trailing a faint whiff of stale dumpster cardboard past the card-catalog terminal, Josh spotted two guys from the football team sitting near the magazine rack, leaned over their table, and groaned loudly enough to carry across three aisles of oak shelving.

“Can you believe that crazy lunch lady?” Josh muttered, tossing his notebook onto the oak table with a slap that sounded like a gunshot in the silent room. “Ten pages single-handed just ’cause the bumper-car twins—”

“Shhh!”

The sound cracked through the library air like a bullwhip.

Every head between the biography wall and the encyclopedias froze. Standing at the end of the *900* History aisle with one finger raised was Mrs. Periwinkle, sliding her tortoiseshell spectacles up onto the bridge of her nose so her eyes magnified to owl-like proportions.

“Mr. Riley,” Mrs. Periwinkle hissed in a razor-edged stage whisper that somehow reached every corner of the room without breaking her own decibel law. “This is a house of scholarship. If you wish to bellow like barn livestock, the Commons lies thirty feet behind that glass. Within these walls, silence is observed.”

“I was just sitting down to write Mrs. DeMarco’s stupid—” Josh started to whine.

“And it appears,” a second, chillingly calm voice observed from directly behind him at the glass entrance doors, “that you have not yet written the title.”

Katie and I looked up from our coding notebook, our eyes going wide.

Standing just inside the library doorway with an institutional nutrition reference binder tucked neatly under one arm—having stepped across the Commons on her mid-shift break to return a library volume—was Mrs. DeMarco.

Across the carpet beside the circulation desk, Mrs. DeMarco’s dark eyes met Mrs. Periwinkle’s magnified gaze. Neither woman spoke a word to the other, yet a single, nearly imperceptible nod passed between them—the silent, terrifying handshake of Northwood High’s two supreme authorities.

“Mrs. DeMarco,” Mrs. Periwinkle said smoothly, folding her hands in front of her pastel periwinkle cardigan, “if Mr. Riley finds your outdoor sanitation curriculum and essay assignment insufficiently engaging, I would be more than happy to host his afternoon rehabilitation right here in the Media Center.”

Josh blinked rapidly between Mrs. DeMarco and Mrs. Periwinkle, a fresh, existential horror dawning across his face as he realized there was no Geneva Convention protecting him in this room.

“Our *930* Ancient Civilizations shelves and *500* Natural Sciences stacks are overdue for a complete shelf-reading audit,” Mrs. Periwinkle continued, sweeping one hand toward three thousand thick clothbound volumes. “Every single spine verified to the third decimal place of the Dewey Decimal System, in total, uninterrupted silence under my direct supervision from two o’clock until four—followed, of course, by scrubbing the library’s wastebaskets before departure.”

Mrs. DeMarco tilted her head a fraction of an inch, the faintest trace of dry amusement flickering behind her eyes as she looked at Josh.

“A generous academic offer, Mrs. Periwinkle,” Mrs. DeMarco murmured. “Well, Mr. Riley? Fresh autumn air at Dumpster Number One and silent progress on your ten-page essay right now—or three weeks of silent Dewey Decimal precision under Mrs. Periwinkle’s tutelage? The choice is entirely yours.”

For Josh Riley—a boy who viewed three-digit numbers after a decimal point and enforced silence as psychological torture worse than death—there was no choice at all. Every ounce of attitude evaporated from his spine on the spot.

“The dumpsters, Mrs. DeMarco,” Josh squeaked in a terrified whisper, dropping into the solitary study carrel nearest the circulation desk and flipping his blank notebook open so fast he nearly tore the cover. “I’ll do the dumpsters and the grease traps! I’m writing the essay right now—not another word, swear to God!”

“A prudent calculation, Mr. Riley,” Mrs. DeMarco replied softly. Offering Mrs. Periwinkle one last nod of mutual professional respect, she set her returned binder cleanly in the drop slot and slipped back out through the glass doors toward her cafeteria.

Behind the front desk, Mrs. Periwinkle watched Josh hunch silently over his notebook for five full seconds to verify compliance, then glided down the carpeted aisle past our oak reference table. Without breaking stride, she set two crisp, newly cataloged *Structured Programming & Visual Algorithms* handbooks silently at the corner of our table, gave Katie and me a tiny, almost imperceptible nod over the rims of her spectacles, and returned to her post.

Waiting until she was ten feet away, Katie leaned sideways across our armrests, pressed her forehead lightly against my shoulder to muffle her silent laugh, and squeezed my right hand twice—both of us grinning from ear to ear inside the safest, quietest forty-five minutes at Northwood High School.

Sixteen on Four Wheels & Finding Dates

Part 1: Navigating Northwood High on Four Wheels, Two First Dates, & Why We Ride on Saturday

Date: 2001-10-15 at 07:10 America/New_York

Monday, October 15, 2001, 7:10 AM — Rolling the “Blue Mile” & The Brass Elevator Key

“Keep your speed dial on two until we clear the Commons tiles, Nate, or the vibration is going to rattle our teeth right out of our heads,” Katie said with a wry smile on Monday morning as the two of us rolled our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs through the pinned-open double fire doors of Northwood High School.

Beneath our ten-inch solid drive wheels, the textured quarry tiles of the Northwood High Commons buzzed like a washboard before giving way to the smooth, polished linoleum of the main academic corridor everyone called the “Blue Mile.”

It was the start of our second full week navigating eleventh grade on four wheels instead of two feet, and physically, the difference was like night and day.

Back in September, walking from the morning bus loop to first period had left our calves cramping, our knees trembling, and our shoulders aching from the weight of our backpacks before the first bell even rang. Now, thanks to the Section 504 Medical Mobility Plan that Dr. Carter had signed and Dad had walked into the principal’s office, neither Katie nor I carried a single textbook between classes. A duplicate set of our Junior-year textbooks sat on a designated shelf in each of our classrooms, and clipped to our lanyard ID badges alongside our house keys were two shiny brass Vanguard Elevator keys issued by the school custodian.

Socially, however, showing up to your Junior year of high school in matching power wheelchairs was like dropping a boulder into the middle of a swimming pool.

As Katie and I glided side by side down the right-hand lane of the Blue Mile with our right index fingers resting lightly on our armrest joysticks, the noisy wall of lockers ahead of us reacted the exact same way it had all last week. Conversations dropped to sudden, awkward whispers as we rolled past. Kids who had known us since sixth grade either stared straight down at their sneakers as if looking at a power wheelchair might be rude, or leaped three feet out of our path against the lockers as though we were driving runaway forklifts.

When we reached the B-Wing stairwell at the end of the hall—where two hundred students were jostling up the concrete steps toward the second floor—I pulled my brass key on its retractable lanyard reel, inserted it into the keyhole beside the heavy gray door of the school’s service elevator, and turned it clockwise.

With a slow mechanical clunk, the sliding metal door rattled open, releasing the familiar scent of lemon floor wax and damp mop buckets. Katie and I rolled our compact power chairs straight inside side by side, and as the door slid shut, sealing out the roar of the stairwell, Katie reached her left hand across the two inches between our armrests and laced her fingers through mine.

“Did you see Todd Jenkins jump into the water fountain alcove when we turned the corner by the trophy case?” I asked as the old hydraulic elevator groaned upward toward the second floor at roughly half a mile an hour.

“He nearly knocked his own varsity jacket off his shoulder,” Katie laughed, squeezing my hand as the floor indicator light blinked from 1 to 2. “Remind me again why we used to be afraid of using this elevator?”

“Because we didn’t know how nice it was to get to first block without our legs shaking,” I said honestly as the elevator chimed and the door rattled open onto the upstairs landing. “See you at ten-fifty-five at our table?”

“Count on it,” Katie smiled, giving my hand one last squeeze before we released our fingers and steered in opposite directions down the hall—Katie toward first-block Chemistry on Gold Days, and me toward first-block English.

Monday, October 15, 2001, 11:00 AM — Head Over Heels for Heather & Katie’s Guarded Heart

“You were smiling all the way from Mrs. DeMarco’s milk cooler to the table, Nate,” Katie teased gently three and a half hours later as the two of us parked our compact power wheelchairs side by side in the cleared dual-wheelchair bay at the end of our sunlit corner cafeteria table and clicked our joystick motors off. “Let me guess: Heather Collins sat next to you in second-block Computer Lab again?”

I felt my ears turn warm all the way to the tips as I set my brown paper lunch bag beside our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook.

“She moved her chair right next to my power chair for the whole ninety-minute block,” I admitted, unable to keep the grin off my face as I poked Katie’s straw into her apple juice box for her and handed it across our armrests. “When everybody else in the row stepped around my wheelchair like it was radioactive, Heather didn’t even blink. She showed me wallet photos of her family, helped me pick a color palette for our *Quantum Basic* menu screen, and asked if I wanted to sit with her at the computer table every Gold Day this semester.”

The truth was, I wasn’t just crushing on Heather Collins—at sixteen years old, I was completely, head-over-heels in love with her. From the first week of Junior year in Room 204, Heather had treated me with a warm, effortless kindness that made my heart race every time she walked through the classroom door.

Beside me, Katie took a sip of her juice box, her expression softening with genuine happiness for me before a quieter, more thoughtful look crossed her face.

“What about Ryan Miller in first-block Chemistry?” I asked, reaching my right hand across the gap between our chairs to take Katie’s left hand on the laminate tabletop. “You said on Friday that he kept leaning across the lab bench to talk to you.”

“He did again today,” Katie said, though her voice was noticeably more reserved than mine. Ever since seventh grade at Morrison Middle School—when Chad had dumped her in the middle of the cafeteria and left her sobbing beneath the blue butterfly in her bedroom—Katie had kept a careful, protective wall around her heart when it came to boys. “Actually, while we were cleaning up our beakers at the

accessible lab sink, Ryan asked if I wanted to go out with him to Emerald Creek Mall this weekend. And he asked if you had a girlfriend you wanted to bring along so we could make it a double date."

My breath caught in my throat. Neither Katie nor I had ever been on a real high-school date before. Before our legs gave out in September and we got our compact power wheelchairs, Katie and I had gone to both Emerald Creek Mall and Chesapeake Bay Mall all the time—with Chesapeake Bay Mall out on Lynnhaven Parkway always being our favorite "big trip" mall (which we still hadn't visited yet since getting our powerchairs), and Emerald Creek Mall becoming our favorite regular teenage hangout because we only needed to ride a single bus from Military Highway to get there.

"Wait—what did you tell him?" I asked.

"I told him I'd talk to you at lunch first," Katie said carefully, her fingers tightening around mine. "Honestly, Nate, I don't know about Ryan. He's nice enough when we're lab partners, but I can't tell if he actually likes *me* or if he just likes having someone who balances his chemical equations for him. Still… I see the way your whole face lights up whenever you talk about Heather. And if we go together as a double date on Saturday afternoon, neither one of us has to go through our first high-school date alone."

"Why Saturday specifically?" I asked, glancing at the calendar inside my binder.

"Because I checked Dad's printed CVTA Route 15 schedule on the refrigerator this morning," Katie explained, tapping the timetable notes she had copied into the margin of our notebook. "Remember the alternating branch rule at Old Emerald Creek Road and Military Highway? Route 15 only serves Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday. On Sundays, every single trip runs straight down to Robert Hall Boulevard and skips Emerald Creek Mall completely. So if we want to take the bus to the mall ourselves, it has to be on Saturday."

"Then let's do Saturday," I said earnestly, squeezing her hand so she knew my promise from seventh grade hadn't changed one bit. "I'll ask Heather in Computer Lab on Wednesday morning, and you tell Ryan we'll meet them at the Emerald Creek Mall upstairs food court at twelve-forty-five on Saturday. And Katie—if Ryan acts weird for even one second, you and I have our bus fare in our pockets and each other right beside us."

Wednesday, October 17, 2001, 10:05 AM — Two Very Different Reactions

"A Saturday afternoon double date at Emerald Creek Mall with you and Katie?" Heather Collins repeated on Wednesday morning near the end of second-block Computer Lab, her warm hazel eyes lighting up with an immediate, genuine smile that made my chest feel weightless. "I would love to, Nate! How are you and Katie getting over to Emerald Creek?"

"We live right near Military Highway and Indian River Road now, so we're taking CVTA Route 15 at twelve-twenty-five," I explained honestly, bracing myself just in case a high-school girl thought riding the city bus on a first date was uncool. "The

high-floor bus has a hydraulic wheelchair lift in the front stairwell, so Katie and I can roll our power chairs right aboard together without Dad having to break them down for the trunk of his car."

Heather didn't flinch or look embarrassed for a fraction of a second. Instead, her smile grew even warmer.

"That is so smart—my dad can drop me off at the main mall entrance at twelve-forty, and I'll ride the back glass elevator right up to the second-floor food court to meet you and Katie," Heather said brightly, reaching over to touch the sleeve of my flannel shirt. "I can't wait for Saturday, Nate."

Fifty minutes later at Third-Block lunch, however, when Katie rolled up to our cleared bay at the corner table under Mrs. DeMarco's watchful eye and parked beside me before we headed into Mrs. Periwinkle's library for study hall, I could see immediately from the tight set of her jaw that her conversation with Ryan Miller in first-block Chemistry had gone very differently.

"Ryan agreed to meet us at twelve-forty-five on Saturday," Katie said quietly, unwrapping her sandwich and taking my right hand across the table, "but we didn't even make it out of the Chemistry lab before he got weird about two things."

"What did he say?" I asked, frowning.

"First, when I told him we were meeting at Emerald Creek Mall, Ryan puffed his chest out and said, *'Oh, I'll drive over to your house in my coupe and pick you up—just fold your wheelchair up and throw it in my trunk,"*" Katie recounted, shaking her head in disbelief. "I tried to explain to him twice that a motorized power wheelchair with a battery box and solid drive wheels doesn't just fold flat like an umbrella stroller, and that even if Dad disassembled it into four pieces, it wouldn't fit inside a two-door sports coupe."

"And what was the second thing?" I asked.

"When I told him that you and I were riding CVTA Route 15 to the mall together because we always travel as a pair," Katie said, her blue eyes steady and guarded as she looked at me, "Ryan frowned and said, *'Wait—you're bringing your brother on the bus instead of riding with me? Don't you ever go anywhere without Nate?'* I looked him straight in the eye and told him, *'No, Ryan. Nate is my twin brother, and he comes first.'* He backed down and said he'd meet us at the food court at twelve-forty-five, but… I have a feeling Saturday is going to be a very short test for Ryan Miller."

Part 2: Cousin Wesley, Ryan's Escalator Exit, & Two Dates at Emerald Creek Mall

Date: 2001-10-20 at 12:45 America/New_York

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 12:45 PM — The Second-Floor Food Court & Cousin Wesley

"Nate! Katie! You guys made it right on time!" Heather Collins called out with a radiant smile at twelve-forty-five on Saturday afternoon, waiting for us on the terracotta-tile landing right outside the brushed-brass sliding doors of the

freestanding early-1980s glass elevator on the main retail concourse—its warm cream-colored corner columns framing multi-pane glass and topped with a small glass pyramid cap beneath the white steel roof trusses—right where the elevator connected the first floor of the main concourse up to the second-floor food court wing of Emerald Creek Mall.

Twenty minutes earlier, Dad had walked with us out to the corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road, pressed a twenty-dollar bill into each of our hands, and waved from the sidewalk as Katie and I rode the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift aboard the 12:25 PM Saturday southbound CVTA Route 15 (Bus #914). Right on schedule at 12:45 PM, the high-floor Beacon V bus had dropped us off at the bus stop on the mall's outer ring road, straight across the parking lot from the first-floor exterior entrance of Wellington's, the two-story anchor department store at the end of the wing. Rolling side by side from the ring road through the ground-floor cosmetics and apparel aisles of Wellington's into the first-floor main concourse, Katie and I had rolled right into the glass-backed scenic elevator directly in front of the department store's mall entrance and ridden it up to the second floor.

Before I could even click my joystick speed dial down to one on the upper landing, Heather stepped straight up to my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair, leaned down without a trace of hesitation, and wrapped her arms around my shoulders in a warm hello hug that sent my heart soaring into the skylights.

"Hi, Nate," Heather said softly against my cheek before straightening up and smiling just as warmly at my twin sister. "And hi, Katie! My dad dropped me off at the lower Wellington's entrance and I rode the glass elevator right up here from the first-floor concourse so we could roll into the food court wing together—and whenever we go downstairs to browse the lower level, I'm riding the elevator right alongside you two."

"Thanks for waiting for us by the elevator, Heather," Katie said, her guarded posture relaxing noticeably at how naturally Heather included both of us and had zero problem being seen riding the mall elevator with two kids in wheelchairs.

Turning 180 degrees away from the glass elevator and the two-story interior entrance of Wellington's behind us on the main retail concourse, the three of us rolled straight into the bustling second-floor food court wing—where the high white tented fabric canopy ceiling and skylights echoed with weekend chatter, the far exterior glass exit doors at the back of the wing opened straight out onto the graded upper section of the mall parking lot that gently sloped up to the second-floor level, and Bobby Vanguard's 1982 synth-pop classic *"Moving Up the Escalator"* drifted down from the PA speakers above the food court escalators—just as Ryan Miller strolled over from the brass-and-glass mezzanine railing in his letterman jacket.

Unlike Heather, Ryan didn't look thrilled to see our two compact power wheelchairs rolling side by side.

"Hey," Ryan said, glancing down at Katie's motorized drive wheels as we picked a four-top table positioned right on the tile concourse between the two central escalators—with the up escalator rising from the first floor on Katie's and my side, and the down escalator descending to the first floor on Heather's and Ryan's side—and pulled two plastic chairs away so Katie and I could park our power chairs side

by side facing Ryan and Heather. “Katie, I still don’t get why you made me meet you here instead of letting me pick you up in my car. You seriously couldn’t just fold that chair up and stick it in my trunk?”

“Ryan, I told you on Wednesday—it’s a power wheelchair,” Katie replied evenly, tapping the black battery box beneath her seat. “It has electric motors and heavy batteries. It doesn’t fold up like a beach chair, and Nate and I ride Route 15 together.”

Ryan let out a loud, skeptical sigh, slumping into his seat across from Katie as Heather and I brought back our lunch trays from Crown Burger and Annie’s Pretzels.

Halfway from the counter to the table, the progressive neuropathy weakness in my left forearm flared under the weight of the plastic food tray. My left wrist trembled, tipping my large cola cup toward the edge of the tray. Instantly—without me having to say a single word—Katie glided her power chair half a foot to her right, slid her left hand under the corner of my tray to steady it onto the table, pinched open the paper wrapper on my straw, and laced her left fingers through my right hand between our armrests while my wrist tremor settled.

Across the table, Ryan stared at our joined hands as if we had just committed a felony.

“Are you kidding me right now, Katie?” Ryan snapped, setting his burger down on its wrapper and leaning forward across the table. “First you refuse to ride in my car unless your brother comes along, and now you’re sitting here holding his hand and opening his straw while you’re supposed to be on a date with *me*? Who’s number one here—me or your brother?”

The noisy food court seemed to fade into background static around our table. Beside me, Katie didn’t flinch, and she didn’t let go of my hand.

“Nate is number one in my life, Ryan,” Katie said clearly, looking him straight in the eyes. “He is my twin brother. We’ve been through everything together, and he is always going to come first.”

Ryan scoffed, his face flushing red as he turned toward Heather next to him, clearly expecting her to back him up. “Heather, are you seeing this? Doesn’t it bother you that your date is sitting here holding his sister’s hand and acting like they’re glued together?”

Heather looked at Ryan with calm, unmistakable steel in her hazel eyes—and then reached across the tabletop to lay her right hand warmly over my left hand.

“No, Ryan, it doesn’t bother me one bit,” Heather said firmly. “In fact, I love how close Nate and Katie are.”

Ryan blinked at her. “What? Why?”

“Because my fourteen-year-old cousin Wesley—my mom’s sister’s son—is severely developmentally disabled,” Heather explained, her voice steady and proud as she looked from Ryan to Katie and me. “Wesley and I grew up together, and whenever the two of us go anywhere, I hold Wesley’s hand, I hug him, and we look out for

each other the exact same way Nate and Katie do. If I ever screamed at Nate or got jealous of him for holding his twin sister's hand and hugging her, I would be disrespecting the exact relationship I have with Wesley."

Heather turned her gaze back to me, her eyes shining with so much warmth and affection that my throat went tight.

"I knew before I ever said yes on Wednesday that Nate and Katie travel as a pair," Heather continued softly. "And watching the way they take care of each other only makes me love Nate more."

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 1:20 PM — Ryan's Escalator Exit & "Did You Bring Two Dates?"

Ryan stared from Heather to Katie and me, his ego visibly bruised beyond repair as he realized neither girl at the table was going to bend to him.

"Whatever," Ryan muttered bitterly, shoving his plastic food-court chair back across the quarry tile and standing up. "If I wanted to play second fiddle to your twin brother and a pair of wheelchairs all afternoon, I would've stayed home. Have fun riding the city bus, Katie."

Heather, Katie, and I watched in silence as Ryan snatched his jacket off the back of his chair.

Beside me, Katie kept her chin up, but I felt the slight tremor in her left hand where her fingers were still laced with mine, and I saw the hurt glistening at the corners of her blue eyes. Even though Katie had stayed guarded with Ryan all week—and even though part of her had figured from the start that this wouldn't work—having a boy walk out on her in the middle of a crowded food court still stung.

And then Ryan did something that turned my blood to ice.

Because our table sat right between the two central escalators—with the up escalator on Katie's and my side, the down escalator right on Heather's and Ryan's side, and the glass elevator back behind us—the entrance to the down escalator was to Ryan's immediate right as he stood up from his chair. Instead of walking back toward the elevator or the upper-level parking-lot doors, Ryan turned to look directly at Katie sitting in her compact power wheelchair, took two steps to his immediate right, and stepped deliberately onto the moving metal steps of the down escalator—riding it down to the first floor in a massive, calculated show of disrespect because he knew Katie's disability made it physically impossible for her to follow him down those stairs.

As the top of Ryan's head sank below the second-floor floorplate on the escalator, a long, quiet breath left Katie's lips.

"I kind of figured before we even got off the bus today that it wouldn't work with him," Katie admitted quietly, blinking back the moisture in her eyes as she looked down at her lap belt. "Still… taking the escalator just to rub it in that I can't follow him was pretty low."

“It wasn’t just low, Katie—it was disgusting, and he didn’t deserve five minutes of your time,” Heather said immediately, stepping around the corner of the table to rest a gentle, supportive hand on Katie’s shoulder while I squeezed Katie’s left hand with everything I had. “And we are *not* letting him ruin our Saturday. Come on—finish your pretzels, and let’s the three of us go walk the second floor of the mall together!”

Katie looked up at Heather in surprise, then glanced at me.

“You’re sure you don’t mind me tagging along on your date, Heather?” Katie asked softly.

“Are you kidding? You’re not tagging along—we’re a team today,” Heather smiled warmly.

Ten minutes later, after we cleared our trays, the three of us rolled out of the food court and into the wide, sunlit second-floor concourse of Emerald Creek Mall. I rolled down the center of the polished terrazzo walkway in my compact power chair, with Katie rolling right beside my left armrest holding my left hand, and Heather walking right beside my right armrest holding my right hand.

Halfway past the Oak & Iron Outfitters and The Literary Alcove upper-level windows, three guys from our Junior-year History and English classes at Northwood High School—Marcus, Devon, and Chris—came walking out of the music store carrying CD bags.

None of the three had ever had a class with Katie and me at the same time, so they had no idea Katie was my twin sister—and as their eyes landed on me rolling down the mall in my power wheelchair flanked by two pretty sixteen-year-old girls holding both of my hands, all three of them stopped dead in their tracks.

Marcus grinned from ear to ear and gave me an impressed salute.

“Whoa, Prairie—save some for the rest of us, man!” Marcus laughed, nudging Devon’s elbow as they walked past. “Did you seriously bring *two* dates to Emerald Creek Mall today?!”

For one second, Heather, Katie, and I blinked at each other—and then all three of us burst out laughing so hard that every bit of the sadness Ryan had left behind vanished into the vaulted ceiling of the mall.

“Tell them yes, Nate!” Heather giggled, squeezing my right hand as Katie laughed beside us. “Let the whole eleventh grade think you’re the smoothest guy at Northwood High!”

“With the two prettiest girls in Virginia Beach on either side of my chair,” I grinned, looking from Katie’s bright, restored smile on my left to Heather’s glowing face on my right, “I’m definitely not correcting them.”

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 2:40 PM — A Hug for Me, A Handshake for Katie, & Route 15 Home

We spent the next hour browsing the second-floor music and book aisles at The Literary Alcove together before riding the freestanding glass-enclosed elevator down to the first-floor main concourse at two-forty and rolling out through the first-floor entrance of Wellington's toward the ring road so Katie and I could catch the 2:48 PM northbound CVTA Route 15 bus back up Military Highway.

Just outside the automatic sliding glass doors in the crisp October sunshine, Heather's father pulled up to the pickup curb in his burgundy sedan and gave a friendly wave through the windshield. Fifty feet down the wide concrete sidewalk, the blue-and-yellow CVTA bus stop sign stood waiting for the 2:48 PM bus.

Stopping beside us on the sidewalk, Heather turned to me first. Bending down in front of my power chair, she wrapped both arms warmly around my neck and hugged me close, her cheek pressing against mine for a long, unhurried moment.

"Today was the best first date I've ever had, Nate," Heather whispered in my ear before pulling back with a bright smile. "Same computer table on Monday morning?"

"Same computer table on Monday morning," I promised, my face glowing.

Then Heather turned to Katie's power wheelchair right beside mine. Instead of giving a polite wave from a distance, Heather stepped squarely in front of my twin sister, met Katie's blue eyes with genuine warmth and respect, and extended her right hand.

"It was really great hanging out with you today, Katie," Heather said earnestly. "Next Saturday, maybe the three of us can bring my cousin Wesley along and get pretzels together."

Katie looked at Heather's outstretched hand, and a real, unguarded smile broke across my sister's face as she reached out with her right hand and shook Heather's hand warmly.

"I'd really like that, Heather," Katie said. "See you at school on Monday."

We watched from the sidewalk as Heather climbed into the front passenger seat of her father's car and waved out the window until the sedan merged onto the ring road. As soon as her dad's car turned the corner, Katie and I steered our compact power wheelchairs side by side down the sidewalk to the CVTA Route 15 bus stop and laced our inner hands together while we waited for the 2:48 PM high-floor Beacon V bus to round the loop.

"Well," I said quietly, looking over at my twin sister as the familiar white bus with its horizontal blue-and-green TRT stripes and CVTA door sticker signaled toward our curb, "one out of two first dates wasn't bad."

“Are you kidding, Nate?” Katie smiled, squeezing my hand as the bus pulled up and the operator switched on the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift. “Finding out in twenty minutes that Ryan was a jerk—and finding out that Heather loves you *and* gets us completely because of her cousin Wesley? I’d call that a hundred percent success.”

The Uncut Curb at Smoker’s Corner

The Handicap Lot Edge, The Crosswalk to Grass on Lions Way, & Why Brittany Turned Down the Cigarette

Date: 2001-11-08 at 14:00 America/New_York

Thursday, November 8, 2001, 2:00 PM — Eight Spare Minutes Before Bus 417 & Where the Sidewalk Runs Out

“Nate, Katie—Bus 417 is stuck third in line behind two slow tie-downs, so I’ve got at least eight minutes before I can lower our lift!” Miss Gloria, the cheerful bus aide on our afternoon Special Needs school bus, called over the rumble of idling diesel engines outside Stairway A as she tapped her aluminum clipboard against her mittened palm in the crisp November air. “Don’t roll further than the edge of the handicap lot!”

“Just rolling down the sidewalk to the corner of the lot for some air, Miss Gloria—we’ll be right back before our bus pulls up!” Katie called back warmly, nudging her right-hand joystick forward as I matched her speed inch for inch beside her.

Five months had changed every single rule of two o’clock dismissal at Northwood High School.

Back in May at the end of tenth grade, walking off campus with our maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher had required nothing more than Dad’s standing walker note on file in the Main Office and cutting across the lawn to the fence. Once our legs had given out for good in the B-Wing hallway in September and Dr. Carter had prescribed our compact black motorized SwiftChair power wheelchairs, however, we no longer rode a regular fifty-four-passenger yellow bus—and we couldn’t simply roll off school grounds unannounced. Under our Section 504 transportation plan, Katie and I were assigned to Bus 417, a short yellow lift-equipped bus that loaded right outside Stairway A. Every weekday afternoon at two o’clock, the driver and Miss Gloria checked each wheelchair student onto the hydraulic platform by name on a printed manifest before dropping Katie and me off at the aluminum front-porch ramp of our single-story brick ranch on Arvin Road under the unattended home self-release waiver Dad had signed. Leaving campus any other way would have required an adult signing us off the manifest in the Main Office before fourth block ended so Special Needs Dispatch wouldn’t radio a missing-student alert across Kempsville.

Even if we had lived in some alternate universe where Dad signed ten walker notes and Brittany hadn’t started pulling away from us at school, though, one glance ahead showed why our SwiftChairs could never make that five-minute trip between Northwood High and Earlton Court in either direction.

Following the closest concrete sidewalk leading away from the school entrance, Katie and I glided down the curb ramp into the blue-striped handicap parking section at the outer corner of the student parking lot—and eased our right index fingers back to neutral right where the asphalt stopped.

Directly in front of our five-inch front caster wheels stretched a wide, bumpy expanse of unpaved green grass with zero sidewalk leading out to two-lane Lions Way. Out on Lions Way itself, a set of white ladder-style crosswalk stripes ran across the asphalt—yet neither end of that painted crosswalk had a curb cut at all. Leaving Northwood High, a wheelchair couldn't cross the soft turf, couldn't drop off the unbroken standard concrete curb onto Lions Way, and couldn't climb the matching unbroken standard curb on the far side by the gray concrete light pole. Even coming from Brittany's house on the other side of the galvanized chain-link fence—where the short concrete strip actually met the asphalt dead end of Macgregory Street completely level so you could roll straight through the narrow fence gap—your front casters would dead-end three feet later at the uncut Lions Way curb with zero ramp on either side and nothing but grass across the road.

For an ambulatory teenager in sneakers, stepping off grass down a normal street curb and stepping back up the other side was so effortless you didn't even notice your knees bending. For two fifty-pound motorized power wheelchairs, this blue-striped corner of the student handicap parking lot was as close to Smoker's Corner as Katie and I could physically get.

Katie reached her left hand across the narrow gap between our armrests and laced her fingers tightly through my right hand, both of us looking across the stretch of green grass and two-lane Lions Way toward the narrow opening in the chain-link fence.

"There she goes through the gate now," Katie said quietly beside me.

All autumn long, watching Brittany drift away from our corner cafeteria table and Mrs. Periwinkle's library toward Tyler's loud senior crowd in the Commons had left an ache in both of our chests that neither of us liked to talk about out loud. Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve hadn't drifted an inch—three weeks earlier, right after Brenda signed the divorce stipulation restoring her maiden name, Brenda had driven straight to Earlton Court demanding that her sister cut Dad off, only to scream that Karen was a traitor and storm off the Fletchers' porch for good when Aunt Karen refused to take her side, reminded her that Dad had still paid off her cruise debt so she had a roof over her head, and offered to drive her to an Alcoholics Anonymous meeting instead. Two Sundays ago, when Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve came over to Arvin Road with homemade lasagna to admire how smoothly our SwiftChairs turned in the hallway, Dad hadn't gloated once about the maiden-name order or said a single ugly word about Karen's sister at the table, and Aunt Karen still called Dad twice a week to check on us—yet at school, sixteen-year-old Brittany acted as if stopping at our lunch table for more than five seconds might get her kicked out of her new circle.

"Look who's waiting on the Macgregory side of the fence," I murmured, my jaw tightening slightly. "Because we aren't walking across the grass and out that gate beside her at two o'clock anymore, she's walking straight into them all by herself every afternoon."

Thursday, November 8, 2001, 2:06 PM — An Open Palm on Macgregory Street & The Cousin We Still Knew

Across Lions Way on the public asphalt dead end of Macgregory Street—where the narrow concrete strip met the neighborhood pavement flush in front of brick ranch houses framed by golden-orange November trees, while Officer Whitehead was still forty yards up the bus loop near the main driveway—Brittany had stopped at Smoker's Corner instead of walking straight down toward Earlton Court.

Adjusting the strap of her backpack over her plum ribbed sweater, Brittany stood listening with an anxious, eager-to-please half-smile behind her thin silver wire-rimmed glasses as two older seniors—a tall eighteen-year-old boy in a dark unbranded jacket who hung around Tyler's locker every morning and a senior girl—laughed near the chain-link fence.

Beside me at the edge of the handicap lot, Katie's fingers suddenly went rigid around my hand.

"Nate, look," Katie breathed.

Across Lions Way beyond the fence opening, the tall eighteen-year-old boy glanced casually down the road to make sure Officer Whitehead wasn't watching, fished a small flip-top cardboard cigarette pack out of his jacket pocket, and extended the closed box straight toward sixteen-year-old Brittany.

Even across the quiet lawn and two lanes of pavement, we could see his coaxing grin as he waggled the box toward her hand, gesturing for her to take one for the walk home.

My stomach knotted hard. Remembering our Aunt Liz's hacking cough up in Newport, remembering how fiercely all three of us used to hold our breath just to hurry past that exact patch of Macgregory Street asphalt back in May, and knowing that our own daily neuropathy prescription carried a lethal warning label against tobacco and alcohol alike, I braced myself for the worst—convinced that in her desperation to belong to Tyler's crowd, Brittany was about to reach out and take it.

She didn't.

The eager-to-please half-smile vanished from Brittany's face in an instant. Straightening her spine in her plum sweater, Brittany lifted her right hand squarely in front of her chest with her open palm facing the box like a stop sign and gave a firm, unmistakable shake of her head, stepping half a pace back along the flush concrete strip.

The eighteen-year-old boy shrugged, slipped the closed box back into his jacket pocket, and turned back toward the senior girl as Brittany pivoted away to adjust her backpack strap.

As she turned, Brittany's eyes swept across the chain-link gate and the white stripes of Lions Way—and locked straight onto Katie and me sitting side by side in our black SwiftChairs at the paved edge of the student handicap parking lot across the grass.

For three quiet seconds, nobody moved. Behind her silver wire-rimmed lenses, Brittany's cheeks flushed from across the road—half embarrassed to have been caught lingering at Smoker's Corner at all, and half softened by a sudden flash of the girl who had spread an apartment guide across our laps on Earlton Court back in May. Lifting her hand a few inches from her hip, Brittany gave Katie and me a small, shy wave before walking away down Macgregory Street toward Earlton Court.

Back behind us by Stairway A, two sharp, friendly toots of a bus horn echoed down the sidewalk as Bus 417 finally pulled forward to the hydraulic loading zone and Miss Gloria waved her clipboard in the air for us.

"Ready to roll back to the lift?" I asked softly, giving Katie's left hand a squeeze before easing my right thumb onto my joystick to turn smoothly on the handicap-lot pavement back toward the sidewalk.

"Yeah," Katie said—and as we hummed side by side up the walkway toward Stairway A in the slanting gold November sunlight, the heavy sadness that had weighed on her voice five minutes earlier had lifted into quiet, stubborn hope.

Once we paused in line behind the lowered steel elevator platform of Bus 417 while the driver unclipped the safety chain, Katie looked across at me with earnest certainty in her blue eyes.

"Did you see her face when she put her hand up just now, Nate?" Katie whispered beneath the hydraulic hum of the lift. "Even standing right in the middle of Tyler's friends with nobody else around to back her up, she wouldn't touch that pack. She hasn't turned into them—she's just lonely walking out that gate by herself now that our chairs can't cross that grass and those curbs. The sweet cousin we grew up with is still right inside her, and we aren't giving up on her."

"Not a chance," I agreed quietly, squeezing my twin sister's hand one more time before releasing her fingers for thirty seconds to guide my SwiftChair onto the waiting yellow bus lift toward home.

Seventeen, Senior Year, & Greenway Court

Drunken New Year

Part 1: The Gas-Station Run, A Box of Dry Cereal, & Why I Never Had a Twenty-First Birthday Drink

Date: 2002-12-31 at 21:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 31, 2002, 9:30 PM — The Broken Ground Rules & The Gas-Station Run

"Brittany, Dad laid down the ground rules before he walked out that front door—nobody is allowed over here while he's up in Rhode Island, and there is zero alcohol allowed in this house!" I said sharply at nine-thirty on New Year's Eve, sitting in my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair in the front hallway beside Katie's chair as our seventeen-year-old maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher pulled the front door open to the cold December night.

Tonight was supposed to be about saving her.

It was Tuesday, December 31, 2002—the middle of our Senior year at Northwood High School, just over three months before Katie and I would turn eighteen on April 8. Ever since the Friday afternoon in September of our Junior year when the borrowed time in our legs had finally run out in the hallway at school, both Katie and I had used our compact power wheelchairs full-time from the moment we woke up until we went to bed at night.

Back when we were kids, Brittany had grown up down on her family's old rural farm off Blackwater Road—zoned for Blackwater Elementary and Pungo Ridge Middle while Katie and I went to Northwood Elementary and Morrison Middle—bonding deeply with the two of us during all the afternoons Grandma Ruth and Dad watched her at our house whenever Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve worked odd shift hours. Then, in the summer before ninth grade, Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve had finally sold the farm and moved to Earlton Court right across the Lions Way fence from Northwood High School. For our first two years of high school, Brittany, Katie, and I had done everything together—eating lunch at our corner table in Mrs. DeMarco's cafeteria, whispering over homework in Mrs. Periwinkle's library, walking through Smoker's Corner to Brittany's living room on Earlton Court, and promising to get an apartment and live together as three when we grew up. Even after Dad divorced our mother in August 2001, Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve had stood loyally beside Dad, Katie, and me, and Dad had made sure Brittany stayed welcome in our home. Once Katie and I moved into our SwiftChairs in eleventh grade—stopped cold at the edge of the student handicap parking lot because the Lions Way crosswalk led straight into unpaved grass with zero curb cuts on either side—Brittany had fallen in with Tyler's hard-partying crowd out at Smoker's Corner. Still, Katie and I had never forgotten watching across Lions Way last autumn when one of Tyler's friends held out a pack of cigarettes to Brittany on Macgregory Street and she raised her palm and firmly refused to touch it—convincing both of us that the sweet cousin we loved was still inside her somewhere.

Up in Newport, Rhode Island—Dad and Grandma Ruth's hometown, where Grandma Ruth had moved back home in 1998 to live near Dad's sister Aunt Elizabeth and our older cousin Chelsea—Grandma Ruth had come down with a bad winter bronchitis over Christmas and couldn't travel south to Virginia on the ARTS train. Because hauling two heavy power wheelchairs nine hours north up Interstate 95 into New England winter weather for a brief New Year's visit would have been exhausting, Katie and I had stayed home in Virginia Beach while Dad drove up to Newport, Rhode Island to check on Grandma Ruth, Aunt Liz, and Chelsea for the New Year. Holding onto the memory of Brittany turning down that cigarette at Smoker's Corner, Katie and I were the ones who had asked Dad and Aunt Karen to let Brittany spend New Year's Eve at our house while Dad was out of state—both so an able-bodied person would be under the roof in case of a winter power outage and because we wanted to try to rescue her from Tyler's crowd. In our minds, if we

could just pull Brittany away from those kids for one safe, warm New Year's Eve—eating pizza, drinking sparkling apple cider, and laughing together the way the three of us used to in ninth and tenth grade—maybe she would come back to us. Before Dad backed his Holt sedan down the driveway to head north for Rhode Island, he had stood right in the center of our living room and laid down the law: the front door was to stay deadbolted, nobody else was allowed over at the house, and there was zero alcohol allowed under his roof.

Instead, with Dad four hundred and fifty miles away in Newport, Brittany had picked up the cordless kitchen phone and invited the exact wrong crowd we had been trying to rescue her from straight to our front door.

Now, standing on our aluminum front porch ramp in the porch light were five teenagers from that hard-partying Northwood High crowd—along with a tall, scruffy twenty-one-year-old guy named Derek who had just used his vertical driver's license to do a run to the corner gas station out on Military Highway, carrying two heavy plastic grocery bags clinking with glass bottles and cardboard twelve-packs.

"Oh, chill out, Nate—don't be such a pair of babies," Brittany scoffed, waving Derek and the other four kids past our wheelchairs into our small living room. "Uncle David is all the way up in Newport, Rhode Island with your grandma and Aunt Liz until tomorrow night! We'll throw the empties in the outside trash bin in the morning and nobody will ever know unless you two snitch."

"This isn't your house, Brittany, it's ours!" Katie said firmly, her left hand reaching across our armrests to grip my right hand as Derek dumped the plastic bags onto our kitchen counter with a loud crash of bottles. "Our dad works his tail off to pay the rent on this place, and we don't want strangers drinking in our living room!"

"Well, they're already here, and Derek already spent forty bucks at the gas station," Brittany shot back, grabbing two plastic cups from the dish rack as one of her friends cranked the volume knob on our living-room stereo up until the bass rattled the window blinds. "If you two don't want to party, go play on your computers in your room and leave us alone."

Tuesday, December 31, 2002, 11:15 PM — Hiding Behind a Locked Bedroom Door

By eleven-fifteen that night, our living room had devolved into a loud, sour-smelling war zone.

Katie and I had stayed near the hallway threshold as long as we could to make sure nobody broke Dad's things, but as the gas-station bottles emptied over the next ninety minutes, Brittany's guests turned into every kind of drunk at once.

Over on the living-room sofa, one boy in a hooded sweatshirt was already passed out cold with his mouth open and an empty can rolling across the carpet beneath his sneakers, while a girl beside him was slumped sideways over the armrest, half-conscious and groaning that the room was spinning. Near the kitchen doorway, Derek and another guy in a baseball cap had turned mean and belligerent—shouting profanities inches from each other's faces and shoving kitchen chairs out of the way in an angry argument over who owed whom ten dollars for the gas-station run. And

right in the middle of the rug, Brittany and her friend Jenna were completely loopy—stumbling into the coffee table, slurring every third word, and cackling at the top of their lungs as they spilled sticky soda and liquor across the floor.

For Katie and me, the smell of stale alcohol drifting down the hallway and the sound of angry, slurred shouting inside our own home hit every raw nerve left behind by our mother on the cruise ship sixteen months earlier.

When Derek slammed his palm against the kitchen wall so hard that the framed family photos in the hallway crooked on their nails, Katie looked at me with wide eyes and gripped my wrist.

"Nate, I don't want to be out here near them anymore," Katie whispered over the roar of the stereo and the shouting. "If Derek or that other guy trips over our wheelchairs while they're fighting, neither of us can stand up to get out of the way."

"Grab that unopened box of dry cereal off the lower pantry shelf so we have food for the rest of the night and don't have to come back out here," I told her immediately, snagging two cans of ginger ale on my lap tray while Katie tucked the family-size box of toasted oat cereal onto her lap. "We're locking ourselves in your room for the night."

As we backed our two compact power wheelchairs down the short hallway toward Katie's bedroom at the back corner of the house, one of Brittany's guests—a loudmouth senior from Northwood High named Tyler who had been chugging out of a plastic cup by the stereo—spotted us retreating and stumbled down the hall after us.

"Hey! Where do you two think you're rolling off to?" Tyler slurred, thrusting a red plastic cup toward my face as I steered Katie inside the bedroom ahead of me. "Come on, Prairie, stop acting like you're too good for the rave and take a drink!"

"We don't drink, Tyler—stay out of our hallway," I told him flatly.

Before Tyler could take another step, I backed my power chair across the threshold into Katie's bedroom, swung the solid wooden bedroom door shut right in his flushed, angry face, twisted the brass privacy lock until it clicked, and wedged the heavy rubber doorstop beneath the bottom gap.

On the other side of the oak panel, Tyler banged his fist twice against the door and yelled spitefully over the bass of the stereo, *"Fine, lock yourselves in a bedroom all night, you stuck-up losers! See if anybody cares!"*

For good measure, once Katie and I used our armrests to transfer onto the edge of her bed side by side beneath the framed blue butterfly print from our old house, I used my joystick to inch my fifty-pound power wheelchair right up against the inside of the doorknob like a steel roadblock.

Even through the closed door, we could still hear the muffled thudding of boots, the angry shouting from the kitchen, and the loopy, off-key shrieking from the living room.

Pulling Katie's green-and-gold quilt around both of our shoulders, I opened the top flaps of the cardboard cereal box between us so we had handfuls of dry cereal to munch on for dinner, switched the small thirteen-inch television on her dresser to the

GBS New Year's Eve broadcast from Times Square with the volume turned low, and wrapped my right arm around my twin sister's shoulders while my left hand held hers.

Wednesday, January 1, 2003, 12:00 AM — Why I Never Had a Twenty-First Birthday Drink

"Ten minutes to midnight," Katie murmured, resting her blonde head against my shoulder as the crowd in Times Square cheered on the small screen and another loud crash of glass echoed from the kitchen on the other side of our locked bedroom door. "Nate, we literally asked Dad to let Brittany come over tonight because we wanted to rescue her from that crowd. Back in ninth and tenth grade, the three of us did everything together—we used to talk about getting an apartment and living together as three when we grew up. And instead, the first chance she got, she brought that exact crowd into our house and told us to go hide in a bedroom."

"I know, Katie—and you can't rescue somebody who chooses that crowd over the family who tried to look out for her," I said quietly, squeezing her hand while glancing at the cordless extension handset on Katie's nightstand beside the two unopened cans of ginger ale we had brought into the bedroom on our lap trays. "If Dad were anywhere in Hampton Roads tonight, we would have quietly called him from the bedroom phone an hour ago and asked him to come to the house immediately. With him nine hours north in Newport with Grandma Ruth, Aunt Liz, and Chelsea, calling him right before midnight wouldn't get him down Interstate 95 tonight—it would just scare him half to death while he's stuck in Rhode Island. First thing in the morning, though, we're calling him, and Dad is going to hit the roof."

For a long moment, I sat there listening to the contrast between the two sides of that bedroom door: out in the living room, kids our age were passed out on the floor, screaming at each other in drunken rage, or stumbling around out of their minds—while in here, Katie and I were safe, clear-headed, and holding onto each other.

Up until that exact night at seventeen years old—four months shy of my eighteenth birthday in April—I had always assumed that when it came to alcohol, I was just waiting until my twenty-first birthday like everybody else to have my first legal drink. I was a rule-follower by nature; I didn't break laws, so I had figured that once I turned twenty-one, I'd probably try a glass of beer or wine just to see what the big deal was.

Sitting on the edge of that bed with Katie's hand in mine, listening to Derek's slurred shouting and Brittany's loopy giggling through the drywall—and remembering the look on our mother's face on Deck 4 of the *Sunward Tropics* right before she landed in the ship's brig—something settled permanently inside my chest.

"Katie?" I said softly as the digital clock on the television screen ticked to 11:59 PM and the glittering crystal ball began its sixty-second descent down the flagpole in Times Square.

"Yeah, Nate?" Katie asked, looking up at me.

"You know how I always said I was waiting until my twenty-first birthday to have my first legal drink?" I said, popping the tabs on our two cold cans of ginger ale and handing one to my sister. "Listening to what's going on in our living room tonight—

some of them passed out cold, some of them furious and trying to fight each other, some of them acting like they lost half their brains—I don't ever want to end up like that. Not even once. When we turn twenty-one, I'm not having a twenty-first birthday drink. I'm never touching the stuff for the rest of my life."

Katie looked at the can of ginger ale in her hand, then looked up into my eyes with a fierce, unmistakable pride.

"Me neither, Nate," Katie said, clinking her ginger ale can gently against mine just as *12:00 AM — HAPPY NEW YEAR 2003* flashed across the small screen and confetti snowed over Times Square. "Why would either one of us ever put something in our bodies that turns people into *that*—when we can stay sharp, write our code, and take care of each other?"

"Happy New Year, Katie," I whispered, setting my ginger ale on the nightstand and pulling my twin sister into a tight, two-armed hug under the quilt.

"Happy New Year, Twin Brother," Katie whispered back, hugging me tight beneath the quilt while the drunken shouting in the living room finally began stumbling out toward the street—the two of us holding fast behind our locked bedroom door until morning light, when one quiet phone call up to Newport, Rhode Island was going to make sure Brittany never set foot inside our home again.

Part 2: The Drunken New Year Lie, Heather's Bitter Goodbye, & Twin Sisters Always Stay

Date: 2003-01-06 at 08:05 America/New_York

Monday, January 6, 2003, 8:05 AM — Blindsided Outside Room 204

"Save it, Nathaniel—don't you dare roll up to my locker with that innocent smile on your face and pretend you didn't do anything wrong!" Heather Collins snapped at five minutes past eight on Monday morning, slamming her locker door shut so hard that the metal vents rattled down the second-floor hallway of Northwood High School.

My right thumb froze on the joystick of my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair, bringing my chair to an abrupt halt three feet from her locker outside Room 204.

It was Monday, January 6, 2003—the very first morning back at school after winter break. Because Heather's parents had taken her and her cousin Wesley up to the Shenandoah Valley to visit her grandparents between Christmas and New Year's Day, I hadn't seen her in person for over a week. All morning long on the CVTA Route 15 bus ride and up the school elevator with Katie, I had been grinning from ear to ear, carrying a small folded note in my jacket pocket asking Heather if she wanted to meet Katie and me at Emerald Creek Mall that coming Saturday afternoon.

Instead, as Katie rolled her power chair up beside mine in the busy hallway before first period, I found myself staring into a face I barely recognized.

The warm, gentle girl who had held my hand on the second-floor bridge of the mall, who had defended my bond with my twin sister because of how fiercely she loved her cousin Wesley, was staring down at me with hard, glassy eyes and a jaw clenched so tight her chin was trembling.

“Heather, what’s wrong?” I asked, completely blindsided as my stomach dropped into my shoes. “Did something happen over break? I don’t even know what you’re talking about!”

“Oh, you don’t know what I’m talking about?” Heather laughed—a short, jagged, bitter sound that made several students walking past us turn their heads. “Really, Nate? Look down the hall by the stairwell!”

I glanced over my shoulder toward the east stairwell. Leaning against the cinderblock wall in his varsity jacket with a smug, spiteful smirk plastered across his face was Tyler—the loudmouth senior who had stumbled down our hallway with a red plastic cup on New Year’s Eve and banged his fist on Katie’s bedroom door when we refused to join Brittany’s drunken rave.

“Tyler was in my homeroom ten minutes ago bragging to half the senior class about the wild New Year’s Eve rave at your house off Military Highway,” Heather said, her voice shaking with a cold, venomous fury that cut straight through the hallway chatter. “He told everybody how you got yourself and some girl wicked drunk on gas-station liquor, locked the two of you inside a back bedroom with a chair wedged against the doorknob, and spent the whole night hooking up behind a locked door while the party went on outside!”

For two full seconds, my brain couldn’t even process the sheer absurdity of what I was hearing.

“What?!” I gasped, staring at her in disbelief. “Heather, that’s a complete lie! Neither one of us drank a single drop of alcohol!”

“And you know what the worst part is, Nate?” Heather cut me off, her voice cracking with bitter humiliation as angry tears welled in the corners of her eyes. “When Tyler first started laughing in homeroom about how you locked yourself in a back bedroom all night with a girl, I actually defended you! I immediately assumed you were in that room with *Katie*—because I know the two of you always stick together and look out for each other! I looked right at Tyler in front of everybody and said, *‘That was his twin sister Katie, you idiot!’* And Tyler looked me dead in the eye, laughed in my face, and told the whole room it *wasn’t* Katie—that it was some blonde girl from the party who got wasted with you before you locked the door in his face!”

Beside me, Katie’s blue eyes went wide with outrage.

“Heather, Tyler *only* saw the back of my blonde head from the hallway before Nate shut the door in his drunken face!” Katie spoke up immediately, rolling her power wheelchair six inches forward to put herself right alongside me. “It *was* me in that bedroom! Our maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher used to be our closest friend here at Northwood before she fell in with Tyler’s crowd—Nate and I literally asked our dad to let her stay over on New Year’s Eve while he was up in Newport, Rhode Island visiting our sick Grandma Ruth, our Aunt Liz, and our cousin Chelsea because we were trying to keep Brittany away from the wrong crowd! Instead, she invited Tyler and strangers with gas-station alcohol behind our backs! If our dad had been

anywhere in Hampton Roads, we would have quietly called him to come to the house immediately—instead, Nate and I grabbed an unopened box of dry cereal out of the pantry and locked ourselves in my bedroom all night just to stay safe until we called our dad and our Aunt Karen and Uncle Steve in the morning! Even Brittany's own parents were heartbroken and deeply disappointed in her when they came over New Year's morning to scrub our living room and apologize to us, and our dad banned Brittany from setting foot in our house! Tyler was furious that Nate wouldn't drink with him or join the rave—he's lying to get back at us!"

I reached into my jacket pocket with a shaking hand, desperate to make Heather hear the truth.

"Heather, please, listen to me—Katie's telling the absolute truth!" I pleaded, my chest aching as if someone had dropped a cinderblock onto my sternum. "We ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box and drank two cans of ginger ale while watching the ball drop on a thirteen-inch TV! I literally promised Katie at midnight that I'm never even having a twenty-first birthday drink because watching Tyler and those kids act like drunken idiots disgusted me so much! You know me, Heather—how could you ever believe I would get drunk or cheat on you?"

Slowly, painfully, I realized from the cold, shuttered look on Heather's face that the damage was already done.

Sitting in front of twenty kids in homeroom while Tyler laughed in her face and told everyone her boyfriend was locked in a bedroom all night with another girl had humiliated her to the core—and once that bitter poison had taken root in her chest, no amount of truth about a cardboard box of dry cereal was going to undo it.

"Save it for somebody gullible enough to buy it, Nathaniel," Heather said coldly, stepping back from our two wheelchairs as the five-minute warning bell rang overhead. "I stuck up for you in front of everybody because I thought you were different from every other guy at this school, and you made me look like a complete fool. Don't call my house, don't wait for me at the bus loop, and don't ever talk to me again. We're done."

Before I could get another word out of my throat, Heather spun on her heel, walked briskly down the hallway past Tyler—who flashed me one last triumphant, nasty grin before disappearing into his classroom—and vanished around the corner toward the science wing.

Monday, January 6, 2003, 3:45 PM — Roles Reversed Under the Blue Butterfly

All through first period, lunch, and afternoon classes, I felt like I was moving underwater.

What hurt more than anything wasn't just that my very first relationship had ended in less than sixty seconds on a Monday morning—it was the crushing, helpless injustice of being condemned for the exact opposite of who I was. I had followed every rule my father had laid down; I had protected my twin sister from a living room full of reckless drunks; I had sworn off alcohol for the rest of my life; and yet because one angry liar wanted revenge for having a bedroom door closed in his face, the girl I had been head over heels in love with for a year and a half now hated my guts without ever knowing I was innocent.

By the time the CVTA Route 15 Beacon V bus lowered us down the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell lift onto the sidewalk along Military Highway at three-thirty that afternoon and we rolled up the aluminum ramp into our house, the knot in my throat was so tight I could barely breathe.

Without saying a word, Katie steered her power chair ahead of me down the short hallway into her bedroom—the exact same room where we had hidden six nights earlier—and patted the edge of her mattress beneath the framed blue butterfly print on the wall.

Just like we had done on that afternoon in seventh grade when Chad had dumped Katie in the cafeteria of Morrison Middle School—except with our roles completely reversed—we locked our wheelchair brakes side by side and transferred onto the edge of her bed.

As soon as I sat down, I buried my face in my hands, my shoulders shaking as the bitter sting of Heather's final words replayed in my ears.

Beside me, Katie didn't lecture me or tell me to tough it out. Instead, she wrapped both of her arms tightly around my shoulders, pulled my head down against her shoulder, and rested her cheek against my blonde hair while her hand rubbed slow, steady circles across my back.

"It isn't fair, Katie," I choked out against the sleeve of her sweater, my voice breaking in the quiet bedroom. "I didn't even know what she was talking about when I rolled up to her locker. We were sitting on this exact bed eating dry cereal out of a box to stay away from Tyler's booze, and she thinks I betrayed her."

"I know, Nate. I was right there with you every single second," Katie whispered fiercely, holding me with every ounce of strength in her seventeen-year-old arms. "Tyler is a vindictive jerk who couldn't stand that you wouldn't act like an idiot with him, and if Heather threw away everything she knew about your character over one drunk liar's story without even listening to the two of us, then she didn't deserve my brother's heart in the first place."

I lifted my head, wiping my eyes with the back of my wrist as I looked at my twin sister.

In seventh grade, when Chad had walked out on Katie and left her crying in the middle school hallway, I had held her right under that same framed blue butterfly print and promised her that I would never leave her behind. Now, five years later at seventeen—with both of our power wheelchairs parked side by side at the foot of the bed—Katie reached out, laced the fingers of her left hand tightly through my right hand, and gave me the exact same unbreakable anchor.

"Remember what you told me in seventh grade when Chad broke my heart, Nate?" Katie said softly, her blue eyes locked onto mine. "Boyfriends and girlfriends can walk away over a rumor in a sixty-second hallway conversation. Twin Sisters never walk away. You and I know the truth about who you are, and we've got each other for life."

Taking a long, steadying breath, I squeezed Katie's hand back and leaned my head against her shoulder until the shaking in my chest finally subsided—knowing beyond a shadow of a doubt that as we headed toward high school graduation and our adult lives together, the only person in the world I would ever completely trust was sitting right beside me.

Greenway Court, Apartment A6 & The Square Closet Sanctuary

Part 1: Apartment A6 on Greenway Court, Dad's Microwave Cart, & Across-the-Hall Neighbors

Date: 2003-07-16 at 07:40 America/New_York

Wednesday, July 16, 2003, 7:40 AM — Dad's Rolling Cart & Our Own Set of Keys in Apartment A6

"Careful with the power cord on the toaster, Nate—tuck it through the back wire loop so it can't snag on your armrest when you turn around by the stove," our father said cheerfully at twenty minutes to eight on Wednesday morning, tightening the last chrome corner bolt on the two-shelf rolling utility cart he had just assembled beside our tiny kitchenette counter.

Sitting side by side in our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs inside Apartment A6, Katie and I watched with huge grins as Dad lifted our new countertop microwave onto the top shelf of the cart, set our two-slice chrome toaster right next to it, and plugged both cords into the wall outlet above the speckled laminate counter.

"Look at the clearance on that," Katie said happily, rolling her wheelchair forward to test the reach. Without leaning an inch off her seat cushion, she popped open the microwave door with her left hand and tapped the toaster lever with her right. "Now we still have the whole counter square above the dorm fridge free for making sandwiches!"

"That's the whole idea," Dad smiled, wiping his forehead with the back of his sleeve as the through-wall box air conditioner mounted into the red brick directly below our wide, three-pane white-framed rear window hummed steadily in the July heat. "When a studio kitchen only gives you a four-burner stove, a single sink, and an under-the-counter dorm refrigerator, you two need every square inch of prep space at seated height."

We had turned eighteen on April eighth and rolled across the graduation stage of Northwood High School a month ago in June. Because our estranged mother Brenda had spent the spring calling our dad's house in Virginia Beach and threatening to track us down the second we turned eighteen and were no longer covered by the family-court custody order, Dad had quietly gone apartment hunting across the city line in the tree-lined West Ghent neighborhood of Norfolk.

At the beginning of July, Dad had introduced us to Dave and Deb—the husband-and-wife landlords who owned this quiet, two-story flat-roofed red-brick building on Greenway Court, where Apartments A1 through A10 sat downstairs on the first floor

and Apartments B1 through B10 sat upstairs on the second floor. Even better, Dad had signed the lease and paid the rent for Apartment A6 himself so that Katie and I could finally have a safe, independent home to call our own as eighteen-year-old college freshmen.

Every detail of the building and our studio fit our daily lives like a glove. Out front, beneath the black lamppost on the grass walkway, the building's recessed glass-and-aluminum main entrance door stayed locked twenty-four hours a day and required our brass apartment key to open—meaning nobody from the street could wander into the interior hallway uninvited. Just inside the front lobby past the row of locking metal mailboxes, Dave had bolted down a short, nonslip aluminum modular ramp over the three shallow rubber-treaded lobby steps so Katie and I could roll our power wheelchairs straight up into the first-floor hallway without a bump.

Down at the very back of the first-floor hallway—directly opposite Apartment A5—our wooden door opened into Apartment A6. All twenty apartments in the building shared the exact same enlarged bedroom-style rectangular studio layout, with units on opposite sides of the hallway like Apartment A5 and Apartment A6 built as exact mirror images of each other, giving us plenty of open floor space for two wheelchairs to pivot side by side. Against the side wall stood the full-sized bed we shared and our long workstation desk holding our shared desktop computer tower and seventeen-inch CRT monitor. Along the front corner sat our small kitchenette with its stove, sink, under-the-counter dorm fridge, and Dad's brand-new microwave-and-toaster cart. Tucked off to the side were two doors: one leading into our square walk-in closet with its soft carpeted floor, and the other opening into an accessible bathroom equipped with a roll-under sink, a toilet, and a standing shower where Dad had placed a sturdy padded transfer bench and a handheld shower sprayer within easy reach.

"Alright, you two, I've got to get across the river to work before traffic backs up on Interstate 264," Dad said, picking up his tool bag and kissing the top of Katie's head before squeezing my shoulder. "Remember, keep the front lobby door latched behind you whenever you go out to catch the Route 2 bus on Hampton Boulevard, and call me tonight after you test out the microwave."

"Thank you for the cart, Dad—and for giving us our own place," I said, rolling beside Katie to see him to the door.

"You two earned it," Dad said warmly. "Have a great morning."

Wednesday, July 16, 2003, 7:48 AM — Familiar Faces Across the Hall in Apartment A5

"Come on, Nate—let's roll out with Dad as far as the front sidewalk while the morning air is still cool," Katie suggested, slipping her brass Greenway Court key lanyard around her wrist. "I want to see how the cell signal is out by the grassy field across the street before we call CCHR about our fall books."

"Good call," I agreed, glancing at the single bar of reception on my flip phone—the thick red-brick walls of the Greenway Court building blocked half the cellular towers in West Ghent whenever we were inside Apartment A6.

I pulled our wooden apartment door open, rolled my SwiftChair out into the quiet first-floor hallway right behind Dad and Katie, and turned to pull our deadbolt shut.

At that exact second, the heavy deadbolt of Apartment A5—directly across the narrow back hallway from our door—let out a loud metallic thunk.

The door to Apartment A5 swung open, and out stepped an eighteen-year-old guy with side-parted golden-blond hair, glasses, and a stiff, slightly uneven gait in his legs, flanked closely by an eighteen-year-old girl with a shoulder-length blonde bob, a protective posture, and her hand steadying his elbow.

For two full seconds, all four of us froze in the back hallway between Apartment A5 and Apartment A6.

I stared at the guy's wire-rimmed glasses and the unmistakable way he stood shoulder-to-shoulder with the girl beside him. He stared down at our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs, then up at Katie's and my matching platinum-blonde hair.

"Wait a second," I blinked, my jaw dropping as nine years of neighborhood and school memories clicked into place at once. "Michael? Michael Ragsdale?!"

Behind his wire-rimmed glasses, Michael's eyes went wide with genuine shock, and the tight, guarded tension in his shoulders vanished on the spot.

"Nathaniel? Katie?!" Michael said, recognizing us immediately from three doors down on Delaney Street and our childhood two-week summer camp at Virginia Dominion University—as well as the hallways of Northwood High School, where all of us had just graduated a month earlier. "You two live in A6?!"

"We just moved in at the start of the month!" Katie beamed, lifting a hand in a friendly wave from her armrest—since neither she nor I ever liked being touched by anyone outside the two of us and our dad—as she smiled at Michael and at Ashley Raybourn, whom we recognized from our graduating class at Northwood High. "Our dad rented A6 for the two of us so we'd have our own place near the Route 2 bus line! Don't tell me you two just moved into A5?!"

"We literally got the keys from Deb last night," Ashley laughed, a huge, relieved smile breaking across her face as she looked from Katie and me to our dad. "We were just heading outside across the street to the grassy field so we could get three bars of cell service to call Michael's mom before the moving truck gets here at nine."

"That's the exact reason we were rolling outside right now!" I grinned, holding up my flip phone with its lone, stubborn bar of signal. "The brick walls in the back of the building eat every cell signal alive!"

Dad chuckled warmly, shaking Michael's and Ashley's hands in the hallway before we all headed down the corridor together, rolled smoothly down Dave's nonslip aluminum ramp over the three rubber-coated lobby steps, and pushed out through the locked glass-and-aluminum front entrance door into the sunny July morning.

While Dad waved goodbye from his pickup truck in the decal-controlled parking lot, Katie and I rolled across the quiet street with Michael and Ashley to the open grassy field where neighbors were walking their dogs among the slatted wooden benches. Parking our two power wheelchairs right flush against the ends of the wooden bench

where Michael and Ashley sat pressed side by side, we spent the next twenty minutes catching up like old teammates—talking about how Michael's sisters Jessica and Rachel were out in Washington State, how Katie and I were starting our freshman classes together at the Community College of Hampton Roads on the bus, and how relieved both pairs of us were to have a locked front building door and a quiet rectangular studio where nobody could bother us.

When we finally waved to Michael and Ashley as they headed off to meet Michael's mom and the moving truck, Katie and I rolled back across Greenway Court, unlocked the glass front door with our brass key, and wheeled back into the cool, air-conditioned sanctuary of Apartment A6.

"Can you believe that, Nate?" Katie smiled as the deadbolt clicked shut behind us and the aroma of fresh toast drifted from our new rolling cart in the kitchenette. "Out of every apartment building in the entire city of Norfolk, our old neighbor from Delaney Street and VDU summer camp is right across the hall from us in A5."

"Best across-the-hall neighbors we could ever ask for," I agreed, parking my wheelchair beside hers at our shared computer workstation desk.

Part 2: Brenda in the Back Alley & Discovering the Square Closet Sanctuary

Date: 2003-08-09 at 20:45 America/New_York

Saturday, August 9, 2003, 8:45 PM — Footsteps Behind the Exterior Iron Stairs & Hiding in the Square Closet

"Wait—turn the speakers down, Nate," Katie whispered sharply at a quarter to nine on Saturday evening, her hand dropping onto my wrist over the computer mouse. "Listen."

I clicked the mute icon on our seventeen-inch CRT monitor at the shared workstation desk, leaving only the low, steady hum of the through-wall box air conditioner mounted into the brick below our wide three-pane rear window.

Outside in the narrow first-floor back alley—right behind the black iron exterior fire-escape staircase that climbed the rear brick wall of our Greenway Court building beside the bushes and trash bins—an angry, slurred woman's voice echoed off the brick.

"I know their father rented them an apartment in this building!" our estranged mother Brenda's voice rasped in the humid August dusk, followed by the crunch of her shoes on the gravel behind the iron stairs. "Stupid locked front door won't even let a mother into the lobby to see her own eighteen-year-old kids! Katie! Nathaniel! Which window is yours?!"

My blood turned to ice water in my veins. Beside me at the computer desk, Katie's fingers clamped around my forearm so tightly I could feel her pulse racing against my skin.

Even though we had kept the white horizontal mini-blinds tilted shut over the wide three-pane window above our through-wall air conditioner, Apartment A6 sat on the first floor at the very back of the building. If Brenda stepped two paces past the

black iron exterior stairs and pressed her face against the glass beside the bushes, even the faintest glow from our desk lamp or our computer monitor would tell her immediately that Apartment A6 was ours—and she would bang on our back window and scream in the alley all night long.

“Kill the lamp and the monitor,” Katie breathed silently in my ear, her voice barely above a whisper. “If the room is pitch dark and dead silent when she looks through the blinds, she’ll think the apartment is empty.”

In less than three seconds, I reached behind the tower to flip the master rocker switch on our surge protector—plunging the CRT monitor and the desk lamp into instant darkness—while Katie clicked off the small stove hood light over the kitchenette.

Outside in the back alley, Brenda’s footsteps crunched closer toward the iron stairs, her knuckles rapping sharply against one of the rear brick window frames down the wall.

“The square closet,” Katie whispered, pointing through the shadows toward our open closet door. “Grab the sleeping bag and the pillows off the bed—if we’re inside the closet with the door closed, she won’t see a single shadow or hear our chairs even if she shines a flashlight through the window slats.”

Moving in silent, practiced twin synchronization, I pulled our soft navy-blue sleeping bag and two pillows off the full-sized bed while Katie guided us across the dark studio carpet to the doorway of our square walk-in closet. Quickly spreading the sleeping bag and pillows flat across the square carpeted floor inside the closet, Katie and I parked our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs side by side just outside the closet frame, switched both joystick controllers completely off so their green battery-level LEDs wouldn’t glow in the dark, and transferred smoothly down onto the closet floor.

Reaching up from inside the shared sleeping bag, I pulled the solid wooden closet door shut until the latch clicked softly into place.

Inside the square closet, the darkness was total and absolute.

Katie immediately turned on her side inside the sleeping bag, wrapped both arms tightly around my shoulders, and pulled my head against her chest while I wrapped my arms around her waist—holding each other with every ounce of steady, deep-pressure warmth we had so neither of us would tremble or make a sound.

Thirty seconds later, through the muffled layers of the closed closet door and the rear brick wall, we heard Brenda’s footsteps stop right behind the exterior iron staircase outside our back window, just above our humming through-wall air conditioner.

We heard her fingernails tap twice against the exterior glass of Apartment A6. We heard her mutter a bitter curse under her breath when she saw nothing but dark, empty blinds and heard nothing over the drone of the air-conditioning compressor. Two minutes later, her footsteps retreated down the back alley toward Raleigh Avenue, and the distant slam of a car door told us she had finally given up and driven away.

Even after the alley went quiet, neither Katie nor I moved to open the closet door.

Wrapped together inside our shared sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of that small, enclosed square closet, something remarkable happened to our nineteen-thousand-rpm fight-or-flight nervous systems. Out in the open studio room, the streetlamp shadows on the blinds and the knowledge that someone could walk down the back alley always left a tiny background thread of vigilance running in our autistic brains. Inside the enclosed four walls of the square closet, zipped up together in the velvet dark with Katie's arms locked securely around me, the outside world couldn't touch us at all.

"Are you okay, Nate?" Katie whispered against my hair in the pitch dark, her hand rubbing slow, soothing circles between my shoulder blades.

"More than okay," I whispered back, letting out a long, sleepy breath as every tense muscle in my back and legs finally melted into the carpet. "It's so quiet in here, Katie. I actually feel completely safe."

"Me too," Katie murmured, resting her chin against my forehead as a soft yawn escaped her lips. "We don't have to move back out to the bed tonight if you don't want to. Let's just stay right here in our little fortress."

Resting my head against my twin sister's shoulder inside our shared sleeping bag on the square closet floor, I closed my eyes—and for the first time since moving out on our own, both of us slept nine uninterrupted hours straight through the night without waking up once.

From that August night forward, that compact square closet literally became our bedroom. Yes, we still had our full-sized bed out in the main studio apartment, kept neatly made up under its quilt—but it rarely ever got used. For both of us on the autism spectrum, sleeping cuddled up together inside our single shared navy-blue sleeping bag in the snug, confined space of the closet made us feel completely secure in a way an open room never could—a habit that would stay with the two of us for the rest of our lives.

Part 3: Hurricane Isabel, Two Layers of Sandbags at Greenway Court, & Two Weeks at Dad's House on Arvin Road

Date: 2003-09-17 at 15:15 America/New_York

Wednesday, September 17, 2003, 3:15 PM — Unplugging Apartment A6, Seeing Michael Sad Across the Hall, & Two Layers of Sandbags at the Top of the Lobby Ramp

"Make sure both twenty-four-volt battery chargers are in the front zipper pocket of the duffel bag, Nate," our forty-five-year-old father said inside Apartment A6 at three-fifteen on Wednesday afternoon, September 17, 2003, lifting our desktop computer tower off the workstation desk and setting it high on the center of our full-sized bed mattress beside our seventeen-inch CRT monitor. "On the radio coming through the tunnel, Coastal Virginia Transit Authority just announced they're suspending all bus service across Norfolk and Virginia Beach tonight ahead of Hurricane Isabel, and the National Weather Service advisory says the storm surge up the Elizabeth River could hit eight feet above normal low tide tomorrow afternoon."

Sitting in her compact black SwiftChair power wheelchair beside the open door of our under-the-counter dorm refrigerator, eighteen-year-old Katie handed me the last carton of milk and the cheese drawer to pack into Dad's blue insulated cooler.

"We unplugged the microwave and the toaster on the rolling cart too, Dad," Katie said, wiping the inside of the dorm fridge dry with a dish towel before propping its door open an inch so it wouldn't mildew if the power went out. "And Nate already rolled up our navy-blue sleeping bag from the square closet floor so we can bring it to Arvin Road."

"Good thinking, sweetheart," Dad smiled, zipping the sleeping bag into a heavy plastic protective bag and resting his hand comfortably on the rear push-handle of Katie's wheelchair to help ease her chair back two feet around the cooler in the narrow kitchenette aisle. "Besides getting you two away from the Elizabeth River flood zone, our house on Arvin Road is already registered on Commonwealth Power's Medical Priority list for your electric wheelchairs, so if the storm knocks the power lines down, we'll be on the priority list to get our electricity turned back on."

Neither Katie nor I ever liked being touched by anyone we didn't know. With strangers, classmates, or neighbors, even an unexpected pat on the shoulder or someone reaching for our wheelchair push-handles made our skin crawl and set off every alarm bell in our autistic nervous systems. Between the two of us, of course, it was the exact opposite—Katie and I held each other's hands across our armrests whenever we rolled side by side and hugged each other tight inside our shared sleeping bag every night—and both of us were completely comfortable when our dad helped maneuver our wheelchairs over tight thresholds or into the floor tie-downs of his van.

When Dad pulled our solid wooden hallway door open so Katie and I could roll our two SwiftChairs out into the back of the first-floor corridor with our backpacks strapped behind our seats, the heavy brass deadbolt of Apartment A5—directly across the narrow hall from our door—clicked shut at the exact same moment.

Standing in front of Apartment A5 with a canvas backpack slung over his shoulders and his brass key ring in his hand was eighteen-year-old Michael Ragsdale.

Both Katie and I noticed the change in him immediately.

Back in mid-July and August, whenever we had seen Michael in the hallway or out by the grassy field across Greenway Court, Ashley Raybourn had been right beside him—her shoulder pressed against his, steadying his uneven Cerebral Palsy gait and grounding him the exact same way Katie and I grounded each other. At the end of August, however, Ashley had packed her bags and left Norfolk to start her freshman year away at college. Michael's mom had already picked up his one-eyed black Lab rescue Archie earlier that morning to keep the dog safe during the hurricane, leaving Michael all by himself in the empty mirror-image studio across the hall.

Even behind his glasses, you could see how sad and hollowed-out Michael looked without Ashley there.

Katie reached her right hand across the gap between our wheelchairs and laced her fingers tightly through my left hand. Both my sister and I felt a quiet, genuine ache in our chests for our old Delaney Street and summer-camp neighbor—yet both of us also knew there was nothing we could do to help him. Neither Katie nor I could go

over and give someone a hug without our own sensory wiring locking up, and even if we could have, we knew that nobody in the hallway could replace the safe person he was missing.

“Hey, Nathaniel. Hey, Katie, Mr. Prairie,” Michael said quietly, shifting the strap of his backpack. “Are you guys heading out to your dad’s house in Virginia Beach before the wind picks up?”

“Just locked up A6 and lifted the computer onto the bed,” I told him warmly from my chair while Katie gave him a gentle, sympathetic wave with her free hand from her armrest. “Dad’s taking us over to Arvin Road for the storm. Are you getting out of West Ghent before CVTA shuts the buses down tonight?”

“Yeah,” Michael nodded, glancing once down the hallway toward the front door. “I’m walking up to Hampton Boulevard right now to catch the Route 2 bus downtown, transferring to the Route 6, and then taking the Route 12 out to Kemps River Drive. My cousin Maria is meeting me there—she’s going to take me to Crown Burger to grab food before everything closes, and then I’m staying at her house in the downstairs bedroom until the storm passes.”

Just then, heavy footsteps clomped down the interior stairs from the second floor, and the twenty-something guy who lived in Apartment B5—directly upstairs from Michael’s apartment—squeezed past us carrying two plastic bags of ice and a cardboard case of beer back up toward the second-floor landing.

“You first-floor folks are evacuating already?” the neighbor from B5 called down cheerfully over the stair railing. “A bunch of us up on the second floor are throwing a hurricane party tonight! We’ve got candles, flashlights, and three coolers on the landing!”

Dad shook his head with a polite, dry smile as the B5 door slammed upstairs. “A hurricane party two blocks from the Elizabeth River with an eight-foot storm surge in the forecast. Come on—let’s get down the ramp while the streets are still dry.”

When the four of us reached the end of the first-floor hallway at the top of the lobby ramp, we saw why our landlords, Dave and Deb, had parked their pickup truck right up against the front curb walk.

Working side by side in canvas work gloves inside the front entrance door, Dave and Deb were stacking two full layers of heavy burlap sandbags right across the top of the lobby ramp and the three shallow rubber-coated steps—forming a solid, double-tiered barrier separating the lower entrance lobby and the wall of metal mailboxes from the elevated first-floor apartment corridor.

“Wait right there a second, David—let me leave the center gap at the top of the ramp open until Katie and Nathaniel roll down!” Dave called out, wiping the sweat from his forehead as he and Deb steadied the burlap sacks and Dad placed his hands smoothly on the rear push-handles of my chair and then Katie’s to help guide our front caster wheels past the two layers of sandbags, down the modular lobby ramp past the mailboxes, and out through the front glass door. “The city says the river tide tomorrow afternoon is going to push higher than the 1933 hurricane. Even if floodwater pushes through the front glass door into the lower lobby and reaches the mailboxes, two layers of sandbags right here at the top of the lobby ramp will keep it out of the first-floor hallway and out of A5 and A6!”

“Thank you for sandbagging the top of the ramp, Dave, Deb,” Katie said earnestly from her wheelchair as we rolled out onto the dry concrete front walkway toward Dad’s silver wheelchair-accessible minivan.

Out on the sidewalk in front of the circular red-brick planter, Katie and I lifted our hands to wave goodbye to Michael as he turned up Greenway Court toward Hampton Boulevard beneath the overcast gray clouds and rising wind to catch his first bus.

“Stay safe at your cousin’s house, Michael!” Katie called out.

“You two stay safe at your dad’s place too!” Michael called back, giving us a small wave before walking up the block.

Once Dad deployed the side fold-out aluminum ramp of his minivan, helped guide both of our SwiftChairs into the middle bay, and clicked all eight floor tie-down straps onto our frames, Katie reached across the narrow aisle between our chairs and held my hand the whole drive across the Elizabeth River to Dad’s house on Arvin Road.

Thursday, September 18 – Friday, September 19, 2003 — Losing Power for Two Days, Dead Wheelchair Batteries, Feeling Undignified Crawling on the Floor, & Dad Crawling With Us at Eye Level

By two o’clock on Thursday afternoon, September 18, 2003, the overnight rainbands had given way to the full eyewall gusts of Hurricane Isabel—battering all of Hampton Roads with howling seventy-mile-per-hour winds and horizontal sheets of torrential rain.

At ten minutes past two, a pole transformer two streets over toward Military Highway exploded with a low green flash against the dark afternoon clouds, and the electricity inside Dad’s single-story brick ranch on Arvin Road went dead.

Two years earlier, right after our legs gave out in September 2001 and Dr. Carter prescribed our full-time electric wheelchairs, Dad had filed a physician-signed Serious Medical Condition certification with Commonwealth Power so that our house on Arvin Road carried an official Medical Priority flag on our residential meter. During ordinary summer thunderstorms or winter ice squalls, that priority flag meant our street always came back online within three or four hours.

Hurricane Isabel, however, was no ordinary storm.

As we listened to the emergency broadcasts on Dad’s battery-powered weather radio Thursday evening while eating grilled cheeseburgers and hot dogs that Dad cooked on the charcoal grill under the sheltered back patio overhang before the food in the dark freezer could thaw, the announcers reported that nearly two million customers across Virginia had lost electricity at once. Hundreds of century-old oaks and tall Virginia pines had snapped across the primary high-voltage transmission lines and substations along Military Highway and Indian River Road. Even with a Medical Priority flag on our meter on Arvin Road, line crews couldn’t energize our neighborhood tap line until tree crews sawed through the fallen trunks and rebuilt the main Kempsville feeder circuit first.

That Thursday night, when the peak of the hurricane roared across Virginia Beach—rattling the windowpanes and sending pine limbs thudding across the roof—Katie and I rolled down the hallway to our old bedroom, spread our shared navy-blue sleeping bag across the floor of the bedroom closet just like we did in our square closet at Apartment A6, transferred down into the sleeping bag together, and held each other tight with the closet door nearly shut until the howling wind finally began to subside toward dawn.

Throughout Thursday night and Friday morning, Katie and I tried everything we knew to stretch the charge on our twenty-four-volt SwiftChair batteries—switching our joystick controllers completely off whenever we stopped moving in the living room or kitchen. Yet twenty-four-volt gel-cell batteries weren't built to run for two days without a wall outlet.

At two-thirty on Friday afternoon, as I was turning my wheelchair around in the hallway outside the bathroom, the battery gauge on my right armrest dropped to a single flashing red LED and let out three sharp warning beeps. Half a second later, the electromagnetic motor brakes clicked shut, and my chair died completely on the hallway carpet.

Twenty minutes later, right beside the living-room sofa, Katie's joystick controller let out the exact same three beeps and went dark.

Dad disengaged the manual freewheel levers on the rear motors so our two dead powerchairs could be pushed out of the center of the hallway, but an unpowered electric wheelchair weighs nearly two hundred pounds and has small, thick motor-drive tires with no manual handrims. Neither Katie nor I could push our own dead chairs an inch, and even Dad could barely wrestle one heavy dead frame across the carpet at a time.

To get to the bathroom, the kitchen, or the living room, Katie and I had no choice: we had to slide down out of our seats onto the floor and crawl everywhere on our hands and knees.

I had never felt anything so undignified in my eighteen years of life.

Just three months ago, Katie and I had rolled across the stage in our caps and gowns to receive our Advanced Studies Diplomas from Northwood High School. We were eighteen-year-old college freshmen at the Community College of Hampton Roads with our own apartment lease in Norfolk—and now, simply because the power company hadn't gotten the street lines back up yet, the two of us were reduced to dragging ourselves down the hallway on our hands and knees like toddlers, our knees rubbing against the carpet and our palms pressing against the cool bathroom linoleum.

When Katie crawled back out of the hallway bathroom on Friday afternoon and sat back against the hallway wall beside me, her cheeks were burning bright red and her blue eyes were shining with hot, silent tears of sheer humiliation.

"I hate this, Nate," Katie whispered, pulling her knees up and hiding her face against my shoulder as I wrapped my arm around her on the hallway carpet. "We're eighteen years old. It feels so undignified having to crawl around on the floor like babies just to use the bathroom."

Down at the end of the hall, Dad stood in the kitchen doorway holding a battery lantern. He looked at the two dead black powerchairs parked uselessly against the wall, and then he looked down at his eighteen-year-old son and daughter sitting huddled together on the floor.

Dad didn't say a word about looking on the bright side, and he didn't stay standing up on his two feet looking down at us.

Instead, Dad set the lantern down on the carpet, walked over to the sofa, and pulled all three thick sofa cushions, a pile of pillows, and two folded blankets down onto the living-room rug. He carried the blue insulated cooler of ice and ginger ale off the kitchen counter and set it right on the floor beside the cushions. Then he walked to the hall closet, pulled out a stack of our favorite board games and card games—*Solo*, *WordSmith*, *Real Estate Baron*, *Stage 10*, and *Suspect*—along with two of his yellow legal pads and a handful of mechanical pencils, and set them in the center of the floor cushions.

And then our forty-five-year-old father dropped right down onto his own hands and knees on the hallway carpet and crawled over to Katie and me so that he was completely at eye level with the two of us.

Katie lifted her head from my shoulder, blinking in surprise through her wet eyelashes as Dad crawled right alongside us into the living room on his hands and knees.

"If my two favorite people in the world are traveling on hands and knees until Commonwealth Power fixes the feeder line," Dad said gently, looking straight into Katie's eyes and mine from the exact same height on the carpet, "then I'm traveling on hands and knees right here with you. Nobody in this house is looking down on anybody."

A shaky laugh broke through Katie's tears as she reached out to squeeze my hand, and the crushing knot of embarrassment in my chest loosened all at once.

For the rest of Friday afternoon, Friday night, and Saturday morning, Dad stayed down on the floor at eye level with us—crawling to the kitchen on his hands and knees whenever we crawled, eating peanut-butter sandwiches and potato chips together on the sofa cushions, sketching HTML table layouts on his yellow legal pads, and playing marathon lantern-lit rounds of *Solo*, *WordSmith*, and *Real Estate Baron* where Katie mercilessly bankrupted both Dad and me before bedtime.

And on Friday night before Katie and I crawled into the bedroom closet to sleep in our shared sleeping bag, Dad clicked his mechanical pencil twice and wrote a bold heading across the top of his yellow legal pad by the glow of the lantern.

"First thing Monday morning," Dad promised us from the carpet, "we are going straight to Dr. Carter's office to get an order written for two lightweight, collapsible manual wheelchairs as backups."

Katie glanced from the legal pad to her wrists, flexing her fingers thoughtfully against the sofa cushion. "Dad, even if we had plain manual wheelchairs right now, neither Nate nor I has the wrist or upper-arm strength to push manual hand-rims very far on our own."

“That’s the exact part I was thinking through while we were playing *WordSmith*,” I added, tapping the edge of Dad’s legal pad. “Dr. Carter’s seating clinic carries those clamp-on right-armrest joystick power-drive kits made for folding manual cross-brace frames—the ones with a compact battery pack clipped underneath the seat.”

Dad’s eyes lit up behind his glasses as he wrote every word down on the pad. “Wait—walk me through how those work if the power goes out.”

“In normal use, we still drive ourselves everywhere with a right-hand joystick without straining our wrists or shoulders, and we’ve got a second set of charged backup batteries ready to go if a SwiftChair ever runs down,” I explained. “If you ever need to put them into the trunk of a regular car, you just unclip the battery box underneath and the manual frame folds flat. And if another hurricane knocks out the grid for days and even the backup battery packs run dry, you flick the hub clutches to manual so the big spoked wheels spin freely—meaning you can push a lightweight manual chair effortlessly with the rear push-handles instead of two-hundred-pound dead powerchairs trapping us on the floor.”

Dad underlined *COLLAPSIBLE MANUAL CHAIRS + RIGHT-ARMREST JOYSTICK ATTACHMENTS* twice across the top of the yellow sheet. “Done. First thing Monday morning, we’re getting Dr. Carter to write the prescription for the exact pair.”

Saturday, September 20 – Thursday, October 2, 2003 — Stranded Without Wheels on Saturday, Recharging Overnight, Assessing Greenway Court on Sunday, Ordering Our Joystick-Outfitted Manual Chairs, & Setting Up a Medical Priority Flag for Apartment A6

If any of us needed one more reminder of why we couldn’t live without backup manual wheelchairs fitted with joystick attachments, we got it at one-thirty on Saturday afternoon, September 20.

Outside, city chainsaw crews had finally cleared enough fallen oak trees off Military Highway, Indian River Road, and the Norfolk approaches to reopen the main roads—and Dad’s cell phone chimed on the coffee table with a message from Dave and Deb letting tenants know the Elizabeth River floodwaters around Greenway Court had receded enough to come check on our apartments.

Katie and I immediately sat up on the living-room sofa cushions, eager to ride across the river and see whether our studio, our clothes, and our desktop computer in Apartment A6 had survived the eight-foot storm surge.

Then all three of us looked down the dim hallway at our two dead, two-hundred-pound SwiftChairs parked like lead anchors against the drywall—and realized we couldn’t go anywhere.

Electricity still hadn’t come back on Arvin Road. Without power to charge our SwiftChairs, Dad couldn’t even wrestle those dead motorized frames down the front step ramp and up the minivan ramp, let alone push two unpowered two-hundred-pound chairs across a mud-slick Norfolk parking lot. And without folding manual chairs in the house, Katie and I had zero wheels to get from the living room to the minivan or from the Greenway Court curb into our building.

“I could drive over to Norfolk by myself for an hour just to peek inside A6,” Dad offered hesitantly from the carpet, already frowning at his own suggestion as he looked at the two of us stranded on the floor cushions in a dark, unpowered house.

“No, stay here with us, Dad,” Katie said at once, reaching for my hand while Dad nodded in immediate agreement. Neither of us wanted Dad navigating tangled power lines across the river alone while we were stuck helplessly on the living-room rug without working chairs, and Dad had zero desire to leave his eighteen-year-old son and daughter stranded on the floor either. If we had owned lightweight folding manual chairs right then, Dad could have unfolded them in thirty seconds, rolled both of us straight out to the van, and wheeled us right into Greenway Court even with dead batteries. Instead, all three of us had to sit tight on the living-room cushions through Saturday afternoon and wait on the grid.

At six-fifteen that Saturday evening, the amber strobe lights of a Commonwealth Power bucket truck finally flashed through the front bay window on Arvin Road.

Now that tree and transmission crews had rebuilt the main Kempsville feeder line out on Indian River Road, the utility dispatcher’s computer had flagged Dad’s Medical Priority account on Arvin Road and routed a two-man line crew straight down our street to clear a snapped pine limb and slam a new fuse into our pole transformer. Five minutes later, the ceiling lights, the kitchen refrigerator, and the central air conditioning hummed back to life—and Dad went straight to the living-room outlets to plug in both of our twenty-four-volt SwiftChair battery chargers for the night.

Rolling out of our bedroom closet into the hallway in our fully charged SwiftChairs on Sunday morning, September 21, felt like getting our legs and our dignity back all at once.

Right after Dad made us a hot breakfast of scrambled eggs and toast, he deployed the side fold-out ramp of the minivan in the driveway, guided both of our freshly charged SwiftChairs into the middle bay, clicked all eight tie-down straps onto our frames, and drove Katie and me across the Elizabeth River into West Ghent so the three of us could inspect Greenway Court together.

As we turned off Hampton Boulevard, the streets around our neighborhood were littered with snapped tree limbs, coiled utility cables, and drying river silt. Dad parked in the front lot, lowered the minivan ramp, and walked beside us up the concrete path to unlock the front glass entrance door while Katie and I rolled our SwiftChairs right up to the doorway and peered down into the lower lobby.

We saw immediately how close our building had come to disaster—and what had saved it.

During Thursday afternoon’s peak storm surge, a huge volume of Elizabeth River water had pushed through the front glass entrance door into the lower lobby, leaving a dried brown silt waterline across the brick walls and getting right into the lower lobby mailboxes.

Yet right at the top of the lobby ramp and the three shallow rubber-coated steps above the mailboxes, the two layers of heavy burlap sandbags that Dave and Deb had stacked inside the doorway had held like a dam—stopping the floodwater cold and preventing a single drop of water from entering the first-floor hallway or any of the apartments. Once Dad shifted two sandbags aside so Katie and I could roll up

Dave's nonslip lobby ramp and unlock the wooden door of Apartment A6, we rolled inside and saw that our carpet, our kitchenette cart, our square closet, and our computer up on the mattress were one hundred percent dry.

Out by the front walkway as we rolled back outside, our upstairs neighbor from Apartment B5—who had stayed behind with a few other tenants to throw that hurricane party on Thursday—leaned over the second-floor iron railing and called down to us.

"You guys are lucky you went to your dad's house!" the neighbor from B5 told us, shaking his head. "At high tide Thursday afternoon, the river came all the way up over Greenway Court and the parking lot! If you had stayed in the building, you would've been trapped on an island—and if Dave and Deb hadn't put those two layers of sandbags at the top of the lobby ramp, the whole first floor would've flooded!"

Because the electricity was still completely out on Greenway Court, Dad locked Apartment A6 back up, helped secure our SwiftChairs back inside the minivan, and drove us home to Arvin Road.

First thing Monday morning, September 22—with Dad's yellow legal pad tucked under his arm—the three of us rolled into Dr. Evelyn Carter's family medicine office in Virginia Beach. The moment Katie and I told Dr. Carter how our powerchair batteries had died on Friday afternoon and left us crawling on the carpet and unable even to ride over to check our apartment on Saturday until the street power came back on, Dr. Carter didn't hesitate for a second. Right there in the exam room, she wrote out the medical-necessity prescription and seating-clinic referral for two lightweight, collapsible cross-brace manual wheelchairs outfitted with right-armrest joystick power-drive attachments and removable under-seat battery boxes—giving us joystick driving that wouldn't strain our arms, folding frames that could fit in any car trunk, and manual freewheel push-handles so a dead battery would never trap us on a floor again.

We spent Tuesday and Wednesday at Dad's house on Arvin Road catching up on our CCHR computer science readings now that classes were preparing to resume, and on Wednesday afternoon, September 24—figuring six days had surely been long enough for Norfolk crews to re-energize West Ghent—we rode with Dad to the neighborhood supermarket on Indian River Road to go grocery shopping, picking out fresh milk, orange juice, eggs, bread, sliced honey ham, and cheddar cheese to restock our dorm fridge in Apartment A6.

From the grocery store parking lot, Dad drove us straight across the river to Greenway Court with our insulated bags of cold groceries in the back of the minivan.

When we turned down Redgate Avenue toward Greenway Court, our hopes soared: right across the way, the multi-story complex of Tidewater General Hospital—the region's only Level 1 Trauma Center—was lit up from top to bottom with full electrical power.

"Look, Nate—Tidewater General has all its lights on!" Katie smiled, squeezing my hand across our wheelchair armrests as Dad helped guide our two SwiftChairs up the front walkway and over the lobby ramp into our Greenway Court building. "Our power has got to be back on by now!"

Yet the moment we unlocked Apartment A6 and I reached up from my wheelchair to flip the wall switch, nothing happened.

Six full days after Hurricane Isabel had passed, the power failure on Greenway Court was still in progress.

Out in the front lobby, where Dave was wiping down the metal mailboxes, we found out why.

“We thought for sure the lights would be back on by today, Dave, especially with Tidewater General lit up right across the way,” Dad said, resting his hands on our rear push-handles.

“Tidewater General is the Level 1 Trauma Center, so it’s on a dedicated hospital priority feed,” Dave sighed, shaking his head in frustration. “Meanwhile, we’re still sitting here in the dark. I can’t confirm it officially with the engineers at Commonwealth Power, David, but the line crews out on Hampton Boulevard told us our building’s power grid is physically attached to the Midtown Tunnel circuit. When forty-four million gallons of Elizabeth River water flooded the Midtown Tunnel on Thursday, it shorted out the whole feeder—and they told us it’s going to take crews two full weeks to figure out how to cut the grid so that we’re separated from the Midtown Tunnel before our power comes back on.”

Standing in the dim first-floor hallway behind our wheelchairs, Dad looked from the dark doorway of Apartment A6 to Katie and me—realizing at once why Dad’s house on Arvin Road had gotten its electricity back in forty-eight hours while our Greenway Court building was still sitting unprioritized at the bottom of a tangled tunnel circuit.

“When we switched the Apartment A6 electric bill into your names in July,” Dad said, pulling his cell phone and his pocket notebook from his jacket, “the Medical Priority flag stayed attached only to my meter on Arvin Road. Commonwealth Power doesn’t have a Medical Priority flag on file for Apartment A6—so their outage system doesn’t even know there are two full-time electric wheelchair users living in this building.”

Right there that afternoon—before we loaded our bags of groceries back into the minivan and returned to Dad’s house on Arvin Road for another week—Dad called Dr. Carter’s office and Commonwealth Power’s Critical Care desk, helping Katie and me set up an official Medical Priority flag on our electric account for Apartment A6 on Greenway Court so that our Norfolk apartment would never be left behind in an extended power outage again.

And true to what the line crews had told Dave, our Greenway Court building stayed completely without electricity for two full weeks—until Commonwealth Power finally figured out how to cut and isolate our neighborhood grid from the flooded Midtown Tunnel on Thursday, October 2, 2003, allowing Katie and me to finally roll back into our dry, brightly lit studio sanctuary across the hall from Michael.

Wednesday, November 12, 2003, 5:30 PM — Our Backup Joystick-Outfitted Manual Chairs, Dad's Microwave Cart, & A Happy Year in Our Studio Sanctuary

By November and winter of our eighteenth year—with the hurricane debris cleared from West Ghent, our studio humming with warm electricity again, and our two brand-new backup collapsible manual wheelchairs fitted with right-armrest joystick attachments delivered through Dr. Carter's seating clinic and kept safely charged in reserve at Dad's house on Arvin Road—life inside Apartment A6 on Greenway Court settled into the happiest, most peaceful routine Katie and I had ever known.

Every morning, after waking up well-rested inside our shared sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of our square closet bedroom—while the full-sized bed out in the main studio stayed smooth and untouched—we used the padded transfer bench in our accessible shower, brushed our teeth side by side at the roll-under bathroom sink, and rolled out to our compact kitchenette. While I popped four slices of whole-wheat bread into the toaster on Dad's rolling utility cart and pulled the milk carton and butter out of the under-the-counter dorm fridge, Katie scrambled eggs on the four-burner stove, and we washed our plates and skillet in the sink the minute we finished eating.

Whenever we headed out our door and down Dave's nonslip aluminum ramp through the locked front lobby, we waved to Michael Ragsdale and his one-eyed black Lab Archie across the hall in Apartment A5 before rolling down Greenway Court and Redgate Avenue to Hampton Boulevard to catch the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 2 bus into Downtown Norfolk. Side by side in the front wheelchair bays of the bus, we rode ten minutes downtown to the Martin Building at the Community College of Hampton Roads Norfolk campus for our morning lectures, grabbed hot burgers and fries upstairs at the third-floor food court of The Admiral Center on Fridays, and rode the afternoon Route 2 bus right back home to West Ghent.

In the evenings, while the radiators and the through-wall fan kept our rectangular studio cozy and warm, Katie and I parked our SwiftChairs side by side at our long workstation desk in front of our shared desktop computer. Taking turns at the keyboard while the other sister or brother read aloud from our textbooks or debugged lines of HTML and Quantum Basic code on the seventeen-inch CRT monitor, we had everything we needed under one roof: four locked walls, a full kitchen cart, our own bus passes, and each other.

The Admiral Center Patio & Moving Together to Williamsburg

Part 1: Spilled Hot Chocolate on The Admiral Center Patio & Brandon Mercer Presents Himself as a Gentleman

Date: 2004-05-14 at 14:45 America/New_York

Friday, May 14, 2004, 2:45 PM — Spilled Hot Chocolate Under the Green Umbrellas & A Polite Visitor from Williamsburg

“Watch out—!” Katie gasped as a man in a pinstriped suit carrying three bulging department-store shopping bags cut straight across the brick pedestrian promenade of The Admiral Center without looking down, clipped the edge of our round wrought-iron patio table with his hip, and sent Katie’s steaming paper cup of hot chocolate tumbling sideways across the tabletop.

I yanked my left hand back off my armrest just in time to keep the hot brown wave from splashing onto my jeans while Katie hit her reverse joystick half an inch to save her royal-blue V-neck sweater. The man in the suit didn’t even break stride, muttering into the cell phone pressed against his ear as he vanished around the corner toward Monticello Avenue and left dark puddles of hot chocolate dripping through the black mesh tabletop onto the red bricks beside our front caster wheels.

“Unbelievable,” I muttered, reaching toward the side pocket of my backpack for a tissue. “He didn’t even look back.”

“Hold still a second so it doesn’t drip onto your footrests,” a calm, pleasant voice said right beside us.

Before I could even unzip my bag, a clean-cut young man who looked to be about twenty-two years old stepped over from the next patio table carrying a thick stack of brown paper café napkins. Wearing a neatly pressed light-blue button-down shirt with the sleeves rolled to his forearms, khaki trousers, and a dark leather wristwatch under short sandy-brown hair, he laid a ring of dry napkins around the puddle before a single drop could reach Katie’s shoes or the electronic joystick housing on her right armrest.

“Are you two okay? None of that got on you or your controls, did it?” he asked, looking straight at Katie’s face and mine rather than staring down at our matching black SwiftChair power wheelchairs.

“Not a drop, thank you,” Katie said, her surprised frown softening right away at how quickly and matter-of-factly he had helped. “You saved my shoes.”

“Let me grab a wet cloth from the counter and replace that hot chocolate for you,” he said with an easy, unhurried smile, scooping the soaked napkins into the patio trash receptacle. “No extra coffee syrup, right? I heard you order it inside behind me.”

“Just plain hot chocolate,” Katie smiled, blinking in pleasant surprise that a complete stranger had noticed.

Katie and I exchanged one of our quiet, wordless twin looks across our armrests while he stepped back inside the corner bakery café. We had turned nineteen five weeks earlier on April eighth, and forty minutes ago we had rolled side by side out of our final freshman spring-semester exam across the street at the Downtown Norfolk campus of the Community College of Hampton Roads. Nearly a full year in Apartment A6 over on Greenway Court had taught both of us how ninety percent of the neurotypical public acted around two nineteen-year-olds in identical compact

powerchairs: people either stepped wide around us on the sidewalk like our tires were contagious, patted our shoulders like we were ten years old, or spoke only to whichever clerk or able-bodied adult happened to be standing nearby.

Two minutes later, the young man walked back out onto the shaded brick patio carrying a damp bar towel in one hand and a cardboard tray holding a fresh steaming cup of hot chocolate, a chilled bottle of strawberry-kiwi flavored water, and a tall plastic cup of apple juice in the other. After wiping the wrought-iron tabletop completely clean and dry, he set the hot chocolate and the unopened flavored water in front of Katie and paused respectfully beside the empty patio chair across from us.

“I’m Brandon, by the way—Brandon Mercer,” he said, leaning forward just enough to be comfortably at our seated eye level as he extended his right hand across the table to me and then to Katie. “Do you two mind if I sit for a minute before I head back across the bridge-tunnel?”

“Please do,” Katie said warmly, shaking his hand while a faint touch of pink colored her cheeks. “I’m Katie Prairie, and this is my twin brother, Nathaniel—everybody calls him Nate.”

“Good to meet you both, Nate, Katie,” Brandon said, pulling the wrought-iron chair closer and taking a sip of his apple juice. “Are you two celebrating the end of finals over at CCHR?”

“Just turned in our last programming exam,” I said, immediately relaxing at how naturally he kept both of us in the conversation instead of talking past me to Katie or past Katie to me. “We’ve been taking all our freshman classes together downtown and riding the Route 2 bus over from our apartment in West Ghent.”

“Wait—you two share an apartment and take all your college classes together?” Brandon asked, his expression lighting up with warm admiration. “Honestly, that’s awesome. Most siblings our age barely call each other once a month once they finish high school. Seeing a brother and sister actually have each other’s backs every day tells you everything about what kind of people they are.”

Across the narrow gap between our wheelchairs, Katie reached her left hand over to brush my knuckles—our subtle, lifelong signal whenever someone passed the unspoken test that mattered more to us than anything else in the world.

Friday, May 14, 2004, 3:25 PM — Apple Juice, Peninsula Geography, & Exchanging Numbers Before Route 2

For the next forty-five minutes under the dark-green canvas patio umbrellas, talking with Brandon felt effortless. When I pulled a cold can of ginger ale out of my backpack to go with Katie’s hot chocolate, Brandon mentioned casually that he didn’t touch alcohol or coffee himself and stuck to apple juice, sports drinks, or hot chocolate—making Katie and me trade an instant, delighted twin grin, since alcohol had been a hard line for both of us ever since surviving our mother Brenda on Delaney Street.

He told us he was twenty-two, worked full-time in hospitality bookkeeping up in Williamsburg while taking evening business classes, and rented a quiet single-story house just north of the College of Charles and Anne within easy walking distance of

the brick Williamsburg Transportation Center on North Boundary Street. When Katie asked what the buses were like up there compared to CVTA down here in Norfolk and Virginia Beach, Brandon didn't roll his eyes the way car drivers usually did whenever we brought up transit routes; instead, he described the white-and-colonial-blue Colonial Triangle Transit Authority buses pulling right into the brick station bays thirty feet from the train depot doors.

At four-ten, Brandon glanced down at his leather wristwatch and stood up with a reluctant smile.

"I promised my boss I'd have the Friday afternoon ledgers locked in the safe before five-thirty, so I'd better beat the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel backup," Brandon said, pulling a small notepad and a black pen from his shirt pocket. He wrote his name and telephone number neatly across the top sheet, tore it off, and handed it directly to Katie while glancing warmly toward me as well. "Katie, meeting you and Nate today made my whole week. If neither of you minds me driving down I-64 next Saturday afternoon, I'd really love to take both of you to lunch right here in Ghent—completely at your pace."

Katie looked down at the slip of paper in her fingers, then looked over at me across our armrests with bright, hopeful blue eyes. Since seventh grade at Morrison Middle School, when a boy had cruelly dumped Katie the moment he realized she wasn't interested in ditching me at lunch, my sister hadn't trusted a single guy enough to consider going on a date.

"What do you think, Nate?" Katie asked quietly, asking me right out in the open in front of him without a shred of hesitation.

I watched Brandon's face closely to see if having a nineteen-year-old girl check with her twin brother first annoyed him even a fraction of an inch.

Brandon didn't flinch or smirk. He simply stood patiently by the wrought-iron chair with his hands relaxed at his sides, smiling warmly at both of us.

"I think lunch in Ghent next Saturday sounds great," I told her honestly, squeezing Katie's hand back.

"Then we'd really like that, Brandon," Katie beamed, tucking the folded slip carefully into the zippered pouch of her wallet behind her Virginia State ID card. "Drive safe through the tunnel."

As we unlocked our joystick brakes five minutes later and rolled side by side up Monticello Avenue toward Charlotte Street to catch the four-thirty Route 2 bus home to Greenway Court, Katie kept her hand laced tightly through mine the entire block—both of us convinced we had just met the politest, most understanding young man in Virginia.

Part 2: A Non-Negotiable Package Deal, Dad's Calling Cards, & Moving Together to Williamsburg

Date: 2004-06-19 at 13:30 America/New_York

Saturday, June 19, 2004, 1:30 PM — Labeling the Cables & The Non-Negotiable Package Deal

“Look how neatly Brandon labeled every single monitor and speaker cable with masking tape before coiling them into the carton, Nate,” Katie said happily inside Apartment A6, easing her compact SwiftChair back six inches from our workstation desk so our forty-six-year-old dad could lift our seventeen-inch CRT monitor into its padded cardboard box.

Standing beside the desk in a rolled-sleeve plaid flannel shirt with a tape dispenser in his hand, Dad glanced over his glasses toward the window, where twenty-two-year-old Brandon Mercer was carefully wrapping Katie’s glass blue-butterfly paperweight in bubble wrap before setting it into the top of a book box.

“You’ve got a methodical streak, Brandon,” Dad said approvingly, pulling a strip of clear packing tape tightly across the monitor carton. “Most guys your age toss all the power cords into a grocery sack and spend half a Saturday figuring out what plugs into what.”

“My dad always told me that if you take your time and keep everything organized up front, nothing gets damaged on the road, Mr. Prairie,” Brandon replied with that calm, respectful smile he had worn every single weekend since mid-May.

Sitting in my SwiftChair beside Katie with my fingers laced warmly through hers across our inner armrests, I felt the last trace of moving-day nervousness settle inside my chest.

For five straight weeks after meeting us on the brick patio of The Admiral Center, Brandon had driven down Interstate 64 from Williamsburg every Saturday and Sunday without missing once. He had never rushed Katie, never complained that the three of us went everywhere together, and never acted awkward when Katie and I finished each other’s sentences or needed quiet breaks away from noisy restaurant dining rooms. Two weeks earlier, right as Dave and Deb sent out the annual July lease-renewal notice for our single-room studio here on Greenway Court—and with our summer and fall general-education classes at CCHR available online and at the Peninsula satellite classrooms—Brandon had invited Katie to move up to Williamsburg with him.

Katie hadn’t even needed to look at me before giving him our lifelong rule in one clear sentence: *Nate and I don’t separate. Wherever I live, my brother lives too—we’re a package deal.*

We had half-expected Brandon to blink, backtrack, or mumble an excuse about couples needing their own space. Instead, Brandon hadn’t hesitated for a single heartbeat. He had smiled, told both of us that his rented single-family house on a quiet tree-lined street just two blocks from the Williamsburg Transportation Center on North Boundary Street had a spare bedroom, a gentle wooden ramp up to the front porch, and wide ground-floor doorways, and insisted he would be honored to have both of us under his roof so Katie and I never had to spend a day apart.

Saturday, June 19, 2004, 2:45 PM — Two Laminated Calling Cards Behind Our State IDs & Rolling Out of Greenway Court

“Brandon, do me a favor and grab the folding hand truck out of the bed of my pickup so we can wheel these heavy book cartons down the lobby ramp in one trip,” Dad said, gesturing toward the hallway door.

“Right away, Mr. Prairie,” Brandon nodded, stepping briskly out into the first-floor corridor.

As soon as Brandon’s footsteps faded past the lobby mailboxes, Dad set his tape dispenser down on the bare workstation desk, reached into his shirt pocket, and pulled out two crisp, laminated blue-and-white prepaid telephone calling cards. Pulling up the lone wooden kitchen chair so he sat at eye level right in front of Katie’s wheelchair and mine, Dad handed one card to Katie and one card to me.

“Before we load up the truck and head up I-64, I want both of you to tuck these right behind your Virginia State ID cards in your wallets,” Dad said quietly, tapping the toll-free 1-800 access number and the twelve-digit personal identification number printed under the scratch-off silver strip he had already cleared for us on the back of each card. “Each card has five hundred prepaid minutes preloaded on it, and they never expire as long as I top them up once a year.”

“For payphones, Dad?” Katie asked, turning the glossy plastic card over in her fingers.

“For any payphone anywhere in the country,” Dad said, looking steadily from Katie’s eyes to mine. “Williamsburg is forty-five miles across the water in another area rate zone, and neither of you carries rolls of quarters around in your pockets. If you’re ever out at a bus stop, a college building, or a train station and need to reach me at home on Arvin Road or at my office desk, you don’t need a single coin. You pick up any payphone receiver, dial that 1-800 number for free, punch in your twelve-digit code when the automated voice asks for it, and dial my number.”

“Got it memorized already,” I said, unzipping my wallet, sliding out my vertical Under-21 Virginia State ID card—which still carried Dad’s brick ranch address on Arvin Road in Virginia Beach—and slipping the prepaid calling card snugly into the clear plastic window right behind it alongside the fresh, unactivated thirty-day CVTA bus pass I always kept in reserve for Norfolk and Virginia Beach, while Katie did the exact same thing with hers. “And our old bedrooms on Arvin Road are still staying just how they are?”

“Untouched,” Dad promised warmly, resting one large, calloused hand over both of our joined hands between our armrests. “I like Brandon, kids—he’s been polite to me and patient with both of you—and I’m proud of you for trying a new adventure together. Just remember that Arvin Road is home base for as long as I’m breathing. If anything up there ever stops feeling right, you call me day or night and we come straight home.”

“We will, Dad—and we have each other right down the hall twenty-four-seven,” Katie smiled, leaning forward to hug Dad tightly around the neck before we rolled our rolled-up navy-blue closet sleeping bag and four pillows into their protective plastic bag by the door.

Across the narrow corridor, our friend Michael stepped out of Apartment A5 to wave goodbye and wish both of us luck up on the Peninsula before Brandon rolled the hand truck back inside. Twenty minutes later, with our computer tower, our clothes, and our shared sleeping bag loaded beneath the tonneau cover in the bed of Dad's extended-cab pickup truck alongside our two compact SwiftChairs—and Katie and me buckled side by side on the rear bench seat holding hands—we pulled away from Greenway Court and headed west toward the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel and Williamsburg.

Six Buses from Williamsburg, Sea Breeze West, & Coming Home to Arvin Road

North Henry Street, Six Buses from Williamsburg, & The Goyeau Street Tunnel File

Part 1: Closed Bedroom Doors, The Three-by-Six Closet Sanctuary, & Unwritten Couple Rules

Date: 2004-10-15 at 21:40 America/New_York

Friday, October 15, 2004, 9:40 PM — Unplugged Chargers, Faint Thumbprints, & "Normal Adult Privacy"

"Oh, relax, Katie—my foot must have snagged the cord while I was sweeping behind the armchair," Brandon sighed, tossing the heavy three-prong plug of my twenty-four-volt SwiftChair battery charger onto the hardwood floor six inches out of my seated reach instead of plugging it back into the baseboard outlet. "You don't have to interrogate me like a courtroom witness every time a plug comes loose. Honestly, sometimes your autism makes you take every little accident like a personal conspiracy."

I sat motionless in my compact black SwiftChair inside the closed master bedroom of Brandon's rented clapboard house two blocks off North Boundary Street, staring down at the dead green LED on my charger brick while a cold, hollow weight settled behind my ribs.

"I wasn't interrogating you, Brandon," I said quietly, keeping my hands folded in my lap so he wouldn't see my fingers trembling against the hem of my sweater. "It's just the third night this week my charger came unplugged after I went to sleep, and if my battery drops below two bars I can't get down the front porch ramp."

Brandon stepped across the rug, stopped directly behind my backrest where I couldn't see his face without twisting my neck, and rested both hands heavily on my shoulders—pressing downward against my collarbones with just enough force to pin my shoulder blades flat against the upholstery.

“And where exactly do you need to roll by yourself in the middle of the day when I have a perfectly good car in the driveway?” Brandon asked in that smooth, disappointed tone that always made my literal nineteen-year-old mind scramble to figure out what unwritten social rule I had broken now. “Look at us, Katie. You and Nate moved up here in June, it’s the middle of October, and I’ve bent over backward welcoming your brother into my house. Most twenty-two-year-old guys wouldn’t let their girlfriend’s twin brother take over the spare bedroom and the dining-room table with his computers. All I ask in return is that after nine o’clock at night, you and I keep this bedroom door closed like a normal adult couple.”

When I started to reach my right hand toward my joystick to angle my chair sideways so I could look up at him, Brandon’s fingers slid down from my shoulder and closed hard around my left wrist—yanking my arm back onto the padded armrest and holding it there for four full seconds until the bones in my forearm throbbed.

“Ow—Brandon, that hurts,” I whispered, wincing as the skin under my sleeve burned right over the faint yellowish-purple thumbprint he had left there on Tuesday night when he claimed he was “just steadying” me by the bathroom doorway.

He let go instantly and exhaled a long, theatrical breath through his nose, shaking his head as if *I* were the one being unreasonable.

“See? That right there is what I mean about you overreacting,” Brandon murmured, tapping the closed white six-panel bedroom door with his knuckles. “And remember what we talked about, Katie. Everyone in a real, grown-up relationship knows you don’t go running down the hall to your brother over private couple disagreements. Doing that is childish, and it hurts me after everything I do for both of you. You want to prove you’re nineteen and not twelve? Stay in this bed tonight instead of crawling into a closet like a scared kid.”

Friday, October 15, 2004, 11:50 PM — Slipping Down the Hall to Nate’s Three-by-Six Closet & Crossing the Line

For two miserable hours after Brandon turned off the bedside lamp and rolled onto his side under the thin quilt, I lay wide awake on the far edge of the exposed queen mattress with my street jeans and long-sleeve shirt still on, staring at the pale rectangle of streetlight slanting across the ceiling from the front yard.

Nothing about how we had gotten here had happened all at once. If Brandon had yelled at us or grabbed my wrist during our first week in Williamsburg back in June, Nate and I would have pulled out Dad’s laminated calling cards, rolled two blocks to the payphone at the Williamsburg train depot, and gone home to Virginia Beach before sunset. Instead, the water had heated up one degree at a time. In July it had been gentle comments that Nate and I spent “ten hours a day parked two inches apart” and ought to practice giving couples polite evening space so Nate wouldn’t feel awkward. Because Nate wanted me to have a happy first relationship—and because neither of us had ever dated anyone in adulthood before and lived in constant dread of breaking neurotypical relationship rules nobody had ever taught us—Nate had politely stayed in his spare bedroom down the hall after supper, having no idea what Brandon was saying or doing once our bedroom door clicked shut.

Except there was one thing about Nate and me that Brandon's guilt trips had never been able to erase, and it drove Brandon quietly furious every time it happened.

Ever since August of last year back on Greenway Court—after our mother Brenda had come screaming and pounding on our metal alley door in a drunken rage—neither Nate nor I had ever felt safe sleeping out in an open room with windows. Because of our autism and the childhood terror our mother had wired into our bones, the only place on earth our nervous systems ever went completely quiet at night was side by side on the floor of a pitch-dark three-by-six-foot closet, sharing four pillows and a single zipped navy-blue sleeping bag where the narrow walls enclosed us on every side. Back in school in Virginia Beach, when our classes went through Family Life Education, Nate and I had learned the rule that brothers and sisters are not supposed to have sex with each other; neither of us really understood why people made such a complicated fuss over it, yet a rule was a rule, and we followed rules strictly. Inside our closet sleeping bag, dressed in clean pajamas or t-shirts and sweatpants, all we ever did was hold each other tight until the shaking stopped.

Beside me in the dark, Brandon's breathing finally deepened into a heavy, rhythmic snore.

Moving one silent inch at a time while my left wrist throbbed in the dark, I eased myself off the side of the mattress onto the seat of my SwiftChair, left the motor off for two seconds until my casters cleared the rug edge, clicked the power button on at its lowest crawl speed, and cracked the bedroom door open just wide enough to slip out into the dark hallway.

Ten feet down the corridor, the door to Nate's spare bedroom stood ajar an inch—the way my twin brother always left it whenever his gut told him something wasn't right.

The second my front tires crossed his threshold, I saw the faint amber glow of Nate's watch face turn toward me from the open doorway of his three-by-six bedroom closet, where our shared navy-blue sleeping bag and four white pillows were already spread lengthwise across the clean closet floor.

"Katie?" Nate whispered barely above a breath, sitting straight up inside the closet opening as I braked my chair beside his parked SwiftChair and transferred down onto the soft sleeping bag beside him.

I pulled the wooden closet door almost all the way shut until the room vanished into safe, enclosed darkness, buried my face against my twin brother's collarbone, and started shaking from head to toe.

As Nate wrapped his right arm around my shoulders inside the sleeping bag, his fingers brushed the tender, swollen skin of my left wrist through my cotton sleeve—and I gasped sharply in the dark before I could bite my lip.

Nate froze completely still.

"Katie," Nate whispered against my hair, his voice dropping an octave in the pitch dark as he gently pushed my sleeve back two inches and felt the raised heat along my wrist with his fingertips. "Did Brandon do that to you?"

Every rehearsed excuse Brandon had planted in my head—about private couple disagreements, about being immature, about misunderstanding his grip because of my autism—shattered the instant my twin brother held me at eye level without pinning me down.

“He keeps unplugging my charger on purpose, Nate, and tonight he grabbed my arm hard when I tried to turn my chair around and told me I wasn’t allowed to tell you,” I whispered, hot tears soaking into the collar of Nate’s t-shirt. “And all week while you’ve been doing your CCHR coursework in the afternoon, he’s been printing maps of Canada and talking crazy about taking me up across the border where healthcare is free so we never need Dad or you again. I hate it here, Nate. I don’t want a boyfriend anymore. I just want to go home.”

In the dark of that narrow three-by-six closet, Nate wrapped both arms around me with all the steady, protective strength in his nineteen-year-old body and held me close until my breathing slowed to match his.

“Nobody touches you like that ever again, Katie, and you aren’t going anywhere near Canada—or anywhere else—with him,” Nate whispered fiercely against my forehead. “We came here together, and we’re leaving together. Tomorrow we get our chargers, our IDs, and our laptops in our bags, and the very first opening we get, we’re getting out of Williamsburg and going home to Dad.”

Part 2: Six Buses from Williamsburg — The Blind Leap at Boundary Street, Crown Burger, Open Radio on Route 20, & Dad at Indian River Road

Date: 2004-10-16 at 15:35 America/New_York

Saturday, October 16, 2004, 3:35 PM — The Blind Ticket Window at Boundary Street & A Leap of Faith Toward Newport News

“Both of you wait right out here by the bus island and don’t crowd me inside the waiting room,” Brandon snapped at three-forty-eight on Saturday afternoon, hitching the strap of an overstuffed black canvas duffel bag higher onto his shoulder outside the brick colonial depot of the Williamsburg Transportation Center on North Boundary Street. “The ticket line inside is cramped enough without two wheelchairs blocking the queue, and I need to get our passes sorted out at the counter before the shift change.”

Sitting wheel-to-wheel with Nate on the red-brick plaza thirty feet outside the heavy brass-and-glass entrance doors under a crisp, windy October sky, I kept my hands folded calmly over my canvas lap bag and didn’t argue a word.

Earlier that afternoon back at the house, when Brandon had found both of us sitting fully dressed in the living room with our backpacks clipped to our backrests—and our shared navy-blue sleeping bag rolled tight inside its weatherproof sack strapped across Nate’s rear frame—he had ordered both of us to roll the two blocks over to the station with him, barking vaguely about an “autumn weekend rail excursion” while keeping his coat pocket buttoned over a thick fold of cash. Neither Nate nor I knew where Brandon was actually buying tickets to, and we didn’t care. All Nate and I knew—having quietly packed both twenty-four-volt SwiftChair battery chargers, both CCHR laptops, our daily medication pouches, a handful of crisp one-

dollar bills, and our wallets holding our Virginia State IDs, Dad's laminated calling cards, and the unused thirty-day CVTA bus passes we still had from Norfolk before noon—was that wherever Brandon Mercer was going, we were not going a single foot further with him.

"Stay right here," Brandon repeated, glancing down at our chairs as if two nineteen-year-olds without a car were bolted to the bricks. "I'll be out in five minutes."

He turned, pushed through the heavy wooden-and-glass doors into the depot, and disappeared inside.

Nate and I knew the layout of that historic brick station house from rolling past it all summer: the indoor ARTS ticket counter faced inward across the enclosed waiting room, with solid brick walls and zero line of sight out onto the local bus bays outside where we were sitting. Neither Brandon nor the ticket agent behind the counter could see a thing happening at the curb while the dot-matrix ticket printer chugged through paper stock.

Three seconds after the station doors swung shut behind Brandon's back, air brakes hissed loudly along the curved concrete bus island right in front of our footrests.

A white-and-colonial-blue transit coach with Colonial Triangle Transit Authority painted along its side pulled into the bay, its amber front destination sign illuminating in crisp block letters:

GREY LINE — NEWPORT NEWS / LEE HALL.

Nate and I turned our heads toward each other at the exact same instant.

Neither of us knew the Williamsburg or Peninsula bus networks at all, and neither of us had the faintest idea whether it was even possible to string city transit buses together all the way from Williamsburg back to Dad's house in Virginia Beach before nightfall. All we knew from basic Tidewater geography was that Newport News lay southeast straight down the Peninsula toward the harbor—away from Brandon, closer to the water, and closer to home.

"Newport News goes down the Peninsula," Nate said quietly, his blue eyes locking onto mine without a flicker of hesitation. "Now or never, Katie."

"Let's go," I breathed.

Both of us pushed our right-hand joysticks forward in unison. Spotting two compact black powerchairs rolling straight up to the yellow curb strip, the CTTA Grey Line operator immediately flipped his suspension switch; the front of the bus knelt with a pneumatic sigh, and the aluminum ramp unfolded cleanly onto the brick apron.

Nate rolled up the diamond-plate incline first, and I drove right up behind him thirty seconds later. On Colonial Triangle Transit, the Person with a Disability fare was seventy-five cents: before backing into our respective forward securement bays, Nate and I each fed a crisp one-dollar bill into the farebox, plucked out the printed Change Card loaded with twenty-five cents in CTTA bus fare that the machine issued back to each of us, and let the operator swiftly hook all eight four-point floor tie-down straps onto our frames without looking back once toward the blind brick wall of the station house.

At four-oh-one sharp, the ramp folded upright, the dual doors hissed shut, and the Grey Line pulled out onto North Boundary Street and headed southeast onto Route 60—Pocahontas Trail—toward Newport News, leaving Brandon Mercer standing at the indoor ticket counter behind us.

Saturday, October 16, 2004, 4:30 PM — Elmhurst Street at Lee Hall, Thirty-Day Passes, Crown Burger at Warwick & Denbigh, & Calling Dad From Newport News

Once the brick walls of Colonial Williamsburg gave way to tall pines and the long four-lane stretch of Pocahontas Trail past Brewster Gardens, the adrenaline humming in my ears gave way to pure timetable problem-solving.

“Excuse me, sir,” Nate called forward politely from his securement bay as the Grey Line slowed toward the Newport News city line at Lee Hall. “My sister and I know the CVTA routes over in Norfolk and Virginia Beach, so we’ve never ridden down the Peninsula before. How do we connect from Lee Hall down toward Downtown Newport News and Norfolk?”

“Tell you the truth, I couldn’t tell you how to string Coastal Virginia’s routes together down the Peninsula,” the CTTA operator called back honestly, glancing into his wide interior mirror. “Most of us Colonial Triangle drivers only know that Elmhurst Street along the side of the shopping center here at Lee Hall is where we meet up with the CVTA bus—I think that 116 bus goes down to the mall, and their driver should have Peninsula pocket schedules up front. Only catch here on Elmhurst Street is that Colonial Triangle and Coastal Virginia run on two completely separate radio systems, so I can’t call directly over my radio to let that CVTA operator know I’ve got two wheelchairs unloading.”

Before my stomach could even tighten at the thought of watching a timed transfer pull away while eight floor straps were being unhooked, two riders sitting just ahead of us behind the front wheel-well—a woman in navy hospital scrubs and a shipyard apprentice carrying a canvas tool bag—turned around in their seats with warm, reassuring smiles.

“Don’t worry about a thing,” the woman in scrubs told us right away. “Both of us are transferring to that 116 bus too. Here at Lee Hall the buses just line up one behind the other right along Elmhurst Street—soon as the front doors open, we’ll walk straight up to the CVTA bus and let the driver know there are two wheelchairs coming right behind us.”

“We’ll make sure he holds for y’all,” the shipyard apprentice promised with a friendly nod.

“Thank you both so much!” I called out, reaching across the aisle between our two securement bays to squeeze Nate’s fingers as the Grey Line turned off Pocahontas Trail onto Elmhurst Street along the side of the Lee Hall strip shopping center—pulling in directly behind an idling blue-and-silver Coastal Virginia Transit Authority bus signed for Route 116.

The very instant Nate and I saw that familiar CVTA emblem on the bus waiting ahead of us on Elmhurst Street, both of us let out the exact same quiet breath of relief. Throughout our entire time living in the CVTA service district, Nate and I had always carried CVTA thirty-day passes—magnetic passes valid for thirty

consecutive days starting from the day of first usage in a farebox rather than thirty days from the date of purchase. Because the unused spares tucked behind the calling cards in our wallets from before leaving Norfolk in June hadn't lost a single day sitting unactivated all summer, seeing that CVTA 116 bus at Lee Hall meant we were completely good on fare all the way home to Virginia Beach.

Outside our right-hand windows, there was no multi-bay transfer loop and not a single bus shelter—only a metal bus-stop signpost and a ribbon-thin concrete sidewalk squeezed so narrowly between the street curb and the grass strip bordering the shopping center parking lot that a wheelchair ramp deployed onto the sidewalk would have left zero room for our powerchairs to clear the ramp and turn safely. Knowing the tight geometry of Elmhurst Street by heart, our CTTA operator purposely stopped several feet away from the curb out in the street lane so his front ramp could fold down flat onto the level asphalt pavement with plenty of maneuvering room.

True to their word, the moment our front doors hissed open, the woman in scrubs and the shipyard apprentice stepped briskly down and walked straight forward along Elmhurst Street to the open front door of the CVTA 116 lined up ahead of us, pointing back toward our bus while our CTTA driver crouched to unclip our eight tie-down hooks. Through our windshield, we watched the CVTA operator give an immediate wave, ease his own forty-foot coach a few feet out from the narrow Elmhurst Street curb as well so his wheelchair ramp could deploy safely onto the pavement, pull his yellow parking-brake knob tight, and fold his ramp down to meet us.

Rolling smoothly off the Grey Line ramp and forward along the asphalt into the waiting CVTA 116, we thanked the two passengers who had held the connection for us, swiped our fresh thirty-day CVTA passes through the farebox reader for their very first day of use with two crisp confirmation beeps, and backed into the two forward wheelchair bays while the operator secured all eight straps to our frames. Climbing back into his seat and pulling the doors shut, the driver unhooked the black coiled handset of his two-way radio beside the farebox to alert CVTA Dispatch that he had picked up two wheelchair passengers:

"11601 to Dispatch."

"Dispatch, go ahead 11601," the dispatcher's voice crackled cleanly from the small metal speaker above the windshield.

"Dispatch, I've picked up two 10-16s at Lee Hall."

"10-4."

Hearing that familiar four-digit ten-code—10-16, CVTA's radio call for a wheelchair passenger that operators logged with Dispatch whenever wheelchair spaces were occupied—made something deep in my chest loosen for the first time since noon. Even up here on the Peninsula, we were officially back on our home transit system.

As the 116 pulled south onto Warwick Boulevard past the brick gates of Fort Eustis, Nate asked our CVTA operator how to connect south toward Downtown Norfolk and pulled folded pocket paper timetables from the front rack for the southbound

Warwick trunk routes and the cross-harbor Expressways line. Spreading the folded brochures across our laps, our eyes scanned the columns together the way we had read transit schedules since high school.

“Hold on—look closely at the arrival column at Warwick and Denbigh,” Nate pointed with his index finger as our stomach rumbles reminded both of us we hadn’t eaten anything since toast at nine that morning. “When we get off the 116 at Warwick and Denbigh, Route 106 comes in fifteen minutes—and look at its arrival time at Newport News Transit Center: five-forty-five.”

I traced my finger across to the Expressways Route 61 timetable right beside it, and my breath caught.

“There’s a Route 61 leaving Newport News at five-forty-five, and then the very last Route 61 of the night crossing the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel leaves at six-forty-five!” I said. “A five-forty-five arrival on the 106 for a five-forty-five departure on the 61 has zero margin for error—if weekend traffic slows the 106 by sixty seconds, we miss the five-forty-five bus and have to sit out in the open at the transit center for a whole hour right when Brandon might be driving down I-64 looking for us!”

“Now look one column to the right at Route 107,” Nate said, tapping the next line. “Route 107 comes forty-five minutes from now at Warwick and Denbigh, and it pulls into Newport News Transit Center at six-fifteen—giving us a rock-solid thirty-minute timed buffer to make sure both of our chairs are first in line for the two wheelchair bays on the six-forty-five Route 61!”

Because we were deliberately building a forty-five-minute layover buffer at Warwick and Denbigh instead of trying to make a tight connection, our 116 operator didn’t need to call ahead to another bus when he knelt at the bustling corner of Warwick Boulevard and Denbigh Boulevard just before four-fifty. Spotting the red-and-gold sign of a Crown Burger fifty yards back from the intersection with an accessible curb cut leading straight to its side entrance, Nate and I rolled inside completely out of sight of Warwick Boulevard traffic, took turns using the clean accessible restroom, washed our hands and faces in warm water, and parked wheel-to-wheel at a corner booth away from the street windows with two hot cheeseburgers, a large basket of salty fries, and two cups of ginger ale.

For forty-five calm, disciplined minutes indoors away from the highway, Nate and I ate every bite, watched the minute hand on Nate’s wristwatch, and rolled back out to the bus stop three minutes before our third bus pulled up to the curb: southbound CVTA Route 107.

Both wheelchair bays on the 107 were wide open. Once we swiped our thirty-day passes and the operator clipped our eight tie-down straps tight against the floor tracks and pulled back out into the southbound lane of Warwick Boulevard, she reached down to her radio handset to log both wheelchair bays with Dispatch:

“10702 to Dispatch.”

“Dispatch, go ahead 10702.”

“Dispatch, I’ve picked up two 10-16s at Warwick and Denbigh.”

“10-4.”

Riding south down the lower end of the Peninsula as the October sun sank orange toward the James River, we rolled off the ramp at the Newport News Transit Center right on schedule at six-fifteen in the evening—thirty full minutes ahead of the final six-forty-five cross-water departure, with Bay Four completely clear so our two SwiftChairs sat right at the front of the boarding line.

And the second we saw the white-and-blue Expressways Route 61 bay sign right beside us, the terrifying guesswork of the Peninsula was over—because once that bus crossed the water to Monticello Avenue in Downtown Norfolk at seven-twelve, Nate and I didn't need a single paper map or schedule anymore. We knew every route, transfer bay, and evening timetable across Norfolk, Chesapeake, Virginia Beach, and Portsmouth completely by memory.

"Come on—there's a lowered payphone right over by the brick pillar," Nate said, pulling his wallet from his pocket and sliding out the laminated blue-and-white prepaid calling card Dad had tucked behind our State IDs back in June.

Rolling our chairs side by side up to the stainless-steel ADA payphone mounted at seated height on the transit center wall, I lifted the cold armored receiver off the hook, held it between my ear and Nate's so both of us could hear, dialed the toll-free 1-800 access number for free without needing a single quarter, punched in our twelve-digit PIN when the chime sounded, and dialed Dad's home landline on Arvin Road.

Dad picked up before the second ring even finished.

"Hello?"

"Dad, it's Katie and Nate!" I said, my voice catching for the first time all afternoon at the sound of our father's voice. "We're at the Newport News Transit Center right now—we left Brandon at the Williamsburg train station on the CTTA bus because he was hurting me and trying to take us somewhere we didn't want to go, and we're coming home!"

Over the phone line, we heard the kitchen chair scrape back sharply on Dad's linoleum floor.

"Are both of you safe right now? Did he injure either of you?" Dad asked immediately, his voice dropping into rock-steady focus.

"We're both right here together at Bay Four and nobody knows where we are," Nate answered into the mouthpiece beside my cheek. "Dad, we're getting on the six-forty-five Expressways Route 61 across the bridge-tunnel—it arrives on Monticello Avenue in Downtown Norfolk at seven-twelve. From Monticello we have an eight-minute buffer for the seven-twenty outbound Route 20 to Glenrock Mall, where we make a direct connection to the seven-forty-five Route 15 south down Military Highway, putting us at Military Highway and Indian River Road at eight-oh-one. Or do you want to drive across the tunnel to get us?"

"Stay right on that 61 bus at six-forty-five—if I head toward the tunnel now and we pass each other in the tubes, you'll already be in Norfolk before I reach Newport News," Dad said at once, calculating the clock just like we did. "Get across the

water on the 61, stay right next to the driver, and I will be standing under the streetlight at the Military Highway and Indian River Road bus stop at seven-fifty waiting for your Route 15 to pull up. Come home, kids. You're almost there."

Saturday, October 16, 2004, 6:45 PM – 8:01 PM — Under the Bay on Expressways Route 61, The Open-Radio 10-16 Hold, & Dad Waiting Under the Streetlight

At six-forty-two, a high-backed CVTA Expressways bus with *61 DOWNTOWN NORFOLK* lit up across its front sign pulled into Bay Four, knelt at the curb, and locked both of our SwiftChairs into the two forward securement bays after we swiped our thirty-day passes. Settling back into his driver's seat and closing the doors, the operator lifted his radio handset to report our boarding before pulling out of the transit center:

"6102 to Dispatch."

"Dispatch, go ahead 6102."

"Dispatch, I've picked up two 10-16s at Newport News Transit Center."

"10-4."

At six-forty-five on the dot—the very last transit bus of the night crossing Hampton Roads—our fourth bus pulled onto Interstate 64 East. Ten minutes later, as dusk deepened into purple night over the Chesapeake Bay, our tires hummed across the concrete trestle onto the North Island and plunged downward between the gleaming white ceramic wall tiles and bright fluorescent ceiling tubes of the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Holding Nate's hand tightly across the narrow center aisle while salt air and tunnel exhaust rushed past the sealed windows beneath sixty feet of open bay water, I felt my shoulders drop two full inches for the first time since July. Once that bus climbed up into the lights of Willoughby Spit on the Norfolk side, the entire harbor stood between us and Williamsburg.

True to the printed timetable, Expressways Route 61 glided to the curb on Monticello Avenue in Downtown Norfolk at seven-twelve sharp—giving us an unhurried eight-minute buffer to roll down the ramp onto familiar Southside concrete and position our chairs at the outbound stop without needing anyone to hold a bus.

At seven-eighteen, our fifth bus—an outbound CVTA Route 20 signed for Glenrock Mall and Virginia Beach Boulevard—pulled to the curb. After we rolled up the front ramp and swiped our thirty-day passes, Nate looked up politely at the night-shift operator while he crouched down to clip all eight floor straps onto my frame and Nate's.

"Excuse me, sir—we're trying to make the seven-forty-five outbound Route 15 connection at Glenrock Mall heading south down Military Highway to Indian River Road," Nate told him earnestly.

Unlike our buffered transfers at Warwick and Denbigh, Newport News, and Monticello Avenue, this final swap at Glenrock Mall was our only direct CVTA-to-CVTA pulse connection of the night, with zero built-in cushion if traffic or unloading slowed us down. Taking one look at the two nineteen-year-old twins sitting side by side in compact powerchairs with everything we owned strapped to our backs and a rolled-up sleeping bag tied behind Nate's seat, the veteran Route 20 operator gave us a single warm nod, climbed into his seat, and logged our two wheelchair bays with Dispatch first:

"2004 to Dispatch."

"Dispatch, go ahead 2004."

"Dispatch, I've picked up two 10-16s at Monticello Avenue."

"10-4."

"We hit our lights down the Boulevard, I'll make sure that 15 knows you're coming," the driver promised over his shoulder, releasing his air brake at seven-twenty sharp and heading east out Virginia Beach Boulevard past Park Avenue, Tidewater Drive, and Ballentine.

Even with steady Saturday evening traffic, both Nate and I knew the math in our heads: unstrapping two electric wheelchairs and deploying a ramp takes three extra minutes—just enough time on a zero-buffer pulse transfer for the seven-forty-five outbound Route 15 to release its brakes and pull out of Glenrock Mall right in front of us, stranding us in a dark mall lot for another hour.

As our bus approached the busy junction of US-58 and US-13 in Norfolk—slowing in the right-hand lane along Virginia Beach Boulevard right before making the right turn into Glenrock Mall—our Route 20 operator reached down beside his farebox, unhooked the coiled black cord of his open-channel two-way analog radio, and called directly across the Southside frequency to the waiting Route 15 bus:

"Outbound 20 to the outbound 15 at Glenrock Mall, I have two 10-16s for you."

For two heartbeats, quiet white static hissed from the small metal speaker mounted above the windshield before the Route 15 operator's voice crackled back—checking first to make sure we were boarding the right direction rather than the inbound Route 15 heading north toward Naval Base Norfolk:

"10-4. Are they heading towards Emerald Creek Mall?"

Holding the coiled handset beside his shoulder, our Route 20 operator glanced up into his wide interior mirror toward our two wheelchair bays to confirm with us which way we were going. "Hey—that 15 operator wants to make sure you two are headed outbound toward Emerald Creek Mall and Chesapeake, not north toward the Naval Base. Which way are y'all going?"

"Outbound toward Chesapeake, sir—we're both heading towards Indian River Road!" Nate answered clearly right away.

"10-4, they say they are heading to Indian River Road," our Route 20 driver answered into the handset, confirming we were heading outbound toward Chesapeake.

“10-4, Route 15 copies.”

Tears stung the backs of my eyes so suddenly that I had to blink twice as Nate squeezed my fingers across the aisle. Neither of those CVTA drivers knew who we were or what we had just fled up on the Peninsula; they were simply two night-shift bus operators double-checking our direction and holding a connection over an open radio so two wheelchair riders wouldn’t get stranded in the dark.

At seven-forty-six, our Route 20 made the right turn off Virginia Beach Boulevard and swung into the orange sodium-lit bus loop at Glenrock Mall right behind the idling outbound Route 15, whose front doors were already propped open with its ramp resting on the concrete island. Unclipped in ninety seconds flat, Nate and I called out a heartfelt *“Thank you!”* to our Route 20 driver, rolled thirty feet across the concrete bay straight up the waiting ramp of our sixth and final bus—outbound CVTA Route 15—and swiped our thirty-day passes one last time for the night.

Once the Route 15 operator hooked our eight tie-down straps tight, stowed his ramp, and pulled smoothly out onto eight-lane Military Highway at seven-forty-eight, he keyed his handset to log our final two wheelchair spaces of the night:

“1502 to Dispatch.”

“Dispatch, go ahead 1502.”

“Dispatch, I’ve picked up two 10-16s at Glenrock Mall.”

“10-4.”

Rolling south across the low highway bridge over the Eastern Branch of the Elizabeth River from Norfolk into Virginia Beach as the clock ticked to eight o’clock, I peered ahead through the dark right-hand window toward the bright intersection of Military Highway and Indian River Road.

There, standing right beneath the amber glow of the corner streetlight in his navy windbreaker—hands out of his pockets, watching the bus’s headlights pull to the curb—stood our dad.

At eight-oh-one sharp, the Route 15 knelt at the Indian River Road stop and lowered its ramp. Before our front caster wheels even touched the sidewalk concrete, Dad dropped to one knee between our two SwiftChairs and wrapped both Nate and me in a fierce, trembling three-way hug that smelled like laundry soap, coffee, and home.

“I’ve got you both,” Dad whispered thickly, holding onto my shoulders and Nate’s at eye level without pinning either of us down for a millisecond. “You’re home, kids. Nobody is ever touching either of you again.”

Fifteen minutes later, rolling up our familiar aluminum front ramp into the quiet, warm brick ranch on Arvin Road, we saw what Dad had already done while waiting to walk up to the bus stop: inside my old bedroom, the wide closet doors stood open, vacuumed clean, with four fresh white pillows and clean cotton sheets already banked neatly along the carpet waiting for our shared sleeping bag.

Part 3: The Goyeau Street Tunnel Bus, The Trashed Ticket on East Jefferson Avenue, & Protected Non-Traveling Complainant

Date: 2004-10-20 at 14:00 America/New_York

Wednesday, October 20, 2004, 2:00 PM — The Federal Courthouse on Granby Street & Two Regular Adult Tickets to Detroit

“Take all the time you need, Miss Prairie,” Special Agent Morales said gently, clicking his ballpoint pen open above a yellow legal pad inside a quiet ground-floor conference room at the Walter E. Hoffman United States Courthouse on Granby Street in downtown Norfolk while a detective from the Williamsburg Police Department switched on a small digital recorder. “Nobody in this room is rushing you or your brother.”

Four nights of uninterrupted sleep zipped inside our shared sleeping bag on the clean closet floor of our home on Arvin Road—plus real home-cooked meals at Dad’s dining table and the matching silver flip phones Dad had bought for Katie and me at the Military Highway cellular store on Monday afternoon right after the Williamsburg police photographed her bruised wrist—had finally stopped Katie’s hands from shaking, though she still kept her right fingers laced tightly through mine across our wheelchair armrests while Dad stood right behind our shoulders. Spread across the oak conference table in front of Agent Morales lay the photographs of the dark thumbprint bruises on Katie’s left wrist, the cassette tape from Dad’s Arvin Road answering machine containing three furious messages Brandon had called in from a Washington train platform late Saturday night swearing American law would never touch him once he crossed into Canada, and the Williamsburg station printout the detective had subpoenaed Monday morning.

“What blew his cover before he even left Virginia,” the Williamsburg detective said, sliding the printed ARTS terminal ledger across the oak blotter, “was what the indoor ticket clerk at 468 North Boundary Street entered at three-fifty-nine on Saturday afternoon while the two of you were boarding the Colonial Triangle Grey Line bus outside. Look at the passenger count and fare code.”

Katie and I leaned forward together in our SwiftChairs to read the dot-matrix accounting line.

“Quantity two, Regular Adult one-way coach, Williamsburg to Detroit via Washington and Toledo, paid in cash,” I read aloud, blinking in disbelief. “Wait—only *two* tickets? There were three of us at the station! And why did he book Regular Adult coach instead of a Passenger With a Disability wheelchair space and a companion fare?”

“Because first, Mr. Mercer never intended to take you with them, Nathaniel—he planned to walk out of that depot, force your sister toward the train platform, and leave you stranded by the bus bays,” the detective said grimly. “And second, because the ARTS window inside the Williamsburg depot has no view of the bus loop outside, the clerk couldn’t see Katie’s powerchair, and Mr. Mercer clearly had no idea disability or companion rail discounts even existed. Had you two stayed on that brick platform, Katie physically couldn’t have boarded the upper-level coach seat he booked out of Washington on the overnight train anyway. Instead, by paying

full walk-up Regular Adult cash price for two non-refundable tickets all the way to Michigan, he drained almost every dollar out of his bank account before he stepped back outside to an empty bus island."

"And rather than eat the loss on his own non-refundable Regular Adult ticket—which was completely valid for solo travel with zero questions from the conductors—he got on the northbound train alone Saturday evening," Special Agent Morales picked up, turning his heavy black agency laptop forty-five degrees toward Dad, Katie, and me. "He thought routing to Detroit and taking the city tunnel bus into Ontario instead of riding the cross-border Maple Leaf train in New York would keep his name off an advance electronic rail manifest sent to the newly formed Canada Border Services Agency. Watch what actually happened to him on Sunday afternoon at four-fifteen."

Wednesday, October 20, 2004, 2:20 PM — Ripped Tickets on East Jefferson Avenue, Rejected Dimes, 555 Goyeau Street, & Arrest on Cass Avenue

Katie's blue eyes widened as Agent Morales scrolled through the scanned federal border packet uploaded jointly by the Canada Border Services Agency and United States Customs and Border Protection.

"According to his own statement in Secondary Inspection, Mr. Mercer stepped off the connecting rail bus in downtown Detroit on Sunday afternoon fuming over the unused Regular Adult paper ticket in Katie's name still sitting in his jacket," Morales explained, pointing to the narrative log. "Afraid Canadian border officers might search his coat, find a nineteen-year-old Virginia woman's unused one-way ticket, and run a missing-persons check—and apparently unaware that unused ARTS paper stock often retains exchangeable residual value at a staffed counter—he stood at the curbside bus stop on East Jefferson Avenue in downtown Detroit, ripped Katie's hundred-plus-dollar ticket and his travel receipt into pieces in sheer anger and disgust, and threw them into a municipal trash barrel right before the Transit Windsor Tunnel Bus pulled up."

Dad let out a stunned whistle behind us. "He literally threw half his money into a trash can on East Jefferson Avenue?"

"And the Transit Windsor farebox took the rest of it sixty seconds later," Morales said with the faintest trace of a dry smile. "Because Transit Windsor is a Canadian municipal agency picking up curbside in Detroit, their fareboxes accept American dollars only at a strict one-to-one par rate with zero change and zero change cards, and their Canadian coin mechanism automatically rejects American dimes and gold-colored American dollar coins. When Mr. Mercer dropped loose American dimes and a dollar coin into the slot and they clattered straight through into the reject cup while the driver told him to pay exact fare or step off, he angrily shoved his last ten-dollar American bill into the no-change bill feeder just to get across the river."

"How much money did he have left when the bus came out of the tunnel in Canada?" I asked.

"One crumpled American dollar bill, three quarters, and four rejected American dimes," Agent Morales replied, clicking open the property inventory logged at 35 Park Street East in downtown Windsor, Ontario, right off the 555 Goyeau Street tunnel plaza and Wyandotte Street East. "Without a single international train

manifest needed, Mr. Mercer lit up every behavioral flag at the primary booth inside 555 Goyeau Street: a twenty-two-year-old man from six hundred miles away in Williamsburg, Virginia riding a local commuter bus with a packed duffel bag, zero travel receipts because he had just trashed them across the river, no hotel reservation on Goyeau Street or Wyandotte Street East, no return ticket to the United States, and one dollar and seventy-five cents in spendable cash. And because he had thrown Katie's ticket away to hide why he came north, he couldn't even spin a story about a girlfriend stranding him without confessing what he had tried to do in Virginia."

"What did he tell the Canadian officers?" Katie asked quietly.

"Cornered in Secondary Inspection inside 35 Park Street East, he lost his temper and blustered about staying in Ontario to look for work where healthcare was free," Morales said, shaking his head. "Within five minutes, CBSA found him statutorily inadmissible under Sections 20 and 39 of Canada's Immigration and Refugee Protection Act for failing to prove he would leave Canada and for total financial inadmissibility—plus citing Ontario's strict residency rules barring visitors from provincial healthcare. Because he didn't even have three dollars and fifty cents left to pay his own return bus fare under Canadian law, two CBSA officers escorted him onto a custodial return Tunnel Bus back beneath the Detroit River and handed his exclusion file straight to United States Customs and Border Protection at East Jefferson Avenue and Randolph Street in downtown Detroit."

"And that's when our customs officers opened his duffel bag?" Dad asked.

"Under Title 19, Section 1582 of the United States Code, every person returned from a foreign port of entry undergoes a mandatory warrantless border search," Morales nodded, tapping the thick federal indictment packet beside his laptop. "Hidden under his clothes at the Randolph Street compound, CBP forensic officers uncovered two external hard drives packed with skimmed hospitality credit-card magnetic-stripe dumps and stolen guest identity profiles from Williamsburg—turning your local domestic assault and unlawful restraint report into a multi-district federal wire-fraud and interstate coercion prosecution. After CBP logged the drives and released him onto Randolph Street in the cold rain Sunday evening with a dollar seventy-five in his pocket, he walked nine blocks northwest to a brick men's homeless shelter on Cass Avenue. Yesterday afternoon, once our Norfolk and Detroit warrants cleared NCIC, two Deputy United States Marshals walked up to the intake line on Cass Avenue and put Brandon Mercer in federal handcuffs without incident."

Wednesday, October 20, 2004, 2:40 PM — "Protected Non-Traveling Complainant (V-W, Zero Infraction)"

Agent Morales slid the printed twelve-page federal summary packet across the oak conference table so Katie could read the bottom box for herself.

"Because the Williamsburg ARTS station computer preserved the original two-passenger cash PNR pairing his name with yours before he threw the paper stub into that Detroit trash bin, Miss Prairie, his own transaction corroborated your statement from start to finish," Morales added kindly, tapping the bottom line of the federal printout. "And just so your mind is completely at ease—look right here at how you are listed in the system: protected non-traveling complainant."

Beside me, Katie's fingers tightened around my hand on the armrest as her blue eyes locked onto that four-word label. For someone whose autistic mind ran on exact, literal rules, an unfamiliar government phrase in a federal border computer wasn't reassuring until every single word was defined down to the syllable.

"Wait—what does protected non-traveling complainant mean?" Katie asked, sitting up straighter in her SwiftChair as she looked directly at Special Agent Morales. "Does having my name in the ARTS reservation record and the Customs and Border Protection file mean I'm flagged? Did Nate and I break a railroad or border rule because Brandon put my name on a ticket to Detroit that I didn't use? If Nate and I ever get passports one day and want to ride a train into Canada together, are the border officers going to think I did something wrong?"

Seeing how intently she was staring at the code box, Agent Morales didn't wave her concern away. He turned the page completely toward her, rested the tip of his pen directly beneath the printed line, and walked through the statutory wording one piece at a time.

"Let's read each word literally, Miss Prairie, because every word on this form has a strict legal definition," Morales said calmly. "First, non-traveling certifies that both the United States and Canadian governments have verified you never boarded that train, never left the Commonwealth of Virginia, and never set foot near the Detroit-Windsor border. You and your brother were riding local transit buses home to Virginia Beach six hundred miles away while Mr. Mercer rode north alone."

Katie nodded once, her shoulders easing slightly, though her gaze stayed fixed on the paper. "And complainant?"

"Complainant is the legal word for the innocent victim and witness bringing the complaint against the person who broke the law," the Williamsburg detective explained gently. "Your name only appears in the evidence file as the person he targeted—the exact same way a bank's name appears in a bank robbery report. Nobody charges the bank for getting robbed, Miss Prairie."

"And protected is the best word on the whole page," Agent Morales finished, pointing to the status code printed beside her name: *V-W, Zero Infraction*. "That Protected Victim-Witness firewall attaches a permanent legal shield to your identity. First, it certifies on the permanent record that you and your brother broke zero federal laws, zero state laws, zero Canadian immigration laws, and zero rail tariff rules. Not a felony, not a misdemeanor, not even a civil warning. And second, if the two of you ever get United States Passports and cross into Canada together ten months or twenty years from now, your traveler profiles are one hundred percent clean."

Katie stared down at those printed words—*V-W, Zero Infraction*—reading them silently three times until the literal rule clicked into permanent place inside her head.

Letting out a long, quiet breath, my nineteen-year-old twin sister looked sideways at me with clear blue eyes and gave my hand a firm squeeze.

"Zero infraction," Katie murmured softly, satisfied at last. "We didn't break a single rule, Nate."

“Not a single one, sis,” I smiled back, squeezing her fingers while Dad rested both warm hands on our shoulders. “And the guy who did is sitting in a federal detention cell up in Michigan while you and I go home for dinner on Arvin Road.”

Tiffany’s Sea Breeze West Apartment, Dirty Old Tonomy Hill, & Coming Home to Arvin Road

Part 1: Chapters & Co. After Williamsburg & Tiffany Sloan Invites Both Twins Into Sea Breeze West

Date: 2004-11-05 at 15:15 America/New_York

Friday, November 5, 2004, 3:15 PM — Falling Style Sheets at Chapters & Co. & Umbrellas Over Both Joysticks

“Whoa—careful! Death by cascading style sheets is a terrible way to start a Friday weekend!” a bright, playful voice laughed right beside my right wheel inside the Computer & Internet aisle of Chapters & Co. at The Admiral Center.

I blinked and pulled my fingers back from the upper-middle bookshelf just as a girl who looked to be about twenty—with a heavier build, shoulder-length dark reddish-brown hair cut in neat bangs above black-rimmed rectangular glasses, and a warm, friendly grin—caught a falling eight-hundred-page copy of *Cascading Style Sheets & Dynamic Web Design* cleanly in midair before it could land across my knees.

“Thank you,” I said, feeling my ears warm slightly as she tucked the extra copy back onto the oak shelf and handed the first copy comfortably into my hands at chest height. Parked two inches to my left with a cardboard carrier holding two cups of hot cocoa on her lap tray—never letting more than arm’s reach come between our two SwiftChairs in public now after surviving three and a half months at Brandon Mercer’s house up in Williamsburg—Katie smiled politely across my armrest too.

“Those programming books are practically cinder blocks,” an older woman with a pleasant smile remarked, stepping up behind the girl with a bookstore tote bag over her arm.

“I’m Tiffany, by the way—Tiffany Sloan, and this is my mom, Sandra,” the girl said, shaking my hand and then reaching smoothly across to shake Katie’s free hand with zero awkwardness at seeing two identical compact powerchairs side by side. “Wait—do both of you actually write real website code from scratch?”

“Since seventh grade at Morrison Middle School,” I said, my shyness melting the second HTML and CSS entered the conversation. “Katie and I just transferred all our fall CCHR coursework back down to the Norfolk and Virginia Beach campuses three weeks ago, and we’re converting our old table layouts to stylesheets.”

“Are you serious?! That is amazing!” Tiffany beamed, placing a hand over her heart as she looked back and forth between Katie and me. “Wait—you two take your college classes together and go everywhere together? My younger brother and I are super close too. Honestly, I always say family comes first, no matter what. If a guy isn’t close with his sister, that’s a giant red flag in my book!”

Even with our guard much higher after October, hearing someone say out loud that a brother and sister sticking together came first—and watching Tiffany clear two heavy wooden café chairs out of our way at a round table two minutes later without making a fuss—made my chest feel lighter than it had in months. Forty minutes later, when we rolled out the mall's sliding glass doors toward Monticello Avenue into a sudden chilly November rain shower, Tiffany popped open her compact umbrella straight over my head and my right-hand joystick controller while her mom Sandra opened a wide navy golf umbrella over Katie's head and joystick all the way to the covered Route 20 bus shelter—handing me her phone number on the back of a cardstock bookmark before our bus arrived.

Saturday, November 20, 2004, 2:00 PM — Why Commute From Kempsville When Both of You Can Stay at Sea Breeze West?

Over the next two weekends, Tiffany couldn't have acted sweeter toward both of us. When her mom dropped her off at Dad's brick ranch on Arvin Road off Indian River Road and Military Highway with extra-cheese pizza and a two-liter bottle of cold ginger ale—remembering from our very first bookstore chat that neither Katie nor I touched alcohol or coffee—Tiffany knelt right down on the living-room carpet between our two wheelchairs to look at HTML files at eye level, laughed warmly whenever Katie and I finished each other's sentences, and treated Dad with total courtesy.

Then, on the Saturday afternoon before Thanksgiving, after watching Katie and me groan over the printed CVTA Virginia Beach schedule showing how early the connecting buses out of Kempsville shut down every evening—and how Sunday bus service into our neighborhood didn't exist at all—Tiffany set down her plastic cup of ginger ale with a bright, helpful smile.

"Wait a second—why are the two of you putting yourselves through two-hour Virginia Beach bus transfers and early evening curfews every day when I literally have a ground-floor apartment sitting half-empty up in West Ocean View?" Tiffany asked, looking warmly from me to Katie. "I lease Apartment 3 on the first floor at Sea Breeze West right off West Ocean View Avenue and Duffy's Lane. CVTA Route 1 stops right at the corner—running every fifteen to thirty minutes all day and straight through the night until two-fifteen in the morning, seven days a week!"

Katie and I glanced at each other across our armrests immediately, remembering the ironclad vow we had made on the Route 61 bus under the Chesapeake Bay five weeks earlier.

"Nate and I don't split up, Tiffany," Katie said clearly and politely, resting her hand squarely over mine. "Not for apartments, not for college, and not for relationships. Wherever one of us lives, both of us live."

"Well, duh—I meant *both* of you!" Tiffany laughed without missing half a beat, reaching out to pat Katie's forearm reassuringly. "Why on earth would I ever ask twins as close as you two to split up? Apartment 3 has a wide step-free front door right off the courtyard, an open living room and kitchen where Nate can set up his desktop computer on the dining table, a big bright-green three-cushion sofa under the front blinds, a wide hallway closet, and a step-free bathroom with steel grab bars

on the tub! You don't even have to sign a lease or change your Virginia Beach IDs—it's already my apartment! Bring your computers, a week or two of clothes, and your sleeping bag, and come stay with me in Ocean View!"

Sitting around the dining table with Dad that evening, the safety math looked totally different from Williamsburg. West Ocean View wasn't forty-five miles across the harbor on unfamiliar Peninsula routes; it sat right inside Norfolk on CVTA Route 1, twenty-two minutes up Interstate 64 from Dad's driveway on Arvin Road. Our bedrooms, our main furniture, and our legal address stayed anchored right at Dad's house; both Katie and I now carried matching silver flip phones clipped inside our lap bags right alongside the laminated calling cards tucked behind our State IDs; and above all, Katie and I would be right beside each other twenty-four hours a day.

Because I hadn't had a girlfriend look at me with stars in her eyes since Heather Collins dumped me in high school—and because Katie didn't want her own awful experience with Brandon to stop me from having a chance to be happy as long as the two of us stayed together—we loaded my Quantum OS XN Pro desktop tower, our two CCHR laptops, two suitcases of clothes, our battery chargers, and our shared navy-blue closet sleeping bag and pillows into Dad's pickup truck that Sunday afternoon, rolling side by side across the step-free threshold of Tiffany's ground-floor apartment at Sea Breeze West with our thirty-day CVTA bus passes tucked right inside our wallets.

Part 2: The Worst Christmas Ever: Eighteen Stops to Dirty Old Tonomy Hill, Four Days with Cousin Chelsea, & The West Main Road Shortcut Home

Date: 2004-12-24 at 15:30 America/New_York

Friday, December 24, 2004, 3:30 PM — Eighteen Stops to Dirty Old Tonomy Hill & The Mask Slipping in the Cold

"Oh, great—another girl," twenty-year-old Tiffany muttered with a sharp, ugly edge in her voice as the blue-and-white Ocean State Transit Authority Route 63 bus hissed away from the curb on Dirty Old Tonomy Hill on Friday afternoon, Christmas Eve, leaving Katie, Tiffany, and me in the biting Rhode Island December wind outside the weathered World War II-era public housing buildings.

"I already told you, Tiffany, all of our cousins are women—there really aren't any other guys our age in our family," I replied wearily from my compact SwiftChair while Katie reached across the narrow gap between our wheelchairs in her thick winter parka and squeezed my gloved fingers.

We were in Newport, Rhode Island—our dad David's birthplace and childhood home—at the tail end of a bone-rattling overnight and daylong Pathfinder bus marathon up the Eastern Seaboard. Because our Aunt Elizabeth had died earlier in 2004 from lifelong smoking not long after our Grandma Ruth passed away, our twenty-two-year-old paternal cousin Chelsea was facing her very first Christmas without her mother. Dad had bought round-trip Pathfinder tickets for Katie and me so Chelsea wouldn't spend Christmas Eve crying alone—and the second Tiffany heard Katie and I were taking a four-day trip together without her, Tiffany had flatly refused to stay behind in Norfolk and insisted on tagging along on our holiday visit.

Getting two powerchairs from Norfolk to Newport on Christmas Eve had been an eighteen-stop haul across four separate terminal transfers where drivers had to cycle the coach wheelchair lift twice at every gate: starting downtown in Norfolk, crossing the harbor to Hampton and stopping briefly in Williamsburg and Richmond, changing buses for Fredericksburg, Springfield, and Washington, changing a second time to crawl off Interstate 95 onto Interstate 395 through block after block of Downtown Baltimore traffic lights on West Fayette Street before rolling up through Newark, Delaware and Philadelphia into the crowded subterranean gates of Manhattan's Port Authority Bus Terminal, changing a third time up the Connecticut coast through Bridgeport, New Haven, Braxton, and Providence into Boston's South Station, and changing a fourth time down through Fall River, Massachusetts into the Newport Gateway Center to board local OSTA Route 63.

Before Tiffany could snap another remark about Katie and me sitting together on the bus, the front door of the nearest weathered building swung open.

"Nate! Katie! Welcome to Newport!" cried a slurred, overjoyed voice as our twenty-two-year-old cousin Chelsea hurried down the low wooden entry ramp with her familiar uneven gait, dropped down between our two wheelchairs, and threw one arm around my neck and the other around Katie's shoulders in a tight squeeze hug. "I'm s-so happy you came for Christmas!"

A tear spilled from the corner of Chelsea's eye. Aunt Liz's heavy smoking during pregnancy was the reason Chelsea had been born developmentally disabled, with a severe speech impediment and chronic asthma requiring her to carry both her daily maintenance inhaler and her rescue inhaler everywhere—yet Aunt Liz was still her mama, and missing her weighed heavily on Chelsea's heart.

"So you really like *my* boyfriend, huh?" Tiffany asked beside us, curling her lip in open disgust as Chelsea hugged me again.

"Nate an' Katie are my only family, my only cousins!" Chelsea answered innocently through her speech impediment, completely missing the venom behind Tiffany's tone as she led the three of us up the interior ramp into her small ground-floor apartment. "Make yourselves cozy on the couch! I gotta take a shower real quick."

The second the bathroom door clicked shut and the shower water turned on, Tiffany whirled around in the middle of Chelsea's living room, her face dark red behind her black-rimmed glasses as she glared at Katie and me parked wheel-to-wheel near the sofa.

"First your twin sister holds your hand across every bus aisle from Virginia to Massachusetts, and now your cousin can't keep her hands off you either!" Tiffany started screaming at the top of her lungs.

"Keep your voice down, Tiffany—you're in Chelsea's home, and she doesn't understand adult arguments!" Katie warned sharply, braking her chair half an inch forward to shield my left side right as the bathroom door flew wide open.

Because the sound of Tiffany screaming at us through the thin drywall had terrified Chelsea into thinking someone was hurting her cousins—and because Chelsea's developmental disability meant she genuinely did not grasp abstract modesty rules

when someone she loved sounded in danger—Chelsea came bolting straight out of the shower soaking wet and completely naked, dripping soapy water onto the carpet without the faintest awareness that she had zero clothes on.

“W-why are you yelling at Nate an’ Katie?!” Chelsea gasped in a frightened, wheezing voice.

Tiffany recoiled and shrieked in outrage—growing twice as furious when neither Katie nor I acted shocked at all. Keeping my eyes respectfully turned toward the hallway wall while Katie rolled smoothly forward to pull a thick dry bath towel off the linen shelf, both of us remembered from childhood visits—like Christmas 1994 when we were nine—that Chelsea didn’t always understand why she needed clothes on inside a safe house, and that our family always guided her gently and patiently without shaming her.

“It’s okay, Chelsea—nobody’s hurt, sweetheart, let’s get you dried off and warm in your pajamas,” Katie said in the calmest, most loving voice imaginable, wrapping the big fluffy towel all the way around Chelsea’s shoulders to protect her dignity and guiding her gently back into the bathroom while Chelsea took a shaky puff from her rescue inhaler by the sink.

“I wish it was j-just you an’ Nate,” we heard Chelsea whimper against Katie’s shoulder behind the bathroom door. “She’s scary!”

Friday, December 24 – Monday, December 27, 2004 — Locked Safe Inside Chelsea’s Bedroom & The West Main Road Shortcut Home

Right after Christmas Eve supper, Tiffany leaned close to the kitchen counter and hissed loud enough for the whole room to hear: “She has a crush on you, Nathaniel, and it’s sick. First your sister, now her—I’m starting to wonder where your loyalties are!”

“Don’t you dare talk about our cousin like that!” I snapped, my patience finally breaking as Chelsea stood by the sink with fat tears rolling down her cheeks. “Look—you made her cry! Her mother died, our Grandma Ruth died, and Katie and I are the closest family she has left! Because of her disability, Chelsea doesn’t know the difference between family love and romantic love—she hugs Katie and me the exact same way she did when we were eight years old!”

Sobbing heavily and wheezing around her breath, Chelsea grabbed Katie’s sleeve with one hand and my sleeve with the other, tugging both of our wheelchairs down the short hall into her bedroom.

“Just Nate an’ Katie!” Chelsea sobbed fiercely when Tiffany marched down the hall trying to follow us in. The instant Katie’s rear wheels cleared the doorframe beside mine, Chelsea slammed her bedroom door straight in Tiffany’s face and twisted the brass thumb-lock shut.

“Mean Tiffany stay out! Only Katie an’ Nate!” Chelsea cried, reaching for her puffers on the dresser before tugging off her damp sweater to climb under the covers—blurting out through her tears that she didn’t care about pajamas because she

always slept naked anyway, until Katie gently tucked Chelsea's soft pink cotton nightshirt over her head and helped her pull the heavy quilt all the way up to her chin so she stayed warm and covered.

Terrified that if Katie and I rolled back out into the living room Tiffany would scream at us all night long, Chelsea clung to Katie's hand and mine and begged both of us not to unlock the door. Every single night of that three-night stay—Christmas Eve, Christmas night, and Sunday night—Katie and I transferred out of our SwiftChairs fully dressed in our sweaters and jeans and curled up side by side along the outer edge of the quilt holding Chelsea's hands until her asthmatic breathing slowed into sleep, leaving a furious Tiffany banished alone on the living-room sofa outside.

When Monday morning, December 27 finally arrived and we packed up to leave, Chelsea glanced down at our printed Pathfinder return tickets—and even with her developmental delays, spotted a timetable disaster immediately. Our itinerary started at the Newport Gateway Center on a local run to Fall River, Massachusetts with only a five-minute transfer window to catch the connecting coach to Providence. Unloading two powerchairs on a hydraulic lift in Fall River in five minutes was physically impossible; we would miss the Providence bus cold.

"D-don't take Fall River bus!" Chelsea told us earnestly at the top of her wooden ramp, hugging Katie and me tight while ignoring Tiffany completely. "Take OSTA Sixty right out on West Main Road—goes straight over bridge to Providence Kennedy Plaza, whole hour early!"

Whispering a quiet promise in Chelsea's ear as Katie and I hugged her goodbye—*Next time we come up, Cous, I swear it really will be just Katie and me, zero Tiffany*—we rolled out to West Main Road, rode OSTA Route 60 straight into Providence with forty-five minutes to spare, and rolled all the way back down the Eastern Seaboard to Norfolk side by side, knowing now beyond a shadow of a doubt who Tiffany Sloan really was behind her black-rimmed glasses.

Part 3: Milk Isn't Allowed in This Fridge, Tiffany's Sunday Morning Accusation, & Yes-or-No Questions Through Tears

Date: 2005-11-13 at 08:30 America/New_York

Autumn 2005 — No Milk in the Fridge, Pots in the Bathtub, & The Brick Wall Inside Tiffany's Hallway Closet

"Get that carton away from my refrigerator right now, Nathaniel—I told you milk is nasty, and milk is not allowed inside my apartment!" twenty-one-year-old Tiffany barked from the kitchen doorway of Apartment 3 at Sea Breeze West one evening that autumn, snatching the cold plastic half-gallon of two-percent milk straight off my lap tray and pouring the entire unopened jug down the greasy stainless-steel sink drain while Katie and I sat frozen side by side in our compact black SwiftChairs.

Once the holiday trip to Newport peeled Tiffany's polite mask completely off, living inside her ground-floor apartment on West Ocean View Avenue across 2005 turned into a slow, suffocating grind of filth, arbitrary rules, and behind-closed-doors intimidation. Whenever nobody from outside could see through the front window blinds, Tiffany dropped every ounce of the sweet bookstore persona she had used at Chapters & Co. She refused to carry trash out to the dumpster behind the building,

leaving tied-up white plastic garbage bags slumped along the kitchen baseboard, and whenever the two-basin sink filled up with crusted skillets and hardened macaroni pots, she simply stacked the dirty pots and pans straight onto the porcelain floor of the bathroom tub rather than wash a single dish.

Worse than the filth was the way she went after our autism and our wheelchairs whenever she didn't get her way. If my fingers tapped quietly against my armrest while reading a CCHR textbook, or if Katie rocked her shoulders half an inch to self-regulate after a loud Route 1 bus ride, Tiffany mocked our movements to our faces and snapped that we acted like toddlers instead of twenty-year-olds. Behind closed doors, when she wanted past us in the narrow hallway instead of waiting two seconds for us to back up, she grabbed the push-handles or armrests of our SwiftChairs and shoved our wheelchairs roughly against the drywall, or caught Katie sharply by the upper arm when Katie rolled between us to defend me—always followed ten minutes later by the exact same manipulative lecture Brandon Mercer had used in Williamsburg: that "real adults in relationships" didn't run tattling to their fathers or cling to their twin siblings all evening.

Out on the breezy concrete courtyard walkway one afternoon while Tiffany was at work, Katie braked her chair flush against mine, looked straight into my eyes, and drew a hard line in the sand.

"Nate, I'm only staying under this roof because I refuse to leave you alone with her for five minutes," Katie whispered fiercely, squeezing my hand. "If she ever brings up the word marriage—even as a joke—I'm going to sit in the front pew of that church right up until the minister says *Speak now or forever hold your peace*, and I am rolling straight down the center aisle screaming *NO* at the top of my lungs!"

"You wouldn't even have to scream it alone, sis—I'd be rolling right beside you out the church doors," I whispered back.

Because Katie and I had learned our lesson in Williamsburg—and because we unconditionally prioritized each other over everyone else on earth—Tiffany ran headfirst into an unbreakable brick wall every night at bedtime. Her queen mattress in the doorless back bedroom had sagged into a deep, sour-smelling trough down the middle, and when Tiffany demanded that I leave Katie alone and sleep beside her in that caving-in bed while Katie slept out by the front desk, I flatly refused. Every single night without fail, Katie and I parked our two SwiftChairs side by side in the straight right-hand hallway, pulled open the two white bi-fold doors of Tiffany's three-by-six hallway closet beneath the wire pantry shelves and hanging winter coats, and transferred fully clothed in clean T-shirts and sweatpants down into our single shared navy-blue sleeping bag and two white pillows—zipping the bag up and pulling the bi-fold doors nearly shut from the inside so we could hold each other safely in the pitch dark.

Sunday, November 13, 2005, 8:30 AM — Tiffany's Filthy Lie, The Family Life Rule, & Yes-or-No Questions Over a Flip Phone

On Sunday morning, November 13, 2005, at half past eight, Katie and I were sitting wheel-to-wheel at the edge of the kitchen eating dry toasted-oat cereal out of plastic bowls without milk—wearing clean weekend shirts after transferring out of the hallway closet twenty minutes earlier—when Tiffany stomped down the short carpeted hall in her black-rimmed glasses and mint-green tee.

On her way past the left wall of the hallway, Tiffany's foot caught the open louver of the white bi-fold closet door, where our unzipped navy-blue sleeping bag and two indented white pillows were still laid lengthwise across the closet carpet.

Tiffany stopped dead, kicked the bi-fold closet door so hard the top track rattled in its metal channel, and spun into the kitchen in front of the greasy stove and black top-freezer refrigerator with her face twisted dark red.

"I have had it—I am *done* with the two of you!" Tiffany shrieked at the top of her lungs, slamming her palm against the edge of the stove so violently our cereal spoons jumped in our bowls. "Eleven months of your weird little hand-holding, eleven months of your stupid wheelchairs blocking my hallway, eleven months of you refusing to sleep in my bed like a normal boyfriend because you'd rather crawl into a dark closet on the floor with your twin sister!"

Katie flinched hard beside me, her hand flying across our armrests to grip my fingers as both of our chests tightened against the sudden ear-splitting volume in the tiny room. "Tiffany, please stop yelling—"

"Shut up! Don't talk to me like I'm stupid!" Tiffany screamed, leaning forward across the linoleum and hurling the ugliest, filthiest accusation either of us had ever heard in our twenty years of life. "I know why the two of you lock yourselves inside that closet every night and every single afternoon whenever I'm not here! You two are having *sex* in my closet behind my back! You're a pair of sick, disgusting freaks —pack nothing, get your wheelchairs out that front door right now, and don't ever come back into my apartment!"

For three seconds, the words hit Katie and me like a physical blow across the face.

Katie and I did *not* have sex. We had never touched each other that way once in our entire lives, and the very thought made both of our stomachs lurch with bewildered horror. Ever since we had sat side by side in Family Life Education classes back in Virginia Beach public schools, our literal autistic minds had learned the clear, absolute rule taught by our teachers: brother and sister are not supposed to have sex. Neither Katie nor I actually understood *why* neurotypical society had made that rule —just as half of humanity's unspoken romantic rules made zero logical sense to us —because to the two of us, zipping fully clothed into a dark, snug three-by-six closet to hold hands and hug away nightmares was pure sensory safety and had nothing on earth to do with sex. We simply obeyed the Family Life rule one hundred percent literally because a rule was a rule.

Having someone scream in our faces that our lifelong safe harbor was dirty— accusing us at top volume of breaking a rule we had faithfully kept our whole lives while throwing us out onto the concrete with zero warning—blew every circuit in both of our autistic nervous systems at the exact same instant.

“Out! Get out of Apartment 3 *now*!” Tiffany roared, yanking the front door wide open to the cold forty-six-degree November wind off the Chesapeake Bay and shoving the back of my SwiftChair headrest toward the concrete threshold.

Trembling violently, Katie and I drove our wheelchairs out over the low concrete lip onto the open exterior walkway as Tiffany slammed the hollow-core door shut behind our rear caster wheels and threw the deadbolt with a loud metallic *clack*.

Out on the cold concrete breezeway of Sea Breeze West—on a Sunday morning when CVTA ran zero Sunday bus service across the city line toward Kempsville and Arvin Road—both Katie and I crashed headlong into a full-blown autistic meltdown.

Tears poured hot and fast down Katie’s cheeks as she bent double over her lap with ragged, gasping sobs, her left hand clamping over her ear while her right hand crushed my fingers across our armrests. My own throat locked shut in complete situational mutism; every time I tried to force air past my vocal cords to tell Katie we were going to be okay, nothing came out except choked, heaving cries and hyperventilating gasps.

Remembering the silver flip phones Dad had bought for both of us right after Williamsburg—kept clipped inside my jacket pocket alongside the laminated prepaid calling card behind my Virginia ID—I fumbled my phone open with shaking fingers, pressed and held the number-one key for Dad’s house on Arvin Road, and pressed the warm plastic earpiece right between Katie’s wet cheek and mine so we could both hear him.

The line rang twice—and then our forty-seven-year-old father picked up in Virginia Beach.

“Hey, Nate—good Sunday morning, kiddo!” Dad’s warm voice answered brightly, before dropping immediately into razor-sharp focus at the sound of two voices sobbing uncontrollably into the tiny microphone. “Nate? Katie? Kids, talk to me—what’s wrong?”

“Uhh—uhh—” I gasped, my chest hitching so hard around tears that not a single consonant would form, while Katie sobbed helplessly against my shoulder right beside the phone.

A stranger would have panicked or barked ten complicated questions at once. Dad didn’t. Dad had raised two autistic twins by himself since we were thirteen years old, and he recognized the sound of a total sensory and verbal shutdown in two heartbeats flat. Because an audio flip phone had no camera to see us nod or shake our heads, Dad dropped his voice an octave—slow, steady, and anchor-calm—and switched immediately to simple, one-at-a-time yes-or-no questions where two small sounds were all we had to manage.

“Okay, sweetheart, okay, buddy—listen to Dad’s voice, you don’t have to talk in words right now,” Dad said gently and clearly over the line. “Take one slow breath with me. I’m only going to ask you yes-or-no questions, one at a time. Just give me *mm-hmm* for yes, or *uh-uh* for no. Can you do that for Dad?”

Pressing my forehead against Katie’s temple around the flip phone, both of us managed a shaky, tear-choked *“Mm-hmm.”*

“Good job—I heard that loud and clear,” Dad said calmly. “Question one: are either of you bleeding, hit, or physically hurt right now? *Mm-hmm* for yes, *uh-uh* for no.”

“Uh-uh,” I choked out through my tears as Katie whimpered *“Uh-uh”* beside me—though a hard sob blurred the middle of Katie’s sound.

Dad didn’t guess or rush ahead. “Katie bug, your tears caught on that one and I want to be one hundred percent sure,” Dad checked gently. “Give me one more clear *uh-uh* if nobody is hurt.”

Katie sucked in a trembling breath through her nose and pressed her lips near the mouthpiece. *“Uh-uh.”*

“Thank God. Question two,” Dad continued at the exact same unhurried pace, though we could already hear the jingle of his truck keys being lifted off the kitchen hook on Arvin Road in the background. “Are the two of you right beside each other in your wheelchairs right now?”

“Mm-hmm,” we whispered together.

“Question three: are you at Tiffany’s apartment at Sea Breeze West on West Ocean View Avenue?”

“Mm-hmm.”

“Question four: I hear wind in the microphone—are the two of you outside away from her right now?”

“Mm-hmm.”

“Question five,” Dad said quietly, the steel tightening underneath his calm fatherly voice. “Did Tiffany blow up at you and throw you out?”

Katie let out a broken sob against my collarbone as both of us cried out at once: *“Mm-hmm! Uh-huh!”*

“Last question, kids,” Dad said firmly, the heavy garage door on Arvin Road rumbling open behind him as he climbed into his extended-cab pickup truck. “Do you want me to come straight up Interstate 64 right this minute with the folding ramps, pack every single thing you own out of Apartment 3, and bring both of you home to Arvin Road for good?”

“Mm-hmm!” Katie and I sobbed into the flip phone together, clinging to each other’s sleeves in the cold bay wind. *“Uh-huh!”*

“I’m backing out of the driveway right now—twenty-four minutes door to door,” Dad promised softly, switching his phone onto his dashboard speaker as his truck engine turned over. “Roll back under the covered breezeway out of the wind, lock your brakes side by side, and hold onto each other. Don’t hang up—I’m staying right here on the line breathing with you the whole drive up.”

Sunday, November 13, 2005, 9:05 AM — Dad's Pickup Truck, Leaving Zero Trace Behind, & Cold Milk Home on Arvin Road

True to his word, twenty-three minutes later Dad's pickup truck swung into the asphalt lot of Sea Breeze West with the two folding aluminum wheelchair ramps rattling softly in the bed.

Before he even looked toward Apartment 3, Dad cut the engine, strode straight up the concrete walkway in his flannel jacket, and dropped onto both knees right between our two SwiftChairs—wrapping one strong arm around Katie's trembling shoulders and the other around mine, pulling both of our heads in against his chest until the last waves of our meltdown finally subsided into quiet, exhausted hiccups.

"I've got you both," Dad murmured into our hair, kissing Katie's forehead and squeezing the back of my neck. "Wait right here in the warm cab of the truck with the heater running. You never have to step inside that door again."

Unfolding the aluminum ramps to guide our SwiftChairs safely up into the spacious extended cab and strapping our frames down in the back, Dad turned, walked calmly up to Apartment 3, and knocked twice with the heel of his fist.

When Tiffany cracked the door expecting to gloat—and instead found a broad-shouldered forty-seven-year-old Navy-town systems engineer staring silently down through his glasses at her—every ounce of bluster drained right out of her face. Dad didn't scream, curse, or dignify her frantic, backpedaling excuses with a single argument. In forty methodical minutes of dead fatherly silence, Dad carried out my 2004 desktop computer tower, our seventeen-inch CRT monitor, both laptops, our CCHR textbooks, Katie's wooden dresser and television and DVD player, every hanger of our clothes, both 24-volt wheelchair chargers, and—last of all—our shared navy-blue sleeping bag and two white pillows straight out of Tiffany's hallway closet, loading and tarping every cord neatly in the pickup bed until zero trace of Katie or me remained on West Ocean View Avenue.

By eleven-thirty that Sunday morning, our wheels were rolling across the spotless oak-and-tile floors of Dad's quiet single-story brick ranch on Arvin Road in Virginia Beach.

Before unloading a single box of books, Dad walked straight to his gleaming white refrigerator, pulled out an ice-cold plastic gallon of two-percent milk, and set it square in the center of the clean kitchen table in front of two fresh bowls of cereal and sliced bananas.

"In your own home," Dad said softly, pouring tall glasses of cold white milk for both of us and resting a steady hand on each of our shoulders, "nobody ever yells at you for who you are, nobody ever tries to close a door between the two of you, and there is always cold milk in the fridge. This house is yours for as long as you want it."

Later that week, once our tears had dried and we had wiped every trace of Tiffany off my Quantum OS XN Pro hard drive, Dad took Katie and me up to Chesapeake Bay Mall to pick out a brand-new queen mattress and a soft navy-and-slate-blue queen comforter set so we could share the big sunny back bedroom on Arvin Road together instead of splitting into separate rooms—and when bedtime came each night and Katie and I still tucked our shared navy-blue sleeping bag and two pillows

onto the clean carpeted floor of that bedroom's three-by-six closet instead of using the mattress, Dad simply smiled from the hallway, wished us goodnight, and let us heal in peace.

Part 4: Thanksgiving Dinner Home on Arvin Road, The Black Friday Closet Sanctuary, & Quietly Launching Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit

Date: 2005-11-24 at 13:00 America/New_York

Thursday, November 24 – Friday, November 25, 2005 — Thanksgiving Dinner Home on Arvin Road & Engineering the Closet Above Our Sleeping Bag

"Smell that roasting bird!" Dad smiled from the stove of our single-story brick ranch on Arvin Road off Military Highway and Indian River Road as Katie and I rolled our compact SwiftChairs down the hallway into the warm, cinnamon-and-sage-scented kitchen at one o'clock on Thanksgiving afternoon.

Eleven days of uninterrupted quiet back under Dad's roof—eating at a scrubbed table, charging our wheelchairs side by side every night without anyone unplugging our cords, and commuting together to our classes at CCHR—had already put color back in Katie's cheeks and steadied both of our hands. While Katie braked beside the counter to take the wooden spoon to the steaming bowl of mashed potatoes and I arranged silverware and folded napkins along the long side of the dining-room table where our two wheelchairs rolled up flush together, there were zero eggshells left under our tires—just our forty-seven-year-old father and his twenty-year-old twins home safe together.

Twenty minutes later, with platters of carved roast turkey, herb stuffing, mashed potatoes and gravy, cranberry sauce, buttered rolls, and green beans spread across the tablecloth, Dad raised his tall glass of iced tea and looked warmly between Katie and me behind his glasses.

"After watching the two of you weather Williamsburg last fall and Ocean View this year without ever once letting anyone pry you apart," Dad said softly, his voice thick with quiet pride, "having my son and my daughter permanently back home at this table—safe, finishing college side by side, and looking out for each other the way you two always have—is the best Thanksgiving gift a father could ever ask for."

"Nobody's ever putting a closed door between the three of us again, Dad," Katie smiled, squeezing my left hand across our armrests as the three of us clinked our iced-tea glasses together.

The very next morning—Black Friday, November 25—Dad walked into our shared back bedroom carrying his yellow tape measure, his spirit level, his cordless drill, and two boxes of white vinyl-coated wire shelving.

Looking from the brand-new queen bed in the corner—its soft navy-and-slate-blue Chesapeake Bay Mall comforter smoothed flat, crisp, and completely untouched—over to the open three-by-six bedroom closet where our unzipped navy-blue sleeping bag and two indented white pillows lay lengthwise across the vacuumed carpet beneath low-hanging winter jackets, Dad crouched down beside the closet threshold and rested a gentle hand on the sleeping bag.

“You two haven’t slept on the new mattress a single night since coming home on the thirteenth, have you?” Dad asked quietly—zero judgment in his eyes, only deep fatherly understanding.

“We tried looking at the bed the first night, Dad, and the comforter is really pretty,” Katie admitted honestly, holding my hand across our armrests. “Whenever the lights go out, though, an open room still makes both of us think of Brandon and Tiffany yelling over us. Inside the three-by-six closet with the doors pulled almost shut, it’s pitch dark and snug just like back on Greenway Court, and as long as we’re zipped inside our shared sleeping bag hugging each other, neither of us wakes up scared.”

“You don’t think it’s weird that we’re twenty years old and still sleeping in the closet, Dad?” I asked softly.

“Nate, you and your sister just survived two awful relationships back to back, and the two of you found a gentle, harmless way to keep each other calm through the night,” Dad answered firmly, standing up and clicking open his yellow tape measure. “There is nothing weird about two autistic twins who love each other needing the dark, a snug space, and a hug to sleep in peace. Watch what we’re going to do.”

Across Black Friday afternoon, with Katie and me holding the level and handing up drywall anchors and steel screws from our wheelchairs, Dad remounted the vertical wall tracks and heavy-duty coat rod twenty-eight inches higher up the closet studs—clearing every low-hanging hem and shoe box off the bottom so the entire three-by-six carpeted closet floor remained a one-hundred-percent unobstructed, full-length sleeping-bag sanctuary built specifically for the two of us.

Sunday, November 27, 2005, 7:30 PM — The Seattle Transit Blog & Quietly Launching Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit

“Look at this site I just found on OmniSearch, Katie,” I said two evenings later on Sunday night of Thanksgiving weekend, angling our seventeen-inch CRT monitor slightly toward my sister’s wheelchair along our wide computer desk on Arvin Road while my freshly wiped Quantum OS XN Pro desktop tower hummed quietly beside our two open laptops. “It’s called the Seattle Transit Blog.”

Katie set her cold can of ginger ale on a coaster, released her brake, and rolled right up flush against my left armrest, resting her chin lightly on my shoulder as we read the screen together.

Out in Washington State, everyday bus riders, programmers, and wheelchair commuters who rode TAPS—the Transit Authority of the Puget Sound—had built a public blog dissecting King County and Pierce County bus corridors, regional Cascade Card smart-card fares, low-floor fleets, and timed light-rail feeder pulses with the exact kind of logical, map-by-map precision that made both of our autistic minds light up. Even better, down in the comment threads, daily riders, bus operators, and city planners were trading real timetable math instead of shouting into thin air.

Katie looked from the glowing Seattle Transit Blog masthead down to the stack of folded paper Coastal Virginia Transit Authority pocket timetables spread across our desk: Route 12 along Indian River Road, Route 15 down Military Highway, Route

20 along Virginia Beach Boulevard, Route 25 and Route 29 into the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus, Route 1 up through Norfolk, and Route 61 across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

“Why doesn’t Hampton Roads have something like the Seattle Transit Blog for CVTA?” Katie asked softly, a bright, unmistakable spark catching in her blue eyes. “Think about it, Nate. Neither of us drives a car, and living back home here on Arvin Road in Virginia Beach shows every crack in this regional bus grid every single day! Look at today—it’s Sunday, and we literally can’t roll out to catch a bus anywhere in Kempsville because Virginia Beach shuts down almost its entire bus grid on Sundays!”

“And look at what happened to the two of us back in October last year when we escaped Williamsburg,” I added, the pieces locking cleanly together in my head. “It took us six buses across two transit agencies to get from the Williamsburg train station down to Dad at Military Highway and Indian River Road—and if we hadn’t skipped Route 106 to build a buffer and caught that very last 6:45 PM Route 61 Expressways bus out of Newport News Transit Center, both of our powerchairs would have been stranded on the wrong side of the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel all night!”

“Let’s start our own blog tonight and jot our ideas down in public,” Katie said, pulling her laptop closer across the desk. “Simple, constructive, and honest—*Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit*.”

Checking Omni Corporation’s hosted BlogSphere service—which handled the post database, permalinks, RSS feed, and reader comments automatically while letting us switch into raw HTML mode—we registered *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* under both of our first names and spent the next hour stripping out BlogSphere’s cluttered stock layout to hand-code a crisp, fast-loading coastal-navy, white, and teal two-column HTML and style-sheet template from scratch, linking the Seattle Transit Blog right at the top of our sidebar blogroll.

> Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit
> A Rider-Written Blog Exploring What Public Transit Across Hampton Roads Could Be
> Written by Katie & Nate

Without naming Brandon Mercer or the fear we had been escaping, Katie typed and published our opening Sunday-night post laying out the six-bus Peninsula-to-Southside gauntlet—asking why a metropolitan region of one and a half million people severed its cross-harbor Route 61 lifeline at 6:45 PM on a Saturday night and left riders waiting thirty minutes inside Newport News and Hampton transit centers with half-ripped mirrors, bare glue-stained plywood, and broken restroom stalls.

Right behind it, we opened the folded Route 1 and Route 25 timetables under our desk lamp to draft our second post on the glaring transit cliff at the Norfolk–Virginia Beach city line. On the Norfolk half of Route 1—up Granby Street and Ocean View out to the Amphibious Base—buses ran every fifteen to thirty minutes until 2:15 AM seven days a week; the exact instant Route 1 crossed into Virginia Beach toward Pleasure House Road, Haygood, and Pembroke East, most trips turned right back around into Norfolk, slashing Virginia Beach service to once an hour ending at 6:22 PM with *NO SUNDAY SERVICE* printed across an empty white box. Route 25 did the exact same turnaround at Greenwich and Newtown Roads—reminding Katie with a wry grin of the old bus-rider story about Virginia Beach’s sweet, library-

loving Mayor Myra Overton wanting Route 20 to turn back at Newtown Road “just to keep the riff-raff out.” Even worse, at CCHR Virginia Beach Campus, Route 12 ended at 5:48 PM, Route 25 ended at 5:53 PM, two-hour paper transfers expired mid-journey on hourly routes, and any citizen riding Route 33 to watch a 6:00 PM Virginia Beach City Council meeting had to catch the last 5:33 PM bus away from City Hall twenty-seven minutes before the gavel even fell.

When I clicked Publish on that second entry at nine o’clock on Sunday night, our sidebar visitor counter on Arvin Road read zero.

Katie laced her fingers warmly through mine across our wheelchair armrests and rested her cheek against my shoulder as we admired our glowing masthead on the glass screen.

“In 2008, Virginia Beach holds its next Mayor’s Race and City Council elections,” Katie murmured quietly, reading the exact math in my head. “If you and I keep riding every route together and writing two or three honest, schedule-backed posts every single week while we finish college, three years from now *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* won’t have zero readers anymore—and maybe the people running our city will finally have to listen to the people who ride the bus.”

Part 5: The CCHR Disability Counselor, The Glossy Fishersville Pitch, & Why Brother and Sister Should Get to Share a Dorm Room

Date: 2007-02-15 at 13:30 America/New_York

Thursday, February 15, 2007, 1:30 PM — “Have Neither of You Heard of DARS?”

“We’ve hit the ceiling of what static HTML and a hosted BlogSphere template can do, Mrs. Evans,” I explained across the cluttered oak desk inside the Disability Support Services office at the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, where twenty-one-year-old Katie and I sat parked wheel-to-wheel in our compact black SwiftChairs with our freshly issued Associate of Applied Science degree transcripts resting in our lap folders. “Over the past fifteen months while we lived at home on Arvin Road finishing our final semesters here at CCHR, *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* has grown from zero visitors to thousands of daily commuters across Hampton Roads. We want to build our own interactive timetable calculators and database-driven web applications from scratch—and for that, we need an intensive course in server-side PHP and SQL relational databases.”

“And our family timing lines up right at the start of March,” Katie added, resting her hand lightly across my left armrest. “Dad just landed a big senior systems engineering job up in Northern Virginia at Tysons Corner starting Monday, March fifth, and closed on a second house on Sunset Drive near King Street in Alexandria while keeping our brick ranch here on Arvin Road permanently for the two of us. Since CCHR isn’t running an intensive server-side PHP and SQL sequence this spring, we came by to ask if you knew of any specialized technical certificate programs we could take together without piling up four-year university debt.”

Mrs. Evans, who had signed off on our classroom wheelchair accommodations ever since freshman orientation in the fall of 2003, slipped off her reading glasses and blinked back and forth between the two of us in genuine surprise.

“Wait a minute, Katie, Nathaniel,” Mrs. Evans said. “Have neither of you ever met with a counselor over at DARS?”

Katie and I glanced at each other across our armrests and shook our heads at the exact same second. “What’s DARS?” Katie asked.

“The Virginia Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services,” Mrs. Evans replied, pulling open her side file drawer and lifting out a crisp state directory folder. “Because both of you use power wheelchairs full-time with progressive neuromuscular weakness, you qualify for full state career-and-technical tuition sponsorship. They never advertise on television or highway billboards, so plenty of community-college graduates have no idea it exists, but the Commonwealth operates a residential post-secondary campus up in the Shenandoah Valley in Fishersville—right between Staunton and Waynesboro—called Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center.”

At the word *rehabilitation*, both Katie and I instinctively frowned. Neither of us was looking for physical therapy or basic life-skills classes; we rode multi-bus regional transit transfers across Hampton Roads by memory, ran one of Coastal Virginia’s fastest-growing civic websites, and already held accredited associate degrees.

Mrs. Evans spotted our expressions immediately and held up a reassuring hand. “Now, don’t let the old 1940s name fool you—think of their Business and Information Technology division as a specialized technical institute,” she said warmly, sliding a printed course catalog sheet across her desk toward our wheelchairs. “Look right here at track BIT-204: Web Applications Developer. It is a dedicated, full-time classroom program teaching server-side PHP, SQL relational database design, and dynamic web application architecture. And because Fishersville sits right near the junction of Interstate 81 and Interstate 64, it’s barely a two-hour drive down from your father’s new place in Alexandria.”

Katie leaned over my armrest so our shoulders pressed warmly together as we read the course block:

> Business & Information Technology Division — Web Applications Developer
> Curriculum: Server-Side Scripting (PHP), Relational Database Management (SQL), Dynamic Web Architecture, & Client-Server Integration.
> Format: Self-paced, module-driven instruction in a dedicated campus computer laboratory with on-campus dormitory housing and dining included.

“Server-side PHP and SQL, self-paced modules, and zero tuition debt,” I murmured, my eyes lighting up as I traced the curriculum line. “If it’s self-paced, Katie, two twins who have been coding HTML since seventh grade and Quantum Basic since high school could fly through those modules.”

“Let me call over to the regional DARS office on Newtown Road right now,” Mrs. Evans smiled, reaching for her desk telephone. “If your dad starts his Tysons Corner job on Monday, March fifth, we can expedite your intake paperwork so he can drop the two of you off at the dorms on Sunday afternoon, March fourth, right on his drive north to Alexandria.”

Friday, February 23, 2007, 6:30 PM — The Glossy Barton Hall Brochure & Our Unbroken Twenty-One-Year Streak

Eight evenings later, spread open across our clean dining-room table on Arvin Road while Dad stood beside our wheelchairs with a steaming mug of coffee, lay the glossy, full-color tri-fold campus brochure and welcome packet that the regional DARS counselor on Newtown Road had handed us that afternoon.

Inside the Newtown Road office, our intake appointment had gone as smoothly as two twenty-one-year-old programmers could have hoped. The counselor had admired our freshly earned CCHR associate transcripts, signed our full state sponsorship authorizations for the Web Applications Developer track, explained that we would take our self-paced PHP and SQL modules in the campus computer laboratory by day while living in the student dormitory at night, and opened the glossy tri-fold to sunny photographs of red-brick buildings framed by the Blue Ridge foothills, a heated indoor pool, a student Recreation Hall, a dining commons, and a bright two-bed dormitory room in Barton Hall.

“Look at the photo of the Barton Hall room right here in the center panel, Dad,” Katie said, tapping the glossy photograph showing two standard college Twin XL beds along opposite walls, two study desks, and wide sliding closet doors in the corner. “Dr. Carter’s seating clinic already tuned up our two backup collapsible manual cross-brace frames and clipped fresh battery packs onto the right-armrest joystick drives for us this morning, so instead of hauling our heavy SwiftChairs up to the mountains, you can just unclip the battery boxes whenever you visit from Alexandria in a regular car and fold our frames into the trunk.”

“And the counselor confirmed tuition, lab books, dorm housing, and three meals a day in the cafeteria are one hundred percent covered,” Dad nodded through his glasses, resting a warm hand on Katie’s shoulder and mine before stepping into the kitchen to rinse his coffee mug. “I’ll load your collapsible joystick chairs and suitcases into the truck next Sunday morning, March fourth, get you settled into Barton Hall that afternoon, and head right up Interstate 81 and Interstate 66 to Sunset Drive in Alexandria before work Monday morning.”

Once Dad stepped into the kitchen, Katie and I turned our SwiftChairs toward each other beside the dining table and studied the glossy photograph of the two-bed Barton Hall dorm room more closely.

“Okay, let’s think our room setup through logically,” I said quietly, reaching across our armrests to hold Katie’s hand. “Dorm beds at every college are Twin XL, so even if we pushed one against the wall, a single mattress is way too narrow for the two of us.”

“And we already know why regular colleges normally separate guys and girls in dorm rooms,” Katie replied with complete, matter-of-fact autistic logic. “Colleges don’t want boyfriends and girlfriends moving into a dorm room together in September and then having some loud, messy breakup in November where somebody gets thrown out in the hallway—like Tiffany did to us.”

Katie squeezed my fingers, a warm, completely confident smile lighting up her face.

“Except none of that applies to us, Nate!” Katie said brightly. “We’re twin brother and sister—actual family! We *can’t* break up! We’ve been side by side since we were babies in cribs, and in twenty-one years—through Arvin Road, Greenway

Court, Brandon's house in Williamsburg, and Tiffany's apartment in Ocean View—you and I have never spent one single night under separate roofs in our entire lives! Since we're brother and sister, of course they'll assign us one of those two-bed dorm rooms together!"

"That makes total sense," I agreed immediately, glancing from the wide sliding closet doors in the Barton Hall photograph back down our hallway toward our Arvin Road bedroom closet, where our shared navy-blue sleeping bag and two white pillows waited neatly beneath Dad's raised shelves. "On paper, we'll let their housing chart assign us the two Twin XL beds in the room so their paperwork is happy. And as long as that Barton Hall dorm closet is at least three feet deep by six feet wide like ours here at home—once we lock our room door at bedtime—"

"—we'll just unroll our sleeping bag lengthwise on the dorm closet floor, slide the closet doors shut so it's pitch dark and snug, and sleep cuddled up together like we always do!" Katie finished, grinning from ear to ear as she leaned across our armrests and wrapped both arms tightly around my neck. "Take our PHP and SQL modules during the day, eat together in the dining hall, code *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* at our dorm desks at night, and curl up safe inside the closet at bedtime. We can totally make a mountain dorm room work for a few months, Nate!"

Hugging my twin sister close in the warm dining room on Arvin Road, I rested my cheek against her blonde hair as we tucked the glossy Fishersville brochure neatly into our laptop bag and rolled down the hallway together to get ready for bed in our closet sanctuary.

Twelve Days at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center & Walking Out for Good

Barton Hall Check-In, Rushing Voc Eval in One Week, & 'Door Greeter!?'

Part 1: Sunday Check-In at Barton Hall, The Opposite-Gender Dorm Rule, & Expelling the Creepy Roommate

Date: 2007-03-04 at 11:15 America/New_York

Sunday, March 4, 2007, 11:15 AM — Why Dormitories Were Never Built for Us

"It was a whole lot easier for me to bring the two of them up here on a Sunday since I start my new weekday schedule up in Tysons Corner tomorrow morning," Dad explained to the residential staffer who met the three of us outside the flat-roofed 1960s red-brick entrance of Barton Hall at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville.

“Oh, clients arrive on Sundays all the time, Mr. Prairie, so it’s no big deal at all,” the staffer smiled, propping the heavy glass vestibule door open against the chilly March mountain breeze as Katie and I guided our wheelchairs side by side across the threshold. Our backpacks hung over our canvas seatbacks, and Dad rolled a brass luggage cart stacked with our suitcases and laptop bags right behind us over the scuffed green-and-white terrazzo floor. “Come on back to the dorm office so we can introduce ourselves and get their intake paperwork started.”

Looking down the wide cinder-block corridor, with its buzzing fluorescent troffers and faded 1970s brass plaques reminding visitors that the facility had stood on these former World War II Army hospital grounds since November 1947, I reached across my armrest and brushed my knuckles against Katie’s fingers. She gave my hand a quick, grounding squeeze before we rolled into the intake office behind a wooden counter.

“Here are their updated medical clearances and my emergency contact numbers,” Dad said, setting a manila folder on the blotter in front of the Sunday residential coordinator, a middle-aged woman whose plastic badge read *Linda*. “You’ll see two addresses listed for me. My Virginia driver’s license has my new primary residence on Sunset Drive near King Street in Alexandria, right down the road from my new engineering job in Tysons Corner, and the second number is our brick ranch on Arvin Road off Indian River Road and Military Highway down in Virginia Beach. I bought that Virginia Beach house from my old landlord years ago and kept it as their permanent home down in Virginia Beach so the twins always have their familiar house and routine waiting for them in Hampton Roads.”

“Got both numbers right here on the top sheet,” Linda said, clipping the page into two green intake folders. She glanced over the counter at our wheelchairs—the backup folding manual cross-brace frames with spoked push-rim wheels and rear rubber push-handles that Dr. Carter’s seating clinic had fitted with right-armrest joystick power-drive kits back after Hurricane Isabel—and raised her eyebrows slightly. “I see the vocational counselor’s note here says you two left your full-size power chairs in Virginia Beach?”

“Dr. Carter had these backup folding frames rigged up with joystick drives for us after Hurricane Isabel,” I explained, resting my palm on my right-hand controller. “Neither of us has the wrist or upper-arm strength to push manual hand-rims across a campus, so we still drive everywhere with the joysticks, and if we ever catch a ride off campus in a regular compact sedan, you just unclip the battery box underneath and the frame folds flat into a trunk.”

“Very smart,” Linda said, sliding our two green folders and two brass room keys on plastic tags across the counter. “Now, for your initial Vocational Evaluation period here in Barton Hall, Nathaniel, your room is down on the men’s wing, and Katie, you are in Room 157 over on the women’s wing. Please remember that under Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center residential policy, there is strictly no visiting dorm rooms of the opposite gender.”

Katie and I looked at each other across our armrests as that announcement hit us like a bucket of ice water. Back home on Arvin Road, when we had looked at the glossy brochure from the DARS office showing a two-bed college-style dorm room in Barton Hall, we had figured that since regular colleges only separate men and women so boyfriends and girlfriends don’t have messy breakups—and since we were twin brother and sister who had been at each other’s side since we were little and had never spent a single night under separate roofs in twenty-one years, even

while surviving abusive partners in Williamsburg and Ocean View—they would let us share a room, put up with two Twin XL beds on paper, and cram ourselves into our sleeping bag in the dorm closet at bedtime.

Keeping my voice completely polite, I leaned forward in my chair toward the counter.

"Excuse me, ma'am—I think there might be a misunderstanding," I said politely. "Katie and I aren't a boyfriend and girlfriend who might break up; we're fraternal twins—brother and sister. We thought since we're family, we'd be able to share one of the two-bed rooms. We've been at each other's side since we were little, we've lived together every single day of our lives—all through earning our associate degrees at the Community College of Hampton Roads—and whenever one of us gets overwhelmed at night, the other one is right there."

"I understand you're brother and sister, Nathaniel, and that you're used to sharing a home," Linda replied in a practiced, unyielding voice, tapping the highlighted paragraph on the housing sheet, "but this is a state residential facility, not an off-campus house. We keep men and women on separate wings because we can't have male and female clients in the same dorm rooms hooking up behind closed doors."

Katie and I blinked at her, both of our literal autistic brains stalling on the slang phrase.

"Hooking up?" Katie asked politely, tilting her head. "Like hooking up a computer monitor? What does 'hooking up' mean?"

Linda paused, her cheeks coloring slightly as she looked across the counter at the two of us and lowered her voice a notch. "It means having sex, Katie."

Katie and I looked at each other and then looked straight back at Linda in complete earnestness. Ever since sitting side by side in Family Life Education classes back in Virginia Beach public schools, both of us had known as a strict, memorized rule that brothers and sisters are not supposed to have sex with each other—a rule we obeyed one hundred percent literally even though neither of us had ever really understood why it was a rule, or why people like Tiffany Sloan in Ocean View got so twisted in the head assuming a dark closet sleeping bag had anything to do with sex.

"Oh!" Katie said matter-of-factly. "Well, we're brother and sister—we know brothers and sisters aren't supposed to have sex with each other, so of course we won't have sex!"

"Yeah, of course we won't," I agreed earnestly, nodding right alongside my twin sister.

Linda stared at the two of us for a second, momentarily flustered by how plainly we had just said that across the intake counter, before clearing her throat and falling right back on the rulebook.

"Be that as it may, nobody shares a room across the gender line here, and opposite-gender room visitation between six and eleven in the evening is an earned privilege reserved exclusively for Level 4 clients over in Cantor Hall," Linda said firmly. "All newly arriving clients here in Barton Hall start at Level 2. You two are more than welcome to spend time together in the dorm lobby, the outdoor courtyard, the recreation hall, or the dining hall—just not inside the dorm rooms proper. Since you

just arrived today, I'm going to escort you down the halls right now so you can help each other unpack your bags, but once your suitcases are unpacked, you'll each have to leave the other's room."

Katie and I exchanged a deeply unhappy look across our armrests, biting our tongues and staying polite at the counter even as our hearts sank at being forced into separate rooms on opposite wings. As Linda stood up from her chair and stepped around the counter, however, the male residential staffer who had held the front door lingered by the office threshold, looked down at the standard rubber push-handles sticking out the back of Katie's folding frame, and reached both hands straight for her grips without asking as if he were about to wheel her down the corridor himself.

Katie clicked her joystick controller off, slammed both manual wheel-locks forward with a sharp metal *clack*, whipped her head around, and went straight after him with an aggressive edge in her voice that she almost never used back home.

"Get your hands off my wheelchair right now!" Katie barked across the lobby. "Do not touch my push-handles! Do I look like a piece of luggage to you?! Our chairs have joysticks on the armrests for a reason—my brother and I drive ourselves, and if you grab my chair without my permission again, you and I are going to have a serious problem!"

"Hey—watch your tone with residential staff, young lady," the staffer bristled, jerking his hands back from her rubber grips while his face turned red.

"Watch your hands around my sister's wheelchair!" I shot right back, guiding my own chair flush alongside Katie's so nobody could step between us.

Linda held up a hand between the counter and the doorway, frowning sharply at the two of us. "Katie, Nathaniel, I'm going to let that slide with a verbal warning since you two just came through the door five minutes ago and I know check-in day is stressful, but aggressive outbursts toward staff are a write-up offense here at Roosevelt."

Neither Katie nor I apologized. Instead, both of us fixed the staffer by the doorway with identical, disgusted looks—staring him straight in the eye with an unblinking glare that amounted to a flat-out dare: *go ahead and write us up right now if you want to.*

The staffer swallowed, looked away from our twin glares, and shoved his hands into his pockets without touching his clipboard.

With Linda walking beside us down the men's corridor first, Katie and Dad helped me unload my clothes and laptop bag onto my side of the narrow cinder-block two-bed room—where my assigned roommate was already lounging on the opposite mattress watching us in silence—before we rolled across the building to Room 157 on the women's wing to help Katie unpack alongside her new roommate, who greeted all three of us warmly.

As soon as the last suitcase was stowed under Katie's bed and we rolled back out to the neutral territory of the Barton Hall lobby with our MagnaBook laptops resting on our lap trays, Katie steered her wheelchair flush against mine and leaned close to my ear.

“I noticed your roommate was staring at my tits the entire time I was helping you unpack,” Katie said quietly, her jaw tight.

“I noticed it too, and I wasn’t thrilled about it for a second,” I answered, my blood simmering as I put my arm around my sister’s shoulders while our laptops booted up. “Your roommate back in Room 157 seemed like a genuinely nice person, whereas I think I got stuck with a complete jerk of a roommate. What do you want to do?”

“No offense, Nate, but your roommate gave off a really bad first impression,” Katie sighed, before turning in her seat and pulling me into a tight, reassuring hug so I knew she didn’t blame me for who the housing office had put in my room.

A moment later, Dad walked out of Linda’s office tucking our signed carbon copies into his coat pocket. “All right, you two, the paperwork is finished,” Dad said warmly. “Come on—I’m taking both of you into Waynesboro to get a real lunch before I have to get on the highway toward Alexandria.”

3:00 PM — House Guard 2 in the Dorm Lobby, Cafeteria Rations, & The 11:00 PM Curfew Check

“I wish they had an actual lap pool here instead of just the small therapeutic pool, but oh well,” Katie sighed, peering through the interior observation glass of the campus recreation hall at the quiet, steamy natatorium before glancing down at her wristwatch as her stomach gave an audible rumble. “I’m already hungry again and it’s only three o’clock, even after that big lunch Dad bought us in Waynesboro.”

“Look at the board games over on that table—half the boxes are missing their lids, and the TV in the lounge is turned up way too loud,” I said, turning my chair beside hers. “Want to head back across the walkway to the Barton Hall lobby?”

“Please,” Katie nodded, rolling out the automatic doors beside me into the cool afternoon air.

We parked wheel-to-wheel on the far side of the Barton Hall lounge chairs, well out of earshot of the front desk.

“If it weren’t for that silly opposite-gender dorm rule, I’d say let’s just head back to one of our rooms and close the door,” I muttered, looking toward the two separate wing doors at opposite ends of the lobby.

Instead, I unzipped my backpack, pulled out a two-way stereo headphone splitter, and plugged both of our headsets into the audio jack of my laptop. Sliding a DVD into the drive, we queued up the brownstone booby-trap sequence of one of our favorite childhood Christmas comedies, *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan*—right where the kid stands on the rooftop throwing bricks down at the two bumbling burglars.

Within two minutes, both Katie and I were shaking with laughter across our armrests—laughing so hard that half a dozen other students sitting around the dorm lobby looked over and asked what on earth was so funny. Grinning, Katie hit the rewind button back to the scene where the two bandits were robbing the toy-store cash

register, unplugged the headphone splitter so the sound played through my laptop speakers, and angled the screen toward the lounge so the other students could crowd around and laugh right along with us.

When the sequence wrapped up at quarter to five, we shut down the DVD player and zipped our laptops back into our bags.

“How about we roll inside the courtyard together for some fresh air,” Katie suggested, lacing her fingers through mine, “and then we’ll split up for two minutes just to drop our backpacks off in our rooms, wait for each other right outside the wing doors, and head to dinner together?”

“Deal,” I said, giving her a quick hug before we parted at the hallway junction.

When I unlocked my door on the men’s wing and rolled inside to set my backpack on my desk chair, my roommate looked up from his pillow with a sleazy smirk. “Hey, man—who was the hot blonde babe in here with you earlier?”

I didn’t dignify him with a single word. Locking my desk drawer, I spun my wheelchair around in the narrow aisle, rolled straight back out to the courtyard walkway where Katie was waiting for me, and told her verbatim what he had just said.

“Gross,” Katie said, curling her lip in disgust as we turned toward the covered breezeway at five-thirty with the stream of residential students heading to the main cafeteria. “If he walks past us tonight, hold my hand so he gets it through his thick skull not to talk to me.”

Inside the noisy dining hall, we picked up two plastic trays, balanced them across our lap trays along the stainless-steel rail, and steered over to a small table for two near the wall.

“Looks like burgers and french fries,” Katie said, picking up a limp, lukewarm fry from her plate. She took one bite and made a face. “That tastes nasty!”

At the next table over, a veteran student in a faded hoodie snorted around his plastic fork. “You two must be new here. Get used to your rations.”

“Well,” I sighed, poking dubiously at my gray hamburger patty, “the food definitely isn’t the greatest, but what choice do we have?”

As soon as we dumped our trays at the dish window and rolled back out into the cool dusk air toward Barton Hall, Katie reached across our armrests and took my hand, giggling softly under her breath. “Just in case your creepy roommate is watching from the sidewalk—I want it to look like we’re dating.”

“Where to now?” I asked as the front doors of Barton Hall slid open. “Dorm lobby?”

“Yeah,” Katie said softly, her smile fading a little as she looked toward the separate hallway doors. “Until it’s time for bed. I miss living together back home.”

We parked in our quiet corner of the lobby, where I wrapped my arm around her shoulders and Katie snuggled against my chest with a long yawn. “We’ll have breakfast together first thing in the morning,” I promised, resting my cheek against her hair, “and then we’re staying right at each other’s side through every minute of evaluation.”

By nine o’clock, both of us were nodding off in our chairs. Tearfully, we hugged each other goodbye in the middle of the lobby before reluctantly turning down our separate wings for the night.

When I rolled into my room on the men’s wing, the bed across from mine was empty. Relieved to have the room to myself, I changed into my pajamas, locked my wheelchair brakes beside the frame, and transferred under the stiff institutional blanket—lying awake in the dark waiting for the eleven-o’clock curfew check.

Five minutes past eleven, the hallway door clicked open and a night staffer shone his flashlight inside, pausing when the beam hit the empty mattress across from mine.

“Where’s your roommate?” the staffer asked.

“I haven’t seen him at all tonight,” I said from my pillow. “And considering the sexually suggestive things he was saying about my sister earlier today, I really don’t want to see him right now.”

The staffer stepped inside and lowered his clipboard. “What did he say?”

“Right after I finished unpacking, he asked me, ‘Who’s the hot blonde babe?’” I replied. “And earlier, while my sister was helping me unpack, she noticed him staring at her breasts.”

“What’s your sister’s name?” the staffer asked, uncapping his pen.

“Katie. Katie Prairie. Room 157,” I replied.

When my wristwatch alarm beeped at quarter to seven on Monday morning, I looked across the narrow room and saw my roommate passed out face-down on top of his bedspread in his street clothes, reeking of stale beer and marijuana. Keeping silent so I wouldn’t wake him, I got dressed, transferred into my wheelchair, and rolled straight out to the Barton Hall lobby, where Katie came through the women’s wing doors less than a minute later and wrapped her arms around my neck.

Before we could head out the front doors toward the cafeteria, the weekday morning dorm supervisor—a tall, no-nonsense woman with steel-gray hair—stepped out of the residential office and beckoned to the two of us.

“Nathaniel, Katie, step into my office for thirty seconds,” she said, closing the door behind our wheelchairs. “I wanted both of you to know before you head to breakfast that Nathaniel’s roommate is being expelled and escorted off the property by Campus Police this morning. At eleven-fifteen last night, night staff caught him trying to sneak past the fire doors into the women’s dormitory wing to pressure another female client into sleeping with him, and just like you, Katie, that young woman wanted nothing to do with him and turned him straight in because he wouldn’t stop harassing her. Between that, his prior write-ups, and staggering back onto campus intoxicated after curfew, he is done here. You have that room to yourself, Nathaniel.”

Katie let out a long breath beside me, her shoulders dropping two inches in pure relief as we thanked the supervisor and rolled back out into the morning hallway together.

Part 2: Rushing Voc Eval in One Week, Auto Shop & 'Door Greeter!?', Refusing Separation, & Staying Stuck on Level 2

Date: 2007-03-05 at 07:15 America/New_York

Monday, March 5, 2007, 7:15 AM — The Medication Line, Auto Shop & Woodworking, & "Door Greeter!?"

"We need our breakfast," Katie said as we rolled side by side out of the Barton Hall lobby toward the dining hall breezeway.

"I'm guessing breakfast is going to be just as nasty as dinner was last night," I replied as the automatic doors slid open into the crisp March mountain air.

Twenty minutes later, after pushing watery scrambled eggs and limp toast around our plastic plates, we rolled down the corridor to join the long single-file line of Level 2 clients waiting outside the dispensary window for our morning maintenance medication.

"This is so stupid," Katie whispered in exasperation as we inched forward in our joystick-outfitted wheelchairs. "We're twenty-one years old, and we're both used to managing our own medication bottles back home in our apartment."

When we reached the counter, the dispensary nurse leaned toward the opening and spoke to us in a high-pitched, sing-song voice as if we were seven-year-olds learning how to swallow a chewable vitamin. "Good morning, friends! Ready to take our morning pills with a big sip of water?"

I looked straight across the counter at her. "Ma'am, we have associate degrees and we've managed our own prescriptions in our own apartment in Norfolk for three and a half years," I said flatly. "You don't need to talk down to us like children. Just hand us the paper cups and check our names off the clipboard."

The nurse's patronizing smile vanished immediately, and she handed over our pleated paper cups in silence.

"I don't think I'm going to like it here," I said quietly to Katie as we rolled away from the window, slipping my arm around her shoulders.

"I already miss the apartment," Katie whispered back, leaning against my arm.

Right then, angry screams echoed from the main entrance doors down the hall.

"You are not my boyfriend anymore, and I don't ever want to see you again!" a girl shouted, shoving through the doors.

"Get out of my life too, jerk!" a boy shouted right back at her.

Down the hallway from us, another student sighed and shook his head. “Those two. Always fighting. Always arguing.”

Katie looked over at me with a wry, grateful smile. “I’m glad we’re siblings, Nate.”

I pulled her into a warm hug across our armrests and whispered, “Yeah. No boyfriend-girlfriend drama between us.”

At eight-thirty sharp, we followed the directional signs into the Vocational Evaluation wing of the Bates-Harding Building and parked side by side at a scarred laminate table at the front of the intake room. At the dry-erase board stood the lead evaluation specialist, Ms. Hollis, holding a thick stack of yellow checklists while her evaluation aide, Mr. Miller, passed them down the rows.

“Welcome to Vocational Evaluation,” Ms. Hollis announced briskly. “Before any client at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center is permitted to enter a vocational training classroom, you will spend the next two full weeks right here in Voc Eval completing three mandatory requirements under Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services guidelines. First, you will demonstrate independent-living skills to our staff—making your dorm bed with proper corners, doing a load of laundry, and preparing a basic meal in the test kitchen. Second, you will rotate with Mr. Miller through our campus trade shops—auto mechanics, woodworking, nursing assistant, food service, and retail—so we can determine which trade is the best fit for you. And third, our team will grade your daily socialization and appropriate social skills.”

Katie raised her hand immediately. Neither of us had been prepared for any of this—not the rules, not the baby-talk at the dispensary window, and certainly not two weeks of mandatory Vocational Evaluation. We had zero interest in the rehabilitation side of RRC; we had come to Fishersville strictly for the Web Applications Developer class, fully expecting to treat the center like college—go to class, sleep in the dorm, and be done with it.

“Excuse me, Ms. Hollis?” Katie said. “Nathaniel and I already have our associate degrees from the Community College of Hampton Roads, we lived in our own off-campus apartments in Norfolk for three and a half years, and our vocational counselor in Hampton Roads specifically sent us here for the Web Applications Developer PHP and SQL track. We’ve been writing HTML since seventh grade and Quantum Basic since high school. Why do we need to spend two weeks touring auto mechanics, woodworking, and nursing?”

Ms. Hollis tapped her pen against her clipboard with a tight, practiced smile. “Everyone follows the same two-week evaluation protocol here, Katie. Nobody skips the trade rotations. Mr. Miller, take the group down to the auto mechanics bay first.”

For the next three hours, Katie and I sat side by side in mounting disbelief as Mr. Miller led our cohort from one manual-labor shop to the next. In the auto mechanics bay, we sat parked beside a hydraulic lift smelling burnt motor oil while an instructor demonstrated a heavy pneumatic impact wrench that neither Katie nor I had the upper-body strength to lift off a workbench, let alone use standing under a car chassis. Forty-five minutes later, Mr. Miller marched the group into the woodworking shop, where fine oak sawdust drifted over our lap trays and screaming

table saws vibrated through the concrete floor. Right before lunch, we were wheeled into the nursing assistant training lab to watch students practice two-person transfers lifting a hundred-and-fifty-pound plastic mannequin onto a hospital bed.

As soon as Mr. Miller led the group back into the Bates-Harding evaluation room at eleven-thirty, I steered straight up to Ms. Hollis's desk with Katie right beside me.

"Ms. Hollis, that tour makes zero sense for the two of us," I said bluntly. "We're both in wheelchairs with progressive neuromuscular weakness in our legs and arms. We can't stand under a hydraulic lift in an auto shop, we can't stand at a table saw in a woodworking shop, and we certainly can't lift hospital patients in nursing school. We came here to write server-side PHP and SQL code."

Ms. Hollis looked down at our wheelchairs—never once glancing at our CCHR transcripts in her folder—and put on a bright, syrupy smile.

"Now, Katie, Nathaniel, here at Roosevelt we have to evaluate realistic physical alternatives in case the stamina demands of software engineering prove too taxing," Ms. Hollis said, tapping her pen on the desk blotter. "If the computer track doesn't pan out, we have a wonderful partnership with ValueMart right down the road in Waynesboro! We could train Katie to be a ValueMart Door Greeter—it has very minimal physical requirements, and you just sit in the vestibule and smile at shoppers—and Nathaniel, with your polite voice, we could place you in our Food Service Prep or stockroom tagging track!"

Katie stared at her in utter, stunned disbelief.

"Door greeter!?" Katie repeated out loud, her voice ringing off the painted cinder-block walls so loudly that every student in the room turned around to look. "My brother and I have associate degrees with honors! We write HTML, CSS, and Quantum Basic by hand, we run a regional transit analysis website read by city councilors across six cities, and you look at two people in wheelchairs and think our career ceiling is sitting by the sliding doors at ValueMart saying hello to shoppers?!"

"I'm simply explaining all of the options DARS offers our clients," Ms. Hollis said stiffly, her cheeks reddening as Katie and I exchanged a look of pure disgust and rolled back to our table.

Tuesday, March 6, 2007, 9:15 AM — "Do Not Grab Our Wheelchairs!" & Refusing Separation at Social Break

"All right, group, let's head down the hall to the independent-living test kitchen so we can check off your meal-prep rubric!" Mr. Miller called out at nine-fifteen on Tuesday morning as Katie and I closed our testing binders and powered on our right-armrest joysticks to roll out into the Bates-Harding corridor.

Before we had even cleared the doorway, Mr. Miller walked briskly up behind the two of us without saying a word, reached out, and clamped his right hand onto Katie's rear rubber push-handle and his left hand onto my rear rubber push-handle to shove both of our wheelchairs down the hallway himself.

The sudden manual shove against our motorized wheel hubs jolted both of our cross-brace frames forward at once.

“Hey—take your hands off our wheelchairs right now!” I barked loudly, my voice echoing down the terrazzo corridor as both Katie and I clicked our drives off and slammed our manual wheel brakes locked, stopping Mr. Miller dead in his tracks.

“Excuse me!” Katie shouted, twisting around in her seat so every evaluator and student in the corridor heard her displeasure. “Do not grab my wheelchair! Our chairs have joysticks on the armrests—we drive ourselves! Grabbing somebody’s wheelchair without asking is no different from grabbing our bodies in the middle of the hallway!”

Mr. Miller jerked both hands back as if the rubber grips had burned his palms, his face turning pink. “Oh—now wait a second, Katie, Nathaniel, I was just trying to be helpful and get everyone down to the test kitchen on time—”

“If you want us at the test kitchen, you tell us where the door is with your voice, just like you tell every walking student in this hallway!” I said loudly, refusing to lower my volume by a single decibel. “In our community, a wheelchair is an extension of the person sitting in it. You wouldn’t walk up behind a standing twenty-one-year-old woman and shove her down the hall by her shoulders without asking, and you do not put your hands on our push-handles to push us around this center!”

Mr. Miller muttered a flustered apology and kept six feet behind us all the way to the test kitchen—where Katie and I briskly fried eggs, toasted bread, scrubbed the skillet clean, and checked off every single independent-living box on the clipboard in twenty minutes flat.

By two-fifteen on Wednesday afternoon, however, during the scheduled Vocational Evaluation social break in the painted cinder-block break room, Ms. Hollis marched across the linoleum toward the quiet corner where Katie and I sat parked wheel-to-wheel drinking two cans of ginger ale and sketching relational database tables—with Mr. Miller trailing right behind her.

“Nathaniel, Katie,” Ms. Hollis said, rapping her pen against her clipboard with a disapproving frown, “for the past three days, the evaluation team has noted that the two of you have not separated once—not in the evaluation room, not during break times, not in the cafeteria, and not in the Barton Hall lounge.”

Katie and I looked up from our notebook at the exact same second. “That’s because we’re twins, ma’am,” Katie said firmly. “We do everything together.”

“Well, while you are in Vocational Evaluation, that needs to change—especially during social times,” Ms. Hollis said briskly, gesturing toward two opposite corners of the break room. “Part of your evaluation is proving that you have independent social skills. You two are twenty-one years old—you are supposed to be branching out, making your own individual friends, and going your separate sibling ways during the day. Starting right now for the rest of social break, Nathaniel, you are going over to Table One, and Katie, you are going over to Table Four. Mr. Miller, go ahead and wheel Katie over to Table Four.”

Before Mr. Miller could bring his fingers within six inches of Katie’s rear push-handles, Katie and I reached across our armrests, locked our hands together in an unbreakable grip, and let the entire room hear our displeasure at full volume.

“Keep your hands off my sister’s wheelchair!” I barked across the break room, making every conversation at Tables One through Four stop dead. “We told you yesterday—nobody touches our chairs, and nobody pushes us around!”

“And we are NOT being handled or separated like five-year-olds during break time!” Katie said loudly, her blue eyes blazing straight at Ms. Hollis.

Ms. Hollis blinked, visibly rattled by two Level 2 clients telling her no in front of the entire cohort. “Excuse me, Katie? Nathaniel? Refusing a socialization directive during social time goes down as a deficiency on your Vocational Evaluation rubric.”

“Then write it down in capital letters as a deficiency!” Katie shot back loudly enough for the whole wing to hear. “My brother and I are perfectly polite to everyone in this room! Just Sunday afternoon in the Barton Hall lobby, we shared our DVD with half the building and had everyone laughing together! We know how to talk to people, we already passed your bed-making, laundry, and kitchen checks yesterday, and we already have associate degrees! What we do not tolerate is Center staff grabbing our wheelchairs like they own our bodies or trying to pry twin brother and sister apart during social time just to check a box on your clipboard!”

“And we are not sitting in Vocational Evaluation for a second week,” I added loudly and evenly, holding Katie’s hand tightly across our armrests. “Put the entire two-day Web Applications Developer technical, mathematical, HTML, and logic exam battery on our table at eight-thirty tomorrow morning. Either we test out of Voc Eval in one week and start the Web Applications Developer class on Monday morning, or we will call our father in Alexandria right now, pack our suitcases in Barton Hall, and go home tonight!”

Every student at the four break tables was staring straight at Ms. Hollis and Mr. Miller. Pressing her lips into a thin line, Ms. Hollis motioned for Mr. Miller to step back. “Fine,” she said clippedly. “Be at Testing Table Two at eight-thirty sharp tomorrow morning, and we’ll see if you can pass the full Web Applications packet in one sitting.”

Thursday, March 8, 2007, 8:30 AM — The Outdated 1990s Exam Battery & Proving We Don’t Cheat

When Katie and I rolled into the Vocational Evaluation testing room at eight-twenty-five on Thursday morning and locked our manual wheel brakes side by side at Testing Table Two, Ms. Hollis and Mr. Miller were already waiting for us with matching looks of smug anticipation.

Having watched us refuse to sit at separate tables during Wednesday afternoon’s social break, both of them were clearly convinced that the real reason Katie and I insisted on sitting wheel-to-wheel was so we could cheat off each other—either whispering answers back and forth or letting one twin carry the other through the math and coding sections so she could disqualify us both and ship us right back to the ValueMart Door Greeter and Food Service tracks.

Ms. Hollis stepped up to the laminate tabletop and slapped down two three-inch-thick, spiral-bound exam packets, two green optical bubble sheets, two lined legal pads for scratch work, and four sharpened No. 2 pencils.

“Since the two of you flatly refused to sit at separate testing tables,” Ms. Hollis announced pointedly, resting her palms on the packets, “I have pulled two different versions of the five-part Web Applications Developer entrance battery. Nathaniel, you have Form A. Katie, you have Form B, where all of the problem sets and multiple-choice items are scrambled in a completely different order. You have until three-thirty tomorrow afternoon to complete all five booklets: Computer Hardware and Operating Environments, HTML and Web Page Design, Applied Algebra, Binary and Boolean Logic, and Relational Database Normalization.”

She gestured to Mr. Miller, who pulled a metal folding chair right up to the opposite side of Testing Table Two—barely four feet from our front casters—and sat down holding a clipboard and a digital stopwatch while Ms. Hollis positioned herself directly behind our wheelchairs.

“Mr. Miller will be sitting right here facing your hands and eyes the entire time, and I will be monitoring from behind your chairs,” Ms. Hollis said coldly. “If either of you whispers a single word, glances sideways at the other person’s booklet or bubble sheet, taps a code on your wheelchair armrests, or shares a single line of scratch paper, both of your exams will be confiscated on the spot for academic dishonesty, you will receive an automatic failure on your DARS evaluation rubric, and you will be permanently disqualified from the Information Technology track. Do we understand each other?”

Katie looked straight up at Ms. Hollis without flinching. “Ma’am, my brother and I graduated with honors from the Community College of Hampton Roads three months ago,” she said evenly. “We don’t sit together to copy answers. We sit together because we’re twins, and neither of us has ever cheated on a test in our lives. Start your clock.”

Ms. Hollis pressed the button on her stopwatch. “Begin.”

Without looking at each other once, Katie and I rested our inner forearms lightly along our adjacent wheelchair armrests—just enough familiar twin contact to keep our nervous systems calm—and flipped open the heavy cardstock covers of Booklet One at the exact same second.

Ten seconds into page one, I heard Katie let out the exact same quiet, disgusted sigh through her nose that had just escaped mine.

It was March of 2007. Katie and I had been hand-coding HTML since seventh grade at Morrison Middle School in 1997, writing Quantum Basic 6.0 since high school in 2001, and building modern standards-compliant web pages at CCHR—and the official Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services “Web Applications Developer” Vocational Evaluation exam battery sitting on our table hadn’t been updated since the mid-1990s.

In Booklet One—Computer Hardware and Operating Environments—there wasn’t a single question about modern 2007 web servers, USB flash drives, or broadband ethernet networks. Instead, Question Three asked how many 1.44-megabyte three-and-a-half-inch floppy disks were required to back up an eleven-megabyte directory without compression. Question Nine asked how to set physical plastic jumpers on an ISA expansion card to resolve an IRQ interrupt conflict between a parallel printer port and a serial mouse. Question Fourteen asked how to edit startup configuration files in Q-Core so a desktop computer could free up enough conventional memory below the 640-kilobyte barrier to launch a database utility, and Question Twenty-

Two asked us to calculate how many minutes it would take to download a three-megabyte uncompressed bitmap image over a 28.8-kilobit-per-second dial-up telephone modem.

Shaking my head in silent disbelief as I darkened the green bubbles on Form A, I flipped to Booklet Two—HTML and Web Page Design—and nearly groaned out loud.

Every single question treated 1996 browser wars and long-deprecated HTML 3.2 markup as if they were the pinnacle of modern software engineering. Instead of cascading style sheets or semantic markup, the test demanded to know the exact body-tag attribute to tile a repeating sixteen-color GIF image across a webpage background, how to format paragraph text using deprecated inline font-face tags, how to slice a 640-by-480-pixel VGA screen into three separate scrolling framesets, and which proprietary tag made a line of warning text blink on and off or scroll horizontally across the screen like a stock ticker. Beside me, I could hear the crisp, irritated scratch of Katie's No. 2 pencil writing a brisk margin note on her written-response sheet before she bubbled in the obsolete answer the grading key wanted.

And yet, for the next three hours, Mr. Miller sat four feet away leaning forward on his elbows, staring unblinkingly from my eyes to Katie's eyes, while Ms. Hollis paced back and forth behind our rear push-handles every four minutes waiting to pounce on a sideways glance that never came.

She caught nothing—because there was nothing to catch.

Neither Katie nor I spoke a syllable, tilted a page, or lifted our eyes from our own paperwork. When ten o'clock arrived and Mr. Miller cleared his throat to announce the fifteen-minute morning restroom and water-fountain break, both of us simply shook our heads without looking up and kept right on working. On my yellow legal pad on the left side of the table, I worked front-to-back through Form A's two's-complement binary arithmetic, hexadecimal memory conversions, Boolean truth tables, and quadratic word problems in neat, vertical block columns; on the right side of the table, Katie tore through Form B's scrambled logic gates, algebraic proofs, third-normal-form relational database diagrams, and hand-written SQL join queries using her own distinct step-by-step factoring notation—ending with a final section that absurdly asked us to diagram how an HTML form passed query strings to a 1990s Perl CGI-BIN script over a dial-up intranet.

At eleven-forty-five—fifteen minutes before the lunch bell, having completed the entire two-day, twelve-hour testing battery in three hours and fifteen minutes flat—Katie and I closed the back covers of Booklet Five within ten seconds of each other, set our No. 2 pencils down on the laminate, and rolled side by side up to Ms. Hollis's desk.

"We're finished," I said, sliding Form A, my bubble sheet, my written SQL and HTML packet, and my scratch pad across her blotter as Katie laid Form B right beside mine.

Ms. Hollis stared down at the two completed stacks, her eyebrows shooting up in open skepticism. Convinced that we had either Christmas-treed the bubble sheets at random just to get out before lunch or found some clever way to copy off each other right under Mr. Miller's nose, she pulled the laminated Form A and Form B plastic

grading overlays out of her locked desk drawer and lined them up over our answer sheets right in front of us while Mr. Miller stepped over to check our written database normalization and scratch pads against the instructor key.

As Ms. Hollis's forefinger moved down the columns of green bubbles on Form A and then Form B, the smug expectation drained right out of her face.

"Ninety-nine percent on Form A," Ms. Hollis murmured under her breath, blinking twice before recounting the holes on Katie's overlay, "and ninety-eight percent on Form B."

Even more damning to her cheating theory, the single multiple-choice question I had missed on Booklet One wasn't even the same question Katie had missed on Booklet Three. Suspiciously, Ms. Hollis snatched up our two yellow scratch pads and held them side by side, hunting for identical handwriting, copied formulas, or matching erasures.

"Their scratch work is completely different from page one to the end, Ms. Hollis," Mr. Miller admitted quietly, pointing to our written SQL and HTML packets. "He solved all the hexadecimal conversions by factoring through base-two, and she solved hers by direct base-sixteen division. And on the written HTML and database section, they both got one hundred percent—in fact, on Question Forty-Two, Katie wrote a three-sentence citation in the margin explaining that the test key's 1996 HTML 3.2 syntax was officially deprecated by the World Wide Web Consortium in 1999, and she wrote out both the obsolete 1996 tag from our answer key and the modern CSS2 rule so we couldn't mark it wrong."

Katie folded her hands neatly on her lap tray and looked straight across the desk at Ms. Hollis.

"And while we're on the subject of Question Forty-Two, Ms. Hollis, that entire exam battery is an embarrassment," Katie said bluntly. "Whoever wrote those five booklets hasn't updated a single page since my brother and I were in seventh grade in 1997. Half the hardware questions were asking about 28.8k dial-up modems, 1.44-megabyte floppy disks, and ISA jumper pins, and the web design section tested HTML 3.2 font and blink tags that nobody in the real world has used in almost ten years."

"If we had handed in HTML 3.2 framesets and font tags like that at the Community College of Hampton Roads," I added dryly, "our professors would have failed us on the spot. At least once we're out of Vocational Evaluation and inside Mr. Alderman's Web Applications Developer lab on Monday morning, we'll be working in an actual 2007 computer classroom instead of filling out 1990s paper packets."

Pressing her lips into a thin, bloodless line, Ms. Hollis couldn't say a word in rebuttal. With two near-perfect answer sheets, forty pages of independent scratch work, and our Monday ultimatum hanging over her desk, she uncapped her pen, stiffly signed both of our one-week Vocational Evaluation completion forms, and cleared us to start the Web Applications Developer class on Monday morning.

Saturday, March 10, 2007, 1:00 PM — Still Stuck on Level 2 in Barton Hall & Hating the Yellow Hall Pass Rule

“Look at this yellow slip of paper, Nate,” Katie whispered in disgust on Saturday afternoon as we sat parked wheel-to-wheel in the Barton Hall lobby holding two signed yellow paper Level 2 Hall Passes while we waited by the glass doors for the Center recreation van. “We rushed the entire two-week Voc Eval in one single week so we could start our Web Applications Developer class on Monday morning, and we’re still stuck right here in Barton Hall on Level 2!”

“Because moving over to Cantor Hall is part of earning Level 3, and nobody who’s only been on campus for six days has been here long enough to earn Level 3, let alone Level 4,” I muttered, looking down at the counselor’s signature on my yellow paper pass. “Back home in Norfolk or Virginia Beach, if we want to go buy snacks or browse computer books at Chapters & Co., we just roll out our front door to the nearest CVTA bus stop, pay our fare, and go wherever we please like normal adults. Up here in Barton Hall, a Level 2 client can’t even roll past the front gates on Roosevelt Avenue to catch the local VATS shuttle bus between Staunton, Fishersville, and Waynesboro without begging the dorm office for a signed yellow Hall Pass stating where we’re going and what minute we’ll be back.”

“And if you don’t want to wait two hours on the shoulder of Route 250 for the VATS bus on a Saturday,” Katie added, gesturing toward the recreation clipboard hanging outside the lobby office where students had to sign up for chaperoned van trips to The Spot recreation hangout or the Waynesboro ValueMart, “you have to sign up for a chaperoned Center van ride! We will be twenty-two years old in four weeks, Nate. We have associate degrees, we run our own regional transit website, and we had to get a signed Hall Pass from a dorm counselor just to ride four miles down the road to buy laundry detergent and ginger ale at ValueMart—the exact store Ms. Hollis thought I should stand at the door and greet shoppers for!”

“And tonight makes our seventh night in a row being forced down separate hallways for the eleven-o’clock bed check,” I whispered back, lacing my fingers tightly through hers across our armrests as the white Center van pulled up to the curb outside. “Let’s see what Mr. Alderman’s PHP class looks like on Monday morning, Katie—because I am already sick to death of this place.”

Starting Web Apps While Stuck in Barton Hall, Sleeping in the Closet, & The Chickenshit Report

Part 1: Starting Web Apps While Stuck on Level 2 in Barton Hall, Quantum OS 2000 Professional, & Meeting Tina, Jim, and Sheila

Date: 2007-03-12 at 08:00 America/New_York

Monday, March 12, 2007, 8:00 AM — “Death Before Dishonor, NOTHING Before Coffee!”, Adult Bathroom Rules, & Sitting Together in Class

“*Death before dishonor, NOTHING before coffee!*” Katie read aloud with a grin at eight o’clock on Monday morning as we rolled our joystick-outfitted wheelchairs down the 1970s concrete-block corridor of the Information Technology wing and

paused outside the interior office window of the Computer Hardware lab right next door to our classroom, where a bold vinyl sticker was plastered across the glass above a gurgling twelve-cup commercial coffee brewer.

“That’s Mr. Culpepper’s office window,” a middle-aged student with a salt-and-pepper beard chuckled, stepping out of the adjoining hardware doorway holding an empty ceramic mug while half a dozen hardware students hovered around the counter waiting for the amber pot to finish dripping. “He teaches the Computer Hardware and network cabling lab next door, and I’m telling you right now, that classroom never gets started for the day until the coffee is brewed and ready. Those guys swear by their morning coffee.”

“More for you guys, then,” I laughed as Katie and I pulled two cold cans of ginger ale out of our backpack side pockets. “Neither my sister nor I can stand the taste of coffee.”

“You two must be Nathaniel and Katie Prairie,” our Web Applications Developer instructor, Mr. Alderman, said with a welcoming smile, stepping out of the adjacent computer lab doorway as Mr. Culpepper gave us a friendly wave through his sticker-adorned office window next door. Mr. Alderman gestured toward the long double workstation table near the front of our lab where two wide wheelchair bays sat side by side. “I saw how the two of you tore through the entire Voc Eval coding packet in a single sitting on Thursday morning. Take those two stations right there together—you’ve got plenty of room to park your chairs wheel-to-wheel.”

“Thank you, Mr. Alderman,” Katie said, exhaling the first genuine breath of relief either of us had taken since arriving in Fishersville as we steered into the adjacent bays and locked our manual wheel brakes side by side. “After Ms. Hollis spent last week trying to split us up to opposite corners of the break room, we half-expected another lecture about sitting apart.”

“Not in my classroom, and not in Mr. Culpepper’s lab next door either,” Mr. Alderman said firmly, leaning against the instructor podium while the aroma of Mr. Culpepper’s fresh-brewed coffee drifted through the open connecting doorway and Katie and I popped the tabs on our cold ginger ales. “We treat our students like grown adults on a real job site. You sit where you work best, and one more thing so you know you’re not in Voc Eval anymore: in this classroom, you never have to raise your hand or ask permission to go to the bathroom. Simply tell me you’re heading to the restroom so I know where you are, and go. How’s Barton Hall treating you two so far?”

“Honestly, we’re already counting the hours on our fingers,” I admitted as Katie and I unzipped our backpacks. “Even though we rushed Voc Eval in one week so we could start your class today, we’re still stuck over in Barton Hall on Level 2 because moving to Cantor Hall is part of earning Level 3, and nobody stays long enough in seven days to earn Level 3 or Level 4. That makes eight straight nights of being forced down separate men’s and women’s wings at eleven o’clock with flashlights shining in our faces, plus begging for signed yellow paper Hall Passes just to step off campus.”

“Ah, watch out for the overnight dorm log over there,” Mr. Alderman said with a dry chuckle, shaking his head. “Half the night staff in the dorms love writing down every petty little thing they can find on what the teachers around here call the Chickenshit Report. Just keep your heads down in my lab and you’ll be fine.”

9:00 AM — Quantum OS 2000 Professional, Meeting Tina, Jim, and Sheila, & Refusing to Be Pushed Around

“All right, everyone, now that Mr. Culpepper’s coffee pot next door is finally done brewing and the building is officially awake, go ahead and hit the power switches on the desktop towers so you can see what the Commonwealth left us with,” Mr. Alderman called out at nine o’clock once the rest of the class had settled into their seats.

Katie and I pressed the round plastic power buttons on the two beige Commonwealth of Virginia property-tagged desktop towers sitting on our table. As the bulky CRT monitors flickered to life with a high-pitched static hum, both of us stared in disbelief at the splash screen.

“Quantum OS 2000 Professional?” Katie whispered, blinking at the screen. “Nate, it’s March of 2007! This operating system is seven years old!”

I clicked the Start menu to open a command prompt and check the local PHP configuration—and immediately hit a glaring red system dialog box: *ADMINISTRATOR ACCESS DENIED — CONTACT VITA SYSTEM ADMINISTRATOR*. Not only was the operating system seven years out of date, but VITA—the Virginia Information Technology Agency in Richmond—had locked the machines down with group-policy permissions so suffocating that a student login couldn’t install up-to-date software or a modern web browser, couldn’t edit a local PHP configuration file, couldn’t start or stop a local web server service, and couldn’t even open the control panel.

Across the aisle from our wheelchairs, the middle-aged man with the salt-and-pepper beard who had been waiting on Mr. Culpepper’s coffee pot earlier tapped his keyboard twice, stared at the locked-down Quantum OS 2000 Professional desktop, and let out a dry laugh. “Well, if the Commonwealth wants us to build database-driven web applications on these dinosaurs, I hope they’re planning to give us until the year 2030.”

“Where are you from?” I asked, hearing the unmistakable Tidewater cadence in his voice.

“Virginia Beach,” he grinned, setting his mug down and reaching across the aisle to shake my hand and then Katie’s. “I’m Jim. Spent twenty years working on computer hardware and network cabling down at the Oceanfront and Lynnhaven before my back gave out and Voc Rehab sent me up the mountain to retrain.”

“No way—we’re from Virginia Beach too!” Katie beamed. “We live right on Arvin Road in Kempsville, and we went to Northwood High School and the Community College of Hampton Roads!”

At the two workstations immediately to Katie’s right, two middle-aged women turned their chairs around with warm smiles. The woman sitting closest to Katie was short and petite, Caucasian, with straight jet-black hair and sharp eyes behind her glasses; beside her sat a cheerful woman with a sketchpad full of interface wireframes.

“I’m Tina, from up Route 340 in Luray,” the petite woman in glasses said, shaking Katie’s hand and then mine, “and this is Sheila—she commutes down I-81 from Harrisonburg every morning and does all our digital graphics and UI layouts. While half the twenty-year-olds in the dorms spend all day screaming at each other in the cafeteria, the three of us actually came here to build software.”

“And there is only one way any of us writes real PHP and SQL in this room,” Sheila added, sliding the beige state keyboard all the way to the back of her desk against the CRT monitor.

Right beside Katie, Tina unzipped her shoulder bag, pulled out her own sleek personal laptop, and set it right on the desk in front of the useless state keyboard—alongside a well-thumbed, spiral-bound copy of the Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center Student Handbook bristling with sticky notes.

“Every single student in this class—Jim, Sheila, Sarah, Amanda, Bryan, Sean, and me—brings our own personal laptop and runs a local web server, PHP 5, and an SQL database on our own hard drive,” Tina told us plainly, adjusting her glasses. “Technically the Center rules say no personal computers in class, but Mr. Alderman and the old vocational administrator let us do it because they know VITA locked these state towers down so tight you can’t code a single script on them.”

“Wait—why do you have sticky notes all through the student handbook?” Katie asked, glancing at Tina’s spiral booklet.

Tina grinned behind her glasses. “Because I’m short, I stay in the dorms here four nights a week before I drive my compact sedan home to Luray every Friday afternoon at three-thirty sharp, and I don’t let anyone at this center push me around. I tell it like it is straight to their faces, and the RRC staff hate it—but they can’t write me up or touch me because I never break a single rule in this book. I heard down the hall how the two of you rushed Voc Eval in one week flat and told off Ms. Hollis when she tried to split you up at social break. Good for you. Half the staff here think a clipboard—or seeing rubber push-handles on the back of a wheelchair—gives them a license to boss you around. Follow the handbook to the letter and call them on their nonsense, and there’s not a thing they can do to you.”

At four o’clock that very afternoon, when class let out and Tina walked over to the Barton Hall lobby with us to drop off a PHP reference binder before heading to her car, we saw Tina’s method in action firsthand.

Katie and I rolled side by side up to the Barton Hall front counter, laid our signed yellow paper Level 2 Hall Passes on the blotter to log our departure for the VATS shuttle bus into Waynesboro, and turned our wheelchairs toward the automatic glass doors—just as a prickly afternoon residential supervisor named Mr. Vance marched out of the inner office and stepped right in front of our front casters with his arms crossed.

“Hold on right there, you two,” Mr. Vance barked, reaching his right hand out to grab the rear rubber push-handle of my manual frame as if he were about to wheel me backward away from the exit. “Where do you think you’re rolling off to at four o’clock? You two are still Level 2 clients here in Barton Hall!”

“First, take your hand off my brother’s wheelchair push-handle right now,” Katie said sharply, locking her joystick brakes alongside mine without backing up a millimeter. “Second, we know we’re still Level 2, Mr. Vance, which is why our counselor signed our yellow Hall Passes at three-thirty and they are sitting right there on the desk blotter in front of you.”

“Under Section Three of the residential handbook,” I said evenly, pointing down at the two signed yellow slips clipped to the desk ledger, “Level 2 clients who have completed their afternoon training block and hold a signed Hall Pass are permitted off campus until eight o’clock in the evening. Just because our wheelchairs have manual push-handles on the back so they can fold into a car trunk doesn’t mean staff get to grab them or push us around when we’ve followed your rules to the letter.”

Standing right beside Katie’s chair with her car keys in her hand, Tina peered up at Mr. Vance through her glasses, her jet-black hair framing a look of cool, unapologetic amusement.

“They’ve got you dead to rights on page twelve of the handbook, Mr. Vance,” Tina said bluntly in front of half the lobby. “Their yellow passes are signed in ink, they logged their departure time, and neither of them is breaking a single rule in this building. If you keep grabbing his chair and blocking the doorway when they’ve complied with Center policy, the only person violating the handbook here is you.”

Mr. Vance’s face flushed crimson from his collar to his hairline. He glared at Tina and then down at Katie and me, searching desperately for something to cite us for—and finding nothing at all, he let go of my push-handle and stepped stiffly out of the doorway.

Tuesday, March 13, 2007, 9:30 AM — Coding on Personal Laptops & Standing Up to the New VITA-Obsessed Administrator

“Mr. Alderman,” a sharp voice rang out from the doorway of the Web Applications Developer classroom at nine-thirty on Tuesday morning, “why are all of these students using personal laptops instead of the Center-provided computers?”

Katie, Tina, Sheila, Jim, and I all paused with our fingers hovering over our personal laptop keyboards and looked toward the center aisle. Standing there in a pressed navy suit with a clipboard tucked against her arm was the brand-new vocational division administrator who had started on campus that week—frowning down the row of open personal laptops sitting in front of the dark, powered-off state CRT monitors.

“Because, ma’am,” Katie spoke up politely from her wheelchair before Mr. Alderman even had to step around the podium, “the Center-provided computers on these desks are horribly outdated. They’re still running Quantum OS 2000 Professional, and VITA has the permissions locked down so hard that we can’t install up-to-date software, configure a PHP server, or run a local database.”

The new administrator marched over to our front workstation table, looking down at Katie and me in our wheelchairs as if she expected the two of us to shrink back and shut our laptop lids. “VITA has assured my office that every workstation on the Commonwealth network is configured with standard agency software and

mandatory security lockdowns," she said sharply. "You are clients here, not the IT department. Close those personal laptops right now and use the computers VITA provided."

Neither Katie nor I touched our laptop hinges.

"No, ma'am, we won't do that," I said calmly from my chair, meeting her stare without blinking. "Our state vocational rehabilitation plans specifically fund us to complete the Commonwealth's accredited Web Applications Developer syllabus in PHP 5 and relational database design. If you force us onto seven-year-old Quantum OS 2000 Professional machines where VITA has blocked local web servers and command prompts, you are preventing us from completing the state-mandated curriculum."

Right beside Katie's chair, Tina stood up to her full petite height, pushed her glasses up the bridge of her nose, opened her spiral-bound handbook, and looked the new administrator straight in the eye.

"Let me tell you how it is, since somebody needs to say it plainly," Tina said, her voice steady and fearless while Sheila and Jim stood behind us. "None of us is breaking a single VITA network rule—not one of these personal laptops is plugged into the Commonwealth's ethernet jacks. VITA configured those beige dinosaurs on the desks for someone typing memos in a seven-year-old word processor, not for web application developers. We need computers with up-to-date software, and we need permissions not to be locked down so hard that we can't even start a local web server or edit a configuration file. Unless VITA is going to walk in here today and install modern software with developer permissions on those towers, closing our laptops means shutting down the entire class."

"And if you shut down the class," Katie added evenly from her wheelchair, reaching across our armrests to hold my hand, "my brother and I—and everyone else at these desks—will be happy to call our regional Vocational Rehabilitation counselors before lunch and explain that the new administration in Fishersville won't let us write code."

The new administrator stared from Tina's unblinking glasses to Katie's and my twin wheelchairs. Because not a single personal laptop in the room was plugged into the state ethernet wall jacks, we weren't violating a single VITA network regulation, and she knew Mr. Alderman, Mr. Culpepper next door, and the regional counselors would back us up. Muttering under her breath about "consulting with VITA compliance," she turned on her heel and walked out the door, leaving the five of us to exchange satisfied grins and go right back to coding on our personal laptops: Katie, Tina, and I writing the PHP back-end logic, Sheila designing the interface graphics, and Jim keeping everyone's hardware humming.

Part 2: Emergency in the Therapeutic Pool, Caught Sleeping Together in a Closet, Calling the Staffer's Bluff, & The Chickenshit Report

Date: 2007-03-13 at 16:15 America/New_York

Tuesday, March 13, 2007, 4:15 PM — Emergency at the Therapeutic Pool & The Towel Showdown

“I told you to leave her alone!” I shouted across the ninety-two-degree water of the indoor therapeutic pool at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center, projecting my voice intentionally loud so the recreation staffer sitting behind the office glass would hear me.

Across the warm water from where our two joystick-outfitted wheelchairs sat parked at the top of the sloped therapeutic pool entry ramp, Chris—an aggressive student from the IT class cohort who had been pestering Katie since Monday morning and refused to accept that my twin sister had zero interest in dating him—smirked and wading-stepped closer.

“Come on, Nate, let’s swim up to the shallow ramp,” Katie said tightly, turning in the warm water to get away from him.

We pushed off through the buoyant water toward the shallow ramp together, and Chris plowed straight through the water right behind us. Before I could pivot between them, he lunged forward and slammed both hands down into the water right in front of Katie’s face—striking her hard across the bridge of her nose and cheek while his flailing fingers caught and tore the front piece of her two-piece swimsuit top.

Katie gasped, clutched onto my left forearm with one hand while clapping her other hand over her face, and burst into sobs.

My heart dropped into my stomach. Katie never cried over splashes or arguments; if Katie was crying, she was hurt.

Wrapping my arm around her waist in the buoyant water, I guided her immediately up the submerged shallow ramp to our parked wheelchairs at the edge of the wet tile deck and helped her transfer into her seat while I pulled myself into mine right beside her. When I gently eased her hand back half an inch to check her face, I saw two things at the exact same second: Chris’s hand had split the thin skin right across the bony bridge of her nose while rupturing the blood vessels inside her nostrils so bright red blood was pouring steadily from her nose, and the front piece of her swimsuit top had been ripped away in the water, leaving her chest bare while both of her hands had to stay pressed tightly over her bleeding nostrils.

“Get me Student Health and Campus Security!” I roared at the top of my lungs across the natatorium. “My sister’s nose is bleeding!”

Since Katie was in no condition to speak with both of her hands occupied holding her bleeding nose, I angled my wheelchair right in front of hers and leaned forward to use my own hands to cover up my sister’s bare breasts and shield her modesty on the open pool deck while we waited for someone to bring a towel.

Instead of grabbing a towel from the rack by the wall, the poolside staffer walked over with a clipboard in his hand and frowned at me.

“You know I’m going to have to report you for inappropriate contact,” the staffer said, staring straight at my hands covering my sister’s chest while blood dripped between her fingers onto the wet tile.

“Either report me or get a towel to cover my sister’s dignity!” I retorted angrily, not giving a damn what he thought while my sister sat bleeding and exposed in front of the pool.

Staring at the blood running down Katie’s wrists and her torn swimsuit top floating by the gutter, it finally dawned on the staffer why my hands were covering her chest. He hurried over to the rack and brought back a thick white bath towel just as the Recreational Therapy supervisor rushed out with a walkie-talkie crackling that both Student Health and RRC Campus Police were on the way.

Only when that dry towel was wrapped securely around Katie’s chest and shoulders did I let go.

Seconds later, two Student Health nurses pushed through the double doors and immediately pressed a sterile gauze pack over Katie’s bleeding nose and swollen cheek, while a Campus Police officer pulled out his notepad to take a formal written statement from me and three other students who had witnessed Chris lunge at her in the water.

Over the edge of the bloody gauze pack, Katie fixed the poolside staffer who had threatened to write me up with a furious glare.

“You’re going to write up my brother for trying to cover my boobs while no one wanted to get a towel or something?” she stammered thickly past the bandage.

The staffer looked down at his shoes without a word as the Recreational Therapy supervisor ordered everyone out of the water, closing the natatorium so maintenance could scrub the tile coping with a one-to-ten bleach solution, shock-chlorinate the ninety-two-degree water to four parts per million, and run a full sixty-minute filtration turnover hold.

While Student Health escorted Katie across the walkway to the clinic in the Bates-Harding Building, one of Katie’s female friends from our class hurried into the women’s locker room and brought all of Katie’s dry clothes and backpack out to me. Stacking her bag on the seat of her wheelchair, I rolled both chairs over to the Student Health waiting room and sat stubbornly outside the exam door until evening —refusing to be more than ten feet away from my sister while she was hurt.

7:30 PM – 11:25 PM — Closing Time at the Rec Hall, Locking the Seasonal Closet From the Inside in Street Clothes, & Accused of Having Sex

“I don’t want to leave your side,” Katie whispered at seven-thirty that evening as the Student Health clinic door opened and she rolled out wearing her swimsuit bottom and a worn-out oversized loaner T-shirt. Once the clinic nurses had finally gotten the heavy bleeding inside her nostrils to clot and stop, they had had to pull the split skin across the bony bridge of her nose together with sterile MedStrip wound-closure strips and tape a protective white gauze-and-paper-tape dressing across the bridge of her nose and swollen right cheek, instructing her to keep the MedStrips and white tape bandage dry and in place across her nose for a full seven days so the split bridge wouldn’t reopen. Reaching across our armrests for my hand as we rolled toward Barton Hall in the gathering dusk, she started sobbing again. “I don’t give a damn about the Level 2 dorm rule… please don’t leave me tonight, Nate.”

“We used to live together!” she stammered as we paused outside the Barton Hall entrance so she could run into her room just long enough to change out of her damp swimwear into dry street clothes—blue jeans, sneakers, and a zip-up fleece hoodie. “We used to share a bed! Hell, we would sleep in closets together!”

Looking at the fresh white gauze taped across my trembling sister’s swollen nose after eight straight nights of forced separation in Barton Hall, I made up my mind on the spot. We weren’t going to try rolling down the dorm hallways in pajamas carrying pillows and blankets off our beds—that would be a dead giveaway to every staff member on duty. Instead, once Katie came back out in her dry jeans and hoodie, the two of us rolled over to the campus Rec Hall to spend the evening together in a corner booth where no one could separate us.

At ten-forty that night, the Rec Hall staffer flicked the overhead lights twice and called out across the game tables that it was five minutes until ten-forty-five—the mandatory departure time for all Level 2 clients to head back to Barton Hall ahead of the eleven-o’clock curfew check, while Level 3 and Level 4 clients from Cantor Hall were allowed to stay until the Rec Hall closed at eleven sharp.

Still dressed in our full daytime street clothes and shoes, Katie and I looked at each other and nodded without saying a word. First, both of us went to the bathroom one last time so neither of us would have to open a door in the middle of the night.

When we rolled back out of the restrooms at ten-forty-four, while the staffer at the Rec Hall front counter was busy collecting billiard balls and board games and the other Level 2 students were filing out the front glass doors toward Barton Hall, Katie and I checked over our shoulders to make sure no one was looking—and slipped quietly down a darkened hallway off the rear of the Rec Hall.

At the end of that darkened hallway stood the heavy solid-wood door to the seasonal storage closet—a walk-in closet big enough to fit both of our wheelchairs inside out of sight.

I reached out and tried the brass doorknob. To our relief, it turned smoothly—it was unlocked!

Immediately, Katie and I rolled both of our joystick-outfitted wheelchairs all the way inside the dark closet, pulled the door shut behind us, and twisted the interior thumb-turn lock until it clicked, locking the door from the inside.

In the quiet darkness, smelling of cedar and cardboard boxes, we clicked off our wheelchair power switches and felt around the shelves and floor for anything soft. Packed along the back wall were lumpy canvas storage bags stuffed with spare winter coats, folded fabric stage curtains, and foam cushions. Still wearing our full street clothes, jeans, hoodies, and sneakers, we pulled two lumpy bundles onto the linoleum floor to use as makeshift pillows, spread a thick folded stage curtain over our shoulders as a makeshift blanket, and transferred out of our wheelchairs onto the floor.

Wrapping both of our arms tightly around each other in the dark, Katie tucked her head beneath my chin with a long, shaky exhale. Confident that nobody would ever find us locked inside a back seasonal closet, we started to drift off to sleep in our street clothes.

At eleven-twenty-five, just as I was sliding into sleep with my arms around my sister, the sound of footsteps echoed down the darkened Rec Hall hallway outside our closet.

Both of us went completely still in the dark.

The footsteps stopped right outside our door. Someone grabbed the outer brass doorknob and tried to turn it—*rattle, rattle*—finding it locked from the inside.

Katie and I held our breath and remained dead quiet, not moving a muscle in the dark.

Then, right outside the wood, we heard the metallic jingle of a master key ring. A key scraped into the outside lock cylinder, the bolt clicked back as someone unlocked the door, and the solid-wood door swung wide open as a blinding flashlight beam swept past our two parked wheelchairs and shone straight down onto the two of us huddled in our street clothes on the floor.

"Aha! I knew it!" the night supervisor barked, glaring down at us while the Rec Hall staffer stood behind him in the hallway. "What the hell do you two think you're doing locking yourselves inside a dark closet to have sex?! You know the Center rule—if two clients are caught having sex anywhere on this campus, at any time, both of you get kicked out of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center!"

We had already heard plenty of stories from other students during our first week and a half about clients sneaking off to have sex being a rampant thing all over campus, and the second the supervisor barked *"I knew it!"* without even pausing to look at us, we figured this back closet in the Rec Hall was probably one of the places where clients got caught hooking up.

Neither Katie nor I shrank back an inch. Pushing the makeshift curtain off our shoulders as we transferred back up into our wheelchairs in our full street clothes and sneakers, both of us went straight back at the night supervisor at full volume.

"Have sex?!" I roared in disgust, staring at him like he had lost his mind. "Are you out of your sick mind?! First of all, she's my twin sister! Second, look at us—we're wearing our full street clothes, jeans, hoodies, and shoes! We locked ourselves in here to sleep using lumpy bags as pillows because my sister got her nose broken open in your pool this afternoon and your stupid Level 2 dorm rules wouldn't let us stay together!"

"Look at my face!" Katie snapped furiously, pointing straight at the swollen purple bruise on her cheek and the white medical tape across her broken nose. "My nose was broken open in your therapeutic pool five hours ago by a creep in our class, your poolside staffer tried to write my brother up for covering my dignity when nobody brought a towel, and when we just wanted a quiet closet where my brother could hold me so I wouldn't be alone all night, you unlock the door and accuse twin brother and sister of having sex?!"

"I don't care what story you give me—locking yourselves inside a dark seasonal closet together and skipping the eleven-o'clock curfew check is grounds for expulsion!" the night supervisor barked, shaking his clipboard in our faces. "Keep yelling at me like that, both of you, and I will have you kicked out of this Center and sent home right now!"

Katie and I called his bluff on the spot.

“Do it! Kick us out right now!” I fired right back at him without blinking, unlocking my wheelchair brakes and rolling straight out of the closet into the Rec Hall corridor. “It’s eleven-twenty-five at night—don’t wait until morning! Walk right down the hall to the Rec Hall’s front-desk telephone and call our father in Alexandria right now! Tell him to get in his pickup truck and come pick us up tonight!”

“Go on, walk over to the Rec Hall desk phone and call our Dad in Alexandria right now!” Katie dared him at the top of her lungs, rolling right out beside me and pointing down the hallway toward the front counter. “Wake him up at eleven-twenty-five, tell him you’re kicking us out, and then explain to him why my nose is bandaged! We’re ready to leave this place right now—we’ll go back across to Barton Hall and pack our suitcases this second!”

The night supervisor froze dead in his tracks with his pen in the air.

He stared from my face to Katie’s bandaged nose, realizing in an instant that we weren’t scared teenagers begging not to get expelled—we were dead serious and ready to roll across to our rooms and pack our bags that very minute. Within three seconds, every ounce of bluster drained out of his face, and he backed all the way down.

“Nobody is calling your father tonight, and nobody is getting kicked out,” the night supervisor muttered stiffly, lowering his clipboard and refusing to take a single step toward the Rec Hall desk telephone. “Your vocational counselor is off work tomorrow on Wednesday. I am putting a residential write-up in the overnight log for missing eleven-o’clock bed check, and your counselor will speak to the two of you about this on Thursday morning when she returns. Now get across to Barton Hall and go to your assigned beds.”

Only when we were back in our separate rooms in Barton Hall ten minutes later with our laptop webcams open on our nightstands so we could watch over each other through the screen did Katie speak quietly into her microphone.

“Wait a second, Nate,” Katie whispered, frowning thoughtfully past the white tape across her nose. “Everybody on campus knows the rule: if two students are caught having sex anywhere at any time, both of them get kicked out of the Center automatically. He automatically assumed that’s what we were doing and threatened to kick us out on the spot—so why did he back down the very second we told him to call Dad in Alexandria and said we were ready to leave tonight?”

“Because he realized kicking us out wasn’t a punishment to us—we actually wanted to leave,” I said quietly.

“I think it’s more than that, Nate,” Katie said slowly, her sharp eyes narrowing on the screen. “Think about how hard Voc Eval pushed to keep us here for two full weeks, and how fast that supervisor just panicked when he saw two full-time Web Applications students ready to pack their suitcases in Week Two. I bet the Center’s funding from the state is tied to how many dorm beds and classroom seats they keep filled. They only kick people out when they think you’ll beg to stay—the second he saw we’d gladly walk out the door tonight, he backed down so they wouldn’t lose two seats.”

“Whether it’s their headcount funding or covering their own behinds over the pool, we now know their threats are hollow,” I whispered back.

“I just need to be hugged,” Katie murmured toward the webcam, her bandaged nose and swollen cheek catching the glow of her screen.

“I know,” I said softly, keeping my hand resting beside the camera lens until her eyelids drooped, “and I’ll be waiting right outside your suite door first thing in the morning. Goodnight, Katie.”

Wednesday, March 14, 2007, 8:30 AM — The Bates-Harding Office & “I LET HIM COVER MY DIGNITY!”

“I’m still so upset,” Katie whispered in my ear at quarter to eight on Wednesday morning as we met right outside her women’s-wing suite door and I pulled her into a tight morning hug across our armrests.

“I understand,” I whispered back, rubbing her shoulder. Hoping to coax even a tiny smile out of her, I asked, “You ready to go eat some more garbage?”

Katie giggled just a bit against my collar, though when I started to ease back from the hug, she held on tightly to my jacket sleeves and refused to let go—making it crystal clear without words: *please don’t let go*.

As we finally rolled side by side past the Barton Hall front desk toward the dining hall breezeway, the morning desk clerk looked up from the overnight binder and tapped a pink slip of paper. “Nathaniel, Katie—just so you know, your regular vocational counselor has her scheduled day off today, so your disciplinary write-up meeting for getting caught in the hallway closet at eleven o’clock last night is on her calendar for Thursday morning. Also, check the lobby board after dinner tonight—housing is running the mid-month dormitory room reassignments this evening.”

Neither of us cared about Thursday’s closet write-up meeting—and as soon as we finished breakfast at eight-thirty, an administrative runner paged both of us over to the student-services duty supervisor’s office in the Bates-Harding Building regarding Tuesday afternoon’s incident at the pool.

Rolling through the wood-paneled office door beside Katie, I took one look at the printout sitting on the duty supervisor’s desk—the morning Chickenshit Report—and saw the poolside staffer’s entry from Tuesday afternoon literally accusing me of *“fondling Katie’s bare breasts while she was in distress, after having been assaulted and her swimsuit top destroyed by the person who assaulted her.”*

Katie rolled her eyes and growled across the desk, “Delete that from the record! I told him to cover my boobs while we waited for someone to get a damn towel! None of this shit would’ve happened if that boy didn’t cause me a nosebleed in the first place!”

My sister was furious—Katie never cussed like that in front of staff—and she kept right on going: “And I don’t care if you call our Dad! He would tell you himself that my brother acted protectively in covering them!”

Having riled herself all the way up on top of Tuesday's pool assault and getting dragged out of the closet at eleven o'clock the night before, Katie's nervous system overloaded all at once, her voice cutting out as she descended straight into a full autistic meltdown.

Instinctively, I steered my wheelchair flush against hers, locked my brakes, and held her tightly in my arms while she trembled against my shoulder.

The duty supervisor looked into Katie's blank, overloaded eyes, seeing immediately that the only reason she had gone completely silent was because her autistic brain was in a full sensory shutdown.

"Let me try something," the supervisor said quietly, pressing the intercom button on his desk phone. "Could we please get a cup of water brought in for Katie?"

Turning back to the two of us while I held my trembling sister, he spoke in a calm, steady voice. "You really care about her, don't you, Nathaniel? No, I don't think you were touching her inappropriately. I think you were acting on instinct and shielding her from further humiliation while you waited for a towel to cover her up, and while she was busy trying to stop her nose from bleeding until help could arrive. I have the medical report from the nurses in Student Health right here on my desk that says the exact same thing."

When the secretary brought in a small paper cup of cool water and Katie slowly took a few sips, her breathing steadied. Reaching across the wooden desk, Katie pulled a yellow legal pad toward her wheelchair, picked up a thick black marker, and wrote down in firm block letters:

I LET HIM COVER MY DIGNITY!

"Katie, I'm agreeing with you," the supervisor said gently, tapping his keyboard and deleting the Tuesday afternoon poolside entry from my record on the spot. "That pool-deck entry is gone. Your regular counselor will still see the two of you tomorrow morning at ten o'clock regarding last night's eleven-o'clock seasonal closet write-up, since she's out of the office today, but as far as yesterday afternoon at the pool goes, you did the right thing looking out for your sister, Nathaniel."

"Back home in our apartment, we are at each other's side twenty-four hours a day," I told him bluntly before we unlocked our brakes to roll over to Mr. Alderman's classroom. "In case there's a meltdown or an emergency in the middle of the night, the other one is right there. We are not used to being apart—and we are not staying somewhere that treats keeping my sister safe like a rule violation."

Fifteen minutes later, when we rolled into the Web Applications Developer lab and told Tina, Sheila, and Jim that the poolside report had been deleted—while our ten-o'clock disciplinary meeting over getting locked in the seasonal closet was still on our counselor's calendar for Thursday morning—Tina immediately flipped open her sticky-noted Student Handbook to the residential discipline section and lowered her voice behind her glasses.

"Watch yourselves at ten o'clock tomorrow morning, you two," Tina warned us seriously. "Up until last night, the two of you were driving the staff crazy by bending the rules and lawyering the handbook without technically breaking a single written policy. Skipping the ten-forty-five Rec Hall departure and locking yourselves inside that seasonal closet after curfew, though, is the first time you

actually broke a written rule. And since the night supervisor already saw last night that threatening to kick you out doesn't scare you, they're going to try to hit you tomorrow morning with a Level 1 restriction."

"What's a Level 1 restriction?" Katie asked, frowning past the white tape across her nose.

"Level 2 is where every new student starts in Barton Hall—you can go anywhere on campus freely without signing out, and if you leave campus you either need a signed yellow paper Pass or you sign up at the Rec Hall desk for a Center-sponsored trip to places like The Spot or ValueMart, while Level 3 over in Cantor Hall only has to sign out to leave campus and Level 4 can come and go off campus as they please without any pass or sign-out," Tina explained, tapping page eighteen of her handbook. "Level 1 is the disciplinary punishment tier. If they demote you to Level 1 tomorrow morning, they strip away all of your off-campus Pass and trip privileges for up to thirty days so you can't even ride the VATS bus or leave the campus gates, lock you into your separate dorm wings right after supper with flashlight bed checks every thirty minutes, and force you to sign a written Behavioral Contract ordering mandatory separation during meals, breaks, and recreation hours. And under Center rules, if you refuse to sign a Level 1 Behavioral Contract, they threaten to expel you for non-compliance and call your family to come pick you up."

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests, and the exact same fire lit up in both of our eyes.

"We will never sign a Level 1 restriction or a separation contract," I promised Tina flatly. "Not a single word of it."

"I dare anyone in that counseling office to try to make us sign a piece of paper ordering my brother and me to stay apart or locking us into separate wings after supper!" Katie said fiercely, her hand gripping mine across our armrests. "And if they tell us that refusing to sign their Level 1 contract means we're kicked out of the Center and they're calling our father in Alexandria to come pick us up, we'll look them straight in the eye and say, *'Go ahead!'* Dad will be in his pickup truck heading down Interstate 81 before they even hang up the phone."

The Dormitory Room Mix-Up, A Safe Closet in Luray, & Leaving RRC After Twelve Days

Part 1: The Dormitory Room Mix-Up, Blind Red-Tape Room Reassignments, & A Sleepless Night for Natalie

Date: 2007-03-14 at 21:15 America/New_York

Wednesday, March 14, 2007, 9:15 PM — When Red Tape Blindly Follows a Scrambled Room Roster

"What are you doing in here, Tina?" I asked in surprise at nine-fifteen on Wednesday night as the door to my men's dormitory room in Barton Hall clicked open and in walked our short, petite classmate with her glasses and straight jet-black hair, holding a newly issued plastic room keycard and an overnight bag.

Tina pushed her glasses up the bridge of her nose and held up the white plastic keycard with a look of sheer disbelief. “I thought something was fishy when the front desk handed me this keycard ten minutes ago and told me my room had been reassigned over here to Barton Hall.”

Sitting in my wheelchair at my desk with my laptop webcam connected to Katie’s room on the women’s wing, I swiveled my laptop screen toward the doorway so the camera faced Tina. “Katie, look who just walked into my dorm room with a keycard.”

Over the live video window, Katie’s eyes went wide behind the white tape across her nose. Before Tina could say another word, the outer corridor door opened again and two more classmates from our Web Applications Developer cohort, Jim and Amanda, stepped into our hallway holding their own reassigned keycards and printed room slips.

“Wait a second—they moved Amanda and me out of Cantor Hall into the Barton Hall men’s wing too?” Tina said, comparing the printed room numbers stapled to their keycards against Jim’s slip. “Look at this roster sheet. The computer printout scrambled the men’s and women’s room numbers across the whole campus, and because of the ridiculous red tape around here, the front-desk staff just followed the printout blindly and handed out the keys anyway—putting women in men’s rooms and men in women’s wings without once using their brains to question the sheet!”

“Thank goodness I go home to Luray every Friday afternoon,” Tina added, shaking her head in disgust, “because four nights a week of this bureaucracy is already pushing my limit.”

“What’s going on over there?” Katie asked nervously through my laptop speakers. “Do not close this chat window, Nate. I’d come over to your room right now, except I need to stay by my things in case someone comes to my room.”

“Makes sense,” Tina said, gesturing toward the doorway. “And nobody at that front desk is pushing us around tonight. Come on, Nate, Jim—let’s roll out to the lobby counter and get this sorted out right now.”

Rolling out to the Barton Hall lobby counter with my open laptop balanced on my lap tray, we found the only evening dorm staffer on duty: Herbert—whom every student on campus called Herb because he was the one genuinely decent staffer who organized weekend video-game tournaments in the lounge, even though he had zero administrative authority to override housing red tape.

“I can’t even get through to my boss on the phone because it’s after hours, and the system locked me out of the housing database so I can’t check the master roster either,” Herb explained, holding up both hands helplessly behind the wooden counter as Tina tapped the scrambled room-assignment ledger. “Now, all of you in the IT class, I know you don’t break the rules—”

“Thanks, Herb,” Katie said through my laptop speaker.

At that exact second, on my laptop screen, the door to Katie’s dorm room on the women’s wing swung open.

“Katie, do you mind pointing the laptop toward the door?” Herb asked, leaning over the counter toward my screen. “I would like to see who it is.”

Katie turned her laptop camera toward her doorway—and froze in terror as Chris, the exact guy who had broken her nose open and torn her swimsuit top in the therapeutic pool the afternoon before, stood in her doorway waving a reassigned plastic keycard and launching into an aggressive verbal altercation with her.

I didn't hesitate for half a second.

"Katie: pack your things and come to my room," I said into the microphone. Turning my wheelchair toward Tina and Jim, I said, "I'm going to go get my sister. Jim, please come with me just in case that boy tries something."

I looked straight back into the webcam lens where Chris stood in Katie's doorway and said coldly, "You touch my sister again and I will personally murder you." Then I flashed a single look across the counter at Herb that said plain as day: *Don't even think about arguing with me.*

Herb looked back at me with quiet respect. "You really care about your sister, don't you?"

I nodded once and pushed my joystick full forward down the corridor toward the women's wing, with Jim and two more classmates from our class, Bryan and Sean, striding right beside my wheelchair.

By the time we turned into Katie's hallway, Chris had bolted out the side exit and Katie was shoving her clothes into her open suitcase with trembling hands. Rolling straight inside, I helped her sweep the rest of her clothes and toiletries into her bags while Jim, Bryan, and Sean lifted her suitcases to carry them back to my room on the men's wing.

Tears were streaming down Katie's cheeks around her nasal bandage as she rolled her wheelchair into my room beside me. Taking one look at her face when he checked the doorway, Herb didn't say a word about Level 2 visitation rules; he could see Katie was one breath away from snapping.

Katie wrapped her arm tightly around my shoulders, and I looked straight at Herb. "I don't care what the rules state." Turning to Tina, who held the reassigned keycard to the second bed in my room, I asked, "Would you care if my sister stayed right here in my room with me tonight?"

"Campus Police to Barton Hall," crackled loudly over Herb's walkie-talkie.

Herb hurried out of the hallway toward the main lobby to answer the radio call, leaving Amanda, Bryan, Jim, Katie, Kim, Sarah, Sean, Tina, and me inside the room. Looking through her glasses at the frightened expression on Katie's face, Tina spoke with warm, unmistakable kindness.

"She needs you right now, Nate," Tina said. "I have no problems at all—you two keep this whole room to yourselves tonight."

Once the door closed and we sat together by the edge of my narrow bed, I took my sister's shaking hands in mine. "Katie, what's wrong?"

Katie looked at me with wide, terrified blue eyes and squeaked, "Thank you for insisting I come down here."

Leaning close against my shoulder so her voice barely rose above a whisper, she trembled. “Nate… right before he opened my door, I heard crying down the hall. I think he hurt Natalie!”

Like a dam breaking, Katie buried her face against my neck and sobbed. Across the room, Tina, Sarah, and Jim exchanged grim, horrified looks: everyone on campus knew that while Natalie was chronologically an adult, cognitively she had the mind of a young child.

Tina sat down on the chair beside us, resting a steadying hand on Katie’s arm while the rest of our classmates kept watch by the door.

“Would you like to change into your PJs?” I asked my sister gently.

“Please,” she whispered, clutching my wrist and bringing me into the bathroom with her so she wouldn’t have to be alone behind a closed door for even sixty seconds.

When we came back out in our pajamas, Tina looked at the two of us with quiet resolve. “You know I drive my compact sedan home to Luray every single Friday afternoon anyway,” Tina said. “How about this weekend the two of you come with me and spend it at my house in Luray?”

“That might not be a bad idea,” Katie whispered, wiping her eyes with her sleeve.

“Pack yourselves a duffel bag tomorrow, and we will leave on Friday at three-thirty sharp as soon as Mr. Alderman’s class is over,” Tina promised, reaching for the wall switch to turn off the overhead fluorescent light on her way out the door so we could lock the room behind her.

As soon as we were alone in the quiet dark, neither Katie nor I even tried to lie out in the open on that narrow institutional Twin XL mattress. Just as we had planned over the glossy brochure back home on Arvin Road—and just as our nervous systems had needed every night since Brenda bang-searched the back alley behind Greenway Court—we pulled the blankets and two pillows off my bed, spread them lengthwise across the floor inside my six-foot dorm closet, transferred out of our wheelchairs onto the closet floor, and pulled the sliding closet doors completely shut.

“On one hand, I’m glad we are back together inside a closet again,” Katie whispered in the dark, pressing her forehead against my collarbone, “but yet on the other, I feel so weird and sick about what happened tonight.”

I wrapped both arms securely around her and whispered back, “I can’t wait to get out of here with Tina on Friday.”

Neither of us slept a single wink all night, lying wide awake in each other’s arms on that enclosed dorm closet floor until a thin line of gray dawn showed beneath the sliding doors.

Thursday, March 15, 2007, 6:15 AM — Canceled Write-Up Meetings & Sweeping Wednesday Night Under the Rug

At six-fifteen on Thursday morning, having not slept a minute, Katie, Tina, Sarah, and I dressed quietly and rolled out of my room into the main Barton Hall lobby, where Herb and the weekday morning supervisor, Kellie, were standing behind the counter surrounded by stacks of handwritten room rosters.

“Morning, you four,” Kellie said in his deep voice, gesturing toward the dark computer terminal on his desk without a single word of reprimand about Katie sleeping in my room the night before. “Our housing database is still completely locked up from last night’s scrambled bed reassignments, and the entire counseling wing is in an emergency staff meeting trying to sort out who is sleeping where—so Nathaniel, Katie, your counselor’s ten-o’clock disciplinary meeting over Tuesday night’s closet write-up is canceled.”

“Thank you for letting us know,” I said, keeping my left arm wrapped around my twin sister’s shoulders as the four of us rolled back out of the lobby toward the dining hall breezeway.

Once the automatic glass doors slid shut behind us, Tina glanced over her glasses at Katie and me with a dry, knowing smirk. “Well, how about that. If their own room database hadn’t blown up in their faces last night, your counselor would have been sliding a Level 1 restriction and a mandatory separation contract across her desk at ten o’clock this morning—and the two of you would already be on the phone calling your dad in Alexandria to come get you today.”

“And instead, their own chaos just bought us today and tomorrow in Mr. Alderman’s lab to copy the rest of the PHP and SQL curriculum onto our laptops before we head to Luray with you tomorrow afternoon,” Katie whispered back, squeezing my hand.

Right outside the cafeteria doors, Katie gasped softly and pointed toward the concrete bench by the bushes. Sitting on the bench surrounded by three of her friends was Natalie, sobbing inconsolably and rocking back and forth.

“That thing… he pees from…” Natalie stammered through her tears, rubbing at her eyes like a hurting seven-year-old child who only understood that what had been done to her had caused sharp physical pain, with no adult comprehension of the violation itself or the lifelong weight of its consequences.

“I think… well… I don’t even want to consider it,” Katie whispered in horror beside me, her hand shaking in mine as Jim walked up behind us and saw the look on our faces. Every single one of us knew right then what Chris had done to Natalie before he had walked down the hall with that reassigned keycard to Katie’s door.

“Katie, I’m so glad I insisted on you spending the night with me,” I whispered, holding her hand tightly as the dining hall doors opened at six-thirty.

Carrying our trays to the far corner table away from the noise, Katie, Sarah, Tina, and I sat together in grim silence.

“What happened to Natalie last night—and Chris walking straight up to your door with a dorm keycard twenty-four hours after breaking your nose in the pool—is an absolute disgrace,” Tina said quietly behind her glasses. “And watch: the center administration is going to drag its heels and bury the whole thing so they don’t look bad in Richmond.”

Trying to coax even a faint breath out of my pale sister, I tapped my plastic fork against the rock-hard gray square sitting on my plate that was supposed to be toast and asked rhetorically, “What is *this*?!”

Less than an hour later, as we rolled along the walkway from the dining hall toward Mr. Alderman’s classroom at seven-fifty, we stopped by the curb and watched in stunned, furious silence as two RRC staffers escorted Chris out to a waiting passenger van by the front gate carrying his duffel bag—with not a single state trooper cruiser, sheriff’s deputy, or pair of handcuffs in sight.

“Wait—they’re just kicking him out and putting him in a van?” Tina said aloud on the sidewalk beside Katie’s wheelchair, her voice shaking with anger. “He assaulted Katie in the pool on Tuesday, he attacked Natalie in the dorms last night during their own keycard mix-up, and instead of calling the State Police and having him arrested in handcuffs, the administration is just escorting him off the property and sweeping the whole thing under the rug so it doesn’t show up on a state incident report?!”

“Look at the courtyard,” I said bitterly as the eight-o’clock bell rang and classes resumed across campus as if nothing had happened at all, while Natalie’s friends led her weeping toward the clinic. “They wouldn’t even let Katie and me sleep in a hallway closet together without threatening to write us up, and they just let a predator walk out the front gate without calling the police.”

Part 2: A Safe Closet at Tina’s House in Luray, Walking Out After Twelve Days, & Coming Home to Kempsville

Date: 2007-03-16 at 15:45 America/New_York

Friday, March 16, 2007, 3:45 PM — Collapsing Our Wheelchairs into Tina’s Compact Sedan & Finding a Quiet Closet in Luray

“See how easy that is when you don’t have two four-hundred-pound power bases to wrestle with?” Tina smiled back at Katie and me through her glasses at three-forty-five on Friday afternoon, standing at the open trunk of her silver four-door compact sedan in the Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center student parking lot.

Sitting side by side on the rear passenger bench seat holding hands through the open back door with our packed duffel bags and laptop cases tucked at our feet—and the white MedStrip and gauze bandage from Tuesday’s pool assault still taped across the bridge of Katie’s nose for the rest of the week—Katie and I watched as Tina unclipped the compact battery boxes from underneath our two folding wheelchairs, pulled straight up on the canvas seat straps to collapse both cross-brace frames flat, and lifted the folded frames—spoked push-rim wheels, rear rubber push-handles, and right-armrest joysticks and all—smoothly into her trunk side by side.

“Dr. Carter knew what she was doing when she had us leave our full-size SwiftChairs back at the house in Virginia Beach,” I said, letting out a long breath as Tina closed the trunk lid, climbed behind the steering wheel, and turned out of the campus gates onto Route 250 toward Route 340 North.

“Take a good look in the rearview mirror, you two,” Tina said cheerfully as the flat-roofed 1960s and 1970s red-brick dormitories of Fishersville disappeared behind the tree line and the Blue Ridge Mountains rose to our right along the Shenandoah River. “Every Friday at three-thirty, I put that place in my mirror and don’t think about a single clipboard until Monday morning.”

An hour and fifteen minutes later, when Tina turned into her driveway in the quiet green valley of Luray and unfolded our wheelchairs by the front porch, rolling inside her sunlit house felt like stepping out of a monochrome prison into another world. In Tina’s kitchen, a pot of homemade beef stew was simmering on the stove; in the living room, where afternoon sunlight slanted across a braided rug with not a single laminated institutional rule sign on the walls, Tina had already pulled out her wide living-room daybed and made it up with crisp cotton sheets, four fluffy pillows, and a thick patchwork quilt specifically for the two of us.

At ten-thirty that night, after eating two bowls apiece of real home-cooked stew and talking PHP arrays and SQL joins around Tina’s kitchen table, Katie and I changed into our pajamas and rolled back out beside the freshly made living-room daybed.

“Goodnight, you two—sleep as late as you want tomorrow morning, and nobody is knocking on any doors at eleven o’clock in my house,” Tina said warmly, clicking off the hallway lamp on her way to her bedroom.

As soon as Tina’s bedroom door clicked shut, Katie and I looked at the wide daybed sitting out in the open beneath the front living-room windows, and then looked at each other. Even in a kind friend’s living room, twelve raw days at Fishersville on top of more than three years of sleeping exclusively inside latched closets since Greenway Court made lying exposed in an open room with windows feel impossible. Without needing a word between us, we lifted Tina’s thick patchwork quilt and four fluffy pillows off the daybed, carried them across our laps to Tina’s wide, carpeted coat-and-linen closet just off the living room, spread a soft cocoon across the closet floor, transferred down side by side, and pulled the wooden closet door gently shut.

In the quiet, enclosed dark of Tina’s closet, Katie curled straight into my arms under the quilt, buried her face against my collarbone, and let out a long, shuddering sigh that released twelve solid days of tension all at once.

“Nate,” Katie whispered, lacing her fingers tightly through mine, “I am never spending another night in Barton Hall. Twelve days of that place is more than enough for an entire lifetime.”

I listened to the quiet mountain wind rustling the trees outside Tina’s front window, holding my twin sister close.

“We don’t have to go back, Katie,” I whispered, rubbing her back under the quilt. “Before we shut down our laptops in Mr. Alderman’s lab at three-thirty today, we copied the entire PHP 5 and SQL course syllabus and every textbook exercise onto both of our hard drives. We already have our associate degrees from the Community College of Hampton Roads. We don’t need to stay locked up in Barton Hall as Level

2 clients begging for yellow Hall Passes—or stay at a center that sweeps what happened to Natalie under the rug just to protect whatever state funding they get for keeping their dorm beds and classroom seats filled—when we can master server-side PHP and SQL from home."

Sunday, March 18, 2007, 1:00 PM — Calling Dad to Pack Up Barton Hall & Returning to Our Routine in Virginia Beach

"I don't blame you two one bit," Tina said over hot pancakes and fresh apple juice at her dining table on Saturday morning, setting her coffee mug down and adjusting her glasses beneath her jet-black hair after Katie and I told her our decision and dialed Dad's number in Alexandria on speakerphone. "Between the aides grabbing your wheelchair push-handles during Voc Eval, that insulting ValueMart door-greeter pitch, keeping you stuck in Barton Hall on Level 2 with yellow Hall Passes, the Chickenshit Report after the pool, writing you up for sleeping in a closet, and the disgusting way the administration swept what Chris did to Natalie under the rug on Thursday, I wouldn't stay another night in those dorms either if I were in your shoes. You already copied Mr. Alderman's full PHP and SQL curriculum onto your laptops, and Sheila, Jim, and I are online every afternoon. We'll share every lecture note, review each other's database code over instant messenger, and build our projects together without a single dorm supervisor breathing down your necks."

"Listen to me, both of you," Dad's voice came through the speakerphone from his house on Sunset Drive in Alexandria, warm and fierce at the same time. "I couldn't be prouder of you for standing up for each other and walking away from a place that refused to respect your dignity or your bond. Stay right there at Tina's house today and rest up. Tomorrow morning I'm driving my pickup truck down Interstate 81, we'll stop by Fishersville just long enough to clear the rest of your clothes out of Barton Hall and drop your room keys on the front desk, and I'll bring you straight home to Virginia Beach."

At one o'clock on Sunday afternoon, March 18, 2007—exactly fourteen days after we had first rolled through the doors of Barton Hall—Dad backed his pickup truck up to the curb outside Barton Hall while Tina parked her compact sedan right beside him. The second Dad stepped out of his truck and saw the white MedStrip and gauze bandage still taped across the bridge of his daughter's nose from Tuesday's pool assault, his jaw set into solid granite as he wrapped both of us in a fierce hug. Within twenty minutes, Dad, Jim, and Tina had loaded the rest of our suitcases from our dorm rooms into the bed of the pickup truck, and Katie and I rolled side by side up to the Barton Hall front counter.

Without waiting for a single exit interview or the canceled Thursday counselor write-up meeting over the hallway closet, Katie and I dropped our Level 2 room keys onto the wooden blotter simultaneously.

"We're checking out permanently," Katie told the startled Sunday desk clerk, before both of us spun our wheelchairs around, rolled out the automatic glass doors into the sunshine, and hugged Tina, Sheila, and Jim tightly in the parking lot.

“Log onto instant messenger as soon as you get unpacked down at the coast,” Tina told us, squeezing Katie’s hand and then mine before we transferred into the cab of Dad’s pickup truck. “Module Four on database normalization starts Monday morning at nine sharp, and Sheila, Jim, and I expect your code in the shared folder!”

“Count on it!” Katie grinned out the passenger window as Dad pulled out of the lot and headed east toward Afton Mountain and Interstate 64.

“Are you sure it’s no trouble for us to move back into the Arvin Road house while you’re working up in Tysons Corner during the week, Dad?” I asked as the pickup climbed toward the Blue Ridge tunnel.

“Trouble? Nate, that’s the entire reason I kept the Virginia Beach house when I bought the place on Sunset Drive in Alexandria and updated my driver’s license,” Dad said, reaching across the console to pat my knee and Katie’s shoulder. “I bought that brick ranch on Arvin Road off Indian River Road and Military Highway from our old landlord years ago so the two of you would always have your own ramp, your own walk-in closet sanctuary, and the Kempsville streets and bus routes you know by heart. That house is yours for as long as you want it.”

When Dad pulled into the driveway on Arvin Road in Virginia Beach at dusk that Sunday evening and unlocked the front door at the top of the aluminum wheelchair ramp, Katie and I transferred out of the travel frames right back into our full-size SwiftChair power wheelchairs, rolled side by side to our familiar dining table, and opened our laptop lids together just as Tina, Sheila, and Jim’s names lit up green on our screens.

Unofficial Homeowners: Back Home in Virginia Beach (2007–2008)

Arvin Road, Crossing Without a Crosswalk, Horizontal IDs on Route 12, & Yearly Passes at Fairlawn

Part 1: Unofficial Homeowners, One Bedroom and One Office, & The Closet We Both Know We’ll Use

Date: 2007-03-18 at 18:30 America/New_York

Sunday, March 18, 2007, 6:30 PM — Unofficial Homeowners & The Address on Our State ID Cards

“Oh, thank goodness,” Katie breathed at six-thirty on Sunday evening the second she slid off the folding manual travel chair onto the padded contoured seat of her full-size black SwiftChair inside our front foyer, resting her right hand on the

familiar fingertip joystick. “No rear push-handles for strangers to grab, no clunky clamp-on battery box underneath, and no yellow Level 2 Hall Pass required to roll down our own hallway.”

“Amen to that,” I said, transferring into my own full-size SwiftChair right beside hers and powering on my controller as Dad lifted our two collapsed manual travel frames—spoked push-rim wheels and all—and tucked them neatly into the back of the front hall utility closet in case Tina or another friend ever picked us up in a compact car.

Rolling side by side out of the foyer into the warm kitchen of our single-story brick ranch on Arvin Road at the corner of Indian River Road, Katie and I stopped by the dining table and simply took in the quiet. Outside the kitchen window, the familiar neighborhood streetlamps of Kempsville were flickering on in the March dusk.

Dad walked in from the garage carrying the last of our suitcases from the bed of his pickup truck, set two newly cut brass house keys and a blue leather household binder on the table between our wheelchairs, and pulled up a wooden dining chair across from us.

“Alright, you two,” Dad said warmly, opening the front flap of the binder to show us the printed account sheet and sliding two reloadable Meridian debit cards across the laminate tabletop toward our hands. “Before we start moving furniture and before I have to head back up to Alexandria tonight for work in Tysons Corner tomorrow morning, let’s go over how everything works here so neither of you has to worry about a single bill. The mortgage on this house, the City of Virginia Beach real-estate taxes, the homeowner’s insurance, the electric bill, the water and sewer, and the high-speed cable internet are all set to automatic payment straight out of my main checking account up in Northern Virginia. You don’t ever have to touch a utility bill.”

He tapped the two debit cards sitting in front of Katie and me.

“Every Friday morning when my paycheck clears, your grocery and spending money goes straight into this joint checking account,” Dad continued. “Until your own software and web-development work starts paying what you want it to pay, every dime of your groceries, bus passes, computer parts, and spending money is covered. As far as day-to-day life goes, the two of you are the unofficial homeowners of our house here on Arvin Road.”

Katie reached into her crossbody bag, unzipped her wallet, and pulled out her laminated Virginia Department of Motor Vehicles identification card, setting it down on the table beside her debit card.

“Look at the address line, Nate,” Katie smiled, tapping the plastic card with her fingernail.

I pulled my own wallet out of my jeans pocket and laid my Virginia State ID card right beside hers. Printed across the front of both cards in crisp black DMV block letters was the exact Arvin Road address in Virginia Beach where we were sitting right now.

“We never even have to go to the DMV to change our address,” I said, grinning across the table at Dad. “That’s the exact address we’ve had on our State ID cards ever since the three of us left Mom back in September 2001. Neither of us ever bothered updating our IDs during our temporary stays in Norfolk or Williamsburg, because this house was always home base.”

“And because we turned eighteen right here at this table in April 2003 when we were seniors at Northwood High,” Katie added, her blue eyes lighting up as she connected the dots, “our Virginia Beach voter registrations at the Kempsville precinct have been anchored to this exact address for four straight years too.”

“Which means as far as the Commonwealth of Virginia and the City of Virginia Beach are concerned,” Dad chuckled, patting both of our hands across the table, “you never left. Now—I’ve still got three hours before I need to get on Interstate 64 and head up to Alexandria, and we’ve got three bedrooms down that hallway to set up the way you two want them. Tell the moving crew what the floorplan is.”

7:15 PM — Reconfiguring the Three Bedrooms: Dad’s Room, Our Dual-Desk Office, & The Queen Bed With the Closet Sanctuary

Katie and I exchanged a single glance across our wheelchair armrests—having already mapped out every square foot of the hallway during the drive down from Luray in the cab of Dad’s pickup truck—and rolled side by side down the hardwood corridor with Dad walking right behind us.

“First,” I said, pausing outside the open door of the master bedroom at the end of the hall, “the master bedroom stays a hundred percent yours, Dad. Whenever you drive down from Alexandria on the weekends or for holidays, or whenever you have work down in Hampton Roads and need a place to sleep, your room and your bed are right here waiting for you.”

“Deal,” Dad smiled. “What about the two bedrooms you two have had since 2001?”

Katie released her joystick brake and rolled three feet left to the doorway of the middle bedroom—the room that had been mine during high school—before turning to point across the hall to the room that had been hers since 2001, where the framed watercolor print of a blue butterfly still hung on the cream drywall.

“After twelve days of Barton Hall forcing us onto separate wings every night at eleven o’clock,” Katie said firmly, her fingers lacing through mine between our chairs, “Nate and I made our decision together. We are living together in this house as brother and sister, and we don’t want two separate sleeping bedrooms anymore. We’re going to sleep in the room that was my bedroom, and put the queen-size bed in there.”

“And the bedroom that was my room,” I picked up seamlessly, gesturing into my old room across the hall, “becomes our office. If we take my old twin bed frame out to the garage storage bay, we have a whole twelve-by-twelve room along the front window where we can put two wide computer desks side by side, wire our ethernet switch and our local Linux testing server right into the cable modem, and roll both of our SwiftChairs up next to each other all day while we work through Mr. Alderman’s PHP and SQL modules with Tina, Sheila, and Jim.”

“And one more thing inside our bedroom,” Katie added softly, looking up at Dad with earnest blue eyes as she pointed toward the wide double doors of her bedroom closet. “Inside the closet, we want to clear the floor completely clean and put our thick sleeping bag and four pillows down on the carpet—so whenever we want that quiet, confined space together to feel completely secure, it’s already set up waiting for us.”

Dad looked at the two of us holding hands between our wheelchairs, and his expression softened with unmistakable fatherly pride and understanding. He didn’t ask a single skeptical question, didn’t lecture us about “normal” adult bedrooms, and didn’t bat an eye.

“Then let’s get to work,” Dad said, rolling up the sleeves of his flannel shirt.

For the next hour and a half, the three of us transformed the hallway. First, Dad unbolted the steel rails of my old twin bed, stacked the frame neatly against the dry wall of the garage, and helped us slide two sturdy six-foot laminate worktables flush against each other along the wall of my old bedroom. While Katie organized our spiral notebooks and reference manuals on the lower bookshelf that we could reach easily from our wheelchair seats, I plugged our surge protectors, gigabit switch, and laptop docking cables underneath the desks—testing the clearance so both of our SwiftChairs could roll straight under the tabletop side by side with less than an inch between our armrests.

Across the hall in Katie’s room, Dad carried in the queen box spring and mattress, centered the headboard directly beneath the framed blue butterfly print, and helped us pull on the fitted cotton sheets and the soft navy-and-slate-blue queen comforter set we had bought together at Chesapeake Bay Mall back in November 2005.

Then Dad stepped over to the wide bedroom closet, moved the low shoe rack and spare boxes into the hall storage cupboard, vacuumed the closet carpet from corner to corner, and helped us spread our thick double sleeping bag and quilted pad across the floor of the closet, banking four plush pillows in a neat row against the interior wall.

Stepping back with his hands on his hips, Dad looked from the freshly made navy-and-slate-blue queen bed in the center of the bedroom over to the open closet doors, where the sleeping bag and four pillows sat tucked inside the quiet three-by-six-foot alcove.

A slow, knowing grin spread across Dad’s face, and Katie and I started laughing right along with him.

“Now, that queen bed looks mighty sharp sitting there in the middle of the room,” Dad chuckled, shaking his head affectionately as he looked down at the two of us, “even if all three of us in this room know perfectly well that you two are probably going to sleep in that closet every single night.”

“Hey, the queen bed is great for reading code books in the afternoon and folding laundry,” Katie giggled, her cheeks warming as she squeezed my hand, “and the closet doesn’t have any windows or hallway noise.”

“And nobody in this house is ever going to yank the closet door open at eleven o’clock with a flashlight,” I said quietly, looking at the soft pillows tucked inside the alcove.

“Not in your house, Nate,” Dad said firmly, resting a hand on my shoulder and then on Katie’s. “In this house, you sleep wherever the two of you feel safest.”

9:45 PM — Dad Heads Back to Alexandria, Locking Our Front Door, & Our First Night Back in the Closet

After a quick eight-thirty run across Indian River Road in Dad’s pickup truck to the Market Square supermarket to load the kitchen refrigerator and pantry with two gallons of cold milk, cartons of chocolate milk, two twelve-packs of ginger ale, cereal boxes, bread, sandwich turkey, and frozen dinners, Katie and I rolled out onto the front porch at the top of our aluminum wheelchair ramp at quarter to ten to see Dad off.

“I’ll call you both tomorrow evening on my way home from Tysons Corner—and I’ve already cleared Tuesday afternoon on my calendar so I can drive back down and be right there in the exam room with you at Dr. Carter’s office when she checks Katie’s nose and takes that bandage off,” Dad said, bending down in the cool March night air to wrap Katie and me in a tight three-way hug at the top of the ramp. “Have fun jumping into Module Four with Tina, Sheila, and Jim in the morning—and enjoy having your house back.”

“Drive safe up I-95, Dad, and call us when you get to Alexandria,” Katie told him, hugging his neck before waving from her wheelchair as he climbed into the cab of his pickup truck.

We sat side by side at the top of the aluminum ramp, holding hands as Dad backed down the driveway, tapped his horn twice in a soft goodbye, and turned off Arvin Road onto Indian River Road toward Military Highway and Interstate 64.

Once the red taillights disappeared behind the pine trees at the corner, we wheeled back across the threshold into the warm foyer, pushed the solid wooden front door shut, and turned the brass deadbolt until it clicked firmly into place.

For the first time in our adult lives, the entire house was ours.

Rolling side by side down the quiet hallway past our newly wired dual-desk office, we brushed our teeth together at the bathroom sink, turned into our bedroom, and clicked off the overhead ceiling fixture until only the warm amber glow of the small nightstand lamp illuminated the room.

Right in front of us sat the pristine navy-and-slate-blue queen bed. Three feet to our right stood the open doors of the bedroom closet, where our thick sleeping bag and four plush pillows waited in the quiet, enclosed shadows.

Even with our own front door deadbolted behind us, both of our nervous systems were still raw—still shaken, scared, upset, and angry over those twelve days at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center, from the pool and Wednesday night’s keycard terror to the staffer yanking the Barton Hall closet door open at eleven o’clock and writing us up for holding each other.

Katie looked at the queen bed, looked over at the open closet doorway, and reached for the hem of her shirt.

“Closet?” I whispered.

“Closet,” Katie whispered back without half a second’s hesitation. “And no pajamas tonight, Nate. Just us.”

We rolled our two SwiftChairs right up to the edge of the open closet doorway, parked them side by side with our armrests touching, switched off both joystick controllers, and helped each other slip out of our clothes, folding them neatly across our wheelchair seats. Lowering ourselves smoothly inside our single shared sleeping bag on the carpeted closet floor, I reached out and pulled the closet door almost all the way shut until just a thin ribbon of warm light filtered across the carpet, zipped the sleeping bag up around our shoulders, and wrapped both of my arms tightly around my twin sister, skin to skin.

Pressing her warm cheek against my bare chest and tangling her legs with mine inside the dark, enclosed space—doing the exact thing that would have gotten us written up and thrown out of Barton Hall—Katie let out a long, trembling breath that finally melted the last knot of Fishersville tension from her shoulders. Holding each other close while the queen bed out in the bedroom sat completely untouched, we drifted straight off to sleep in our own closet, in our own home, where nobody in the world could ever separate us again.

Part 2: Dr. Carter’s Exam Room, Skin to Skin in the Closet, & No Crosswalks at Military and Indian River

Date: 2007-03-20 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, March 20, 2007, 2:00 PM — Dr. Evelyn Carter’s Exam Room, Peeling Off the Seven-Day Bandage, & Our Annual Physicals With Dad

“You’re safe right here with me and Dad, Katie,” I whispered at two o’clock on Tuesday afternoon inside Exam Room Two at Dr. Evelyn Carter’s family medicine office on Kempsville Road, keeping both of my arms wrapped tightly around my twin sister’s shoulders across the gap between our parked SwiftChairs.

With our inner armrests flipped up and out of the way so our wheelchairs could sit flush against each other, Katie buried her cheek against my collarbone and hugged me back with both arms just as tightly. Right behind our chairs, having driven his pickup truck down from Northern Virginia that morning so he wouldn’t miss a minute of the appointment, Dad stood with one steady hand resting on my shoulder and the other on Katie’s back.

Even in Dr. Carter’s familiar ground-floor office—where she had been taking care of the two of us ever since Dad moved us into the brick ranch on Arvin Road back in the autumn of 2001—just sitting under fluorescent clinical lights next to a paper-lined examination table only seven days after the Bates-Harding clinic nurses had taped Katie’s split nasal bridge had both of our nervous systems on high alert. Holding onto each other in a full two-arm embrace was the only way to keep the memory of Fishersville out of the room.

A gentle two-beat knock sounded at the wooden door before Dr. Evelyn Carter stepped inside carrying both of our thick manila medical charts and a stainless-steel tray with sterile saline packets and gauze pads. Seeing Katie and me locked in a tight two-arm hug between our wheelchairs with the white gauze-and-paper-tape dressing across the bridge of Katie's nose, Dr. Carter didn't rush us or ask us to pull apart. Instead, she pushed the exam room door firmly shut, set her charts on the counter, and rolled her cushioned stool over in front of us with quiet, unmistakable concern.

"Take all the time you two need," Dr. Carter said softly, looking from Katie and me up to Dad. "David told me on the phone yesterday that he brought you both home from Fishersville for good on Sunday, and that a male client struck Katie in the face in the therapeutic pool last Tuesday. Tell me what happened up there."

Still holding onto each other, Katie and I told Dr. Carter everything while Dad stood right behind us—starting on our very first afternoon when an aide grabbed Katie's manual wheelchair push-handles without asking and tried to steer her down the women's wing like a shopping cart, and going right through the Vocational Evaluator who looked at our accredited computer-science associate degrees from the Community College of Hampton Roads and pitched us a partnership to work as door greeters at the Waynesboro ValueMart. We told her how they kept us stuck on Level 2 in Barton Hall begging for signed yellow paper Hall Passes because moving to Cantor Hall required earning Level 3; how Chris struck Katie in the face and ripped her swimsuit top in the ninety-two-degree pool while a poolside staffer wrote me up on the morning Chickenshit Report for covering my sister's bare chest while she held her bleeding nose with both hands; how a night supervisor unlocked a hallway seasonal storage closet with a master key after the eleven o'clock bed check and accused us of having sex when we were in full street clothes holding each other on bags of curtains; and how the administration scrambled on Thursday to sweep Chris's Wednesday night keycard assault on Natalie under the rug without calling the police just to keep their dorm beds and classroom seats filled.

"We never want to set foot inside Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center ever again, Dr. Carter," Katie said fiercely, lifting her chin from my shoulder as her blue eyes met the doctor's.

"Not for a single day," I added right beside her, my arm still around her waist. "We already have our associate degrees, and we copied the entire PHP and SQL web-development curriculum onto our laptops before we left on Friday. We just want to go home to our house on Arvin Road and live together where no one can ever tell us that we aren't allowed to share a bed or even a closet!"

Dr. Carter's jaw tightened with visible indignation as she uncapped her fountain pen, opened both of our medical charts on her lap, and wrote several firm lines in black ink across the top of each clinical summary sheet.

"Then neither of you will ever set foot in that place again," Dr. Carter said firmly, looking straight at Dad and then back at the two of us. "I am documenting right here in both of your permanent medical files that any institutional program that forcibly separates the two of you, threatens you with isolation contracts for seeking sensory grounding together, or allows staff to grab your wheelchairs without consent is medically contraindicated and actively harmful to your cerebral palsy spasticity and autistic regulation. Your home on Arvin Road is exactly where you belong."

“Thank you, Evelyn,” Dad said quietly, his hand squeezing Katie’s shoulder.

“Now, Katie,” Dr. Carter smiled warmly, snapping on a pair of blue nitrile gloves and opening a warm sterile saline swab, “let’s take a look at the bridge of that nose and get those seven-day wound-closure strips off your face so you don’t have to look at them in the mirror anymore.”

Taking a slow breath together, Katie and I eased out of our tight two-arm hug so Katie could sit upright facing the doctor—and immediately relaxed to holding hands, lacing my right fingers through her left fingers across the gap between our wheelchairs while Dad kept his hand on her shoulder.

Never letting go of my hand, Katie held completely still as Dr. Carter moistened the paper tape with warm saline, lifted the outer white gauze square away, and then carefully peeled off the three narrow, sterile MedStrip wound-closure strips that the Bates-Harding clinic nurses had taped across the split skin on the bony bridge of her nose the previous Tuesday.

Switching on her penlight, Dr. Carter examined the bridge of Katie’s nose closely, gently palpated the nasal bone and cartilage, and checked inside both nostrils.

“That knitted together beautifully, Katie,” Dr. Carter said, clicking off her penlight and handing Katie a small hand mirror from the counter. “Keeping those MedStrips dry for the full seven days did the trick. The split skin across the bridge has closed into a clean, flat seam that will fade completely over the next couple of weeks, your septum is straight, and the hairline contusion on the nasal bone is stable and healing right on schedule.”

Katie tilted the small mirror toward her eyes, touched the smooth bridge of her nose lightly with her free right fingertips, and beamed at me across our joined hands. “Look, Nate—no more bandage! And right in time for us to go to the Buckner Boulevard DMV on Friday to get our horizontal twenty-one-and-over State ID pictures taken!”

“And speaking of turning twenty-two on April eighth,” Dr. Carter said, glancing down at the preventive-care tabs on our two open charts with a warm smile, “you two are less than three weeks away from your annual physical date anyway. Since you’re both already sitting right here in my exam room and David is here with you before he drives back up to Alexandria tonight, how would you feel about knocking out both of your annual physicals right now so you don’t have to make a second trip next month?”

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchairs. As long as nobody asked us to let go of each other’s hand, getting our annual checkups done in one sitting meant uninterrupted weeks at home in our new office on Arvin Road.

“Let’s do it right now,” Katie said, and I nodded right along with her.

For the next twenty-five minutes, with Dad sitting right beside us and our fingers stayed laced together across our wheelchair armrests, Dr. Carter completed both of our annual physicals side by side—checking our blood pressure cuffs on our outer arms, listening to our hearts and lungs with her warmed stethoscope, checking our ears and reflexes, and evaluating our lower-extremity cerebral palsy muscle tone and seated posture in our full-size SwiftChairs. By two-forty-five, she had signed off on a clean bill of health for both of us, and after Dad took us out for an early dinner and

gave us one more fierce hug at the top of our aluminum porch ramp on Arvin Road before heading back up Interstate 64 to Alexandria for the rest of the workweek, our house was completely ours again.

Wednesday, March 21, 2007, 8:30 AM — Waking Up in Our Closet Sanctuary & Morning PHP With Tina, Sheila, and Jim

“You’re warm,” Katie murmured sleepily at eight-thirty on Wednesday morning, her bare shoulder pressed tightly against my chest inside our single shared sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of our bedroom closet.

I kissed the top of her blonde hair in the quiet dark and kept my arms wrapped securely around her waist. Outside in the main bedroom, three feet past the nearly closed closet door, the navy-and-slate-blue comforter on our queen-size bed hadn’t been unfolded once since Dad helped us make it on Sunday night.

Neither of us had the slightest interest in sleeping out on that open mattress. Even after telling Dr. Carter everything yesterday afternoon, our minds were still raw—still carrying the lingering fear of Chris standing in Katie’s doorway with a reassigned dorm keycard after hurting Natalie, the fury of watching the administration escort him into a van without calling the police, and the humiliation of a night-shift staffer yanking the Barton Hall hallway closet door open at eleven o’clock to write us up for holding each other. Waking up undressed together inside our own dark, enclosed closet on Arvin Road—feeling each other’s steady breathing skin to skin and knowing we were doing the exact thing that would have gotten us punished and separated at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center—was the only medicine that kept the nightmares away.

“Nobody knocking on the door,” I whispered against her temple. “Nobody checking Hall Passes.”

“Just us,” Katie whispered back, hugging my ribs tightly for another full minute—her face finally free of the seven-day nasal bandage Dr. Carter had peeled off the afternoon before—until we unzipped the sleeping bag, reached up to pull our folded shirts and jeans off the seats of our parked SwiftChairs just outside the closet doorway, and transferred up into our chairs.

After helping each other shower on the padded transfer bench in the hall bathroom and pouring two bowls of cereal with cold milk in the kitchen, we rolled across the hardwood hallway into my old bedroom—now officially our dual-desk software office.

At nine o’clock sharp, right as we slid our two SwiftChairs side by side underneath the twelve-foot span of laminate worktables with our armrests touching, our instant-messenger client chimed. On our screens, Tina, Sheila, and Jim popped online from the Web Applications Developer classroom back in Fishersville.

“Look at the two of you sitting in a real office without a single yellow Level 2 badge in sight!” Tina typed into the group chat window, waving quietly at her webcam before her instructor walked past the front whiteboard. “Mr. Alderman just handed out the Module Four exercise sheet on relational foreign keys and PHP session arrays. Check your shared folder—I just uploaded the prompt!”

For the next few days, while morning sunlight slanted through the front blinds onto our keyboards, Katie and I worked on a couple of the copied PHP and SQL exercises unofficially from home while chatting with Tina, Sheila, and Jim. We didn't care one bit that rolling out of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center after twelve days meant we were technically RRC dropouts who had never officially completed the program; both of us already held an Advanced Studies Diploma from Virginia Beach City Public Schools at Northwood High School and an accredited Associate of Applied Science degree from the Community College of Hampton Roads, and we had realized during our first week in Fishersville that an RRC piece of paper meant nothing in the real world compared to our associate degrees and actual working code.

Even better, it didn't take long working on those copied RRC modules unofficially from home before Katie and I looked at each other across our desks and decided to stop following RRC's rigid classroom exercises altogether and start doing our own thing—staying friends with Tina, Sheila, and Jim on instant messenger while we focused one hundred percent on rebuilding our transit blog, Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, from the ground up into a custom database-driven PHP web application where every route timetable, transfer window, and municipal service comparison across all six Hampton Roads cities could be queried dynamically.

2:15 PM — Crossing Without a Crosswalk to Market Square

When we rolled into the kitchen at two-fifteen that afternoon to make turkey sandwiches for lunch, I opened the refrigerator door and held up the plastic milk jug. Less than half an inch of milk sloshed across the bottom, and the bread bag on the counter was down to the two heel slices.

"First solo grocery run without Dad's pickup truck," Katie said, glancing out the kitchen window toward the corner of Arvin Road and Indian River Road. "Good thing there's a Market Square supermarket right across the street."

"Let's see how much our two chairs can haul in one trip," I grinned, rolling back to the hall closet to grab two heavy-duty canvas backpack panniers and two insulated reusable grocery totes.

We slipped the padded straps of the backpack panniers securely over the contoured high backs of both of our SwiftChairs, tucked the folded insulated totes beside our thighs, checked that our battery gauges showed all green bars, and rolled out the front door and down our aluminum porch ramp into the crisp March afternoon.

Exiting the house, we made a right onto quiet Arvin Road and another right onto the sidewalk along Indian River Road, rolling west toward the major signalized intersection where Indian River Road met eight-lane Military Highway.

Across the street sat the brick storefront of the Market Square grocery plaza.

Getting across the asphalt to reach it, however, made both of us stop our wheelchairs dead at the concrete curb cut and stare.

“Wait a second, Nate,” Katie said, raising her voice over the deafening roar of eighteen-wheelers, dump trucks, and commuter sedans barreling through the intersection. “Look at the pavement between our curb cut and the curb cut on the other side of the street.”

I looked down at the wide, oil-stained expanse of multi-lane asphalt.

The intersection had overhead traffic lights. It had sloped concrete curb cuts poured into the corners. Right behind us stood bus stops for CVTA Routes 12 and 15 where transit riders got off the bus every half hour to walk home or buy groceries.

Yet across the entire intersection of Military Highway and Indian River Road, there was not a single painted white crosswalk stripe—and no pedestrian countdown head—anywhere on the pavement.

“How do you pour wheelchair curb cuts at a major intersection with two bus routes and a supermarket across the street,” I asked in disbelief as a pickup truck whipped a fast right turn on red two feet in front of our footplates without even glancing at the sidewalk, “and not paint a single crosswalk line to tell drivers that people cross here?!”

“Stay right beside my left wheel, and don’t move an inch until the through-lane turns red and I check every right-turning bumper,” Katie said, her hand steady on her joystick.

We waited through an entire two-minute signal cycle until the cross-traffic halted, made direct eye contact with the driver at the front of the turning lane so he wouldn’t gun his engine into us, and pushed our joysticks full forward side by side across the bare, unmarked lanes of asphalt. The second our front casters climbed the opposite concrete curb cut into the Market Square parking lot, both of us let out a breath at the exact same time.

Inside the bright, fluorescent aisles of Market Square, our two-wheelchair shopping system worked like clockwork. Instead of struggling with a clumsy metal shopping cart that couldn’t be steered alongside a joystick controller, Katie held the open insulated tote bags on her lap while I pulled a gallon of milk, two cartons of chocolate milk, loaves of whole-wheat bread, sliced turkey, cheddar cheese, apples, and boxes of pasta off the low and middle shelves.

At the checkout register, after swiping the joint checking debit card Dad had given us on Sunday night, we balanced the load evenly between our two chairs like a pair of cargo engineers: the gallon of milk and canned goods went into the heavy canvas backpack slung over the back of my SwiftChair, the chocolate milk, soda six-pack, and frozen boxes went into Katie’s rear pack, and the lighter bags of bread and fruit rode flat across our laps inside the insulated totes.

After waiting through two more heavy traffic cycles to cross the unmarked, crosswalk-free lanes of Indian River Road back to the Arvin Road corner and unpacking our haul into the kitchen fridge, Katie didn’t even take her jacket off before rolling straight into our office bedroom and tapping my monitor.

“Pull up the new PHP admin panel for Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, Nate,” Katie said, her blue eyes bright with purpose. “We just took our first solo grocery trip from Arvin Road, and our readers—and the traffic engineers at Virginia Beach

City Hall—are going to read all about what happens when you put CVTA Route 12 and Route 15 bus stops and a grocery store at Military Highway and Indian River Road with curb cuts, heavy traffic, and zero crosswalks.”

Part 3: Crossing Both Roads for Route 12, Buckner Boulevard DMV, & Horizontal State IDs on the Spot

Date: 2007-03-23 at 09:40 America/New_York

Friday, March 23, 2007, 9:40 AM — Crossing Both Roads to Catch the Southbound Route 12

“Look at how baby-faced we were in these pictures,” Katie laughed on Friday morning as we sat side by side in the hallway by the front door, holding up our two vertical Virginia State identification cards before slipping them into our lanyard pouches.

Both of us had gotten those original vertical Under-21 State ID cards back in October 2001, right after we turned sixteen and moved with Dad into this house on Arvin Road when he was first renting it from the landlord—years before he eventually bought the place outright. Across the top of each vertical card ran the bright red banner announcing the date we would turn twenty-one, and printed underneath our names was our exact street address here on Arvin Road.

Crucially, neither of us had ever bothered telling the Virginia Department of Motor Vehicles about a single one of our temporary moves over the past three and a half years—not when the two of us lived on Greenway Court, up in Williamsburg, or at Tiffany’s apartment on West Ocean View Avenue, and not during our twelve days up in Fishersville. As far as the DMV’s computer database in Richmond was concerned, Katie and I had lived continuously at this exact house on Arvin Road since we were sixteen years old.

Now that we were twenty-one—and only sixteen days away from turning twenty-two—we wanted to trade in those worn vertical Under-21 cards for proper adult horizontal State ID cards before heading over to Fairlawn Recreation Center on Monday to sign up for resident memberships. And since the nearest DMV Customer Service Center was over on Buckner Boulevard in Virginia Beach, getting there meant taking CVTA Route 12.

At nine-forty that morning, we rolled out our front door and down the aluminum porch ramp into the sunny March air.

Getting from our driveway to the Route 12 stop heading toward the Community College of Hampton Roads required a specific two-stage crossing. Exiting the house, we made a right onto Arvin Road and another right onto the north sidewalk of Indian River Road, rolling west down the block to the roaring multi-lane intersection of Indian River Road and Military Highway.

Because the bus stop for southbound routes sat on the far southwest corner of the intersection, crossing one street wasn’t enough—we had to cross both Indian River Road and Military Highway without a single painted crosswalk stripe on either roadway.

“Indian River first while the through-lanes on Military have the green,” Katie called out over the rumble of a passing dump truck as we lined our SwiftChairs up side by side at the concrete curb cut.

The moment the turning traffic cleared, we pushed our joysticks forward in tandem across the unmarked asphalt of Indian River Road to the median island and the opposite corner, pivoted ninety degrees at the curb cut, waited through the next signal cycle while eight lanes of Military Highway traffic thundered past our footplates, and then rolled straight across Military Highway to the southbound CVTA bus stop sign.

That southbound stop on Military Highway was a workhorse corner for our end of Kempsville: it served CVTA Route 12 heading east toward the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, as well as CVTA Route 15 heading south toward either Emerald Creek Mall or Robert Hall Boulevard in Chesapeake on an alternating basis.

Seven minutes later, a low-floor CVTA Route 12 coach with *12 CCHR* glowing across its amber front destination sign pulled up to the curb, kneeled its front suspension, and unfolded its metal ramp onto the sidewalk so Katie and I could roll aboard and lock down our chairs for the ride over to Buckner Boulevard.

10:35 AM — Two Tickets (B042 and B043), The DMV Waiting Rite of Passage, & Horizontal Cards Printed on the Spot

Rolling through the double glass doors of the Buckner Boulevard DMV Customer Service Center at ten-thirty-five, Katie and I wheeled side by side up to the check-in podium near the entrance.

“Good morning,” Katie told the information clerk. “My twin brother and I live together at the same address, and we both need to trade our vertical Under-21 State ID cards for horizontal cards now that we’re over twenty-one. Can we just use one ticket number together?”

“Sorry, honey—DMV policy is one ticket number per person, one transaction per ticket,” the check-in clerk replied without missing a beat, tapping the touchscreen on the electronic queue ticket dispenser twice and handing Katie a paper slip printed with B042 and me a second slip printed with B043—the B prefix routing us into the queue for driver’s license and identification card renewals and reissues.

“Two separate ticket numbers for twins living in the same house,” I grumbled under my breath as we rolled over to the open space beside the waiting room chairs.

“At least they’re right next to each other,” Katie whispered back, glancing up at the red LED matrix board where B039 was flashing. “How long could three numbers possibly take?”

Famous last words.

Over the next ten minutes, the robotic female voice on the overhead ceiling speakers chimed through B040 and then called out:

“Ding-dong… Now serving… Customer Number… B-zero-four-one… at Window… four.”

Katie and I both sat up straight in our SwiftChairs and rested our right hands on our joysticks, ready to roll the second B042 was called.

Instead, the DMV’s automated queue computer decided that B041 was the end of the B batch—and immediately launched into a twenty-five-minute marathon of every other letter in the alphabet.

“Ding-dong… Now serving… Customer Number… T-one-one-eight… at Window… nine,” the robotic voice droned, routing vehicle title and registration paperwork down the hall.

“Ding-dong… Now serving… Customer Number… C-zero-two-seven… at Window… two,” it chimed two minutes later for the compliance and suspension desk, followed by a string of A tickets for original learner’s permits, D tickets for combined multi-step transactions, and E tickets for the express window.

Every time the two-tone chime echoed across the acoustic ceiling tiles, Katie and I looked up expectantly at the red LED board—only to groan in unison as another T or C flashed on the display while B042 and B043 sat frozen in limbo.

Finally—just when I was starting to wonder if the computer had forgotten the letter B existed—the speaker chimed again:

“Ding-dong… Now serving… Customer Number… B-zero-four-two… at Window… six.”

“Finally!” Katie exhaled, and both of us pushed our joysticks forward to roll side by side up to the lowered accessible counter at Window 6.

“Good morning to you both,” the DMV representative behind Window 6 smiled as we pulled up.

“Good morning, ma’am,” Katie said, sliding her B042 ticket and her 2001 vertical card across the laminate counter while I tried to slide B043 and my vertical card right beside hers. “My brother and I both need new horizontal State ID cards now that we’re over the age of twenty-one.”

The representative glanced down at my B043 slip and shook her head with an apologetic smile. “I can’t open B043 in the computer until I close out B042, young man—you’ll have to wait your turn until B043 is called.”

I let out a quiet sigh and backed my SwiftChair half a foot to the right to wait my turn while the representative processed Katie’s renewal first.

Typing Katie’s identification number into her terminal, the representative glanced at her screen. “Are you still at the same address on Arvin Road here in Virginia Beach that we’ve had on file since October 2001?”

“Yes, ma’am—still the exact same house on Arvin Road,” Katie smiled, confirming that her Virginia Beach voter registration in the Kempsville precinct was still current as well before rolling two feet over to the adjustable camera post in front of the pull-down sky-blue backdrop to have her new photo snapped.

The second Katie's photo registered in the system and the representative closed out B042 to send Katie's card to the thermal printer behind the counter, the representative pressed the queue button on her keyboard.

Right above our heads, the ceiling speaker chimed:

"Ding-dong… Now serving… Customer Number… B-zero-four-three… at Window… six."

"Now it's officially your turn," the representative chuckled as I rolled my SwiftChair six inches forward to the exact spot Katie had just vacated and slid B043 and my 2001 vertical card across the counter.

After confirming that I also still lived at the exact same Arvin Road address on file since October 2001, verifying my voter registration, paying our two card fees with our joint debit card, and having my own picture snapped in front of the blue screen, I rolled right back beside Katie's chair at Window 6 while the thermal card printer behind the counter whirred through its second pass.

A moment later, with both transactions completed, the representative smiled warmly and handed Katie and me our two brand-new, still-warm plastic Virginia identification cards—printed horizontally on the spot, with no red Under-21 banner anywhere in sight and our Arvin Road address gleaming crisply across the front.

11:45 AM — Dropped Off by the Bank on Northbound Military Highway

By eleven-forty-five, after riding the westbound CVTA Route 12 bus back from Buckner Boulevard, I reached up and pulled the yellow chime cord as the bus approached Indian River Road.

On the return trip home, Route 12 dropped us off on the northbound side of South Military Highway right in front of the brick Piedmont Bank branch at the southeast corner of the intersection.

Once the bus ramp folded back inside and the coach pulled away through the traffic light, Katie and I rolled up to the corner curb cut in front of the bank, waited for a clean break in the turning cars, and crossed the unmarked lanes of Indian River Road to the northeast sidewalk.

From there, we made a right onto the sidewalk of Indian River Road—rolling east against the flow of westbound traffic with our new horizontal Virginia State ID cards tucked safely inside our lanyards—and then made a left onto quiet Arvin Road, where our brick ranch house sat waiting for us on our left.

Part 4: The :07 Bus From Glenrock Mall, Yearly Memberships at Fairlawn Rec Center, & The 1977 Building's Quirks

Date: 2007-03-26 at 10:31 America/New_York

Monday, March 26, 2007, 10:31 AM — Catching the :07 Route 25 Past the Newtown Road Border

“Make sure we’re on the ten-thirty-one northbound Route 15 and not a minute later,” Katie reminded me on Monday morning as we waited side by side in our SwiftChairs at the bus stop on Military Highway and Indian River Road. “If we miss the eleven-oh-seven Route 25 departure out of Glenrock Mall, the eleven-thirty-seven bus turns around at Newtown Road and stays in Norfolk, and we’ll be stuck waiting a whole hour until twelve-oh-seven just to cross into Virginia Beach.”

“Don’t I know it,” I said, shaking my head at the folded paper timetable in my hand as the northbound CVTA Route 15 bus pulled up to the curb.

Fourteen minutes later, at ten-forty-five sharp, Route 15 dropped us off at the transit transfer bay outside Glenrock Mall in Norfolk, giving us twenty-two minutes to roll over to the Route 25 stop before the eleven-oh-seven bus pulled out.

On paper, CVTA Route 25 ran every thirty minutes out of Glenrock Mall. In reality—thanks to the infamous city-line service cliff—every second bus only ran as far as Greenwich Road and Newtown Road at the Norfolk border before turning right back around. Only the buses departing Glenrock Mall at seven minutes past the hour, from six-oh-seven in the morning until six-oh-seven in the evening on Monday through Friday, actually crossed the city line and continued all the way down Princess Anne Road to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus.

Boarding the eleven-oh-seven Route 25 side by side, Katie and I rode east across the Newtown Road border and down Princess Anne Road until I pulled the yellow stop cord just before Edwin Drive.

Once the operator lowered the ramp at the corner of Princess Anne Road and Edwin Drive, we rolled our two SwiftChairs side by side down the sidewalk along Edwin Drive, turned onto Marlborough Drive, and steered right into the entrance of Fairlawn Recreation Center—carefully weaving our front casters around the deep, familiar potholes cratering the asphalt parking lot outside the low 1977 brick building with its sloped metal roof.

11:40 AM — Yearly Memberships, The Concrete Spiral Ramp, & Two Locker Room Doors

Rolling through the front entrance doors into the first-floor lobby felt like traveling straight back into our Kempsville childhood.

Right ahead of us on the left stood the wood-laminate front counter, and across the speckled terrazzo floor on the right—wrapping straight around behind the brick elevator enclosure with its key-locked call button—rose the rec center’s unmistakable 1977 architectural centerpiece: a massive, unpainted gray concrete ramp with metal pipe railings that climbed from the first floor up to the second and third floors. Because the building had opened in 1977—thirteen years before the Americans with Disabilities Act was ever signed into law—that concrete ramp was nowhere near ADA compliant.

“Two adult resident yearly memberships, please,” Katie smiled up at the recreation clerk behind the front counter, sliding the brand-new horizontal Virginia DMV State ID cards we had just picked up on Buckner Boulevard on Friday alongside our joint debit card across the laminate ledge.

The clerk glanced down at the Virginia Beach street address on Arvin Road printed across both of our IDs, typed our names into the desktop terminal, and had us pause in front of the webcam lens on the counter before handing back two freshly laminated plastic Fairlawn Recreation Center annual passes.

“Welcome back to Fairlawn,” the clerk said, holding up a brass key on a coiled wristband. “Did you two want me to come around and unlock the elevator for you to get up to the second floor, or are your power chairs okay on the concrete ramp?”

“With electric motors and full batteries, we can take the spiral ramp just fine,” I smiled, clipping my new membership card onto my lanyard beside Katie’s. “Wait until you see someone try to push a manual chair up that grade, though.”

Before climbing to the second floor, we took a nostalgic loop down the first-floor wing. Everything about the 1977 building still had the exact endearing, slightly worn neighborhood quirks we remembered from middle and high school. Past the meeting rooms sat the snack lounge, where a hand-lettered paper sign taped across the glass of the vending machines warned patrons in bold marker that the front desk could not issue refunds when the coils ate your dollar bills and that you had to call the vending company’s phone number yourself. Across the hall, we peeked into the Adult Lounge—which had pool tables and board-game tables just like the Youth Lounge down the corridor, minus the arcade cabinets—and rolled past the little two-lane bowling alley, where, right on cue, a laminated yellow sign hung between the ball returns reading *LANES CLOSED FOR PINSETTER MAINTENANCE*.

“Some things in Kempsville never change,” Katie giggled, squeezing my hand before we steered our SwiftChairs onto the bottom apron of the massive dark-gray concrete spiral ramp.

With our dual electric motors humming steadily against the steep 1970s incline, we spiraled side by side up the concrete helix around the lobby walls to the second-floor check-in desk. Down one corridor sat the open-gym basketball court and the enclosed racquetball court; down the other, through a sudden blast of warm, chlorine-scented air, lay the twenty-five-meter indoor pool, where the air and water stayed at a constant, humid eighty-four degrees while the non-humidified hallway outside sat at a brisk seventy-two.

Standing in the seventy-two-degree corridor between the hallway and the pool deck, however, Katie and I stopped our chairs in front of the two heavy doors leading into the changing area.

The door on the left was marked *MEN*. The door on the right was marked *WOMEN*. There was no other changing room anywhere on the floor.

Katie looked at the two separate doors, then looked down at her legs and over at me, the smile fading slightly from her lips.

“Well, that’s going to make swimming here tricky,” Katie said quietly.

At home on Arvin Road, neither of us ever thought twice about getting dressed or undressed because we always had each other right there to steady an elbow, help pull a wet swimsuit strap over a fatigued shoulder, or assist with the transfer bench. Here in the 1977 recreation center, once Katie rolled through the women's locker room door and I rolled through the men's door, there was no legal way for a brother and sister to help each other change into swim gear—and out on the pool deck beyond the tile showers, the five-foot-to-eight-foot pool didn't even have a mechanical transfer chair to lower a wheelchair user into the water.

"For today, we've got the Adult Lounge pool tables, the open gym, and our yearly cards in our pockets," I said, reaching across our armrests to take my sister's hand as we turned our wheelchairs back toward the top of the concrete spiral ramp to head down and catch the northbound Route 25 back to Glenrock Mall. "And if the two-lane bowling alley downstairs ever actually has both pinsetters working on the same afternoon, we'll treat it like a holiday."

A Near-Miss at Dying Glenrock Mall, Locking Down WHOIS, & Forming Our Virginia LLC

Part 1: A Dying Single-Story Mall, Spotting Brenda in the Concourse, & The WHOIS Wake-Up Call

Date: 2007-03-29 at 15:25 America/New_York

Thursday, March 29, 2007, 3:25 PM — Behind the Pillar in a Dying Single-Story Mall

"Nate—stop your chair right now and pull behind this pillar," Katie whispered sharply at three-twenty-five on Thursday afternoon, her left hand shooting across our armrests to cover my wrist just as we rolled inside the north corridor doors of Glenrock Mall to get out of the chilly March wind while waiting for our three-forty-five southbound Route 15 bus home.

I didn't ask a single question. Hearing the sudden ice in my twin sister's voice, I feathered my joystick backward and pivoted my SwiftChair in complete silence beside hers until both of our wheelchairs were tucked squarely behind a wide, beige-tiled structural column next to a lush indoor planter.

Unlike the two-story concourses of Emerald Creek Mall or Chesapeake Bay Mall, Glenrock Mall in 2007 was a sprawling, single-story 1970s shopping center that was visibly dying in slow motion even though its main concourse remained bright, clean, and welcoming under warm overhead skylights. All along the brightly lit single-level corridor stretching toward the center court, more than half of the inline retail storefronts sat closed and empty behind pulled-down security grilles with *FOR LEASE* signs taped inside the glass—their upper fascism bulkheads marked by faded, ghostly "label scars" in the paint and stucco where the illuminated letters of familiar national chain stores had been unbolted and hauled away. Aside from a discount shoe outlet, a watch-battery kiosk, and a cellphone-case cart in the middle of the polished terrazzo floor, the bright concourse was remarkably quiet.

And standing fifty feet down that single-story concourse in front of the cellphone-case cart—holding two stapled sheets of computer printer paper in her hand—was our estranged mother, Brenda.

My heart slammed against my ribs so hard I could hear my pulse in my ears. Beside me behind the wide column, Katie's hand gripped mine like a vise.

Neither of us had seen our mother's face since late August 2001, when the Virginia Beach court had granted Dad sole custody and exclusive possession after the cruise ship security tape—and the only time we had heard her voice since then was that terrifying Saturday night in August 2003 when she had lurked in the back alley behind the iron fire-escape stairs at Greenway Court in Norfolk while we hid inside our dark square closet.

"They're twenty-one years old—a boy and a girl, twins, blonde hair, both of them in black motorized wheelchairs," Brenda was saying loudly to the bored teenager working the cellphone-case cart, tapping the printed sheets in her hand. "I went by their old building on Greenway Court and up to that dump in Ocean View, and the managers said they moved out! Look at this printout from their little bus website—they wrote right here on Monday that they transfer between Route 15 and Route 25 at Glenrock Mall! You work right by the bus doors, don't you? Have you seen them roll through here today?!"

The teenager behind the cart shrugged his shoulders and shook his head without looking up from his magazine. "Lady, a hundred people walk through those bus doors every hour to catch the 15 and the 20. I don't keep track of who rides the bus."

Behind the beige-tiled pillar, Katie and I didn't breathe a sound.

As Brenda spun around in frustration and marched toward the opposite wing of the single-story concourse to badger the cashier inside the discount shoe store—her back turned completely away from the north entrance—Katie squeezed my fingers twice.

Moving in dead-silent synchronization with our speed dials turned down to a whisper-quiet crawl, we backed our two SwiftChairs ten feet from the column, glided out the automatic glass doors onto the exterior sidewalk apron, and rolled straight down the curb to the Route 15 bus bay just as the three-forty-five southbound bus pulled in from Little Creek Road and kneeled its front suspension.

Not until the hydraulic ramp folded back up, our four-point floor straps clicked tight, and the bus pulled out of the Glenrock Mall ring road onto southbound Military Highway toward Indian River Road did either of us let out the breath we had been holding.

4:15 PM — Checking Our Domain WHOIS Behind a Deadbolted Door

The second we rolled up our aluminum ramp on Arvin Road at four-fifteen, pushed our front door shut, and turned the brass deadbolt, Katie's hands were still trembling.

Before we even touched our computers, the two of us rolled straight down the hallway into our bedroom, helped each other out of our jackets and clothes, climbed inside our shared sleeping bag on the closet floor with the door pulled shut, and held each other skin to skin in the quiet dark for twenty straight minutes until Katie's breathing slowed and the cold knot in my stomach uncoiled.

When we finally dressed and rolled side by side into our dual-desk office at quarter to five, I opened a terminal window on my Linux machine and ran a public WHOIS query on the domain name for Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit.

"Look at the registrant output on my monitor, Katie," I said grimly, pointing at the plain-text lines returned by the public domain registry.

Back in early 2006, when we had pointed a custom domain name to Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit using the personal registrar login I had created back in 2005 while we were still staying at Tiffany's apartment on West Ocean View Avenue, the registrar had automatically pulled that saved Norfolk mailing address into our domain contact profile—and by default, ICANN published that exact record for anyone on the internet to query for free.

"That's how she knew to go to West Ocean View after checking Greenway Court," Katie said, her jaw tightening as she read the screen over my shoulder. "She typed our website name into a public domain lookup, saw the old West Ocean View apartment address still sitting on our registrar profile, went up there, and when the building manager told her we had moved out back in November of 2005, she started reading our blog posts to see which bus hubs we ride through!"

"Thank goodness we never updated our registrar account profile to Arvin Road after Dad brought us home from Ocean View," I breathed, my skin prickling at how close we had come to handing her a map to Dad's Virginia Beach house. "Because she has no idea this house on Arvin Road even exists. When Dad moved the three of us here in October 2001 after the custody order, she never got this address."

"And she is never going to get it," Katie said fiercely, picking up the desk phone on the table between our chairs and pressing the speed-dial button for Dad's cell phone up in Northern Virginia. "We need to lock down our domain registration today, Nate—and we need a real legal shield so our names and our home street never show up on a public database ever again."

Part 2: Dad's Legal Consultation, Our Virginia LLC, & A Virtual Mailbox at The Parcel Center

Date: 2007-04-03 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, April 3, 2007, 2:00 PM — The Registered Agent Shield & Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC

"Your father already took care of my consultation fee and the hundred-dollar State Corporation Commission filing fee by credit card this morning," attorney Kenneth Vance said warmly on Tuesday afternoon, sliding a blue legal folder across his ground-floor conference table off Independence Boulevard as Dad listened in over the walnut speakerphone from his lunch break up in Tysons Corner. "And when

David told me that Brenda was spotted wandering around Glenrock Mall with a printout from your website trying to figure out where you two live, I pulled the corporate forms immediately."

Sitting side by side in our SwiftChairs across the mahogany table, Katie and I leaned forward together. Six years earlier, in late August 2001, Mr. Vance was the exact Virginia Beach attorney who had taken Dad's shipboard security tape into circuit court, won Dad sole custody of the two of us, and secured the divorce stipulation restoring Brenda's maiden name, Walsh.

"We want to make sure our home street on Arvin Road never appears on a public website lookup, a domain database, or a business license," Katie told Mr. Vance clearly. "And once we finish our PHP and SQL coursework, we want to be able to build websites and software under a real business name without renting an expensive corporate office suite."

"Which is the smartest move you can make," Mr. Vance nodded, opening the folder to the Virginia State Corporation Commission Form LLC-1011, Articles of Organization, alongside a twenty-page Operating Agreement. "Right now, if you register a domain name or accept a check in your personal names from home, anyone who knows how to run a public database search can try to trace your residential address. By forming a Virginia limited liability company—owned strictly fifty-fifty by the two of you as Managing Members—the LLC becomes the legal owner of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit and every line of software you write."

He tapped the second paragraph on the state filing sheet with his fountain pen.

"Now look at Box Three and Box Four on the Articles of Organization," Mr. Vance explained. "Every Virginia LLC is required by statute to list a Registered Agent and a Registered Office address on the public State Corporation Commission database. If you list yourselves as your own Registered Agent, you have to put your home street address on the public state website. Instead, as a member of the Virginia State Bar, I am listing myself as your official Registered Agent and putting this law office right here off Independence Boulevard as your Registered Office."

"Wait—so if Brenda or anyone else searches our LLC on the state website in Richmond, the only address that comes up is your law office?" I asked, a huge wave of relief washing across my chest.

"My law office, my receptionist, and my security cameras," Mr. Vance smiled firmly. "And for Box Five—the LLC's Principal Office mailing address, which you'll also use for your domain WHOIS records, your bank checks, and your website footer—you don't need to lease a commercial office building. All you need to do on your way home today is stop at a commercial mail center like The Parcel Center, fill out Postal Form 1583 with your two Virginia State ID cards, and rent a commercial mailbox for fifteen dollars a month. That gives you a real commercial street address with a suite number. Every piece of business mail and every public WHOIS lookup goes to that suite number, while the two of you do one hundred percent of your work from your dual desks at home."

"What do you two think of that?" Dad's voice asked warmly through the speakerphone.

Katie looked at the corporate header printed across the top of the Operating Agreement—*PRAIRIE TWIN INTERACTIVE, LLC*—and laced her left fingers through my right hand before picking up the blue pen with her right hand.

“We love it, Dad,” Katie said, signing her name cleanly on the first Managing Member line and passing the pen across our armrests to me so I could sign the second fifty-fifty Managing Member line right beside hers.

3:45 PM — Signing Form 1583 at The Parcel Center & Scrubbing Our WHOIS Clean

Forty-five minutes later, on our bus ride back down toward Indian River Road, Katie and I rolled into the storefront of The Parcel Center in the commercial strip plaza near the highway.

Behind the counter, the clerk checked our two laminated Virginia DMV State ID cards, notarized our signatures on Postal Form 1583, and handed us two small brass mailbox keys along with a printed card showing our new commercial mailing address: a real commercial boulevard street number followed by *Suite 214*.

The moment we rolled back up our aluminum porch ramp on Arvin Road at four-thirty and deadbolted the door behind us, we wheeled straight into our office bedroom and logged into our domain registrar control panel.

Typing side by side, I replaced our personal names and the old West Ocean View apartment address on every domain record with *Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC* and our new *Suite 214* commercial mailbox address, enabled the registrar’s full WHOIS privacy proxy shield on top of it, and triggered an immediate registry refresh.

When I opened the Linux terminal window sixty seconds later and ran a fresh public WHOIS query on Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, every trace of our personal names, our phone number, and our residential history had vanished completely from the public internet.

“Go ahead and refresh the page at the library now, Brenda,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder as she watched the clean terminal output on my screen. “You’ll never find this house in a million years.”

Twenty-Two in Alexandria: Riding DMV Transit, Touring the White House & the U.S. Capitol, Meeting Senator James West, The Spark to Run for City Council, & Two Blue Passports

Part 1: Accessible Taxi to Newport News, The ARTS Train to Alexandria, & Riding Northern Virginia Transit on Our Twenty-Second Birthday

Date: 2007-04-08 at 09:15 America/New_York

Saturday, April 7 – Sunday, April 8, 2007 — Across the Water to Newport News & Rolling Into Alexandria

“Happy early twenty-second birthday, you two!” Dad beamed on Saturday afternoon, standing right beside the blue mobile wheelchair lift on the red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station as the ARTS conductor lowered Katie and me down from the stainless-steel vestibule of the Northeast Regional.

“Dad!” Katie grinned, releasing her joystick brake the second the lift apron touched the brick and rolling straight into his outstretched arms while I wheeled right up beside her for a three-way platform hug.

“How was the ride up from Newport News?” Dad asked, slinging both of our overnight duffel bags—including our rolled-up double sleeping bag—over his shoulders.

“Smooth as glass once we got across the harbor,” I told him as we rolled side by side along the station platform toward the short pedestrian sidewalk running beneath the King Street railroad bridge.

Because Norfolk still had zero passenger rail service in 2007—forcing anyone on the Southside who wanted to catch an ARTS train to cross the water to the Peninsula—Dad had pre-paid a wheelchair-accessible lift taxi van to pick Katie and me up at our driveway on Arvin Road at six-thirty that morning and drive us through the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel straight to the Newport News ARTS station on Warwick Boulevard. Since Newport News was the origin terminal for the morning train, the crew had plenty of time to wheel the station lift up to the accessible coach door, lock our SwiftChairs into the wide wheelchair bays across from the café car, and let us watch the Chickahominy swamps, the state capitol domes of Richmond, and the Rappahannock River bridges roll past our window all the way up to Northern Virginia.

Even better, when we rolled with Dad through the short underpass beneath the railroad tracks and emerged onto the west side of the tunnel, Dad’s two-story brick house on Sunset Drive sat right there at the foot of the hill—less than three minutes from both the ARTS train platforms and the elevated Capital Transit Yellow and Blue Line station at King Street.

Inside the house, Dad had already set up the ground-floor front room for us with a portable aluminum threshold ramp over the front step, a roll-in shower bench in the downstairs bathroom, and a cleared, freshly vacuumed first-floor coat and linen closet where we immediately spread out our sleeping bag and four pillows. Before we even unpacked our clothes, Katie and I proudly pulled out our lanyards at the dining table to show Dad the brand-new horizontal Virginia State ID cards we had gotten on Buckner Boulevard—both still showing our uninterrupted Arvin Road address from 2001, with the red Under-21 banners officially gone for good. That night—our last night of being twenty-one—after eating Dad’s homemade lasagna at the dining table, Katie and I slipped into that quiet downstairs closet, zipped our sleeping bag up around our shoulders, and slept skin to skin in each other’s arms without a single worry in the world.

Sunday, April 8, 2007, 10:30 AM — High-Platform Level Boarding & A Transit Grid That Doesn't Quit at Dinner

When we woke up on Sunday morning, April 8—officially twenty-two years old—Dad was standing in the kitchen holding two mugs of hot chocolate and two crisp plastic Capital Transit CapitalPass farecards loaded with a full week of unlimited rail and bus passes.

"For your twenty-second birthday week," Dad announced, handing one plastic card to Katie and one to me, "before we head into Washington on Tuesday for your big birthday surprise, we're going to spend today riding the buses and trains up here in Northern Virginia so the authors of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit can see how a connected regional network operates."

Twenty minutes later, the three of us rolled across the bus loop to the King Street Capital Transit station, tapped our plastic farecards against the accessible wide-aisle faregate pads, rode the glass elevator up to the center island platform, and waited as a six-car Yellow Line train glided to a halt alongside the concrete edge.

When the bi-parting metal doors slid open, Katie and I both stared at the threshold between the station platform and the railcar floor.

The concrete platform sat at the exact vertical height of the train floor. There were no steps, no steep ramps, and no waiting ten minutes for an operator to unfold a mechanical lift.

Katie pushed her joystick forward, and her front casters glided straight across the two-inch rubber gap-filler strip into the railcar alongside mine in less than two seconds.

"Did you just see that, Nate?!" Katie gasped, her eyes shining as the chime sounded and the doors closed behind us. "We just rolled straight onto a train by ourselves in two seconds flat! And look at our farecards—when you transfer from the train to a local Alexandria or Arlington bus at the station loop, the electronic reader automatically discounts the transfer instead of handing you a soggy paper slip that expires while you wait for an hourly bus!"

All Sunday afternoon and evening, Dad took us everywhere across Alexandria and Arlington: riding the Blue and Yellow Lines up past National Airport and Pentagon City, transferring seamlessly onto low-floor local buses with working automated stop announcements and paved curb-cut boarding pads at every single corner, and eating our twenty-second birthday dinner together at a bright restaurant near Old Town at eight o'clock at night.

When we finished our birthday cake at quarter past nine on a Sunday night and rolled back out to the street, buses were still pulling up to the illuminated shelters every fifteen minutes, and trains were still running overhead in both directions until midnight.

"Look at the clock on my phone, Nate," Katie said softly as we rolled off the nine-thirty bus at King Street and headed through the underpass back to Dad's house on Sunset Drive. "It's nine-thirty on a Sunday night, and families, restaurant workers, and people in wheelchairs are still riding buses and trains home without a single worry about getting stranded. Why can't Hampton Roads have this?"

Part 2: Unclipping Our Backpacks, Where Is President George W. Walker Today?, & The White House Tour That Sparked a Political Calling

Date: 2007-04-10 at 08:15 America/New_York

Tuesday, April 10, 2007, 8:15 AM — Unclipping Our Wheelchair Backpacks on Sunset Drive

“Hold it right there before you two roll out the front door,” Dad said with a grin at eight-fifteen on Tuesday morning in the hallway of his brick house on Sunset Drive, holding up the printed instruction sheet from Senator James West’s office. “Rule number one on the Secret Service boarding sheet: zero backpacks, zero bags, zero cameras, and zero cell phones allowed inside the White House—and there are no storage lockers at the gate.”

Katie glanced back over her shoulder at the black nylon backpack clipped to the backrest of her SwiftChair—where we normally carried our spare chargers, rain ponchos, and notebooks—and then looked over at mine.

“Not even a wheelchair bag?” I asked, reaching behind Katie’s backrest so we could unbuckle each other’s straps.

“Not in 2007,” Dad said, helping me lift Katie’s backpack off her frame while she unclipped mine and set both bags neatly beside the hall coat rack. “If you show up at the East Wing gate on Fifteenth Street with a bag or a camera, the Secret Service turns you right around, and the nearest place to rent a storage locker is all the way over at Union Station. All the three of us need in our pockets today are our CapitalPass transit cards, our White House tour confirmation letter, and those brand-new horizontal Virginia State ID cards of yours.”

“Good thing we spent three hours at the Buckner Boulevard DMV waiting on tickets B042 and B043,” Katie laughed, patting her wallet pocket as our chairs felt noticeably lighter without our everyday packs hanging behind our shoulders.

As we rolled side by side through the King Street railroad underpass toward the Blue Line platform on a crisp April morning, Katie looked up at Dad with genuine curiosity.

“How on earth did you manage to score three confirmed passes to tour the White House on three weeks’ notice anyway, Dad?” she asked.

“By writing to our brand-new Senator from Virginia,” Dad smiled as the elevator doors opened onto the King Street platform. “When you two walked out of Fishersville in March and came back home to Arvin Road, and we planned this birthday week up here, I sent constituent tour requests to Capitol Hill. Everyone in Virginia knows our senior Senator, Senator John Warren, is an institution in the Senate, of course, and his office was booked solid with spring school trips—but our newly sworn-in junior Senator, Senator James West, just took office in January and wanted to prove right out of the gate that his office answers every constituent letter. His constituent-services director called me back personally within forty-eight hours,

submitted our security clearance numbers to the Secret Service for a nine-thirty White House tour, and invited us up to his Senate office this afternoon to watch the Senate in session."

Katie looked down at the embossed tour pass in her hand, her blue eyes widening with quiet respect. "A brand-new United States Senator actually had his office call a regular family back in two days just to help two twins in wheelchairs see the White House and the Capitol?"

"Sure did," Dad said warmly as the northbound Blue Line train glided up to the platform edge. "And his staff told me he wants to step out of his office and say hello to you two himself when we pick up our gallery passes this afternoon."

9:25 AM — Flashing Our Horizontal State IDs at the East Wing & Where President George W. Walker Is Today

At nine-twenty-five, after riding the Blue Line elevator up to the sidewalk at McPherson Square and rolling two blocks down Fifteenth Street alongside the black wrought-iron perimeter fence of the White House grounds, the three of us approached the uniformed Secret Service checkpoint at the East Wing visitor entrance.

Side by side, Katie and I reached into our wallets and handed our brand-new horizontal twenty-one-and-over Virginia State ID cards up to the uniformed Secret Service officer at the podium.

The officer held Katie's horizontal card and then mine alongside the cleared manifest clipboards, checked our photographs and our April 8, 1985 birthdates, and smiled down at both of us without a single blink.

"Katie Prairie and Nathaniel Prairie from Virginia Beach," the officer said, handing our horizontal IDs back to us. "Happy twenty-second birthday to both of you, and welcome to the White House. Because you're in power wheelchairs, Officer Henderson right inside the East Wing doors will take your family up the accessible ramp and the visitor elevator so you don't miss a single room on the route."

"Thank you, sir," Katie and I said together, tucking our horizontal State ID cards proudly back into our pockets as we rolled smoothly through the security pavilion and into the wood-paneled East Wing lobby.

Inside, a tall Uniformed Secret Service Tour Officer with a polished gold badge on his navy lapel—Officer Henderson—greeted the three of us warmly and guided our two SwiftChairs up the interior accessible ramp into the vaulted Ground Floor Corridor beneath the Executive Residence.

As our small tour group paused outside the Vermeil Room—lined with gilded silver services and portraits of First Ladies—and then looked into the red-and-cream China Room and the book-lined White House Library, a father standing next to us in a lightweight jacket raised his hand.

"Excuse me, Officer," the man asked hopefully. "Is there any chance our tour group might catch a glimpse of President Walker walking down the hallway today?"

Officer Henderson chuckled good-naturedly—the practiced, polite laugh of an officer who heard that exact question twenty times a morning.

"I always hate to disappoint folks on their first trip, sir, but White House public tours almost never cross paths with the President," Officer Henderson explained warmly, gesturing toward the west end of the vaulted corridor. "Even when the President is here at the complex, his working offices are over in the West Wing, and the First Family's private living quarters are upstairs on the Second and Third Floors—completely separate from the historic Ground Floor and State Floor reception rooms we tour here."

"Wait—doesn't the flag on the roof tell you whether the President is home, like Buckingham Palace?" the man's teenage son asked.

"A lot of people think that, actually, because of the movies," Officer Henderson smiled, shaking his head. "By federal law, the American flag over the White House flies twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week, whether the President is in Washington or halfway around the world. If you want to know the real insider secret for whether the President is working in the Oval Office, you look over at the exterior portico door of the West Wing. Whenever the President is physically inside the West Wing, a United States Marine sentry in full dress blues stands at rigid attention right outside that door. The minute the President leaves the West Wing—either to travel or to walk back to the Residence for the night—the Marine sentry steps down."

"And how do the reporters know when he's done with public appearances for the whole day?" Katie asked curiously from her wheelchair.

"That's called 'calling a lid,'" Officer Henderson answered with an appreciative nod toward Katie. "Whenever the President is finished with all public appearances, speeches, and travel for the day, the Press Secretary's office gets on the loudspeaker in the press briefing room and announces a 'travel and photo lid.' Once a lid is called, everyone knows the President is in for the evening and won't be seen in public again until morning. Today, though, there's no Marine sentry at the West Wing door for the opposite reason—President George W. Walker isn't even in the District of Columbia right now."

"Where is he today?" I asked.

"President Walker flew back late last night from Yuma, Arizona, where he spent Monday touring the southwestern border," Officer Henderson replied, leading our three-person family over to the wood-paneled Visitor Elevator so we could ride up to the State Floor while the walking group climbed the marble stairs. "And about twenty minutes ago, he headed across the Potomac River into Northern Virginia—right over to American Legion Post 177 in Fairfax, Virginia—to deliver a ten-fifteen address to military families and veterans on the emergency supplemental appropriations bill."

Inside the elevator cab, I leaned across our inner armrests, wrapped my arm around Katie's shoulders in a quick, warm squeeze, and whispered against her cheek with a grin.

"Hold on, Katie," I murmured as she leaned into my hug. "We rode the CCT bus right through the middle of Fairfax two days ago on our birthday, and today President Walker is in Fairfax while we're inside his house!"

Katie had to press her lips together to keep from laughing out loud as the brass elevator doors slid open onto the State Floor.

10:05 AM — FDR's Wheelchair in the East Room, John Adams's Prayer in the State Dining Room, & The Spark Inside Katie

When we rolled out of the elevator into the vast, sunlit expanse of the East Room—with its gleaming oak parquet floors, gold silk damask draperies, and three towering Bohemian cut-glass chandeliers overhead—the lighthearted humor in Katie's eyes gave way to sudden, breathtaking awe.

Officer Henderson walked beside our chairs across the polished floor, pausing beneath the full-length 1797 Gilbert Stuart portrait of George Washington—the famous canvas Dolley Madison had ordered unscrewed from the wall and carried to safety before British troops burned the White House in August 1814.

Then Officer Henderson looked down at Katie's and my two black SwiftChairs and pointed toward the wide, flush oak thresholds connecting the rooms along the State Floor.

"A lot of visitors don't realize it when they walk through these rooms," Officer Henderson told the three of us quietly, "but for twelve consecutive years—from March 1933 until April 1945, through the depths of the Great Depression and the entirety of the Second World War—the President of the United States governed this country from a wheelchair right across these exact parquet floors. President Franklin Delano Roosevelt had wooden ramps built over the thresholds of the East Wing and the State Floor long before accessibility laws existed, and he held his regular press conferences and wartime briefings right in these halls. And decades later, the coalition work that led to President George H.W. Walker signing the Americans with Disabilities Act out on the South Lawn on July 26, 1990 came right through these doors."

Beside me, Katie's left hand found my right hand between our armrests and held on tight. Looking down at the oak parquet under her front casters—realizing that a President in a wheelchair had steered the United States through its darkest twentieth-century hours across the very floorboards beneath our tires—made the room feel less like a glass museum case and more like a living workshop of history.

From the East Room, we rolled side by side through the silk-walled Green Room—Thomas Jefferson's old dining room—and into the oval Blue Room at the center of the South Portico, looking out the tall floor-to-ceiling windows across the South Lawn toward the Jefferson Memorial gleaming beyond the Tidal Basin. Passing through the parlor walls of the Empire-furnished Red Room, we rolled into the final major room on the State Floor: the State Dining Room.

Even with the velvet tour rope guiding visitors toward the Cross Hall, Officer Henderson let the three of us pause for a full minute in front of the carved white marble fireplace mantel on the west wall.

Above the mantel hung George Peter Alexander Healy's portrait of Abraham Lincoln seated in quiet, heavy contemplation, his chin resting on his hand as he carried the weight of a divided nation. Directly beneath the portrait, carved into the

stone frieze of the fireplace mantel at President Franklin Roosevelt's direction, were the words President John Adams had written to his wife Abigail on his second night in the unfinished White House in November 1800:

I Pray Heaven to Bestow the Best of Blessings on THIS HOUSE and on All that shall hereafter Inhabit it. May none but Honest and Wise Men ever Rule under This Roof.

I turned my head to look at my twin sister.

Katie wasn't just admiring the painting or the gilded molding like a tourist anymore. Her posture in her SwiftChair was bolt upright, her blue eyes fixed on Lincoln's portrait and the carved words beneath it with a fierce, luminous intensity I had never seen on her face before.

As we rolled out through the red-carpeted Cross Hall between the marble columns and emerged through the Entrance Hall onto the accessible ramp of the North Portico overlooking Pennsylvania Avenue, Dad noticed the quiet fire in Katie's eyes too.

"You grew awfully quiet back there in the State Dining Room, Katie," Dad said gently as we paused on the North Portico driveway in the April sunshine. "What were you thinking about?"

Katie looked back up at the white sandstone columns of the North Portico and then down at our two wheelchairs resting side by side on the pavement.

"All my life, Dad," Katie said, her voice steady and almost startled by its own clarity, "whenever people on television talked about the White House or the government, it always felt like some distant planet run by people who didn't live in the real world we live in. Being inside those rooms—seeing the floors where President Roosevelt rolled his wheelchair, reading John Adams's prayer carved into that stone mantel, and realizing how many laws that affect every single day of our lives were signed or vetoed behind those walls—just made something click in my head."

She looked straight at me, her fingers still linked with mine.

"The people who govern in rooms like that aren't magical beings, Nate," Katie said softly. "They're just citizens who showed up and ran for office. And when people who ride public buses and use wheelchairs aren't in the room when the decisions get made, nobody speaks for us."

Part 3: Beneath the Capitol Dome: Touring the Crypt, the Rotunda, National Statuary Hall, & the Historic Old Senate Chamber

Date: 2007-04-10 at 11:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, April 10, 2007, 11:30 AM — The Capitol Police Checkpoint & The Compass Stone in the Crypt

From McPherson Square, the three of us rode the Capital Transit Blue Line beneath the National Mall to Capitol South Station, took the street elevator up to First Street SE in the late-morning sunshine, and rolled up the wide, curved walkways of Capitol Hill.

Because the new underground Capitol Visitor Center on the East Front was still a massive fenced construction site in the spring of 2007, constituent tours entered through the accessible South Wing pavilion near Garfield Circle. Waiting right inside the accessible entrance with three yellow visitor badges was a cheerful twenty-three-year-old staff assistant from Senator James West's office named Marcus, standing alongside a gray-haired historian wearing the unmistakable crimson-red blazer of the United States Capitol Guide Service.

"Welcome to the United States Capitol, Mr. Prairie, Katie, and Nathaniel," the U.S. Capitol Police officer at the screening table smiled as Katie and I proudly handed over our new horizontal twenty-one-and-over Virginia State ID cards for the second time that morning. "Still no bags or backpacks, I see—you two are making my job easy today! Right through the wide gate and enjoy your tour."

Once we clipped our visitor passes to our collars, our red-blazered Capitol Guide—Mr. Galloway—led the three of us and Marcus onto the elevator up to the first floor and out into the circular sandstone colonnade of the Capitol Crypt.

Forty massive Doric columns of Virginia Aquia Creek sandstone rose around us, supporting the vaulted groin arches that held up the weight of the Rotunda floor directly overhead.

"Roll right over here to the center of the ring," Mr. Galloway invited us, gesturing toward a sunken white marble star set inside a brass ring in the center of the stone floor. "Right beneath your wheels is the Compass Stone—the exact geographic zero-point dividing Washington, D.C. into its four quadrants: Northwest, Northeast, Southwest, and Southeast. Every street address in the federal capital is measured outward from this single stone."

Katie positioned her SwiftChair beside the brass ring so her front right caster rested on the Northeast line while mine rested on the Southeast line, reaching across her armrest to lace her fingers with mine.

"Think about the sandstone in these forty columns, too," Dad remarked, running his hand admiringly along the warm, fossil-flecked grain of one of the pillars. "Quarried down on Aquia Creek in Stafford County, Virginia, and barged up the Potomac River more than two hundred years ago."

12:00 PM — Looking Up Into the Capitol Rotunda

A two-minute elevator ride brought the five of us up to the second floor, and when the bronze doors slid open and Katie and I rolled side by side through the sandstone archway into the United States Capitol Rotunda, both of us tilted our heads all the way back against our headrests in stunned silence.

Rising one hundred and eighty feet straight above our wheelchairs was the soaring white cast-iron canopy of the Capitol Dome, flooded with midday sunlight streaming through the ring of tall peristyle windows. At the very crown of the oculus, Constantino Brumidi's fresco—*The Apotheosis of Washington*—seemed to float in midair above the continuous three-hundred-foot painted stone belt of the Frieze of American History.

Around the curved sandstone walls at floor level hung eight monumental historical oil paintings in heavy gilded frames, four of them painted from life by John Trumbull, who had served as George Washington's own aide-de-camp during the Revolutionary War.

While other tourists snapped photos of *Declaration of Independence*, Katie rolled her SwiftChair slowly across the flagstones to stop directly in front of two paintings side by side: *Surrender of Lord Cornwallis*, painted on the fields of Yorktown just thirty-five miles up the road from our home in Virginia Beach, and *General George Washington Resigning His Commission* at Annapolis in December 1783.

"Most visitors walk right past that fourth Trumbull painting on their way to Statuary Hall," Mr. Galloway observed approvingly, stepping up beside Katie's wheelchair and Dad. "Do you know why historians consider *General George Washington Resigning His Commission* the most important painting in the entire Rotunda?"

"Because he gave the power back," Katie answered immediately, her eyes fixed on the painted parchment scroll in Washington's outstretched hand. "He had the Continental Army behind him, and he could have stayed in power for life like a king—Wait, that's what King George III said when they told him Washington was going to resign and go home to Mount Vernon, isn't it? That if he did that, he would be the greatest man in the world?"

Mr. Galloway beamed from ear to ear. "Spot-on! In a republic, the highest office in the land doesn't belong to the person holding the commission—it's held in trust for the people and returned to civilian hands under the Constitution."

12:35 PM — John Quincy Adams's Whisper Spot in National Statuary Hall & The Historic Old Senate Chamber

Rolling south through the tall bronze doors out of the Rotunda, we entered the semicircular Greek Revival amphitheater of National Statuary Hall—the original chamber of the House of Representatives from 1807 until 1857, ringed with marble and bronze statues contributed by the states.

Mr. Galloway guided Katie's and my wheelchairs over to a small brass plaque embedded in the black-and-white marble tiles on the east side of the floor, stamped with the name *JOHN QUINCY ADAMS*.

"Wait right here on this brass marker, Katie and Nathaniel," Mr. Galloway said with a twinkle in his eye, walking thirty-five feet away across the crowded floor toward the opposite side of the hall and turning his back to us.

Even with dozens of visitors talking across the room, Mr. Galloway's softest whisper traveled up the curved parabolic ceiling, bounced across the plaster arch overhead, and dropped straight down into Katie's and my ears as clearly as if he were leaning over our armrests:

"When John Quincy Adams served in the House of Representatives after leaving the Presidency, he sat at this exact desk—and he could hear every word the opposing party whispered on the other side of the chamber!"

Katie and I both grinned across the hall at him as Dad laughed out loud.

Before we headed through the underground tunnel to grab lunch in the Senate cafeteria prior to our one-forty-five appointment with Senator West, Marcus and Mr. Galloway took us on one final elevator ride up to the semicircular gallery entrance of the historic Old Senate Chamber—the intimate, crimson-and-gold room where the United States Senate had debated the fate of the Union from 1810 until 1859, and where the Supreme Court of the United States had subsequently sat for seventy-five years until 1935.

Looking across the two curved tiers of polished mahogany desks toward the crimson silk canopy and the gilded wooden eagle perched above the Vice President's dais, Katie asked Marcus and Mr. Galloway a question that made both men pause.

"When a bill comes to the Senate today," Katie asked, pointing toward the front row of desks, "how much of the actual text gets written during the speeches on the floor versus inside the committee rooms before the cameras ever turn on?"

"Ninety-five percent of it happens in committee and subcommittee markups, Katie," Marcus answered honestly, impressed by the question. "Floor speeches get the headlines on the six-o'clock news, but the Senators who sit down in committee, read every line of the statutory formulas, and write the amendments are the ones who actually decide whether a transit agency gets funded or a ramp gets built."

Katie nodded slowly, filing every word of that answer away inside her memory as we turned our chairs toward the elevator.

Part 4: Meeting Senator James West, Watching the U.S. Senate From the Gallery, & Why Can't We Ride the Bus to City Hall?

Date: 2007-04-10 at 13:45 America/New_York

Tuesday, April 10, 2007, 1:45 PM — Meeting Senator James West & Riding the Capitol Subway

At one-forty-five, after eating lunch with Dad in the Senate cafeteria, the three of us rolled down the marble corridor of the Senate Office Building and turned through the tall wooden double doors of United States Senator James West's suite, where the Great Seal of the Commonwealth of Virginia hung beside the entrance.

Before the receptionist had even finished handing us our three blue cardboard United States Senate Gallery passes, the inner door of the Senator's private office opened—and out walked Senator James West himself in his dark navy suit and striped tie.

He didn’t stand stiffly behind a rope line or talk exclusively to Dad over our heads the way so many adults did when they saw two twenty-two-year-old twins in motorized wheelchairs. Instead, Senator West walked straight across the reception carpet to our chairs, leaned down to look Katie and me directly in the eyes, and shook Katie’s hand and then mine with a firm, warm grip.

“Katie and Nathaniel, happy twenty-second birthday, and welcome to Washington,” Senator West said in his steady Virginia cadence. “My staff told me the two of you just finished your computer science degrees down at the Community College of Hampton Roads in Norfolk, started your own vocational software course, and run your own regional transit blog down at the coast. How did the White House and the Capitol Rotunda treat you this morning?”

“They were unforgettable, Senator West,” Katie said, her voice clear and earnest as she shook his hand. “Thank you so much for having your office arrange our passes. We couldn’t believe how quickly your staff called our dad back.”

“Don’t ever let anyone tell you that these buildings belong to the lobbyists or the politicians, Katie,” Senator West told her, looking from Katie’s eyes to mine and then up at Dad. “The United States Capitol belongs to the people of the United States—and my number-one job as your Senator from Virginia is making sure when constituents from Virginia Beach knock on this door, somebody answers. I have to head over to the floor in ten minutes to speak on the transportation and veterans’ appropriations bill, so I’m going to have Marcus take the three of you down to the Capitol subway right now so you can watch the live session from the front row of the gallery.”

Watching a sitting United States Senator take the time in the middle of a busy legislative afternoon to look us directly in the eyes and remind us that the Capitol belonged to the constituents who knocked on its door left an impression on my sister that neither of us would ever forget.

Five minutes later, Marcus escorted the three of us down the elevator to the bright underground tunnel of the Capitol Subway system, guided our two SwiftChairs onto the level accessible car of the electric subway tram, and rode with us beneath Constitution Avenue straight into the basement of the Senate Wing.

2:10 PM — Looking Down From the Third-Floor U.S. Senate Gallery

Riding the Senate wing elevator up to the third floor, we followed the gallery doorkeeper’s quiet hand signals through the heavy padded double doors of the Visitors’ Gallery and rolled our two SwiftChairs side by side into the level wheelchair alcove overlooking the United States Senate Chamber.

The moment we looked over the brass-and-mahogany balcony railing, Katie’s breath caught audibly in her throat.

Directly below us stretched the four semicircular tiers of a hundred historic mahogany desks arranged across the blue patterned carpet of the Senate floor. Down at the tiered marble rostrum, the presiding officer’s gavel tapped once, the reading clerk called out the number of a pending amendment, and Senators rose behind their

desks—including Senator James West and senior Senator John Warren on the Virginia aisle—to debate federal transit formula grants and veterans' medical care in live session.

When Senator James West rose behind his desk to speak, he glanced up briefly toward the third-floor gallery alcove where the three of us were sitting and gave a subtle, respectful nod before addressing the Chair.

For forty-five straight minutes, Katie didn't look away from the Senate floor once. She leaned slightly forward in her SwiftChair, her left hand resting warmly over mine on my armrest, watching how a single elected voice standing behind a mahogany desk could force an entire chamber—and an entire federal agency—to put its numbers on the public record and vote in the daylight.

8:30 PM — Back at Dad's Dining Table in Alexandria: The 5:30 PM Last Bus Home & How to Run for City Council

That evening, after eating dinner near Capitol Hill and riding the Yellow Line train across the Potomac River bridge to King Street at eight-fifteen—transferring effortlessly onto a local evening bus just to see the neighborhood loop before rolling through the railroad underpass and retrieving our wheelchair backpacks inside Dad's brick house on Sunset Drive—Katie didn't head straight for the downstairs closet to rest.

Instead, she rolled her SwiftChair right up to Dad's dining table, opened her silver laptop beside mine, and pulled up two browser tabs side by side: the official meeting calendar of the Virginia Beach City Council, and the printed PDF timetables for Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Routes 12 and 33.

Dad walked in from the kitchen carrying three tall glasses of cold ginger ale, set them on coasters, and looked at the fierce, concentrated expression on my sister's face. "What are you looking at on there, Katie?"

Katie turned her laptop screen slightly so Dad and I could both see it, and her voice was shaking with genuine, righteous anger.

"Look at what the three of us just did tonight here in Alexandria and Washington, Dad," Katie said, tapping the corner of her keyboard. "Today we toured the White House, toured the Capitol Rotunda and Statuary Hall, watched the United States Senate in session from the gallery, ate dinner at seven-thirty, and rode public trains and buses all the way back to Sunset Drive at eight-thirty at night without a single problem. Now look at the schedule back home in Virginia Beach—the largest city in the entire Commonwealth of Virginia!"

She pointed her finger at the Virginia Beach City Council schedule on the left half of her screen, and then at the CVTA bus timetable on the right half.

"Virginia Beach City Council formal evening sessions and public-comment hearings down at the Municipal Center start at six o'clock in the evening," Katie said, her blue eyes flashing. "If Nate and I want to ride the bus from Arvin Road down to City Hall to speak to our own City Council during a six-o'clock meeting, we have to take

Route 12 to the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus hub and transfer to Route 33 down to the Municipal Center. Now look at the return schedule from the Municipal Center!"

I leaned in over my armrest and read the black-and-white timetable columns aloud with her.

"To get back to the CCHR hub in time to connect to Route 12, Route 25, or Route 29," I said, "you have to leave the Municipal Center on the five-thirty PM Route 33 bus—because the very last Route 12 bus back to Indian River Road and Military Highway leaves CCHR at five-forty-eight PM!"

"Five-thirty PM!" Katie repeated, slapping her palm lightly against the tabletop. "City Council meetings start at six o'clock, and the last bus home for a citizen who needs to connect at CCHR leaves City Hall at five-thirty—thirty minutes before the meeting even starts! And even if you live right on Route 33 and don't have to transfer at CCHR, the last northbound bus going all the way to Sixty-Eighth Street leaves the Municipal Center at six-oh-one PM—one minute after the Mayor bangs the gavel! If you rely on a bus in Virginia Beach, you are literally locked out of attending your own City Council meetings unless you want to get stranded fifteen miles from home in the dark!"

Dad sat down in the wooden chair across from us, resting his forearms on the table as he looked at Katie. "And because none of the people sitting on the Virginia Beach City Council ever ride a bus, none of them even notices—or cares—that the schedule locks bus riders out of City Hall."

Katie stared at the screen for a long, quiet moment—remembering President Roosevelt's wheelchair path across the State Floor of the White House, the portrait of Abraham Lincoln above John Adams's carved prayer, the hundred mahogany desks she had looked down upon from the United States Senate Gallery that afternoon, and the words Senator James West had spoken to us in his reception room: *Don't ever let anyone tell you that these buildings belong to the lobbyists or the politicians.*

Then Katie opened a third browser tab and typed a search query into the address bar: *Commonwealth of Virginia State Board of Elections Candidate Qualification Guide — City Council*.

"What are you pulling up now, Katie?" I asked softly, rolling my chair flush against hers.

"How old you have to be, how many registered voter signatures you need on a petition, and what forms you have to file to run for the Virginia Beach City Council," Katie answered, her voice steady as steel as the PDF loaded on her screen. "Look right here under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-501: eighteen years old, a qualified voter registered at your residential address in the Kempsville District—which we've had on our Virginia State ID cards and voter registration on Arvin Road since 2001—and one hundred twenty-five certified voter signatures. If the politicians on the Virginia Beach City Council won't ride the bus or let bus riders attend their six-o'clock meetings, Nate, then we're going to learn every rule in this book, and I'm going to run for City Council so we can make the changes from the inside."

Flipping up the inner armrest between our two SwiftChairs, I leaned across and wrapped both arms tightly around my twin sister's shoulders. Katie exhaled a long, slow breath and buried her face against my neck, wrapping her arms around my chest as the familiar, steady deep pressure of our embrace settled our racing nerves —and twenty minutes later, inside the quiet, dark sanctuary of Dad's downstairs bedroom closet, we fell asleep cuddled up together inside our shared sleeping bag with the future of Virginia Beach already taking shape in our minds.

Part 5:

Date: 2007-04-19 at 13:15 America/New_York

Thursday, April 19, 2007, 1:15 PM — "What's This?" and Why We Wanted Passports

"Wait a second—what's this?" the young teller behind the counter at the neighborhood bank branch asked on Thursday afternoon, squinting down at the brand-new horizontal plastic card I had just slid under the acrylic window alongside our business checking signature card. "Do you have a driver's license?"

Sitting right beside my left wheel, Katie let out a slow, measured breath through her nose.

"It's a Virginia State ID card," I told the teller patiently, tapping my finger against the words *COMMONWEALTH OF VIRGINIA — IDENTIFICATION CARD* printed in bold letters across the top of the laminate. "It's issued by the Virginia Department of Motor Vehicles, and it's an official state identification card."

"Oh!" the teller blinked, glancing down through the glass partition at the two black motorized wheelchairs Katie and I were sitting in before her cheeks turned pink. "Right—sorry about that! I'm just so used to looking at driver's licenses all day that the top banner threw me off."

Every single adult who doesn't drive knows that exact moment. On paper, under every state and federal statute in America, a valid DMV-issued State ID card is 100 percent equal to a driver's license for proving who you are. In the real world, however, an astonishing number of clerks, tellers, and receptionists stare at a State ID card as if you just handed them a laminated grocery-store coupon and ask, *"What's this?"* until you explain to them that it is, in fact, an ID card.

As we rolled out of the bank lobby onto the sidewalk ten minutes later, Katie looked over at me with her mind already made up.

"You know what we're doing this afternoon while we're already out on the bus, don't you, Nate?" Katie asked.

"Getting United States Passports?" I grinned.

"Getting United States Passports," Katie declared firmly. "First of all, after riding the ARTS train up to Alexandria and Washington last week, I want the two of us to have real passports so if we ever decide to take the train all the way up to Montreal or Toronto—or fly across the Atlantic one day—we don't have to wait three months

for paperwork. And second of all, I would love to see anybody in the Commonwealth of Virginia look at an official United States Passport with the gold eagle on the cover and ask us, *'What's this?'*"

2:30 PM — Form DS-11, Two-by-Two Photos, & Raising Our Right Hands at the Post Office

That afternoon, back at our dual-desk office on Arvin Road, Katie and I downloaded two copies of U.S. Department of State Form DS-11—the official Application for a U.S. Passport for first-time adult applicants—and filled out every box in black ink, carefully leaving the signature line at the bottom blank just as the instructions required until we were right in front of an authorized Acceptance Agent.

From the fireproof steel document box Dad kept in the hall linen closet, we pulled out our original certified Commonwealth of Virginia birth certificates with the raised embossed seals from the Division of Vital Records in Richmond, tucked them into a rigid manila folder alongside our horizontal Virginia State ID cards and our checkbook, and rode the bus over to the Kempsville post office passport window.

"Two first-time adult passport applications and two sets of passport photos, please," Katie told the uniformed postal acceptance clerk at two-thirty as we rolled our SwiftChairs side by side up to the passport counter.

"You two came prepared," the postal clerk smiled, checking our unsigned DS-11 forms and our raised-seal birth certificates before sliding a white pull-down screen down behind the end of the counter. "Roll right over here in front of the white screen one at a time so I can take your two-by-two photos. Chin level, shoulders square to the lens, and give me a natural look looking straight into the camera."

Because the backs of our SwiftChairs came up behind our shoulders in dark black upholstery, the clerk angled the camera slightly downward at seated eye level so the two-inch-by-two-inch frame captured our heads and shoulders cleanly against the plain white backdrop.

While the photo printer behind the counter spat out two glossy sheets of twin two-by-two portraits and the clerk trimmed them with a heavy metal die-cutter, a newer postal clerk at the adjacent register leaned over to glance at the two horizontal Virginia cards Katie and I had laid on the counter.

"Wait—what kind of cards are those?" the trainee clerk asked, squinting at the lack of a driver-class code.

Katie and I looked at each other and burst out laughing at the exact same second.

"They're Virginia State ID cards," Katie told him cheerfully. "And in about ten weeks, we're going to have two blue books to go right alongside them."

"Don't mind him—state IDs are 100 percent valid primary photo identification for a DS-11," our passport acceptance clerk chuckled, copying our Virginia ID numbers onto the verification block of our applications and stapling one two-by-two photo to Katie's form and one to mine.

She turned both clipboards around on the lowered counter and handed us each a black ballpoint pen.

“All right, Katie and Nathaniel—please raise your right hands,” the clerk said officially. “Do you solemnly swear or affirm that the statements made on this application are true and that the photograph attached is a true likeness of yourself?”

“I do,” Katie and I said together, our right hands raised side by side from our wheelchairs.

Under the clerk’s watchful eyes, we signed our full legal names inside the signature boxes on our DS-11 forms, wrote out the checks for the Department of State application fee and the post office execution and photo fees, and watched her seal our applications and our certified birth certificates inside two tamper-evident transmittal pouches bound for the National Passport Center.

Ten Weeks Later (Saturday, June 30, 2007) — Two Crisp Blue Books in the Mailbox

Because the spring and summer of 2007 saw the largest nationwide passport backlog in modern history—triggered by new federal rules requiring passports for air travel across the Western Hemisphere—the routine six-week wait stretched into ten full weeks.

Every afternoon when the mail carrier walked up Arvin Road, I rolled out onto the front porch ramp to check the mailbox beside our front door.

Then, on Saturday afternoon, June 30, 2007, I opened the metal mailbox lid and pulled out four stiff envelopes from the United States Department of State: two flat manila envelopes returning our original raised-seal Virginia birth certificates, and two stiff flat-rate cardboard mailers with protective inserts inside.

“Katie!” I called out, wheeling straight down the hallway into our dual-desk office and holding up the four envelopes. “They’re here!”

Katie spun her SwiftChair away from her keyboard so fast her front casters chirped against the floor mat. Side by side, we tore open the tear-strips on the two stiff cardboard mailers and slid out two brand-new, dark navy-blue United States Passports, the gold Great Seal of the United States and the new biometric electronic-chip symbol gleaming across the textured front covers.

Opening the inside covers, we stared down at our digitized two-by-two post-office portraits printed beneath the holographic eagles, valid for ten full years until June 2017.

“Look at that, Nate,” Katie smiled, setting our two open passports on the desk blotter before flipping up her inner armrest and leaning right into my arms for a long, tight, deep-pressure hug. Pressing my cheek against her hair as we held each other close—feeling that unmistakable calm and security that always washed over both of us whenever we cuddled together—I listened to her whisper against my shoulder: “Our own house on Arvin Road, our own software LLC, our horizontal Virginia State IDs, and now two United States Passports. Wherever the rails go next, we have our tickets.”

Associate Degrees in Hand, ‘Not the Right Skill Match,’ & Launching Prairie Twin Interactive From Arvin Road

Associate Degrees in Hand, ‘Not the Right Skill Match,’ & Putting Our Virginia LLC to Work

Date: 2007-06-14 at 14:15 America/New_York

Thursday, June 14, 2007, 2:15 PM — “Not Quite the Right Skill Match” & The Careful Language of Corporate HR

“Your PHP database queries and your Associate of Applied Science transcripts from the Community College of Hampton Roads are certainly impressive on paper,” the human-resources director said in a smooth, carefully measured voice at two-fifteen on Thursday afternoon inside a second-floor office park off Virginia Beach Boulevard, folding her hands neatly atop our printed resumes without quite meeting our eyes. “However, after reviewing our current project pipeline this afternoon, we feel that your background isn’t quite the right skill match for what our team is looking for right now, and we are looking for candidates with a bit more traditional in-house agency experience.”

Sitting side by side in our black SwiftChairs across the glass conference table, Katie and I exchanged a single, quiet glance.

We didn’t need a translator to know what had actually changed between eleven o’clock that morning—when the company’s lead developer had practically begged us over the phone to come in as soon as possible after testing our live PHP and SQL transit-schedule database—and two-fifteen that afternoon.

At eleven o’clock on the telephone, we were two twenty-two-year-old software developers with accredited associate degrees from CCHR and clean, normalized SQL code. At two o’clock, when the elevator doors opened and Katie and I rolled into the reception lobby side by side in two motorized power wheelchairs after riding CVTA Route 15 and Route 20 to the office park, we watched the lead developer’s smile freeze on his face before he hurriedly called the human-resources director into the room.

It was our sixth traditional job interview across Virginia Beach and Norfolk since returning from our birthday week in Alexandria and finishing the final PHP and SQL modules with Tina, Sheila, and Jim in May.

We had done everything the traditional employment playbook told young adults to do. We had filled out the multi-page paper and online applications. We had brought our framed Associate of Applied Science degrees from the Community College of Hampton Roads—never once regretting that we had rolled out of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center after twelve days without an RRC certificate, because we knew an RRC piece of paper meant nothing in the real world next to an accredited college degree and live production code.

And in all six interviews, the exact same script had played out almost word for word.

No employer in 2007 was foolish enough to say out loud that they didn't want to hire two twenty-two-year-old twins in power wheelchairs who commuted by public bus. Every human-resources manager in Hampton Roads had been trained by corporate counsel on how to avoid running afoul of the Americans with Disabilities Act and Virginia's disability rights statutes. Their language was always impeccably polite, rehearsed, and legally bulletproof: *not quite the right skill match*, *looking for a different blend of experience*, *decided to go in another direction*.

Yet when a company posts an entry-level job asking for HTML, CSS, PHP, and SQL, raves about your live PHP database over the phone, and suddenly discovers ten minutes after seeing your wheelchairs that you "aren't the right skill match" while leaving the exact same job posting up on their website three weeks later, you don't have to be a lawyer to read between the lines.

"Thank you for your time this afternoon," Katie said politely, closing her leather portfolio binder and resting it across her lap as we turned our wheelchairs around, rolled out to the elevator, and headed back down to the bus stop on Virginia Beach Boulevard.

4:00 PM — Putting Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC to Work From Our Dual Desks on Arvin Road

When we rolled back up our aluminum porch ramp on Arvin Road at four o'clock, poured two tall glasses of cold ginger ale in the kitchen, and wheeled side by side into our twelve-by-twelve office bedroom, neither of us was defeated. If anything, watching six corporate HR departments hide behind polite boilerplate had burned away the last shred of doubt about what we needed to do.

"You know what the funniest part of that interview was, Nate?" Katie asked, parking her SwiftChair flush beside mine under our twelve-foot span of worktables and tapping the framed Virginia State Corporation Commission certificate hanging on the wall above our monitors—*PRAIRIE TWIN INTERACTIVE, LLC*. "That agency's own corporate website is still running broken table layouts from 1999 that don't even validate in a modern browser, and their contact form throws an unescaped SQL error if you type an apostrophe into your last name."

I burst out laughing, the tension of the afternoon evaporating in an instant. "And they told us we didn't have the right skill match!"

"We don't need a corporate HR department to give us permission to write code and earn our own spending money," Katie said firmly, her fingers lacing through mine across our wheelchair armrests. "We already have our associate degrees from CCHR. We already have two six-foot desks, high-speed internet, and our own Linux server right here in this room. And thanks to Dad and Mr. Vance, we already have Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC registered with the state and our Suite 214 commercial mailbox at The Parcel Center so we can sign client contracts and cash business checks without ever putting Arvin Road on an invoice."

"And when a small business owner in Virginia Beach, Norfolk, or Chesapeake hires Prairie Twin Interactive over email and phone to build their PHP website or normalize their inventory database," I grinned, opening a fresh directory on our

server to build our commercial portfolio site, “the code doesn’t care that the two developers writing it are sitting side by side in power wheelchairs—or that we take our lunch breaks together in our own kitchen and sleep every night in our bedroom closet.”

By the end of July, we had landed our first three paid web-development contracts—building a custom PHP parts-catalog database for an independent marine-supply shop in Norfolk, redesigning the schedule and registration portal for a Tidewater community music school, and coding an automated invoice tracker for a regional printing company.

The Friday afternoon in August when we rolled into The Parcel Center, unlocked Box 214 with our brass key, and pulled out our very first three client checks made payable to *Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC*, Katie held the envelopes up in the sunlight with tears of pride shining in her blue eyes.

Dad was still faithfully covering every household bill on Arvin Road from Alexandria, just as he had promised. Now, however, as we deposited our own self-earned software revenue into our business and joint accounts, bought our own thirty-day CVTA bus passes, upgraded our video camera gear, and spent every evening analyzing regional transit budgets side by side at our dual desks, we weren’t just surviving anymore.

We were twenty-two-year-old business partners, unofficial homeowners, and best friends—and as 2007 turned toward the 2008 municipal election year across Hampton Roads, we were ready to take on City Hall.

Do Better: Ideas for CVTA & The Kempsville City Council

Do Better: Ideas for CVTA & The Four-Bus Mayoral Loop

Part 1: Does the Bus Run? Calling Out CVTA’s Complacency & The 2008 Regional Mayoral Challenge

Date: 2008-04-14 at 13:30 America/New_York

Thursday, April 14, 2008, 1:30 PM — The Binders at Eighteenth Street & The “Good Enough” Mentality

“Look at the open three-ring binder on the corner of the staff table, Nate,” Katie whispered, leaning slightly across her SwiftChair armrest toward mine as we parked our wheelchairs at the end of the front visitor row inside the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority boardroom on Eighteenth Street in Norfolk. “That’s our Tuesday post. They printed the whole thing out and highlighted the timetable chart in yellow.”

I followed my sister’s gaze across the polished laminate table where CVTA’s senior operations staff and the appointed city council commissioners from around Hampton Roads were shuffling their agenda packets before the monthly Transportation District Commission meeting gaveled in.

Sure enough, clipped inside the deputy planning director’s black binder—and photocopied into three separate packets along the commissioners’ dais—were six pages printed directly from Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, complete with the coastal-navy header and the custom PHP route-comparison tables I had coded the week before at our dual desks in the brick ranch on Arvin Road off Indian River Road and Military Highway in Virginia Beach.

“Every weekday morning between eight and ten o’clock, our server logs show static IP blocks from this building and all six City Halls reading our PHP tables,” I whispered back to Katie, glancing down the row of commissioners. “They read every word we write, Katie. They just don’t know what to do with two twenty-two-year-old twins in power wheelchairs who won’t pat them on the back for the status quo.”

When the commission chair called the brief public-comment period at the start of the one-thirty afternoon meeting—scheduled, as always, in the middle of a Thursday workday when almost no working commuter could attend—Katie released her joystick brake and rolled smoothly up to the low microphone table at the front of the room, with me rolling right up beside her holding our printed schedule audit.

“Mr. Chairman, commissioners, and CVTA staff,” Katie said clearly, her voice steady and polite as every head along the horseshoe dais turned toward our two wheelchairs. “My brother Nathaniel and I are the authors of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit. We ride CVTA buses in our power wheelchairs every week across Virginia Beach, Norfolk, Chesapeake, and the Peninsula, and we pay our regular thirty-day pass fares just like thousands of other citizens who depend on this network.”

Down at the staff table, the senior service planner and the communications director exchanged an immediate, tight-lipped glance, recognizing our names at once.

“Over the past two years,” Katie continued, resting her hand on the timetable charts across my lap, “we have documented why riders across Hampton Roads are being left behind—not because our region lacks the roads or the riders, but because this agency and our six member cities have settled for schedules that lock working people out. Look at your own printed Route 1 schedule between Downtown Norfolk and Pembroke East: on the Norfolk side of the line, from Downtown Norfolk through Wards Corner and Ocean View to the Amphibious Base, Route 1 runs every fifteen to thirty minutes and runs late into the night until 2:15 AM, seven days a week. The exact moment Route 1 crosses the city line into Virginia Beach toward Pleasure House Road, Haygood, and Pembroke East, most of the buses turn around at the border, service drops to once an hour, only runs during the day with the last bus leaving Pembroke East at 6:22 PM, and has no Sunday service at all. On Route 25 from Glenrock Mall to the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus, buses run every thirty minutes to Newtown Road at the city line, where half of them turn right back around into Norfolk, leaving the Virginia Beach side down Princess Anne Road to CCHR with hourly daytime-only service that ends at 5:53 PM. At the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus hub, the last Route 12 bus back toward Military Highway and Indian River Road leaves at 5:48 PM. If a citizen rides Route 33 to the Virginia Beach Municipal Center to attend a 6:00 PM City Council meeting and needs to catch Route 12,

Route 25, or Route 29 at CCHR to get home, they have to leave City Hall at 5:33 PM—twenty-seven minutes before the council meeting even starts. Across the water, the last southbound Route 61 across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel still leaves Newport News Transit Center at 6:45 PM, and riders transferring on multi-bus routes are still getting penalized with a second fare because the two-hour paper transfer expires while they wait for sixty-minute local buses."

"We aren't here to bash public transit," I added from my chair beside Katie. "We love public transit. We need public transit to live our lives. We're here because CVTA can be so much better than this—with timed evening transfer pulses at CCHR, Glenrock Mall, and Hilltop, service running until at least ten or eleven o'clock at night, clean transit center restrooms, and a modern smart-card fare system that doesn't punish two-bus commuters—if the leaders on this commission have the political willpower to fund and demand it."

The commission chair offered a polite, practiced nod as the three-minute timer beeped. "Thank you both for your comments. Staff will take your blog submissions under advisement."

Twenty minutes later, when the board recessed into the hallway outside the Eighteenth Street conference room, CVTA's senior service planner and one of the veteran municipal council commissioners walked past our wheelchairs near the water fountain. Stopping beside us with a folder tucked under his arm, the planner offered the tired, defensive half-smile of a bureaucrat who had spent fifteen years guarding an unchallenged routine.

"Look, Katie, Nate," the planner said, lowering his voice as the commissioner nodded beside him, "we read your blog every week. You two obviously put a lot of math into those PHP charts of yours. But you have to be realistic about how transit works in a region like Hampton Roads."

"Realistic about what?" Katie asked, looking straight up at him from her SwiftChair.

The commissioner shrugged his shoulders, palms turned upward in the exact gesture that summed up thirty years of regional transit policy.

"Does the bus run?" the commissioner asked rhetorically. "Yes, the bus runs. Every morning the garages roll the fleet out across all six cities. Do people get to CCHR and the malls and the shipyards during the day? Yes. Is it good enough for what our city councils budget every spring? I guess so. Nobody at City Hall is clamoring to spend millions more running buses late into the night or overhauling transfer rules when the buses are already out there running their routes."

Katie and I looked at each other as the planner and the commissioner patted the folder and walked back into the boardroom.

There it was, spoken right out loud in the hallway of Eighteenth Street: the entire institutional philosophy of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority.

Does the bus run? Yes. Is it good enough? I guess so.

For decades, CVTA and the politicians who funded it had hidden behind that exact complacency. As long as a diesel bus rolled past a stop sign once an hour during banker's hours and the annual federal grant paperwork got signed, the agency and the six city councils treated the box as checked. Until Ideas for Coastal Virginia

Transit came along, nobody with the technical skills to dissect their Transportation Service Plans—and the daily lived reality of riding those buses in power wheelchairs—had ever stood up in public and told them to *do better*.

As we rolled our wheelchairs out the automatic glass doors of the Eighteenth Street headquarters toward the Granby Street bus stop to catch our ride home, Katie's jaw was set with quiet fire.

"Did you hear what that commissioner said, Nate?" Katie asked as we waited on the concrete sidewalk pad. "'Nobody at City Hall is clamoring to spend money or overhaul the routes because it's good enough.' He just admitted the truth. The problem isn't that CVTA can't be improved. Every single improvement we've written about on the blog is completely doable. The only thing missing is the political willpower from the mayors and city councils who control CVTA's purse strings and sit on that board."

"And half of those city halls are up for election this year," I said, the realization clicking into place as the low-floor CVTA bus pulled up to the curb and kneeled its front suspension.

"Every single one of them has elections in 2008," Katie said as the hydraulic ramp folded down onto the concrete and we rolled up into the front wheelchair securement bays. "And as soon as we get home to Kempsville, we are going to put their political willpower to the test in front of every voter in Hampton Roads."

Mapping the 2008 Regional Mayoral Elections & Issuing the Open Challenge

Back at our dual computer desks in the spare bedroom office of our new Kempsville house that evening, Katie and I pulled up the official 2008 Virginia State Board of Elections candidate filings across all six member cities of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority: Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Norfolk, Hampton, and Newport News.

Sipping cold ginger ale from our glasses while my PHP editor and our browser tabs glowed side by side across our monitors, we mapped out the exact 2008 municipal calendar across the six cities.

"Look at how the 2008 mayoral calendar breaks down across the six CVTA cities," I said, pointing to the state election schedule on my screen. "Out of the six cities—Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Norfolk, Hampton, and Newport News—four of them are holding direct elections for Mayor here in 2008, while the other two are mid-term on their mayoral cycle."

Katie rolled her chair closer and read down the certified candidate lists with me.

"Norfolk and Newport News both elected their mayors to four-year terms back in May 2006, so neither Norfolk nor Newport News has a Mayor's race until May 2010—though both cities have City Council seats on the ballot next month on Tuesday, May 6, 2008," Katie noted. "Then, on that same Tuesday, May 6, 2008 spring municipal ballot, three CVTA cities are electing their Mayors: Chesapeake has an open-seat Mayor's race, Portsmouth has a contested Mayor's race, and Hampton has an open-seat Mayor's race across the water."

“And then our own city—Virginia Beach—moved its municipal elections to the fall general election ballot on Tuesday, November 4, 2008,” I said, scrolling down to the Virginia Beach filings. “And look at the Virginia Beach Mayor’s race: Mayor Myra Overton is running for another term after twenty years as Mayor, and she’s facing three challengers in a four-way race for Mayor of Virginia Beach, right alongside the at-large and district City Council races.”

Katie looked at Mayor Myra E. Overton’s name on the screen and shook her head thoughtfully.

Every lifelong resident of Virginia Beach knew the paradox of Mayor Myra Overton. On a personal level, she was a genuinely sweet, gracious, grandmotherly lady who had gotten her start in civic and political life serving on the city’s public library board and had championed the Central Library on Virginia Beach Boulevard for decades. If you met her at a ribbon-cutting or a neighborhood library reading, she couldn’t have been nicer.

As a municipal politician overseeing transportation for the largest city in Virginia, however, her twenty-year tenure had been a disaster for anyone who rode a bus. Among daily CVTA riders, bus operators, and local political watchers, there was a famous story that had circulated for years to explain why Virginia Beach’s bus service hours were so abysmal compared to Norfolk’s. There was no way to confirm she had ever actually said the words out loud, of course, but as the local legend went, if Mayor Overton had her way, the Route 20 bus on Virginia Beach Boulevard would depart Downtown Norfolk, roll east down the Boulevard to Newtown Road at the city line, and turn right back around and stay in Norfolk—to keep the riff-raff out, of course.

Whether that story was literal truth or courthouse folklore, one glance at the printed Route 1 and Route 25 timetables—where frequent, late-night Norfolk buses hit the Virginia Beach border and suddenly shriveled into once-an-hour daytime-only runs that vanished after dinnertime—made it painfully obvious why everyone in Hampton Roads believed it.

Katie leaned forward, resting her forearms on the desk.

“Four mayoral elections across Hampton Roads in 2008—Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton in May, and Virginia Beach in November—plus City Council races in all six CVTA cities,” Katie said. “Every single one of those candidates puts glossy photos on their campaign flyers claiming they care about regional transportation, traffic relief, working families, and citizens with disabilities. Let’s see how many of them are actually willing to step out from behind a podium and ride the bus with the two of us.”

Opening the PHP administrative dashboard for Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, Katie and I drafted our landmark open letter together, carefully checking every word before publishing it to the top of the front page and sending personalized copies directly to the official campaign email addresses of every certified candidate for Mayor in Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton—as well as the City Council candidates across all six CVTA cities:

> Thursday, April 14, 2008 — An Open Invitation to the 2008 Mayoral & City Council Candidates of Hampton Roads: Come Ride the Bus With Us
>
> Whenever we speak with staff and commissioners at the Coastal Virginia

> Transit Authority about late-evening bus curfews, ninety-minute routes, expired two-hour paper transfers, and missing sidewalk curb cuts, we hear the same unspoken excuse: Does the bus run? Yes. Is it good enough? I guess so.
>
> For the thousands of citizens across Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Norfolk, Hampton, and Newport News who rely on CVTA buses every single day to get to college, to work, to medical appointments, and to civic meetings —including wheelchair riders like the two of us—"good enough" is not good enough. CVTA can be improved into a first-class regional transit network, and the only ingredient missing is the political willpower of the elected mayors and city councils who fund and govern it.
>
> This year, voters in four of our six CVTA cities—Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton on May 6, and Virginia Beach on November 4—will elect their next Mayor, while voters across all six cities will elect members of their City Councils. Therefore, Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit is issuing a simple, non-partisan public invitation to every candidate for Mayor in Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton, and every candidate for City Council across the region:
>
> Meet the two of us at a CVTA transit hub, leave your campaign car in the parking lot, pay the regular bus fare alongside us, and ride a real multi-bus loop on CVTA with two daily wheelchair riders. No staged press vans, no special charter buses, and no shortcuts—just the real schedules, the real transfers, and an honest conversation on camera about how we can give Hampton Roads the transit system our citizens deserve.

When I clicked Publish and dispatched the invitation emails across all four mayoral races and six cities, the comment section on Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit lit up within twenty minutes. Daily bus commuters from Ocean View to Kempsville, CCHR students, shipyard workers in Newport News and Portsmouth, and even readers who had followed us over from the Seattle Transit Blog cheered the challenge on and began forwarding the link to local newspaper reporters and campaign managers.

Then we waited to see which politicians actually had the courage to show up.

Silence Across the Region — And the One Candidate Who Said Yes

Days turned into weeks as the May 6, 2008 municipal elections in Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, Norfolk, and Newport News approached and passed.

Every morning, Katie and I sat side by side at our desks in Kempsville with our hot chocolate or cold ginger ale, checking our campaign inbox and phone messages.

From the mayoral campaigns in Chesapeake: silence. From the mayoral campaigns in Portsmouth: silence. From the mayoral campaigns in Hampton: a single three-sentence form email from a campaign aide thanking us for our "interest in regional infrastructure" and stating that the candidate's schedule did not permit a multi-hour

bus ride, followed by silence. From the incumbent City Council members and establishment candidates across Norfolk, Newport News, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, and Virginia Beach: not a single acceptance.

Even here in Virginia Beach, as the four-way November 2008 Mayor's race heated up through the summer, the twenty-year incumbent mayor's campaign ignored our invitation completely. The wealthy banking-executive frontrunner backed by the courthouse establishment didn't reply. The veteran budget-hawk former councilman didn't accept either. And every single incumbent and establishment candidate running for the Virginia Beach City Council pretended our email didn't exist.

"They really don't care, do they, Nate?" Katie said quietly one warm afternoon at our desks, staring at the spreadsheet on my monitor where almost every single row across Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, Norfolk, Newport News, and Virginia Beach still read *No Response*. "They want the title of Mayor or City Council member, and they want to sit on regional boards and cut ribbons on highway interchanges, but not one of them is willing to spend two and a half hours riding the bus system they fund."

Just as I reached for the mouse to update our public tracker post on the blog, my email client chimed with a new incoming message.

I blinked at the sender line on the screen, then clicked it open.

"Katie," I said, sitting forward in my SwiftChair. "Look at the inbox. Someone just replied."

Katie rolled her chair right up against mine and leaned in toward the monitor.

The email wasn't from a campaign press secretary or an automated mailing list. It came directly from the fourth candidate on the ballot for Mayor of the City of Virginia Beach—Scott Tanner, a young, thirty-something political-outsider Navy veteran who wasn't part of the entrenched City Hall establishment and didn't have the backing of the big beachfront real-estate donors.

His message was four sentences long:

> From: Scott Tanner for Mayor Campaign
> To: Katie & Nate — Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit
> Subject: Re: Open Invitation to 2008 Mayoral Candidates — Come Ride the Bus With Us
>
> Katie and Nate,
> I read your blog post and your route analyses, and you're right—nobody asking to lead the largest city in Virginia should be afraid to ride the bus system our citizens depend on every day. I accept your challenge. Tell me which transit hub in Virginia Beach to meet you at, what time to be there, and which buses we're riding, and I'll leave my car in the lot and ride the whole loop with the two of you.
> — Scott

Katie stared at the screen for three seconds, and then a slow, fierce grin broke across her face as she reached over and gripped my hand.

“Out of every mayoral candidate in Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, and Virginia Beach—and every City Council candidate across all six cities—only one person had the guts to say yes,” Katie said, her blue eyes shining with determination as she pulled the folded CVTA Virginia Beach route map across our desk. “And he’s running for Mayor right here in Virginia Beach. Come on, Nate—get your video camera batteries on the charger. We’re going to meet him at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus loop, and we’re going to take him on the exact four-bus circuit across Virginia Beach and Norfolk: Route 29 to Hilltop, Route 20 to Glenrock Mall, Route 15 down Military Highway, and Route 12 right back to CCHR.”

Part 2: The Four-Bus Mayoral Loop, Silenced at Eighteenth Street, & Choosing to Run for the Kempsville Seat

Date: 2008-09-16 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, September 16, 2008, 2:00 PM — Four Buses Across Two Cities & The Expired Two-Hour Transfer

“Right on time,” twenty-three-year-old Katie said, nodding toward the concrete island at the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus transit hub as mayoral candidate Scott Tanner locked his sedan in the student visitor lot and walked over to our two compact SwiftChairs with a notebook tucked under his arm.

“Katie, Nate—good to meet you both in person,” Scott said, shaking Katie’s hand and then mine while I checked the microphone levels on the compact digital camcorder mounted to my wheelchair lap tray. “I brought crisp single-dollar bills and quarters just like your email said. Where does our loop start?”

“Right here on Route 29 northbound to Hilltop,” Katie said, pointing up at the approaching forty-foot low-floor bus pulling into the CCHR bus loop. “We’re going to ride a single continuous four-bus circuit across Virginia Beach and Norfolk and bring you right back to your car at this exact bus stop: Route 29 from CCHR up to Hilltop, Route 20 westbound down Virginia Beach Boulevard into Norfolk to Glenrock Mall, Route 15 southbound down Military Highway back across the city line into Virginia Beach, and Route 12 back here to CCHR.”

When the front ramp of the Route 29 bus folded down onto the concrete pad, Katie and I rolled aboard into the dual front wheelchair securement bays and swiped our thirty-day CVTA magnetic passes through the farebox. Right behind us, Scott stepped up into the vestibule, fed his base fare plus the paper transfer fee into the bill validator, and took the timestamped paper transfer slip the driver tore off the cutter bar.

“Keep an eye on the punched time at the top of that paper transfer,” I told Scott as I framed the timestamped slip in my camcorder viewfinder while the bus pulled out of CCHR onto Princess Anne Road. “It’s good for exactly two hours.”

Because Virginia Beach’s local routes ran on forty-five- to sixty-minute headways without synchronized transfer pulses, the math of the two-hour paper transfer trap unfolded right in front of my camera lens in real time.

Our first leg on Route 29 carried us northeast up First Colonial Road to the Hilltop transfer stop, where we waited twenty-five minutes on an unsheltered concrete sidewalk pad in the September sun before boarding a westbound Route 20 bus down Virginia Beach Boulevard.

Halfway down the Boulevard past Little Neck and Newtown Road, an older Hispanic gentleman carrying a canvas tool bag boarded the bus and asked the operator a confused question in Spanish about which stop connected to the Military Highway corridor. Before the operator could shake his head, Scott leaned across the aisle and answered the rider fluently in Spanish—explaining the exact stop at Glenrock Mall where they could both transfer to Route 15.

“You speak Spanish?” Katie asked with genuine respect when the rider thanked Scott warmly and sat down two rows behind our wheelchairs.

“Picked it up during my Navy deployments to South America,” Scott said simply. “Half the folks riding Route 20 work in the hospitality kitchens at the Oceanfront or the construction yards along the Boulevard. A mayor ought to be able to talk to the people who keep the city running.”

When Route 20 dropped us off at the Glenrock Mall transit hub in Norfolk, we waited another twenty-eight minutes for our third bus—a southbound Route 15 heading down Military Highway toward Virginia Beach.

By the time the Route 15 bus rolled south along Military Highway and crossed the low bridge over the Eastern Branch of the Elizabeth River from Norfolk back into Virginia Beach, it was four-fifteen in the afternoon. Holding my camcorder steady on my lap tray with the river glinting through the bus window behind Katie and Scott, I recorded the conversation that became the centerpiece of our video.

“We’re crossing back into Virginia Beach right now, Scott,” Katie said on camera, holding up the official printed CVTA timetables for Route 33 and Route 12. “Let’s talk about what happens if a taxpaying citizen of Virginia Beach who relies on the bus—like Nate and me, or a working parent, or a senior citizen—wants to attend a formal evening meeting of the Virginia Beach City Council down at the Municipal Center in Courthouse.”

“Formal City Council meetings gavel in at six o’clock in the evening,” Scott said, looking down at the printed schedule columns in Katie’s hand.

“Six o’clock in the evening,” Katie repeated clearly. “Now look at the Route 33 schedule serving the Virginia Beach Municipal Center. You can ride Route 33 down to City Hall in the afternoon just fine. If you live at the north end of the Oceanfront, the last northbound Route 33 all the way to Sixty-Eighth Street leaves the Municipal Center at 6:01 PM—one minute after the council meeting starts—and the 7:01 PM trip terminates early at Nineteenth Street. And if you live anywhere else in Virginia Beach and need to ride Route 33 from the Municipal Center back to the CCHR hub to catch your connecting bus home—like Route 12, Route 25, or Route 29—look at the departure times.”

Katie tapped her finger against the bottom row of the Route 33 and Route 12 timetables so my camera lens could capture the exact numbers.

“The very last Route 33 out of the Municipal Center to CCHR leaves at 6:33 PM, and by the time it reaches CCHR, every single connecting route except Route 36 has already shut down for the night,” Katie said. “Because Nate and I live in Kempsville and ride Route 12 home from CCHR toward Military Highway and Indian River Road, look at when the last Route 12 bus of the entire day departs CCHR: 5:48 PM. To catch that 5:48 PM Route 12 home from CCHR, we have to leave City Hall on the 5:33 PM Route 33 bus—twenty-seven minutes before the six o’clock City Council meeting even starts! Our last bus home literally pulls out of CCHR twelve minutes before the Mayor bangs the gavel.”

Scott stared at the two printed timetables in disbelief, looking up into my camera lens. “So if you ride the bus to a six o’clock Virginia Beach City Council meeting to speak during public comment, you’re stranded at City Hall with no way home.”

“Every single Tuesday night,” I said from behind the camera. “You cannot tell citizens that local government is open to the public when City Hall’s own bus schedule locks bus riders and wheelchair users out thirty minutes before the meeting begins.”

Twenty minutes later, when we rolled down the front ramp off Route 15 at Indian River Road and boarded our fourth and final bus—eastbound Route 12 back to CCHR to complete our circle—the final piece of CVTA’s broken math played out right on cue.

Katie and I rolled up the ramp and swiped our thirty-day passes. Behind us, Scott handed his paper transfer slip to the Route 12 operator.

The operator glanced at the punched holes along the top edge of the paper slip and shook his head.

“Sorry, sir—this transfer expired nineteen minutes ago,” the driver said, tapping the two-hour rule printed on the farebox. “That’ll be another full dollar-fifty fare to ride back to the college.”

Right on camera, Scott had to reach into his pocket and feed a second full fare into the box just to finish a single afternoon round-trip back to his parked car at CCHR—solely because waiting for hourly buses had eaten up more than two hours.

Thursday, November 19, 2009, 1:35 PM — Cut Off at the Eighteenth Street Microphone & Blackballed From TRAC

That night in September 2008, I edited our four-bus ride down into a crisp twelve-minute documentary video with full burned-in open captions and published it at the top of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit.

Within a week, the video had been watched more than forty thousand times across Hampton Roads and picked up by *The Tidewater Pilot* and every television station in Norfolk and Virginia Beach. In the November 2008 election, twenty-year incumbent Mayor Myra Overton was defeated, and although the wealthy banking-executive frontrunner edged out Scott Tanner in the four-way race, the public uproar over our video forced CVTA and City Hall to promise a “comprehensive review” of bus transfers and Virginia Beach evening service hours.

Fourteen months later, however, on a gray Thursday afternoon in November 2009 inside the CVTA boardroom on East Eighteenth Street in Norfolk, we learned exactly what CVTA's executive suite thought of that promise.

Katie and I had ridden three buses into Norfolk carrying a twenty-four-page PHP audit we had compiled over the autumn, documenting more than nine hundred missed transfer connections at Glenrock Mall and CCHR alongside a formal request for CVTA's raw General Transit Feed Specification schedule tables so riders could build real-time trip-planning tools. Just two weeks earlier, I had also submitted my formal application to fill one of Virginia Beach's vacant citizen seats on CVTA's Transit Riders Advisory Committee—known around the agency as TRAC.

Parked side by side in our SwiftChairs at the low public-comment table in the center of the boardroom, I was two minutes and forty seconds into reading our findings into the record while CVTA President and Chief Executive Officer Leonard Sterling and Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead sat slouched in their high-backed leather chairs along the raised executive tier.

"—and because the outbound Route 20 and southbound Route 15 schedules at Glenrock Mall are offset by four minutes in the master dispatch table without a hold-for-transfer rule," I said clearly into the gooseneck microphone, holding up our printed PHP chart, "evening commuters transferring back into Virginia Beach are missing the final southbound bus seven nights a week—"

BZZZZT.

Before I could finish the sentence, Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead reached forward and jabbed the master cutoff switch on the clerk's console. The red ring at the neck of my microphone went dead in the middle of my word.

"Your three minutes are expired, Mr. Prairie," CEO Leonard Sterling said flatly without looking up from his leather portfolio. "Next speaker."

"Mr. President, if staff would simply release the raw GTFS schedule files we requested under the Freedom of Information Act—" Katie spoke up from her SwiftChair beside me, her voice carrying across the quiet room even without the microphone.

"Public comment is not a question-and-answer session, Ms. Prairie," Sterling interrupted, waving a hand toward the rear doors. "The commission has a full agenda."

Fifteen minutes later, when the board recessed briefly before its closed executive session, Katie and I rolled our wheelchairs out into the tiled corridor near the drinking fountain to speak with Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead and the agency's government-affairs director as they walked toward the coffee credenza.

"Mr. Halstead," I said politely, holding out the bound copy of our twenty-four-page schedule audit and a thumb drive containing our PHP transfer-timing script, "we brought a clean copy of the Glenrock Mall and CCHR connection data for your scheduling department, and I wanted to check on the status of my application for the Virginia Beach citizen seat on the Transit Riders Advisory Committee."

Halstead stopped, looked down his nose at the thumb drive in my hand, and didn't even reach out to take it. A thin, patronizing smirk curled the corner of his mouth.

“Look, Nate, Katie,” Halstead said, lowering his voice just enough that the reporters inside the boardroom couldn’t hear him, “let’s save everybody some time. My scheduling engineers don’t take operational direction from statistically insignificant hobbyist bloggers, and we aren’t handing over internal GTFS database files so the two of you can play armchair transit director from your living room.”

Katie’s blue eyes narrowed. “We ride your buses every single day of the week in power wheelchairs, Mr. Halstead. There is nothing ‘hobbyist’ about needing a bus that actually connects before dark.”

“And as for the Transit Riders Advisory Committee,” Halstead added smoothly, adjusting his silk tie as he turned back toward the executive suite door, “staff already forwarded our recommendations for the Virginia Beach TRAC vacancies this morning. Your name wasn’t on the list, Nate. TRAC is reserved for constructive community stakeholders—not blog agitators with a laptop.”

The heavy oak door of the executive suite clicked shut behind him.

For ten seconds, Katie and I sat side by side in the quiet hallway on East Eighteenth Street, staring at that closed oak door. They had cut off my microphone at a hundred and eighty seconds, laughed at our engineering work, locked up public schedule data paid for by the taxpayers, and secretly blackballed me from a volunteer citizen advisory committee because we had dared to prove on camera that their schedules were broken.

And the final insult came four months later, in the spring of 2010, when the eleven-member Virginia Beach City Council met down at the Municipal Center to vote on the city’s annual transit contribution. Rather than holding CVTA accountable or funding the evening connecting pulse we had proposed, ten-year Kempsville District incumbent Councilman Harold Dietz led the budget motion to strip out every dime of proposed late-evening bus funding—muttering into his dais microphone at the Tuesday afternoon work session that *“almost nobody rides the bus out of Courthouse after dark anyway.”*

Sitting side by side at our dual coding desks in our house off Military Highway and Indian River Road in Kempsville that evening watching the archived City Hall webcast over cold glasses of ginger ale, Katie reached forward and clicked Pause on the video player.

“Of course nobody rides the bus out of Courthouse after dark, Councilman Dietz,” Katie said to the monitor, her voice calm and razor-sharp. “There isn’t a bus out of Courthouse after 6:33 PM! That’s like taking the ramp off a building and claiming nobody in a wheelchair ever comes inside.”

Katie turned her SwiftChair toward me, her blue eyes steady and bright.

“Leonard Sterling and Richard Halstead think they can cut off your microphone at Eighteenth Street and blackball you from TRAC because we’re just two twenty-five-year-old bloggers in wheelchairs with no vote on their budget,” Katie said. “And Harold Dietz thinks he owns the Kempsville seat on the Virginia Beach City Council for life. Well, Harold Dietz’s seat is on the ballot this November, Nate. City Council elections in Virginia are non-partisan, and we live right here in our house in Kempsville. What do you say we stop asking Richard Halstead and Councilman Dietz for permission—and go take his seat on the City Council?”

“Let’s do it,” I said immediately, already opening a fresh PHP project directory on my MagnaBook Pro. “If they won’t let us sit at the public-comment table for three minutes, we’ll put you up on the dais where they have to answer to you.”

The Empty Podium on WHRC TV-15, The 94.1% Landslide, & Councilwoman Prairie

Part 1: The Empty Podium on WHRC TV-15, The 8:24 PM Three-Bus Sprint Home, & The Front-Page Metro Headline

Date: 2010-10-14 at 19:28 America/New_York

Thursday, October 14, 2010, 7:28 PM — The Empty Mahogany Podium Under the WHRC Studio Lights

“Two minutes to air, Ms. Prairie,” the WHRC TV-15 floor director called out quietly, holding up two fingers beside the center studio camera inside the public-television broadcast center on Hampton Boulevard in Norfolk. “Still no sign of Councilman Dietz or his campaign manager at the front desk, so per station rules, his podium stays lit and his microphone stays open.”

Parked in my compact SwiftChair just outside the edge of the key lights next to the producer’s monitor cart, I glanced across the blue-curtained television set toward my twenty-five-year-old twin sister.

Katie sat upright and composed in her black SwiftChair behind a low, wheelchair-accessible mahogany desk that the WHRC studio crew had set up on the left side of the stage, wearing a crisp royal-blue blazer over a cream blouse with a small brass lapel microphone clipped to her collar. Six feet to her right stood the second debate position: a tall, traditional standing mahogany podium bearing a white placard that read *COUNCILMAN HAROLD DIETZ — KEMPSVILLE DISTRICT*, bathed in a bright, unforgiving pool of overhead tungsten light and completely empty.

For five months, Katie and I had poured every ounce of our energy into the non-partisan Kempsville District race. We hadn’t hired a political consultant, we hadn’t taken a single check from Oceanfront hotel developers, and we hadn’t hosted cocktail receptions. Instead, I had built a custom PHP precinct-mapping and sidewalk-canvassing engine on our home server off Military Highway and Indian River Road in Kempsville, and we had spent the spring, summer, and early autumn campaigning directly from the front wheelchair securement bays of CVTA Routes 12, 15, 20, 25, and 29 and rolling down the neighborhood sidewalks of Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur with Dad driving down from Alexandria every weekend to knock on front doors that had brick steps.

Through it all, ten-year incumbent Councilman Harold Dietz had treated our campaign as if we were invisible. When Coastal Virginia Public Media had sent out the formal certified invitations in September for tonight’s live forty-five-minute Kempsville City Council debate on WHRC TV-15—broadcast right from the edge of the Virginia Dominion University campus across all of Hampton Roads—Katie had returned her signed confirmation within twenty minutes. Councilman Dietz hadn’t even bothered to reply. Because he had neither accepted nor formally

declined the invitation, WHRC's strict non-partisan broadcast rules required the studio to leave his standing podium on the stage and give the viewing public an unfiltered look at who had bothered to show up for the job.

"Ten seconds," the floor director whispered, lowering his arm toward the center camera lens. "Five, four, three…"

The red tally light atop Camera One glowed bright in the darkened studio.

"Good evening, and welcome to Coastal Virginia Public Media's live 2010 Decision coverage from our WHRC TV-15 studios on Hampton Boulevard in Norfolk," the veteran public-television moderator began in his resonant baritone. "Tonight we examine the race for the Kempsville District seat on the Virginia Beach City Council. Seated to my left is challenger Katie Prairie, a twenty-five-year-old Kempsville homeowner, software developer, and co-founder of the regional transit watchdog website Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit. To her right, as viewers at home can see, is the podium reserved for ten-year incumbent Councilman Harold Dietz. Although WHRC extended multiple invitations to Councilman Dietz's office over the past six weeks, our producers received neither an acceptance nor a decline, and his podium remains open should he arrive during tonight's broadcast. Because our non-profit public media rules require us to pose every scheduled municipal policy question to the stage, we will proceed with our full forty-five-minute forum. Ms. Prairie, the first question is yours."

Watching from beside the monitor cart with my MagnaBook Pro resting on my wheelchair lap tray, I felt a quiet surge of pride as the director punched up the wide two-shot on the studio monitors.

Every time the moderator asked a question about Kempsville stormwater drainage along Indian River Road, aging neighborhood sidewalks around Morrison Middle School and Northwood High School, small-business permitting, municipal transparency, or the city's annual transportation budget, the studio camera framed the stark visual contrast across every living room in Virginia Beach and Norfolk: on the left, a poised, razor-sharp twenty-five-year-old woman in a power wheelchair citing exact line items from the City of Virginia Beach's eight-hundred-page operating budget from memory without a single paper note on her desk; on the right, six feet of empty blue carpet and a vacant mahogany lectern where the ten-year incumbent hadn't cared enough to stand.

"Ms. Prairie, let's turn to regional transportation and your proposal for an Evening Civic Access Transit Pulse," the moderator said at the eight-minute mark before the end of the broadcast. "Critics on the current City Council have argued that extending CVTA bus service out of the Virginia Beach Municipal Center and the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus past six-thirty in the evening is an unnecessary taxpayer expense because ridership after dark is low. How do you respond?"

Katie looked straight into the glowing red camera lens.

"Saying nobody rides the bus out of the Virginia Beach Municipal Center after six-thirty at night when the last bus leaves at 6:33 PM is like taking the wheelchair ramp off City Hall and claiming nobody in a wheelchair ever comes inside," Katie said, her voice warm, clear, and unhurried. "Formal evening meetings of the Virginia Beach City Council gavel in at six o'clock. Yet if a working parent, a senior citizen, a college student, or a wheelchair user in Kempsville rides Route 33 down to City Hall and needs to connect to Route 12, Route 25, or Route 29 at the CCHR hub to

get home, the very last Route 12 bus of the day leaves CCHR at 5:48 PM—meaning a citizen has to leave City Hall at 5:33 PM, twenty-seven minutes before the Council meeting even begins. For the cost of less than one-tenth of one percent of our city budget, we can run an evening bus pulse until ten-thirty at night so working people and citizens with disabilities are never locked out of their own local government again."

At 8:14 PM on the dot, the moderator thanked Katie, signed off to the viewers across Hampton Roads, and the red tally lights on the studio cameras clicked off.

And that was when the real moment of the campaign began.

Thursday, October 14, 2010, 8:14 PM — Crossing Six Lanes of Hampton Boulevard With Reporter Greg Mercer to Catch the 8:24 PM Route 2

The instant the studio floor director called *"We're clear!"* at 8:14 PM, Katie didn't linger on the stage to bask in the applause of the camera crew.

While the audio technician unclipped the brass lapel mic from her blazer, Katie glanced down at her wristwatch, released her joystick brake, and rolled swiftly down the studio ramp toward my wheelchair as I closed my MagnaBook Pro and slipped it into my padded canvas backpack.

"Eight-fourteen, Nate," Katie said quietly as our two SwiftChairs fell into formation heading for the heavy soundproof doors of Studio A. "We have ten minutes to make the crosswalk."

Out in the bright fluorescent lobby of the WHRC broadcast center, *Tidewater Pilot* Metro politics reporter Greg Mercer—a veteran city-hall journalist in a rumpled trench coat with a spiral reporter's notebook in one hand and a digital voice recorder in the other—stepped away from the reception counter and hurried straight toward us.

"Ms. Prairie! Katie!" Greg Mercer called out, clicking the record button on his handheld recorder. "Greg Mercer with *The Tidewater Pilot*. That empty podium on live television was something else. Do you have ten minutes to sit down here in the lobby and give me a quick post-debate interview for tomorrow morning's Metro section?"

Katie glanced at the round wall clock above the WHRC glass entrance doors—8:15 PM—and looked back up at Greg with a friendly, earnest smile.

"I'd be happy to answer every question you have, Mr. Mercer," Katie said as I hit the big silver ADA push-plate to swing the front lobby doors open into the crisp October night air, "as long as you don't mind walking fast across Hampton Boulevard with us right now."

Greg blinked in surprise, tucking his pen behind his ear as he stepped out onto the concrete sidewalk beside our two powerchairs. "Across Hampton Boulevard? Sure—did your campaign staff have to park your wheelchair van over in the university lot across the street?"

Katie and I exchanged a quick twin look as we set our SwiftChair speed dials to four miles per hour and rolled briskly down the WHRC front walk toward the signalized intersection at Forty-Ninth Street and Hampton Boulevard.

“We don’t have campaign staff, Mr. Mercer,” I said as Katie pressed the pedestrian crosswalk button at the curb, “and we don’t own a wheelchair van.”

Greg Mercer looked down at our two compact powerchairs, genuinely puzzled as six lanes of heavy port and university traffic rumbled past under the amber streetlights of Hampton Boulevard.

Wait—if the two of us didn’t have a fifty-thousand-dollar wheelchair-lift van waiting in the lot, and our dad David wasn’t down from Alexandria on a Thursday night, how on earth were two twenty-five-year-old twins in power wheelchairs getting all the way from the West Side of Norfolk back to Kempsville in Virginia Beach at eight-fifteen at night?

The white *WALK* silhouette flashed on across the six-lane boulevard.

“Come on, Mr. Mercer—this light only gives twenty-two seconds,” Katie said cheerfully.

Jogging two steps to keep pace with our electric motors as we rolled straight across all six lanes of Hampton Boulevard to the opposite sidewalk, Greg held his digital recorder out toward Katie. “Wait a second—where are we going if your car isn’t over here?”

Reaching the far curb cut on the southbound side of Hampton Boulevard, Katie and I braked our SwiftChairs side by side right beneath a blue-and-white metal sign bolted to a utility pole:

CVTA BUS STOP — ROUTE 2 (HAMPTON BLVD / DOWNTOWN NORFOLK).

Greg Mercer stopped dead in his tracks on the concrete sidewalk, his mouth slightly open as he looked up at the metal bus stop sign, then down at our two power wheelchairs, and then back up Hampton Boulevard where the twin headlights of an approaching forty-foot low-floor CVTA gill-window transit bus were cresting the rise three blocks north.

“You’re taking the city bus?” Greg asked, staring at us in disbelief. “From a live television debate on Hampton Boulevard back to Virginia Beach—at eight-twenty at night?”

“Not just one city bus, Mr. Mercer—three of them,” I said, checking the glowing digital readout on my watch: 8:22 PM. “And that’s why we couldn’t stay in the WHRC lobby for ten minutes.”

“Walk me through this before that bus gets here,” Greg said rapidly, holding his voice recorder right between Katie’s chair and mine while his other hand scribbled furiously across his spiral pad under the streetlight. “What happens if you miss that bus coming down the street right now?”

“Look at the timetable math,” Katie said calmly, pointing up Hampton Boulevard as the southbound CVTA Route 2 bus signaled toward the curb with its amber destination sign glowing *2 DOWNTOWN NORFOLK*. “The WHRC debate ended at 8:14 PM. This bus pulling up right now is the 8:24 PM Route 2 southbound. We

have to catch this exact 8:24 PM bus down Hampton Boulevard to the Downtown Norfolk Transit Center, which gets us into Downtown Norfolk just before nine o'clock."

With a loud hiss of compressed air, the forty-foot Route 2 bus braked at the curb beside us and kneeled its front suspension. The folding glass doors swung open, and the warning chime beeped as the steel hydraulic wheelchair ramp unfolded onto the sidewalk concrete.

"Once we get to Downtown Norfolk Transit Center just before nine," I continued as I rolled backward up the steel ramp first to pull into the rear-facing curbside securement bay, "we have fifteen minutes to transfer onto the 9:15 PM Route 20 bus heading eastbound out Virginia Beach Boulevard."

"And that 9:15 PM Route 20 bus gets us out to the Glenrock Mall transit hub at 9:45 PM," Katie added, pausing at the bottom of the wheelchair ramp and looking back over her shoulder at Greg Mercer standing under the streetlight with his notebook and recorder. "At 9:45 PM at Glenrock Mall, Nate and I have to transfer onto the very last Route 15 bus of the night going south down Military Highway across the city line into Virginia Beach. If we had stayed in the WHRC lobby talking for ten minutes and missed this 8:24 PM bus right here on Hampton Boulevard, we would miss the 9:15 PM Route 20 in Downtown Norfolk, we would miss the last Route 15 of the night at Glenrock Mall, and the two of us would be stranded in Norfolk overnight in our wheelchairs with no way home."

Greg Mercer stared at Katie, stunned silent for two full beats as the bus driver waited patiently at the controls.

"My God," Greg breathed, his pen hovering over his pad. "You just debated for forty-five minutes on live television next to an empty podium because the incumbent didn't bother to show up, and now you're sprinting to catch a three-bus transfer chain across two cities before the system shuts down for the night."

"Mr. Mercer," Katie said simply, her blue eyes steady under the streetlight before she guided her SwiftChair smoothly up the metal ramp into the bus vestibule beside me, "improving the CVTA bus system—specifically Virginia Beach's locally funded share of the regional system—is the entire reason I'm running for City Council. Have a good night, and thank you for walking us to the stop!"

As we swiped our thirty-day CVTA passes through the farebox and locked our wheelchair brakes in the dual front bays, the hydraulic ramp folded back inside, the glass doors hissed shut, and the 8:24 PM Route 2 bus pulled away down Hampton Boulevard—leaving the veteran *Tidewater Pilot* reporter standing on the curb under the bus stop sign, staring after our taillights and scribbling in his notebook as fast as his hand could move.

Friday, October 15, 2010, 9:30 AM — Section B1 Above the Fold & All Ten Lines Lit on WHRC 89.5 FM

We made our 9:15 PM Route 20 transfer in Downtown Norfolk with eleven minutes to spare, caught the final 9:45 PM southbound Route 15 at Glenrock Mall, and rolled through the front door of our house off Military Highway and Indian River Road in Kempsville at ten-forty that night—tired, happy, and ready for a late cup of hot chocolate before bed.

At nine-thirty the next morning, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at our dual coding desks drinking cold orange juice and checking our overnight campaign emails, we heard the familiar sound of Dad's key turning in the front deadbolt.

"Morning, kids!" Dad called out, walking into our home office carrying a steaming travel mug of black coffee in one hand and a thick bundle of five freshly printed Friday morning editions of *The Tidewater Pilot* under his other arm. "I took a personal day in Tysons and drove down early so we could canvass Bellamy Manor this afternoon—and I bought out the newsstand box at the corner convenience store on my way in. Have you two seen Section B yet?"

"Not the print edition," I said as Katie and I rolled our chairs back from our desks. "Did Greg Mercer's blurb run inside the Metro pages?"

Dad let out a laugh that crinkled the corners of his eyes behind his glasses, pulled the Metro & Virginia section from the top of the bundle, and laid Section B1 flat across our desk.

It wasn't a two-paragraph blurb buried on page four.

Stretching all the way across the top of the Friday Metro front page above the fold in bold seventy-two-point black type was a banner headline written by Greg Mercer:

AN EMPTY PODIUM—AND AN 8:24 P.M. BUS TO CATCH Incumbent Dietz Skips Televised WHRC Debate; Challenger Katie Prairie Commands the Hour—Then Races Across Hampton Boulevard in Her Wheelchair to Make Last Bus Connection Home to Virginia Beach

Directly beneath the headline sat two side-by-side color photographs spanning all six columns of the page. On the left was a crisp frame captured from the WHRC TV-15 broadcast showing twenty-five-year-old Katie seated at her accessible studio desk next to Councilman Harold Dietz's brightly lit, completely empty mahogany podium. On the right was a photograph taken by a *Tidewater Pilot* photographer Greg Mercer had reached by cell phone on Hampton Boulevard—showing Katie and me rolling our black SwiftChairs up the steel hydraulic ramp of the kneeling 8:24 PM CVTA Route 2 bus under the streetlights while regular night-shift commuters looked on from the windows.

Katie and I read down the twenty-eight-inch column together in amazed silence. Greg Mercer hadn't missed a single detail: he had printed the exact 8:14 PM debate sign-off, the twenty-two-second sprint across all six lanes of Hampton Boulevard, the minute-by-minute transfer math of the 8:24 PM Route 2 to the 9:15 PM Route 20 to the final 9:45 PM Route 15 at Glenrock Mall, and Katie's parting words from the bottom of the bus ramp right in the closing box quote.

“Look at the traffic counter on our campaign server, Katie,” I said, glancing up at my real-time PHP analytics monitor. “Our website hits just passed twelve thousand for the morning, and small online donations of ten and twenty-five dollars are coming in every thirty seconds from Kempsville, Bayside, and Norfolk.”

At twelve-oh-six that afternoon, while the three of us were eating turkey sandwiches at the kitchen table before heading out to canvass, I clicked open the live audio stream of Coastal Virginia Public Media’s non-profit public radio station, WHRC 89.5 FM, during its flagship Friday noon regional call-in program.

“Welcome back to *Tidewater Forum* on WHRC 89.5 FM, I’m Catherine Lindsey,” the host said over our desktop speakers. “Before we open the phone lines for our weekly Friday civic roundtable, I need to remind our listeners of the ground rules: as a non-profit 501(c)(3) public broadcasting organization, WHRC radio and television are strictly prohibited by federal law from endorsing or opposing any candidate for public office. However, judging by our studio switchboard over the last ten minutes, it appears half of Hampton Roads has read Greg Mercer’s front-page Metro column in this morning’s *Tidewater Pilot* about last night’s Kempsville City Council debate here in our building. All ten of our studio call-in lines are flashing right now. Let’s go first to Line One—Arthur in Kempsville, you’re on WHRC.”

“Thank you, Catherine,” an older gentleman’s voice came over the radio clearly. *“I’ve lived off Kempsville Road for thirty-four years and I voted for Harold Dietz twice in the past. Last night I tuned in to Channel 15 to watch the debate, and I sat there for forty-five minutes looking at an empty wooden podium while that young lady in the wheelchair answered every single budget and drainage question like she’d been running the city for ten years. And then I open my paper over breakfast this morning and find out she and her twin brother had to hustle across six lanes of Hampton Boulevard in the dark just to catch three buses home before CVTA locked up for the night! You don’t have to endorse anybody on the radio—the voters in Kempsville can see for ourselves who’s actually working for a living.”*

“Thank you, Arthur—let’s go to Line Two, Brenda calling from a cell phone near Glenrock Mall,” Catherine Lindsey said.

“Hi, I’m a respiratory therapist and I ride that exact Route 20 and Route 15 transfer at Glenrock Mall three nights a week,” the second caller said, her voice thick with emotion. *“I’ve seen Katie and her brother Nate in their wheelchairs on the front of the bus for years taking notes and talking to riders, and I never realized she was running for City Council until I saw the photo of them rolling up the Route 2 ramp in the paper today. For ten years City Hall has acted like those of us who ride the bus after eight o’clock at night don’t exist. Everybody on my shift at the hospital is voting for Katie Prairie on November second!”*

Line after line, for forty consecutive minutes without a single negative call, listeners from Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Larkspur, College Park, and across Hampton Roads lit up all ten phone lines on WHRC 89.5 FM—until the host finally had to laugh on air and remind callers that the program had other regional news topics on its rundown.

Sitting at our Kempsville kitchen table with Dad grinning over his coffee mug and Katie holding my hand across our wheelchair armrests, we finished our sandwiches, loaded four hundred fresh palm cards into our canvas side-bags, and rolled out into the crisp October sunshine for the final eighteen days of sidewalk canvassing before Election Day.

Part 2: The WTGA 790 AM Disability Attack, The 94.1% Landslide, & The Eighteenth Street Reckoning

Date: 2010-10-28 at 08:15 America/New_York

Thursday, October 28, 2010, 8:15 AM — Five Days Before the Election: The Incumbent Attacks Katie's Wheelchair on WTGA 790 AM

"Turn the desktop speakers up a notch, Nate," twenty-five-year-old Katie said from her SwiftChair beside mine on the Thursday morning before the election, pausing her typing on our morning canvassing walk-sheets as the live web stream of conservative talk radio WTGA 790 AM—Tidewater Talk 790—crackled across our home office off Military Highway in Kempsville. "The host just said Harold Dietz called in unscheduled."

I reached over and turned up the volume knob beside my monitor while taking a sip of cold chocolate milk.

For the past thirteen days since Greg Mercer's front-page Metro story in *The Tidewater Pilot* and the forty-minute switchboard takeover on WHRC 89.5 FM, Councilman Harold Dietz had vanished from public view—canceling two neighborhood civic-league appearances while our volunteer canvassing teams knocked on thousands of doors across Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur. Now, with five days left before Tuesday's election, the ten-year incumbent had evidently decided to go live on Hampton Roads' loudest morning talk-radio microphone to try to stop the bleeding.

"We're joined on the studio line right now by Virginia Beach City Councilman Harold Dietz, representing the Kempsville District," the WTGA morning host announced. *"Councilman, folks all over the city have been talking about that empty podium over at WHRC and the front-page story in the Tidewater Pilot about your twenty-five-year-old opponent catching three buses home at eight-twenty at night. Looks like you've got a real horse race on your hands out in Kempsville."*

When Harold Dietz's voice came through the broadcast compressor, he didn't sound like a calm ten-year incumbent. He sounded tight, defensive, and rattled.

"Well, Mike, let's call that newspaper story what it was—a staged piece of political theater," Dietz snapped over the airwaves. *"The Tidewater Pilot loves a melodramatic human-interest angle, so they print a picture of my opponent rolling onto a bus at night as if riding a bus qualifies somebody to manage a one-point-seven-billion-dollar municipal corporation. Let's talk about the real world at City Hall that nobody at the newspaper wants to mention."*

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests, our fingers stilling on our keyboards.

“First of all,” Dietz ploughed ahead, his voice rising with irritation as he went completely off script, *“if my opponent were actually elected on Tuesday, do the taxpayers of Virginia Beach have any idea what City Hall facilities would have to do to the historic mahogany City Council chamber in Building One? They would have to tear out the woodwork on the side of the raised Council dais and spend tens of thousands of taxpayer dollars building a custom structural wheelchair ramp just to get one person up to a desk! And second, let’s be honest with the voters about the demands of this job. Serving on the Virginia Beach City Council isn’t a hobby you do from a laptop. We sit in six-hour afternoon budget workshops followed by six-hour evening sessions that run past midnight, plus regional commission meetings all over Tidewater. Are we really supposed to pretend that a twenty-five-year-old girl in a wheelchair—who has to have her twin brother rolling right beside her everywhere she goes just to get through the day—has the physical stamina to handle twelve-hour days on the City Council?”*

Inside our quiet home office in Kempsville, the silence lasted three full seconds.

Even over the radio broadcast, you could hear the WTGA morning host draw in a sharp, audible breath inside the Norfolk studio as he realized the incumbent councilman had just committed political suicide on live air in the largest military and veteran community on the East Coast.

“Uh—Councilman Dietz,” the WTGA host cut in quickly, his tone dropping an octave as the red warning lights on his studio call screener’s board began flashing like a Christmas tree, *“hang on a second there, Harold. We have eighty thousand disabled veterans and wounded warriors living right here in Virginia Beach and Norfolk who use wheelchairs every day, and federal law under the Americans with Disabilities Act requires public buildings to be accessible anyway—”*

“I’m just saying the voters deserve to know the practical reality and the cost, Mike!” Dietz insisted defensively before the host hastily took the program to a commercial break—and when the show came back from the break three minutes later, Councilman Dietz was no longer on the line.

What followed over the next forty-five minutes on WTGA 790 AM was unlike anything we had ever heard on conservative talk radio.

The host didn’t take a single call defending Harold Dietz—because there weren’t any. Instead, caller after caller was a furious Navy chief, a retired Marine colonel, a wounded Iraq or Afghanistan veteran from Little Creek or Naval Air Station Oceana, or a lifelong conservative Kempsville homeowner calling in to blister the incumbent for attacking a candidate’s wheelchair and mocking the bond between twin siblings who had lived with a spinal-cord condition since high school.

“Mike, this is Senior Chief Petty Officer Miller calling from Bellamy Manor,” a booming voice growled on Line One. *“I served twenty-four years in the Navy and I’ve voted Republican in every election for the last thirty years. My nephew lost the use of his legs in Anbar Province in 2007 and uses a power wheelchair just like Katie and Nate Prairie. For a sitting Virginia Beach City Councilman to go on the radio and complain about the cost of putting a wheelchair ramp on the City Council dais—and to insult a young woman’s stamina because she uses a wheelchair and works alongside her twin brother—is the most disgraceful thing I’ve ever heard in this city. I walked out to my front yard five minutes ago, pulled Harold Dietz’s sign out of my grass, and threw it in the trash can!”*

By noon on Friday, the fallout had turned into an avalanche. Three of Virginia Beach's largest business associations issued public statements revoking their endorsements of Councilman Dietz and clarifying that they stood for equal access for all citizens. When *The Tidewater Pilot* called our campaign phone asking for Katie's response to Dietz's radio remarks, Katie gave Greg Mercer a single, quiet two-sentence statement:

"My brother Nate and I have used power wheelchairs since our legs gave out during our junior year at Northwood High School, and we have never once asked anyone in Virginia Beach for pity. All we have ever asked for is a ramp to the table and a bus that runs late enough for working people to get home."

On Saturday morning, October 30—seventy-two hours before the polls opened—*The Tidewater Pilot* devoted the entire top half of its Editorial & Opinion page to a special full-width spread of reader letters under the banner headline:

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR: DIETZ'S ATTACKS ON BUSES, WHEELCHAIR RAMPS CROSS THE LINE

Sitting at our kitchen table with Dad over Saturday morning pancakes and orange juice, I read three of the printed letters aloud while Katie listened beside me:

> A Ramp to the People's Dais Is Not a "Special Favor"
> As a retired Navy Master Chief who lost both legs above the knee to an IED outside Fallujah in 2006, I nearly drove my hand-control truck off Kempsville Road on Thursday morning listening to Councilman Harold Dietz complain on WTGA 790 AM about the cost of building a wheelchair ramp up to the City Council dais for Katie Prairie. When I came home from Bethesda Naval Hospital in a wheelchair, nobody told me I lacked the "stamina" to contribute to my community. If the mahogany dais in Building 1 doesn't have a wheelchair ramp after twenty years of the Americans with Disabilities Act, that isn't an indictment of Katie Prairie—it is an indictment of Harold Dietz and every politician who never thought a citizen in a wheelchair belonged up there.
> — Master Chief Robert H. Callahan, USN (Ret.), Kempsville, Virginia Beach

> The 8:24 PM Bus Is Real Life, Not "Political Theater"
> Councilman Dietz claims Katie and Nate Prairie catching the 8:24 PM Route 2 bus home from the WHRC debate was a "publicity stunt." Tell that to those of us who close the retail stores at Pembroke Mall and Glenrock Mall every night and pray our connecting Route 20 or Route 15 bus isn't five minutes late so we aren't stranded in the dark. Katie and Nate Prairie have ridden the bus with us in the rain and cold for five years. On Tuesday, the bus riders of Virginia Beach are going to send one of our own to City Hall.
> — Denise T. Holloway, College Park, Virginia Beach

> We Remember the Day Their Legs Gave Out at Northwood High
> Hearing Councilman Dietz mock Katie Prairie for having her twin brother Nate rolling beside her broke my heart and made my blood boil. I taught English at Northwood High School in September 2001 on the Friday afternoon when sixteen-year-old Katie and Nate's legs gave out within three hours of each other. Every teacher in that building watched those two teenagers refuse to give up, finish high school from hospital beds and wheelchairs, earn their degrees at CCHR, build their own software business,

> and make their home right here in Kempsville. Their bond isn't a weakness—it is the finest example of family courage in Virginia Beach.
> — Margaret L. Sterling, Retired Teacher, Bayside, Virginia Beach

When I finished reading Mrs. Sterling's letter, Dad had to take off his glasses and wipe his eyes with his napkin, while Katie held my hand tightly across our armrests.

Tuesday, November 2, 2010, 7:19 PM — The 94.1% to 5.9% Landslide & The Four-Station Election Night Post-Mortem

At seven o'clock on the evening of Tuesday, November 2, 2010, the polls closed across the City of Virginia Beach.

We hadn't rented a hotel ballroom at the Oceanfront. Instead, Katie, Dad, and I were gathered inside our living room off Military Highway and Indian River Road in Kempsville along with sixteen of our volunteer sidewalk canvassers, CCHR students, and fellow CVTA bus riders, with platters of warm pizza and two-liter bottles of ginger ale, orange soda, and flavored water set out on the dining table and a fresh pot of black coffee brewing in the kitchen for Dad. Across the living room wall, I had connected four television monitors and my dual laptop screens to our custom PHP precinct-return engine, which scraped the live precinct-by-precinct XML data feed straight from the Virginia State Board of Elections and the Virginia Beach Voter Registrar every fifteen seconds.

At 7:08 PM, the first four Kempsville precincts reported their optical-scan tabulator tapes.

Dad leaned over my shoulder, staring at my PHP dashboard screen through his glasses. "Nate… check your parser code on Kempsville Precinct Three and Bellamy Precinct One. Is a decimal point shifted?"

"The parser checksums match the state XML feed to the single vote, Dad," I breathed, my heart hammering against my ribs as five more precincts popped onto the screen in bright green. "Look at the raw totals."

At 7:19 PM—just nineteen minutes after the polls closed—all four local television network affiliates in Hampton Roads (WCVB-TV 10 Coastal News 10, WTID-TV 3 NewsChannel 3, WVHR-TV 13 13News, and WHRC TV-15) flashed simultaneous breaking-news graphics across the bottom of their screens with a loud electronic chime:

PROJECTION — VIRGINIA BEACH CITY COUNCIL (KEMPSVILLE DISTRICT): KATIE PRAIRIE (WINNER) — 94.1% HAROLD DIETZ (INCUMBENT) — 5.9%

Inside our living room in Kempsville, a roar went up that shook the framed blue butterfly print on the hallway wall. Dad wrapped both of his arms around Katie's shoulders and mine at the same time, his voice choked with pride, while Katie pressed her forehead against mine across our armrests with tears of pure joy shining in her blue eyes.

As the final precincts locked in over the next twenty minutes confirming the staggering 94.1% to 5.9% margin—the largest landslide defeat of a sitting incumbent in the modern history of Hampton Roads municipal politics—we unmuted the four television feeds and the radio stream to hear the stunned political analysts dissect what had just happened.

On WCVB-TV 10, Coastal News 10 anchor Don Roberts turned to Virginia Dominion University political science professor Dr. Quentin Marsh standing in front of the electronic precinct map.

"Ninety-four point one percent to five point nine percent, Dr. Marsh," the anchor said, shaking his head at the big board. *"We have never seen numbers like this in a contested Virginia Beach City Council race. How does a ten-year incumbent get wiped out by eighty-eight points?"*

"Don, what we just witnessed tonight in Kempsville is the textbook anatomy of a catastrophic one-two political knockout," Dr. Marsh explained, tapping the touchscreen map of Virginia Beach. *"Three weeks ago, before the WHRC debate, Harold Dietz was sitting on a comfortable eight-point incumbent lead mostly because voters didn't know who Katie Prairie was. Then came Punch Number One on October fourteenth: Dietz didn't even bother to RSVP to WHRC TV-15, leaving his podium empty on live television for forty-five minutes while Katie Prairie demonstrated complete command of the municipal budget—followed ten minutes later by Greg Mercer's front-page story in the Tidewater Pilot showing Katie and her twin brother Nate sprinting across six lanes of Hampton Boulevard in their wheelchairs to catch the 8:24 PM Route 2 bus so they wouldn't miss the last three-bus transfer chain home to Virginia Beach. We now know from campaign insiders that by the Monday after that story ran, Dietz's internal tracking poll had crashed from an eight-point lead down to a dead heat—48.2 percent to 47.8 percent, a razor-thin four-tenths of one percent margin right inside Virginia's automatic recount threshold—and his major Oceanfront donors threatened to freeze his final forty-thousand-dollar TV buy."*

Across the room on WVHR-TV 13, a live 13News remote camera panned across a cavernous, completely deserted ballroom at an Oceanfront resort hotel where untouched trays of shrimp cocktail sat under heat lamps beside a silent podium banner reading *RE-ELECT COUNCILMAN DIETZ*.

"And that panic inside the Dietz camp led directly to Punch Number Two last Thursday morning on WTGA 790 AM," the WVHR-TV 13 political reporter told the studio anchors from the empty ballroom. *"Trying to look tough for his panicked donors, Councilman Dietz went on live talk radio, mocked the Prairies' three-bus ride home, complained about the taxpayer cost of building a wheelchair ramp up to the City Council dais in Building 1, and questioned whether a woman in a wheelchair rolling alongside her twin brother had the stamina to serve on Council. In a city filled with military families, disabled veterans, and working bus commuters, that radio call turned a 0.4 percent race into a 94 percent wipeout. The Councilman called Ms. Prairie three minutes ago to concede and left the hotel through a side kitchen door."*

Meanwhile, on WTID-TV 3 NewsChannel 3, the tech-desk correspondent pulled up a live graphic highlighting our grassroots ground game:

"Don't overlook the engineering behind this victory, either," the WTID-TV 3 analyst noted. *"Katie and Nathaniel Prairie didn't spend a dime on outside political consultants. Nathaniel Prairie wrote their custom PHP voter-turnout and precinct-mapping software himself, and look at the precinct turnout bars along the CVTA Route 12, Route 15, Route 20, and Route 36 corridors—precincts that normally see 18 percent turnout in an off-year municipal election surged by 42 percent tonight because bus riders and working families came out in droves to vote for one of their own."*

Even over on conservative talk radio WTGA 790 AM, the evening election host sighed into his microphone as the 94.1% total scrolled across his screen: *"Folks, Harold Dietz dug his own grave right here on our morning airwaves last Thursday. When a twenty-five-year-old woman and her twin brother out-work you, out-debate you, ride three city buses home in the dark, and build their own software from scratch, attacking their wheelchairs in a Navy town is a guaranteed way to get sent into retirement."*

January to May 2011 — The Building 1 Dais Ramp, Locking $810,000 of CVTA Perks in Escrow, & Taking Seat on the CVTA Commission

During the eight weeks between Election Night in November 2010 and Reorganization Night in January 2011, municipal carpenters and accessibility contractors went to work inside the City Council Chamber of Building 1 at the Virginia Beach Municipal Center.

Removing the steep wooden steps on the right wing of the curved mahogany City Council dais, the city constructed a permanent, gently sloped, red-carpeted wheelchair ramp bordered by polished mahogany handrails leading straight up to the Kempsville District desk, where the heavy leather swivel chair was rolled away so twenty-five-year-old Councilwoman-Elect Katie Prairie could pull her compact black SwiftChair directly up to the voting console.

On Tuesday evening, January 4, 2011, with the chamber gallery packed wall-to-wall with Kempsville neighbors, CCHR students, bus operators, and retired Master Chief Robert Callahan sitting in the front row in his own wheelchair, Katie rolled up the new mahogany dais ramp to her Kempsville District seat, inviting Dad and me onto the dais beside her solely for the ceremonial swearing-in while I held open our bound leather copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Neither Katie nor I believed in any religion or any god—and before the ceremony, Katie had politely notified the Clerk of the Circuit Court that under Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution, Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia, and Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia, she would be taking the secular constitutional affirmation on the Virginia Constitution rather than a religious oath on a Bible, omitting the optional parenthetical reference to a deity at the end.

Placing her left hand flat on the Virginia Constitution and raising her right hand, Katie repeated the constitutional affirmation of office as the newly elected Kempsville District Councilwoman in a clear, ringing voice that echoed to the back of the chamber:

“I do solemnly affirm that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me as a member of the Council of the City of Virginia Beach, according to the best of my ability.”

As soon as the applause thundered across the chamber, Dad and I descended the ramp back to the front row of the public gallery so Councilwoman Katie Prairie could take her official seat alone at the Kempsville console on the dais.

She didn’t wait six months to keep the promise she had made to Greg Mercer at the 8:24 PM bus stop on Hampton Boulevard.

Just two weeks later, on Tuesday evening, January 18, 2011, Item 9B came up on the formal Virginia Beach City Council agenda: a request from the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority for a $1.42 million mid-year supplemental municipal appropriation to cover administrative cost overruns at CVTA’s Norfolk headquarters.

Stepping up to the low citizen and staff microphone podium on the chamber floor below the raised mahogany dais were two men in tailored charcoal suits whom Katie and I knew very well: CVTA President and Chief Executive Officer Leonard Sterling, and Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead—the exact two executives who, fourteen months earlier on East Eighteenth Street, had cut off my public-comment microphone at the hundred-and-eighty-second buzzer, sneered in the hallway that we were *“statistically insignificant hobbyist bloggers,”* refused to release raw GTFS schedule files, and secretly blackballed me from the Transit Riders Advisory Committee.

Now, the roles were reversed. Sterling and Halstead were standing down at the floor microphone looking up at the raised mahogany dais—where twenty-five-year-old Councilwoman Katie Prairie sat in the elected seat of power looking down at them with her finger resting beside her microphone button, while I sat as a private citizen down in the front accessible bay of the chamber floor right beside the dais ramp with the PHP line-item audit I had prepared for her open on my MagnaBook Pro.

When CEO Sterling finished his five-minute presentation asking the City Council to approve the $1.42 million check with no strings attached, the Mayor turned toward the right wing of the dais.

“Councilwoman Prairie,” the Mayor said, “you have the floor.”

Katie pressed her white microphone button. The green indicator ring lit up—and this time, Richard Halstead didn’t have a cutoff switch.

“Thank you, Mr. Mayor,” Katie said, her voice calm, polite, and surgical as every camera in Building 1 zoomed in on her desk. “Mr. Sterling, Mr. Halstead, before the voters of Kempsville elected me to this Council by a margin of ninety-four point one percent, the two of you cut off my brother Nate’s microphone at Eighteenth Street and told us in the hallway that CVTA doesn’t take operational direction from ‘hobbyist bloggers.’ Now that you are asking the taxpayers of Virginia Beach for an extra one point four two million dollars, my brother and I have gone through every single line of your general ledger.”

Down at the podium, Richard Halstead swallowed hard, a bead of sweat glistening at his temple under the television lights.

“Out of the one point four two million dollars you are requesting tonight,” Katie continued, reading directly from the PHP audit sheet on her desk, “six hundred and ten thousand dollars goes toward fuel and frontline bus operator wages, which I fully support. The remaining eight hundred and ten thousand dollars, however, is earmarked for executive retention bonuses, out-of-state conference travel, fleet take-home sedans for senior staff, and proprietary scheduling consultant contracts. Meanwhile, here in Virginia Beach, the last Route 12 bus out of the CCHR hub still leaves at 5:48 PM, locking citizens out of our 6:00 PM Council meetings, and your agency still refuses to publish its raw General Transit Feed Specification database tables for the public.”

Katie held up a two-page printed budget amendment she had drafted with the City Attorney that morning from our audit notes.

“Therefore, Mr. Mayor,” Katie announced, “I move an amendment to Item 9B: the City of Virginia Beach will release the six hundred and ten thousand dollars for bus operators and fuel tonight, and we will lock the remaining eight hundred and ten thousand dollars of executive overhead in a restricted municipal escrow account. Not one penny of that eight hundred and ten thousand dollars will be released by the City Treasurer until CVTA meets two mandatory conditions: first, publishing its complete, unredacted GTFS schedule database online under an open public license within thirty days; and second, implementing the Evening Civic Access Transit Pulse—extending Route 33 out of the Virginia Beach Municipal Center until 10:30 PM on Council nights and operating a synchronized 9:00 PM and 10:00 PM evening connecting pulse for Routes 12, 25, 29, and 36 at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus hub.”

“Second!” called out At-Large Councilman Ronald Villa from the other side of the dais with a broad grin.

When the electronic voting board on the chamber wall chimed ten seconds later, all eleven lights glowed green: 11–0.

And the reckoning wasn’t quite finished. Immediately after the budget vote, the Mayor called up Item 9C—the resolution appointing Virginia Beach’s new municipal representatives to the governing board of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority, the Transportation District Commission, to fill the seat vacated by former Councilman Harold Dietz.

By a second unanimous 11–0 vote, the Virginia Beach City Council appointed Councilwoman Katie Prairie as a voting Commissioner of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority.

Nine days later, on the fourth Thursday of January 2011, while every other city council commissioner from across Hampton Roads drove into Norfolk and parked in the reserved VIP lot behind CVTA headquarters on East Eighteenth Street, CVTA’s newest governing Commissioner arrived the exact same way she and I had always traveled: by riding a three-bus chain on CVTA—boarding Route 15 northbound on Military Highway, transferring to Route 20 westbound at Glenrock Mall into Downtown Norfolk, and riding Route 1 up Granby Street to Eighteenth Street while paying our regular fare.

When Katie and I rolled our SwiftChairs through the double doors of the Eighteenth Street boardroom, I parked at the front accessible citizen-advisor table while Commissioner Katie Prairie rolled straight up onto the raised Commissioners’

horseshoe dais—right past Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead's chair. Under New Business, the very first official action Commissioner Katie Prairie took from the dais was exercising her unilateral prerogative as a Virginia Beach Commissioner to make a citizen appointment to the Transit Riders Advisory Committee.

"Pursuant to Section 4.2 of the Commission bylaws," Katie said clearly into her Commissioner's microphone while looking straight across the table at Richard Halstead, "as a voting Commissioner for the City of Virginia Beach, I hereby appoint Nathaniel Prairie to the Virginia Beach citizen seat on the Transit Riders Advisory Committee, effective immediately."

By May 2011, CVTA had published its complete open GTFS schedule feed and launched the permanent Evening Civic Access Transit Pulse across Virginia Beach. For the first time in the history of our city, any citizen who rode a public bus or used a wheelchair could attend a six o'clock City Council meeting, speak at the public microphone, and ride a CVTA bus safely home afterward.

Inside Building 1 at the Municipal Center, Katie also established a daily office habit that baffled the veteran city hall staffers down the corridor: whenever she was sitting at her desk and the main constituent telephone line rang, she didn't wait for a city clerk or a shared administrative receptionist to screen the call and take a paper message. In Katie's literal autistic mind, her name was on the door, the voters of Kempsville had hired her to do the job, and sitting three feet away from a ringing telephone without picking it up would be rude and dishonest. So whenever she could reach the receiver, she pressed the button herself and answered, "Councilwoman Katie Prairie's office, this is Katie speaking," so the caller knew she was actually at her desk working for them—regularly leaving Kempsville homeowners and retired shipyard workers speechless for two full seconds when they realized their own City Councilwoman had picked up the phone on the first ring.

And on every single Tuesday night when the Virginia Beach City Council adjourned at nine-thirty, Councilwoman Katie Prairie rolled down the mahogany dais ramp in Building 1 to meet me at the front of the gallery, and the two of us rolled out to the Municipal Center bus shelter alongside the citizens who had come to watch the meeting, swiped our thirty-day CVTA passes, and rode the 9:45 PM Route 33 and Route 12 pulse right back home to Kempsville.

The Gentlewoman from Virginia Beach: The House of Delegates

Stopped at the Third-Floor Gallery, Seated by Delegate Ronald Villa, & Winning the 85th District

Part 1: Stopped at the Third-Floor Gallery by Capitol Police, Seated on the House Floor Near Delegate Ronald Villa, & The Spark to Run

Date: 2012-02-09 at 11:35 America/New_York

Thursday, February 9, 2012, 11:35 AM — Stopped Outside the Third-Floor Public Viewing Gallery by Capitol Police

“The public viewing gallery for the House of Delegates should be right around this corner on the left, Nate,” twenty-six-year-old Katie said as the brass doors of the small historic passenger elevator slid open on the third floor of the Virginia State Capitol.

Side by side, we guided our compact SwiftChairs out of the narrow elevator cab onto the polished heart-pine floorboards of the third-floor balcony corridor.

It was a cold Thursday morning in February 2012, midway through the winter session of the Virginia General Assembly and thirteen months into Katie’s term representing the Kempsville District on the Virginia Beach City Council. Earlier that morning at nine o’clock, after riding up from Hampton Roads to testify both as a Virginia Beach City Councilwoman and as co-founder of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, Katie and I had presented our evening ridership numbers and bus-stop accessibility data to a House Transportation subcommittee down in the General Assembly Building—urging the state legislature not to slash the state transit operating funds that matched our new evening bus service in Virginia Beach. Since our afternoon train back home didn’t leave until four o’clock, we had rolled through the underground Capitol tunnel hoping to sit in the public viewing gallery and watch the full House of Delegates convene at noon.

Ahead of us, a line of schoolteachers, college students, and day-trippers was filing past the velvet rope into the steeply tiered wooden benches of the third-floor House Public Gallery.

Before our front casters reached the doorway, however, a uniformed Virginia Division of Capitol Police lieutenant standing beside the gallery entrance stepped gently into the center of the corridor and held up a gloved hand.

“Good morning, folks—hold up just a second for me,” the Capitol Police lieutenant said, his tone polite but firm as he looked down at our two power wheelchairs.

Katie and I braked our SwiftChairs together. “Good morning, Lieutenant,” Katie said calmly. “We already cleared the security screening downstairs at the visitor entrance. We’re just heading into the public viewing gallery to watch the noon House session.”

“Yes, ma’am, I see your visitor stickers,” the lieutenant replied, glancing toward the narrow gallery threshold and then back at our heavy powerchairs with genuine concern on his face. “I’m very sorry, folks, but we can’t bring wheelchairs into the third-floor public viewing gallery.”

My eyebrows drew together. “Is there not a level space at the top of the gallery aisle?”

“It’s not the floor space inside the doorway, sir—it’s emergency evacuation safety,” the Capitol Police lieutenant explained earnestly, gesturing back toward the small retrofit elevator we had just ridden up and the steep, winding eighteenth-century stairwell at the end of the hall. “Thomas Jefferson designed this building in 1788. If a fire alarm goes off or we have to order an emergency evacuation of the Capitol while the House is in session, that passenger elevator automatically locks out and recalls to the ground floor. From this third-floor gallery, the only way out of the building is down three flights of steep, narrow historic stairs. My officers have no safe way to carry power wheelchairs down three stories of stairs in an emergency, and I can’t put the two of you in a position where we couldn’t get you out of the building safely.”

Katie and I looked at each other across our armrests. Having spent more than ten years navigating every flavor of architectural barrier in Virginia, both of us could tell immediately that the Capitol Police officer wasn’t trying to brush us off—he was looking at a genuine life-safety trap in a two-hundred-year-old building and taking his duty seriously.

“So there’s nowhere in the State Capitol where a citizen in a wheelchair is allowed to watch their own House of Delegates vote?” Katie asked quietly, not angry at the officer, but with that familiar, steady look in her blue eyes whenever she ran into a systemic wall.

“I didn’t say that, ma’am,” the Capitol Police lieutenant said with a reassuring half-smile, reaching up to unclip the microphone of his shoulder radio. “Give me two minutes right here by the elevator. I’m going to walk downstairs and speak directly to the Sergeant-at-Arms and House Leadership to explain that we have a member of the public in a wheelchair and her companion upstairs who came to watch the House session, and that Capitol Police have emergency-egress safety concerns with the third-floor gallery. Let me see what Leadership can do.”

We parked our SwiftChairs beside the marble bust in the third-floor elevator vestibule and waited while the ten-minute warning bell for the noon floor session chimed overhead.

Four minutes later, the brass indicator needle above the third-floor elevator swung upward. The doors slid open, and the Capitol Police lieutenant stepped out alongside a tall gentleman in a dark three-piece suit wearing the silver badge of the Sergeant-at-Arms of the Virginia House of Delegates.

“Councilwoman Prairie and Mr. Prairie?” the Sergeant-at-Arms asked warmly.

“Yes, sir,” I said.

“The Lieutenant just spoke with me and the Speaker’s office about the safety concern up here on the third floor,” the Sergeant-at-Arms said, holding out two heavy cream-colored cards stamped in gold leaf with the seal of the Commonwealth. “House Leadership does not want any Virginian turned away from watching the people’s House in session because of a wheelchair. By order of the Speaker, you and one ADA companion—or in your case, both of you together—have been granted a rare honor today. If you’ll ride the elevator down to the first floor with me, we’re going to seat you right on the Floor of the Virginia House of Delegates.”

Katie’s blue eyes widened slightly as she looked across at me, and we rolled our wheelchairs straight back into the elevator cab beside the Sergeant-at-Arms.

Thursday, February 9, 2012, 11:52 AM — Seated on the House Floor Near Virginia Beach Delegate Ronald Villa & The Spark

When the elevator doors opened on the first floor, the marble rotunda corridor outside the House Chamber was packed three-deep with corporate lobbyists, reporters, and political staffers pressed against the brass velvet rope.

Under the rules of the House of Delegates, members of the general public and registered lobbyists were strictly barred from crossing that threshold onto the Chamber floor during session. Yet as the Sergeant-at-Arms stepped out of the elevator ahead of our two wheelchairs, the doorkeepers immediately unhooked the velvet rope and swung open the tall mahogany double doors.

“Make way, please—honored guests of the House coming through to the Floor,” the Sergeant-at-Arms announced.

Thirty-five lobbyists in thousand-dollar suits parted in stunned silence as two twenty-six-year-old twins from Virginia Beach rolled their compact black SwiftChairs straight across the threshold onto the lush green carpet of the Virginia House of Delegates Chamber.

Rolling inside at floor level felt completely different from looking at photographs of the chamber. High above us rose the cream-and-gold coffered ceiling and the glittering crystal chandeliers; directly ahead stood the Speaker’s elevated marble rostrum and the twin electronic voting boards listing all one hundred Delegates in alphabetical order. And instead of staring down at the tops of lawmakers’ heads from a distant third-floor balcony, we were rolling right past the curved rows of polished mahogany desks where the elected representatives of the Commonwealth sat.

“Right over here on the outer right aisle, folks,” the Sergeant-at-Arms whispered kindly, guiding our two wheelchairs to a wide, level carpeted bay near the rear row of desks on the first floor—twenty feet from an emergency ground-level exit door. “I figured two folks from Virginia Beach would feel right at home sitting next to one of your hometown Delegates.”

At the mahogany desk immediately beside our wheelchair bay, a dark-haired Delegate in a crisp navy suit—with a brass nameplate on his desk reading *MR. VILLA — VIRGINIA BEACH (21ST DISTRICT)*—turned around in his leather swivel chair to see who was being seated beside him.

The instant his eyes landed on our two wheelchairs, Delegate Ronald Villa broke into a huge, genuine grin and stood right up to shake our hands.

“Katie! Nate!” Delegate Villa said warmly, clasping Katie’s right hand and then reaching across to shake mine. “What a surprise! How did the two of you manage to score floor seats in the House of Delegates?”

“We tried to go upstairs to the third-floor public viewing gallery, Delegate Villa,” I explained with a grin, “and Capitol Police stopped us because they were worried about how they’d evacuate our wheelchairs down three flights of stairs in an emergency. They talked to House Leadership, and the Sergeant-at-Arms brought us down here to sit next to you.”

“Well, I couldn’t ask for better company on my aisle!” Delegate Villa laughed, gesturing toward the two neighboring delegates seated to his left. “Hey, guys, let me introduce you to Virginia Beach City Councilwoman Katie Prairie from Kempsville and her twin brother Nathaniel. Long before Katie won her Kempsville Council seat, the two of them started the Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit blog. Back when I was serving At-Large on the Virginia Beach City Council before I was elected to the House, I was actively fighting to get more covered bus shelters built for our bus riders so working folks and seniors wouldn’t be standing out in the pouring rain along Kempsville Road, Princess Anne Road, and Holland Road. Every time city staff claimed we didn’t know which bus stops needed shelters the most, Katie and Nate had already ridden every route in their wheelchairs and published the exact stop-by-stop boarding numbers and sidewalk photos on their website!”

The two neighboring delegates smiled and shook our hands across our lap trays as the noon bell rang and the Speaker rapped his wooden gavel to call the House of Delegates to order.

For the next hour and fifteen minutes, Katie and I sat side by side in our SwiftChairs right on the green carpet of the House Floor beside Delegate Ronald Villa’s desk.

Whenever a bill came up on the electronic calendar board, Delegate Villa leaned over his desk armrest between votes to whisper a quick, friendly explanation of the parliamentary procedure—pointing out how the white request-to-speak buttons worked on the desk consoles, how committee chairmen signaled floor amendments, and how the red and green lights on the big wall boards tallied the yeas and nays in real time. Even though he sat on the Republican side of the aisle and knew our transit blog frequently called out state and local leaders in both parties when public transit got shortchanged, Delegate Villa treated us with the warm, unpretentious respect of a former At-Large City Councilman who genuinely cared about the bus riders in his city.

Then, at twelve-forty-five, the budget amendment Katie and I had testified for at nine o’clock that morning came up on the floor—a measure to restore four million dollars in state operating assistance for local public bus systems across Hampton Roads, Richmond, and Northern Virginia.

Sitting right on the House Floor, Katie and I watched the big electronic voting board on the front wall as the bell chimed and the red and green lights blinked on beside each lawmaker’s name.

Right next to us, Delegate Ronald Villa reached forward and pressed his green *YEA* button to support the transit funds for Hampton Roads.

Across the chamber, however, the incumbent Delegate representing our own Eighty-Fifth House District back home in Kempsville—Delegate Richard Tatum, who had ignored three straight emails Katie had sent him asking for a ten-minute meeting to coordinate state matching funds for Virginia Beach's new evening bus routes—didn't even look up from his cell phone as he reached over and slapped his red *NAY* button, helping defeat the transit amendment by six votes.

I turned my head slightly to look at my twin sister.

Katie wasn't looking at the floor carpet anymore. Sitting upright in her compact SwiftChair on the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates, her blue eyes were locked onto the mahogany desks and the big electronic voting board at the front of the room. For the first time in her life, the Virginia General Assembly wasn't a distant, abstract institution behind a television glass screen or three stories below a balcony rail. She was sitting right on the Floor. She could see the buttons on the desks. She could hear how the bills were debated. And she could see firsthand that while she had fought for a full year on the Virginia Beach City Council to get evening buses running out of the Municipal Center, the Eighty-Fifth District's own State Delegate up here in Richmond was voting to starve those very same buses of state matching funds.

When the House recessed at one-fifteen and Delegate Villa shook our hands again before heading off to his afternoon committee meeting—promising to keep working with us on bus shelters and regional transit back home in Virginia Beach—Katie and I rolled out the tall mahogany double doors of the House Chamber into the first-floor marble corridor.

As we rode the elevator down toward the underground Capitol tunnel, Katie reached across our wheelchair armrests and took my right hand in a grip so steady and electric that I felt it all the way to my shoulders.

"Nate," Katie whispered as the elevator doors closed around just the two of us.

"Yeah, Katie?" I asked, looking straight into her eyes.

"Being stopped at the third-floor viewing gallery by Capitol Police and brought down to sit on the House Floor beside Delegate Villa today was the best thing that ever could have happened to us," Katie said, her voice quiet and ringing with unmistakable purpose. "Did you see how ordinary those mahogany desks are when you're sitting right next to them on the green carpet? Just like on City Council back home, all it takes to make room for a power wheelchair at one of those desks is pulling out a single wooden swivel chair."

My breath caught in my chest as I realized what my twin sister was saying.

"Richard Tatum didn't even look up from his phone when he voted against our buses today," Katie continued, squeezing my fingers tightly. "We proved on the Virginia Beach City Council that when you put a bus rider in a wheelchair at the table, you can change the schedules for the entire city. But as long as politicians in Richmond keep cutting state transit funds and blocking disability Medicaid waivers, local City

Councils are fighting with one hand tied behind their backs. The next House of Delegates election is in November 2013. Let's go home, talk it over with Dad, and map out how we win the Eighty-Fifth District seat."

Part 2: Telling Dad at Our Kempsville Kitchen Table, The 125-Signature Ballot Petition at CCHR, & Winning the Eighty-Fifth House District

Date: 2012-11-23 at 18:30 America/New_York

Friday, November 23, 2012, 6:30 PM — Brainstorming with Dad Around the Kempsville Kitchen Table

"Dad," twenty-seven-year-old Katie said after the three of us had finished our Friday evening Thanksgiving leftovers and I had set three fresh glasses of ice-cold ginger ale down on the oak kitchen table of our house off Military Highway and Indian River Road in Kempsville, "Nate and I have a big decision we want to talk through with you before the end of the year."

Sitting across the table from our two compact SwiftChairs in his flannel shirt, our fifty-four-year-old dad set his glass down, adjusted his eyeglasses, and looked from Katie's face to mine with a knowing fatherly smile.

"Wait—let me guess," Dad said warmly. "The last time the two of you gave me that exact synchronized twin look across this table was back in 2010 right before Katie told me she was going to run against Harold Dietz for the Kempsville seat on the Virginia Beach City Council. Who rattled your cage this time?"

"Delegate Richard Tatum," Katie answered without missing a beat, sliding my MagnaBook Pro laptop across the table so Dad could see the newly redistricted map of the Eighty-Fifth House District glowing on the screen. "Back in February, when Nate and I rode up to Richmond to testify for state public-transit matching funds, Capitol Police stopped us at the third-floor viewing gallery over emergency-evacuation concerns and House Leadership brought us down to sit right on the Floor of the House of Delegates next to Ron Villa's desk. We sat twenty feet away from Richard Tatum and watched him slap his red Nay button against Hampton Roads bus funding without even looking up from his cell phone."

"And after serving two years on the Virginia Beach City Council," I added, tapping the boundary lines on the laptop screen, "we've seen firsthand that almost everything we're trying to fix locally—dedicated regional funding for CVTA, clearing the state developmental-disability Medicaid waiver waitlist for Virginia families raising adults like our cousin Chelsea up in Newport, Rhode Island, and enforcing real accessibility rules—is controlled up in Richmond by the General Assembly. Look at the new decennial map for the Eighty-Fifth House District, Dad: it covers Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur, right around Fairlawn Recreation Center on Marlborough Drive. Eighty-five percent of the precincts in the Eighty-Fifth House District are the exact same Kempsville neighborhoods that elected Katie to City Council in 2010."

Dad leaned over the table, studying the precinct map carefully before looking back up at Katie.

“I know my daughter, and I know that once the two of you set your minds to something, nobody in Virginia is going to stop you,” Dad said proudly, though his voice turned serious and practical as he switched into systems-engineer problem-solving mode. “So let’s brainstorm this right now from start to finish before the calendar flips to 2013. Walk me through every step between tonight and swearing-in day in January 2014. First question: Virginia Beach City Council is non-partisan under state law. If you run for the Virginia House of Delegates against Richard Tatum next November, you have to declare a party ballot line. How are you filing?”

“I’m running as a Democrat—Katie Prairie, D-Virginia Beach,” Katie said without a second’s hesitation. “City Council elections are non-partisan by law, so party labels weren’t on the ballot in 2010, but you, Nate, and I have been Democrats our entire lives. Nate and I grew up in a Democratic household watching you vote for the Democratic ticket in every election, Dad. Back when we were teenagers in high school, we would have gladly voted for the Democratic candidates right alongside you if we’d been old enough to cast a ballot, and the three of us have voted Democrat in every single local, state, and federal election since the day Nate and I turned eighteen. Ron Villa has always been fair to us on bus shelters from the Republican side because he came up through City Council, but the House majority caucus in Richmond just spent the whole 2012 session cutting public transit, blocking healthcare expansion, and starving disability services. If I’m going up to Richmond to fight for working families, bus riders, and disabled Virginians, I’m running proudly under the party banner the three of us have always believed in.”

“Damn right,” Dad nodded with a proud grin, pulling a yellow legal pad and a ballpoint pen toward his elbow. “The three of us have never hidden what we stand for. Second question: what happens to your Kempsville seat on the Virginia Beach City Council during the campaign—and what happens to your software business here at home if you win?”

“Under Virginia law, a sitting City Council member does not have to resign her municipal seat just to run for the General Assembly,” I explained, opening the Code of Virginia tab I had bookmarked in our browser. “Katie’s four-year City Council term runs through 2014, and the House of Delegates election is in November 2013. That means Katie keeps representing Kempsville on the Virginia Beach City Council through the entire 2013 campaign so our neighbors never lose their vote at City Hall. Once she wins the House seat in November 2013, she’ll serve through the final December 2013 Council meeting and then formally resign her City Council seat effective December 31, 2013—right before taking her oath in the House of Delegates on the second Wednesday in January 2014.”

“And because the Virginia General Assembly is a part-time citizen legislature,” Katie added, “session only runs for sixty days in even-numbered years and forty-five days in odd-numbered years during January and February. Ten months out of every year, Nate and I stay right here in our house off Military Highway in Kempsville running our software business and riding CVTA buses around the district. For January and February, we’ll rent a one-bedroom accessible apartment right on a JRTC bus route in Richmond.”

Dad wrote *Jan–Feb: 60/45-day Winter Session (Richmond Bus Route Apt)* at the top of his legal pad, then tapped his pen below it.

“Alright—now walk me through the official election-law timeline under Title 24.2 of the Code of Virginia,” Dad said. “What paperwork has to be filed between January 1, 2013 and the ballot deadline so Tatum’s lawyers can’t try to knock you off the ballot on a technicality?”

I rotated the second browser tab toward Dad, where Katie and I had already built a step-by-step statutory checklist.

“Step one happens on January 2, 2013,” I said. “We file Katie’s Statement of Organization with the Virginia State Board of Elections in the COMET campaign finance system, register *Katie Prairie for Delegate*, and open a dedicated campaign checking account at our credit union within ten days. Under state law, every candidate committee has to designate an official Campaign Treasurer who lives in Virginia. Katie and I want me to serve as Campaign Manager and Chief Technology Officer—and we want to know if you’ll serve as our official Campaign Treasurer, Dad.”

Dad’s chest swelled visibly behind his glasses. “Try and stop me. I balanced our household books down to the penny when I was putting myself through CCHR after the divorce—I’ll make sure every campaign finance report we file with Richmond reconciles to the cent. What’s step two?”

“Step two is ballot qualification between January 2 and the late-March primary filing deadline,” Katie said, pointing to the four official State Board of Elections forms we had downloaded:

“To qualify for the June Democratic Primary ballot in a House of Delegates district,” Katie explained, “a candidate has to file four things before five o’clock on the March filing deadline: first, the Certificate of Candidate Qualification under Section 24.2-501 certifying that I’m a qualified voter and resident of the Eighty-Fifth House District; second, the Declaration of Candidacy under Section 24.2-520 along with the party primary filing fee paid to the Virginia Beach Treasurer; third, the General Assembly Statement of Economic Interests under Section 30-111 disclosing our fifty-fifty software company and our house here in Kempsville; and fourth—the most important part—the Petition of Qualified Voters under Section 24.2-506.”

“How many valid voter signatures does the Code of Virginia require for a House of Delegates candidate?” Dad asked, poised with his pen.

“The statute requires a minimum of one hundred and twenty-five signatures from qualified, registered voters residing inside the Eighty-Fifth House District, witnessed by a circulator who signs the affidavit on the back of each legal-sized petition sheet before a notary public,” I said. “Professional campaigns sometimes get sloppy and turn in two hundred signatures, and then get disqualified when fifty of the signers turn out to live across the street in the Eighty-First or Twenty-First District. So we aren’t turning in one hundred and twenty-five signatures. We’re going to collect four hundred verified Eighty-Fifth District signatures—and before a single voter signs our clipboard, I’m going to look up their street address live on my laptop against the official Eighty-Fifth District registered-voter file so we have a one-hundred-percent validity rate.”

“And where are we collecting those four hundred signatures?” Dad asked with a grin, already guessing the answer.

“Right at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus transfer loop, along the Kempsville Road and Princess Anne Road bus stops, and out on the neighborhood sidewalks every Saturday morning in January and February,” Katie smiled, reaching across our armrests to take my hand while extending her other hand across the table to Dad. “No paid petition mercenaries from out of town. Just the three of us.”

Dad placed his large, warm hand over both of ours in the center of the kitchen table.

“Then on Saturday, January fifth, I’m driving down from Alexandria with three legal-sized clipboards and a box of black pens,” Dad said. “Let’s put a bus rider in the House of Delegates.”

January to December 2013 — 412 Signatures at CCHR, Canvassing the 85th District, & Passing the Baton on City Council

On the first Saturday morning of January 2013, right after Katie and I filed her Statement of Organization with Dad listed as Treasurer, the three of us set up at the edge of the concrete passenger island at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus loop.

Every time a CVTA Route 12, Route 25, Route 29, or Route 33 bus pulled into the college transfer hub, dozens of Kempsville residents stepped off the doors and recognized Katie immediately as the twenty-seven-year-old City Councilwoman in the black SwiftChair who had fought to keep their evening buses running until ten-thirty at night.

“Councilwoman Prairie! Are those petitions to run for State Delegate against Richard Tatum?” a CCHR nursing instructor asked excitedly on our very first morning, spotting the legal-sized State Board of Elections sheets clipped to Katie’s lap tray. “Give me a pen right now—and wait two seconds while I call my husband and my daughter over from the Route 12 shelter so they can sign too!”

With Dad standing beside our wheelchairs holding the extra clipboards and signing the circulator affidavits in front of a mobile notary at the end of each afternoon, and with me verifying every signer’s address and precinct number on my laptop on the spot, we didn’t just hit the statutory minimum of one hundred and twenty-five signatures—by the end of February, we had collected four hundred and twelve verified signatures from registered Eighty-Fifth District voters.

When the five-o’clock primary filing deadline closed on the last Thursday of March 2013, not a single Democratic challenger had filed against a popular sitting Kempsville City Councilwoman who had turned in four hundred and twelve bulletproof grassroots signatures. The Virginia State Board of Elections officially certified Katie as the Democratic Nominee for the Eighty-Fifth House District without the expense of a June primary.

Two days later, a pair of sleek political consultants from Richmond rode down I-64 and asked to meet us at a restaurant near Pembroke Commons. Spreading glossy brochures across the table, they informed Katie that to run a “serious” House of Delegates campaign in Virginia Beach, she needed to pay their firm a forty-thousand-dollar retainer to lease the state party’s voter-targeting software, hire an out-of-state direct-mail agency, and host high-dollar donor receptions at Oceanfront hotels.

Katie and I listened politely, took a sip of our ginger ales, and turned their entire forty-thousand-dollar sales pitch down flat.

"My brother and I are professional software engineers," Katie told the stunned consultants before we rolled out to catch our bus home. "Nate already wrote our custom PHP precinct-mapping and voter-turnout engine for my 2010 City Council victory, and it runs faster, cleaner, and with better precinct math than anything on K Street. Every dollar small donors give our campaign is going straight into printing accessible literature and reaching voters in Kempsville—not paying commissions to Richmond consultants."

From April through November 2013, the three of us ran the most disciplined grassroots campaign the Eighty-Fifth District had ever seen.

Every weekday after our software client work and Katie's City Council duties, Katie and I rode CVTA buses across the district and rolled down the residential sidewalks of Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur. Whenever a house had two or three brick steps up to the front porch, Dad—who drove down from Alexandria every Friday night through Sunday evening, joined during the weekdays by a dozen volunteer CCHR students and fellow bus riders—walked up the steps to knock on the door while Katie and I parked our SwiftChairs right at the bottom of the front walk so the homeowner could step out onto the porch and talk directly with Katie eye-to-eye.

By mid-October, internal polling showed that Katie had erased Delegate Richard Tatum's twelve-point incumbent cushion.

Panicking during the final ten days of the race, Tatum's Richmond campaign consultants dropped a glossy, full-color attack mailer into every mailbox in Kempsville showing a photograph of the steps of the State Capitol with the headline: *THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY MOVES FAST—CAN KATIE PRAIRIE KEEP UP?* Inside, the mailer sneered that Katie "doesn't even hold a driver's license" and claimed that two twenty-eight-year-old twins who rode the city bus would be "out of their depth in Richmond."

The backlash across Virginia Beach was instantaneous.

Disabled veterans from Naval Air Station Oceana and Little Creek, parents of special-needs children at Morrison Middle School and Northwood High School, senior citizens along Kempsville Road, and hundreds of commuters who rode the evening buses Katie had championed on City Council flooded the local newspaper letters page and local television broadcasts with outrage. Even former At-Large City Councilman and sitting Republican Delegate Ronald Villa over in the neighboring Twenty-First District told a Norfolk newspaper reporter on the record, *"Anyone who thinks Katie and Nate Prairie can't keep up at the State Capitol has never watched those two work a transportation budget."*

On Election Night—Tuesday, November 5, 2013—sitting side by side with Dad at our kitchen table in Kempsville tracking the eighteen precincts of the Eighty-Fifth House District on my PHP dashboard, we watched the final returns lock in at 8:15 PM:

Katie Prairie (D): 54.4% — Richard Tatum (R, Incumbent): 45.6%.

At twenty-eight years old, my twin sister was officially Delegate-Elect Katie Prairie of the Eighty-Fifth House District.

Over the next eight weeks of November and December 2013, we completed every statutory transition step between Election Night and Opening Day:

First, on the Wednesday and Thursday after the election, the three-member Virginia Beach Electoral Board met at the Municipal Center to conduct the official canvass of precinct returns, transmitting the certified abstract up to the Virginia State Board of Elections in Richmond under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-675 so the Secretary of the Board could mail Katie her official, gold-sealed Certificate of Election.

Second, during the first week of December, we traveled up to Richmond for the one-day House Clerk's administrative intake—receiving Katie's office assignment in Room 518 on the fifth floor of the General Assembly Building—and met via video conference with attorneys at the Division of Legislative Services to draft and pre-file her first three legislative bills on regional transit funding, developmental-disability Medicaid waiver slots, and statewide ADA building enforcement ahead of the December pre-filing deadline.

Third, on the third Tuesday evening of December 2013, Katie rolled up the permanent ramp to the Virginia Beach City Council dais at the Municipal Center one last time. After casting her final municipal votes and thanking the people of Kempsville for three unforgettable years of service on City Council, Katie formally submitted her resignation from the non-partisan Kempsville Council seat effective at 11:59 PM on December 31, 2013—welcoming her newly elected Kempsville Council successor, Councilwoman Amelia Thornton, so she would never hold dual municipal and state legislative office when her House term began.

When Katie and I rolled out of the Municipal Center at nine-thirty that December night and boarded the 9:45 PM CVTA Route 33 bus that she had fought to create, the driver saluted her from behind the wheel.

"Next stop for you two is the State Capitol up in Richmond, Delegate-Elect Prairie!" the driver beamed.

"Only for forty-five and sixty days every winter," Katie smiled, holding my hand across the center aisle between our two wheelchair bays as the bus rolled toward CCHR. "And on Friday, January third, Nate and I are moving into an apartment right on West Broad Street so we can ride the Richmond city bus to the Capitol too."

Freshman Session on West Broad Street & Riding JRTC Route 6 to the Capitol

Part 1: The West Broad Street Loft, Making Up the Decoy Bed for Our Closet Sanctuary, & Weekend Reconnaissance on JRTC Route 6

Date: 2014-01-03 at 14:15 America/New_York

Friday, January 3, 2014, 2:15 PM — Five Days Ahead of Opening Day at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts

“I still apologize that we only had a one-bedroom accessible apartment left on the ground floor for the legislative session, Delegate Prairie,” the property manager of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts said nervously as he held open the wide oak door of Apartment 104 and handed twenty-eight-year-old Katie two brass keys and a pair of electronic lobby fobs. “When the General Assembly convenes every January, the two-bedroom corporate units book up months in advance. If you and your brother need us to roll a folding cot into the living room—”

“No cot needed at all, Mr. Davenport, thank you,” Katie said with a warm, reassuring smile from her compact black SwiftChair as she rolled smoothly across the threshold ahead of me and our fifty-five-year-old dad. “A one-bedroom apartment with one queen bed is actually the exact layout my brother and I asked for.”

Behind us, pushing a wheeled bellhop cart loaded with our two dark-blue comforter bags from home, our dual laptop stands, and two plastic crates of kitchen staples that he had driven down I-95 from Alexandria in the bed of his pickup truck to meet our morning ARTS train from Norfolk, Dad chuckled softly at the property manager’s polite blink of surprise.

Once Mr. Davenport wished us a good winter in Richmond and stepped back out into the wide brick-and-timber hallway, I clicked the deadbolt shut and looked around our new sixty-day winter sanctuary.

It was Friday, January 3, 2014—five full days before the Virginia General Assembly would gavel in at noon on Wednesday, January 8 for Katie’s very first session representing the Eighty-Fifth House District back home in Kempsville and Virginia Beach.

When Katie had flipped the Eighty-Fifth District seat two months earlier in November 2013—running on the exact public-transit, disability-access, and working-family platform we had spent the previous eight years championing on Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit—party staffers in Richmond had automatically sent us brochures for upscale high-rise apartments down in Shockoe Slip and luxury suites near the downtown hotels where veteran lawmakers stayed during the winter session.

Katie and I had taken one look at the transit map of Richmond and turned every single one of those downtown hotel brochures down.

Instead, we had chosen Apartment 104 inside the Broad & Boulevard Lofts—a renovated brick warehouse building on West Broad Street right near Boulevard at the edge of Scott’s Addition and the Museum District. The building had a flush concrete entrance off the wide West Broad Street sidewalk with zero steps, blue ADA push-button automatic doors, forty-two-inch interior doorways, low-pile commercial carpet, and a roll-in bathroom with steel grab bars. Even better, thirty feet outside the front lobby glass stood a blue-and-white bus stop sign for the James River Transit Company—Richmond’s public bus network, universally known across the capital region as the JRTC Transit System.

“Come look at this view out the living room windows, Nate,” Katie called out, rolling her SwiftChair across the open floor plan toward the two tall industrial sash windows facing south over West Broad Street.

I rolled up beside her left armrest while Dad carried our bedding bags into the bedroom. Right below our first-floor windowsill, a blue-and-white forty-foot JRTC Stalwart low-floor transit bus with an amber LED destination sign reading *6 BROAD STREET — DOWNTOWN / CAPITOL* glided past the curb.

“Four separate JRTC trunk routes converge right along this stretch of West Broad Street,” I said, resting my hand over Katie’s fingers on her armrest as we watched a westbound bus pass in the opposite lane thirty seconds later. “Route 6 runs straight down Broad Street past the Science Museum and Central Virginia University to Ninth and Broad at Capitol Square in eleven minutes, and straight west to the shops and grocery store at Oak Lawn in ten minutes.”

“And arriving five days early gives us all of Saturday and Sunday to learn the bus routes, test every transfer stop, and get our routine locked down before Monday morning’s New Member Orientation even starts,” Katie said, letting out a quiet, contented breath as her shoulders relaxed.

Because both of us were autistic, rolling cold into an unfamiliar city and a brand-new legislative building on the same morning would have been a recipe for sensory overload. Coming up to Richmond five days ahead of Wednesday’s Opening Day gavel wasn’t a vacation; it was how Katie and I mapped our perimeter so that by the time the session bell rang, every doorway, curb cut, bus stop, and timetable between our bed and the House Floor felt completely predictable.

We rolled into the bedroom to help Dad finish unpacking.

Although the apartment came furnished with a solid oak queen bedframe, a firm mattress, and two nightstands, all three of us knew that bed was strictly for appearances while Katie and I slept inside the walk-in closet—yet we still didn’t want stiff, bleach-scented corporate rental linens filling the room. Dad had already stripped off the rental bedspread onto the top shelf, spreads of our own cotton sheets and navy-blue comforter went across the decoy mattress, and then the three of us cleared the carpeted floor of the spacious walk-in closet and unrolled our thick double sleeping bag and four pillows inside.

“There,” Katie said happily, glancing from our cozy walk-in closet sanctuary to the familiar comforter while I plugged our dual powerchair chargers into the wall outlet beside the closet doorway. “Now it smells like home.”

Out in the front room, Dad helped us push the rectangular oak dining table right up in front of the tall windows overlooking West Broad Street. Within forty minutes, we had our two MagnaBook Pro laptops, our dual twenty-four-inch external monitors, our hardware firewall router, and our portable video-capture encoder cabled neatly across the tabletop.

Before Dad headed back out to his pickup truck at five-thirty to beat the Friday evening traffic north up I-95 to his house on Sunset Drive in Alexandria, he stood by the front door and pulled both of us into a long, tight hug across our wheelchair armrests.

“If anybody at that Capitol gives my daughter or my son a hard time next week, you call me,” Dad said fiercely, kissing the top of Katie’s blonde head and clapping my shoulder.

“We’ll be fine, Dad,” Katie smiled, hugging him back as I squeezed his forearm. “We’ve got each other, we’ve got our laptops, and we’ve got a bus stop thirty feet from the front door.”

That Friday night, after eating a quiet supper of toasted cheese sandwiches and tomato soup at our window table while watching the headlights and blue-and-white JRTC buses roll down West Broad Street, Katie and I parked our two SwiftChairs beside the untouched queen bed in our exposed-brick bedroom and transferred down into our quilted navy-blue sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of the walk-in closet. Wrapping both arms closely around each other with Katie’s cheek resting against my chest—feeling the calming deep pressure that always grounded us best in a brand-new city—we drifted off to sleep safe inside our new Richmond perimeter.

Saturday & Sunday, January 4–5, 2014 — Buying Regular 30-Day JRTC Passes & Mapping the Broad Street Spine

At nine o’clock on Saturday morning, bundled up in our matching winter parkas, knit gloves, and wool scarves with our canvas backpacks hooked behind our wheelchair headrests, Katie and I rolled out the automatic glass doors of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts to the West Broad Street bus stop.

The January air was crisp and clear at thirty-six degrees. Three minutes after we braked our SwiftChairs on the concrete waiting pad alongside a Central Virginia University nursing student and two restaurant cooks heading downtown for the Saturday lunch shift, an eastbound JRTC Route 6 Stalwart low-floor bus pulled smoothly to the curb.

The air brakes hissed, and as the front doors folded open and the front air suspension dropped four inches toward the sidewalk, the bus’s external automated voice annunciator spoke through the doorway speaker in its crisp, unmistakable cadence—announcing the route once as the doors opened before switching to the safety warnings as the stainless-steel front flip-ramp folded out onto the concrete:

“Route 6. Downtown. Welcome aboard JRTC!”

“Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!”

“Morning, folks! Watch your roll coming aboard,” the JRTC operator called out cheerfully, reaching down to flip up the two bench seats over the front left and right wheelchair securement bays.

“Good morning!” Katie said brightly as she rolled up the gentle slope of the low-floor ramp first and backed her SwiftChair deftly into the curbside wheelchair bay, while I rolled right up behind her into the street-side bay across the narrow aisle.

“Caution: lift is stowing!” the automated voice announced as the stainless-steel ramp folded back into the front threshold step with a solid clank.

After the operator clicked the four-point retractable floor straps onto our wheelchair frames and returned to his seat, Katie and I each reached forward to the farebox beside the steering column and fed crisp dollar bills into the bill validator to pay our standard one-dollar-and-fifty-cent base fares like any other rider in Richmond.

“Where are you two headed this cold Saturday morning?” the operator asked as he pulled the forty-foot bus back into the eastbound lane of West Broad Street.

“Ninth and Broad first so we can roll over to the JRTC customer service window and buy our thirty-day unlimited magnetic swipe passes for the winter,” Katie replied, holding my hand across the center aisle between our two wheelchair bays. “We’re staying right back there at Broad and Boulevard through the middle of March.”

“Well, you picked the best bus line in the city of Richmond to live on,” the driver said with a proud grin in his wide rearview mirror. “Between the 6, the 1, the 2, and the 3, you won’t ever wait more than ten minutes on Broad Street from six in the morning till midnight.”

As the bus rolled straight east down the wide six-lane boulevard—passing the domed neoclassical rotunda of the Science Museum of Virginia in the old Broad Street Union Station, the brick dormitories and classrooms of Central Virginia University around Monroe Park, and the historic storefronts of the Arts District—I had my pocket notebook open on my lap tray, logging the exact travel times and stop spacing while the interior automated voice announced every single cross street we passed, whether there was a bus stop on that block or not:

“Robinson Street.”

“Mulberry Street.”

“Allison Street.”

“Meadow Street.”

“Lombardy Street.”

“Belvidere Street.”

“Listen to the onboard GPS annunciator, Katie,” I murmured with an appreciative grin as the voice called out *“First Street”*, *“Second Street”*, *“Third Street”* in steady sequence down the straight Broad Street corridor. “It announces every single cross street along the route even when it isn’t a bus stop—and whenever a JRTC bus completes a turn, it announces both streets on the corner. For a blind rider or someone visiting Richmond for the first time, you always know down to the exact block where you are.”

“Eighth Street. Ninth Street.”

Eleven minutes after boarding outside our apartment, the bus pulled up to the curb at Ninth and Broad Street—directly across from the tall granite tower of the General Assembly Building and the wrought-iron gates of Capitol Square.

“Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!”

After thanking the driver and rolling down the front ramp onto the brick sidewalk at Ninth and Broad, Katie and I stopped by the downtown transit ticket counter, paid sixty dollars apiece out of our own checking account for two standard thirty-day unlimited JRTC magnetic swipe passes, and spent the next three hours testing the entire downtown pedestrian and transit grid in our powerchairs.

We rolled down the Ninth Street hill to Ninth and Main to time the bus transfer down to Richmond Main Street Station in Shockoe Bottom—listening at the intersection corner as a turning bus announced externally to the crosswalk, *"Caution! Bus is turning right. Pedestrians, look both ways!"* followed inside by both street names as it straightened out onto Main Street. We tested the exterior brick ramps leading into Capitol Square and located the ground-level accessible entrance on the north terrace of Thomas Jefferson's historic white-columned State Capitol. We checked the elevator lobby inside the General Assembly Building at Ninth and Broad, noting exactly how many minutes it took to roll from the Route 6 bus stop curb into the building, clear the security magnetometer, and ride up to the fifth-floor legislative offices.

Then, at one-thirty in the afternoon, we rolled back out to the westbound bus shelter at Ninth and Broad. When the outbound bus pulled up to the curb and the front doors folded open, the automated voice announced once across the sidewalk:

"Route 6. Oak Lawn. Welcome aboard JRTC!"

"Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!"

Rolling aboard, we swiped our new thirty-day JRTC magnetic passes through the farebox reader with a clean electronic *beep* and rode Route 6 all the way past our apartment building out West Broad Street to the Oak Lawn transfer center.

Rolling down the wide sidewalk of the open-air Oak Lawn shopping plaza, we went straight into the Market Square supermarket. With an insulated canvas grocery carrier clipped to the rear frame of each of our SwiftChairs and two hand baskets resting on our lap trays, Katie and I spent an hour picking out two weeks' worth of breakfast cereal, milk, whole-wheat bread, sliced turkey, pasta, fresh apples, and three twelve-packs of ginger ale.

By four o'clock Saturday afternoon, we had ridden JRTC Route 6 ten blocks back east to our apartment stop at Broad and Boulevard, unloaded our groceries into our kitchen cabinets, and spent Sunday afternoon sitting side by side at our front window table writing a two-thousand-word weekend dispatch for Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit:

> *What Hampton Roads Can Learn from Richmond's Broad Street Trunk Line: How JRTC Uses a Straight Six-Mile Spine to Deliver Ten-Minute Service*

By Sunday night, we knew every bus stop, every curb cut, and every timetable along Broad Street by heart. We were ready for Monday morning.

Part 2: Gold License Plates vs. JRTC Route 6, Turning Down the Parking Deck Pass, & The 60-Inch ADA Restroom Showdown

Date: 2014-01-06 at 08:15 America/New_York

Monday, January 6, 2014, 8:15 AM — The First Time Richmond Politicians See a Delegate Roll Off the City Bus

At eight-fifteen on Monday morning—forty-eight hours before the 2014 General Assembly would formally convene—the intersection of Ninth and Broad Street outside the General Assembly Building looked like a luxury auto dealership convention.

All along the curb leading toward the private legislative parking deck at Seventh and Marshall, gleaming black luxury sedans and massive chrome-trimmed SUVs idled in a bumper-to-bumper line. Nearly every bumper bore a special gold-embossed state license plate reading *VIRGINIA — HOUSE OF DELEGATES* or *VIRGINIA — SENATE*, stamped with the lawmaker's low seniority number. On the wide brick sidewalk flanking the bronze revolving doors of the General Assembly Building, groups of veteran Delegates, State Senators in tailored wool overcoats, and high-priced corporate lobbyists stood clutching leather briefcases and paper coffee cups from the downtown luxury hotels, trading back-slaps and committee gossip in the cold morning sunshine.

None of them paid the slightest attention to the public JRTC bus stop sign planted at the curb thirty feet from the General Assembly Building's accessible side doors—where half a dozen state clerical workers and hospital aides were waiting to step off the morning bus.

With a low rumble of its diesel engine and a crisp hiss of air brakes, our eastbound blue-and-white JRTC Route 6 Broad Street bus pulled up to the Ninth and Broad curb stop after calling out *"Eighth Street"* and *"Ninth Street"* inside the cabin.

As the front doors folded open, the external automated voice rang out across the sidewalk:

"Route 6. Downtown. Welcome aboard JRTC!"

"Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!"

Inside the front vestibule, where Katie and I had just ridden the eleven-minute trip down from Broad and Boulevard after swiping our regular sixty-dollar monthly passes at the farebox, the operator unhooked our floor straps as the stainless-steel wheelchair ramp settled onto the brick sidewalk.

"Have a great first week at the Capitol, Katie and Nate!" the operator called out warmly over his shoulder. "Show 'em how we do things on Route 6!"

"Thank you, Marcus! See you at five-thirty this evening!" Katie called back cheerfully.

Wearing a tailored royal-blue wool blazer over a crisp white blouse—with the small gold seal of the Virginia House of Delegates pinned to her left lapel and her leather legislative portfolio resting on her lap tray—twenty-eight-year-old Freshman Delegate Katie Prairie eased her joystick forward and rolled her compact black SwiftChair briskly down the city bus ramp onto the Ninth and Broad sidewalk.

Three seconds later, wearing my charcoal wool jacket with both of our MagnaBook Pro laptops strapped securely across my lap tray, I rolled my matching SwiftChair down the bus ramp right behind my twin sister.

"Caution: lift is stowing!" the automated voice announced behind us as the bus ramp folded back up with a hydraulic *clank* and the blue-and-white JRTC bus pulled away into the Broad Street traffic.

Outside the General Assembly Building doors, the morning chatter stopped dead.

Six veteran Delegates, two senior State Senators who had just stepped out of a town car, and a circle of corporate telecommunications lobbyists standing beside the granite columns all froze in their tracks. Three of the lobbyists literally lowered their coffee cups halfway from their mouths, staring from the retreating tailpipe of the city transit bus to the gold House of Delegates member pin gleaming on the lapel of Katie's blazer as our two power wheelchairs rolled side by side toward the entrance.

One of the veteran lawmakers—a silver-haired, five-term Delegate from Northern Virginia who sat on the House Transportation Committee and still had his gold-plated SUV keys dangling from his gloved fingers—took two steps across the brick sidewalk and blinked down at us in utter bewilderment.

"Excuse me—Delegate-Elect Prairie?" he stammered, glancing back over his shoulder toward the empty bus stop curb as if checking for a hidden camera crew. "From the Eighty-Fifth District in Virginia Beach?"

"Good morning, Delegate!" Katie said brightly, braking her SwiftChair beside mine to shake his hand. "And this is my twin brother, business partner, and volunteer data strategist, Nathaniel Prairie."

"Did—did the two of you just get off the *city bus*?" the veteran Delegate asked, his voice loud enough that a dozen other lawmakers and lobbyists turned their heads to listen. "Don't you have a handicap van or a legislative driver? The Clerk's office reserves oversized accessible spaces on the ground level of the Seventh Street legislative parking deck for members!"

Katie exchanged a quick, amused twin look with me before looking back up at him with complete, unbothered sincerity.

"Why on earth would we drive a car in downtown traffic when JRTC Route 6 picks us up thirty feet outside our apartment on West Broad Street every ten minutes and drops us right here at the front door of the General Assembly Building?" Katie asked smoothly. "A thirty-day unlimited JRTC bus pass costs sixty dollars at the ticket window, the low-floor ramp takes ten seconds to deploy, and my brother and I get to spend our eleven-minute commute talking with the regular working people of Richmond who ride the bus every day. That's how we commute back home on CVTA in Virginia Beach and Norfolk too."

Around the entrance plaza, several lobbyists exchanged stunned glances—realizing at once that the twenty-eight-year-old software developer from Virginia Beach who had just unseated an incumbent by campaigning from her power wheelchair on public buses wasn't doing it as a campaign-season photo op. She actually lived it every single day.

Five minutes later, when we rolled inside the warm marble lobby of the General Assembly Building and checked in at the Clerk's administrative orientation table, the facilities coordinator smiled and slid a thick manila packet across the counter toward Katie's lap tray.

"Welcome to Richmond, Delegate Prairie," the coordinator said, holding up a plastic windshield RFID transponder alongside a DMV application form for special official *HOUSE OF DELEGATES* license plates. "Because both you and your brother use power wheelchairs, we went ahead and blocked off two contiguous van-accessible spaces right next to the basement tunnel elevator in the General Assembly Parking Deck. Here is your garage transponder and your legislative license-plate form."

Katie gently pushed the plastic garage transponder and the *HOUSE OF DELEGATES* license-plate application right back across the counter.

"Thank you so much for thinking of us," Katie said kindly, "but neither Nate nor I can drive due to our medical restrictions, and neither of us owns a car—so there isn't any vehicle to put House of Delegates license plates on. Whenever anyone does drive us in a private vehicle, the only person we want behind the wheel is our dad in his own truck, and as a State Delegate I'm thankfully not the President of the United States being forced to ride around in an armored Secret Service limousine. We bought our thirty-day JRTC bus passes on Saturday and we're riding Route 6 down Broad Street every morning and evening. Please reassign those two ground-floor parking spaces to Capitol custodians or building maintenance staff who have to drive in before dawn—they deserve a close parking spot a whole lot more than we do."

The orientation clerk stared at the returned garage transponder on the table as if nobody in the four-hundred-year history of the Virginia General Assembly had ever voluntarily given back a reserved downtown parking pass.

Monday Afternoon & Tuesday, January 6–7, 2014 — The Steel Tape Measure & The 60-Inch ADA Restroom Showdown

While Katie didn't care one bit about a VIP parking space or a gold license plate, we discovered at one-thirty that Monday afternoon what she *was* willing to go to war over before her first session even gaveled in.

After spending the morning getting our legislative network credentials, setting up Katie's new fifth-floor office in Room 518 of the General Assembly Building, and eating a quick lunch in the basement cafeteria, Katie and I rode the elevator down to the underground concourse tunnel and rolled up into the first floor of the historic State Capitol to inspect the accessible desk that the Clerk's staff had modified for her at the end of the minority aisle on the House Floor.

The desk itself on the green carpet of the House Chamber was fine—they had removed the standard mahogany swivel chair so Katie's compact SwiftChair could roll straight under the writing surface within easy reach of the gooseneck microphone and the electronic voting buttons.

The problem came ten minutes later, when we rolled out into the first-floor marble corridor near the House cloakroom and Katie went to use the nearest ladies' restroom while I rolled toward the men's room next door.

Less than thirty seconds after Katie pushed her way past the heavy, spring-loaded solid-oak outer door of the women's restroom—which didn't even have a blue ADA automatic push-button opener on the wall—she backed right back out into the corridor with her jaw set and a familiar flash of storm-cloud steel in her blue eyes.

At the exact same moment, I backed my SwiftChair out of the men's restroom entrance twenty feet down the hall.

"How bad is the women's side?" I asked, rolling quickly up beside her.

"Go look inside the doorway while it's empty, Nate," Katie said tightly, reaching into the side pocket of my backpack and pulling out the twenty-five-foot retractable steel tape measure we always carried for site audits. "It's the exact same fake 'retrofitted' stall they have up on the fifth floor near our office."

I checked that the restroom was unoccupied and looked inside the entrance as Katie pulled out the yellow steel tape blade and measured the end stall.

Whoever had signed off on the restroom renovation twenty years earlier had clearly never sat in a wheelchair a day in their life. They had simply bolted two chrome grab bars onto the tile wall of a forty-two-inch-wide stall at the end of a narrow forty-inch aisle and hung an *ACCESSIBLE* plaque on a stall door that swung *inward* toward the porcelain toilet bowl.

When Katie rolled her compact SwiftChair inside the stall frame, her front footrests stopped two inches short of the toilet bowl while the rear battery casing of her wheelchair still stuck eight inches out past the door jamb—making it physically impossible to pull the inward-swinging stall door closed behind her. To use the restroom at all, any wheelchair user would either have to leave the stall door wide open to the entire room or take two separate elevators down through the underground tunnel to a single unisex medical restroom in the far basement corner of the complex—a twenty-minute round trip that would cause a sitting Delegate to miss roll-call floor votes.

"Forty-two inches wide by fifty-four inches deep, with an inward-swinging door and zero sixty-inch turning circle," I said, writing the exact measurements into my notebook while Katie snapped the steel tape measure back into its casing. "That fails federal ADA Accessibility Guidelines Section 4.17.3 on three separate counts."

"And there are plenty of extra square feet at the end of both restroom rows if they simply shift the outer laminate partition twelve inches toward the dead vanity corner and reverse the hinges so the stall door swings outward," Katie said, her voice calm, quiet, and utterly immovable. "Come on, Nate. Let's go pay a visit to the Department of General Services Facilities Director before two-thirty."

Ten minutes later, Katie and I rolled our two SwiftChairs side by side into the Capitol Facilities Management suite on the lower level.

When the Deputy Director for Capitol Facilities came out to the reception counter in his gray suit, he offered Katie the indulgent, patronizing smile of a career bureaucrat who assumed a twenty-eight-year-old freshman in the minority party could be brushed off with paperwork jargon.

“Delegate-Elect Prairie, we appreciate your feedback,” the Deputy Director said smoothly, folding his hands across his stomach, “and I assure you that accessibility upgrades are part of our long-term Master Capitol Complex Modernization Plan. However, modifying restroom partitions and installing motorized door actuators in the General Assembly Building and the Capitol requires an architectural engineering review, historical preservation sign-off, and a capital-outlay work order. Realistically, we can put that in the queue for the summer interim after the session adjourns in March.”

Katie didn’t raise her voice by a single decibel. Instead, she set our steel tape measure down on the counter with a crisp *clack* and looked straight up into his eyes from her SwiftChair.

“Let me explain what is actually going to happen between now and Wednesday at twelve o’clock noon,” Katie said evenly. “The partitions on the fifth floor of the General Assembly Building and in the first-floor corridor restrooms outside the House Chamber aren’t Thomas Jefferson’s historic plaster—they’re standard bolt-together powder-coated steel commercial bathroom dividers installed in the nineteen-nineties. Under federal ADA Accessibility Guidelines Section 4.17.3, a standard wheelchair toilet stall is required by federal law to provide a minimum sixty-inch clear width and a stall door that clears the turning envelope. Right now, a sitting member of the Virginia House of Delegates cannot close the bathroom stall door in her own workplace.”

The Deputy Director shifted his weight uncomfortably. “Delegate Prairie, our carpenter and electrical shops are completely booked with pre-session podium setups—”

“At twelve o’clock noon on Wednesday, every television network camera in the Commonwealth of Virginia is going to be rolling live in the House Chamber for Opening Day,” Katie continued without blinking, her left hand resting on my wrist across our wheelchair armrests. “If the fifth-floor restrooms and the first-floor House corridor restrooms do not have outward-swinging stall doors, a full sixty-inch turning clearance, and working ADA push-button outer door openers by five o’clock tomorrow afternoon, my very first act as a sworn Delegate on Wednesday will be rising on a point of personal privilege on live statewide television—and inviting the Speaker of the House and the entire Capitol press corps to follow me out into the hallway with their cameras so the voters of Virginia can watch a female Delegate in a power wheelchair get wedged halfway out of an illegal forty-two-inch bathroom stall door because Facilities told her to wait until March.”

The silence in the Facilities office was absolute.

Behind the reception glass, two maintenance supervisors who had been listening over their clipboards traded a wide-eyed look. The Deputy Director’s face went pale as he pictured the six-o’clock Wednesday evening news showing a newly sworn twenty-eight-year-old Delegate in a wheelchair stuck in an open bathroom stall door while trying to cast her first floor votes.

“I—let me call the carpentry foreman and the electrical shop chief right now,” the Deputy Director said quickly, reaching for his desk telephone. “We have heavy-duty commercial partition brackets and two power-door actuator kits in the maintenance warehouse off Fourteenth Street.”

“Thank you,” Katie said politely, picking our steel tape measure back up off the counter. “Nate and I will be working in Room 518 until five o’clock today and all day tomorrow. Feel free to ask us to test the turning radius with our chairs before your crew bolts the brackets down.”

By four o’clock on Tuesday afternoon—twenty hours before the Opening Day gavel—the carpentry and electrical crews had shifted the end partitions fourteen inches into the dead alcove space, reversed the heavy chrome hinges so the stall doors swung cleanly outward with interior loop pulls, and mounted blue wireless ADA push-button door openers outside both the women’s and men’s restrooms on the fifth floor and outside the House Chamber.

When the head carpenter asked Katie and me to test the finished stalls at four-fifteen on Tuesday, Katie rolled her SwiftChair effortlessly inside, spun a full three-hundred-and-sixty-degree circle without her footrests touching a single wall, pulled the outward-swinging door shut with the interior D-ring handle, and rolled back out to shake every carpenter and electrician’s hand in person.

“Nobody should ever have to beg for the right to close a bathroom door in privacy,” Katie told me quietly as we rolled out the front entrance of the General Assembly Building at five o’clock that Tuesday evening to catch our westbound JRTC Route 6 bus back to Broad and Boulevard.

On Wednesday morning, January 8, 2014, when the blue-and-white JRTC Route 6 bus kneeled at the curb of Ninth and Broad at ten-thirty ahead of the noon Opening Day swearing-in ceremony—with Dad waiting proudly for us on the brick sidewalk outside the Capitol gate in his best navy suit—none of the veteran politicians or lobbyists by the entrance looked surprised anymore when the front wheelchair ramp folded down.

Inside the House of Delegates Chamber at twelve o’clock noon, while Dad stood beside my SwiftChair next to Katie’s modified desk on the first-floor chamber carpet, the Clerk of the House called the freshman class forward to take the constitutional oath of office under Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia.

Just as she had done when she was sworn onto the Virginia Beach City Council three years earlier, Katie didn’t reach for a Bible, and she didn’t pretend to believe in a religion or a god that neither of us believed in. Instead, exercising her explicit constitutional right under Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution, Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia, and Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia to affirm rather than swear—and to omit the optional parenthetical religious phrase at the end—Katie placed her left palm squarely on the gold-stamped cover of the Virginia Constitution resting across my lap tray between our two wheelchairs, raised her right hand toward the Speaker’s rostrum, and spoke her constitutional affirmation as the sole elected Delegate for the Eighty-Fifth District in a clear, ringing voice:

“I do solemnly affirm that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me as a member of the House of Delegates, according to the best of my ability.”

Across the center aisle, three senior opposition delegates immediately craned their necks, whispering indignantly to a political blogger in the front press row that the new twenty-eight-year-old Democrat from Virginia Beach had placed her hand on a copy of the state Constitution instead of a Bible, said “affirm” instead of “swear,” and left out “so help me God.” By five o’clock that evening, conservative talk-radio hosts in Richmond and Tidewater—along with the televangelist commentators on *The 777 Circle* broadcasting out of the Covenant Broadcasting Network studios right off Indian River Road back home in Virginia Beach—were already having a field day over it, only for Katie to tell a Capitol corridor reporter with a calm, unbothered smile as we rolled out to catch our evening bus:

“Have the commentators complaining on television actually read the Constitution of the United States or the Constitution of Virginia? Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution states in plain English that all state legislators shall be bound by Oath or Affirmation to support the Constitution, and that no religious test shall ever be required as a qualification to any office or public trust. And if you open Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia—the exact document I placed my left hand on today—the words ‘or affirm’ and ‘so help me God’ are printed in parentheses specifically because Virginia law guarantees every non-religious citizen the right to make a solemn secular affirmation. I wasn’t elected to be anybody’s pastor, and my left hand belongs on the exact Constitution I just affirmed to the people of Virginia Beach that I would defend.”

Delegate Katie Prairie of Virginia Beach and her twin brother Nate had arrived in Richmond on the city bus, paid their regular fare, watched Katie affirm her constitutional oath of office on the Constitution of Virginia without bowing to a religious test, and made it crystal clear from Day One that the people’s House belonged to everyone.

House Bill 663 & Live on Meet the Nation

Part 1: Line 18, Seated by Delegate Ronald Villa on the Floor, & A Question Across the Chamber

Date: 2016-02-04 at 11:35 America/New_York

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 11:35 AM — The Capitol Tunnel & Splitting Up at the Chamber Doors

“Look at Line 18 on Page 1 again, Nate,” my twin sister Katie said, tapping her yellow highlighter against the two-page bill printout resting on her lap tray as our compact SwiftChairs rolled side by side down the long underground concourse tunnel connecting the General Assembly Building to the historic Virginia State Capitol. “‘Anatomical sex means the physical condition of being male or female, which is determined by a person’s anatomy.’ Not a birth certificate, not a driver’s license, and not how someone lives their daily life—strictly their physical anatomy. And then look at Line 54 on Page 2: ‘Any person who willfully and knowingly violates this section shall be liable for a civil penalty of not more than fifty dollars,’ enforced by a law enforcement officer’s summons.”

“I read it three times while I was setting up the daily calendar script this morning—and even Sam, Mandy, and Sarah spotted the flaw in ten seconds flat when they dropped off the morning floor packet in Room 518,” I replied, steering my wheelchair smoothly beside hers past the subterranean security desk as the fifteen-minute warning bell for the noon floor session chimed from the bronze wall speakers overhead. “Delegate Cobb and Delegate Marsh put it straight onto today’s Second Reading floor calendar out of the General Laws Committee. Because it didn’t come through any of your three committees, they think everybody on the Floor is going to treat it like a routine committee bill and wave it through before lunch.”

It was thirty-year-old Katie’s second two-year term representing the Eighty-Fifth House District back home in Kempsville and Virginia Beach, and she sat as a rank-and-file member of the thirty-four-seat Democratic minority facing a sixty-six-seat Republican supermajority. In the hierarchy of the Virginia House of Delegates, Katie held no leadership office—not Speaker, not Majority or Minority Leader, not Whip, and not a committee gavel. The chamber was presided over from the high marble rostrum by the Republican Speaker of the House, William J. Harwell of Stafford, who referred all legislation to committees and appointed every standing committee roster, while the sixty-six-member Republican majority on the floor was managed from the front row of the center aisle by House Majority Leader Richard Callaway of Danville, flanked by Deputy Majority Leader Todd Gentry, Majority Whip Jackson Milligan, and Republican Caucus Chair Timothy Hughes, across from our Democratic Minority Leader, Tom Toscano, along with Democratic Whip Eileen Fillmore and Democratic Caucus Chair Kenneth Plumley.

As a second-term opposition delegate who used a power wheelchair full-time, medically could not drive, and rode public buses and passenger trains everywhere she went, Katie served on three standing committees where she could do the most practical good for working families: the House Committee on Transportation, the House Committee on Health, Welfare and Institutions, and the House Committee on Education. On the Transportation Committee, whenever a colleague from a suburban district casually remarked in a hearing that “people can always drive,” Katie would look calmly across the committee table from her SwiftChair and reply, “No, they can’t. I took the bus here.”

House Bill 663 had not come through Transportation, Health, Welfare and Institutions, or Education. It had been reported out of someone else’s committee—the House Committee on General Laws, chaired by Delegate Gilbert Peace—where the majority had advanced it to the House Floor without anyone asking what the statutory words actually required a human being to do.

Every day the General Assembly was in session during January and February, the two of us operated by the exact same synchronized routine we had followed since her freshman session in 2014: we woke up in our accessible one-bedroom winter-session apartment at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street, rode the eastbound JRTC Route 6 bus straight down Broad Street to Ninth and Broad, and went over every bill on the daily House calendar line by statutory line the exact same way we audited PHP code or Coastal Virginia Transit Authority bus schedules. Twenty minutes earlier upstairs in Room 518, when our three favorite thirteen-year-old middle-school House Pages—eighth-grade triplets Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins from Southside Virginia, who followed Katie around the Capitol whenever they had a free courier run—had delivered the printed Second Reading calendar packet to Katie’s desk, Katie had handed each of them a copy of House Bill 663.

Thirteen-year-old Sarah had reached the operative language on Line 18 first. She wasn't trying to make a political or constitutional argument; as a literal, rule-following thirteen-year-old autistic girl, she had simply applied the proposed statutory rule to herself—*I am a girl, and this bill says I am allowed into the girls' room because of my anatomy*—read the definition twice, and looked up at Katie with genuine fear in her eyes.

"Delegate Prairie?" Sarah had asked softly, pointing a finger at Line 18 on the page.

"Yeah, Sarah?" Katie had answered.

"Wait," Sarah had said, her voice tight. "Does somebody have to see my parts to prove I'm a girl?"

Katie had stopped reading completely.

Right beside her twin sister, Mandy had immediately looked over Sarah's shoulder at the page. "What?"

"It says which bathroom I can use depends on my anatomy," Sarah had said.

"So how do they know?" their brother Sam had asked, looking up from his copy.

Katie had gently taken the printout back from Sarah's hand. For three seconds, the office had gone dead quiet as my sister read Line 18 and Line 54 again.

"That's a very good question," Katie had said softly.

"Maybe your birth certificate?" Mandy had suggested, squinting at her copy of the bill.

"The bill doesn't say that," Katie had told her.

"A doctor?" Sam had asked.

"Doesn't say that either," Katie had replied.

"But they don't know," Sarah had said literally.

"Right," Katie had agreed.

"Everybody knows Sarah's a girl," Mandy had said reassuringly, taking her sister's hand.

"But how?" Sarah had asked.

"The bill says anatomy," Sam had pointed out. "Not your Page badge, and not how you're dressed."

"Exactly," Katie had said, as the software-developer quality-assurance part of our brains clicked straight into gear. If you stress-tested House Bill 663 the way we stress-tested a software routine before production—input: an accusation that someone used the wrong restroom; required statutory determination: anatomical sex; evidence specified by statute: none; verification procedure: none; authorized

investigator: unspecified; standard of proof: unspecified; privacy protections for minors: unspecified—the entire statute collapsed into a terrifying Fourth Amendment hole.

Looking straight into thirteen-year-old Sarah's eyes first so the frightened eighth-grader would know she was safe, Katie had said gently, "Sarah, nobody should ever have to see your private parts for you to use a bathroom."

Sarah had let out a long, relieved breath. "Okay."

Then Katie had looked back down at the yellow-highlighted text of House Bill 663, her blue eyes hardening into flint. "Which means the Gentleman from Spotsylvania has some explaining to do."

We rode the subterranean elevator up into the historic Capitol and rolled out onto the first-floor marble corridor just outside the tall mahogany double doors of the House Chamber. Lobbyists, school groups, and legislative aides were hurrying past the white marble columns as the ten-minute bell sounded.

At the velvet brass rope flanking the Chamber entrance—where the Sergeant-at-Arms staff checked member pins—Katie braked her SwiftChair and turned toward me.

Ever since our very first visit to the State Capitol back in February 2011—when Capitol Police had stopped us outside the third-floor public viewing gallery because the small historic elevator locked out during fire alarms and there was no safe way to evacuate a wheelchair down three flights of eighteenth-century stairs—House Leadership and the Sergeant-at-Arms had maintained a standing ADA floor pass for me (and any visiting constituent in a wheelchair plus one companion) to watch the daily session from a level wheelchair bay inside the first-floor House Chamber itself, right along the outer right aisle beside our fellow Virginia Beach lawmaker, Delegate Ronald Villa of the Twenty-First District.

"Are you set to plug into the floor feed over by Ron's desk?" Katie asked, reaching across our armrests to give my right hand our familiar twin squeeze.

"All set," I said, patting the padded laptop bag strapped across my lap tray where my MagnaBook Pro and my digital stream-capture rig were tucked alongside our daily legislative binder. "I'll have the chamber stream hooked into my laptop before the Speaker bangs the gavel so I can record and caption your remarks for the constituent archive."

"Wait until Delegate Cobb finishes his floor pitch on House Bill 663," Katie said, her blue eyes steady and focused as she tucked the highlighted two-page printout under her left wrist on the lap tray. "I'm going to ask the Speaker to let me put one direct operational question to him on the record."

"Give him hell, Delegate Prairie," I whispered with a small smile.

"See you at the center doors when we recess," Katie said warmly.

Releasing my hand, my twin sister eased her joystick forward, nodded to the doorkeeper holding open the left-hand mahogany door, and rolled her compact black power wheelchair across the green carpet toward her modified accessible desk at the end of the far left minority aisle.

I flashed my gold-stamped ADA floor pass to the Sergeant-at-Arms assistant at the right-hand doorway and rolled quietly inside to the designated wheelchair bay along the outer right aisle, twenty feet from the ground-level emergency exit.

Right beside my bay, seated at his mahogany desk bearing the brass nameplate *MR. VILLA — VIRGINIA BEACH (21ST DISTRICT)*, Delegate Ronald Villa looked up from his leather binder and gave me a warm, familiar nod.

“Morning, Nate,” Delegate Villa whispered, reaching over to shake my hand just as he had done the very first day the Sergeant-at-Arms had brought Katie and me onto the Floor back in 2011. “How’s the Route 6 bus running down Broad Street this morning?”

“Right on the ten-minute headway, Delegate Villa,” I whispered back with a smile as I flipped down my lap tray, opened my laptop, plugged my headphones into the assistive-listening audio jack at the side rail, and launched my digital capture software hooked into the chamber’s fixed legislative webcast camera.

Looking across the wide expanse of green carpet under the tall cream-and-gold coffered ceiling and crystal chandeliers of the House Chamber, I had a clear, floor-level view of the Speaker’s high marble rostrum at the front of the room, the Clerk’s well, the red-and-green electronic voting boards flanking the front wall, and Katie sitting upright in her compact SwiftChair at her accessible desk across the chamber on the minority aisle, her yellow-highlighted copy of House Bill 663 resting squarely in front of her desk microphone.

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 12:18 PM — Watching Across the House Floor as Katie Challenges the Patron

At twelve o’clock noon on the dot, the Speaker of the House rapped his wooden gavel against the rostrum block.

Up in the third-floor public gallery overhanging the rear wall—where two dozen college students from Virginia Dominion University and Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute, a handful of off-duty teachers, and several parents sat along the wooden benches—and down across the hundred mahogany desks on the Floor, everyone fell silent for the opening prayer, the Pledge of Allegiance, and the routine morning leaves of absence.

By 12:18 PM, the House had moved into the Second Reading calendar of bills reported out of committee. Half the Delegates on the floor were leaning back in their leather swivel chairs chatting with deskmates or flipping through binders while the Clerk read bill titles in a rapid, monotone cadence.

“House Bill 663, a bill to amend the Code of Virginia relating to single-gender public restrooms and facilities in buildings owned or leased by the Commonwealth, public institutions of higher education, and local school divisions; civil penalty. Patron, Delegate Cobb.”

From my wheelchair bay beside the outer right aisle, I clicked the red Record button on my laptop capture window and checked my audio level meters. Right in front of me, I saw Delegate Ronald Villa—a pragmatic coastal Virginia Beach Republican who cared about bus shelters, military families, and Oceanfront tourism, not culture-war stunts—let out a quiet sigh and rub his forehead as the bill was called.

Three rows ahead on the majority side of the House Floor, Delegate Martin Cobb—with his chief co-patron, Delegate Robert Marsh, seated two desks over—stood up behind his mahogany desk, buttoned his navy suit jacket, and leaned into his silver gooseneck microphone.

“Mr. Speaker and members of the House,” Delegate Cobb’s voice echoed across the chamber and came cleanly through my floor headphones, “House Bill 663 is a simple, common-sense measure to protect personal privacy and public safety across the Commonwealth of Virginia. This legislation directs the Department of General Services, every public institution of higher education, and every local school board to ensure that every single-gender public restroom, locker room, and shower facility in any public building or school is used exclusively by individuals whose anatomical sex matches the designated gender on the door—backed by a fifty-dollar civil penalty enforceable by law enforcement summons. I hope it will be the pleasure of the House to engross the bill and advance it to its third reading.”

Across the chamber at the end of the minority aisle, I saw Katie press the white request-to-speak button on her desk console and raise her right hand into the air.

Up on the high marble rostrum, the Speaker glanced down toward the left aisle.

“For what purpose does the gentlewoman from Virginia Beach, Delegate Prairie, rise?” the Speaker asked into his microphone.

Across the green carpet, Katie flipped the toggle switch at the base of her desk microphone so the green indicator ring illuminated, and lifted the two printed pages of House Bill 663 in her right hand.

“Mr. Speaker, to see if the gentleman from Spotsylvania will yield for a question on the bill,” Katie’s voice rang out crisp and clear across the chamber.

“Does the gentleman from Spotsylvania yield to the gentlewoman from Virginia Beach?” the Speaker asked.

Standing at his desk across the center aisle, Delegate Cobb gave a brief, stiff nod. “I yield for a question, Mr. Speaker.”

“The gentleman yields,” the Speaker said.

From my wheelchair on the far side of the floor, I watched my twin sister look straight across the House Chamber at the bill’s patron.

“Thank you, Mr. Speaker,” Katie said. “Look with me for a moment at the exact text printed in House Bill 663, Delegate Cobb. My brother and I write computer software for a living, and when you write code—or when you write a state law—definitions determine how an instruction actually executes in the real world. Unlike bills that reference a birth certificate or a state identification card, your Line 18 on Page 1 explicitly defines anatomical sex as ‘the physical condition of being male or female, which is determined by a person’s anatomy.’ Not their driver’s license. Not how they

are dressed. Their physical anatomy. And then on Page 2, Line 54, you mandate that a law enforcement officer issue a fifty-dollar civil summons at the restroom door based on that physical anatomy."

Across the floor around me, the background murmur of side conversations suddenly died down. Delegates who had been thumbing through their afternoon calendars looked up from their desks.

"The language of the bill speaks for itself, Mr. Speaker," Delegate Cobb replied stiffly into his desk microphone. "Restrooms in state buildings, public colleges, and public schools will be restricted strictly by anatomical sex, and law enforcement officers are authorized to issue a fifty-dollar civil summons to anyone who enters a restroom that does not match their anatomical sex."

Up at the front row of the center aisle, I saw Deputy Majority Leader Todd Gentry lean sharply across the mahogany divider toward House Majority Leader Richard Callaway's desk. Even from my wheelchair bay along the right rail, I could read the urgent tension in Gentry's posture as he whispered, "Richard, Prairie's gutting the bill. Are you going to do something?"

Majority Leader Callaway didn't even look up from the two-page printout of House Bill 663 resting on his leather blotter. "Like what?"

"Stop her!" Gentry hissed under his breath. "Look what she's doing to Cobb."

"She's asking him how his bill works," the Majority Leader murmured dryly, turning Page 1 over to Page 2 with two fingers. "She's reading the bill. And Cobb seems to be doing an adequate job of gutting it himself."

Over at her accessible desk on the far left aisle, Katie released her joystick brake half an inch, rolling her compact SwiftChair flush against the mahogany desk edge as she held the two printed pages of House Bill 663 high in the air. Across the chamber, I could hear the raw, unmistakable fire rising in my sister's voice.

"Mr. Speaker, when the people of Kempsville and Virginia Beach first elected me to serve in this House of Delegates two years ago," Katie declared, her voice echoing off the marble walls of the Capitol chamber, "I had to fight the facilities bureaucracy in this very Capitol complex just to get an ADA-compliant restroom stall wide enough for my power wheelchair to turn around in and close the door in privacy! Every single day of my life since I was sixteen years old, I have known what it feels like to have strangers stare at my body and treat a basic human necessity like using a public restroom as a public spectacle. And now the gentleman comes onto the Floor of this House with House Bill 663 and tells the women and girls of Virginia that the state government is going to police 'anatomical sex' at the door of every ladies' room from Virginia Beach to Blacksburg for a fifty-dollar fine!"

Up in the third-floor public gallery above us, the college students and parents leaned forward over the brass balcony rail, holding their breath. Down on the House Floor, you could have heard a pin drop.

"Then if the gentleman says there will be no physical inspection, how does the Commonwealth establish that someone's anatomical sex does not match the designation of the facility?" Katie demanded, shaking the printed pages of House Bill 663 across the aisle. "How, exactly, is a police officer or a state building inspector standing outside a restroom door at the Community College of Hampton

Roads, or Virginia Dominion University, or right outside in this State Capitol corridor supposed to verify a citizen's 'physical anatomy' before writing your fifty-dollar ticket? If I am accused of being in the wrong women's restroom, what am I supposed to show somebody to prove that I'm female? I return to the exact question a thirteen-year-old girl asked me twenty minutes ago when she read your bill: why on earth should I—or any girl or woman in the Commonwealth of Virginia—have to pull my pants down for a government official or a police officer to prove I have female parts just to use the ladies' room?!"

An audible gasp swept across the chamber, followed half a second later by a sudden burst of applause from the visitors up in the third-floor gallery benches and several sharp "Hear, hear!" calls from the minority desks down on the Floor. Right beside my wheelchair on the Republican side of the floor, Delegate Ronald Villa winced, shook his head at Cobb's bill, and exchanged an unmistakable *she's got him dead to rights* look with his seatmate.

And up at the front row of the center aisle, at the words *a thirteen-year-old girl asked me twenty minutes ago when she read your bill*, I saw House Majority Leader Richard Callaway freeze for half a second and turn his head to look straight back at thirteen-year-old Sarah Hawkins standing at attention in her navy blue House Page blazer behind his desk.

Sarah looked right back at the Majority Leader and gave a single, solemn nod.

Even from across the green carpet, you could practically see the *oh, for heaven's sake—one of my thirteen-year-old Pages found the hole in this bill* realization cross the Majority Leader's face.

Bam! Bam!

"The House will come to order! The House will be in order!" Speaker William J. Harwell barked from the marble rostrum, pounding his wooden gavel twice as he looked up toward the third-floor balcony. "The guests in the public gallery are reminded that demonstrations of approval or disapproval are strictly prohibited by the rules of the House!"

Down on the Republican benches two seats over from Delegate Cobb, the bill's chief co-patron, Delegate Robert Marsh, shot to his feet with his face flushed crimson, stabbing a finger toward his microphone button. "Mr. Speaker! Point of order! The gentlewoman from Virginia Beach is using indecorous language on the floor of this House!"

Before the Speaker could rule—and before Democratic Minority Leader Tom Toscano could even rise from the front row of the left aisle—the Republican Majority Leader himself stood up behind his center-aisle desk.

"Mr. Speaker," Majority Leader Callaway called out calmly.

Up on the rostrum, Speaker Harwell paused with his gavel in hand. "The Majority Leader."

Richard Callaway looked once at Delegate Marsh and Delegate Cobb, and then straight up at the rostrum. "Mr. Speaker, the Gentlewoman's phrasing may be uncomfortable, but the Gentlewoman didn't introduce anatomy into this legislation.

The bill did. The legislation before us expressly makes anatomical sex determinative. I believe she is entitled to ask the patron how the Commonwealth proposes to determine that fact."

A stunned hush fell over all one hundred desks in the chamber.

Across the green carpet, Katie looked at the Republican Majority Leader in quiet amazement—remembering a sentence she would never forget for the rest of her life—before turning her eyes back to the bill's patron.

Out on the majority aisle of the House Floor, Delegate Martin Cobb stood completely frozen behind his desk microphone for four full seconds, his face turning beet-red under the chamber chandeliers as he looked from Katie's power wheelchair to the uneasy, downward stares of his own party colleagues around him.

"I—Mr. Speaker, the bill does not—nobody is suggesting—" Delegate Cobb stammered into his microphone, shuffling his folder on his desk without answering the question.

"Mr. Speaker, that is literally what the words printed on Page 1 and Page 2 of House Bill 663 require!" Katie replied from her SwiftChair, her voice steady, clear, and unflinching across the silent chamber. "Transgender women are women, transgender men are men, and every citizen in this Commonwealth deserves basic human dignity and privacy without politicians stationing bathroom police at the door to inspect people's anatomy. No woman or girl in Virginia should ever have to pull her pants down to prove she has female parts just to use a public restroom!"

Along the Republican rows from Hampton Roads to the Northern Virginia suburbs, I saw half a dozen moderate delegates—starting with Delegate Ronald Villa right beside my wheelchair and Appropriations Chairman S. Christopher Jennings two rows ahead—emphatically shaking their heads at Majority Whip Jackson Milligan. Milligan hurried up the center carpet and leaned down beside the Majority Leader's ear.

"Leader, we're bleeding votes," the Majority Whip murmured urgently.

"How badly?" Richard asked under his breath.

"Badly."

Majority Leader Richard closed his leather binder with a quiet snap, stood up at his front-row desk, and flipped on his microphone. "Pass it by."

"Mr. Speaker," the Majority Leader announced briskly across the chamber, "I move that House Bill 663 be passed by for the day."

"Without objection, House Bill 663 is passed by for the day," Speaker Harwell announced immediately, rapping his gavel once and hurrying straight ahead. "The Clerk will read the next bill on the calendar."

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 12:35 PM — Archiving the 95-Second Clip, “Your Bill Killed Your Bill,” & Rolling Back Through the Tunnel

In my wheelchair bay beside Delegate Villa’s desk, I clicked the Stop button on my capture window and exhaled a quiet breath.

Delegate Villa leaned slightly toward my armrest and whispered out of the corner of his mouth, “Your sister just drove a freight truck straight through the middle of that bill, Nate.”

I gave him a quiet grin and looked down at the timeline bar on my laptop screen while the Clerk moved on to a routine highway-naming bill. Checking the timestamp on the video file I had just recorded from the chamber feed, I saw that the entire floor exchange between Katie and Delegate Cobb ran ninety-five seconds.

Just like I did whenever Katie spoke on a bill on the House Floor, I opened Quantum Code right there on my lap tray, typed out a verbatim, frame-accurate WebVTT closed-caption file for the ninety-five-second video, burned high-contrast open captions along the bottom of the frame so constituents watching on mute could read every word, and uploaded the clip to Katie’s legislative website archive, StreamTube, and The Grid at 12:35 PM with a standard archival heading:

> Delegate Katie Prairie (D-Virginia Beach) Questions HB 663 Patron on the House Floor Regarding “Anatomical Sex” Restroom Enforcement (Feb. 4, 2016)

Twenty-five minutes later, at one o’clock, the House adjourned its Thursday floor session so members could grab lunch before afternoon committee work.

I unplugged my audio cable from the side rail, packed my laptop and capture rig back into my bag, shook Delegate Villa’s hand, and eased my joystick forward to roll toward the right-hand chamber doorway.

Right near the front of the aisle by the Clerk’s well—where Speaker William J. Harwell had just stepped down from the marble rostrum to confer with House Majority Leader Richard Callaway while thirteen-year-old House Page triplets Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins stood dutifully at attention behind the Majority Leader’s desk holding stacks of committee folders—a red-faced Delegate Martin Cobb marched up to the Majority Leader with his copy of House Bill 663 crumpled in his fist.

As I slowed my SwiftChair behind a cluster of departing delegates waiting for the doorway to clear, I heard every word.

“Leader, Prairie ambushed me out there!” Delegate Cobb complained bitterly. “Prairie killed my bill!”

Majority Leader Callaway stopped buttoning his suit coat and looked at the Gentleman from Spotsylvania over the top of his reading glasses.

“No,” Richard said flatly.

“Leader, you heard what she did on the floor!”

“I certainly did,” the Majority Leader replied in his calm, unhurried Danville baritone. “Katie asked how your bill worked.”

For two full seconds, nobody around the Clerk’s well made a sound.

“Your bill killed your bill, Martin,” Richard told him evenly. “And for your information, Sarah found this.”

Delegate Cobb blinked past the Majority Leader’s shoulder at thirteen-year-old Sarah Hawkins standing in her navy blue House Page blazer. “Leader…”

“Sarah is thirteen,” Richard said flatly.

“I understand that.”

“Apparently she understood the bill,” the Majority Leader replied dryly. “You brought a statute onto the House calendar whose central operative concept collapses under the very first implementation question. Supporters will always tell you why your bill is wonderful; opponents will tell you where it breaks. You should’ve put this bill in front of Katie before it ever left committee.”

Delegate Cobb stared at him as if the Majority Leader had lost his mind. “Prairie would’ve opposed it!”

“Of course she would’ve opposed it,” Richard replied. “That’s why you should’ve put it in front of her. Give your bill to the smartest person you know who’s determined to kill it. If it survives her, you might have something.”

Richard glanced half an inch over his shoulder toward the three eighth-grade Pages standing behind his desk.

“Better yet,” the Majority Leader added dryly, “you should’ve given it to Katie and those three Pages who follow her around.”

Cobb blinked at the three teenagers in their navy blue Page blazers. “Sam, Mandy, and Sarah?”

“Yes.”

“They’re thirteen.”

“And apparently none of the four of them were going to let you get away with an undefined enforcement mechanism,” Richard said.

Beside the Clerk’s desk, Speaker Harwell looked from the crumpled printout of House Bill 663 to the three eighth-graders in quiet disbelief. “Three thirteen-year-olds caught this?”

Standing between her brother and her twin sister, thirteen-year-old Sarah nodded solemnly. “We caught it really fast, Mr. Speaker.”

Right behind the Majority Leader’s back, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah clamped their lips tightly together, their shoulders twitching in unison as all three of them tried desperately not to laugh out loud on the House Floor.

Without even turning his head around, the Majority Leader caught them in the reflection of the brass rail.

“And don’t you three start,” Richard muttered—though I could see the corner of his mouth twitching as a thoroughly chastened Delegate Cobb turned on his heel and stalked out the side door.

Speaker Harwell let out a long breath, shook his head, and murmured to his floor leader, “Next time somebody brings us a bill about people’s anatomy, Richard, have Prairie read it first.”

“Actually, Mr. Speaker,” Majority Leader Callaway sighed, rubbing the bridge of his nose as he tucked his binder under his arm, “never bring a bill to this floor that failed Prairie—and have those three read it too.”

Biting the inside of my cheek to keep from grinning from ear to ear, I rolled out the right-hand chamber doorway into the first-floor marble corridor just as Katie came rolling out the left-hand doorway in her SwiftChair.

“Hey,” I said, rolling right up beside her and reaching out to take her left hand. “The ninety-five-second floor clip is captioned and archived on your constituent page—and wait until I tell you what the Majority Leader and the Speaker just told Delegate Cobb by the Clerk’s well. First, when you mentioned on the floor that a thirteen-year-old girl asked you that question twenty minutes ago, the Majority Leader turned right around and looked at Sarah standing behind his desk, and Sarah nodded right back at him! Then when Marsh tried to call you out of order, the Majority Leader stood up and told the whole House that you didn’t introduce anatomy into the legislation, the bill did. And when Cobb complained after the gavel that you killed his bill, the Majority Leader looked him dead in the eye and told him, ‘No, Katie asked how your bill worked—your bill killed your bill, and Sarah found this,’ while Sarah told the Speaker, ‘We caught it really fast!’ The Majority Leader said next time Cobb should have you and Sam, Mandy, and Sarah proofread his legislation before bringing it to the floor!”

Katie’s blue eyes lit up with a mixture of surprise, warmth, and quiet respect as she squeezed my fingers and we turned our wheelchairs side by side toward the elevator down to the underground Capitol tunnel. “Looks like Sarah, Mandy, Sam, and I just became the unofficial House Quality Assurance Department. Even if we sit on opposite sides of the aisle on almost everything else, at least the Majority Leader actually reads the bills. Come on—let’s go grab a sandwich in the basement cafeteria before our two o’clock Transit Legislative Day meetings.”

Part 2: Transit Legislative Day in Room 518, The Six-O’Clock News, & Two Meltdowns Answered by Page Forty-Two

Date: 2016-02-04 at 14:15 America/New_York

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 2:15 PM — Virginia Transit Legislative Day in Room 518 & A Visit from Michael and Rachel Ragsdale

“Permission to roll into the bus delegate’s office?”

Katie and I looked up from the Hampton Roads transit allocation table on her mahogany desk in Room 518—right as the last three Newport News bus operators thanked us in the hallway—and broke into wide grins at the exact same second.

Out of all sixty days of the winter session in Richmond, Virginia Transit Legislative Day was the one afternoon when the marble corridors of the General Assembly Building traded corporate lobbyists in thousand-dollar tailored suits for everyday bus and rail riders wearing bright blue *RIDE TRANSIT VIRGINIA* lapel stickers. Rolling through our open fifth-floor doorway in a folded-frame, blue-upholstered manual wheelchair was our twenty-eight-year-old childhood friend and former across-the-hall neighbor Michael Ragsdale, with his twenty-six-year-old sister Rachel walking right beside him in her glasses and royal-blue Virginia Dominion University jacket, keeping one hand resting lightly on his left rear push-handle and her other hand laced tightly through his fingers. Both of them had blue *RIDE TRANSIT VIRGINIA* stickers pressed over their hearts and carried folders of Coastal Virginia Transit Authority route maps.

“Michael! Rachel!” Katie beamed, nudging her joystick and rolling her SwiftChair out from behind her mahogany desk as I wheeled right up beside her so the four of us could exchange warm hugs across our armrests. “What are you two doing up in Richmond? And Michael, what happened to your ankles?”

“Elective bilateral Achilles heel cord lengthening two weeks ago,” Michael smiled, patting the frame of his blue manual wheelchair while never letting go of Rachel’s hand. “My heel cords have been too tight to pivot safely between driving pedals my whole life, and Rachel stubbornly refused to get her Learner’s Permit until we could walk into the DMV and get our permits together once my surgeon clears me. I can stand and walk short flat distances, but for a full day of marble Capitol hallways, my orthopedic specialist ordered me to use the manual chair and let my Bug guard the push-handles.”

“And we came up on the Hampton Roads transit advocacy bus this morning for Transit Legislative Day,” Rachel added proudly, adjusting her glasses with a grin. “Technically, our family home on Moosewood Drive is just across the district line in the Eighty-First District, and our campus apartment at VDU is in Norfolk’s Eighty-Ninth, so you aren’t officially our Delegate on our voter registration cards—but when there’s a Virginia Beach Delegate in the General Assembly who actually rides CVTA buses every day and knows the Route 25 and Route 2 timetables by heart, she’s our Delegate too! After we finished lobbying our assigned offices for evening bus frequency and Sunday service hours, there was no way we were leaving Richmond without coming up to the fifth floor to see our old Delaney Street and Greenway Court neighbors.”

“Wait—were the two of you up in the third-floor House gallery at noon today?” I asked, spotting the green visitor gallery passes tucked into their lanyards.

“Front row center, right behind the brass rail!” Michael laughed, his eyes lighting up. “Katie, watching you hold up the text of House Bill 663 and ask Delegate Cobb why any woman in Virginia should have to pull her pants down for a government official to prove she has female parts just to use the ladies’ room was the greatest thing I have ever seen in a government building. Nate, the second you posted the captioned video link at twelve-thirty-five, Rachel and I sent it to every student group chat at VDU and CCHR.”

“And tell them what you promised yourself in the hallway afterward, Bear,” Rachel said, nudging his shoulder with a laugh.

Michael grinned sheepishly from his blue manual wheelchair. “When we took the elevator downstairs after the floor session let out for lunch, I was still so fired up about that ridiculous bill that I made a solemn promise to myself and Rachel: if I saw Delegate Cobb—or Delegate Robert Marsh, who keeps talking to reporters about bringing his own bathroom bill—heading toward the men’s room anywhere in the General Assembly Building while we were making our Transit Legislative Day rounds, I was going to wheel right up to the bathroom door and demand that he pull his pants down right there in the corridor to prove he had male parts!”

Katie clapped both hands over her mouth as she and I burst out laughing together across our armrests.

“Did you see either of them?” I asked through my laughter.

“Sadly, no,” Michael sighed, shaking his head with mock disappointment. “Neither of them crossed our path all afternoon, so I never got the chance—wait until he sees how fast that video is spreading across VDU right now, though. By Monday morning, neither of those guys is going to want to show his face near a microphone.”

After spending twenty wonderful minutes catching up on CVTA bus routes, our old first-floor hallway on Greenway Court, and their computer information systems classes at VDU, we rolled alongside Michael and Rachel out to the fifth-floor elevators so they could catch their late-afternoon transit coalition bus back down Interstate 64 to Hampton Roads.

Right as the elevator doors opened for Michael and Rachel at two-forty, an entire New River Valley transit delegation wearing blue *RIDE TRANSIT VIRGINIA* stickers rolled off the elevator and into Room 518—three closely knit families from Christiansburg and Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute in Blacksburg who rode Blue Ridge Transit Route 1 and Route 2 and the Radford Connector around town, and who had been sitting in the third-floor House gallery right beside Michael and Rachel when Katie questioned Delegate Cobb on House Bill 663.

Rolling in first was Jordan in his power wheelchair alongside Aubrie Jean, Megan, Zoë, and Isabel, followed right beside them by Freddie in his matte-black titanium manual wheelchair, his sixteen-year-old sister Harper in her neon-purple wheelchair, and their sisters Paige, Jessica, Sarah, and Jenna, and right behind them came Ryan O’Connell propelling his matte-black titanium manual wheelchair with his sister Cassidy holding onto his rear push-handles like a rolling walker alongside their youngest sister Holly and their twin cousins Evan and Tyler Wright.

“Four powerchairs and three ultralight manual chairs in one legislative office!” I grinned from beside my laptop as Katie and I wheeled our two black SwiftChairs out from behind her mahogany desk to form a wide semi-circle of seven wheelchairs in the center of Room 518. “Now this is what the General Assembly Building is supposed to look like on Transit Legislative Day—and wait a second, Katie, that’s Ryan, Cassidy, and Holly O’Connell and Evan and Tyler Wright of The Stardust Engine!”

Even though they lived up in Blacksburg and Christiansburg rather than in the Eighty-Fifth House District—though Aubrie Jean beamed as she told us she had grown up right across the city line from Kempsville in the Emerald Creek neighborhood of Chesapeake before heading to CPI, and Katie's face lit up as she told Ryan and Cassidy that she and I listened to *Neon on the Huckleberry Trail* while compiling bus timetables at night and admired how Ryan's rear push-handles were set at the exact height for Cassidy to use as a rolling walker—every single one of them hated House Bill 663 just as fiercely as we did. Speaking through the voice synthesizer on his tablet, Jordan thanked Katie for standing up against a bill that would turn public restrooms into hostile fifty-dollar police checkpoints for wheelchair users and the family members who help them; Freddie, adjusting his glasses with Harper's hand anchored firmly to his right sleeve and Paige's hands resting on his shoulders, told Katie that her ninety-five-second floor cross-examination had exposed a fatal runtime error in Line 18 of Delegate Cobb's statute; and Ryan and Holly thanked Katie on behalf of disabled travelers across the state and Engine Room Records. Before they headed back downstairs to return to Christiansburg and Progress Street NE in Blacksburg, Holly, Zoë, Aubrie Jean, Paige, and Jenna had already pulled out their tablets and phones and shared our captioned ninety-five-second floor video with every student organization, computer science mailing list, Engine Room Records channel, and transit group across Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute.

We spent the rest of the afternoon until five-thirty meeting with special-education parents from Virginia Beach and reviewing coastal flooding amendments with our legislative aide, with both of our laptops closed on our desks.

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 6:00 PM — The Evening News in Richmond and Norfolk

"Hand me the pepper shaker, Nate," Katie said at six o'clock that Thursday evening, setting two warm plates of baked chicken and rice down on the dining table of Apartment 104 at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street after we had ridden the 5:35 PM westbound JRTC Route 6 bus home from Ninth and Broad. "And turn on the television so we can see the weather forecast for the weekend."

Picking up the remote control from the corner of the table, I clicked on the wall-mounted television—tuned first to the Richmond local six-o'clock news broadcast, with my laptop open beside my glass of ginger ale streaming our hometown six-o'clock broadcast from Norfolk so we could keep up with Hampton Roads news while we were in Richmond for the winter session.

I barely had time to set the remote down before both my twin sister and I froze with our forks halfway to our mouths.

On the television screen on the wall—and simultaneously on the Norfolk local news stream playing on my laptop—was the exact ninety-five-second video clip I had captured from my wheelchair bay on the House Floor at lunchtime.

"—and our top story from the State Capitol tonight," the Richmond evening anchor announced over the footage of Katie sitting upright in her compact SwiftChair on the House Floor holding up the two printed pages of House Bill 663, *"a fiery floor exchange in the House of Delegates this afternoon over House Bill 663, the*

controversial bathroom bill restricting public restrooms by 'anatomical sex,' after Virginia Beach Delegate Katie Prairie brought the House Chamber to a standstill with a single question for the bill's patron."

Before our eyes, both the Richmond station and the Norfolk station aired the floor clip in full—every word of Katie asking Delegate Martin Cobb why she, or any woman or girl in the Commonwealth of Virginia, should have to pull her pants down for a government official or a police officer to prove she had female parts just to use the ladies' room, followed by the four seconds of Delegate Cobb standing frozen and beet-red behind his desk microphone before the Majority Leader hurriedly passed the bill by for the day.

Katie stared at the television screen, her blue eyes wide. "Nate… they're playing the whole floor clip on the six-o'clock news. In Richmond and back home in Norfolk."

I reached over and woke my laptop browser window, refreshing the server dashboard for Katie's legislative archive and The Grid.

My jaw dropped.

"Michael and Rachel weren't kidding when they said they shared your clip with everyone at VDU and CCHR!" I said, turning the laptop screen toward her wheelchair. "Look at the traffic logs! Between the Transit Legislative Day riders sharing your link from the Capitol and the beat reporters from the Richmond and Norfolk papers embedding your captioned video on their blogs at two-thirty while we were in meetings, thousands of office workers and college students at Virginia Dominion University, CCHR, and Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute watched it on their phones all afternoon. That's how the assignment desks at the Richmond and Norfolk TV stations grabbed it for the six-o'clock news!"

Friday, February 5, 2016, 9:15 AM — The Speakerphone Call on Line One, Two Twin Meltdowns, & The Majority Leader's Triplets

The black multi-line telephone on Katie's desk in our fifth-floor General Assembly Building office rang once on Line One at nine-fifteen on Friday morning, and just as she had done ever since her very first week on the Virginia Beach City Council, Katie reached over from her SwiftChair to press the speakerphone button herself.

In almost every other legislative office in the Capitol complex, a constitutional officer never picked up their own main telephone line; incoming calls were strictly screened by a legislative aide or session receptionist at the front desk so the member wouldn't be interrupted by cold calls. Teaching Katie to let a ringing phone go unanswered when she was sitting right beside it, however, was impossible. In Katie's literal autistic mind, Room 518 was her office, her name was on the brass plate outside the door, and if she was at her desk with a free hand, the polite, honest thing to do was answer the phone herself so the constituent on the other end knew she was actually there working for them. At this point in our time in Richmond—and certainly up in Washington—people outside Virginia Beach were still learning that Katie answered her own phone directly, and as she pressed the button, she fully expected the caller to be a retired shipyard worker from Kempsville reporting a missed CVTA bus connection on Princess Anne Road.

“Delegate Katie Prairie’s office, this is Katie speaking,” she said, keeping one hand resting on her open municipal transit binder while I sat right beside her left wheel with my silver MagnaBook Pro laptop open on the side table.

There was a brief, startled pause on the other end of the speakerphone. “Oh! Good morning, Delegate Prairie—is this really Delegate Prairie herself? I honestly expected your front-desk scheduler or a legislative assistant to pick up the main switchboard line. My name is Arthur Vance, and I’m a senior producer for *Meet the Nation* at GBS News up here in Washington. I hope I’m not catching you at a bad time?”

Katie blinked, glancing sideways at me in surprise. To the two of us, *Meet the Nation* was the quiet Sunday morning news program our dad David used to put on the living room television in Virginia Beach while the three of us ate scrambled eggs and toast together.

“Not at all, Mr. Vance,” Katie said politely. “My brother Nate and I were just looking over some bus shelter amendments. How can I help you?”

“Well, Delegate, David Vance and our editorial team here in Washington watched your exchange on the House Floor yesterday afternoon over House Bill 663,” Mr. Vance said warmly, his voice remarkably courteous and unhurried. “You raised some serious constitutional questions about how a law like that could ever be enforced in public buildings without violating the Fourth Amendment. David would be honored if you would join him this Sunday morning at nine o’clock for a quiet, one-on-one conversation to walk through the text of the bill—if you’d be willing to make it a Sunday morning exclusive with *Meet the Nation*.”

Katie’s shoulders visibly relaxed in her SwiftChair. After answering questions from the local Richmond and Norfolk newspaper reporters the evening before, the word *exclusive* sounded like a wonderful relief to her: it meant she would only have to put on a stiff blazer, sit under bright lights, state the literal facts of House Bill 663 one time, and then go straight back to our apartment in Richmond without having to repeat the exact same sentences to anyone else.

“Do you mean if I talk to Mr. Vance at nine o’clock on Sunday morning, I only have to tell the story one time and nobody else will ask me to repeat it all afternoon?” Katie asked literally.

On the speakerphone, Arthur Vance let out a soft, warm laugh. “That is the exact agreement, Delegate Prairie. Just you and David Vance one-on-one at nine o’clock sharp, zero cross-talk, and you’re completely done by nine-twenty. We would be happy to send a car down to your address in Richmond at five-thirty Sunday morning to drive you up Interstate 95—”

“Oh, you don’t need to waste money on a car, Mr. Vance,” Katie said right away. “My brother Nate and I always ride public transit and pay our own regular fare, and a car would just get stuck in traffic on the 14th Street Bridge anyway. The suburban Staples Mill station doesn’t have Sunday bus service yet, so we’ll take the early JRTC bus down Broad Street to Richmond Main Street Station, ride the six-oh-five ARTS Northeast Regional train up to Alexandria, and use our blue CapitalPass cards from our family trips with our dad to take the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge into L’Enfant Plaza, and then transfer to the Route P6 bus across the National Mall right to your door on North Capitol Street. We’ll be at your studio desk by eight-thirty—and then we can catch the eleven-twelve train out

of Alexandria with the connecting ARTS Thruway shuttle back to Main Street Station so I can get back to our apartment and out of my dress blazer by two o'clock."

"You two are taking a Richmond city bus, an intercity train, the Yellow Line subway across the Potomac, and a D.C. bus across the National Mall?" Mr. Vance asked, sounding genuinely charmed. "Well, whatever makes you most comfortable, Delegate. We'll have security passes waiting at the Washington bureau front desk at eight-thirty Sunday morning. Thank you so much for giving us your word."

"Thank you for being so polite, Mr. Vance," Katie said, and pressed the button to end the call.

Only as the speakerphone clicked off at nine-twenty-two did Katie and I look down at the plastic telephone console on her desk.

While we had been talking cleanly on Line One for the last four minutes, the little red hold lights on Line Two, Line Three, Line Four, and Line Five had all started blinking furiously at the exact same time, though the ringer had been automatically muted while the speakerphone was active.

Before I could even ask Katie why the whole console was lit up like a Christmas tree, our office door flew open. Katie's twenty-four-year-old legislative aide stumbled in carrying a thick stack of pink paper message slips, followed two seconds later by Greg, the Communications Director for the Virginia House Democratic Caucus, who was holding two vibrating cell phones in his hands and breathing like he had just sprinted all the way up the stairs from the third floor.

"Katie! Do not touch that phone until I clear a schedule!" Greg gasped, leaning over the front edge of her desk. "*Capitol Sunday* is holding on Line Two, *This Sunday* is on Line Three, *Beltway Sunday* is on Line Four, and the cable networks are blowing up my cell phone! They all want to book you for Sunday morning! We can set up a full Sunday morning sweep right now—four television shows back-to-back from eight in the morning until noon—"

"Oh, no thank you," Katie said calmly, shaking her head. "I would hate sitting in a stiff blazer repeating the exact same story four times in a row. Besides, I already promised Mr. Vance on Line One that I would only talk to *Meet the Nation*."

The room went dead silent.

Greg stared down at Katie, then over at my wheelchair, his mouth opening and closing without a sound.

"You… you answered your own phone and promised an exclusive to *Meet the Nation* without talking to me first?" he whispered, his face flushing red.

I looked up from my laptop keyboard, confused by his sudden anger. "Mr. Vance called while we were looking at CVTA bus stops. He was the first one to ask, he was very polite to Katie, and he told her that if she goes on at nine o'clock, she only has to explain the bill once and then we can catch the eleven-twelve train out of Alexandria and come home."

“Yeah,” Katie agreed simply. “Why would I want to go on four television shows on a Sunday morning when I can explain the statute once at nine o’clock and be back in our apartment in sweatpants by two in the afternoon?”

Greg slowly lowered both of his ringing cell phones to his sides, staring at the two of us with his jaw clenched. “I have to go tell the other three networks you’re off the board,” he muttered tightly, backing out of our office doorway into the outer reception room.

As he pulled the heavy oak door behind him, the latch didn’t quite catch, leaving a two-inch gap between the frame and the jamb.

Through that crack, Katie and I heard every single word as Greg snatched up the blinking phones at the legislative aide’s desk in the outer room and started barking into the handsets back-to-back.

“Look, Sarah, I’m telling you, I can’t put her on *Capitol Sunday*!” we heard him shout into Line Two, his voice loud and exasperated. “She’s a backbench delegate from Virginia Beach who has never dealt with national press in her life! She picked up her own main office line five minutes ago before my staff could even get up the stairs and promised an exclusive to *Meet the Nation*! She had no idea what she was doing!”

Beside me, Katie’s hands froze on the edges of her transit binder.

Out in the reception room, Greg slammed down Line Two, punched Line Three, and started all over again. “No, I’m not freezing *This Sunday* out on purpose! Delegate Prairie doesn’t know how Washington booking rules work—she literally answered her own phone and gave away a Sunday morning exclusive without clearing it with Caucus Communications or the Minority Leader’s office! Now I have to go down to the third floor and explain to leadership and the entire Democratic Caucus what just happened!”

The outer hall door banged shut as he hurried down the corridor toward the stairs.

Inside Room 518, the silence felt suffocating.

I looked over at my twin sister, and my stomach dropped right through the floor. Katie’s fingers were trembling violently against the yellow highlighter in her lap, her breathing was coming in shallow, rapid gasps, and every trace of color had drained out of her face.

For two autistic twins who had spent our whole lives relying on literal written rules to survive, there was no phrase on earth more terrifying than *unwritten rules*. Whenever someone in authority started shouting about protocols that weren’t printed in any handbook—about failing to clear things with leadership or breaking rules nobody had ever told us existed—it sent every alarm bell in our nervous systems screaming at once.

“Nate…” Katie whispered, her voice shaking so badly she could barely get my name out as her chest began to heave. “Did I just break a House rule? Was I not allowed to talk to Mr. Vance on the telephone without asking the Caucus first?”

“I—I don’t know, sis,” I stammered, and the raw panic in my own voice immediately set off a feedback loop between the two of us. My own hands were shaking so hard on the keyboard of my laptop that I could barely click open the PDF

of the Rules of the Virginia House of Delegates, my eyes darting frantically down the table of contents for anything about national television interviews or caucus clearance while Katie's breathing grew faster and louder beside me. "It's not in the written standing rules on my laptop, Katie, I swear it isn't, but the way Greg just ran downstairs to report you to the Minority Leader…"

Katie burst into tears, a full-blown autistic meltdown overtaking her as she buried her face in both hands and began sobbing and shaking from head to toe.

"What if they kick me out of the Caucus, Nate?!" Katie cried, gasping for air between sobs as her whole body trembled in her wheelchair. "What if I broke an ethics rule and they expel me from the House of Delegates?! All the voters in Virginia Beach trusted me, and Dad was so proud of us, and I ruined everything just because I answered the telephone!"

Seeing my twin sister in a full autistic meltdown—and spiraling straight into a sympathetic meltdown of my own as the terrifying thought seized my chest that Katie was really about to be kicked out of the House of Delegates because neither of us understood some secret Richmond rule—I released the electromagnetic brakes of my SwiftChair with a trembling hand, wheeled myself flush against the side of her chair, and wrapped both of my arms around her shoulders, hugging her as tight as I could across our armrests.

Katie pressed her wet face into the shoulder of my charcoal suit jacket, sobbing uncontrollably against my lapel while my own tears spilled hot down my cheeks. I held onto my sister with everything I had, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair while my chest shook right alongside hers and my heart hammered at a hundred and thirty beats a minute.

Just then, out of the corner of Katie's tear-blurred eye—and mine—both of us saw three figures appear together in the open outer doorway of our fifth-floor reception room.

It was thirteen-year-old Sam Hawkins and his thirteen-year-old sisters, Amanda—who went by Mandy—and Sarah Hawkins: three eighth-grade triplets who were all serving together this session as middle-school House Pages. Sam was the fraternal triplet, born first, while Mandy and Sarah were identical twins, born second and third. All three of them wore the iconic daily uniform of a crisp navy blue House Page blazer with the official Virginia Page patch on the breast pocket, a brass House Page name badge reading HAWKINS, and a button-down shirt—Sam in gray slacks and a striped tie that looked almost identical to what I wore to work every day, and Mandy and Sarah in matching gray skirts and navy Page ties—with Sam clutching a stack of yellow transportation committee bill folders against his chest while Mandy and Sarah held onto either side of his blazer sleeve.

They were eighth-graders from down near Danville along the North Carolina line—the rural region everybody at the State Capitol called Southside Virginia. When Katie and I had first arrived in Richmond from Virginia Beach and Norfolk, we had been completely baffled whenever senior lawmakers referred to legislators from the Southside. Growing up on our side of the harbor, whenever Katie and I heard the word Southside, we automatically thought of Southside Hampton Roads—everything south of the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel from Norfolk and Portsmouth out to Kempsville and the Oceanfront. It had actually been Sam, Mandy, and Sarah who politely explained to us during Page orientation week in January with

a printed highway map of Route 58 that in Richmond Capitol politics, Southside meant the rural tobacco and textile counties stretching west from Emporia to Danville and Martinsville, well over a hundred miles inland from our coast.

Right after that map lesson during the first week of January—when the thirteen- and fourteen-year-old Pages were getting started learning how state government worked—an impatient senior legislator had barked three vague errands at the triplets at once in the noisy hallway outside the Clerk's office. At the sound of an adult shouting at them, all three thirteen-year-olds had frozen against the marble wall, clutching each other's hands so tightly their knuckles turned white as they trembled on the verge of a sensory and panic meltdown. Recognizing that look in an instant, Katie and I had rolled our two SwiftChairs right up in front of them to block the hallway foot traffic and give them a quiet protective perimeter. Speaking in a soft, calm voice, Katie had told Sam, Mandy, and Sarah that she and I were autistic too, and that just like the two of us were each other's safe person, we could tell the three of them were each other's safe person too.

All three triplets had looked up at Katie with wide, shining eyes and told her that all three of them were autistic as well. Ever since that afternoon, Katie had been Sam, Mandy, and Sarah's absolute favorite Delegate in the entire chamber. Whenever Katie pressed her Page Call button on the House Floor, all three of them practically sprinted together to her wheelchair bay—because Katie never shouted, never used sarcasm, never gave them conflicting tasks at once, and always wrote the exact room number and bill number clearly on a sticky note before thanking Sam, Mandy, and Sarah by name. Even more than that, after watching Katie and me famously ride the city bus down Broad Street every morning and take the intercity passenger train between Hampton Roads and Richmond, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah had decided that public transportation was the biggest issue they wanted to work on as House Pages—volunteering for every House Transportation Committee courier run and choosing statewide bus and passenger rail expansion as their Page legislative project.

Standing together in our fifth-floor doorway, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah froze in their tracks as they saw their favorite Delegate crying and shaking in her wheelchair. Their eyes went wide with alarm, Mandy and Sarah grabbed Sam's hands, and without a single word, all three triplets spun on their heels and took off running together down the hallway toward the elevators.

In our panic, watching even the three young House Pages bolt from our doorway only made us hold onto each other tighter, terrified that the entire Capitol was about to find out Katie had broken a rule and was being expelled.

Three minutes later, urgent footsteps echoed from both ends of the fifth-floor corridor at the exact same moment.

From the marble stairwell came Democratic House Minority Leader Tom Toscano with Greg trailing half a step behind him—and at the exact same second, the brass elevator doors down the hall chimed open and Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway came racing down the corridor right alongside thirteen-year-old Sam, Mandy, and Sarah.

"Right in here, Uncle Richard!" Sam panted outside our doorway, pointing straight toward our open inner door while Mandy and Sarah nodded urgently beside him.

“That press man in the outer office was yelling so loud about breaking an unwritten rule and reporting her,” Mandy said breathlessly, holding tight to Sarah’s hand, “and the Gentlewoman from Virginia Beach is in there crying in her wheelchair!”

Both the Democratic Minority Leader and the Republican Majority Leader reached our doorway at the same time and stopped dead in their tracks as they saw the two of us huddled together in our power wheelchairs—Katie sobbing into my shoulder in a full autistic meltdown, and me crying and shaking right along with her like I was trying to shield my twin sister from an oncoming train.

“Whoa, whoa, hold on a second,” the Minority Leader breathed, the color draining from his own face as he realized what had happened. He spun on his heel and shot a furious glare at the communications director—“Stay out here in the hall, Greg. Do not move a muscle”—before stepping quietly into Room 518 right alongside the Republican Majority Leader, with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah standing right between them clutching each other’s sleeves and the stack of yellow transportation committee bill folders.

The two floor leaders pulled the wooden guest chairs right up in front of our footrests so they were sitting side by side at eye level with us.

Katie lifted her tear-stained face an inch off my shoulder, gasping for breath and wiping furiously at her red eyes with the back of her trembling wrist as she tried to sit up in her chair.

“Mr. Minority Leader, Mr. Majority Leader, I am so sorry,” Katie choked out through her tears, her whole frame still shaking against my arms. “I didn’t know there was a rule that a delegate wasn’t allowed to answer Line One or agree to talk to a television show without asking the Caucus first! When Mr. Vance asked for an exclusive, I only said yes because we used to watch that show with our dad over breakfast and I thought it meant I could tell the story one time and come home on the eleven-twelve train! Please don’t kick me out of the House of Delegates—I’ll call him back right now and cancel it!”

“Please don’t expel her, sirs,” I pleaded, my own voice cracking as my hands shook on Katie’s shoulders. “I searched the whole House Manual on my laptop and we didn’t know—”

Both floor leaders looked at Katie and me, and their faces softened with deep, unmistakable gentleness.

“Expel her? Kicked out of the House?” the Democratic Minority Leader repeated softly, holding up both hands palm-out in a calm, steady gesture. “Katie, Nate—look at both of us. Take a slow breath. You are not getting kicked out of the House of Delegates, you are not getting kicked out of the Democratic Caucus, and you did not break a single rule. Not a written rule, and not an unwritten rule.”

Seeing Katie’s eyes still pink around the edges and my wheelchair parked tight against hers, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah stepped half a pace forward past their uncle toward Katie’s desk.

“Delegate Prairie?” Sam asked quietly, holding out the stack of yellow folders with both hands while Mandy and Sarah stood shoulder to shoulder with him. “We brought the morning transportation dockets you asked for on the sticky note. Are you and Nate okay?”

“When that man in the outer office started shouting that you broke an unwritten rule, we got really scared for you,” Sarah added in a small, earnest voice, her fingers laced through Mandy’s. “So the three of us ran right downstairs to get Uncle Richard.”

Katie blinked in astonishment at the words *Uncle Richard*, looking from the brass HAWKINS name badges on Sam, Mandy, and Sarah’s navy blazers up to the Republican Majority Leader before offering all three triplets a warm, steady smile and taking the folders gently from Sam’s hands to set them neatly on the corner of her blotter. “Thank you, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah. These are the exact bills I needed, and you three were right on time. Nate and I are okay now.”

The Republican Majority Leader rested his hands gently on the shoulders of his nephew and nieces, taking off his reading glasses and tucking them into his breast pocket as he looked at Katie and me with his warm Danville drawl.

“You two have been looking out for Sam, Mandy, and Sarah on the House Floor every single day since January,” Majority Leader Callaway said, his voice thick with genuine emotion. “Because I’m their maternal uncle—their mother’s brother—their Page badges say Hawkins while my desk plaque downstairs says Callaway, so neither of you had any way of knowing. My wife—their Aunt Marge Callaway—and I have custody of all three of them. We rescued these three kids and took them into our home about a year ago after the unspeakable things their mother and stepfather put them through.”

Inside Room 518, both Katie and I inhaled sharply, our hearts clenching as we looked at the three thirteen-year-old triplets clinging to each other’s hands beside their uncle—and in a single heartbeat, remembering our own mother Brenda and how our dad David had fought to rescue the two of us when we were sixteen, along with how Katie’s controlling jerk of a boyfriend Brandon Mercer in Williamsburg in 2004 and my manipulative girlfriend Tiffany Sloan in Ocean View in 2005 had used every closed-door trick in the book trying—and failing—to drive a wedge between us under the same roof, we understood everything about why Sam, Mandy, and Sarah never let go of each other in the hallways.

“After what Sam, Mandy, and Sarah survived before Marge and I got them safe, they are each other’s safe person, and Marge and I don’t let anyone raise a hand or a voice to them ever again,” Uncle Richard continued quietly, drawing the three triplets close against his sides. “Out of all one hundred members of this House—including their own Uncle Richard—you are their absolute favorite Delegate in the entire building, and running errands for your desk is their favorite activity in the Capitol. Over dinner with their Aunt Marge and me on Sunday night, all three of them couldn’t stop talking about how Delegate Prairie’s wheelchair bay is the only spot on the carpet where nobody ever yells at them or barks confusing orders on the fly, and how much it meant to them when you shielded them in the hallway with your wheelchairs and told them that you and Nate were autistic too. So when Sam, Mandy, and Sarah come sprinting into my office telling me somebody is up on the fifth floor shouting about unwritten rules at their favorite delegate from the other Southside, that’s my business too—party lines be damned.”

Katie blinked, a tear of pure gratitude slipping down her cheek as a warm smile broke across her face, looking from Sam, Mandy, and Sarah up to the Majority Leader's eyes while the last trace of panic in my chest melted away completely.

"Now, you and I sit on opposite sides of that green carpet downstairs, Delegate, and lord knows you got my Republican caucus all up in arms yesterday afternoon over House Bill 663," the Majority Leader continued warmly. "That's just politics. We're going to disagree on plenty of votes while you're in Richmond. Personally, though? Marge and I like you a whole lot, Delegate Prairie, because of how kindly you treat Sam, Mandy, and Sarah every single day—and after Marge and I spent all month coaching these three through their Page Manual at our kitchen table, a staffer bullying you and your brother into an autistic meltdown over made-up unwritten rules is personal to me."

He pointed a finger toward the copy of the Manual of the House of Delegates sitting beside Katie's telephone.

"Here is the only rule you, Nate, and my three kids here ever need to know in the Capitol," the Majority Leader said firmly. "Every single unwritten rule you hear a staffer or a lobbyist holler about in the hallways of Richmond is completely made up. The only rules that govern this House are the Constitution of Virginia, the printed House Manual, and the Page Manual—and I know for a fact the five of you are the only people on this floor who have actually read every word of them."

Beside their uncle, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah nodded solemnly in unison.

"Page forty-two," Sam said clearly.

"It says a Delegate controls her own office communications at all times," Mandy added, looking straight at Katie.

"And it doesn't say a single word about asking a press guy first," Sarah finished.

Both the Democratic Minority Leader and the Republican Majority Leader burst out laughing, and Katie let out a bright, genuine laugh too, reaching over to give my forearm a squeeze.

"Sam, Mandy, and Sarah are better parliamentarians than half the lawyers on the Courts of Justice Committee," the Minority Leader chuckled, clapping a hand on his colleague's shoulder before reaching into his breast pocket and handing Katie a clean, folded white handkerchief. "And as for why Greg was losing his mind over your phone call, Katie, it's because neither of you saw what happened to your floor video overnight, did you? After the local stations in Richmond and Norfolk aired your question on the six-o'clock news last night, the national news desks in Washington and New York picked it up. Your ninety-five-second floor clip crossed ten million views across the United States before sunrise this morning."

Both Katie and I froze in our wheelchairs, staring at the two leaders with wide eyes. "Ten million?" I whispered.

"Ten million and climbing," the Minority Leader nodded warmly. "And what you did on the telephone ten minutes ago without even trying, Katie, is the single biggest triumph our Caucus has had in a decade. *Meet the Nation* isn't just a Sunday morning show—it is the most prestigious public affairs broadcast in the United States. Members of Congress in Washington spend ten years lobbying just to get

invited onto that set. Every President, every U.S. Senator, every Governor, and every Fortune 500 CEO in America watches *Meet the Nation* at nine o'clock on Sunday morning. Because you picked up your own phone and politely agreed to give Arthur Vance an exclusive so you only had to tell your story once, he gave a Virginia Beach delegate the solo nine o'clock A-Block lead at the very top of the broadcast."

"Do you know how many sitting Governors and U.S. Senators in both parties would give their right arm to get invited onto the opening A-Block of *Meet the Nation* for a one-on-one exclusive with David Vance?" Majority Leader Callaway added with a chuckle. "Whenever some overcaffeinated press staffer starts hollering because you answered your own phone instead of playing Washington media games, you two didn't do a doggone thing wrong—he did. My job as Majority Leader is to help my caucus govern effectively, not assure our members that everything they write is brilliant. As I told the gentleman from Spotsylvania and Speaker Harwell right after the gavel yesterday—and as Sam, Mandy, and Sarah proudly informed Marge and me over supper last night after telling us how Sarah looked at Line 18 on your desk before noon and asked if somebody had to see her parts to prove she was a girl—you didn't kill his bill, Delegate. His bill killed his bill. Half my own caucus wishes he had put House Bill 663 through the Prairie-and-triplet quality-assurance test before he embarrassed the whole Commonwealth on television."

"Wait," I whispered, the vise around my ribs finally vanishing completely. "So when Greg went downstairs to tell the Caucus what Katie did…"

"We were cheering, Nate!" the Minority Leader smiled, standing up from his chair. "The only people upset this morning are the booking producers at the other three networks who called three minutes too late—and that's their problem, not yours. Now, if you will excuse me for sixty seconds, I'm going to step out into the hallway and make sure Greg understands how things work in this building."

"They take after their favorite delegate," the Majority Leader said, resting a proud hand on Sam, Mandy, and Sarah's shoulders and giving Katie a warm wink as he stood up beside the Minority Leader. "In fact, because the three of them know how famously you and Nate ride the bus and the train everywhere you go, they already told Marge and me that public transportation is the number-one issue they want to work on as House Pages—they've been drafting their Page Mock Session bill all week to connect rural Southside bus routes in Danville and Martinsville with the passenger trains to Richmond and Hampton Roads."

"Because everyone should be able to take a bus or a train wherever they need to go, just like you and Nate do, Delegate Prairie!" Mandy beamed, while Sam and Sarah nodded enthusiastically beside her.

"We'll help you three check every schedule table in your bill on Monday afternoon," Katie promised warmly, her eyes crinkling with genuine joy.

"And just so we're clear on the bipartisan record," the Majority Leader added with a kindly smile, "if you and Nate are taking the six-oh-five train out of Main Street Station on Sunday morning to go talk to David Vance on *Meet the Nation*, don't let anyone in this building bother you all weekend. Safe travels across the Potomac, Delegate—and Marge, the kids, and I will all be watching you Sunday morning before we see you at noon on Monday to strike House Bill 663 off the calendar for good."

As the two leaders turned toward the door, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah all gave Katie and me a bright, relieved wave together before stepping back out into the fifth-floor hallway beside their Uncle Richard.

Once the heavy oak door latched shut behind them—and while the marble acoustics of the corridor outside carried thirty seconds of the Minority Leader blistering Greg by the stairwell and ordering him to apologize to both Katie and me before noon—Katie looked over at me across our touching armrests inside our quiet office, the color completely back in her cheeks and her hands steady on the yellow transportation folders Sam, Mandy, and Sarah had delivered.

“Page forty-two,” Katie said softly, smiling as I pulled our bank card out of my wallet and clicked the confirmation button on my laptop to lock in our Business Class wheelchair bays on Sunday morning’s ARTS Northeast Regional Train 164 from Richmond Main Street Station to Alexandria, along with the eleven-twelve southbound return on Train 143 and its connecting ARTS Thruway 8443 shuttle. “A Delegate controls her own office communications at all times.”

Part 3: Hold the Elevator!, Reuniting With Cousin Brittany in Room 518, Friday Night on JRTC Route 6, & Why Nate Must Speak

Date: 2016-02-05 at 13:15 America/New_York

Friday, February 5, 2016, 1:15 PM — “Hold the Elevator!” in the General Assembly Building Lobby

“Hold the elevator!” I called out across the echoing marble lobby of the General Assembly Building at one-fifteen on Friday afternoon.

Katie and I had just rolled back up the subterranean Capitol tunnel ramp from a twenty-two-minute Friday afternoon floor session with my silver MagnaBook Pro balanced across my lap tray and Katie’s leather bill folder resting on hers, aiming our two SwiftChairs straight toward the main elevator bank to head back up to Room 518 for lunch. Twenty feet ahead of our front casters, the heavy brass doors of the right-hand elevator cab had already begun sliding smoothly shut.

At the sound of my shout, a woman’s hand shot straight out from inside the cab, catching the rubber safety edge between the closing brass doors and popping them wide open again.

“Thank you so much!” Katie called out warmly as she and I nudged our joysticks forward, rolled side by side toward the brass sill, and looked up to thank the stranger holding the door.

Both of our wheelchairs stopped almost dead at the threshold.

Standing inside the wood-paneled elevator cab with her left hand braced trembling against the open brass door and her right hand clutching the worn strap of a shoulder purse like a life preserver was a heavy-set woman right around our own age in an open dark winter coat over a plum knit sweater, faded jeans, and gray sneakers. Years of hard living and stress-eating had softened her rounder face since high

school, yet there was no mistaking those thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses—or that exact warm caramel-ash shade of medium-blonde hair falling past her shoulders.

Katie's breath caught audibly beside me. My fingers froze flat against the lid of my laptop.

"Wait…" Katie whispered, staring straight up into the woman's terrified hazel-brown eyes behind those familiar wire-rimmed lenses. "Are you by chance Brittany Fletcher?"

Inside the elevator cab, Brittany's lower lip quivered so hard she could barely form the word, staring down at the two of us in our matching black-and-silver SwiftChairs like she couldn't comprehend her own luck.

"Yes," Brittany breathed, her voice shaking from head to toe. "Hi, Katie. Hi, Nate."

For three full seconds, neither my twin sister nor I moved a muscle—fourteen years of silence since that awful New Year's Eve in Kempsville crashing silently into every memory of ten-year-old Blizzard of '96 sofa cuddles, freshman-year cafeteria chicken patties, and walking hand in hand across Lions Way to Earlton Court.

Recovering my motor control first, I guided my SwiftChair cleanly into the cab beside Brittany while Katie rolled in right alongside my left armrest, and I reached up in sheer astonishment to press the round brass button for the fifth floor.

As the brass doors slid shut, sealing the three of us inside the quiet wood-paneled cab, Brittany pressed her back against the corner rail, looking like she half expected us to tell her to get off on the second floor.

"Where were you heading just now, Brittany?" Katie asked softly, never taking her eyes off our cousin's face.

"Up—up to Room 518," Brittany stammered, swallowing hard against tears already pooling behind her glasses. "I looked at the directory board out by security. I didn't have an appointment or anything, and I didn't even know if a receptionist would let me leave a note…"

Katie reached across our armrests to grip my right hand, and both of us spoke practically in unison as the floor indicator chimed *5*.

"Come with us to our office right now," I told her firmly.

"Please, Brittany," Katie insisted, rolling out into the quiet fifth-floor marble corridor ahead of her. "The three of us have a lot to talk about."

Friday, February 5, 2016, 1:22 PM — Excusing Everyone From the Inner Office, Speaking With Aunt Karen, Uncle Steven, and Dad, & Brittany's Desperate Favor

Inside the outer reception room of Suite 518, Katie's legislative aide looked up cheerfully from the front desk with a stack of constituent letters—only to pause mid-sentence when she saw our visitor's face crumple the second she stepped across the threshold of Katie's wood-paneled inner office.

Brittany hadn't even reached the wooden guest chair in front of Katie's mahogany desk before the dam broke. Dropping her purse against her ankle, she covered her face behind her wire-rimmed glasses with both hands and burst into ragged, body-shaking sobs.

"I am so sorry, Katie—I am so, so sorry, Nate!" Brittany cried, her voice cracking raw in her throat. "I ruined New Year's Eve, and I brought those horrible people into Uncle David's house when you two were just trying to save me from that crowd at Smoker's Corner, and I've wanted to tell you how sorry I am every single day for fourteen years! I know I got cut off from the family, and I deserved it, I swear I'm not making a single excuse—I just miss home so much, and I miss my mom and dad, and I miss the two of you, and I want to come home!"

Katie took one look at our weeping cousin, turned her SwiftChair ninety degrees toward the open doorway, and spoke in her calmest, clearest Delegate voice.

"Hannah, could you give Nate and me the inner office for the next forty-five minutes and hold all calls at the front desk, please?" Katie asked gently. "This is our cousin from Virginia Beach, and we need a private family moment."

"Of course, Delegate—take all the time you need," Hannah said quietly, stepping back into the reception room and pulling the heavy solid-oak inner door firmly shut until the brass latch clicked into place.

Now it was just Katie, me, and Brittany inside the quiet warmth of Room 518.

I wheeled my SwiftChair around the corner of Katie's desk right alongside my sister's chair, pulled the box of facial tissues off the side table, and held it up to Brittany as she sank onto the front edge of the wooden guest chair right at eye level with our armrests.

"Take a breath, Brittany," I said softly, feeling my throat tighten at the sight of how worn down and exhausted she looked beneath that winter coat. "Nobody here is yelling at you, and nobody is throwing you out."

Wiping furiously beneath her silver wire-rimmed lenses with two crumpled tissues, Brittany let out a long, shuddering hiccup and looked from Katie's royal-blue blazer and brass *DELEGATE PRAIRIE* nameplate to my charcoal suit and laptop.

"I still can't believe my eyes," Brittany whispered, a watery, bewildered smile flickering through her tears. "I've been living over on the Southside across the James River—in Hillside Court public housing—and last night at six o'clock I was standing in the kitchen when the Richmond evening news came on. All of a sudden there you were on television, Katie, sitting right on the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates tearing that awful bathroom bill to pieces, with Nate sitting right next to

you!" She shook her head in amazement. "My heart nearly stopped right there by the sink. I kept thinking, *That's Katie! That's my cousin! What on earth is she doing in the House of Delegates?!* How did this happen?"

For the next ten minutes, while Brittany sipped from a bottle of cold water I pulled from our small office refrigerator and slowly caught her breath, Katie and I caught her up gently on the fourteen years she had missed—how we had finished our computer degrees at CCHR, survived Brandon in Williamsburg in 2004 and Tiffany in Ocean View in 2005 side by side without ever letting anyone separate us, built our software business together, fought to fix CVTA evening bus routes at the Virginia Beach Municipal Center, served on City Council, and won Kempsville's Eighty-Fifth House District so Katie was up here in Richmond every winter while we lived back on Arvin Road the rest of the year.

With every honest answer Brittany gave us—never once blaming anyone else for December 31, 2002, admitting plainly how lonely eleventh grade had felt walking across the uncut Lions Way curb into Smoker's Corner alone while we rode the lift bus, and how badly she had spiraled after drifting away—Katie and I glanced across our armrests at each other and felt fourteen years of armor melt clean away. Underneath all that weight and heartbreak sat the exact same sweet cousin who had cut up my chicken patty sandwich in Mrs. DeMarco's cafeteria and held both of our hands all the way down Macgregory Street.

"Wait a second, though," Katie frowned gently, leaning forward in her SwiftChair at something Brittany had said two minutes earlier. "Brittany, why did you say you were cut off from your mom and dad too? Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven never stopped loving you. We talk to your parents all the time back in Virginia Beach—Aunt Karen even helped Dad and us out after the divorce—and every single holiday your mom cries wondering why you barely ever call Earlton Court anymore."

Brittany froze with the water bottle in both hands, her eyes widening behind her glasses. "Tyler told me… after my car broke down three years ago and we ended up up here in Richmond, Tyler kept telling me nobody in Virginia Beach wanted a failure like me tracking mud back onto their porch."

Katie and I exchanged one horrified look. Without waiting another second, Katie reached across her desk blotter, pressed the speakerphone button on her multi-line console, dialed Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven's landline on Earlton Court first, and tapped the conference key to bridge in our dad David on his cell phone down at the Arvin Road house in Kempsville.

"Hi, Katie sweetheart!" Aunt Karen's warm voice answered on the second ring, with Uncle Steven calling out a cheerful hello right behind her in their kitchen and Dad chiming in a second later: *"Afternoon, kiddos—saw your ten-million-view headline at lunch! Everything okay up in Room 518?"*

"Everything is okay, Dad—Aunt Karen, Uncle Steven, are you sitting down?" Katie asked softly, glancing tenderly at Brittany's trembling hands. "Somebody rode the JRTC bus across the river to Room 518 ten minutes ago without an appointment, and she needs to hear your voices."

"Mom? Daddy? Uncle David?" Brittany choked out toward the speakerphone.

Dead silence hung on the line for half a heartbeat—followed by Aunt Karen letting out a sharp, sobbing gasp on Earlton Court.

"Brittany?! Oh, thank God—Steven, it's Brittany, our baby's in Katie's office!" Aunt Karen cried openly over the speaker. *"Sweetheart, where have you been?! Your father and I have been worried sick about you for months!"*

"Brittany, honey, listen to your old man right now," Uncle Steven's deep, steady voice broke through, thick with emotion. *"I don't care what happened yesterday or fourteen years ago—we love you with everything we've got, your bedroom on Earlton Court hasn't changed an inch, and you always have a home with your mother and me."*

"And with us too, Brittany," Dad added immediately and warmly from Arvin Road. *"What happened when you kids were seventeen is ancient history in our house. You're family, kiddo. If you want to come home to Virginia Beach, all three of us will come get you whenever you say the word."*

Brittany pressed both palms hard over her mouth, tears pouring freely down her cheeks as she nodded at the black plastic speakerphone like they could see her. "I love you guys so much," she sobbed, before suddenly flinching as her eyes darted involuntarily toward the brass clock on Katie's wall—two-oh-five—and a wave of sheer, icy terror washed across her face. "Mom, Daddy—I can't talk long, Tyler gets off his shift at three-thirty and if he checks the apartment and I'm not there before the wedding tomorrow—"

"Wedding tomorrow?!" Uncle Steven, Aunt Karen, and Dad repeated in stunned unison over the speakerphone while Katie and I sat bolt upright in our wheelchairs.

"Please, Katie, can I tell you and Nate first and have you call Mom and Daddy right back?" Brittany whispered frantically, clutching Katie's sleeve with shaking fingers. "If I break down on the phone any longer I won't make the two-thirty bus back across the bridge before he gets home!"

Promising Aunt Karen, Uncle Steven, and Dad that Brittany was safe in our office right this minute and that Katie would call them back with a full plan as soon as Brittany caught her bus, Katie ended the conference call gently and wheeled her SwiftChair right up to Brittany's knees while I rolled in on Brittany's other side, taking both of her cold, shaking hands in mine just like we used to do on the walk home from Northwood High.

"Talk to us, Brittany," I said quietly, looking straight into her eyes. "You're supposed to marry Tyler *tomorrow*?"

"At two o'clock tomorrow afternoon," Brittany sobbed, fresh tears spilling over her lower lashes as she looked Katie and me straight in the eye. "At this bleak brick church down off Hull Street in South Richmond that I didn't even want to go to—it's his uncle's friend's church. I'm supposed to get married tomorrow, Nate, and I'm miserable. I don't love Tyler. I met him four years ago thinking he was finally somebody decent, and instead he's the exact same kind of mean, angry wrong crowd I fell into back in high school, only behind closed doors he controls every dime, keeps the car keys in his pocket, screams in my face, and—and this week when I tried to ask if we could postpone the wedding, he put his hands on me."

My stomach knotted into cold iron, and beside me Katie's jaw set like granite. Neither Katie nor I thought twice about the first name *Tyler*—half a dozen guys in our high-school class alone had been named Tyler—only that someone was hurting our cousin.

"Then don't get back on that bus to Hillside Court at all!" I said immediately, reaching toward my laptop bag. "Stay right here with Katie and me tonight! We have a whole apartment on West Broad Street, and Dad and Uncle Steven will drive up Interstate 64 tonight—"

"No—listen to me, Nate, please!" Brittany pleaded, gripping both of my wrists so tightly her knuckles turned white. "Tyler kept my birth certificate, my Social Security card, and my bank card locked in the strongbox in our bedroom so we can bring the paperwork sleeve to the church tomorrow afternoon! Only tomorrow morning while he goes to get his suit pressed am I going to have the lockbox open to pack my bridal bag. And even worse—you don't know how crazy Tyler gets when he thinks somebody embarrassed him behind his back. If I just vanish off the street today without a word, he won't stop—he'll tear apart Hillside Court, he'll hunt every bus stop in Richmond, and he'll tell the police I was kidnapped or out of my mind!"

Brittany leaned forward on the edge of the chair, staring straight into Katie's eyes and then mine with desperate, trembling courage, still visibly fighting the years of fear he had drilled into her.

"I need a huge favor from the two of you," Brittany whispered through her tears. "Please—come to the church tomorrow afternoon at two o'clock. Nobody on Tyler's side knows who you two are, and he won't be looking at the back pews once the music starts. When the minister reads the part of the service where he asks if anyone knows just cause why we shouldn't be married—*speak now or forever hold your peace*—I need someone to speak up."

Katie and I stared at her in stunned silence.

"You want one of us to object out loud in the middle of the wedding?" Katie asked carefully, making sure she understood every literal mechanic of what Brittany was asking.

"Yes!" Brittany nodded urgently, wiping her cheeks with the back of her sleeve. "I looked up how that pastor runs his weddings—if anybody objects during the lawful-impediment charge, he stops the ceremony right there in front of all forty witnesses and pulls the bride alone into the side vestry office with the church coordinator to verify there's no coercion or abuse! Once I'm behind that closed vestry door away from Tyler with my birth certificate and ID already in my bag, I can show the minister what Tyler did to me, tell him under Virginia law I do not consent to marry him, and walk out the back ramp with you two while the church deacons hold Tyler at the front! Please, Katie—please, Nate—if nobody speaks up tomorrow, I'm going to freeze at that altar out of pure terror. Will you come get me?"

Katie didn't hesitate for a tenth of a second. Flipping up her inner armrest, my twin sister leaned across and wrapped both arms tightly around Brittany's shoulders while I leaned in from Brittany's other side and hugged both of them at once.

“Write down the church address and the cross street right here,” I told Brittany firmly, sliding Katie’s yellow notepad and pen onto her lap. “Katie and I will be inside those sanctuary doors before quarter to two tomorrow—and once we roll down that back ramp with you, we are taking you home with us, and we aren’t letting Tyler near you ever again.”

Friday, February 5, 2016, 5:15 PM & 8:30 PM — Keeping Our JRTC Route 6 Dinner Promise With Uncle Richard & Deciding Who Speaks Tomorrow

After seeing Brittany safely down the elevator to catch her 2:32 PM southbound JRTC Route 74 bus back across the Manchester Bridge—and after Katie called Aunt Karen, Uncle Steven, and Dad back behind our closed office door to let them know we were rescuing Brittany at two o’clock tomorrow afternoon and bringing her back to our apartment while we figured out the safest way to get her home to Virginia Beach—Katie and I kept our regular Friday afternoon schedule at the General Assembly Building so nothing looked out of the ordinary.

“Wait up, Delegate Prairie! Wait for us!”

Katie and I had just rolled our SwiftChairs out the accessible ground-floor doors onto the brick sidewalk at Ninth and Broad at five-fifteen that evening when three familiar voices called out behind us in the crisp February twilight.

Turning our chairs beside the glass-paneled JRTC bus shelter, we saw thirteen-year-old Sam, Mandy, and Sarah hurrying down the granite steps in their wool winter coats over their navy House Page blazers, holding onto each other’s hands—with the Republican House Majority Leader, their Uncle Richard, and a warm-faced woman in a camel-colored coat walking right behind them.

“Evening again, Delegate. Evening, Nate,” Uncle Richard chuckled, his breath misting in the forty-degree evening air as the five of them stopped beside our footrests. “First, let me introduce my wife—this is Sam, Mandy, and Sarah’s Aunt Marge.”

“It is so wonderful to finally meet both of you in person,” Aunt Marge said warmly, shaking Katie’s hand and then mine with both of hers. “I feel like I already know you two by heart from everything these three tell us at the supper table every night.”

“And second,” Uncle Richard said with a good-natured shake of his head, looking down at his nephew and nieces, “since there’s no evening Page study hall on Friday nights, these three have been begging Marge and me all afternoon to let them go for a real bus ride aboard JRTC with you and Nate so they can see firsthand how you two get around Richmond. If we aren’t intruding on your Friday night plans, how would you two feel about supervising a bipartisan field trip on the Broad Street bus to grab some supper together?”

Katie’s face lit up with genuine gratitude for ninety minutes of warm normalcy before tomorrow’s storm. “Intruding? We would love that!”

“Please say we can ride the Route 6 bus all the way out West Broad Street, Nate!” Sam said eagerly, bouncing slightly on his heels between his twin sisters. “We’ve watched the blue-and-white buses pass Capitol Square all month, and neither Mandy, Sarah, nor I have ever ridden a city transit bus in our lives!”

“Then you three are in for a treat,” I grinned, pointing up the block as the amber LED destination sign of a westbound blue-and-white Stalwart low-floor coach—reading *6 BROAD STREET — OAK LAWN*—glided toward the curb at Ninth and Broad. “We can ride Route 6 six miles west straight up the Broad Street spine to the Oak Lawn shopping center, have dinner together at the Oak Lawn Diner where the tables have wide roll-under aisles for our wheelchairs, and then ride the eastbound Route 6 bus right back here to Downtown Richmond.”

As the forty-foot coach pulled smoothly to the brick curb, the pneumatic air suspension released with a gentle hiss, lowering the front step six inches while the exterior speaker above the folding doors chimed out clearly:

“Route 6. Oak Lawn. Welcome aboard JRTC!”

Sam, Mandy, and Sarah watched in rapt fascination as the hydraulic aluminum front ramp unfolded onto the sidewalk with a quiet whir.

“Afternoon, Delegate! Afternoon, Nate! Got a whole crew with you tonight!” Marcus, the regular Friday evening JRTC operator, called out cheerfully, reaching down to flip up the two cushioned bench seats over the front left and right wheelchair securement bays.

“Teaching the next generation of transit planners how the Broad Street spine works, Marcus,” Katie smiled as she and I rolled smoothly up the ramp, executed a synchronized reverse turn in the wide front vestibule, and backed our SwiftChairs into the left and right securement bays facing each other across the center aisle.

While Marcus clicked the four-point floor retractors onto our wheelchair frame brackets, Katie and I reached up to swipe our standard thirty-day unlimited JRTC magnetic passes through the farebox reader with two clean electronic *beeps*, and Uncle Richard stepped up to feed crisp dollar bills into the bill slot to pay the regular fare for himself, Aunt Marge, and the three triplets.

Sam, Mandy, and Sarah took the sideways bench seat directly behind my wheelchair bay, sitting shoulder to shoulder with their hands resting on the stainless-steel stanchion while Uncle Richard and Aunt Marge sat right across from them behind Katie. As the bus pulled away from Capitol Square and headed west up Broad Street, Katie reached across the center aisle to hold my right hand, just like we did on every bus ride.

“Listen to the speaker above the windshield,” I told the triplets as the coach glided through the Arts District and approached the campus of Central Virginia University.

“Eighth Street,” the onboard GPS annunciator called out in a calm, clear voice, followed block by block by *“Seventh Street”*, *“Sixth Street”*, and *“Fifth Street”*.

“Whoa,” Sarah whispered, her eyes wide as she looked up at the interior LED scroll bar matching the voice announcements. “It announces every single cross street along the way, even when nobody pulls the stop cord!”

“And wait until the bus makes a turn at the end of the line,” Katie told them happily. “Whenever a JRTC bus completes a turn, the GPS announces both street names on the corner inside the bus, and an exterior speaker warns pedestrians in the crosswalk outside that the bus is turning. That way, if a rider is blind, or if someone is autistic

and visiting a neighborhood for the first time and needs to know their exact block so they don't get overwhelmed, the bus tells them exactly where they are every thirty seconds."

"Write that down in the notebook, Sam!" Mandy whispered excitedly, nudging her brother's elbow as Sam pulled a small spiral pocket notebook and a pen out of his navy House Page blazer and began jotting down notes as fast as his hand could move.

As we rolled past the columns of the Science Museum and passed the corner of Broad and Boulevard—where Katie and I pointed out the brick facade of our winter-session apartment building at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts right across from the bus stop—Uncle Richard looked around the clean, brightly lit coach at the Central Virginia University students, hospital nurses in scrubs, and office workers riding home alongside us.

"I have to admit, Delegate," Uncle Richard said thoughtfully, resting his arm around Aunt Marge's shoulders, "when you spend twenty years driving a pickup truck around Danville and walking straight from a downtown Richmond parking deck into the Capitol tunnel, you never actually sit down inside a public transit bus and see how seamlessly two folks in power wheelchairs can go anywhere in the city on their own schedule without asking a single soul for a ride."

"That's why public transit is freedom, Uncle Richard," Sam said seriously, looking up from his pocket notebook. "If you can't drive a car—or if you're thirteen like us, or if you use a SwiftChair like Delegate Prairie and Nate—a bus route with a wheelchair ramp and ten-minute service means you aren't trapped in a house waiting on somebody else."

Katie and I exchanged a quiet, deeply moved glance across the center aisle—thinking simultaneously of Sam, Mandy, and Sarah's rescue a year ago and of our own cousin Brittany sitting across the James River tonight waiting to break free tomorrow afternoon.

Over plates of hot meatloaf, mashed potatoes, grilled cheese sandwiches, and tall glasses of ginger ale and sweet tea at the Oak Lawn Diner, the seven of us spent a warm, restorative hour talking transit timetables and rail connections before riding the eastbound Route 6 bus back to Ninth and Broad at seven-thirty-five. Under the cast-iron streetlamp outside Capitol Square, I handed Sam, Mandy, and Sarah three folded copies of the official JRTC System Map and pocket timetable booklets with their weekend homework assignment: read the whole system map, spot why ten-minute service on Route 6 works so well, find the evening and Sunday service gaps—like zero Sunday buses to the suburban Staples Mill train station—and bring three legislative fixes to Room 518 on Monday afternoon.

By eight-thirty that Friday night, after riding the next westbound Route 6 coach eleven minutes up West Broad Street to Boulevard and locking the deadbolt of Apartment 104 behind us, Katie and I parked our SwiftChairs side by side at the dining table with Brittany's handwritten church address resting between us.

"We need to be really smart about how we do this tomorrow afternoon, Katie," I said quietly, lacing my left fingers through her right hand across our armrests. "Your floor video just crossed twelve million views today, and you're going live on *Meet the Nation* thirty-six hours from now."

Katie nodded slowly, her analytical engineer's mind already running the exact same calculation. "If I open my mouth during that ceremony tomorrow—even by a single syllable—somebody in those pews with a cell phone is going to recognize my face from the news."

"And within an hour," I agreed grimly, "every political tabloid and gossip blog in Virginia will twist Brittany's escape into a headline claiming Delegate Katie Prairie crashed a South Richmond wedding to pull a publicity stunt as a Delegate."

"I won't wear my legislative lapel pin, and I won't wear a blazer," Katie decided firmly, looking straight into my eyes. "And from the second we roll into that church until the second we roll out the back door with Brittany, I am not going to say a single word during the ceremony. Not one."

"I'll speak the objection," I promised her, squeezing her hand tightly. "I'm a private citizen, I'm her cousin, and nobody on television cares about me. When that minister says *speak now or forever hold your peace*, I'll raise my hand and say *I object*—and once Brittany tells the minister the truth in that side room, we bring her straight back here across the river to Apartment 104 and figure out with Dad and Uncle Steven how to keep Tyler from ever coming near her again."

Part 4: Via Southside Plaza, Speaking Up at the Altar, Taking Brittany to Meet the Nation, & Left Onto Macgregory Street

Date: 2016-02-06 at 13:10 America/New_York

Saturday, February 6, 2016, 1:10 PM — Riding JRTC Route 74 ("Via Southside Plaza"), Speaking Up at the Altar, & The Side Room

"Route 74. Oak Grove — via Southside Plaza. Welcome aboard JRTC!"

Standing on the windy brick corner of Ninth and Broad at ten minutes past one on Saturday afternoon—Katie dressed deliberately in a plain dark-navy knit cardigan and slacks without a single brass legislative pin anywhere on her collar, and me in my charcoal suit and tie—you couldn't possibly miss where the forty-foot blue-and-white bus kneeling at the curb was headed. Anyone who rode transit in Richmond quickly learned that JRTC made dead sure every soul within two city blocks knew if a bus was going to Southside Plaza: above the windshield, the amber LED headsign flashed back and forth every two seconds between *74 OAK GROVE* and *VIA SOUTHSIDE PLAZA*, while the external speaker repeated *"via Southside Plaza"* loud enough to echo off the limestone walls of City Hall.

Rolling our two SwiftChairs up the hydraulic front ramp, swiping our thirty-day magnetic passes, and locking into the opposing front mobility bays, Katie and I held hands across the center aisle as Route 74 climbed onto the high steel span of the Manchester Bridge over the churning winter rapids of the James River. On the printed JRTC system map, crossing from Downtown Richmond into the Southside took barely seven minutes; looking down through the bridge railings at the wide expanse of gray water separating Capitol Square from the brick rows of Hillside Court and the worn strip shopping centers along Jefferson Davis Highway and Hull Street, it felt twenty miles further away.

Twenty-two minutes later—before the bus swung west toward the sprawling mid-century transfer bays of Southside Plaza—we pulled the yellow stop cord along Hull Street, rolled down the front ramp onto a cracked concrete sidewalk, and wheeled two blocks down a quiet side street to a stark, window-boxed red-brick church with an unadorned wooden sign out front.

Even from the curb, it was obvious why Brittany had never wanted to set foot in the place. Half the parking spaces sat empty under a gray February sky, zero flowers hung on the heavy double doors, and inside the dim vestibule a bored usher barely glanced up from his phone as Katie and I rolled quietly down the side aisle to an open wheelchair gap beside the fourth row of dark oak pews.

True to our Friday night agreement, Katie kept her hands folded calmly over her lap, her face neutral, and her mouth completely closed.

At two o'clock, tinny organ chords hummed from a pair of wall speakers, and the groom stepped out from the side vestry door beside two of his buddies in an ill-fitting dark suit.

Beside me, Katie's entire body went rigid in her SwiftChair, and my blood turned to ice water in my veins.

We knew him.

Fourteen years had thickened his neck and squared off his heavy jaw, yet neither my twin sister nor I could have forgotten that smug, sneering face if we lived to be a hundred. Standing five feet from the minister's podium was *that* Tyler—the exact loudmouth Northwood High senior who had stumbled down our hallway with a red plastic cup on New Year's Eve 2002 banging on Katie's locked bedroom door, and who had leaned against the cinderblock stairwell outside Room 204 smirking five mornings later after maliciously lying to Heather Collins's face that I had gotten wasted behind a locked door with some random blonde party girl.

Katie shot me one wide-eyed, horrified twin glance—her fingers clamping over my right hand across our armrests so hard her knuckles went white, though true to her promise she didn't let a single gasp escape her closed lips.

Thirty seconds later, Brittany walked slowly up the brown carpet alone in a plain, modest ivory knee-length dress, clutching a small white ribbon-tied bouquet in front of her stomach while a matching ivory handbag hung over her left wrist—heavy enough, I knew immediately, to hold her birth certificate, Social Security card, and wallet. Even across four rows of pews, her face behind her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses looked paler and fiercer than it had in Room 518 yesterday—every trace of hesitation gone, replaced by sheer revulsion every time she had to look anywhere near the man standing at the chancel steps.

When Brittany's eyes flicked toward our fourth-row pew gap and saw Katie and me sitting side by side in our SwiftChairs, her shoulders dropped half an inch in fierce, desperate gratitude.

Beside me, Katie gave my right hand one more unmistakable squeeze. She didn't make a sound.

Up on the low carpeted chancel steps, the silver-haired minister opened his black leather ceremony binder and read briskly through the opening exhortation. Tyler stared straight ahead like he was waiting out a traffic court docket; Brittany stared down at the carpet fibres in front of her ivory shoes, trembling visibly at the hem of her sleeves.

Then the minister turned the page and looked out over the forty scattered guests in the pews.

“Into this estate these two persons come now to be joined,” the minister read in a resonant baritone. “If anyone here present can show any just cause why they may not lawfully be joined together, let them speak now, or forever hold their peace.”

Beside me, Katie sat motionless as carved marble, her lips pressed firmly shut.

I clicked off my electromagnetic wheel brake, rolled my SwiftChair six inches clear of the oak pew end into the aisle, raised my left hand squarely into the air, and projected my voice cleanly across the brick sanctuary.

“I object!”

Every head in the church whipped around like a thunderclap had hit the rafters.

Up on the chancel steps, Tyler spun on his heel, his face purpling instantly as his eyes locked onto my wheelchair and then Katie’s. “What the hell—who let them in here?!” Tyler barked, taking half a lunge down the top step with both fists balled at his sides. “Keep reading, Preacher, that’s nobody—”

“Hold right where you are, young man!” the silver-haired minister commanded sharply, raising his right hand palm-out between Tyler and Brittany while two broad-shouldered church deacons in dark suits immediately stepped out of the front pew to block the bottom of the chancel steps.

Because Brittany wasn’t looking at Tyler anymore—she had turned completely around toward my wheelchair with tears streaming openly down both cheeks behind her wire-rimmed glasses, nodding her head *yes* through her sobs.

“Sir, my name is Nathaniel Prairie,” I said clearly and calmly from the aisle while Katie remained completely silent beside my right wheel. “The bride is our cousin, Brittany Fletcher, and she is standing at this altar under physical duress and coercion against her free will.”

“He’s lying! Brittany, tell him to get the hell out!” Tyler roared, straining against the elder deacon’s outstretched arm.

“No—he’s telling the truth!” Brittany sobbed out loud, clutching her ivory handbag to her chest as she backed two steps away from Tyler toward the minister’s robes. “Please stop the wedding—I don’t want to marry him!”

Every trace of brisk routine vanished from the minister’s weathered face. Closing his ceremony binder with a loud snap, he beckoned immediately to the older gray-haired woman in a burgundy suit standing by the organ—the church’s wedding coordinator—and gestured toward Katie and me.

“Deacon Miller, Deacon Ross, keep the groom and the congregation seated in this sanctuary—nobody comes near that hallway door,” the minister ordered firmly. “Miss Fletcher, bring your bag and come right into the vestry office with Mrs. Holloway and me, and let your cousins roll right in with you.”

Seconds later, the heavy oak door of the private vestry side room clicked shut and bolted behind the five of us, muffling Tyler’s muffled shouting out in the nave.

Inside the quiet brick-walled office, Brittany’s knees gave out onto the upholstered sofa beside Mrs. Holloway’s desk as she sobbed uncontrollably into her hands. Katie rolled smoothly right up beside Brittany’s knee to hold her trembling hand, while I parked my SwiftChair just inside the doorway facing the minister’s bookshelf.

“You’re safe behind this door, child, take your time,” Mrs. Holloway murmured gently, wrapping a wool shawl within reach on the sofa arm as the minister set the unexecuted Circuit Court marriage license envelope flat on his desk. “Your cousin stated under the lawful-impediment charge that you are here under physical duress. Tell us plainly in your own words what happened.”

“He—he hit me on Tuesday night and again Thursday morning when I begged him to wait,” Brittany choked out through ragged gasps, pulling the wooden folding modesty screen beside the vestry coat rack halfway across between the sofa and the desk so only gray-haired Mrs. Holloway stood beside her while the minister and I kept our eyes respectfully fixed on the wall calendar across the room. With trembling fingers, Brittany unfastened the top back hook of her ivory dress collar and shifted the shoulder seam just enough for Mrs. Holloway to witness the ugly purple-and-yellow contusions across her upper back, along with the dark, painful bruise marks where Tyler had struck and wrenched her across her buttocks and her breast.

Mrs. Holloway let out a low, horrified intake of breath—“Lord have mercy, baby, help me zip your dress right back up and put this warm shawl around you”—helping Brittany fasten her collar modestly back in place and wrapping the wool shawl snugly around her shoulders before stepping out from behind the screen and giving her husband-in-ministry a single grim, unmistakable nod.

Sobbing into a handful of tissues with the shawl pulled tight to her chin and Katie holding her hand, Brittany looked frantically up at the minister—making dead certain nobody misunderstood the exact truth of what she was reporting.

“He—he hit me and grabbed me there and left those bruises, Pastor, I swear to God he did,” Brittany cried fiercely through her tears, “and I want you to know he did *not* do anything worse than that—he didn’t force himself on me that way, I swear he didn’t! I just can’t marry him! He screams at me every day, he locked up my cards until this morning, and I’m terrified of what he’s going to do next! Please—I just want to go home to my mom and dad in Virginia Beach, and if getting all the way to Virginia Beach can’t be arranged today, I want to stay right here in Richmond with my cousins!”

“You will never stand beside that man in this church again as long as I draw breath,” the minister said quietly and steel-firm, writing *CEREMONY HALTED — NO CONSENT / DURESS* across the outside sleeve of the unexecuted worksheet and handing Brittany back her own certified birth certificate copy while Mrs. Holloway photographed a written church incident statement for Brittany to take to the Virginia Beach magistrate. “Deacon Miller and Deacon Ross are retired Chesterfield

deputies; they're going to keep Mr. Tyler inside that sanctuary for twenty full minutes while Mrs. Holloway lets the three of you out our rear parish-hall wheelchair ramp straight onto Thirty-Fourth Street so you're already across the river on the bus before he ever sees the parking lot."

"Come on, Brittany," Katie spoke for the very first time since leaving Ninth and Broad—her voice gentle, steady, and full of twin steel as she squeezed Brittany's fingers. "You're staying with Nate and me tonight on West Broad Street, and nobody is letting go of you."

Saturday, February 6, 2016, 11:15 PM — Laughing at Saturday Night Sketch, Inviting Terrified Brittany Into Our Closet, & Finalizing the Washington Plan

By four-thirty that Saturday afternoon, after riding the inbound JRTC Route 74 coach—still flashing *VIA SOUTHSIDE PLAZA* in alternating amber letters before climbing back over the Manchester Bridge into Downtown Richmond—and transferring cleanly onto westbound Route 6 up to Broad and Boulevard, Brittany was locked safely behind the steel deadbolt and keypad lobby of Apartment 104 with a hot bowl of chicken noodle soup, her prepaid cell phone powered completely off with the battery pulled out on the counter, and her ivory wedding dress stuffed down the hallway trash chute.

All evening long, though—wrapped in one of Katie's soft oversized fleece sweatshirts and clean cotton pajama pants while Katie updated Dad, Uncle Steven, and Aunt Karen by phone that we had Brittany safe in our apartment—every single time a city bus air-brake hissed or a car horn echoed three floors below on West Broad Street, Brittany flinched hard behind her wire-rimmed glasses, glancing nervously toward the deadbolted front door.

Hoping to keep her close between us where she didn't have to sit alone with her racing thoughts, I transferred onto the middle cushion of our living room sofa at eleven o'clock with Brittany tucked right against my right shoulder and Katie settled against my left shoulder under our shared fleece blanket—right before Katie's cell phone suddenly buzzed five times in rapid succession on the coffee table at eleven-fifteen.

Katie picked it up and blinked at the stack of incoming text messages from three Capitol beat reporters and the Minority Leader's chief of staff.

"What's going on?" I asked, reaching for the television remote. "Did Delegate Cobb pull House Bill 663 already?"

"No," Katie said slowly, reading the glowing screen in disbelief. "A producer in New York just tipped off the Richmond press corps about the eleven-thirty dress rehearsal for *Saturday Night Sketch* in Studio 6B. On the exact same GBS network where I'm appearing tomorrow morning, their writers just scrapped their entire Oval Office presidential cold open after dress rehearsal because my floor exchange on House Bill 663 stole the show! Everyone is telling us to turn on the television right now because House Bill 663 is the star of the eleven-thirty cold open."

"No way!" Brittany gasped against my right shoulder, sitting straight up under our shared fleece blanket as I clicked on the living room television five minutes before eleven-thirty.

At eleven-thirty sharp, the network chime rang out and the broadcast of *Saturday Night Sketch* faded up on a painted replica of a Virginia State Capitol hallway in Studio 6B.

Right beside a mahogany door marked *LADIES ROOM* stood a cast member wearing a khaki state trooper uniform with an oversized foam campaign hat, a clipboard, and a yellow carpenter's tape measure clipped to his belt, sitting behind a folding card table with a hand-painted poster board sign reading:

> COMMONWEALTH OF VIRGINIA
> ANATOMICAL VERIFICATION CHECKPOINT
> HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE OR FIFTY DOLLARS READY

Beside the folding table stood a second cast member wearing a gray hairpiece and a rumpled navy suit with an oversized name badge reading *DELEGATE FROM SPOTSYLVANIA*.

"Oh my gosh, Katie, look at his badge!" Brittany gasped against my right shoulder, clamping a hand over her mouth as a real grin broke across her face.

"Good evening, fellow Virginians!" the actor playing the Spotsylvania delegate declared earnestly into the camera, dabbing sweat off his forehead with a pocket handkerchief while the New York studio audience immediately started laughing. "Now, I know a lot of folks in the news media got the wrong impression this week when Delegate Katie Prairie asked me on the House Floor how my new bathroom bill, House Bill 663, is actually going to work. People are saying, 'Wait a minute, is the Commonwealth of Virginia really going to make women pull their pants down for a government official just to use the ladies' room at Virginia Dominion University or the Community College of Hampton Roads?' And I am here tonight to assure every tourist, college student, and business owner in America that we have worked out a totally normal, non-creepy system!"

Beside me on the sofa, Brittany let out a startled snort of laughter when the actor on network television said Katie's actual name—and Katie's cheeks turned bright pink against my left shoulder.

On screen, the actor gestured proudly toward the cast member in the state trooper uniform, who blew a silver referee whistle as a female cast member carrying a shopping bag walked up to the restroom door.

"Hold it right there, ma'am!" the fake trooper barked, flipping open his clipboard. "Before you enter this state-owned facility to wash your hands, pursuant to House Bill 663, I need to verify your physical anatomy for the Virginia Literary Fund! Did you bring your original hospital birth certificate with the raised county seal?"

"To go to the bathroom at the DMV?" the woman asked, blinking in disbelief. "No! Why would I carry my birth certificate in my purse?"

The fake trooper gasped and looked over at the Spotsylvania delegate. "Uh-oh, Delegate! No birth certificate in the hallway! What's Step Two in Line 18 of your bill?"

The actor playing the Spotsylvania delegate froze, his eyes going wide under the studio lights as he pulled a twenty-foot-long accordion scroll of paper out of his suit pocket and squinted at it in panic.

“Well—uh—hang on, let me check Line 18!” he stammered, his face turning beet-red as the audience howled. “We don’t—nobody is suggesting we look! Wait—Officer, just ask her a trick question only a biological woman from Virginia would know! Ask her what shade of autumn cardigan she’s wearing!”

Brittany dissolved into full, unguarded belly-laughter against my arm, her shoulders shaking under our fleece blanket harder than I had seen her laugh since we were fifteen years old in Mrs. DeMarco’s cafeteria.

“Actually, Delegate,” the woman on screen said dryly, pulling a crisp fifty-dollar bill out of her wallet and slapping it onto the card table, “if the options in Spotsylvania County are handing a state trooper my birth certificate, answering questions about my pants, or paying fifty bucks to buy schoolbooks for the Virginia Literary Fund, here’s fifty dollars—because clearly Spotsylvania County needs all the schoolbooks it can get!”

The studio audience erupted into cheers and applause as the actor playing the delegate stared helplessly into the camera lens for four silent seconds—mimicking Delegate Martin Cobb’s exact four-second freeze-frame from Thursday afternoon’s House Floor broadcast—before dropping into the folding chair behind the card table and shouting into the camera, “I pass the bill by for the day, Mr. Speaker—and live from Midtown New York, it’s *Saturday Night Sketch*!”

In our living room on West Broad Street, I was laughing so hard my ribs ached, Katie sat staring at the opening saxophone montage with both hands pressed over her warm cheeks, and Brittany had to pull her silver wire-rimmed glasses off her nose to wipe genuine, happy tears out of her eyes.

“I haven’t laughed like that in five years, guys,” Brittany breathed, slipping her glasses back on as I clicked off the television so we could head down the short hallway for bed before our early four-thirty alarm.

The moment we reached the darkened bedroom doorway, however, the laughter drained right out of Brittany’s chest.

Katie had laid fresh sheets and two pillows across the untouched queen bed by the tall loft window overlooking West Broad Street, while she and I rolled toward the wide walk-in closet where our double-wide quilted sleeping bag sat unzipped across thick foam pads on the carpet. Out beyond the bedroom glass, a pair of bright car headlights swung abruptly into the curb lane downstairs, sweeping white glare across the bedroom ceiling—and Brittany froze dead in her tracks, clutching both elbows as her whole body started trembling uncontrollably.

“Katie… Nate,” Brittany whispered, her breath hitching in raw panic as she backed away from the tall bedroom window toward our wheelchairs. “Tyler saw both of your faces in that church today. Everyone in Richmond saw Katie on the news—what if he looks up where Katie lives for the session and comes pounding on doors tonight? What if he comes back here at five in the morning while you two are gone on the train?”

Katie and I took one look at our terrified cousin shivering in the dark hallway and didn’t hesitate for half a second.

“You aren’t sleeping out here by that window alone tonight, Brittany,” Katie said softly and firmly, reaching up onto the closet shelf for a third soft pillow to line up right beside ours at the head of our oversized flannel-lined sleeping bag inside the walk-in closet while I clicked on our dim amber battery lantern on the low shoe shelf. “Come inside the closet and share our sleeping bag and pillows with Nate and me. Zero windows, four solid walls, and the door latches from the inside—this is where Nate and I go whenever the world outside gets scary.”

Stepping gratefully past our two parked SwiftChairs into the warm, enclosed eight-by-six walk-in closet as I transferred onto the foam pads beside Katie and pulled the solid closet door nearly shut, Brittany sank down onto her knees at the edge of the unzipped sleeping bag—and broke down crying all over again, burying her face in her hands as fourteen years and four awful years poured out of her at once.

“There’s something else I didn’t even know yesterday in your office, Nate,” Brittany sobbed, lifting her tear-streaked face in the soft amber glow of the closet lantern as she looked straight at me in anguish. “I swear on my mom and dad’s lives, when I met Tyler four years ago at a tire shop on Little Creek Road, I did *not* know he was the same Tyler from New Year’s Eve! That night when we were seventeen, I was so stupid and wasted in your living room that I didn’t even see who Derek brought in or who walked down your hallway, and after Uncle David banned me the next morning, nobody at school ever told me what happened in Heather Collins’s homeroom on Monday! If I had ever had the slightest idea he was the guy who lied to Heather about you, Nate, I never would have started dating him in a million years!”

Katie and I reached out immediately from the foam pad, each of us taking one of Brittany’s shaking hands.

“Wait—how did you find out?” I asked quietly.

“This morning!” Brittany cried, her voice shaking with pure moral disgust. “At nine o’clock this morning—the morning of my own wedding—while I was trying to pack my bag in Hillside Court, the Richmond morning news replayed Katie’s clip from the Capitol, and the camera panned right past you in your wheelchair, Nate! Tyler looked at the TV while he was buttoning his shirt, started laughing that awful mean laugh of his, and bragged right to my face about how back at Northwood High after a New Year’s Eve party off Military Highway, he got back at *‘that stuck-up wheelchair kid Nate Prairie’* for slamming a bedroom door in his face by telling your girlfriend Heather in homeroom that you were wasted behind a locked door hooking up with some blonde party girl!”

Brittany’s fingers gripped mine desperately. “Yesterday afternoon in your office, part of me was still so scared of him I didn’t know how I was going to stop shaking at that altar—and the second those words came out of his mouth this morning, something snapped clean in half inside me! Realizing I was hours away from marrying the exact person who broke your heart and ruined your name with a lie was the straw that broke the camel’s back, Nate! That’s why I couldn’t bear to stand next to him for one more minute today!”

“Brittany, we believe you completely,” Katie whispered fiercely, pulling Brittany’s hands against her heart while I nodded right beside my sister. “Nate and I figured out who he was the exact second he walked out of that church door at two o’clock today—and both of us knew right away you couldn’t possibly have known what he did in Heather’s homeroom.”

Tears kept spilling down Brittany’s cheeks as she knelt there on the closet carpet before climbing into the sleeping bag, telling Katie and me everything Tyler had done behind closed doors in Hillside Court—taking her paycheck stub every Friday, unplugging the router, screaming inches from her face whenever dinner was late, and snapping violently this week when she begged to call off the ceremony.

“You two didn’t see behind that screen in the pastor’s office today,” Brittany whispered shakily, wiping her nose with the back of her wrist before climbing into the sleeping bag. Turning half sideways in the dim, private amber glow of the enclosed closet so only Katie and I were beside her, Brittany carefully lifted the back hem and shifted the loose neckline of Katie’s oversized fleece sweatshirt for three brief seconds—showing Katie and me the ugly, purpling hand-shaped contusions across her lower and upper back and the dark, swollen bruises where he had struck and wrenched her across the top of her buttocks and her breast, before pulling the thick fleece sweatshirt modestly right back down around her knees and collar. “I swear to both of you, he didn’t do anything worse than that—never—he just grabbed me and hit me so hard I couldn’t even lie on my right side on Thursday night.”

Beside me in the quiet closet, Katie clapped both hands over her mouth in sheer, sickened horror, tears springing instantly into my sister’s blue eyes, while a cold, white-hot fury unlike anything I had felt since Ocean View in 2005 locked every muscle in my chest.

Seeing those bruises on our cousin’s body with our own eyes settled everything on the spot.

“We are *not* leaving you behind in this apartment tomorrow morning while we go to Washington,” Katie said in a low, trembling voice of absolute iron, looking straight across at me.

“Not for five minutes,” I agreed instantly—reaching one arm out past the closet jamb to drag my silver MagnaBook Pro and Katie’s cell phone onto the carpet beside us before we even lay down. “Tyler thinks like a bully from Tidewater: he’s either going to prowl around Richmond looking for Katie’s apartment, or he’s going to tear down Interstate 64 toward Virginia Beach hunting for you at Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven’s house. The one place on earth Tyler will never think to go looking for you tomorrow morning is Washington, D.C.”

Right there on the closet floor at midnight, while Katie sent an urgent text and whispered for two minutes on the phone with a wide-awake Dad down on Arvin Road—arranging for Dad, Uncle Steven, and Aunt Karen to leave Virginia Beach together at dawn, drive straight up Interstate 95 to Alexandria, and wait for us just beyond the King Street–Old Town faregates right after *Meet the Nation*—I booked a third Business Class ticket for Brittany on our 6:05 AM ARTS train reservation and promised we would buy her her own blue CapitalPass card at the Alexandria vending machine in the morning.

Setting the laptop back outside the doorway, I pulled the walk-in closet door firmly shut until the latch clicked, switched off the amber lantern, and helped Katie and Brittany settle into our widened sleeping-bag sanctuary in the safe, pitch-dark quiet—lying right in the middle between my twin sister and our cousin with one protective arm around Katie and the other gently around Brittany's unbruised left shoulder until her trembling finally slowed into deep, exhausted sleep.

Sunday, February 7, 2016, 6:05 AM to 2:05 PM — Taking Brittany to Washington for Meet the Nation & Waiting Beyond the King Street–Old Town Faregates

At five-fifteen on Sunday morning, while the rest of Richmond was still fast asleep in the February dark, Katie and I rolled out onto West Broad Street in our winter coats over our broadcast suits with Brittany walking right between and beside our armrests in her dark winter coat and one of Katie's warm knit scarves, caught the early Sunday morning eastbound JRTC Route 6 bus down the hill into Shockoe Bottom, and rode the station elevator up to the historic train shed at Richmond Main Street Station.

At six-oh-five on the dot, the bright headlamp of ARTS Northeast Regional Train 164 swung around the curve from the Peninsula Subdivision and glided alongside the high-level platform. Katie and I engaged the electromagnetic brakes of our SwiftChairs inside the two integrated Business Class mobility bays while Brittany settled into the cushioned companion seat directly across the aisle beside us, keeping a protective hand resting lightly on my armrest as the floorboard heaters hummed against the February chill.

Because crossing the narrow, shifting steel vestibule diaphragm between railcars on a moving train was completely unsafe in a power wheelchair, neither Katie nor I ever tried to roll into the Café Car while the train was in motion—and even though Brittany immediately offered to walk forward and carry breakfast back for us, the friendly Business Class conductor insisted on bringing a cardboard tray back for all three of us himself.

Because Katie and I were twins, we copied each other for food without even thinking about it, and sleepy Brittany happily copied us right down the line: three identical warm bacon, egg, and cheese biscuits, three sweet cheese Danishes, and three cold bottles of apple juice. Running on four hours of sleep at six-twenty in the morning, neither Katie nor I even had the energy for our usual *"Hey, you have my biscuit!"* twin routine—all three of us simply unwrapped our matching breakfasts in sleepy synchrony, sipped cold apple juice as the winter sun rose pale pink and gold over the Rappahannock River at Fredericksburg and the Potomac creeks along Quantico, and let the rhythmic click of the rails carry Brittany safely a hundred miles north of Richmond.

At seven-fifty sharp, Train 164 pulled to a stop at Alexandria Union Station beneath the white stone spire of the George Washington Masonic Memorial.

Detraining onto the brick platform with the station attendant's portable lift rather than staying onboard for the slow twenty-eight-minute freight-switch crawl into Washington Union Station, the three of us followed the flat brick walkway a hundred and fifty feet straight into the King Street–Old Town Capital Transit station. While Katie and I pulled our familiar blue plastic CapitalPass cards out of our

wallets, I rolled up to the accessible Capital Transit ticket vending machine along the brick mezzanine wall, tapped the touchscreen to purchase a brand-new reloadable blue CapitalPass card loaded with round-trip rail and bus fare for Brittany, and handed the crisp new plastic card up to her as it dropped into the dispenser tray.

“Hang onto that card even after today, Brittany,” Katie smiled beside me. “Once we get to a computer, we’ll get the serial number on the back registered online in your name so your fare balance is protected whenever you ride transit up here with us.”

Brittany tucked the blue card proudly between her fingers like a badge of freedom, and the three of us tapped our CapitalPass cards against the circular target pads on the wide accessible faregate, rode the elevator up to the island platform, and rolled straight onto a waiting northbound Yellow Line train.

Twelve minutes later, just past the Pentagon tunnel portal, our silver railcar burst out into the bright morning sunlight high above the Potomac River on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge.

Directly to our right across the shimmering gray water, the northbound highway lanes of Interstate 395 on the 14th Street Bridge were backed up for half a mile behind an early-morning fender bender and a highway maintenance truck—the exact traffic jam a network limousine would have been stuck idling in right then—while our Yellow Line train flew across the river at fifty miles an hour past the white marble dome of the Jefferson Memorial and the Washington Monument.

“Told you the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge beats the 14th Street Bridge every single time,” I grinned across the aisle at Katie and Brittany as we glided smoothly into L’Enfant Plaza at eight-twelve, rode the street elevator up to Seventh Street and Maryland Avenue Southwest, and rolled fifty feet down the sunny brick sidewalk onto a kneeling Capital Transit Route P6 bus—where our CapitalPass cards flashed green with the automatic rail-to-bus transfer discount, carrying the three of us across the open green lawn of the National Mall and past the gleaming dome of the United States Capitol right to the curb on North Capitol Street Northwest at eight-thirty-two.

When we rolled through the security glass of the GBS News Washington bureau three minutes later, senior producer Arthur Vance nearly dropped his coffee mug realizing Katie had genuinely brought her brother and cousin all the way from Richmond by city bus, intercity rail, Yellow Line subway, and local D.C. bus—immediately ushering Brittany into the private, card-locked green room down the hall with hot herbal tea, pastries, and a clear studio monitor feed where zero cameras could ever catch her face.

Inside the main studio, the floor crew had cleared away the standard swivel guest chair and projected a high-resolution panorama of Thomas Jefferson’s white-columned Virginia State Capitol across the curved LED wall behind Katie’s tape mark, while the side monitor glowed blue with *MEET THE NATION — DEL. KATIE PRAIRIE*. When a well-meaning stage manager asked if Camera One should crop tight around Katie’s shoulders so viewers wouldn’t focus on her wheelchair, Katie shook her head politely.

“Keep the frame wide enough to show my chair, please,” Katie told him warmly. “A lot of people watching across the country this morning have never seen a legislator in a power wheelchair on a Sunday morning show, and I don’t hide who I am.”

Seated just outside the wide camera frame beneath the confidence monitor with my silver MagnaBook Pro open to the statutory text of House Bill 663 and Virginia’s fourteen Fortune 500 corporate headquarters, I gave my twin sister a steady nod as the brass orchestra fanfare echoed and Camera One’s tally light flared red at nine o’clock sharp.

“If it’s Sunday, it’s *Meet the Nation*,” moderator David Vance announced coast to coast. “Joining us live in our Washington studio this morning—after riding the early morning train up from Richmond Main Street Station and the Yellow Line across the Potomac—is Virginia Delegate Katie Prairie of Virginia Beach, whose blistering ninety-five-second exchange on the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates over House Bill 663 has been viewed more than twelve million times since Thursday afternoon, and was even immortalized last night in the cold open on late-night television. Delegate Prairie, welcome to *Meet the Nation*.”

“Good morning, David,” Katie said evenly into Camera One. “Thank you for having me—and the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge was wide open all the way across the river.”

“Delegate, let’s start with that moment on the House Floor on Thursday,” Vance said, as the broadcast aired the ninety-five-second floor clip side by side with our live studio feed. “You held up the printed text of House Bill 663 and asked the bill’s patron why you, or any woman or girl in the Commonwealth of Virginia, should have to pull her pants down for a government official or a police officer just to use the ladies’ room at a community college, a public university, or the State Capitol. Critics on the other side of the aisle claim you were being deliberately theatrical to embarrass the majority. Did you plan that line to go viral?”

“Not at all, David,” Katie replied, her voice calm, clear, and completely literal. “Anyone who knows my twin brother Nate and me back home in Virginia Beach and Norfolk knows I don’t do political theater. We write computer software for a living, and when a bill is placed on our desks in the House of Delegates, my job as a constitutional officer is to read every single word literally—because the courts and the police have to enforce the literal words we put into the Code of Virginia, not whatever talking point a politician gives at a press conference afterward.”

Out of the corner of her eye, Katie glanced toward my chair as I tapped the touchpad of my laptop beside the studio monitor.

“And when you read Line 18 on Page 1 and Line 54 on Page 2 of House Bill 663 side by side,” Katie continued smoothly, “the bill applies to every public building, public school, and public college campus owned or leased by the Commonwealth. It defines compliance not by an identification card or how someone lives their daily life, but strictly by what it calls ‘a person’s anatomy,’ and it authorizes any law enforcement officer to issue a fifty-dollar civil summons for the Literary Fund. As someone who has used a power wheelchair full-time since I was sixteen years old—and who had to pull out a steel tape measure before my freshman session just to get an ADA-compliant restroom stall wide enough to close the door in privacy inside our own State Capitol complex—I asked the gentleman from Spotsylvania that question on Thursday because I wanted a literal, legal answer to a basic Fourth Amendment problem: since police officers standing in the hallway of the State

Capitol, Virginia Dominion University, or the Community College of Hampton Roads do not carry a filing cabinet of citizens' birth certificates, how can an officer prove a citizen's physical anatomy in General District Court without conducting an invasive physical search?"

"And as millions of Americans saw on Thursday—and again in parody last night in New York—the patron couldn't answer you," Vance noted. "Instead, the Majority Leader had to pass the bill by for the day. What are you hearing from Virginia's business community and House leadership ahead of tomorrow's noon session?"

"What I can tell you is that employers, universities, and families across Hampton Roads, Richmond, and Northern Virginia are deeply alarmed," Katie said clearly. "Virginia is home to the largest naval base in the world at Norfolk, major shipbuilding and port facilities, world-class public universities like Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute and Virginia Dominion University, and fourteen Fortune 500 corporate headquarters. Transgender women are women, transgender men are men, and none of those employers—and none of the working families I represent in Virginia Beach—sent us to Richmond to waste taxpayer money turning police officers into fifty-dollar bathroom inspectors or turning our Commonwealth into a national punchline. We have coastal flooding to mitigate, public transit systems to expand, disability Medicaid waitlists to clear, and classrooms to fund."

"One final question before we let you go, Delegate Prairie," Vance said, his tone warming with genuine respect. "A lot of viewers across the country are meeting you for the very first time this weekend. You entered public life after fighting to fix public transit schedules in Hampton Roads, and now you've single-handedly brought one of the most controversial bills in the country to a dead halt. Do you have your sights set on higher office down the road—perhaps the State Senate or even here in Washington?"

Just off-camera beneath the studio monitor, I smiled faintly above my laptop keyboard.

"Right now, David, my only focus is noon tomorrow in the building right behind me," Katie said, gesturing slightly toward the glowing image of the Virginia State Capitol behind her SwiftChair, "and catching the eleven-twelve ARTS train out of Alexandria so we can get back to Richmond this afternoon. Once we make sure House Bill 663 is permanently laid on the table where it belongs, I have transportation and accessibility amendments to pass for the people of Virginia Beach."

"Delegate Katie Prairie of Virginia Beach, thank you for joining us this morning," Vance said.

By nine-eighteen, the red tally light atop Camera One clicked off and the floor director unclipped the miniature microphone from the lapel of Katie's royal-blue blazer.

Arthur Vance walked out onto the studio floor holding his cell phone with wide eyes alongside fresh mugs from the green room, where Brittany stood grinning from ear to ear inside the doorway after watching every word on the green-room feed. "Delegate Prairie, our control room phones are already lighting up from Capitol Hill to Richmond, and the Associated Wire just put out an urgent alert from the Virginia

State Capitol—House leadership just announced they are sending House Bill 663 back to the General Laws subcommittee tomorrow morning to strike it from the docket before the noon floor gavel even falls!”

Declining the network town car politely so we wouldn’t miss our handover in Alexandria, Katie and I picked up Brittany from the green room at nine-twenty-five, rolled back aboard the southbound Capital Transit Route P6 bus across the National Mall to L’Enfant Plaza, and rode a southbound Yellow Line train right back across the sunlit Charles R. Fenwick Bridge into Virginia.

At ten-sixteen on Sunday morning, the three of us rode the glass platform elevator down into the brick mezzanine of the King Street–Old Town station and rolled toward the row of stainless-steel faregates.

Brittany gasped softly beside my left wheel, her hands flying to her mouth.

Standing side by side right there on the unpaid concourse just beyond the faregates—having driven three and a half hours straight up Interstate 64 and Interstate 95 together from Virginia Beach since dawn—were our dad David in his navy windbreaker, Uncle Steven in his canvas work jacket, and Aunt Karen holding her arms wide open with tears already shining on her cheeks.

The instant Brittany tapped her blue CapitalPass card and stepped through the wide accessible gate ahead of our SwiftChairs, Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven wrapped their daughter between them in a fierce, sobbing three-way embrace while Dad stepped right up behind them, resting a steady hand on Uncle Steven’s shoulder before leaning down to hug Katie and me tight across our armrests.

“We’ve got you now, baby girl,” Uncle Steven whispered roughly against the top of Brittany’s hair, holding his daughter like he was never letting go again. “You’re coming straight home to Virginia Beach with your mama, Uncle David, and me today—we’re stopping straight at the magistrate’s office to file that protective order, and you’re going to take all the time you need to catch your breath and put your life back together.”

Wiping her cheeks behind her glasses while keeping one arm around Aunt Karen’s waist, Brittany turned back to Katie and me as the six of us walked and rolled the hundred and fifty feet down the flat brick path into Alexandria Union Station twenty minutes before our eleven-twelve southbound train.

“Katie… Nate,” Brittany said softly, kneeling halfway down beside our touching armrests in the quiet brick waiting room so her eyes were right on a level with ours. “Thank you for opening that elevator door on Friday, and thank you for speaking up for me yesterday. I dropped out in the spring of senior year after everything fell apart, and I’m tired of feeling stuck. As soon as Mom, Daddy, and I get back to Virginia Beach this week, I’m signing up for classes at the Coastal Adult Learning Center off Virginia Beach Boulevard to earn my HSE—and maybe even take classes at the Community College of Hampton Roads after that—so I can finally get my life back together.”

Katie flipped up her inner armrest and hugged Brittany tightly around the neck while I held Brittany’s hand firmly in mine.

“Listen to us, Brittany,” I told her, smiling steadily as Katie nodded right beside my cheek. “Route 15 connects right to Route 20 straight past the Coastal Adult Learning Center and CCHR. The sixty-day General Assembly session adjourns in five weeks in mid-March, and the day the gavel drops in Richmond, Katie and I are coming straight back home to Arvin Road in Virginia Beach. That promise the three of us made walking home from Northwood High School is still good—whenever you’re ready this spring, you can move right in with Katie and me while you study for your HSE.”

Brittany nodded through bright, happy tears, hugging both of us one more time before Dad, Uncle Steven, and Aunt Karen stood together on the Alexandria brick platform waving until our eleven-twelve southbound ARTS Northeast Regional Train 143—with Katie grinning playfully across the aisle over our cold apple juices to tease *“Hey, you have my juice!”* before we connected smoothly onto the lift-equipped ARTS Thruway 8443 motorcoach at Staples Mill—carried Katie and me back to Main Street Station, westbound Route 6, and our soft cotton sweatshirts in Apartment 104 by five minutes past two.

Monday, February 8, 2016, 11:45 AM & 2:12 PM — House Bill 663 Laid on the Table & Tyler’s Blind-Rage Left Turn Onto Macgregory Street

At quarter to twelve on Monday morning downstairs in the packed General Laws subcommittee room, with television cameras jammed shoulder-to-shoulder along both walls, House Bill 663 died in nine seconds flat.

Without allowing a single word of floor debate, the subcommittee chairman called for a motion to lay House Bill 663 on the table, gaveled through an unrecorded voice vote before anyone could demand a roll call, and watched a beet-red Delegate Martin Cobb—flanked by an equally sour Delegate Robert Marsh muttering about bringing back his own Physical Privacy Act next year—snatch up his folders and snap into the open air as he stormed out into the corridor:

“I’m going to pray that you all get courage!”

Two hours later at twelve minutes past two, right after the brief Monday afternoon floor session adjourned and Katie and I rolled back into Room 518 ahead of our afternoon transit-map review with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah, Katie’s private cell phone rang with Dad’s number flashing on the screen.

Katie tapped speakerphone immediately. “Hi, Dad! House Bill 663 is officially dead on the table—how is Brittany holding up today?”

“Brittany, Karen, Steven, and I are all completely unharmed, kiddos, and every kid outside on the buses is going to be okay—I wanted to tell you that first before you hear the helicopters on the Norfolk news,” Dad said urgently over the speaker, the unmistakable wail of multiple Virginia Beach Fire and EMS sirens echoing clearly behind his voice. *“Steven and I are standing out on the front lawn of Karen and Steven’s house on Earlton Court right now while Karen stays inside with Brittany.”*

Katie and I both froze over her desk blotter, gripping each other’s hands across our armrests. “Dad, why are there sirens on Earlton Court?!” I asked sharply.

"Tyler showed up here twenty minutes ago," Dad said grimly. *"He drove down from Richmond hunting for Brittany, parked crooked across Steven's driveway at quarter to two, and started pounding on the storm door screaming for her to come out. Steven and I stepped right onto the front porch without letting him within twenty feet of Brittany, handed him a copy of the emergency protective order notice through the screen, and told him Virginia Beach Police were already three minutes out on Kempsville Road and he needed to get off the property."*

Katie's eyes widened. "Did he try to fight you and Uncle Steven?"

"No—he lost his mind completely behind the wheel instead," Dad exhaled heavily. *"You two remember how Earlton Court is laid out from walking over here in ninth and tenth grade: when you leave Karen and Steven's house by car, you have to turn right onto Macgregory Street to get out of the neighborhood, because turning left goes straight into the dead end at Smoker's Corner against the Northwood High School fence."*

My stomach plunged as the exact mental map of those streets flashed behind my eyes—two hundred and fifty straight feet of level residential asphalt dead-ending into a wooden red-and-white striped barricade, a galvanized chain-link fence, an unbroken concrete curb, and Lions Way.

"Dad… two o'clock on a Monday afternoon," Katie whispered in horror. "Two o'clock is Northwood High dismissal!"

"Right at the two o'clock bell," Dad confirmed solemnly. *"Tyler was in such a blind, foaming rage storming off Steven's driveway that instead of turning right off Earlton Court to leave, he yanked his wheel hard left onto Macgregory Street, floored the gas pedal straight to the floorboards down the dead end, blasted clean through the wooden barricade and the chain-link fence separating Macgregory Street and Lions Way, launched over the curb, and T-boned square into the side of a departing yellow Northwood High School bus full of students—with an entire dismissal line of loaded school buses bumper-to-bumper right behind it."*

Katie pressed her free hand over her mouth as my heart pounded in my throat. "Oh my God—the students on that bus?!"

"Thank God for thirty-thousand-pound steel school-bus frames," Dad said, huge relief audible in his voice even over the rumble of fire engines down the block. *"The fire battalion chief and Northwood's School Resource Officer just walked down the street to take mine and Steven's witness statements. Because a loaded sixty-five-passenger school bus weighs seven times what Tyler's sedan did—and because the heavy steel floor rail sits three and a half feet off the pavement right above a car's hood with those high-backed padded seats—the bus jolted sideways a foot and a half and braked clean without tipping or hitting the bus behind it. Every one of the fifty-four teenagers onboard and the bus driver walked off with bumps and bruises, and ambulances and a relief bus are taking all of them to the hospital right now just to get checked out."*

"And Tyler?" I asked quietly.

"He wasn't even wearing a seatbelt, Nate—his car submarined at full throttle into the steel frame rail of that bus and crushed the engine block and steering column straight back into the driver's seat," Dad replied solemnly. *"Firefighters took twenty minutes with hydraulic cutters to pull him out of the wreckage, and the paramedics*

just rushed him code-three under armed Virginia Beach Police guard to the Level 1 Trauma Center at Tidewater General Hospital in Norfolk. From what the battalion chief just told police, his spine and pelvis took the brunt of the impact—even if the trauma surgeons put him back together tonight, he is going to be severely disabled for the rest of his life. And between felony unlawful-wounding and fifty-five assault counts for every bruised student and the bus driver sent to the hospital, two felony counts of destroying a city barricade and a public school bus, violating Brittany's protective order, and the domestic assault detainer coming down from Richmond, a magistrate is already holding a bedside hearing at Tidewater General to hold him without bond—the detective told Karen and Steven that the day he leaves that trauma ward, he's going straight into a state medical prison for years."

Inside quiet Room 518 five floors above Capitol Square, Katie and I let out one long, simultaneous breath that felt like setting down a boulder we had been carrying since Friday afternoon—flipping up our inner armrests so I could pull my twin sister straight into a tight, silent deep-pressure hug across our chairs just seconds before three familiar pairs of footsteps and rustling JRTC system maps echoed cheerfully down the marble hallway from Sam, Mandy, and Sarah.

Fourteen years after Smoker's Corner had stolen our cousin away across an uncut curb, Tyler was never going to hurt Brittany again—and in five short weeks, our cousin was coming home.

Keeping Our High-School Promise, Rescuing Cousin Chelsea From Mount Regalis, & Out of the Closet Into Our Four-Person Nest

Part 1: Sine Die, Welcoming Brittany Home to Arvin Road, Route 20 to the Coastal Adult Learning Center, & Three Cousins in the Closet

Date: 2016-03-14 at 16:30 America/New_York

Monday, March 14, 2016, 4:30 PM — Sine Die, Unloading Boxes on Arvin Road, & Brittany Joining Us Inside the Closet

"Careful with the bottom flap on that one, Steven—that's all of her math workbooks and flashcard boxes!" Aunt Karen called out cheerfully from the top of our aluminum front-porch ramp on Arvin Road as Uncle Steven carried a taped cardboard carton past our two parked SwiftChairs into the living room.

"Got it right against my belt buckle, Karen," Uncle Steven grinned, setting the box gently beside the sofa while our dad followed right behind him with Brittany's quilted winter duffel bag slung over one shoulder and a freshly cut brass front-door key resting in his palm.

Three days after the Speaker's wooden gavel had dropped on the final afternoon of the 2016 General Assembly session in Richmond, the March breeze blowing off the pines along Indian River Road smelled of salt air, damp oak bark, and home. Out by the curb behind Dad's accessible minivan, Uncle Steven's pickup truck sat with its tailgate down and only two laundry baskets left in the bed. Standing in the center of

our sunlit hallway in her plum knit sweater and jeans, thirty-year-old Brittany adjusted her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses, looked around at the framed blue butterfly print down the hall and our dual-desk office across from our bedroom, and let out a long, quiet breath that seemed to let go of fourteen hard years all at once.

Dad stepped up beside Katie's armrest and held out the newly cut brass house key.

"Welcome home to Arvin Road, Brittany," Dad said warmly, closing her fingers gently around the brass bow before glancing down at Katie and me with proud eyes. "You three talked about sharing a roof back when you were walking home from Northwood High School. Took a few extra detours to get here, maybe, but a promise kept is a promise kept."

"Thank you, Uncle David," Brittany whispered, her voice catching slightly before she leaned down to hug Dad around the shoulders, hugged her mom and dad tight at the front door when they headed back over to Earlton Court for supper, and then stood with Katie and me in the quiet living room listening to the refrigerator hum.

For the rest of that Monday evening—after Dad drove back north up Interstate 64 and Interstate 95 toward Alexandria so he wouldn't miss his Tuesday morning shift in Tysons Corner—the three of us fell right back into the easy, unhurried rhythm we had known since the Blizzard of '96. We heated up a big pot of vegetable soup and grilled six golden cheddar sandwiches in the skillet, sorted Brittany's sweaters into the freshly cleared dresser drawers in Dad's spare room so she had plenty of closet rod space of her own, and quizzed her for an hour over ginger ale at the kitchen table from her Coastal Adult Learning Center placement packet.

At ten-fifteen, after we took turns brushing our teeth at the roll-under bathroom sink and changed into soft flannel pajamas, Katie and I rolled side by side into our bedroom and braked our SwiftChairs just short of the untouched navy-and-slate-blue queen bed.

Both of us hesitated at the exact same second, glancing shyly from the smooth comforter on the queen mattress over to the open double doors of our bedroom closet, where our wide navy-blue quilted sleeping bag and four pillows lay spread across the vacuumed carpet.

"Brittany," Katie began gently, lacing her fingers through mine across our wheelchair armrests, "back in Richmond on that Saturday night after the church, we brought you into the walk-in closet because you were terrified Tyler might look through the loft window. Now that he's locked inside the prison ward up at Tidewater General and can never hurt anybody again, you don't have to squeeze onto a closet floor on our account. Dad's spare room has a full mattress with clean sheets, or you can take this whole queen bed right here."

"Yeah," I added quietly, feeling the familiar warmth rise in my ears even with our closest cousin in the world. "Ever since Brenda bang-searched the back alley behind our apartment on Greenway Court when we were eighteen, Katie and I just… haven't been able to turn our brains off on an open bed. We always sleep in the closet. We don't want you thinking you're stuck on carpet just because our nervous systems are wired sideways."

Brittany stood by the foot of the queen bed looking down at the two of us behind her wire-rimmed lenses, and her whole face softened with fierce, unmistakable affection.

Without saying a word, she walked straight past the untouched queen bed, pulled a third soft pillow in a clean cotton case off the mattress, knelt down inside our wide bedroom closet, and tucked that third pillow snugly right beside Katie's and mine at the top of our oversized navy-blue sleeping bag.

"Scoot over and make room under the zipper, both of you," Brittany said softly, patting the open flannel-lined sleeping bag inside the closet alcove and smiling up at our wheelchairs.

Katie blinked in surprise. "Brittany, seriously—your back doesn't need to squeeze into a sleeping bag on the closet carpet just because ours do."

"My back slept better inside that West Broad Street sleeping bag between my two cousins than it slept in five straight years across the river," Brittany answered simply, reaching out to squeeze Katie's hand and then mine. "Listen to me, you two. You opened an elevator door for me when I didn't have an appointment or a friend left in the world. You sat in a church pew and stood up for me when I was shaking too hard to speak. Until the night both of you genuinely feel safe enough to climb into a proper bed without your hearts racing, I don't want a mattress out here by myself. My spot is right here in the closet sharing this sleeping bag and these pillows with you—and one day, when we're ready, we'll figure out the bed part together, as slow as it takes."

My throat went tight in the warm lamplight, and beside me Katie smiled with bright, grateful eyes.

Locking our SwiftChair brakes side by side at the closet threshold and clicking off our joystick controllers, Katie and I transferred smoothly down into our wide flannel-lined sleeping bag while Brittany climbed right inside the sleeping bag beside us with all three of our pillows lined up side by side, set her wire-rimmed glasses safely inside her felt case by the baseboard, and helped me pull the closet doors nearly shut until only a thin ribbon of hallway nightlight remained. With Katie nestled against my left shoulder holding my hand and Brittany wrapping a warm, protective arm across Katie's shoulder to clasp my forearm under the shared sleeping bag, all three of us drifted peacefully to sleep inside our sanctuary.

Tuesday, March 22 & Thursday, May 26, 2016 — Riding Route 15 and Route 20 to the Coastal Adult Learning Center, Passing the HSE, & A Ninety-Second Call to Braxton

"Route 20. Virginia Beach Boulevard — Municipal Center / Oceanfront. Welcome aboard CVTA!"

Eight mornings later under crisp March sunshine, the hydraulic front flip-ramp of the eastbound Route 20 bus folded back into the right-hand vestibule stepwell and the forty-foot coach eased back into the rightmost of the four eastbound lanes along the wide eight-lane divided expanse of U.S. Route 58—Virginia Beach Boulevard—leaving Katie, Brittany, and me on the sunny concrete sidewalk in front of the single-story brick Coastal Adult Learning Center.

Brittany stood very still for three seconds, clutching her navy three-ring study binder against her plum sweater as she stared at the glass entrance doors where adult students in scrubs, work boots, and hoodies were walking inside for the nine o'clock morning session.

"My palms are sweating worse than ninth-grade algebra," Brittany admitted softly, adjusting her glasses with two fingers. "Everyone inside is going to take one look at a thirty-year-old woman who walked out of Northwood High in the spring of 2003 and wonder what took me thirteen years."

Katie rolled her SwiftChair six inches forward and took Brittany's free hand firmly in hers while I rolled right up on Brittany's other side.

"Every single adult walking through those glass doors is here for the exact same reason—because life knocked them sideways once and they came back to finish what they started," Katie told her warmly. "And remember what Nate and I learned when we went back to finish our associate degrees at CCHR: nobody in an adult classroom cares what year you started. They only care that you showed up today."

"Besides," I grinned up at her from my chair, tapping the canvas messenger bag slung across my lap where Katie and I had packed our laptops to work remotely from the public library study tables half a block down while Brittany was in class, "we rode Route 15 up from Military Highway and transferred onto Route 20 right beside you, and we'll be waiting right out here on this bench at twelve-fifteen to quiz you on quadratic equations all the way home."

Brittany let out a genuine laugh, squeezed Katie's hand and mine, squared her shoulders, and walked through the glass doors with her head held high.

For the next nine weeks through April—including a cheerful thirty-first birthday supper Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven cooked for Katie, Brittany, and me with Dad down from Alexandria—and into late May, that morning bus relay down Military Highway and Virginia Beach Boulevard became our favorite part of every weekday. While Brittany tackled language arts, constitutional civics, laboratory science, and algebra inside the Coastal Adult Learning Center, Katie and I answered constituent emails for the Eighty-Fifth House District and wrote custom PHP inventory and scheduling applications for Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC. Every evening after supper on Arvin Road, the three of us spread index cards across the dining table until linear equations and reading-comprehension passages felt like second nature to Brittany, before brushing our teeth and curling up side by side inside our quiet bedroom closet.

Then, at five-thirty on the warm Thursday afternoon of May 26, when Dad drove down early for the Memorial Day weekend and sat with Katie and me around the Arvin Road kitchen table with four chilled bottles of ginger ale waiting on coasters, Brittany practically floated up the front porch ramp waving an official Commonwealth of Virginia testing printout stamped *PASSED — HIGH SCHOOL EQUIVALENCY CREDENTIAL AWARDED*.

"Four for four on the first try—and I got College-Ready honors on Language Arts and Social Studies!" Brittany cheered, throwing her arms around Dad, Katie, and me in turn as Katie clapped excitedly and Dad beamed like a proud father.

“And starting Monday morning,” Katie announced happily, sliding a freshly printed independent-contractor household-and-operations agreement from Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC across the oak tabletop beside Brittany’s ginger ale, “if you still want the job Nate and I talked about, Prairie Twin Interactive is officially hiring our favorite HSE graduate on private company payroll—zero state or taxpayer dollars—to help manage our back-office bookkeeping and household operations right here on Arvin Road.”

Brittany’s eyes misted behind her lenses as she signed her name neatly across the bottom line. “Are you kidding? Living and working right here with my favorite people on earth is the best job in Virginia.”

As we clinked our four ginger ale glasses together over the signed page, Dad glanced up at the wall clock above the stove—six o’clock on the fourth Thursday of the month—and his warm smile tightened slightly around the corners of his eyes.

“Speaking of family,” Dad said quietly, pulling his cell phone from his shirt pocket and setting it in the center of the table on speakerphone, “it’s six o’clock on the fourth Thursday. That’s the ten-minute window when Regalis Community House up in Braxton lets me call your Cousin Chelsea before their supper cleanup.”

Brittany looked curiously from Dad to me. “Uncle David’s niece up in Rhode Island—Aunt Liz’s daughter?”

“Yeah,” I said softly, feeling an old, nagging knot tighten in my chest every time I remembered hugging a crying twenty-two-year-old Chelsea goodbye at the top of her wooden ramp on Dirty Old Tonomy Hill on December 27, 2004 and whispering in her ear that next time it really would be just Katie and me—with zero Tiffany anywhere near us. “After Newport tore down the old World War II public-housing apartments on Tonomy Hill a few years after Aunt Liz and Grandma Ruth died, Chelsea tried living on her own in a private apartment, and because of her developmental delays it fell apart. Rhode Island adult services placed her in a contracted group home on the edge of the King’s College campus up in Braxton. Before Brittany moved home, with Katie and me in full-time powerchairs riding buses to Richmond and Dad working full-time up in Northern Virginia, we didn’t have anyone ambulatory at home during the day who could safely help look after Chelsea.”

On the table, the speakerphone rang four times before clicking open—not in a private bedroom, but with the hollow echo of a tiled institutional hallway.

“Regalis Community House, Director Sterling speaking! How may we brighten your evening?” a man’s voice boomed through the speaker in syrupy, fake-jovial church-deacon sweetness that sounded like molasses poured over sheet metal.

“Good evening, Mr. Sterling—it’s David Prairie calling from Virginia with Katie and Nate for our monthly check-in with my niece Chelsea,” Dad said politely.

“Why, Mr. Prairie! Wonderful to hear from you, sir!” Director Sterling chuckled warmly without missing half a beat, though none of us heard footsteps walking away to give Chelsea privacy—only the heavy scuff of hard-soled men’s dress loafers staying planted right beside the wall receiver. *“Chelsea, step right up here and tell your nice uncle in Virginia how wonderfully you’re doing before seven-thirty quiet hours!”*

Katie, Brittany, and I all stiffened at the exact same instant. *Seven-thirty quiet hours?* Outside our kitchen window in late May, the sun was still bright above the pine tops, and up in Rhode Island it wouldn't even get dark until after eight-fifteen.

"H-hi, Unca David… hi, Nate… Katie," thirty-four-year-old Chelsea's familiar, thickly slurred voice came through the line—halting, effortful, and pitched high with unmistakable fear as her severe speech impediment blurred the consonants together—followed immediately by a tight, whistling intake of breath deep in her bronchial tubes that I knew by heart from Christmas Eve 2004.

"Hi, Chelsea!" I leaned close to the speaker, keeping my voice warm and gentle while Katie gripped my left hand hard. "You sound a little wheezy tonight, Cous. Do you have your rescue inhaler right there in your cardigan pocket?"

For two full seconds, dead silence hung on the line—except for the faint rustle of Director Sterling's starch-stiff sleeve shifting right beside the microphone.

"U-uh-huh… me fine, Nate," Chelsea whispered in a flat, scared cadence that sounded nothing like our affectionate cousin at all, working hard to push each short word out. *"G-gotta fold purple papers now… bedtime soon. Bye, Unca David."*

"There we are—she's excited to finish her evening crafts with her housemates, Mr. Prairie!" Director Sterling's syrupy baritone cut right back across the speaker before Chelsea could form another syllable. *"Have a blessed Memorial Day down in Virginia, folks! Buh-bye now!"*

Click.

Inside our sunlit kitchen on Arvin Road, nobody spoke for five seconds.

Brittany stared down at the silent phone on the oak table, her face pale behind her wire-rimmed glasses because she knew the sound of someone speaking with a warden standing two feet over their shoulder better than anyone in the room.

"She wasn't doing arts and crafts for fun, Uncle David," Brittany said quietly, her voice trembling with sudden, protective recognition. "That man was standing right over that wall phone glaring down at her—and she couldn't catch her breath."

Katie turned her SwiftChair sharply toward Dad and me, her blue eyes blazing with the exact forensic focus that had brought the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates to a standstill three months earlier.

"Seven-thirty bedtime in May, 'purple papers' for King's College, and Chelsea wheezing without her rescue inhaler while that man cuts the line off after ninety seconds," Katie said flatly. She looked across the table at Brittany, at Dad, and at me. "We aren't calling ahead next month so Mr. Sterling can rehearse her at the wall phone. We have Brittany right here under our roof now, we have Prairie Twin Interactive paying the bills, and Dad has vacation days saved up in July. We're driving Dad's wheelchair van straight up Interstate 95 to Braxton unannounced—and we're bringing our cousin home."

Part 2: Turned Away at the Royal Gate, Riding BTA Route 99 Up Mount Regalis, Catching the Two-Faced Manager Red-Handed, & ‘No Known Living Family’

Date: 2016-07-18 at 13:40 America/New_York

Monday, July 18, 2016, 1:40 PM — Turned Away at King’s College’s Wrought-Iron Gate & Riding BTA Route 99 (“The Scrub Bus”) Up Mount Regalis

“Whoa there—hold it right at the booth, Virginia plates,” the uniformed King’s College campus security officer barked, stepping out of his air-conditioned stone gatehouse beneath a towering wrought-iron arch emblazoned in gilded purple-and-gold lettering with *CORONA NON CADIT — 1755* and holding up one white-gloved palm in front of Dad’s silver accessible minivan. “Upper campus is strictly permit-only. Luxury guest passes have to be logged by the Dean’s Office twenty-four hours in advance, and commercial or medical vans are prohibited on Royal Drive.”

Behind the steering wheel after our long drive north up Interstate 95 into Braxton, Rhode Island—a sprawling coastal metropolis of glass towers, bayfront rail viaducts, and sharp class divides where the steep ridge of Mount Regalis loomed over the city so old-money families could literally look down on everyone else—our fifty-seven-year-old dad kept both hands calm at ten and two.

“Afternoon, officer,” Dad said evenly through his open driver’s window while Katie and I sat strapped side by side in our SwiftChairs in the middle bay with Brittany buckled beside us. “This isn’t a commercial delivery van. It’s our personal family vehicle, and we’re here from Virginia to visit my niece Chelsea at Regalis Community House.”

The gate officer peered past Dad’s shoulder at our two motorized wheelchairs, wrinkled his nose as if an out-of-state minivan might scuff the pre-Revolutionary cobblestones, and jerked his thumb downhill toward the base of the ridge while waving a gleaming German convertible driven by a twenty-year-old in purple-and-gold sunglasses straight through the neighboring VIP lane without checking a thing.

“Regalis Community House isn’t on the main quad—it’s down in the old caretaker annex by the rear steam plant,” the guard said dismissively. “No non-faculty vehicles through the Royal Gate, period. Turn around, park down at the Regalis Park train station lot at the bottom of the hill, and take the two o’clock shuttle bus to the rear service loop like the rest of the annex staff.”

In the rearview mirror, Dad’s jaw flexed once, ready to tell the guard exactly who was sitting in the middle bay of his minivan.

“Don’t say a word about the House of Delegates yet, Dad,” Katie murmured calmly from her SwiftChair, resting a steady hand on Dad’s elbow. “If that guard radios ahead to the annex that an elected official is coming through the front gate, Mr. Sterling will have ten minutes to unlock his med-cart, hide whatever he’s making Chelsea do, and put on his sweet telephone voice. Taking the public bus to the back service gate gets all four of us inside that door with zero warning.”

“Smart girl,” Dad nodded, backing the minivan smoothly around the stone turnaround and coasting down the steep switchbacks of Mount Regalis to the base of the hill.

Seven minutes later at Regalis Park Station—the northern Zone 4 terminus of the Braxton Transit Authority where sleek stainless-steel regional trains and Red Line subway cars glided beneath modern glass canopies—Dad locked the minivan in the commuter lot, and the four of us rolled over to the outer curb bay just as a battered forty-foot BTA shuttle bus pulled up with its amber sign reading *99 REGALIS SHUTTLE*.

Even as lifelong transit advocates, Katie and I only needed thirty seconds aboard Route 99 to understand why the cafeteria dishwashers, groundskeepers, and housekeepers riding silently in street clothes beside us called it the Scrub Bus. King’s College banned regular BTA city buses from entering its manicured grounds to avoid what its trustees called visual clutter, relegating every working-class employee on the mountain to a once-an-hour shuttle that climbed the back switchbacks and dumped its riders outside a chain-link service gate beside the brick campus steam plant and three overflowing green dumpsters. There wasn’t a glass shelter, a wooden bench, or a digital countdown sign in sight—just cracked asphalt and a single rusted iron pole bolted with a faded *99* tin plate.

“Watch the crack by the drain grate, Katie,” Brittany said quietly as the hydraulic front ramp folded back up and Route 99 rumbled away down the ridge, leaving the four of us rolling past the humming steam-plant vents toward a weathered, soot-streaked 1920s brick house tucked just inside the open chain-link service gate behind a faded plastic sign reading *REGALIS COMMUNITY LIVING FOUNDATION — AN AFFILIATE OF KING’S COLLEGE*.

Thirty feet above us, a manicured granite balustrade separated the upper academic lawn from the service drive. As two King’s College summer-session undergraduates strolled along the upper stone wall in crisp purple-and-gold polo shirts carrying iced coffees, one of them glanced down at the brick group home and at our two wheelchairs, laughed audibly through his nose, and literally flicked his thumb upward under his chin at his friend—*“Careful, Preston, don’t breathe too deep down by the charity zoo”*—before both of them strolled off toward the Gothic bell tower.

Brittany’s fists clenched at her sides, her cheeks flushing hot behind her glasses, while Dad’s eyes turned to flint.

“Keep walking,” I whispered, gripping Katie’s hand briefly across our armrests before releasing it to steer up the splintered wooden entry ramp of the brick annex. “Wait until you hear what’s coming through that screen door.”

Monday, July 18, 2016, 2:35 PM — Unannounced Inside the Annex: Locked Asthma Inhalers, Piecework Tables, & The Fudged Probate Decree

Through the rusted mesh of the unlocked screen door—propped half an inch open because the window air-conditioning unit in the front parlor wasn’t even switched on in eighty-six-degree July humidity—the exact baritone voice that had boomed *“How may we brighten your evening?”* over Dad’s speakerphone in May was barking across a linoleum room like a drill sergeant.

“I don’t want to hear one more theatrical wheeze out of you, Chelsea, do you understand me?!” Director Sterling snapped sharply from inside. “The Alumni Office wants five hundred purple-and-gold freshman orientation folders stuffed, ribbon-tied, and boxed before supper, and if your fingers are too clumsy to tie a bow without dropping the card on the floor, you’re going straight to your room at seven o’clock instead of seven-thirty without evening pudding!”

“M-my chest hurt bad, M-Mister Sterwing,” Chelsea’s thickly slurred voice pleaded in frightened tears from the middle of the room, every short word halting with her severe speech impediment and punctuated by a tight, unmistakable asthmatic whistle on every exhale. *“C-can’t breathe good. Please… blue puffer in cart? Mama Liz say keep both puffers—”*

“Your puffers stay locked in my office med-cart until eight o’clock med pass, young lady, because I know attention-seeking faking when I see it!” Director Sterling barked back. “Just for talking back, your stuffed turtle stays locked in the hall bin until Friday! Now sit up straight and tie those ribbons!”

Dad didn’t knock. He pulled the screen door wide open, held it firmly against the brick wall, and stepped straight inside as Katie and I rolled our two SwiftChairs abreast across the threshold with Brittany right beside us.

Seated along two scarred folding banquet tables under flickering fluorescent tubes were six developmentally disabled adults sweating in the muggy heat over stacks of glossy purple-and-gold King’s College donor brochures and satin ribbons, while a brass padlock gleamed on the kitchen pantry door behind them. At the end of the nearer table sat thirty-four-year-old Chelsea—her wavy chestnut-brown hair damp against her temples, tears tracking down her pale cheeks, and one hand pressed tight over her whistling sternum with both cardigan pockets completely empty.

For half a heartbeat, Director Arthur Sterling—a slick-haired, ruddy-faced man in a pressed white oxford shirt, purple-and-gold King’s College alumni tie, and polished dress loafers standing over Chelsea with a clipboard—whirled around toward the front door and automatically plastered a blinding, syrupy church-deacon smile across his face before his brain even registered who we were.

“Why, hello there, folks! Welcome to Regalis Community—” Sterling began sweetly.

“Nate! Katie! Unca David!” Chelsea gasped out loud, shoving her folding chair back so fast it clattered against the linoleum as she hurried across the room with her familiar struggling gait, dropped straight to her knees between our two wheelchairs, and threw both arms around my neck while clutching Katie’s wrist. Sobbing and wheezing against my collar just as she had twelve Christmases ago on Tonomy Hill, she fought through her severe speech impediment to push the slurred words out: *“Y-you came! Just Katie an’ you—no mean Tiffany! Group Home Two-Face t-took my puffers, Nate! Nice voice on phone, mean yell face at me! Locked Shelly Turtle up!”*

“I’ve got you, Chelsea—Katie and Uncle David and our cousin Brittany are all right here, and nobody is ever yelling at you again,” I said fiercely, wrapping one arm tight around my trembling cousin’s shoulders while Brittany immediately knelt beside Chelsea with a cool bottled water from her tote bag, gently fanning Chelsea’s flushed face.

Dad took three long strides across the linoleum and planted himself directly in front of Director Sterling, looking straight across his clipboard into the man's eyes.

"Unlock that office medication cart and put both of my niece's prescribed asthma inhalers in her hands in the next ten seconds," Dad said in a low, lethal voice I hadn't heard since the Sunday morning he stared Tiffany down in the doorway of Sea Breeze West and packed us home, "or my next phone call is 911 for Braxton Fire Rescue and the police for reckless endangerment of a disabled adult."

Sterling's syrupy mask vanished like smoke. Scowling, he stalked three steps behind the half-door of his air-conditioned office, unlocked a steel rolling drawer with a brass key on his belt clip, and slapped Chelsea's blue rescue albuterol inhaler and purple maintenance inhaler onto the counter. Brittany snatched both inhalers up immediately, shook the blue canister, helped Chelsea seal her lips around the mouthpiece for two slow, deep puffs, and counted softly to ten with her until the frightening whistle in Chelsea's chest finally began to ease.

"Once her breathing settles, unlock that hall closet and get her suitcases and her stuffed sea turtle," Dad told Sterling coldly. "I am David Prairie—Elizabeth's brother and Chelsea's sole surviving uncle—and we are signing Chelsea out permanently and taking her home to Virginia today."

Instead of flinching, Director Sterling folded his starched cuffs across his chest and let out a cold, superior smirk. Reaching into a hanging file rack behind his counter, he pulled out a laminated legal decree bearing the raised seal of the Braxton Municipal Probate Court and tapped a highlighted paragraph with one blunt forefinger.

"Actually, Mr. Prairie, you aren't taking her past that chain-link fence," Sterling said smugly. "Eight years ago when the Newport housing authority tore down Tonomy Hill, the Braxton Municipal Probate Court appointed the Regalis Community Living Foundation—a chartered subsidiary of King's College—as Chelsea's sole plenary legal guardian and Representative Payee. See Box Seven right there on the decree? *Heirs-at-Law and Next of Kin: None Living.* Legally, mister, you don't exist. You were only allowed courtesy monthly phone calls out of the goodness of my heart—which are hereby revoked—and if you attempt to remove a court ward from King's College property, Campus Police are ninety seconds up the hill and will arrest all four of you for felony custodial interference."

Chelsea whimpered in pure terror, clutching my forearm and Katie's hand with all her strength. *"N-no leave me, Nate! Group Home Two-Face hurt my chest! Please no leave me!"*

Katie didn't raise her voice a single decibel. Sitting tall in her SwiftChair beside me in her royal-blue blazer, my twin sister looked straight past Sterling's smirk at the docket number stamped in the upper-right corner of the laminated decree—*PC-2008-0419*—memorized every digit in two seconds, and pulled out her cell phone.

"Nobody is leaving you behind, Chelsea," Katie promised gently, squeezing Chelsea's fingers before fixing Director Sterling with eyes like blue surgical steel. "Mr. Sterling, my name is Katie Prairie. I sit on the Committee on Health, Welfare and Institutions in the Virginia House of Delegates, and all four of us just witnessed you withhold a prescribed emergency rescue bronchodilator from a wheezing asthmatic adult while forcing Medicaid waiver residents to stuff university alumni

mailers behind a padlocked pantry. Under Title 42, Section 15043 of the United States Code, Rhode Island's federally mandated Protection and Advocacy agency has absolute statutory authority to enter any residential facility unannounced, seize medication logs, and place an immediate protective monitor inside this building."

Sterling's smug smirk faltered for the first time as Katie tapped dial on speakerphone.

Monday, July 18, 2016, 3:30 PM — Federal Protection & Advocacy Investigators & Pulling the Perjured File at Braxton City Hall

Thirty-eight minutes later, two no-nonsense investigators and a registered nurse from the Rhode Island Disability Law Center—accompanied by an inspector from the state Department of Behavioral Healthcare, Developmental Disabilities and Hospitals—walked straight through the annex screen door flashing federal Protection and Advocacy credentials that King's College Campus Security had zero authority to block.

Within fifteen minutes, the nurse had documented Chelsea's post-attack peak-flow reading, ordered both asthma inhalers kept permanently on Chelsea's person, unlocked the hallway confiscation bin to put Chelsea's worn green plush sea turtle—Shelly—right back into her arms, photographed the boxes of uncompensated King's College alumni mailers and the padlocked pantry hasp, and informed a chalk-white Director Sterling that he was suspended from the floor and barred from the premises pending a state licensing audit while two state residential monitors remained inside the house overnight so Chelsea and her five housemates were completely safe, fed a real hot dinner, and free to keep their inhalers and watch evening television for as long as they pleased.

"I'll be back for you tomorrow morning with a judge's paper, Chelsea—I promise on Aunt Liz's memory," Dad told Chelsea gently at ten minutes to four, hugging his niece tight by the porch while Brittany tucked a zippered plastic pouch holding both inhalers safely into Chelsea's cardigan pocket and Katie and I kissed Chelsea's cheek.

"Group Home Two-Face no come back tonight?" Chelsea asked anxiously in her slurred voice, hugging Shelly Turtle tight against her chest while the kind state nurse stood right beside her shoulder.

"Never again, Cous," I promised, holding both of her hands from my wheelchair. "Tomorrow morning, you're coming home to Virginia with all four of us."

Catching the four-fifteen outbound Route 99 shuttle back down Mount Regalis to Dad's minivan at Regalis Park Station, we beat the four-thirty courthouse clerk's buzzer into downtown Braxton City Hall with nine minutes to spare.

At the polished oak counter of the Braxton Municipal Probate Court clerk's office—because unlike Virginia's unified circuit courts, Rhode Island handled adult guardianships through local municipal probate dockets—Katie gave the clerk docket number *PC-2008-0419* and paid twelve dollars in statutory copy fees for the complete public file.

Rolling side by side over to the accessible reading table in the marble corridor while Dad and Brittany leaned over our shoulders, I flipped open the manila folder to Petition Form PC-2.2, dated October 14, 2008, signed under penalty of perjury by Bradford H. Sterling, Esquire—General Counsel to the Regalis Community Living Foundation and, as Katie spotted instantly on the letterhead, Director Arthur Sterling's own older brother.

"Look at Page Two, Nate," Katie breathed, her finger stopping cold on Box Seven beneath *Heirs-at-Law and Next of Kin*.

Typed neatly beside *Mother (Elizabeth Prairie)* and *Maternal Grandmother (Ruth Prairie)* was *Deceased (2004)*. Directly underneath, in the box requiring all living aunts, uncles, and cousins, counsel had checked *No Known Living Next of Kin — Diligent Search Negative*. And stapled to the back of the page as purported proof of that "diligent search" was a single photocopied certified-mail envelope addressed to *David Prairie* at our old house from before our parents' 2001 custody order—seven full years after Dad had moved Katie and me to Arvin Road—stamped *RETURN TO SENDER — FORWARDING ORDER EXPIRED*.

Dad stared down at that envelope with his hands bracing the oak table so hard his knuckles went white. "They knew my name. Chelsea had my cell phone number and my Arvin Road address written in Aunt Liz's blue address book on her kitchen counter—I called her every single month! They mailed notice to a house I hadn't lived in since 2001 on purpose so it would bounce back, swore to a probate judge that Chelsea was an orphan with zero family on earth so King's College could pocket eighty-four thousand dollars a year in Medicaid waiver funds and her Social Security check, and let me keep making two-minute phone calls so I'd never suspect a court had stripped our family's rights!"

"And look what they forgot happened six months ago on January 1, 2016," I said, turning my silver MagnaBook Pro toward Dad, Katie, and Brittany with Rhode Island General Laws Title 33, Chapter 15.2 glowing on my screen alongside local Newport vital-records hours. "Rhode Island's brand-new Uniform Adult Guardianship and Protective Proceedings Jurisdiction Act just went into effect on New Year's Day—matching Virginia Code Section 64.2-2100 word for word. Dad was born in Newport Hospital right alongside Aunt Liz, which means Newport City Hall has both of their certified Rhode Island birth certificates on file twenty-five minutes across the bridges, and Judge Donahue holds Tuesday morning probate sessions right down this hall at nine o'clock sharp."

Katie closed the certified court copy folder with a crisp, decisive snap and reached for her phone to retain a veteran Braxton disability-probate attorney recommended by the Disability Law Center investigator.

"Tomorrow morning at nine o'clock," Katie said quietly, "King's College is going to explain to a Braxton judge why they told a court of law that our cousin had nobody in the world who loved her."

Part 3: Ten Minutes in Braxton Probate Court, Forcing Open the Royal Gate With a Sheriff's Escort, & Goodbye to Newport Over I-895

Date: 2016-07-19 at 09:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, July 19, 2016, 9:00 AM — Certified Newport Birth Certificates & R.I. Gen. Laws Section 33-15.2 in Braxton Municipal Probate Court

"Docket PC-2008-0419, *In re Guardianship of Chelsea*—emergency motion to vacate plenary appointment for fraud upon the court, remove guardian for medical neglect under Section 33-15-18, and issue provisional interstate transfer to the Commonwealth of Virginia under Chapter 33-15.2," the courtroom clerk announced across the wood-paneled Braxton Municipal Probate courtroom at nine-oh-two on Tuesday morning.

At the petitioner's table, Katie and I sat braked side by side in our brushed-silver-and-black SwiftChairs next to our retained Braxton probate counsel, Eleanor Callahan-Vance, while Dad sat tall in his navy blazer holding a leather folder of raised-seal Newport vital records that he had driven across the Jamestown and Newport Pell Bridges at eight o'clock sharp to pick up directly from the Newport City Clerk, and Brittany sat right behind our chairs keeping watch on the courtroom doors.

Across the center aisle, Bradford H. Sterling, Esquire—dressed in a custom charcoal three-piece suit and a purple-and-gold striped King's College alumni tie—flipped open a calfskin briefcase looking annoyed that he had been pulled away from a trustees' breakfast over a Medicaid-waiver annex resident.

"Your Honor," Sterling began smoothly before he had even glanced at our exhibits, "the Regalis Community Living Foundation has served without incident as court-appointed plenary guardian for eight years. Whatever well-meaning out-of-state individuals appeared unannounced at our Mount Regalis practicum residence yesterday lack standing to disturb a final 2008 decree—"

Probate Judge Thomas Donahue held up one thick hand from the bench, peering down over his half-moon reading glasses at the three certified exhibits Ms. Callahan-Vance had just handed up through the bailiff.

"Hold your horses, Counselor," Judge Donahue said, his gravelly Rhode Island baritone dropping ten degrees colder with every page he turned. "I am looking at two raised-seal vital records issued sixty minutes ago by the City Clerk of Newport, Rhode Island: Certificate of Live Birth for David Prairie, born Newport Hospital, and Certificate of Live Birth for his full blood sister Elizabeth Prairie, born Newport Hospital, alongside your own brother's residential telephone log recording monthly calls from *Uncle David Prairie — Virginia Beach, VA* going back eight straight years."

Judge Donahue lifted his eyes from the Newport seals straight to Bradford Sterling's purple-and-gold tie.

"Now I am looking at Box Seven of Petition Form PC-2.2, signed under pains and penalties of perjury by *you*, Mr. Sterling, in October of 2008, swearing to this Court that this young woman had *No Known Living Next of Kin* after you mailed a single certified letter to a house Mr. Prairie sold in 2001—and right underneath it, I am reading a sworn overnight inspection affidavit from the Rhode Island Disability Law Center and a state licensing nurse confirming that at two-thirty-five yesterday afternoon, your foundation's house director had this severe asthmatic woman's rescue bronchodilator locked inside an office cart while she was actively wheezing over five hundred King's College alumni mailers."

Across the aisle, every trace of color drained out of Bradford Sterling's face.

"Your Honor, if there was an inadvertent clerical oversight in the 2008 genealogical search—" Sterling stammered, his fingers suddenly trembling on his calfskin latch.

"If you finish that sentence with anything other than an unconditional consent stipulation, Counselor, my clerk is walking copies of Docket PC-2008-0419 straight upstairs to the Rhode Island Attorney General's Medicaid Fraud Control Unit and the Disciplinary Counsel of the Supreme Court before lunch," Judge Donahue said flatly. He turned toward our table, nodding respectfully toward Katie's wheelchair and Dad. "Ms. Callahan-Vance, I understand Mr. Prairie's daughter here is a sitting member of the Virginia House of Delegates, and the family has a permanent, accessible home waiting in Virginia Beach?"

"Yes, Your Honor," Katie answered clearly and respectfully from her SwiftChair beside me. "Chelsea is our older first cousin and our dad's niece. My twin brother Nathaniel, our cousin Brittany, our father, and I share a fully accessible single-story brick ranch in Virginia Beach. Brittany works full-time for my brother's and my private software company—never a cent of public funds—so Chelsea will have loving twenty-four-hour family care, immediate access to both of her asthma inhalers at all times, and her own doctors five minutes down the road. Under Rhode Island General Laws Section 33-15.2-301, which took effect January 1 of this year, and Virginia Code Section 64.2-2100, our Virginia Beach counsel is standing by to file the mirror acceptance petition in Virginia Beach Circuit Court this week."

"We—the Foundation withdraws all opposition and stipulates to immediate vacatur, immediate discharge, and full release of the ward to her uncle, Your Honor," Bradford Sterling blurted out so fast his voice cracked, practically lunging for his pen before the words *Medicaid Fraud Control Unit* could echo a second time.

Ten minutes after the clerk had called the case, Judge Donahue brought his gavel down with a sharp, satisfying crack: vacating the 2008 institutional guardianship *ab initio* for defective notice, appointing Uncle David Prairie immediate temporary family guardian pending formal interstate transfer to Virginia under Chapter 33-15.2, ordering the Regalis Foundation to wire every penny of Chelsea's withheld personal-needs allowance and back Social Security accounting within seventy-two hours, referring Regalis Community House to state licensing receivership to protect the five remaining residents, and directing a uniformed Braxton County Sheriff's deputy to escort our family's vehicle onto Mount Regalis immediately to execute the release order.

Tuesday, July 19, 2016, 10:45 AM — Raising the Wrought-Iron Royal Gate, Signing Chelsea Out Forever, & Crossing the Stub of Interstate 895 to Newport Harbor

At quarter to eleven under bright July skies, nobody on Mount Regalis told Dad to turn his Virginia minivan around and take the Scrub Bus.

Rolling straight up the cobblestone approach to King's College's main wrought-iron Royal Gate directly behind a black-and-tan Braxton County Sheriff's cruiser, we watched the exact same white-gloved campus gate guard who had sneered at our

wheelchairs twenty-one hours earlier step hastily out of his booth, swallow hard at the sight of the Sheriff's deputy tapping the embossed probate seal against his palm, and hit the brass switch to raise the purple-and-gold barrier arm all the way up.

Two dozen King's College summer students crossing the upper quad stopped dead on the flagstone walk in stunned silence as the Sheriff's cruiser led our out-of-state wheelchair van right past their manicured 1755 bell tower and down the service drive to the front ramp of the brick annex.

Before Dad even finished unfolding the aluminum side ramp of the minivan, the annex screen door flew open—held wide by the smiling state licensing nurse—and out hurried thirty-four-year-old Chelsea in her sky-blue summer cardigan, her wavy chestnut-brown hair brushed smooth, both asthma inhalers tucked right inside her front pocket where her fingers could pat them whenever she wanted, and Shelly the green plush sea turtle hugged tight under one arm.

"Unca David! Nate! Katie! Bwittany!" Chelsea cried out with pure, radiant joy, hurrying down the wooden ramp on her unsteady gait straight into my open arms first and then Katie's while happy tears spilled down her cheeks, pushing her slurred words out excitedly through her severe speech impediment. *"Nice nurse pack my bag! Go Virginia now? No more Group Home Two-Face? Keep my puffers forever?"*

"Never again for the rest of your life, sweetheart," Dad said thickly, handing the speechless interim Foundation supervisor the stamped copy of Judge Donahue's order before picking up Chelsea's battered suitcase in one hand while Brittany slung Chelsea's blue duffel bag warmly over her shoulder and gave Chelsea a gentle side-hug. "Say goodbye to Mount Regalis, Chelsea—you're coming home with your family."

Chelsea didn't even look back at the brick annex or the Gothic spires above the stone wall as Brittany helped her buckle securely into the wide passenger seat right behind Katie's and my locked-down SwiftChairs.

Once we rolled back out beneath the raised wrought-iron arch and descended Mount Regalis toward Interstate 95 South, however, Dad glanced into the rearview mirror at his niece hugging her plush sea turtle and tapped his right turn signal at Exit 1 instead of merging straight south toward Connecticut.

"Before we point the wheels down I-95 toward Virginia," Dad smiled over his shoulder as we curved onto the six-lane concrete flyover of Interstate 895—Braxton's famously quirky east-west stub superhighway that federal engineers had signed *NORTH* toward an unbuilt Aquidneck Island freeway back in the sixties, funneling down from three lanes to a grassy two-lane parkway across the Narrow River watershed before climbing high onto the Jamestown and Newport Pell suspension bridges over glittering Narragansett Bay—"your Aunt Liz and Grandma Ruth and I grew up looking at Newport Harbor, and I refuse to let Chelsea's last memory of Rhode Island be a padlocked pantry by a steam plant. Who votes for New England clam chowder and warm buttered rolls down by the boats at Perotti Park before we head home?"

"Me! Me! Clam chowder! Perotti Park!" Chelsea cheered in her slurred voice, clapping her hands excitedly against Shelly Turtle as the white towers of the Newport Pell Bridge rose ahead of the windshield and dozens of white sails tacked

across the bright blue water below, before leaning forward between our headrests to point proudly out the side window as we rolled off the highway stub toward downtown Newport. *"Look, Nate! Blue OSTA bus! Route 60 bus I show you!"*

"You saved our whole trip home that Monday morning, Cous—you still know Newport buses better than anybody," I grinned back at her, reaching up to high-five her hand while Katie and Brittany laughed warmly beside us.

For one glorious, unhurried hour on the sunny waterfront boardwalk of Perotti Park—with salt spray sparkling off the harbor pilings, seagulls wheeling overhead, and zero shouting Tiffany or barking house managers anywhere within five hundred miles—the five of us ate cups of creamy New England clam chowder and warm rolls together around an accessible picnic table, letting Chelsea say a happy, peaceful goodbye to the island where she and Dad were born.

Then we rolled back up Dad's minivan ramp, buckled in together, took Interstate 895 West—signed *SOUTH*—back across both bay bridges to Interstate 95 South, and drove Chelsea all the way home to Virginia Beach.

Part 4: Tagless Puffer-Pocket Pajamas, Gentle Reminders, Fear of 'Group Home Two-Face,' & Four Cousins Crammed Into One Closet

Date: 2016-07-21 at 20:45 America/New_York

Thursday, July 21, 2016, 8:45 PM — Warm Fleece, Tagless Puffer Pockets, & Gently Helping Chelsea Understand Why We Wear Clothes

"Nate! Katie! Look—Shelly clean!"

Down the warm, steam-softened hallway of our brick ranch on Arvin Road on Chelsea's second evening home from Rhode Island, the hall bathroom door swung wide open after her bath, and out padded thirty-four-year-old Chelsea onto the hallway runner—her damp chestnut-brown curls clinging to her shoulders, her worn green plush sea turtle held proudly in her right hand, her blue and purple asthma inhalers clutched in her left, and not a single stitch of clothing on from head to toe.

Because of her severe developmental disability, Chelsea genuinely did not understand abstract social rules or why anyone needed to put clothes on inside a safe house full of family. Seeing her pad cheerfully toward the living room brought back an instant, fond memory of Christmas 1994 when Katie and I were nine—and of Christmas Eve 2004 up on Dirty Old Tonomy Hill, when twenty-two-year-old Chelsea had bolted soaking wet out of the shower because Tiffany's screaming at Katie and me had terrified her, and had later tugged off her clothes at bedtime declaring that she always slept naked.

Not one of the three of us gasped, laughed, or raised our voices by even half a decibel.

Turning my gaze immediately and respectfully toward the framed watercolor print of blue butterflies on the hallway wall so Chelsea's dignity stayed completely intact, I reached blindly behind my shoulder, lifted our oversized, cloud-soft cream fleece throw blanket off the back of the sofa, and held it out toward Brittany while keeping my voice steady and warm.

"Hey there, Cous—glad Shelly enjoyed the warm steam," I said gently, eyes still resting on the butterfly frame. "Hold up one second with Brittany so you don't catch a chill from the air conditioning."

Brittany didn't miss half a beat. Stepping smoothly down the hallway with a warm, unhurried smile behind her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses, she draped the wide fleece throw gently around Chelsea's bare shoulders like a royal cape while Katie rolled her SwiftChair quietly up beside them holding a freshly laundered cream cotton-modal pajama set across her lap.

Even surrounded by pure warmth, eight years of institutional conditioning up on Mount Regalis showed itself right away. The instant the blanket settled around her shoulders, thirty-four-year-old Chelsea flinched, ducked her chin defensively toward her collarbone, and squeezed Shelly Turtle hard against her chest, her eyes darting anxiously from Brittany to Katie to me.

"Y-you mad?" Chelsea whispered, her severe speech impediment thickening and slurring the consonants together as she worked hard to push each short word out without wheezing. "Group Home Two-Face y-yell bad words when me take scratchy shirt off. T-take Shelly away."

Katie's expression softened with fierce, protective tenderness. Rolling six inches closer, my twin sister reached out and took Chelsea's free hand warmly between both of hers while Brittany gave Chelsea's blanket-wrapped shoulders a reassuring hug.

"Nobody in this house is *ever* mad at you, Chelsea, and nobody will ever yell at you or take Shelly away for the rest of your life," Katie told her gently, speaking in clear, calm sentences. "You didn't do anything wrong at all. Come sit right here on the padded hallway bench with Brittany, let's slip your soft pajamas on inside the bathroom doorway, and then all three of us will show you something neat we made for you and Shelly."

Once Brittany had gently helped Chelsea step into the loose, buttery-soft cream pajama pants and matching long-sleeved top—keeping everything unhurried and cozy—Chelsea came back out into the living room tugging uncertainly at the hem of her shirt, looking down at the fabric in genuine bewilderment.

"Why clothes?" Chelsea asked earnestly, struggling through the slurred *cl* sound as she looked at me, Katie, and Brittany in turn. "No cold snow. Just Nate, Katie, Bwittany. Me always sleep no clothes!"

Sitting together in the warm lamplight—Katie and I braked side by side in our SwiftChairs with our inner armrests flipped up so our shoulders touched, and Brittany seated right beside Chelsea on the low sofa cushion—all three of us knew lecturing Chelsea about grown-up modesty rules would only confuse her. If we wanted to help our cousin understand why she needed to stay dressed around the

house, we had to give her gentle, concrete, loving reasons her mind could actually see and touch—and be ready to repeat them with the exact same patience as many times as she needed.

“Look right here inside the collar first, sweetie,” Brittany began warmly, opening her small wicker sewing basket on the coffee table and holding up a second pastel pajama top so Chelsea could watch Brittany’s small embroidery scissors snip every stiff, papery factory neck label and side-seam tag clean out of the cloth. Taking Chelsea’s fingertips gently in hers, Brittany let her rub the tagless cotton seam against her own cheek. “Up at that mean group home, they put stiff, scratchy shirts on you with sharp tags that poked your neck. Every single shirt and pajama set in your dresser here has zero scratchy tags. And look what I stitched onto the front of every shirt and pair of pants for you.”

Brittany guided Chelsea’s hand down to two deep, quilted front pockets sewn right onto the cream pajama top—and slipped Chelsea’s blue rescue inhaler into the left pocket and her purple maintenance inhaler into the right pocket.

“When you don’t wear clothes, Chelsea, you don’t have anywhere to carry your puffers,” Brittany explained softly, pulling out a tiny strip of matching cream knit cloth she had sewn into a soft little sweater band and sliding it snugly around Shelly Turtle’s plush shell. “When you wear your cozy clothes—just like Shelly’s matching shirt right here—your puffers stay right in your puffer pockets against your side so nobody can ever separate you from them.”

Chelsea’s eyes lit up in immediate wonder as she patted both inhalers through the soft fabric and held up Shelly Turtle’s matching cream band. “Shelly shirt! Puffer pockets!”

“And feel right up there, Cous,” Katie added gently, lifting one hand toward the gentle cool breeze drifting down from the ceiling air-conditioning vent above the hallway. “Remember how damp air and chilly drafts make your bronchial tubes tighten up and whistle? Wearing a soft shirt hugs your chest all day and all night so the cold air-conditioning breeze stays off your ribs and your lungs stay warm and quiet.”

“Plus two more things,” I said affectionately, tapping the cool brushed-aluminum brake lever and metal frame rail on my SwiftChair. “Whenever you hurry over to give Katie and me big bear hugs in our wheelchairs, wearing soft clothes keeps cold wheelchair metal and rough cushion seams from pinching or scratching your tummy. And remember how Uncle David and Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven have keys to come up the ramp with groceries and supper? Everybody in our family keeps their private body covered inside cozy clothes so your body stays private and safe just for you—and if a thunderstorm or a fire drill ever woke us up at night, you’re already dressed and ready to roll right out the door with us.”

Chelsea looked down at her two puffer pockets, felt the warm knit over her sternum, touched Shelly Turtle’s matching cream band, and broke into a wide, proud smile.

“Warm chest,” Chelsea repeated slowly through her speech impediment, patting her shirt with both hands. “No scratchy tags. Puffer pockets!”

“You got it, Cous,” all three of us smiled back at her together.

Thursday, July 21, 2016, 10:15 PM — "Group Home Two-Face Snatch Me!" & Cramming Four Grown Cousins Into One Closet

Ninety minutes later, after we finished warm mugs of caffeine-free apple-cinnamon tea at the kitchen table and took turns brushing our teeth at the roll-under bathroom sink, bedtime arrived—and Katie, Brittany, and I quickly discovered that trauma from Mount Regalis and trauma from Greenway Court spoke the exact same nighttime language.

Inside our spacious master bedroom beneath the second framed watercolor print of blue butterflies, Brittany turned down the soft navy-and-slate-blue comforter on the untouched queen bed, fluffed two plump cotton pillows, set a glowing amber Himalayan salt lamp on the nightstand so the room wasn't dark, and helped Chelsea climb under the covers in her soft cream tagless pajamas with Shelly Turtle tucked under her chin and both inhalers resting right beside her hand.

"Sleep tight right here on this big comfy bed, Chelsea," Brittany whispered affectionately, smoothing a curl back from Chelsea's forehead. "Nate and Katie and I are going to be right here three feet away inside the open closet doorway where you can hear us breathing and see the nightlight the whole night through."

"G'night, Bwittany. G'night, Katie. G'night, Nate," Chelsea murmured sleepily from the center of the queen mattress, blinking slowly in the warm amber glow.

Rolling our two SwiftChairs side by side to the wide bifold doorway of our bedroom closet—where Katie, Brittany, and I had been sharing one oversized, flannel-lined navy sleeping bag and three side-by-side pillows across the vacuumed carpet ever since Brittany moved home in March—Katie and I clicked off our joystick controllers, locked our wheel brakes, and transferred smoothly down onto the closet floor. Brittany slipped off her house slippers, set her wire-rimmed glasses inside their felt case by the baseboard, climbed inside the shared sleeping bag right beside Katie, and left the bifold closet doors propped open a generous ten inches so Chelsea wouldn't feel shut out.

For six quiet minutes, Katie nestled close against my left shoulder lacing her fingers through mine while Brittany rested her warm arm across Katie's shoulder to clasp my forearm under the flannel lining.

Then a stiff midnight breeze off the Chesapeake Bay rattled a cluster of loblolly pine needles sharply against the bedroom gutter—and at that exact same second, a neighbor's pickup truck turning around at the end of Arvin Road swept two pale ribbons of headlight glare across the bottom edge of the window shade.

Out on the queen mattress three feet away, we heard a sharp, panicked gasp—followed instantly by bare feet hitting the bedroom carpet and a tight, frightened whistle catching in Chelsea's throat.

Before Brittany could even reach for our sleeping-bag zipper to go check on her, the bifold closet door shoved all the way open.

Standing silhouetted in the amber salt-lamp glow on trembling legs—clutching Shelly Turtle and both puffers against her cream pajama chest with one arm while dragging her queen-bed pillow behind her by one corner—was thirty-four-year-old Chelsea, tears spilling down her cheeks as she stared back over her shoulder at the curtained bedroom window in sheer terror.

“N-no bed alone!” Chelsea sobbed through her severe speech impediment, dropping straight down onto her knees at the edge of our closet carpet and trying desperately to burrow all five-foot-four of herself headfirst underneath the corner of our three-person sleeping bag right on top of my ribs and Brittany’s shins. “Group Home Two-Face out window! Headlights! Group Home Two-Face c-come snatch me back! Take my puffers! Me stay in c-closet w-with Nate an’ Katie an’ Bwittany!”

“Easy, sweetie—breathe slow with me, nobody’s outside that window,” Brittany said soothingly, sitting halfway up inside our cramped closet alcove to wrap both arms around Chelsea’s shaking shoulders before Chelsea’s panic could trigger a full asthma attack, while I held Chelsea’s right hand steady against my chest and Katie stroked Chelsea’s hair. Counting four slow breaths in and four slow breaths out together until the whistle in Chelsea’s throat eased without even needing her blue puffer, Brittany kissed the top of Chelsea’s chestnut curls and glanced back toward the empty queen bed. “Tell you what, Chelsea—what if I bring my pillow out there and climb into the big queen bed right beside you so you aren’t alone for one second?”

Instantly, two things happened at once.

Beside my left shoulder, Katie’s hand clamped tight around my fingers and both of our hearts kicked into an unmistakable, cold sweat—because after four months of having Brittany tucked safely inside our closet sleeping bag with us, the sudden thought of Brittany and Chelsea lying exposed out in front of a street-facing window while Katie and I hid behind closet drywall set every Greenway Court alarm bell screaming behind our ribs.

And right on top of my right knee, Chelsea shook her head fiercely, wrapping both arms around my grey plaid flannel sleeve like an anchor and wedging her hip stubbornly between my hip and the closet baseboard.

“N-no!” Chelsea cried softly, pushing each slurred word out with total conviction. “Two-Face get you an’ me out there! Safe in c-closet! All four! Me fit right here!”

To prove she fit, Chelsea pulled both knees up to her chest, accidentally bumped the back of her head into the hem of my hanging winter wool coat on the wooden closet rod, and tried to tug four inches of our stretched-tight navy sleeping bag over her shoulder—nearly pulling the whole flannel cover clean off Brittany’s feet on the far left side.

Even with my pulse still thumping, a quiet, helpless laugh escaped my chest in the dim amber glow, and beside me Katie let out a soft, watery giggle against my collarbone.

“Brittany,” Katie whispered, looking helplessly from Chelsea curled like a determined sea turtle between my hip and the drywall to the six-foot span of our reach-in closet, “there is zero chance any of the four of us is sleeping out on that mattress tonight.”

Brittany slipped her silver wire-rimmed glasses back onto her nose for ten seconds, looked down at three cousins clinging together on sixty-eight inches of closet carpet, and smiled with the patient, unstoppable resourcefulness that kept our whole household running.

“Hold onto Shelly for thirty seconds, everybody—nobody gets left outside the fort,” Brittany whispered warmly.

Reaching up onto the top cedar storage shelf above the coat rod, Brittany pulled down the matching spare oversized navy flannel-lined sleeping bag Dad had bought for camping trips back when we first moved to Arvin Road. Having all four of us scoot six inches forward toward our parked SwiftChairs for half a minute, Brittany unzipped both sleeping bags completely flat around their matching heavy brass perimeter teeth, laid the bottom bag wall-to-wall across the carpet from the left drywall stud to the right drywall stud, zipped the second bag directly across the top so the two joined into one giant double-wide four-person sleeping bag, and wedged Chelsea’s fourth pillow snugly into the tight row beside mine, Katie’s, and hers.

“All right—everybody back into the sardine can,” Brittany whispered cheerfully.

There was zero spare real estate left anywhere inside that closet. When all four of us slid underneath the top flannel layer and Brittany tucked her glasses back into their felt case and pulled the bifold doors nearly shut to a thin comforting crack of amber salt-lamp light, Brittany’s left shoulder pressed flush against the left closet wall, Katie lay tucked tight between Brittany and my left side holding my hand, I lay in the center with my ankles brushing a shoebox by the door track, and Chelsea curled happily between my right shoulder and the right baseboard with Shelly Turtle hugged under her chin and her puffers resting beside her pillow. Every time anyone shifted an inch, four sets of knees moved in unison and the sleeves of our winter coats swayed softly overhead like fabric wind chimes.

Yet two minutes after the closet doors settled into place, Chelsea let out the longest, deepest, completely un-wheezy sigh I had heard from her since we were little kids.

“Group Home Two-Face n-no find us in here,” Chelsea murmured sleepily against my right shoulder, her fingers patting my flannel sleeve once to make sure I was real. “Warm chest. Puffer pockets. All four.”

“All four of us, Chelsea,” I whispered, resting my cheek gently against Katie’s blonde hair on my left while Brittany reached her warm arm across Katie’s shoulders to squeeze my forearm under our giant zipped-together sleeping bag. “Nobody is ever snatching you away again.”

Part 5: Eighty Cramped Nights on Closet Plywood, Building Our Four-Person Oak Bed, The Twelve-Minute Try, & Thanksgiving’s Forty-Five-Minute Milestone

Date: 2016-10-14 at 21:00 America/New_York

Friday, October 14, 2016, 9:00 PM — Eighty Sardine Nights in the Closet, Our Custom Solid-Oak Platform Bed, & Retreating Together at Minute Twelve

"Four warm mugs of chamomile-mint, zero caffeine, and one very strict no-heroics rule," Brittany announced cheerfully, carrying a wooden tray down the Arvin Road hallway into our lamp-lit master bedroom on a crisp mid-October Friday night and setting four ceramic mugs along the built-in headboard shelf of our brand-new solid-oak platform bed.

Right behind Brittany rolled Katie and me in our SwiftChairs, with thirty-four-year-old Chelsea walking happily beside my right armrest in soft sky-blue tagless cotton pajamas, one hand resting gently on my shoulder for balance and her other hand patting the two asthma inhalers tucked inside her stitched front puffer pockets.

Reaching October together had taken steady, loving teamwork every single day—especially helping Chelsea remember to keep her clothes on inside the house. Because of her developmental disability, learning a brand-new routine didn't happen from a single conversation in July; over August and September, there had been plenty of warm afternoons after a walk or sleepy mornings after a bath when Chelsea simply forgot all over again, tugging a warm shirt right over her head in the living room because soup had made her toasty or stepping out of the bathroom carrying her towel instead of wearing it.

Every single time—whether it was reminder number three or reminder number fourteen—Katie, Brittany, and I kept the exact same gentle, unhurried routine. I would immediately turn my eyes respectfully toward my laptop screen or the bookshelf without a hint of shock or irritation; Katie would roll up with a warm smile reminding Chelsea about keeping the cool air-conditioning draft off her lungs; and Brittany would step over with an airy, tagless short-sleeved cotton top fitted with soft front puffer pockets so Chelsea never felt scolded, embarrassed, or rushed. Just two hours earlier after Friday supper, when Chelsea's autumn sweater had felt too warm in the kitchen and her hands had gone straight to the bottom hem to pull it off altogether, she had paused halfway on her own, tapped her hip with a proud grin, and called out through her slurred speech impediment, *"Wait—me get cool shirt w-with puffer pockets!"* while Katie, Brittany, and I cheered her around the dish rack.

Our nighttime sleeping arrangement, on the other hand, was beginning to leave physical bruises on all four of us.

For eighty-five consecutive nights since late July, all four grown cousins—three thirty-one-year-olds and one thirty-four-year-old—had slept wedged wall to wall inside our six-foot bedroom closet underneath our two zipped-together navy sleeping bags with four pillows crammed in a row. Emotionally, none of us had ever felt safer. Physically, sixty-eight inches of thin residential carpet laid directly over plywood subflooring was never engineered for four adult skeletons. Every morning at seven-thirty, Brittany climbed out rubbing a stiff purple spot on her left hip where the closet drywall corner met the baseboard; Katie and I stretched aching shoulders and stiff lower backs as we transferred up into our wheelchairs; and at least twice a week, whenever Chelsea rolled over in her sleep hugging Shelly Turtle, her elbow accidentally bonked the point of my chin under our hanging winter parkas.

Even Dad had chuckled gently one Sunday afternoon in late August when he noticed all of our winter coats re-hung inside his spare-room closet so our heads would stop tangling in parka zippers—and that same afternoon around the kitchen table, Katie, Dad, Brittany, and I had sketched out CAD plans on my MagnaBook Pro for the bed we hoped to grow into one day.

In late September, a master cabinetmaker off Witchduck Road had delivered and assembled that vision right across the back wall of our bedroom in place of the old queen bed: a custom solid-oak platform bed built to the exact nineteen-inch seat-to-floor transfer height of our SwiftChairs, wide enough for four adults to stretch out side by side with room to spare, topped with deep orthopedic memory-foam mattresses, smooth bolstered oak side rails, a recessed headboard shelf for glasses and inhalers, and an oversized navy-and-cream patchwork quilt.

For its first two weeks in our bedroom, however, not one of us had lasted past sunset on top of it—until Brittany proposed her twenty-minute tea plan tonight.

“Remember the deal before anybody transfers,” Brittany said warmly, picking up a small round brass kitchen timer and turning its dial solely to the twenty-minute mark before setting it beside the amber salt lamp. “Nobody has to sleep out here tonight. Our giant sleeping bag and all four pillows are spread out ready and waiting three feet away inside the open closet. We’re only sitting up here under the patchwork quilt until our chamomile tea cools down—twenty minutes tops—and the very second *anybody* feels scared of the window or wants the closet walls, we stop the timer and move right into our sleeping bag together. Deal?”

“Deal,” Katie and I answered together, glancing gratefully at each other before locking our SwiftChair brakes flush against the polished oak transfer rail.

“Twenny minutes tea,” Chelsea echoed earnestly in her thick, slurred voice, setting Shelly Turtle carefully on the patchwork quilt first before climbing up onto the right side of the wide mattress as Katie and I slid smoothly out of our chairs onto the center pillows and Brittany settled in on Katie’s left with our four warm ceramic mugs.

For the first eleven minutes, lying back against deep memory foam beneath the soft navy-and-cream quilt felt almost unreal. After thirteen years of feeling hard plywood subflooring through half an inch of compressed closet batting, my shoulder blades actually sank downward without hitting timber. Beside me, Katie let out a tiny, startled breath of relief as the mattress supported the small of her back, taking slow sips of warm mint-and-chamomile tea while Brittany read aloud in a calm, melodic voice from an illustrated Virginia coastal birdwatching book Chelsea loved.

Then, just as the brass timer clicked past minute twelve, a heavy late-evening delivery box truck rumbled down Arvin Road, let out a sharp, pneumatic *pssshh* of air brakes near the corner stop sign, and rattled our front windowpane at the exact moment an October wind gust scraped a dry oak branch across the vinyl siding behind our blackout curtains.

My body didn’t ask my brain’s permission.

In half a heartbeat, every muscle across my chest and stomach locked iron-tight—yanked thirteen years backward to the dark rear brick alley behind Greenway Court in August 2003, listening in frozen terror as Brenda banged down the iron stairwell

hunting for our first-floor window above the humming box air conditioner. Beside my left shoulder, Katie's hand went ice-cold around her ceramic mug, her pulse jumping visibly at the base of her throat.

And right against my right shoulder, Chelsea gasped out loud, clutching Shelly Turtle tight against her puffer pockets with wide, terrified eyes fixed on the curtain rod.

"T-truck!" Chelsea whimpered through her speech impediment, a thin, frightened tightness catching at the top of her breath. "Group Home Two-Face truck! H-him outside window! Closet bag now, Nate! Please, closet bag!"

Brittany didn't sigh, didn't tell us it was only a parcel truck, and didn't ask for *"just two more minutes."*

Before the echo of the air brakes had even faded down Indian River Road, Brittany reached calmly over, clicked the brass kitchen timer off at twelve minutes, took Katie's and Chelsea's tea mugs safely onto the wooden tray, and beamed at all three of us behind her wire-rimmed glasses as if we had just climbed Mount Everest.

"Twelve whole minutes on our very first try!" Brittany praised us warmly, squeezing Katie's shoulder and kissing Chelsea's temple. "Yesterday we did zero minutes, and tonight all four of us did twelve! Come on—into the fort we go."

Thirty seconds later, Katie and I had transferred smoothly from the oak rail onto our SwiftChairs and down onto the familiar closet carpet three feet away while Brittany guided Chelsea gently onto her fourth pillow on my right side, handed her Shelly Turtle, climbed right into our giant zipped-together sleeping bag beside Katie, and pulled the bifold closet doors nearly closed until the bedroom window disappeared from sight.

Inside the snug walls of the closet—knees bumped together again on hard carpet over plywood—Katie's icy fingers slowly warmed back up inside my left hand, my heartbeat dropped out of my throat, and Chelsea pressed her forehead safely against my right biceps.

"Twelve minutes brave," Chelsea whispered sleepily in the warm dark.

"Twelve minutes brave, Cous," Brittany whispered back across Katie's shoulder, holding all of us close until morning.

Thursday, November 24, 2016 & Sunday, January 22, 2017 — Forty-Five Minutes on Thanksgiving Night & Accidentally Falling Asleep in Winter Sunlight

Because Brittany never once treated retreating into the closet as a failure, our nervous systems slowly stopped dreading nine o'clock.

Through late October and November, twenty-minute chamomile-tea tries became our favorite quiet part of every evening. Some windy nights when acorns pattered hard on the roof shingles, Katie, Chelsea, and I only lasted fourteen or fifteen minutes on the oak platform bed before asking for the closet sleeping bag—and

Brittany always cheered fifteen minutes with the exact same warmth. Other quiet nights, when the twenty-minute brass timer gave its soft single *ping*, nobody rushed to move right away.

On Thanksgiving night, November 24—after a joyful afternoon feast around our extended dining table with Dad down from Alexandria and Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven over from Earlton Court, where Chelsea had stayed happily dressed from morning till night in a soft, tagless cranberry-red fleece tunic Brittany had fitted with matching velvet puffer pockets, proudly showing Uncle David and Aunt Karen how Shelly Turtle had a matching cranberry ribbon—steady autumn rain pattered softly against the pine needles outside at nine-fifteen when the four of us climbed under the patchwork quilt with warm mugs of spiced pear-chamomile tea.

At nine-thirty-five, the little timer clicked softly on the headboard shelf.

Brittany reached up to turn it off and glanced kindly across at Katie, Chelsea, and me. “Ready for the closet bag, guys?”

Katie rested her head against my left shoulder, listening to the gentle rain on the porch roof while her fingers stayed relaxed inside mine, and glanced past me at Chelsea, who was lazily stroking Shelly Turtle’s plush flippers without a trace of wheezing.

“Could we leave the lamp low and stay under the quilt ten more minutes?” Katie asked softly. “My shoulders feel really good tonight.”

“Ten more minutes?” I checked quietly with Chelsea on my right. “You feel safe right here with me, Cous, or do you want the closet now?”

Chelsea patted her blue and purple puffers sitting six inches above her pillow on the oak headboard shelf, peeked once at the heavy drawn blackout curtains, and snuggled closer under my right arm. “Stay ten minutes w-with Nate,” she murmured contentedly.

Ten extra minutes turned into twenty-five—stretching all the way to forty-five peaceful minutes together on the soft orthopedic mattress—before a distant fire engine wailing half a mile south along Military Highway finally set Chelsea’s shoulders tensing and kicked Katie’s and my Greenway Court reflexes awake at ten o’clock. Even then, as all four of us transferred calmly three feet back into our giant closet sleeping bag and four pillows for the rest of Thanksgiving night, Katie smiled against my collarbone in the dark because forty-five quiet minutes on an open bed was longer than we had managed since we were eighteen years old.

Then came the third Sunday afternoon of January 2017.

With the Virginia General Assembly convened up in Richmond for the short forty-five-day odd-year winter session—where Dad had driven Brittany and Chelsea up in his accessible minivan on Wednesday afternoon so the five of us could have midweek supper together before all of us came back down to Virginia Beach for the weekend—Sunday morning on Arvin Road dawned crisp, bright, and crystal clear. After riding CVTA Route 15 together down to Kempsville Plaza for warm bagels and rolling back up our sunny front-porch ramp after lunch, all four of us were pleasantly tired at two-thirty in the afternoon.

“My feet are frozen and my eyes are heavy from session bills,” Katie admitted with a yawn as golden winter sunshine slanted cheerfully around the edges of our open bedroom curtains. “Can the four of us just stretch out on top of the patchwork quilt in our sweaters for fifteen minutes so Brittany can thaw her toes before we start Monday’s amendment packet?”

“Fifteen-minute toe thaw coming right up,” Brittany grinned, pulling off her boots and tossing a warm fleece throw across our legs once Katie and I transferred onto the center of the oak platform bed in our daytime flannel shirts and jeans and Chelsea curled up happily against my right side hugging Shelly Turtle.

Nobody set the brass timer because nobody intended to sleep. Sunlight pooled warm and gold across the navy-and-cream quilt; the house furnace hummed softly down the hall; Brittany rested her head back against the pillow beside Katie while Katie laced her fingers through mine; and Chelsea let out a soft, rhythmic breath against my sleeve.

When my eyes blinked open again, the golden rectangle of winter sunlight had crept all the way across the bedroom carpet to the closet door, and the digital clock on our dresser read *4:12 PM*.

I froze—not in panic, but in pure, stunned disbelief.

Beside my right shoulder, Chelsea was still fast asleep in the daylight, breathing deep, silent, un-wheezy breaths with Shelly Turtle tucked beneath her chin. Beside my left shoulder, Katie lifted her head off the pillow at the exact moment Brittany blinked awake behind her silver wire-rimmed glasses.

For five seconds, Katie and I just stared into each other’s eyes.

“Nate,” Katie whispered, barely daring to breathe out loud lest she wake Chelsea up, “we fell *all the way asleep* on the bed. For an hour and forty minutes. And neither of us woke up scared.”

Brittany didn’t say *I told you so*—she simply beamed from ear to ear, reached across Katie’s shoulder to squeeze my hand, and mouthed silently, *So proud of you.*

When darkness fell at ten o’clock that Sunday night, thirteen and a half years of nighttime habit still pulled the four of us back inside our closet sleeping bag one more week. Yet as I lay on that hard closet carpet listening to my twin sister and our two cousins breathing beside me, I knew in my bones that the closet door didn’t own the rest of our lives anymore.

Part 6: Safe From the Dark and ‘Group Home Two-Face,’ Rolling Up Our Closet Sleeping Bag, & Our First Full Night in the Four-Person Nest

Date: 2017-02-11 at 21:30 America/New_York

Saturday, February 11, 2017, 9:30 PM — No More Fear of "Group Home Two-Face," Rolling Up Our Shared Sleeping Bag, & Our First Full Night in the Four-Person Nest

"Okay, twenty-minute timer is officially done," Brittany said softly at nine-fifty on the frosty Saturday night of February 11, 2017, clicking off the little brass timer and setting our four empty chamomile-mint tea mugs onto the oak side table while winter wind rustled the pine needles outside our heavy blackout curtains on Arvin Road. "Do the four of us want to climb into our giant sleeping bag in the closet for sleep, or do we want five more minutes on the quilt?"

Lying in the warm center of the deep orthopedic mattress in my grey plaid flannel pajamas—with thirty-four-year-old Chelsea nestled cozily against my right shoulder in her soft, tagless cream thermal pajamas fitted with front puffer pockets while she hugged Shelly Turtle in her arms and kept both of her inhalers gleaming inches above her pillow on the oak headboard shelf, Katie tucked close against my left shoulder in her lavender knit pajamas with her fingers laced tightly through mine, and Brittany settled right beside Katie in her burgundy flannel pajamas—I stayed completely still and listened to my own ribs.

For thirteen and a half years—five thousand consecutive nights stretching back to Apartment A6 on Greenway Court in August 2003—lying down on a bed after dark had meant waiting for a cold iron fist to close around my lungs at the first creak of vinyl siding or distant set of headlights.

Outside our drawn curtains right then, a February gust brushed pine cones softly across the eaves, and down at the corner of Arvin Road a neighbor's sedan rolled quietly past toward Indian River Road.

Nothing rang inside my chest.

My shoulders were sunk two full inches into warm, supportive memory foam instead of pressing into compressed flannel over hard plywood subflooring. Our front and back deadbolts were thrown, our home address was shielded behind our registered agent and commercial mailbox, Brenda had zero idea where Arvin Road was, Tyler was locked away for life inside a state medical prison ward, and King's College was six hundred miles north under a permanent probate receivership order.

Turning my head gently to the right first, I brushed a stray chestnut curl back from Chelsea's temple. Over the past seven months—thanks to hundreds of gentle, loving, zero-shame reminders from Brittany, Katie, and me—Chelsea hadn't wandered down the chilly hall without clothes in weeks, proudly patting her warm chest and her puffer pockets every night after her bath. Yet nightfall had always been the hardest test for her fear of Mount Regalis too.

"What about you, Chelsea?" I whispered gently, keeping my voice low and unhurried. "Did you hear the wind outside? Are you scared Group Home Two-Face might try to come here tonight, or do you want the closet bag?"

Chelsea blinked her warm brown eyes slowly in the amber salt-lamp glow, reached one hand up to tap her blue and purple puffers resting right within reach on the oak shelf, and then patted my flannel chest solidly with her palm before hugging Shelly Turtle right back under her chin.

“Door locked,” Chelsea murmured steadily through her severe speech impediment, working each short, slurred phrase out without a hint of panic or wheezing in her throat. “Judge paper say Group Home Two-Face g-gone forever. Me got warm chest. Me got puffers. Me safe w-with Nate, Katie, Bwittany.”

My throat went warm and tight all at once.

Beside my left shoulder, Katie lifted her head half an inch off her pillow and looked straight into my eyes in quiet amazement.

“Nate?” Katie whispered. “My heart isn’t racing at all.”

“Mine isn’t either,” I whispered back, smiling slowly in the warm amber lamplight as Katie leaned across to press her forehead briefly against mine before hugging my left arm close against her chest. Looking past Katie’s blonde hair at Brittany’s hopeful eyes shining behind her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses, I nodded toward the open bedroom closet just beyond our two parked SwiftChairs, where our two zipped-together navy sleeping bags and four pillows still lay spread across the carpet. “Brittany… what happens if you bring all four of our closet pillows over here and roll those sleeping bags up onto the top closet shelf tonight?”

Brittany let out the softest, happiest gasp in the world.

“Nobody move a muscle—I’ve been waiting since March to hear those words!” Brittany whispered joyfully.

Slipping quickly off the smooth oak transfer edge before any of us could second-guess ourselves, Brittany knelt inside the wide bedroom closet one last time. First she gathered all four of our familiar cotton-cased closet pillows and arranged them across the wide oak headboard behind our heads. Then she unzipped the brass perimeter teeth joining our two oversized navy flannel-lined sleeping bags, rolled each retired sleeping bag into a neat, tight cylinder, tied their cotton straps fast, and lifted both rolls side by side onto the top cedar storage shelf—leaving the vacuumed closet carpet completely bare, empty, and wide open behind our two quietly charging wheelchairs.

Climbing right back onto the platform bed beside Katie, Brittany pulled the oversized navy-and-cream patchwork quilt all the way up to our chins, wrapped one warm, protective arm across Katie’s shoulder to clasp my forearm, and clicked the bedside lamp down to a soft amber glow.

Katie let out a long, low, utterly shameless groan of pure physical relief as every vertebra in her spine finally melted all the way down into thick orthopedic memory foam for the very first night since we were eighteen years old in West Ghent.

“Oh, my gosh, Nate,” my twin sister breathed against my left shoulder. “Why did nobody tell us real mattresses felt *this* good?”

Brittany laughed softly into the quiet room, resting her cheek affectionately against Katie’s hair. “I only spent eleven months sleeping on closet plywood—the last seven of them wedged against a drywall stud with four sets of knees—trying to break the news gently.”

“Okay, fine,” I admitted with a sheepish grin in the warm amber dark as Katie nodded wholeheartedly against my collarbone. “Sleeping on carpeted closet floors really *did* hurt.”

“Bed is soft,” Chelsea murmured sleepily, snuggling her chestnut curls deeper into the crook of my right shoulder where nobody in a group home could ever yell at her or take her puffers away again. “No closet. Just us four.”

“Thank you for staying in that sleeping bag in the closet with us until all of us felt safe enough to come out, Brittany,” I whispered, holding Chelsea securely against my right side and lacing my left fingers tightly through Katie’s beneath Brittany’s warm hand.

“Every single night for as long as it took, Cous,” Brittany whispered back.

And when Sunday morning sunlight filtered bright and gold around the edges of our curtains at eight-thirty the next day, all four of us woke up in that exact same embrace—out of the closet for good, and home together in our four-person nest.

Across the Rotunda: The Senate of Virginia

Watching Senator Ward Kill Our Bills Across the Rotunda & The 250-Signature Petition

Watching Senator Ward Kill Our Bills Across the Rotunda, Brainstorming the 7th Senate District with Dad, & The 250-Signature Rule

Date: 2018-02-22 at 15:10 America/New_York

Thursday, February 22, 2018, 3:10 PM — The Graveyard Across the Capitol Rotunda

“House Bill 412, patroned by Delegate Prairie of Virginia Beach, relating to dedicated regional public-transit operating assistance and Priority-One developmental-disability Medicaid waiver slots,” the committee clerk read aloud inside the crowded Senate Finance subcommittee room on the afternoon after the mid-session crossover deadline.

Parked side by side in our compact SwiftChairs in front of the witness table—with a dozen CVTA bus riders and three mothers of developmentally disabled adults from Virginia Beach and Norfolk sitting nervously behind us after riding the morning train up to Richmond—thirty-two-year-old Katie and I looked up at the raised mahogany dais of the Senate of Virginia.

It had taken Katie four years of relentless, brick-by-brick legislative work in the hundred-member House of Delegates to get House Bill 412 across the Capitol Rotunda. After winning re-election in 2015 and 2017—and after the 2017 wave brought our side within a single seat of parity in the House—Katie had worked across the aisle with coastal moderates like our Virginia Beach colleague Delegate Ronald Villa to pass House Bill 412 off the House Floor by a bipartisan sixty-two-to-thirty-eight vote. The bill did two things our constituents in Hampton Roads desperately needed: it dedicated a permanent stream of regional transportation revenue to expand evening and Sunday CVTA and JRTC bus service, and it funded fifteen hundred new Priority-One developmental-disability Medicaid waiver slots so Virginia adults with developmental disabilities—people just like our older paternal cousin Chelsea, whom Katie, Brittany, Dad, and I had rescued by Braxton Municipal Probate Court order out of King's College's two-faced Regalis Community House atop Mount Regalis in Rhode Island back in July of 2016 after Brittany moved in with us on Arvin Road that spring, and who now lived safely and happily at home in Kempsville with us—wouldn't sit on an emergency waiting list for ten years when their parents grew old.

Now the bill had crossed the rotunda to the forty-member Senate of Virginia, where Republicans held a narrow twenty-one-to-nineteen majority.

And sitting right in the center chair behind the subcommittee gavel was our own hometown State Senator—twenty-year incumbent Senator Franklin Ward of the Seventh Senate District in Virginia Beach.

"Delegate Prairie, you have two minutes to present your bill," Senator Ward said smoothly, barely looking up from his leather folio as he checked his gold wristwatch.

Katie rolled her SwiftChair flush to the witness microphone and laid out the exact fiscal math of House Bill 412 in ninety seconds—showing how every dollar was already paid for without raising a single tax on working families, and gesturing behind us toward the Virginia Beach parents and bus commuters who had taken a vacation day from work just to testify.

Senator Ward didn't ask a single question about the math, and he didn't call a single citizen witness from the sign-up sheet.

"Thank you, Delegate Prairie, we all know how fond you and your brother are of buses," Senator Ward said with a dismissive wave of his hand. "Unfortunately, this subcommittee has other highway priorities for Hampton Roads this afternoon. Do I hear a motion to pass House Bill 412 by indefinitely?"

"So moved," a majority senator muttered beside him.

"All in favor say aye—opposed no—the ayes have it, and House Bill 412 is passed by indefinitely," Senator Ward announced, rapping his wooden gavel once to kill the bill for the year before the mothers in the back row could even stand up from their chairs. "Next bill on the docket."

Behind us, one of the mothers from Kempsville—whose twenty-nine-year-old nonverbal son had been waiting six years for a disability support waiver—let out a quiet, heartbroken breath and lowered her printed testimony back into her purse.

Katie didn't yell or pound the witness table. She turned her SwiftChair around, rolled back to the visitor rows with me right beside her, and spent ten minutes holding the hands of every parent and bus rider who had traveled up from Hampton Roads, promising them on her word of honor that she wasn't done fighting for them.

Twenty minutes later, after we had accompanied the families down to the Ninth and Main bus stop to catch their ride to Main Street Station, Katie and I rolled back into the center of the historic Capitol Rotunda on the second floor.

In the quiet marble rotunda directly beneath Thomas Jefferson's dome, the tall mahogany entrance doors of the House of Delegates Chamber stood to our south, while the mahogany doors of the Senate of Virginia Chamber stood directly opposite to our north.

Katie braked her SwiftChair right in the center of the black-and-white marble floor between the two chambers and stared at the closed doors of the Senate of Virginia.

"Four years, Nate," Katie said quietly, her voice vibrating with focused steel as she reached across our armrests to grip my right hand. "We spent four years building a bipartisan coalition in a hundred-member House of Delegates to pass that bill, and our own State Senator from Virginia Beach killed it in ninety seconds across the rotunda without even letting our constituents speak."

"Because in a bicameral legislature, passing a bill through the House is only half the equation," I said, squeezing her fingers back. "As long as Franklin Ward holds a committee gavel in a twenty-one-to-nineteen Senate, he can bury every single transit bill and disability-waiver bill we pass."

Katie's blue eyes stayed locked on the north doors of the Senate Chamber.

"The Seventh Senate District covers western and central Virginia Beach and eastern Norfolk," Katie said slowly. "Every single precinct of our Eighty-Fifth House District in Kempsville sits right inside the heart of Franklin Ward's Seventh Senate District. And next year—November 2019—all forty seats in the Senate of Virginia are on the ballot."

I looked at my twin sister, feeling the exact same electric charge I had felt in the Capitol elevator six years earlier.

"Let's finish out this session," I whispered, "and when we get home to Kempsville, let's sit down with Dad."

Saturday, November 10, 2018, 5:00 PM — Brainstorming the Jump to the State Senate Around Our Kempsville Table

"Walk me through the difference between being a State Delegate and being a State Senator," our sixty-year-old dad said that autumn as Katie, Dad, and I sat around our oak kitchen table off Military Highway in Kempsville with my MagnaBook Pro open to the map of the Seventh Senate District of Virginia, right after thirty-three-year-old Brittany carried over a tray of ice-cold ginger ales from the kitchen counter and settled onto the cushioned bench by the dining doorway beside thirty-six-year-old Chelsea, who was hugging her green plush sea turtle Shelly and happily coloring the bus routes on a spare paper CVTA system map. "You're already in state politics in Richmond, Katie, and the voters of the Eighty-Fifth House District have elected

you three times in a row by bigger margins every election. If a constituent on the Route 12 bus asks you tomorrow morning why you're jumping from the House of Delegates to run for the Senate of Virginia, what's the answer?"

"Three reasons, Dad," thirty-three-year-old Katie answered, holding up three fingers from her SwiftChair armrest.

"First," Katie said, "is what happened to House Bill 412 in February. The Virginia General Assembly has two chambers. In the hundred-member House of Delegates, I'm one vote out of a hundred, and even when we build a bipartisan coalition and pass a bill through the House, it has to cross the rotunda and pass the forty-member Senate of Virginia. Right now, the Senate is split twenty-one to nineteen, and our own State Senator here in the Seventh District—Franklin Ward—uses his seniority on Senate Finance and Transportation to kill regional public-transit funding, developmental-disability Medicaid waivers, and minimum-wage increases before they ever reach the Senate Floor. If I stay in the House, we can keep passing bills every February and watching Senator Ward throw them in the trash can every March."

"Second," I said, tapping the legislative math chart I had coded on my laptop screen, "look at the structural difference between the two chambers. In the House of Delegates, there are a hundred members and everyone runs for re-election every two years. In the Senate of Virginia, there are only forty members, and they serve four-year terms. One State Senator represents two and a half times the voting weight of a Delegate. Even bigger: because the Senate is split twenty-one to nineteen right now, flipping just two Senate seats next November flips the entire Senate of Virginia into a Democratic majority. And under the Senate's seniority and caucus rules, if Katie wins the Seventh Senate District and we win the majority, she won't just be one voice at the end of a committee table—she'll be handed the gavel as Chair of a standing Senate committee and sit on Senate Transportation and Finance."

"And third," Katie said, tracing the boundary lines of the Seventh Senate District across my screen from Kempsville and Bellamy Manor up past CCHR, Princess Anne Road, Pembroke Commons, Bayside, and across Newtown Road into eastern Norfolk, "look at who lives in the Seventh Senate District. A House of Delegates district has about eighty thousand residents. A Virginia Senate district has two hundred thousand residents—equivalent to two and a half House districts combined. Every single neighborhood I already represent in the Eighty-Fifth House District is right here inside the Seventh Senate District, alongside the exact CCHR, Pembroke, Newtown Road, and Military Highway bus corridors Nate and I have ridden and written about since 2005."

Dad leaned back in his chair, nodding slowly as he took in the whole picture.

"And what about your current seat in the Eighty-Fifth House District?" Dad asked. "Do you have to resign from the House of Delegates early to run for the State Senate?"

"Not a single day early," I replied. "In Virginia, every twenty-year cycle aligns so that in 2019, all one hundred seats in the House of Delegates and all forty seats in the Senate of Virginia are up for election on the exact same Tuesday—November 5, 2019. Katie serves every single day of her current two-year House term through the 2019 legislative session and all the way to January 2020. Instead of filing for re-election to the Eighty-Fifth House District ballot next spring, she files for the

Seventh Senate District ballot—and Andre Askew, who has worked right alongside us in Kempsville for the past four years, is ready to run for Katie's Eighty-Fifth House seat so our district stays in good hands."

Dad pulled his familiar yellow legal pad and black pen across the kitchen table—the exact same routine the three of us had followed in 2010 for City Council and in 2012 for the House of Delegates.

"Alright, Mr. Campaign Manager and Mr. Treasurer," Dad said with a grin, writing *Katie Prairie for Virginia Senate — 7th District (2019)* across the top line. "Since we're already registered in the State Board of Elections system from Katie's House races, what changes legally under Title 24.2 of the Code of Virginia when a sitting Delegate files for the State Senate?"

"Four main things," I said, opening our 2019 statutory checklist:

"First, right after the 2019 winter session adjourns in late February, we file an amended Statement of Organization in COMET transitioning our campaign committee to *Katie Prairie for Virginia Senate*, keeping you as official Campaign Treasurer and me as Campaign Manager and Chief Technology Officer. Second, Katie files her Certificate of Candidate Qualification under Section 24.2-501, her Declaration of Candidacy under Section 24.2-520, and her updated General Assembly Statement of Economic Interests. Third, because the Seventh Senate District spans two localities—both the City of Virginia Beach and the eastern precincts of the City of Norfolk—our ballot qualification paperwork and primary filing fee get verified across both cities' voter registrars under the State Board of Elections."

"And fourth," Katie added with a determined smile, "the voter petition signature threshold doubles. Under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-506, a House of Delegates candidate needs one hundred and twenty-five qualified voter signatures, while a candidate for the Senate of Virginia is required by law to turn in at least two hundred and fifty signatures of qualified voters registered inside the Seventh Senate District."

"In 2013 we needed one hundred and twenty-five and collected four hundred and twelve," Dad said, tapping his pen decisively against the legal pad. "So for a two-hundred-and-fifty-signature State Senate requirement across two hundred thousand people in Virginia Beach and Norfolk, we're collecting at least eight hundred verified signatures."

"Eight hundred it is," I smiled, reaching across the table to clasp Dad's hand and Katie's hand together while Brittany raised her ginger ale glass from the doorway bench and Chelsea cheered, "More buses for Katie!"

Spring 2019 — Senator Ward Ducks the Race & Collecting 824 Signatures Along Route 20 and Route 25

In late February 2019, twenty-four hours after the forty-five-day winter legislative session adjourned in Richmond, Katie sat in her SwiftChair at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus transfer loop flanked by me, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and forty daily bus commuters and disability advocates to formally announce her candidacy for the Seventh Senate District of Virginia.

Three weeks later, after seeing our first internal poll and watching volunteers line up four-deep around our wheelchairs at the Pembroke Commons, Glenrock Mall, and CCHR bus stops to sign Katie's nominating petitions, twenty-year incumbent State Senator Franklin Ward stunned the Capitol press corps by announcing his sudden retirement rather than face Delegate Katie Prairie on the November ballot.

Instead, the majority party establishment poured over a million dollars in corporate PAC money behind Senator Ward's handpicked successor—a wealthy commercial real-estate attorney who immediately attacked Katie's regional transit plan as a "socialist giveaway to inner-city buses."

With Dad and Brittany walking beside our SwiftChairs every sunny weekend holding the legal-sized petition clipboards, Chelsea beaming in her sun hat as she handed royal-blue campaign stickers to families waiting at the Route 20 and Route 25 shelters, and me checking every signer's street address across both the Virginia Beach and Norfolk voter rolls on my laptop, we turned in eight hundred and twenty-four verified voter signatures to the State Board of Elections in March 2019—more than triple the two-hundred-and-fifty-signature statutory requirement—qualifying Katie unopposed as the Democratic Nominee for the Seventh Senate District.

Flipping the Seventh Senate District, The Mahogany Senate Ramp, & Madam Chair

Flipping the Seventh Senate District, Custom-Milling the Mahogany Senate Ramp, & Swearing In as Madam Chair

Date: 2019-11-05 at 19:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, November 5, 2019, 7:30 PM — Winning the Seventh Senate District & Flipping the Senate of Virginia

"Norfolk precincts around Newtown Road and Glenrock just uploaded to the State Board of Elections server," I called out at seven-thirty on Election Night—Tuesday, November 5, 2019—as my custom PHP precinct-aggregation script refreshed on my laptop screen inside our packed campaign headquarters off Kempsville Road. "And here come the early-vote and seven-o'clock precinct totals from CCHR, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, Pembroke, and the polling place over by Fairlawn Recreation Center on Marlborough Drive!"

Sitting right beside my left armrest in her compact SwiftChair, thirty-four-year-old Katie leaned in while Dad stood behind our two wheelchairs with his hand resting proudly on my shoulder, flanked by thirty-four-year-old Brittany and thirty-seven-year-old Chelsea—who wore her soft cushioned noise-dampening ear defenders resting around her collar ready for the victory cheers and hugged her plush green sea turtle happily against her cardigan.

Unlike our first House race six years earlier—when we had watched eighteen Kempsville precincts around our kitchen table—the Seventh Senate District spanned fifty-four precincts across western and central Virginia Beach and eastern Norfolk. For seven straight months from April through November, Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I had ridden every CVTA bus route connecting the two cities—Route 1, Route 12, Route 15, Route 20, Route 25, Route 29, Route 33, and, starting in

October 2019, the brand-new Route 24 running along Kempsville Road and Witchduck Road to Pembroke East—canvassing thousands of doors from Kempsville and Larkspur all the way north to Bayside and west across Newtown Road into Norfolk, with Brittany managing our volunteer clipboard packets and Chelsea beaming from the front perimeter seat on every afternoon bus loop. In fact, the launch of that new Route 24 corridor along Kempsville Road and Witchduck Road in October 2019 (a completely separate north-south route from the historic, long-retired Laskin Road route that had merely shared a recycled route number years earlier) had marked a personal milestone for our household: the exact month Route 24 began rolling down Kempsville Road, we had pooled our Prairie Twin Interactive savings to buy a larger single-story brick ranch on Lord Nelson Drive strictly fifty-fifty right off the new Route 24 bus line, installing a second custom two-person roll-up hydrotherapy tub and building a second custom solid-oak, wheelchair-transfer-height four-person cuddle nest platform bed in the spacious master bedroom for Katie, Brittany, Chelsea, and me—carrying forward the open, sunlit bedroom sanctuary Brittany and Chelsea had gently coaxed us into back in February 2017—while Dad kept our original brick ranch on Arvin Road off Indian River Road and Military Highway in the family.

And because voters across Virginia Beach and Norfolk remembered Delegate Katie Prairie as the lawmaker who had stood up to the bathroom-bill bullies on Meet the Nation in 2016 and fought every single winter for their buses, schools, and disability waivers, the corporate attack mailers against her hadn't stood a chance.

"Look at the margin in Kempsville and around CCHR, Katie," I said, my voice catching as the green rows populated down my screen at 7:54 PM. "You're carrying your home Eighty-Fifth House precincts by twenty-two points—Andre Askew just won your House seat right on your coattails—and you're winning the Bayside, Pembroke, and eastern Norfolk precincts by eleven points!"

Ten minutes later, at 8:04 PM, the statewide television monitors mounted above the headquarters room chimed in unison.

First came the Seventh Senate District projection:

PROJECTED WINNER — 7TH SENATE DISTRICT: DEL. KATIE PRAIRIE (D-VIRGINIA BEACH) ELECTED TO THE SENATE OF VIRGINIA (55.8% – 44.2%).

And eighteen minutes after that, Brittany slipped Chelsea's soft ear defenders gently up over her ears half a second before a roar went up across the room that rattled the storefront windows when the statewide banner flashed across the bottom of the screen:

BREAKING NEWS: DEMOCRATS FLIP CONTROL OF BOTH THE SENATE OF VIRGINIA AND THE VIRGINIA HOUSE OF DELEGATES.

Katie turned her head toward me, her eyes bright with tears as she threw her arms around my neck across our wheelchair armrests while Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea wrapped all of us in a joyful family hug from behind.

"No more watching our bills die across the rotunda, Nate," Katie whispered against my shoulder. "Our caucus isn't in the minority anymore. Come January, I hold a committee gavel."

December 2019 to Wednesday, January 8, 2020 — The Custom-Milled Mahogany Ramp & Swearing In as Madam Chair

In the weeks between Election Night and the January 2020 Opening Day of the General Assembly, the transition from the House of Delegates to the Senate of Virginia looked very different from our first arrival in Richmond six years earlier.

After the Electoral Boards of the City of Virginia Beach and the City of Norfolk completed their official multi-locality canvass and the Virginia State Board of Elections transmitted Katie's gold-sealed Certificate of Election as Senator-Elect for the Seventh Senatorial District under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-675, Katie received a phone call at our home in Kempsville on the first Monday of December.

It wasn't from a mid-level facilities bureaucrat telling her to wait until March. It was from William, the veteran Clerk of the Senate of Virginia, calling personally alongside the newly elected Senate Majority Leader.

"Senator-Elect Prairie," the Clerk said warmly on speakerphone across our desk, "in the two-hundred-and-forty-year history of the Senate of Virginia, you are the very first State Senator ever elected to sit in our chamber in a wheelchair—and the Majority Caucus has just designated you to serve as Chair of the Senate Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services, as well as a senior member of Senate Transportation and Senate Finance. I want you and Nathaniel to ride up to the Capitol this week so our master architectural woodworkers can measure your SwiftChair in person. When you roll into the Senate of Virginia on January eighth, everything in our chamber is going to look like Thomas Jefferson built it for you himself."

Three days later, when Katie and I rode the morning ARTS train and the JRTC Route 6 bus up to Capitol Square and rolled into the second-floor Senate wing, the Clerk of the Senate was waiting for us with the Capitol's master cabinetmakers and historic preservation carpenters.

Inside the neoclassical Office of the Clerk of the Senate—where tall white marble Ionic columns framed the floor-to-ceiling volumes of the Virginia Acts of Assembly—the carpenters were already constructing a lowered, wheelchair-accessible section of the polished mahogany reception counter so Senator Katie Prairie could sign official Senate parchments and pre-file bills at eye level with me parked right beside her.

And inside the Senate of Virginia Chamber itself, under the tall arched windows and the crimson carpet of the forty-member upper house, the Clerk led us up to the front aisle where the senior committee chairs sat.

Not only had the cabinetmakers modified the front-aisle mahogany desk for the Chair of Rehabilitation and Social Services so Katie's compact SwiftChair rolled smoothly underneath the desktop without a single obstruction, they had also designed a permanent, custom-milled solid-mahogany wheelchair ramp leading directly up to the Clerk's well and the Senate dais—complete with matching turned mahogany balusters and brass handrails stained to the exact eighteenth-century patina of the chamber's historic woodwork.

“Look at the grain on that mahogany, Katie,” I murmured as Katie tested the gentle one-in-twelve slope of the new Senate ramp in her SwiftChair and rolled effortlessly up to the Clerk’s well. “Anyone looking down from the Senate gallery is going to assume that ramp has been part of this Capitol for two hundred years.”

“And it’s staying here for the next two hundred years,” the Clerk of the Senate smiled.

On Opening Day—Wednesday, January 8, 2020, at twelve o’clock noon—after Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, Katie, and I had unpacked our familiar winter-session sanctuary at Apartment 104 of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street the weekend before and ridden the eastbound JRTC Route 6 bus down to Ninth and Broad together, thirty-four-year-old Katie rolled down the center aisle of the Senate of Virginia in her compact SwiftChair.

Because the second-floor Senate Chamber had a level ground-accessible entrance off the Capitol elevator lobby and allowed a Senator’s immediate family onto the floor specifically for the Opening Day swearing-in ceremony, Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea sat beaming in their Sunday best in the front row of the Senatorial family section while I rolled my SwiftChair right up beside Katie’s desk holding our bound leather copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Up on the high marble rostrum, the Lieutenant Governor of Virginia—serving under the state constitution as President of the Senate—called the forty Senators-Elect forward to take the constitutional oath of office under Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia.

Rolling smoothly up the newly installed custom-milled mahogany ramp to the front well with me right beside her left armrest as her ceremonial guest, Katie didn’t reach for a Bible while the opposition senators across the carpet held leather Bibles angled toward the press gallery cameras. Neither Katie nor I believed in any religion or any god, and just as she had done on the Virginia Beach City Council and in the House of Delegates, Katie placed her left palm squarely on the gold-stamped cover of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia resting across my hands, raised her right hand toward the rostrum, and spoke the secular constitutional affirmation under Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia and Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia—omitting the optional parenthetical religious phrase at the end:

“I do solemnly affirm that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me as a member of the Senate of Virginia, according to the best of my ability.”

Ten minutes later, after I rolled back out to the accessible viewing bay to watch the formal floor proceedings alongside Dad, the Clerk read the standing committee assignments for the 2020 session and handed Senator Katie Prairie the polished wooden gavel as Madam Chair of the Senate Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services—sitting right across the chamber from the exact seats where Senator Franklin Ward and his allies had killed her transit and disability bills twenty-two months earlier.

And just as we knew they would, the Republican caucus, right-wing cable networks, and evangelical media had an absolute field day over both what was resting under Katie’s left hand and the four words she had deliberately left out of her oath.

Before the Senate had even gaveled out of its Opening Day ceremonial session at two-thirty that afternoon, an opposition party operative up in the press gallery had blasted out a zoomed-in video clip of Katie's left hand resting on the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia instead of a Bible while she said "I do solemnly affirm" and stopped at "according to the best of my ability" without saying "so help me God." Within forty-five minutes, the opposition party's state committee had sent out a breathless statewide fundraising email accusing the newly minted committee chair from Virginia Beach of "refusing to touch a Holy Bible or say 'So help me God' on the floor of Thomas Jefferson's Capitol." Conservative talk-radio switchboards from Richmond to Tidewater were melting down, right-wing cable pundits on Beacon News and LibertyMax were running red "WAR ON FAITH IN VIRGINIA" banners across the bottom of the screen, and back home in Virginia Beach—just five minutes down Indian River Road from our house in Kempsville—the televangelist hosts of *The 777 Circle* on the Covenant Broadcasting Network were interrupting their afternoon broadcast to warn viewers that their own hometown State Senator had "defied the sacred oath precedent set by George Washington in 1789."

When Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I rolled out of the mahogany doors of the Senate Chamber into the Capitol Rotunda at two-forty-five—with Brittany stepping smoothly to Chelsea's left side to shield her from the bright camera strobes—camera crews from Beacon News, LibertyMax, and the Covenant Broadcasting Network were waiting in ambush beside Thomas Jefferson's marble statue.

"Senator Prairie! Senator Prairie!" the Beacon News correspondent called out, thrusting a microphone toward Katie's lap tray alongside a reporter holding a Covenant Broadcasting Network mic flag while two opposition state senators lingered behind the marble columns to watch the ambush. "The Republican state chairman and the hosts of *The 777 Circle* back in your own district in Virginia Beach just condemned you for refusing to place your hand on a Holy Bible and refusing to say 'So help me God' during your Senate swearing-in today! Why did you break the precedent that President George Washington set at the founding of our country?"

Katie braked her SwiftChair on the black-and-white marble tiles beneath Thomas Jefferson's statue, looked straight into the cluster of television lenses without a flicker of hesitation, and picked up the leather-bound volume off my lap tray so the gold seal of the Commonwealth gleamed under the camera lights.

"First of all, I would gladly encourage the hosts of *The 777 Circle* down on Indian River Road—and my Republican colleagues hiding behind those marble columns—to actually read the Constitution of the United States, the Constitution of Virginia, and a basic history book," Katie answered, her voice calm, crisp, and loud enough to echo across the entire Capitol Rotunda. "Let's start with the law. Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution states in black and white that all state legislators shall be bound by Oath or Affirmation to support the Constitution, and that no religious test shall ever be required as a qualification to any office or public trust under the United States. And right here in Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia—the exact document I placed my left hand on today—the framers put the words 'or affirm' and 'so help me God' inside parentheses, paired with Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia, specifically so citizens who do not subscribe to a religion can make a solemn, binding secular affirmation without being subjected to an unconstitutional religious test."

The Covenant Broadcasting Network reporter opened his mouth to interrupt—"But George Washington himself added 'So help me God' in 1789—"

"No, he didn't—and historians debunked that myth decades ago," Katie cut in smoothly, her literal, encyclopedic memory firing on all cylinders as the cameras rolled live. "Even the Presidential Oath written by the Founders in Article II, Section 1, Clause 8 of the United States Constitution does not contain the words 'So help me God.' Not a single eyewitness, diary, newspaper, or foreign diplomat standing at Federal Hall in New York on April 30, 1789 recorded George Washington adding 'So help me God' to his oath. That story was invented out of thin air sixty-five years later in an 1854 book written by Rufus Wilmot Griswold, who wasn't even born when Washington was alive, and the first President confirmed by contemporary historical records to have said those words was Chester A. Arthur in 1881. And look at whose marble statue we are gathered under right now: Thomas Jefferson, who wrote the Virginia Statute for Religious Freedom right here in Richmond declaring that our civil rights have no dependence on our religious opinions."

Behind the marble columns, the two opposition senators suddenly found something very interesting to look at on their shoes as Katie lowered the Constitution back onto my lap tray and added one final, unbothered smile for the cameras:

"In the Seventh Senate District across Virginia Beach and Norfolk, I represent Christians, Jews, Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists, and non-religious citizens like my brother and me alike. I wasn't elected to be anybody's pastor, and Virginia is a constitutional republic, not a theocracy. My legal obligation as a State Senator is to the Constitution of the United States and the Constitution of Virginia—and if the pundits screaming on Beacon News, LibertyMax, and *The 777 Circle* spent half as much time reading the Constitution as they spend inventing phony history lessons about George Washington, maybe they'd know what Article VI actually says. Now if you'll excuse my brother, my dad, my cousins, and me, we have a Route 6 bus to catch on Broad Street and a committee docket to gavel in tomorrow morning."

When we rolled into Katie's new Senate of Virginia office at eight-thirty the next morning and the main constituent telephone line rang on her desk before her legislative assistant had even finished hanging up her winter coat in the outer room, Katie didn't wait for staff to screen the call. Just as she had done as a Virginia Beach City Councilwoman and as a Virginia State Delegate—because in her literal autistic mind it was her office and it was only polite to answer the phone when she could so constituents knew she was actually at her desk working for them—she reached over from her SwiftChair, pressed the speakerphone button, and said warmly, "Senator Katie Prairie's office, this is Katie speaking," greeting a stunned retired Navy chaplain calling from Norfolk to thank her for defending Thomas Jefferson's Statute for Religious Freedom.

Down on the Senate floor, just like the House of Delegates across the Rotunda, the Senate of Virginia had its own official Senate Page Program for thirteen- and fourteen-year-old eighth-graders appointed from across the Commonwealth—and within forty-eight hours, Katie and I had become the favorite Senator and brother of the eighth-grade Senate Pages for the exact same reason the House Pages had gravitated to our desks four years earlier. Every floor errand from Senator Prairie's desk came on a neat, color-coded sticky note with the exact room number, committee name, and bill number written in clear block print, and nobody in Katie's orbit ever barked a vague instruction or raised their voice when the brass division bells rang.

As for our three favorite eighth-grade House Pages from February 2016—the autistic triplets Sam Hawkins and his identical-twin sisters Mandy and Sarah Hawkins from rural Southside Virginia near Danville, who had told us over sub sandwiches at the Oak Lawn Diner on West Broad Street after riding JRTC Route 6 that Katie was their absolute favorite constitutional officer in Richmond—they had aged out of the middle-school Page program years earlier, graduated together at the top of their high-school class under the loving roof of their Aunt Marge and their Uncle Richard Callaway (who had since retired as Republican House Majority Leader), and enrolled together that fall at age eighteen as freshmen at Central Virginia University right on the West Broad Street Route 6 bus corridor. True to her word on that winter afternoon four years earlier, the moment Sam, Mandy, and Sarah aged out of high school and arrived in Richmond for college, Katie hired all three triplets to work side by side in her Senate of Virginia office—first as paid legislative session and transit-policy interns throughout their four years at Central Virginia University, and then, the morning after all three graduated with honors in May 2024, as her full-time State Senate Legislative and Transit Policy Assistants.

The Accessibility Project: Riding Every Bus Across the Commonwealth for the United States Senate

Part 1: The Living Room Decision in Kempsville, The 10,000-Signature Rule, & The Accessibility Project

Date: 2026-01-10 at 19:30 America/New_York

Saturday, January 10, 2026, 7:30 PM — The Living Room Decision on Lord Nelson Drive & The 10,000-Signature Rule

“Listen to what Senator Martin Warren’s chief of staff just told the political desk at The Potomac Post,” I said, reading aloud from my MagnaBook Pro screen inside the warm living room of our brick ranch house on Lord Nelson Drive in Kempsville while the January rain tapped against the front bay window. “Gregory said, and I quote: ‘State Senator Katie Prairie and her brother are a cute regional novelty down in Tidewater, but two software developers in wheelchairs riding city buses cannot possibly raise the twenty million dollars required to compete against Preston Holloway in a statewide U.S. Senate primary.’”

Sitting on the sofa right beside my right armrest with his familiar yellow legal pad resting on his knee and a mug of black coffee in his hand, our sixty-seven-year-old dad let out a low, dry chuckle and looked across at my forty-year-old twin sister, while across the coffee table in the matching armchairs forty-year-old Brittany and forty-three-year-old Chelsea looked up from sorting Prairie Twin Interactive client folders over tall glasses of ginger ale.

“A cute regional novelty,” Dad repeated, shaking his head behind his glasses. “That’s the fourth election in sixteen years where the party bosses in Richmond or Washington have called the two of you a long shot before a single voter has cast a ballot.”

Parked flush against my left armrest in her compact black-and-silver SwiftChair power wheelchair, Katie didn't look intimidated in the slightest. Her blue eyes were fixed on the muted television screen across the living room, where three-term Democratic U.S. Senator Martin Warren stood at a crystal-chandeliered ballroom podium in McLean raising the arm of his handpicked successor—wealthy Northern Virginia venture capitalist businessman Preston Holloway, whose newly formed super PAC had already banked fourteen million dollars from K Street defense contractors, private-equity hospital chains, and prescription-drug middlemen.

And right below the split-screen video of the McLean donor reception, Global News Network was replaying a clip from the White House South Lawn two hours earlier, where President Garrett Thorne had stopped in front of the Marine One chopper blades to sneer into the press pool microphones about Virginia's newly opened Senate seat.

"Did you hear what Garrett Thorne called you on the South Lawn this afternoon, Katie?" Dad asked quietly, his jaw tightening the way it always did whenever a bully came after his daughter. "He called you 'Broken Katie Prairie rolling around Richmond' and said if Democrats were crazy enough to nominate a spinster on wheels instead of a corporate suit, his Restore the Republic nominee Richard Sterling would bury you in November. And then Vice President Conrad Drayton went straight onto the Liberty First Network at six o'clock to say unmarried, childless, non-religious twins who live together have no stake in the future of the American family."

"No stake in a family?" Brittany scoffed from her armchair, reaching over to squeeze Chelsea's hand as Chelsea frowned behind her glasses and shook her head firmly. "Conrad Drayton wouldn't recognize a real family that actually takes care of each other if we rolled past him on a city bus."

Katie reached her right hand across our wheelchair armrests, laced her fingers tightly through mine, and looked warmly around the living room at Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and me.

Six winters had passed since Katie had rolled up the newly milled solid-mahogany ramp in the Senate of Virginia Chamber in January 2020 to take the gavel as Chair of Rehabilitation and Social Services. Across those six years—through the August 2020 pandemic special session inside the Central Virginia University Student Commons Ballroom on West Broad Street, where Katie had legislated behind a three-sided clear polycarbonate shield wearing a NIOSH-approved trifold N95 respirator fitted with an airtight medical drinking valve while I logged classroom and bus ventilation rates on our pocket NDIR carbon-dioxide monitor and wiped our SwiftChair joysticks down with non-alcoholic benzalkonium chloride and hypochlorous acid wipes—she had never missed a single roll-call vote or a single constituent phone call. She had won re-election overwhelmingly in the renumbered Twenty-Second Senate District in November 2023, and just yesterday afternoon at the Capitol in Richmond, she had co-patroned and cast her second-passage YES votes to place three historic Constitutional Amendments directly onto the November 3, 2026 statewide ballot: enshrining the fundamental Right to Reproductive Freedom, locking Marriage Equality into the Constitution of Virginia while repealing the defunct 2006 ban, and establishing automatic Restoration of Voting Rights upon completion of a prison term.

Yet every single morning when we opened the federal register, we watched the Restore the Republic administration in Washington—and their billionaire Apex Efficiency Commission—try to rip away the exact civil rights, Medicaid home-and-community-based disability waivers, rural hospitals, and Federal Transit Administration operating grants that working Virginians depended on to survive. And instead of fighting back with teeth, Senator Martin Warren's handpicked corporate heir Preston Holloway was going on cable television preaching polite, poll-tested incrementalism so he wouldn't offend his K Street donors.

"Martin Warren doesn't own that Senate seat, Dad," Katie said, her voice calm, steady, and ringing with the exact same crystalline resolve she had carried onto the four buses in 2008. "That seat belongs to the eight point seven million people of the Commonwealth of Virginia. Preston Holloway thinks he can buy the June primary from a ballroom in McLean without ever setting foot on a public bus, and Garrett Thorne and Conrad Drayton think calling me 'Broken Katie Prairie' is going to make Nate and me hide in our house. I want to beat Preston Holloway in the June sixteenth primary, I want to beat Richard Sterling on November third, and on January third, 2027, I want to roll down the aisle of the United States Senate and watch Vice President Conrad Drayton—in his constitutional capacity as President of the Senate—be forced to swear me in on the Constitution of the United States without a Bible and without saying 'So help me God.'"

I grinned across our armrests, feeling the familiar electric surge run straight through my ribs. "He is going to turn purple at the rostrum, Katie."

"Let him," Katie smiled, squeezing my hand before turning to Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea. "Are all four of you with me?"

"Try stopping us, cuz," Brittany grinned, while Chelsea clapped both hands softly and nodded: "Ride all the buses, Katie!"

Dad uncapped his black rollerball pen, tapped it against the top of his yellow legal pad, and wrote *Katie Prairie for United States Senate — 2026* in neat, square block letters across the top margin.

"Every single mile, sweetheart," Dad said warmly. "Alright, Mr. Campaign Manager and Chief Technology Officer—walk your Treasurer through the statutory jump from a forty-district State Senate race to a statewide United States Senate campaign."

I tapped a shortcut on my MagnaBook Pro, pulling up the federal and state election code checklists I had spent the past forty-eight hours compiling in Quantum Code.

"First," I said, "because the United States Senate is a federal office, our campaign finance reporting moves from Virginia's state COMET system to the Federal Election Commission. Tonight we file FEC Form 2—Katie's Statement of Candidacy—and FEC Form 1 registering *Katie Prairie for U.S. Senate* as her principal campaign committee, with you as official Campaign Treasurer and me as Campaign Manager and Chief Technology Officer, plus her mandatory Senate Public Financial Disclosure Report with the Secretary of the United States Senate. And because our campaign donations will process through CivicPulse and Meridian Pay behind Aegis Cloud on the PHP infrastructure we write and maintain ourselves, zero dollars are going to beltway fundraising consultants."

“And what about getting Katie’s name onto the June sixteenth Democratic Primary ballot under Virginia law?” Dad asked, poised with his pen.

“That’s the biggest hurdle—and the exact reason the Washington insiders think we can’t do it without corporate money,” I replied, rotating my laptop slightly toward Dad’s side of the sofa so both he and Katie could read the statutory table. “When Katie ran for the House of Delegates, Code of Virginia Section 24.2-506 required one hundred and twenty-five voter signatures. When she ran for the Senate of Virginia, it required two hundred and fifty. To qualify for the statewide United States Senate primary ballot in Virginia, Section 24.2-506 requires at least ten thousand qualified voter signatures statewide—and there’s a mandatory geographic distribution rule: those ten thousand signatures must include at least four hundred qualified voters from each of Virginia’s eleven Congressional Districts.”

Dad whistled softly, jotting the numbers onto his legal pad. “Ten thousand verified signatures statewide, with a hard floor of four hundred in all eleven Congressional Districts—from Accomack County on the Eastern Shore and Virginia Beach here in the Second District all the way out to the Ninth District in Blacksburg, Bluewater, Abingdon, and Cumberland Gap.”

“Which means if our campaign standard is always collecting more than double the statutory minimum so no party lawyer can challenge us off the ballot,” Katie said, her blue eyes lighting up with mathematical focus, “we aren’t stopping at ten thousand signatures and four hundred per district. We’re collecting at least twenty-four thousand signatures statewide, and at least twelve hundred verified signatures in every single one of the eleven Congressional Districts.”

Just then, Katie’s smartphone buzzed on the coffee table beside our three tall glasses of ice-cold ginger ale. It was a Washington campaign consultant who had been leaving voicemails all afternoon offering to sign on as a paid strategist. When Katie tapped the speakerphone button and told him she was entering the race, the consultant immediately launched into a slick sales pitch offering to lease our campaign a forty-five-foot custom diesel motorcoach wrapped with a giant photograph of Katie’s face for forty-two thousand dollars a month.

Katie looked at me, looked at Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea, and leaned toward the speakerphone.

“Thank you for calling, but our campaign will not be leasing a private tour bus,” Katie told him crisply. “For the past sixteen years, my brother Nate, my dad, my cousins Brittany and Chelsea, and I have ridden regular public transit buses and passenger trains everywhere we go, and we pay standard regular fare at the farebox alongside our constituents. If a rural county or a working-class corridor in Virginia has a public bus route, we are riding that bus with the people who live there. And if a rural county doesn’t have fixed-route bus service between towns, or if a wheelchair ramp breaks down in the rain, my dad is going to rent a wheelchair-accessible minivan to bridge the gap so we experience that exact transit desert the same way disabled and working-class Virginians do every day. Have a good evening.”

She tapped the red disconnect button, and Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea raised their glasses of ginger ale in a five-way living-room toast.

Saturday, January 10, 2026, 8:45 PM — Written Permission From The Paper Wall & The Brooks Family for "The Accessibility Project"

Forty-five minutes after we filed Katie's FEC Form 2 electronically, a chime sounded on my laptop as an incoming OmniMeet video call connected from the New River Valley.

When I clicked accept and angled my screen so Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I could all see it clearly from our seats, two joyful living rooms filled the split window at once.

On the left side of the screen, gathered inside the sunlit control room of Engine Room Records in Blacksburg alongside Holly O'Connell—the youngest O'Connell sister and longtime Day-to-Day Band Manager and General Counsel—sat the members of The Paper Wall: Julian Croft ("Leo"), Maya Sterling ("Olivia"), sisters Izzy ("Luna"), Bea ("Stella"), and Charlotte ("Charlie") Croft, and cousins Diana Hale, Ellie Cross, and Fiona Croft.

And on the right side of the screen, gathered inside the wide, oak-bumpered communal living room of the Brooks Family Compound along U.S. Route 11 between Christiansburg and Radford, sat the found family whom The Paper Wall's music had chronicled—centered around the original trio from Bennett Hall Room 214: thirty-year-old Jordan Shawn Kelly (clean-shaven, wearing his rectangular prescription glasses and behind-the-ear hearing aids, seated in his custom manual wheelchair with his Pinnacle Vanguard Pro laptop open to his dark-screened NeoEdit terminal on Aura Glade) flanked right beside his armrests by his wife Aubrie Jean Kelly and Madison Elizabeth Scott, along with their Room 216 and Constellation family: Zoë Wren Brooks, Lauren Nicole Barnes, Hannah Parker Anderson, Mark Shawn Anderson, Isabel Claire Dawson, Jessamine "Jess" Mercer, Daniel, Laura, and Megan Brooks, and Australian expats Sarah Kristyn Braithwaite and Jessica Gallagher.

"Senator Prairie! Nate! Mr. Prairie!" Aubrie Jean called out warmly, her long brown side-braid resting over her shoulder as she held up a freshly signed, notarized legal document beside Jordan's wheelchair while Holly O'Connell held up the matching Engine Room Records master licensing execution sheet in Blacksburg. "We just saw your FEC filing go live on the wire five minutes ago, and we wanted to be the very first people in the Commonwealth of Virginia to hand you this!"

On the right half of our screen, Zoë shared a high-resolution PDF onto our workspace: a permanent, royalty-free campaign synchronization and public-performance license for Track 13 of *The Eleventh Child, Book 2: System.Restore* —"The Accessibility Project"—signed in ink by every member of The Paper Wall, by Holly O'Connell on behalf of Engine Room Records, and by Jordan, Aubrie Jean, Madison, Zoë, Lauren, Hannah, Mark, Sarah, Jessica Gallagher, Isabel, Jessamine, and Daniel, Laura, and Megan Brooks.

Katie's hand flew to her collar, her blue eyes shining as she looked at the twenty-plus signatures spanning both pages.

"You all signed this for our campaign?" Katie asked softly.

"Every single one of us," Julian Croft smiled from Blacksburg, his arm around Maya's shoulders while Izzy, Bea, and Charlie cheered behind them. "When we wrote and recorded 'The Accessibility Project,' we wanted it to sound like a

triumphant mission briefing—turning accessibility mapping and disability solidarity into an unstoppable anthem. There isn't a candidate in America that song belongs to more than you and Nate."

Beside Aubrie Jean and Madison on the right side of the screen, Jordan's fingers moved swiftly across the tactile keys of his Pinnacle Vanguard Pro laptop, and a moment later he triggered EchoType—filling our Kempsville living room with the warm, clear Australian female cadence of his signature "Sydney" voice profile:

Listen to the first verse of that song, Senator Prairie. Back in the spring of 2015, when the six of us from Suite 214 and 216 were undergraduate freshmen at Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute mapping the Hillside Pass-Through elevators at Eleanor Bennett Hall for our class project, the lyric in our song was: "We cannot pour the concrete for a ramp, we cannot buy an elevator for the camp—the budget's zero, but the mission's clear." Back then, our budget really was zero. All we could do was draw the map and share the key.

Jordan smiled warmly behind his glasses as Aubrie Jean and Madison rested their hands on his shoulders and Daniel and Laura Brooks nodded proudly behind him. He typed another line and pressed the speak key:

Every single eligible Virginian voter in our family—Aubrie Jean, Madison, Zoë, Lauren, Hannah, Mark, Isabel, Jess, Daniel, Laura, Megan, and me—is voting for you in the June sixteenth Democratic Primary and again on November third. And even though Sarah and Jessica are Australian nationals who can't cast a ballot yet, all of us are going to help you gather signatures and campaign across the New River Valley, Bluewater, and Southwest Virginia. Because when you roll onto the floor of the United States Senate and take your seat on the Senate Appropriations Committee, the budget won't be zero anymore. You're going to Washington to pour the concrete for the ramps and fund the elevators for the whole country.

Across our armrests, Katie squeezed my fingers so tightly I could feel her pulse beating against mine.

"When Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I ride the bus up to Montgomery County and Carroll County this spring," Katie promised them, her voice clear and steady as Brittany and Chelsea waved happily into the webcam behind our shoulders, "'The Accessibility Project' is going to be playing from every speaker we bring—and we'll meet the Room 214 crew right at the Route 3 bus shelter at the end of your driveway on Lee Highway."

Part 2: The Jammed Ramp on Victoria Boulevard, ShoreLine Transit Across the Bay, & Wearing the NFA's 'F' Grade in Fairfax

Date: 2026-03-28 at 10:15 America/New_York

Saturday, March 28, 2026, 10:15 AM — The Jammed Wheelchair Ramp in the Rain on Victoria Boulevard in Hampton

Caution: ramp is deploying! the exterior speaker of the twelve-year-old Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 103 bus crackled in the pouring March rain on Victoria Boulevard in Hampton—and then a harsh metallic grind echoed off the wet

asphalt as the front flip-out aluminum wheelchair ramp seized halfway out of the threshold, sticking straight up at a forty-five-degree angle twelve inches above the flooded concrete curb.

Inside the open front doorway of the bus, the uniformed operator hit the hydraulic toggle switch twice more, winced as the worn actuator motor whined without budging an inch, and stepped out into the cold rain in his high-visibility vest.

“Oh, Senator Prairie, I am so sorry,” the operator said, kneeling on the wet sidewalk beside the jammed hinge plate as water dripped from the bill of his cap. “This coach has three hundred and eighty thousand miles on the chassis, and the shop has been waiting six weeks on replacement hydraulic actuators because the spare-parts budget is tapped out. Let me call dispatch for a road supervisor and a relief bus—it might take thirty-five or forty minutes in this weather.”

Parked side by side in our compact SwiftChairs in our rain slickers while Dad stood behind us holding a wide clear umbrella over our laptop bag and petition clipboards and Brittany held a matching umbrella over Chelsea under the dry edge of the canopy, forty-year-old Katie didn’t reach for a phone to summon a campaign car, and she didn’t get angry at the driver.

Instead, she looked at the seven working commuters waiting under the narrow aluminum shelter overhang on Victoria Boulevard—two pipefitters from Peninsula Shipbuilding & Drydock in Newport News still wearing their steel-toed boots after an overnight hull shift, three certified nursing assistants in damp scrubs heading to Hampton, and a retired Navy machinist with a cane—each of whom had already signed our Third Congressional District primary petitions five minutes earlier.

“You don’t owe us a single apology—you can’t drive a bus safely when Washington starves your maintenance shop of spare parts,” Katie told the operator warmly, rolling her SwiftChair two feet closer so he could step back under the dry overhang of the shelter beside Brittany and Chelsea. “Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I aren’t going anywhere. If the riders on Victoria Boulevard have to wait forty minutes in the rain for a road supervisor with a pry bar, then the candidate asking to represent them in the United States Senate is waiting right here in the rain with them.”

I lifted my mPhone on its armrest mount and tapped the live broadcast button on StreamCast and The Grid.

For the next thirty-eight minutes, while the March downpour drummed against the shelter roof on Victoria Boulevard and Preston Holloway was up in Arlington hosting a two-thousand-dollar-a-plate brunch inside a Sovereign Regency hotel ballroom, forty-two thousand Virginians watched live on their phones as Katie sat in her wheelchair in the Hampton rain listening to shipyard workers and hospital aides explain what happens to an hourly worker’s paycheck when a twelve-year-old transit bus breaks down on the way to a shift. When the road supervisor’s pickup truck finally splashed up to the curb with a heavy steel pry bar and freed the corroded hinge pin so Katie and I could roll up into the front four-point securement bays, the entire bus broke into applause—and by the time we rolled down the ramp at the Newport News Transit Center, volunteers waiting at the bays had filled nineteen more petition sheets in a single hour.

That same week, Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I rode every corridor across Eastern and Central Virginia to show voters what a truly connected Commonwealth looked like. In the First Congressional District, all five of us rode the morning ARTS passenger train into the Williamsburg Transportation Center—the exact station where Katie and I had begun our six-bus escape from Brandon Mercer back in October 2004 when we were nineteen—and rolled thirty yards across the brick plaza from the train platform to pay regular fare on the local CTTA Route 1 bus straight to the front gate of Brewster Gardens, proving to hospitality workers and car-free families that Virginia didn't need to waste millions on duplicative consultant studies when an existing train-to-bus connection was already running and simply needed evening frequency and public promotion.

Two days later, in the Second Congressional District, we experienced firsthand how Virginia's Eastern Shore was stranded on a public-transit island at both ends of U.S. Route 13: at the south end, CVTA Routes 1, 27, and 35 met at the Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road transfer point right at the southern foot of the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel, yet neither CVTA nor ShoreLine Transit ran a single public bus across the seventeen-point-six-mile span to Cape Charles; and at the north end in Accomack County, ShoreLine Transit stopped at Oak Hall and Chincoteague Junction just eleven miles short of the Maryland state line—stopping dead before Pocomoke City, Maryland, where Maryland Shore Transit connected north to Salisbury and Delaware's First State Transit network. So after riding CVTA Route 1 to the Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road transfer point at the foot of the bridge-tunnel, Dad met us with a rented silver side-entry wheelchair-accessible ramp minivan, secured our two SwiftChairs into the four-point floor tie-downs while Brittany and Chelsea buckled into the rear bench—where Chelsea watched in wide-eyed wonder as massive ocean container ships glided right over the submerged tunnel islands across the open Chesapeake Bay—and drove us across the Bridge-Tunnel to Cape Charles, where all five of us boarded a ShoreLine Transit cutaway bus with a rear hydraulic lift and rode the entire length of Northampton and Accomack Counties up U.S. Route 13 through Eastville, Exmore, Onley, Accomac, and Oak Hall. Outside the processing plant at Eastern Shore Poultry at shift change, women in hairnets and rubber boots crowded around Katie's SwiftChair and Brittany's petition clipboards to sign as Katie pledged to fight on the Senate Appropriations Committee for dedicated federal interstate transit funds to close both gaps at once—running a permanent public bus connection from Cape Charles across the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel (where public transit buses were already classified under the Bridge-Tunnel District's Class 8 schedule at a nominal one-dollar toll per crossing) directly into the Pleasure House Road CVTA transfer point on Shore Drive with a mandatory statutory cross-honoring agreement so CVTA and ShoreLine Transit fares and passes would be honored seamlessly on both systems, and extending ShoreLine Transit north across the state line into Pocomoke City and Salisbury with a direct Delmarva corridor link to First State Transit in Delaware.

And when we rode the morning ARTS train from Norfolk up through Petersburg in the Fourth District and Richmond in the Fourth and First Districts—riding JRTC Route 6 down Broad Street with its familiar automated voice announcing *"Route 6. Downtown. Welcome aboard JRTC!"* and calling out every single cross street along the corridor while Chelsea smiled at every chime—we continued north to inspect the rail diamond at Doswell Junction in the Seventh District, where the East-West mountain branch tracks crossed the North-South main line less than half a mile from the front gate of Old Dominion Adventure Park.

“Look how close those tracks run to the park entrance, Nate,” Katie said, pointing from the window of our ARTS Café Car as all five of us sipped our complimentary ginger ales around the accessible table. “Thousands of teenagers and working families ride up here every summer for seasonal jobs, and there isn’t a single platform or bus shuttle off Interstate 95. When we build the East-West Commonwealth Rail Corridor linking Norfolk and Richmond through Doswell Junction to Charlottesville, Fishersville, Roanoke, Christiansburg, and Bristol, we’re putting a high-level ADA station right here at Doswell with a dedicated ramp shuttle straight to the gate.”

Tuesday, April 14, 2026, 1:30 PM — Wearing the National Firearms Association’s “F” Grade as a Badge of Honor in Fairfax

When we rolled off the Capital Transit Orange Line elevator in Northern Virginia two weeks later and boarded a local Fairfax Link bus across the Tenth, Eighth, and Eleventh Congressional Districts, our grassroots petition count had already surged past twenty-two thousand verified signatures—and the gun lobby decided it was time to try to scare Katie off the ballot.

At one o’clock that Tuesday afternoon inside their glass corporate headquarters in Fairfax, the National Firearms Association convened a press conference alongside Republican Senate nominee Richard Sterling to announce that they had just issued State Senator Katie Prairie a lifetime “F” rating—pointing to a viral town-hall clip from Alexandria where Katie had called the civilian MR-15 semiautomatic rifle a “weapon of war” and demanded universal background checks, federal extreme-risk red-flag laws, safe storage rules, and a ban on high-capacity magazines and assault weapons.

“Katie Prairie has no business representing Virginia in the United States Senate!” the NFA’s chief lobbyist barked into a bank of television microphones while holding up a red cardstock mailer stamped with a giant black letter F over a photograph of Katie in her wheelchair. “She got a lifetime F grade from the National Firearms Association, she calls America’s most popular rifle a weapon of war, she wants a government takeover of healthcare, she wants taxpayer-funded abortion on demand, and she led the charge in Richmond to put biological men in women’s sports and men in women’s restrooms!”

What the NFA lobbyist didn’t realize was that Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I were riding the eastbound Fairfax Link bus right down the boulevard outside their building at that exact moment.

Hearing the live broadcast on my mPhone earpiece, Katie glanced up at the automated destination sign above the windshield, reached up from her SwiftChair, and pulled the yellow stop-request cord for the concrete bus shelter directly across the street from the NFA headquarters lawn.

When the bus knelt and deployed its front ramp at 1:28 PM, six television camera crews who were packing up their tripods on the sidewalk did a collective double-take as forty-one-year-old Katie Prairie and I rolled down the bus ramp side by side with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea stepping off right behind us—Brittany guiding Chelsea calmly under the quiet shade of the bus shelter while holding extra Eleventh District petition clipboards at the ready.

“Senator Prairie!” the GNN and Beacon News correspondents shouted, sprinting across the crosswalk with their cameramen as the NFA lobbyist and Richard Sterling froze on the headquarters steps behind them. “The National Firearms Association just gave you a lifetime F grade for calling the MR-15 a weapon of war, and Richard Sterling just attacked your record on healthcare, abortion, and transgender kids in schools! Do you regret calling the MR-15 a weapon of war?”

Katie braked her SwiftChair right beside the Fairfax Link bus stop sign, took one of the red NFA “F-Grade” mailers from a reporter’s hand, and held it straight up beside her lapel so every lens had a crystal-clear shot.

“Regret it?” Katie’s voice rang out across the Fairfax boulevard, fearless and unapologetic. “I wear this F grade from the National Firearms Association like a badge of honor! In fact, Nate, let’s frame this right on the wall of our campaign headquarters when we get home to Kempsville! Unlike the lobbyists inside that building who cash checks from gun manufacturers, I served on the Virginia Beach City Council in the exact Municipal Center complex where twelve innocent public servants and citizens were murdered in Building 2 in May 2019, and I know the families who lost their loved ones at Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute in Blacksburg. I have zero problem calling an MR-15 what it is: a weapon of war designed to inflict maximum human carnage on a battlefield. Keeping weapons of war out of Virginia classrooms, college campuses, and grocery stores so our children come home alive from school matters a whole lot more to me than pleasing the gun lobby in Fairfax!”

“And what about Richard Sterling’s attacks on healthcare, abortion, and his claim that you want men in women’s sports and men in women’s restrooms?” the Beacon News reporter pressed.

“Let’s go down his list one by one, because unlike the politicians hiding on those steps, I don’t need a pollster to tell me what I believe,” Katie answered without missing a beat. “First: yes, I proudly champion universal healthcare for every single person in the United States of America, because no family should go bankrupt to pay for insulin, cancer treatment, or a power wheelchair! Second: abortion is a deeply personal, private medical decision strictly between a woman and her doctor—probably the hardest decision a woman ever has to make—and no politician, prosecutor, or senator belongs in that exam room, which is why Virginia voters are going to vote YES on Question 1 this November! And third: when Restore the Republic politicians scream their disgusting talking point that I ‘want men in women’s sports and men in women’s restrooms,’ they are bullying vulnerable transgender kids—who make up less than one percent of the population and just want to go to school safely—to distract working Virginians while they vote to gut your Medicare, your Medicaid waivers, and your public schools! Transgender women are women, transgender men are men, and as I told the Virginia House of Delegates back in 2016 when they tried to pass a fifty-dollar bathroom-police bill, no woman or girl in Virginia should ever have to pull her pants down for a government official just to use the ladies’ room!”

Behind the camera line, a Fairfax County high-school teacher waiting at the bus shelter burst into applause, followed by a dozen office workers on the sidewalk who walked straight over to Dad’s and Brittany’s clipboards to sign Katie’s Eleventh District petition sheets right in front of the stunned NFA officials.

Five days later, when Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I rolled off the JRTC Route 6 bus at Capitol Square in Richmond to file our primary petitions at the Virginia State Board of Elections, we didn't turn in ten thousand signatures. We turned in twenty-four thousand, eight hundred and twelve verified voter signatures—with more than twelve hundred verified voters in every single one of Virginia's eleven Congressional Districts.

Part 3: The Roanoke Express, The Brooks Family Compound on Lee Highway, The Maroon Express to Bluewater, & Winning the June Primary

Date: 2026-05-18 at 11:30 America/New_York

Monday, May 18, 2026, 11:30 AM — Roanoke's Third Street Station, The RVT Roanoke Express, & The Brooks Family Compound on Lee Highway

"Watch how fast the unified validator reads the card, Dad," forty-one-year-old Katie smiled at eleven-thirty on Monday morning, May 18, 2026, as the five of us—Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I—detrained from ARTS *The Patriot* at Roanoke's Third Street Station and rolled across the bus plaza to the waiting forty-five-foot Roanoke Valley Transit coach.

Because the passenger rail extension to Christiansburg Cambria Station on Depot Street NE wouldn't open for regular train service until the following year in 2027, Roanoke Valley Transit operated both the official *ARTS Train Connector* and *The Roanoke Express* out of Third Street Station—linking downtown Roanoke down Interstate 81 to the Christiansburg Transit Center at Falling Branch, New River Valley Mall, and the CPI Transit Center in Blacksburg.

As the operator deployed the coach lift and secured our two SwiftChairs in the front ADA bays, Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I each tapped our blue-and-slate contactless Blue Ridge Go-Cards—printed with the regional slogan *One Card. Three Systems. The Entire Valley.*—against the electronic reader, deducting the standard three-dollar RVT Express fare with five crisp green beeps that made Chelsea beam behind her glasses.

Forty minutes later, our *Roanoke Express* coach glided off Interstate 81 at Exit 118 into the ground-level eight-bay bus terminal beneath VDOT's eight-level, six-thousand-space garage at the Christiansburg Transit Center at Falling Branch, exited directly onto the grade-separated buses-only flyover ramp onto the US-460 Bypass without touching a single local traffic light, made its intermediate regional stop at the New River Valley Mall Transit Center outside Hudson's and The Spot, and pulled into the multi-bay CPI Transit Center in Blacksburg at 12:30 PM.

For the next four hours, Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I rode the entire New River Valley transit network alongside the students, faculty, and working families who used it every day.

Aboard a sixty-foot Prairie Coachworks articulated bus in the *Mountain Mist and River Ribbon* livery on Blue Ridge Transit Route 1—displaying 1 CBURG TRANS CTR and via S MAIN ST on its amber LED destination sign—we rolled down Progress Street NE in Blacksburg, where Ryan and Cassidy O'Connell, their twin cousins Evan and Tyler Wright, and their youngest sister Holly O'Connell were

waiting at the Progress Street bus stop after ten o'clock in the morning to wave, admire the plush green sea turtle peeking out of Brittany's canvas tote bag beside Chelsea, and hand our crew two insulated flasks of cold ginger ale for the road. Continuing south down Business 460 into downtown Christiansburg to the Pepper Plaza Transit Center right next door to the Montgomery County Courthouse across from Pepper Street and ValueMart, we transferred onto a thirty-five-foot low-floor bus on BT Route 2 (*The Christiansburg Local*, displaying 2 NEW RIVER VALLEY MALL / via AQUATIC CTR & CAMBRIA). Rolling past the two Ironwood Collective apartment complexes on Wades Lane and turning down Mill Lane NE past the Blue Ridge Regional Aquatic Center onto Depot Street NE, we inspected the newly paved off-street bus loop on Depot Street NE at Christiansburg Cambria Station—where Katie recorded a campaign video pledging that when ARTS *The Patriot* passenger trains began pulling into Cambria Station in 2027, she would use her seat in the United States Senate to protect federal passenger rail and rural public transit funding all the way to Bristol.

After riding BT Route 4 east out Roanoke Street past the Exit 118C hotels and the Simmons Road NE deviation through the CPI Christiansburg Campus—universally called "the Law School" by every rider on the bus—out to the purpose-built VDOT sixty-foot turnaround loop at Woodland Drive, and taking a loop on 100-percent fare-free Radford Transit aboard *The Radford Connector* down Prices Fork Road and Peppers Ferry Road through Belview, Centerville, and Fairlawn across the New River Bridge into Radford's McConnell Transit Center, we boarded Blue Ridge Transit Route 3 (*The Radford Link*) heading west out of Pepper Plaza along U.S. Route 11.

Halfway between Christiansburg and Radford along Lee Highway, the Route 3 operator tapped his brakes for the privately funded, covered bus shelter sitting on the one-dollar perpetual public transit easement that Daniel Brooks had conveyed at the foot of his family's driveway back in 2014.

When the front ramp folded down onto the concrete pad and Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I moved up the heated, zero-grade brushed-concrete walkway onto the front porch, the front double doors swung wide open—and the real-life heroes of "The Accessibility Project" came out to meet us, led by the original trio from Bennett Hall Room 214.

Thirty-year-old Jordan Shawn Kelly rolled his custom manual chair straight up to Katie and me to shake our hands, wearing his rectangular prescription glasses and behind-the-ear hearing aids, flanked on either side by his wife Aubrie Jean Kelly and Madison Elizabeth Scott, along with Zoë Wren Brooks, Lauren Nicole Barnes, Hannah Parker Anderson, Mark Shawn Anderson, Isabel Claire Dawson, Jessamine "Jess" Mercer, Sarah Kristyn Braithwaite, Jessica Gallagher, and Daniel, Laura, and Megan Brooks—every single one of them wearing royal-blue *Katie Prairie for U.S. Senate* lapel buttons and welcoming Brittany and Chelsea into the foyer like lifelong cousins.

Rolling side by side down the sweeping forty-eight-inch hallways lined with recessed oak wall bumpers and through the zero-threshold pocket doors into the communal kitchen—where dual-height islands let Jordan, Katie, and me roll right underneath the counter while Laura, Aubrie Jean, and Madison poured cold ginger ales for Brittany, Chelsea, Dad, and the rest of us—Katie looked around the room in quiet awe.

“We’ve spent twenty-five years designing our own living spaces around our wheelchairs,” Katie said warmly, looking from the heated concrete bus-stop walkway outside to the dual-height kitchen islands and the first-floor grandparents’ suite. “Rolling off a regular fixed-route Route 3 bus on Lee Highway straight into a house built like this feels like seeing the exact future we’re fighting for.”

Beside us at the accessible island, Jordan tapped a sentence into NeoEdit on his Pinnacle Vanguard Pro laptop and triggered EchoType’s warm “Sydney” voice:

When Daniel and Laura built this compound on Lee Highway, they proved that universal design isn’t a medical burden—it’s what makes a home belong to everyone. Now let’s go show the rest of Virginia.

“And we’ve already registered over fourteen hundred new student voters across CPI and Radford University for the June sixteenth primary,” Zoë added, pulling up her tablet angled toward her eyes to read off the campus precinct tallies she, Aubrie Jean, and Mark had organized with the student disability union at Callahan Hall. “Preston Holloway’s campaign sent a surrogate to Blacksburg last week who parked in a hundred-and-fifty-dollar VIP lot and left after twenty minutes. Meanwhile, every student on the Route 1 articulated buses and the Radford Connector knows you and Nate actually ride the bus and play our song at every stop.”

“And speaking of buses,” thirty-year-old Madison Elizabeth Scott smiled, tapping the Blue Ridge Go-Card clipped to her lanyard as Aubrie Jean and Jordan grinned beside her, “the three of us from Room 214 are riding down to Carroll County with you today! Bluewater is my hometown—and the Bluewater Bunker where my parents, my brother Bob, and my cousin Emily live is forty-five minutes down Interstate 81 and Interstate 77 from here. The next southbound *Maroon Express* pulls into the Christiansburg Transit Center at 1:55 PM. Ready to go show Bluewater what a real Senator looks like?”

Monday, May 18, 2026, 2:30 PM — Riding Bluewater Transit’s Maroon Express Into Bluewater With the Room 214 Crew & Winning the June 16 Primary

Bluewater Transit Maroon Express to Bluewater Transit Center via Christiansburg Transit Center, the exterior ADA speaker of the gleaming forty-five-foot Sainte-Claire 45H3 over-the-road highway coach announced at the Christiansburg Transit Center bay while its two-screen amber LED sign alternated between MAROON EXPRESS and BLUEWATER EXP via CBURG TC.

Unlike the low-floor city transit buses on Blue Ridge Transit, Bluewater Transit’s *Maroon Express* highway coaches were equipped with heavy-duty mid-coach hydraulic ADA wheelchair lifts mounted above the under-floor luggage bays and expanded multi-bay wheelchair securement rows inside the cabin. With the entire Room 214 trio—Jordan, Aubrie Jean, and Madison—riding right alongside us and Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea tapping their Blue Ridge Go-Cards for the five-dollar Express fare, Katie, Jordan, and I rode the hydraulic platform up into the coach cabin, locked into the floor tie-downs, and watched the Blue Ridge mountains rise outside the tinted coach windows as we cruised south down Interstate 81 past the Dublin Park and Ride at Justin’s Station (Exit 98) and the Max Meadows Park and Ride (Exit 84), turned south onto Interstate 77 up the mountain grade past the

Bluewater Park and Ride at Exit 14 (where the coach's GPS automatically dropped the Go-Card validator to one-dollar local mode for the final hop into town), and rolled into the Bluewater Transit Center at 2:35 PM.

Directly across the street stood Bluewater High School—and five minutes earlier, at 2:30 PM on the dot, the final dismissal bell had rung.

As the operator lowered Katie, Jordan, and me down the mid-coach hydraulic lift onto the sunny concrete transit plaza beside Aubrie Jean, Madison, Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea, hundreds of high-school students, teachers, cafeteria workers, and parents were pouring across the crosswalk into the transit center for the 2:45 PM clockface pulse—where Madison's parents David and Diane Scott, her younger brother Bob in his wheelchair, and her cousin Emily were waiting by the shelter to wave, greet Brittany and Chelsea with warm hugs, and cheer us in. Surrounding the bays stood Bluewater Transit's twenty-nine-foot and thirty-five-foot low-floor buses waiting to depart in every direction across the Blue Ridge plateau: the hourly Purple Line heading west on US-58 and US-221 to Galax Community College; the Gold Line heading northeast up US-221 through Dugspur and Willis to the Floyd County Courthouse (where riders connected down State Route 8 to Riner and BT Route 8); the Emerald Line heading east on US-58 across the Blue Ridge Parkway at Meadows of Dan and down scenic Lovers Leap into Stuart and the Martinsville Transit Center (where riders transferred directly onto Piedmont Regional Transit to Danville); the Silver Line heading south down US-52 and Interstate 77 past Fancy Gap to the state-line transfer hub; and a thirty-five-foot low-floor Mountain Empire Transit *Highlands Express* coach waiting to carry riders west toward Wytheville, Marion, Abingdon, and Bristol.

"People in Washington look at a county map of Southwest Virginia and write Carroll County off as deep-red Restore the Republic territory without ever setting foot here," Madison told Katie and me proudly as she, Aubrie Jean, and Jordan greeted Bluewater High School teachers, working parents, and Galax Community College nursing students who gathered around our three wheelchairs on the plaza while "The Accessibility Project" played crisp and bright from our portable speaker. "What the out-of-town pundits never understand is that Bluewater is the largest incorporated town in the entire Commonwealth of Virginia—solely because the voters here in Bluewater have always refused to break away from Carroll County and become an independent city! If Bluewater were an independent city like Galax or Radford, it would show up as a solid Democratic blue circle on every election map in America."

Right there in front of the *Maroon Express* coach during the 2:45 PM pulse—with Katie, Jordan, and me parked side by side in our wheelchairs and Aubrie Jean, Madison, and Brittany handing out campaign literature and voter-registration clipboards beside Dad and Chelsea—Katie spent an hour talking eye-to-eye with Carroll County voters before all of us boarded Bluewater Transit's Emerald Line east across Lovers Leap through Meadows of Dan and Stuart into the Martinsville Transit Center and transferred onto Piedmont Regional Transit eastbound along U.S. Route 58 into Danville.

Waiting for our bus under the Danville transfer shelter—surrounded by television camera crews from Roanoke, Lynchburg, and Danville who had gotten word an hour earlier that a political bombshell was about to drop—were twenty-four-year-old Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins, our three favorite autistic House Pages from February 2016 whom Katie had hired onto her Senate of Virginia staff as soon as

they enrolled at Central Virginia University, standing side by side with their Aunt Marge Callaway and their maternal uncle, retired Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway.

For more than two decades in the Virginia House of Delegates—culminating in his years wielding the floor gavel in Richmond as Republican House Majority Leader—Richard Callaway had been a household name in Virginia politics and the undisputed conservative lion of Southside Virginia. Every county sheriff, poultry and tobacco farmer, small-business owner, and civic club from Martinsville and Danville to South Boston knew Richard by his first name. As the Piedmont Regional Transit operator lowered the front hydraulic ramp and Katie, Jordan, and I rolled down onto the Danville sidewalk beside Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, Aubrie Jean, and Madison, Uncle Richard stepped forward in his navy blazer, shook Dad's hand and mine, greeted Brittany and Chelsea with a warm tip of his head, leaned down to hug Katie warmly, and peeled the paper backing off a royal-blue *Katie Prairie for U.S. Senate* sticker—pressing it squarely onto his left lapel right in front of the rolling television cameras.

An audible gasp rippled through the cluster of Roanoke and Danville political reporters as Uncle Richard stepped up to the microphone stand with Aunt Marge and the triplets standing directly behind Katie's SwiftChair.

"Everybody along Route 58 knows I served twenty-four years in the House of Delegates as a conservative Republican, and that I had the honor of serving as your Republican House Majority Leader in Richmond," Uncle Richard said, his steady Southside baritone carrying across the entire transit plaza. "Marge and I don't agree with State Senator Katie Prairie on every partisan roll-call vote, and Katie has never once asked us to. Eleven years ago, after Marge and I took legal custody of our thirteen-year-old autistic triplet nephew and nieces—Sam, Mandy, and Sarah—after they survived unspeakable abuse, our kids went up to Richmond to serve as eighth-grade House Pages. When a loud, crowded corridor in the General Assembly Building overwhelmed our kids during their first week on the job, it wasn't the loudmouth politicians preening on cable television about family values who stopped to protect them. It was Katie Prairie and her twin brother Nate, who parked their two wheelchairs around our kids like a shield, sat with them at eye level until their breathing steadied, and rode the Route 6 city bus with our whole family to supper on Broad Street."

Uncle Richard rested a proud hand on Sam's shoulder while Aunt Marge squeezed Mandy's and Sarah's hands.

"Four years later, the day Sam, Mandy, and Sarah graduated high school right here in Southside and started college at Central Virginia University, Senator Katie Prairie kept her promise and hired all three of them to work side by side in her Senate office so they would never be separated," Uncle Richard continued, pointing back toward the Piedmont Regional Transit bus idling at the curb. "And that bus sitting behind us—connecting Martinsville and Danville—is running down Route 58 today because Katie Prairie took a transit bill that three eighth-grade Pages from Southside wrote for their Mock Session ten years ago and fought in the Senate of Virginia until it was funded into law. So when Washington consultants for Preston Holloway or Richard Sterling roll through Southside in chartered luxury buses telling you that Katie Prairie can't win rural voters or doesn't care about families, don't buy a word of it. Marge and I are crossing party lines to endorse Katie Prairie for the United States Senate—because for ten years, Katie Prairie has had our family's back."

In the front row of the press scrum, a Roanoke political correspondent thrust his microphone forward, almost tripping over his own camera cable.

“Leader Callaway, are you leaving the Republican Party?” the reporter shouted.

“No,” Uncle Richard answered flatly.

“But you’re endorsing the Democratic nominee for the United States Senate!”

“I am.”

“How do you reconcile those two things after twenty-four years as a Republican in the House of Delegates?”

Uncle Richard looked straight into the cluster of television lenses, his jaw set with the quiet granite authority of a man who had counted votes and governed a real legislative chamber for nearly a quarter of a century.

“I didn’t leave the Republican Party. The Republican Party left me,” Uncle Richard said, and you could hear every camera shutter on the sidewalk freeze. “The people of Danville and Southside Virginia didn’t send me to Richmond for twenty-four years to serve a President, and they didn’t send me there to serve the Republican Party. They sent me there to serve them. They didn’t elect me because they wanted to watch Republicans and Democrats scream at each other on cable television—they sent me there to solve problems, pass budgets, maintain our roads and bridges, fund our schools, support our farmers and small businesses, and make sure the Commonwealth of Virginia still functions tomorrow morning. Twenty-four years in Richmond teaches you that ideological speeches don’t fill potholes. Sometimes solving problems meant working with Republicans, and sometimes it meant working with Democrats—and one of those Democrats was Katie Prairie.”

Uncle Richard glanced down at my sister with a dry, affectionate glint in his eye.

“Katie and I disagreed plenty—if she tells you otherwise, don’t believe her,” Richard added, making Katie laugh aloud from her SwiftChair along with the entire crowd at the bus shelter. “But I never once doubted that she came to Richmond for the exact same reason I did: to do the work. Ten years ago on the floor of the House of Delegates, when one of my own members brought a badly drafted bathroom bill onto the calendar and tried to call Katie out of order for asking how the Commonwealth was supposed to enforce it, I stood up as Republican Majority Leader and told the Speaker that the Gentlewoman from Virginia Beach didn’t introduce anatomy into the legislation—the bill did. Because I learned the hard way in Richmond that when Katie Prairie reads a bill line by line and says there is a problem with how it actually works, you had better hear her out before assuming she’s wrong. I’ve supported Republican Presidents, I’ve opposed Democratic Presidents, and I’ve probably been angry at every Governor Virginia has had at least once. That’s politics. Nobody elected me to swear personal allegiance to another politician. First the Liberty Tax Movement came along and started screaming that any conservative who compromised to pass a budget was a traitor to be primaried. And then Restore the Republic took over and inverted everything our party ever stood for—replacing principles with a single loyalty test to Garrett Thorne. I’ll tell you right here on camera: before 2016, I had never voted for a Democratic candidate in my entire life. Not once. Then Garrett Thorne came down that escalator, mocked disabled Americans on a stage, and demanded personal fealty above the Constitution. In 2016, in 2020, and in 2024, Marge and I voted for the Democrat at

the top of the presidential ballot—not because those were votes for the Democrat, but because Garrett Thorne's name was on the ballot and I refused to put that man in the White House. Back then, I still told myself it was just one man at the top of the ticket. And for a man who spent twenty-four years working inside a Capitol alongside clerks, custodians, Capitol Police officers, and thirteen-year-old Pages like my own kids, watching a mob attack the United States Capitol on January sixth while lawmakers and teenaged Pages were locked inside carrying out a constitutional duty was the day I knew that movement had nothing to do with conservatism. Then came our Virginia Governor's race last November, in 2025. Garrett Thorne's name wasn't on the ballot in 2025—that was an election for Governor of the Commonwealth I spent twenty-four years serving. The Governor of Virginia should answer to the People of the Commonwealth of Virginia, not to President Garrett Thorne! Walking into my Danville precinct and voting against the Republican nominee for Governor of Virginia was the hardest ballot I ever cast, and the first one that truly crossed the Rubicon for me—because when our statewide nominee aligned with Thorne and promised to answer to the White House instead of the People of the Commonwealth of Virginia, I realized this sickness wasn't just one man in Washington anymore. Any candidate who aligns themselves with Garrett Thorne has to learn at the ballot box that Virginia does not belong to him. Now Restore the Republic calls me a RINO and an 'Enemy of the Republic' because I refuse to pledge personal fealty to Garrett Thorne—when the whole point of a constitutional republic is that no citizen owes personal loyalty to a President in the first place! And when they call Katie Prairie an enemy of the Republic, I ask them one simple question: *Have you ever actually worked with her? No? I have.* No Super PAC commercial can tell me she hates families when I've watched her take care of my kids for ten years, and no cable pundit can tell me she hates rural Virginia when she listened to three thirteen-year-olds from Danville talk about public transportation. In 2016, 2020, and 2024, I voted against Garrett Thorne himself. In 2025, I voted against a Republican candidate for Governor to send a message that aligning yourself with Garrett Thorne costs you Virginia. And this year is different again—because this year, I am not just voting against Thorne or his movement in the privacy of a voting booth. I am standing here in broad daylight voting wholeheartedly *for* Katie Prairie. I'm still a Republican. Katie's still a Democrat. I haven't changed parties. I've simply reached an age where I don't need anybody's permission to recognize a good public servant."

On the evening bus ride back up U.S. Route 58 toward Bluewater to catch the northbound *Maroon Express*—while video of the former Republican House Majority Leader declaring *"I didn't leave the Republican Party; the Republican Party left me"* at a Danville bus shelter led every six o'clock television newscast from Roanoke to Norfolk and Washington—Sam, Mandy, and Sarah watched our rural Southside traffic and voter-pledge numbers vertical-spike on my laptop screen and grinned in unison, coining a phrase that every political desk in Virginia would be repeating by November: "the Uncle Richard Effect."

Four weeks later—on Primary Night, Tuesday, June 16, 2026—the political establishment in Washington and Richmond learned the hard way what happens when you dismiss the people who ride the bus.

Despite retiring Senator Martin Warren's handpicked corporate candidate Preston Holloway spending fourteen million dollars in Super PAC television ads, voters across all eleven Congressional Districts—powered by historic turnout in Hampton Roads, Richmond, the CPI and Radford corridors, Bluewater, Charlottesville, and working-class neighborhoods across Northern Virginia—delivered a seismic upset.

At 8:19 PM, the GNN Decision Desk called the Democratic Primary for State Senator Katie Prairie by an eleven-point landslide: fifty-five point six percent to forty-four point four percent.

Part 4: Riding Into Deep-Red RTR Country: Mountain Empire Transit, The Coalfields, & Cumberland Gap With Dad

Date: 2026-07-24 at 09:30 America/New_York

Friday, July 24, 2026, 9:30 AM — Speaking Directly to RTR Voters Aboard Mountain Empire Transit & Cumberland Coalfield Transit

“I’ll be honest with you, Senator Prairie—I voted for Garrett Thorne twice, and I haven’t seen a Democratic candidate for the United States Senate set foot on a bus out here west of Wytheville in thirty years,” the sixty-six-year-old retired coal miner in the faded denim work shirt said across the aisle of the Mountain Empire Transit *Highlands Express* bus as we rolled west through Smyth County between Marion and Abingdon at nine-thirty on Friday morning, July 24, 2026.

Seated right beside him on the perimeter bench was a thirty-four-year-old rural clinic nurse in navy scrubs heading to her shift at Appalachian Mountain Health, while across the aisle our sixty-eight-year-old dad sat with his yellow legal pad resting on his knee and Brittany and Chelsea sat one row back beside our New River Valley volunteers Lauren Nicole Barnes and Hannah Parker Anderson, all of them wearing their royal-blue *Katie Prairie for U.S. Senate* buttons.

Outside the bus windows along Interstate 81 and old Lee Highway, huge red-white-and-blue *Thorne / Drayton — Restore the Republic* barn signs and *Richard Sterling for U.S. Senate* banners dotted the pasture fences across the Ninth Congressional District—counties where Restore the Republic candidates routinely won seventy to eighty percent of the vote, and where Washington party consultants had begged Katie not to waste a single day of her summer schedule.

Instead, Katie had insisted on riding the entire Southwest Virginia transit spine: taking Bluewater Transit’s *Maroon Express* to the Max Meadows Park and Ride at Exit 84, transferring with our Blue Ridge Go-Cards onto Mountain Empire Transit’s *Highlands Express* through Wytheville, Marion, Abingdon, and Bristol Union Station, and then boarding Cumberland Coalfield Transit cutaway buses equipped with rear hydraulic Elevate-U wheelchair lifts up US-23 and US-58A through Big Stone Gap, Powell Valley Community College, Norton, Commonwealth College at Wise, Clintwood in Dickenson County, and Grundy in Buchanan County.

“The consultants in Washington told me not to come out here because they look at a spreadsheet instead of looking at people,” forty-one-year-old Katie told the retired miner warmly from her SwiftChair, her left hand resting in mine across our armrests as the bus climbed the mountain grade toward Abingdon. “If I ask to represent the Commonwealth of Virginia in the United States Senate, I don’t just represent the cities that vote sixty-five percent Democratic—I represent every single town, hollow, and bus route in all ninety-five counties and thirty-eight independent cities. Ask me anything on your mind, sir.”

The retired miner nodded slowly, resting his calloused hands on the handle of his cane.

“Alright then,” he said. “Every night on Beacon News and LibertyMax, Richard Sterling and Conrad Drayton run commercials saying you got an F grade from the National Firearms Association for calling an MR-15 a weapon of war, that you want a government takeover of healthcare, that you support unrestricted abortion, and that you want biological men in women’s sports and men in women’s restrooms. Out here in the mountains, people hunt, people go to church, and people worry about what’s changing. Why should a working family in Smyth County or Wise County give you the time of day?”

Inside the quiet bus cabin, every passenger within five rows leaned in to listen. Katie didn’t hedge a single word or change a single syllable from what she said in Virginia Beach or Fairfax.

“Because I respect you enough to tell you the exact truth to your face instead of lying to you to pick your pocket,” Katie answered, looking him straight in the eye. “Let’s start with guns. My granddad and plenty of my constituents hunt deer and turkey in Virginia. Not a single bill I have ever supported touches a hunter’s shotgun or bolt-action deer rifle. What I called a weapon of war—and what got me that F grade from the National Firearms Association up in Fairfax, which I wear as a badge of honor—is the MR-15 high-velocity semiautomatic rifle with a thirty-round magazine that was used to slaughter twelve people in the Virginia Beach Municipal Center where I served on City Council. You know the difference between a deer rifle and a battlefield weapon, and keeping weapons of war out of our children’s classrooms so grandkids come home alive from school is common sense.”

The clinic nurse in the navy scrubs nodded firmly beside the miner.

“Second, let’s talk about universal healthcare and abortion,” Katie continued. “Right here in Southwest Virginia, Appalachian Mountain Health has closed rural maternity wards and emergency rooms while private health-insurance CEOs cash thirty-million-dollar bonus checks and Appalachian Electric Grid hikes your winter electric bill by forty dollars a month. When a pregnant mother in Wise County or Lee County has to drive ninety minutes over a mountain in winter just to reach an obstetrician, or when a woman faces the most heartbreaking medical complication of her life, that decision belongs strictly between a woman and her doctor—never a politician in Washington or Richmond. And when a retired coal miner with black lung or a diabetic bus rider gets denied a prescription or a wheelchair repair by an insurance bureaucrat, that’s why I fight for universal healthcare—so healthcare is a basic human right for every American from Virginia Beach to Big Stone Gap.”

Katie leaned forward an inch in her SwiftChair, her voice dropping to an earnest, unmistakable intensity.

“And finally, let’s talk about why Richard Sterling and Conrad Drayton spend millions of dollars screaming on television that I ‘want men in women’s sports and men in women’s restrooms,’” Katie said. “My twin brother Nate and I have used these power wheelchairs since the third Friday of September 2001, when we were sixteen-year-old juniors in high school. We know what it feels like to be stared at, mocked by the President of the United States as ‘Broken Katie Prairie,’ and locked out of buildings just for existing in the bodies we were born with. Transgender kids make up less than one percent of the population, and all they want is to go to school and live their lives without grown politicians bullying them or hiring bathroom police. The Restore the Republic billionaires scream about transgender kids every night on cable news for one reason: they hope that if they keep you angry enough at

a sixteen-year-old kid you've never met, you won't notice Richard Sterling and Conrad Drayton voting to cut eight hundred billion dollars out of Medicaid, rural hospitals, and black-lung disability clinics!"

The retired miner stared at Katie for three full seconds—and then a slow, genuine grin broke across his weathered face.

"Well, I'll be damned," he said, reaching into his shirt pocket for his pen and gesturing toward Dad's yellow legal pad. "My brother-in-law has been waiting fourteen months on a Medicaid waiver for his wheelchair ramp in Norton while our hospital cut its night shift. Give me one of those campaign bumper stickers, Mr. Prairie—anybody who rides the morning bus into Smyth County and talks that straight has my vote."

Saturday, July 25, 2026, 2:15 PM — Bridging the Transit Gap in Dad's Rented Wheelchair Van to Cumberland Gap

"Look right there on the bronze plaque, fifth name from the top—*Silas Prairie, 1775*," Dad said quietly, resting a proud hand beside Katie's shoulder as Katie, Brittany, Chelsea, and I gathered along the paved, accessible cliffside trail at the Pinnacle Overlook of Cumberland Gap National Historical Park at 2,440 feet of elevation.

The afternoon before in Big Stone Gap, after all five of us had ridden a Cumberland Coalfield Transit cutaway bus to Powell Valley Community College and held a standing-room-only town hall where retired coal miners with oxygen tanks and union rail workers lined up alongside our SwiftChairs while "The Accessibility Project" echoed through the auditorium, we had reached the westernmost edge of fixed-route public transit in Lee County. Forty miles of winding mountain highway still lay between Big Stone Gap and the western tip of the Commonwealth of Virginia at Cumberland Gap—and just as Katie had promised in our living room in January, whenever there was a gap in public transit connections across rural Virginia, Dad bridged it himself. At eight o'clock that morning in Norton, Dad had rented a silver side-entry wheelchair-accessible minivan equipped with a fold-out aluminum floor ramp and dual four-point floor tie-downs in the removed middle row, securing Katie and me side by side while Brittany and Chelsea rode in the rear bench—Brittany carrying her canvas tote bag with Chelsea's plush green sea turtle tucked inside so Chelsea's hands stayed free to point out the mountain hawks soaring above the ridges—driving all four of us west down U.S. Route 58 through Jonesville and Rose Hill all the way to the mountain pass where Virginia, Kentucky, and Tennessee met beneath the summer clouds.

"Three states at once, Uncle David!" Chelsea marveled behind her glasses, looking out over the stone parapet at the vast green sea of Appalachian ridges before leaning in beside Brittany to trace the raised bronze letters at the edge of the plaque.

"Two hundred and fifty-one years ago, Silas Prairie helped cut a path through this mountain pass so families could cross into a new frontier," Dad said, his voice warm with pride as he looked from Katie and me in our SwiftChairs to Brittany and Chelsea standing right beside us. "And today our whole family rolled all the way from the Atlantic Ocean at Virginia Beach to the westernmost tip of Virginia to make sure nobody ever gets left behind at the curb."

Part 5: Katie's Favorite Place in Virginia: The Cassini Center in Highland County & The October WHRC TV-15 Three-Bus Sprint

Date: 2026-09-19 at 16:30 America/New_York

Saturday, September 19, 2026, 4:30 PM — Past Fishersville on Shenandoah Valley Transit & Over Shenandoah Mountain to The Cassini Center in Palo Alto

"Look out the right window, Katie—there's Barton Hall and the front gate on Roosevelt Avenue," I murmured on Saturday morning, September 19, 2026, as our Shenandoah Valley Transit Route 250 Connector bus rolled through Fishersville between Waynesboro and Staunton in Augusta County.

Nineteen and a half years had passed since Sunday, March 18, 2007, when Dad had packed up our rooms at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center after our twelve unforgettable days as twenty-one-year-old Web Applications Developer students—twelve days in which we had rushed a two-week Vocational Evaluation in a single week after an evaluator suggested training us as Waynesboro ValueMart door greeters, refused to let staff grab our wheelchair push-handles without consent, stayed stuck on Level 2 in Barton Hall because we refused to be separated, got caught sleeping in our street clothes inside a locked seasonal storage closet on Tuesday night after a male client broke Katie's nose and tore her swimsuit top in the therapeutic pool, and rolled out with our friend Tina after watching the administration sweep that same male client's horrific Wednesday-night assault of our sweet dorm neighbor Natalie under the rug.

When the Route 250 Connector stopped at the Fishersville shelter outside the gates, four current disabled vocational students in power wheelchairs boarded the bus, recognized Katie immediately from her campaign commercials, and spent the twenty-minute ride into Staunton telling her how much it meant to see someone in a SwiftChair running for the United States Senate.

At the Staunton transit hub, fixed-route public bus service ended at the eastern foot of the Allegheny Mountains. West of Staunton lay forty-two miles of steep, winding mountain switchbacks up U.S. Route 250 across the George Washington National Forest, climbing over the crests of Calfpasture Mountain, Shenandoah Mountain, and Bullpasture Mountain into Highland County—Virginia's highest-elevation, least-populous mountain county, nicknamed Virginia's Little Switzerland.

So at one-thirty that afternoon in Staunton, Dad picked up the keys to another rented silver side-entry wheelchair-accessible ramp minivan, secured Katie and me side by side into the four-point floor tie-downs in the center cabin while forty-one-year-old Brittany and forty-four-year-old Chelsea buckled into the rear passenger bench, and drove all four of us west over the 3,000-foot summit of Shenandoah Mountain before turning north onto Cowpasture Road N—Route 614—into the quiet mountain hollow of Palo Alto, Highland County.

And at four-thirty that afternoon, we rolled down the minivan ramp onto the grounds of The Cassini Center for Space Exploration for the very first time.

Waiting for us on the forty-eight-inch-wide, ultra-smooth zero-threshold polished concrete arrival plaza beneath the timber-and-stone mountain pavilion was forty-five-year-old Valerie Anne Miller—and parked right beside her in their three

custom-molded, high-back tilt-in-space wheelchairs were her forty-one-year-old non-verbal autistic triplet cousins: Lyra Carina Starling, Orion Rigel Starling, and Celeste Callisto Starling.

Born in the autumn of 1985—just months after Katie and I were born in April 1985—Lyra, Orion, and Celeste were the exact same age as the two of us.

Years earlier, after realizing that standard crowded science museums with glaring fluorescent lights, roaring echoes, stepped planetarium seats, and high-mounted telescope eyepieces locked her triplet cousins out of the cosmos they loved, Valerie had dedicated her life and her family's Palo Alto mountain sanctuary to building a world-class astrophysics and dark-sky observatory engineered from the ground up around her cousins' three wheelchairs and autistic sensory needs.

"Welcome to Palo Alto, Senator Prairie, Nate, Mr. Prairie, Brittany, and Chelsea!" Valerie beamed, greeting my sister by her sitting State Senate title as she stepped forward to shake Dad's hand and welcome Brittany and Chelsea while Lyra, Orion, and Celeste offered joyful, rhythmic hand-flaps and soft welcoming vocalizations from their chairs—prompting Chelsea to smile ear to ear behind her glasses and wave both hands gently back in greeting. "The triplets have been watching your bus videos on our tablet all summer—when I told them this morning that forty-one-year-old twins who use wheelchairs and love space were coming up the mountain with their family to visit them for the first time, Orion tapped his communication switch for 'Saturn' six times in a row!"

Katie rolled her SwiftChair right up beside Lyra's and Celeste's armrests while I rolled up beside Orion's, and over the next four hours—as Katie saw firsthand what Valerie and the triplets had built for the children and families of the Commonwealth, and watched Chelsea blossom in a museum with zero harsh fluorescent lights or echoing crowds—the Cassini Center became my sister's absolute favorite place in all of Virginia.

Rolling five chairs abreast with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking right alongside us down the seamless, zero-threshold hallways lit by warm, indirect amber path LEDs with zero harsh overhead glare and whisper-quiet acoustic timber baffling, Valerie led us first into The Starlight Wing and The Cassini Experience. Instead of vertical glass cases hung at standing eye level, the gallery's six-foot-wide backlit ultra-high-resolution cosmic tables were mounted horizontally at an exact thirty-four-inch height with thirty inches of open knee and footplate clearance underneath—allowing Katie, me, Lyra, Orion, and Celeste to roll our wheelchairs flush around the glowing edge of the Andromeda Galaxy and the Pillars of Creation while Chelsea leaned gently beside Brittany's shoulder, tracing the swirling gold and violet starlight above the glass without anyone ever scolding her to hurry along.

Next, we rolled into The Tranquility Dome—the Cassini Center's planetarium, built with a completely flat, level-entry floor, zero stepped concrete rings, and open perimeter lock-in bays where all five of our wheelchairs parked in a tight circle beneath the dome alongside cushioned companion seats for Valerie, Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea while the sensory-safe sound system played a gentle, low-decibel cosmic soundtrack with zero sudden thunderclaps or startling strobe flashes.

And after sunset, when the Bortle Class 2 dark skies of Highland County blazed to life above the Allegheny ridges with the naked-eye ribbon of the Milky Way, we rolled out into the Roll-Off Roof Observatory.

As the timber-and-steel roof glided silently open on its cushioned rails, Valerie guided us to the twenty-four-inch Ritchey-Chrétien research telescope at the center of the polished concrete deck. Fitted to the rear cell of the telescope was a custom counterweight-balanced, articulated periscope relay eyepiece engineered specifically to swing down to the exact seated eye level of any manual, power, or tilt-in-space wheelchair—and smoothly adjust for any standing guest as well.

One by one—first Lyra, then Orion, then Celeste, then Katie, then me, and then Chelsea with Brittany's gentle steadying hand on her elbow—we peered into the crystal-clear optics at the golden, tilted rings of Saturn—the namesake of the Cassini spacecraft—floating jewel-bright against the black velvet of deep space.

"Pretty rings, Katie," Chelsea whispered in pure wonder through her slurred voice, her brown eyes shining in the starlight as Brittany and Valerie smiled warmly.

When Katie sat back from the eyepiece and reached her left hand across to hold mine while resting her right hand gently beside Lyra's armrest, her eyes were shining under the starlight.

"We've visited every corner of all ninety-five counties and thirty-eight independent cities in Virginia this year, Valerie," Katie whispered softly so she wouldn't disturb the quiet mountain sanctuary around Lyra, Orion, and Celeste. "Before we rolled down our minivan ramp at four-thirty this afternoon, I had never seen the Cassini Center in person—and after seeing what you and your cousins have built here for the children and families of Virginia, this place right here on Cowpasture Road in Palo Alto has officially become my favorite place in the entire Commonwealth. Everywhere else in the world, Nate and I have to fight to bolt a ramp onto a building that was designed to keep us out. Here, you built the entire universe at the exact height of our chairs."

Thursday, October 22, 2026, 8:00 PM to 10:15 PM — The Empty-Podium WHRC TV-15 Debate on Hampton Boulevard & The 8:24 PM Three-Bus Sprint Home

"Come on, Nate, Dad—we have twenty-four minutes to make the curb on Hampton Boulevard!" Katie called out at 8:00:00 PM on Thursday evening, October 22, 2026, pivoting her SwiftChair down the studio stage ramp the exact second the red camera tally light winked off inside the WHRC TV-15 and WHRC 89.5 FM public broadcast studios adjacent to Virginia Dominion University in Norfolk.

Forty-eight hours earlier, trailing by seven points in every independent poll across Virginia, Republican nominee Richard Sterling had panicked and boycotted the marquee televised debate after WHRC TV-15 refused to ban moderator Catherine Lindsey from asking about his support for a national abortion ban, his plan to gut Medicaid disability waivers, or President Garrett Thorne's attacks on "Broken Katie Prairie." So for sixty straight minutes from seven to eight o'clock live across every public television and radio station in the Commonwealth, forty-one-year-old Katie had sat in her SwiftChair beside Sterling's empty mahogany podium and answered every voter question with surgical mastery—laying out the exact statutory math for universal healthcare, reproductive freedom, transgender civil rights, common-sense

gun safety, the three Virginia Constitutional Amendments on the November ballot, the local one-percent public school construction sales tax referendum, and the East-West Commonwealth Rail Corridor.

Now, declining the studio green-room sparkling water and pundit small talk, the three of us had to thread a razor-thin, three-bus evening transfer chain before the suburban routes shut down for the night.

Rolling out the front doors of the WHRC studio to the Hampton Boulevard bus stop alongside Dad, we caught the 8:24 PM southbound CVTA Route 2 bus down Hampton Boulevard and across Norfolk into the Military Highway Station transfer hub. Rolling off Route 2 at 8:58 PM, we crossed the platform to board the 9:10 PM eastbound CVTA Route 20 along Virginia Beach Boulevard—watching the minutes tick down on my phone as the bus hit every red light near Newtown Road—until our driver pulled up to the intersection of Military Highway and Virginia Beach Boulevard at 9:41 PM, just four minutes before the 9:45 PM final outbound CVTA Route 15 of the night pulled up to the curb heading south toward Indian River Road and Kempsville!

As the Route 15 operator locked our four-point floor straps into place and the bus rolled south down Military Highway in the dark, a nursing student sitting across the aisle looked up from watching the replay of the WHRC debate on her phone, stared at Katie and me in our wheelchairs right in front of her, and gasped out loud.

“Wait—you’re Senator Katie Prairie! You were just on television across the entire state of Virginia an hour and forty-five minutes ago!” the student exclaimed. “And you’re really riding the last 9:45 PM Route 15 bus home to Kempsville?!”

“If I don’t make the 9:45 PM transfer at Military Highway and Virginia Beach Boulevard, I don’t get home tonight either,” Katie smiled warmly across the aisle, squeezing my hand as the bus rolled toward Kempsville, where Brittany and Chelsea —who had stayed home on Lord Nelson Drive to watch the live broadcast without the late-night studio rush—were already waiting on the lighted front porch with warm mugs of caffeine-free chamomile tea. “And starting in January, we’re taking this exact fight to the floor of the United States Senate.”

The Senator from Virginia

Election Night, The Decision Desk Call, & The Referendum Mandate

Part 1: Polls Close at Seven, The 8:42 PM Decision Desk Call, & Victory in Virginia Beach

Date: 2026-11-03 at 19:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 7:00 PM — Polls Close & The PHP Precinct Dashboard in Virginia Beach

“Seven o’clock on the dot—polls are officially closed across the Commonwealth of Virginia,” our sixty-eight-year-old dad said, setting five tall paper cups of ice-cold ginger ale down on the folding table beside my MagnaBook Pro inside the quiet green room behind the Virginia Beach convention ballroom while forty-one-year-old Brittany handed cups to forty-four-year-old Chelsea and me. “How fast is the State Board of Elections JSON endpoint pushing the early-vote abstracts tonight, Nate?”

“Refreshing every fifteen seconds, Dad,” I replied, tapping a keyboard shortcut to refresh the custom PHP precinct-aggregation dashboard I had coded on my laptop while Katie rolled her compact silver-and-black SwiftChair power wheelchair flush against my left armrest and laced her fingers through mine.

Through the closed double doors at the end of the carpeted hallway, we could already hear six hundred supporters packing the ballroom floor—Coastal Virginia Transit Authority bus drivers still wearing their navy uniform jackets after finishing their afternoon shifts, community college students from CCHR, shipyard mechanics from Newport News, and nearly two dozen fellow wheelchair users who had ridden the evening bus pulse in from across Hampton Roads because they knew our campaign had picked a venue right on a regular bus line with a permanent, wide stage ramp.

Looking at the clean, color-coded precinct tables rendering on my laptop screen, Katie let out a quiet breath and rested her temple against my shoulder for two seconds.

Twenty-nine years had passed since the autumn of 1997, when Katie and I were twelve-year-old seventh graders at Morrison Middle School learning how to write raw HTML tags by hand in a plain text editor. Back then, watching his two autistic twelve-year-old twins stay up past supper building multi-page HTML websites from scratch had lit a fire under our dad—inspiring him to enroll at the Community College of Hampton Roads so he could earn his computer science degree and build a better life for the three of us. Four years later, during the summer and autumn of 2001—the year of our ill-fated Caribbean cruise on the *Sunward Tropics* and the September Friday when the borrowed time in our legs finally ran out—Katie and I had sat side by side reading Dad’s mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbooks cover to cover so we could learn *Quantum Basic 6.0* right alongside him before earning our Advanced Studies Diplomas from Virginia Beach City Public Schools at Northwood High School and our Associate of Applied Science degrees from the Community College of Hampton Roads. And in March 2007, after twelve unforgettable days at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville—where we rushed a two-week Vocational Evaluation in a single week after an evaluator actually suggested training us as ValueMart door greeters, got written up as Level 2 clients for locking ourselves inside a seasonal closet, and dropped out with our friend Tina after watching the administration sweep a classmate’s assault under the rug—we had worked on the copied PHP and SQL modules unofficially from home for just a few days before deciding to do our own thing at our house off Military Highway in Kempsville, filming our twenty-three-year-old *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* four-bus mayoral loop in 2008, and building websites and desktop applications for the next nineteen years, buying our second Kempsville home on Lord Nelson Drive strictly fifty-fifty in October 2019 the moment CVTA launched the new Route 24 down Kempsville Road.

Every single line of code running our statewide U.S. Senate campaign's turnout model tonight had been written by the two of us at our own desks—without a single K Street data consultant or Washington party contractor touching our servers.

"First batch of Hampton Roads and Richmond early-vote precincts just dropped," I said at 7:18 PM as the green table rows populated down my screen. "Katie, look at Virginia Beach, Norfolk, and Chesapeake. You're outrunning the 2024 baseline by nine points in Kempsville and eleven points along the Military Highway Route 15 corridor."

"What about the Peninsula and the Shenandoah Valley?" Katie asked, leaning closer as her blue eyes tracked the numbers line by line.

"Newport News around Peninsula Commons Mall just came in at seventy-one percent for you, Williamsburg is running fourteen points ahead of projections, and Augusta County right around Fishersville and Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center is giving us the highest Democratic margin in twenty years," I said, my voice catching as the next wave of JSON packets streamed in from the New River Valley and the Alleghenies. "Look at Highland County up in Palo Alto—Valerie and the Cassini Center precinct just came in nineteen points above the 2024 baseline. And look at Montgomery County and Radford—the student, faculty, and Brooks family precincts around Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute and Radford University just reported. You're carrying Blacksburg and Christiansburg by thirty-eight points."

Dad adjusted his glasses, leaning over our shoulders as he turned up the volume on the center wall-mounted television monitor tuned to Global News Network, where GNN's signature Election Night data correspondent Stephen Kovacs—wearing his trademark rolled-up white shirtsleeves, khaki trousers, and striped tie—was pacing excitedly in front of the glowing interactive GNN Big Board.

"Hold on, look at what's happening down in Southwest Virginia along the Interstate 81 and Interstate 77 spine!" Stephen Kovacs said on the broadcast, tapping his fingers rapidly against the touchscreen of the GNN Big Board to zoom into the Ninth Congressional District. "At first glance on our county map, Carroll County down on the Blue Ridge plateau is shaded red. Wait a second—let's tap the municipal precinct overlay inside Carroll County and pull up the Town of Bluewater! Remember, folks, Bluewater is the largest incorporated town in the entire Commonwealth of Virginia because the voters in Bluewater have always refused to break away from Carroll County and become an independent city. If Bluewater were an independent city like Galax or Radford right up the highway, look at what you'd see on the Big Board right now: a bright blue circle right in the middle of Carroll County! State Senator Katie Prairie is winning the Town of Bluewater sixty-four percent to thirty-six percent—where she rode the Bluewater Transit Maroon Express bus right into town across from Bluewater High School—and she is cutting Richard Sterling's rural margins by twelve to eighteen points from Bluewater and Abingdon all the way out to Big Stone Gap!"

On the television screen, Kovacs swiped his hand east across the Blue Ridge escarpment along U.S. Route 58 into Southside Virginia, pulling up Martinsville, Henry County, Danville, and Pittsylvania County in the Fifth Congressional District.

"And slide right across Route 58 with me from Bluewater into Southside Virginia!" Kovacs exclaimed, circling Danville and Pittsylvania County in bright yellow on the touchscreen. "In any normal Virginia statewide race, a Republican nominee has to run up fifty-point margins in rural Pittsylvania and Henry Counties just to stay alive

against Northern Virginia and Hampton Roads. Look at the numbers coming out of Southside tonight: Katie Prairie is carrying the Independent Cities of Danville and Martinsville by twenty-two points, and she is shaving nearly eleven points off Richard Sterling's Republican baseline across rural Pittsylvania and Henry Counties! Senator Prairie's own twenty-four-year-old legislative assistants Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins coined the name for this back in May—they call it 'the Uncle Richard Effect,' after their maternal uncle, longtime Southside delegate and retired Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway, a household name across Virginia politics who crossed party lines at a Danville bus shelter on live television to endorse Katie Prairie because she protected his three autistic kids when they were eighth-grade House Pages, hired all three of them onto her Senate staff, and championed the Piedmont Regional Transit bus link connecting Martinsville and Danville! When the former Republican House Majority Leader looks Southside voters in the eye and tells them Katie Prairie had his family's back for ten years, there is no Super PAC attack ad in Washington that can overcome that math!"

"Remember back in May when Senator Martin Warren's chief of staff Gregory told the newspapers that two software developers in wheelchairs riding public buses could never beat the party establishment's handpicked nominee Preston Holloway in the June primary?" Dad asked with a quiet, wry smile.

"They thought politics belonged to the people who wrote the biggest checks at Washington cocktail parties," Katie said softly, squeezing my hand across our wheelchair armrests. "They forgot that the people riding the bus vote too."

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 8:42 PM — The Decision Desk Call & Three Constitutional Amendments Pass

At twenty minutes past eight, the raw precinct feeds from Northern Virginia—Alexandria, Arlington, Fairfax, and Prince William County—flooded into our PHP database all at once.

I watched the statewide mathematical regression curve on my terminal window cross the ninety-nine-point-nine percent confidence threshold before any television anchor on the wall monitors even opened their mouth.

"Nate?" Katie whispered, seeing my fingers freeze over my mechanical keyboard.

I turned my head and looked straight into my forty-one-year-old twin sister's blue eyes.

"He can't catch you, Katie," I said softly, my throat tightening. "Even if he won seventy percent of every remaining uncounted precinct west of Interstate 81, our leads in Hampton Roads, Richmond, the CPI corridor, and Alexandria are mathematically insurmountable. You just won the United States Senate seat."

Ten seconds later, at 8:42 PM Eastern Standard Time, a sharp orchestral chime rang out simultaneously from all four television monitors on the green room wall.

On the center screen, the red-and-blue map of Virginia flashed bright gold as the banner across the bottom of the broadcast changed in bold white letters:

GNN DECISION DESK — PROJECTED WINNER: STATE SEN. KATIE PRAIRIE (D-VIRGINIA) ELECTED TO THE UNITED STATES SENATE.

Right beside it, the GBS Evening Report, Beacon News, and the Associated Wire flashed the exact same call within five seconds of one another.

Outside in the main ballroom, a roar went up so loud it rattled the framed pictures on the green room drywall—six hundred voices cheering, stomping, and chanting Katie's name while air horns and applause echoed down the corridor, right after Brittany gently slipped Chelsea's cushioned noise-dampening ear defenders up over her ears so the sudden thunder of celebration wouldn't startle her.

Inside our quiet room, Katie didn't look at the television screens first. She turned her wheelchair slightly toward me, threw both arms around my neck across our armrests, and buried her face against my shoulder while Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea wrapped their arms around the two of us in one tight, joyful family embrace.

"We did it, Nate," Katie whispered against my collar, her voice thick with tears. "From the Route 15 bus stop on Military Highway all the way to the United States Senate."

"Every single mile together, Senator," I whispered back, holding my twin sister tight while Dad kissed the top of her blonde hair and wiped his eyes behind his glasses.

When Katie sat back and wiped her cheeks with the back of her hand, she looked back at my MagnaBook Pro screen, where the three statewide ballot referendums and the local city question were finishing their final tallies.

"Tell me about the three Constitutional Amendments, Nate," Katie said immediately. "Did all three pass?"

"Every single one of them just crossed the projection threshold with statewide YES majorities," I told her, pointing to the three green confirmation banners at the bottom of our PHP dashboard. "Question 1—the Right to Reproductive Freedom Amendment—just passed by twelve points. Question 2—the Marriage Equality Amendment repealing the old 2006 ban and locking affirmative marriage rights into the Constitution of Virginia—passed by fifteen points. And Question 3—automatic Restoration of Voting Rights upon completion of a prison term—just passed by nine points. Everything you co-patroned and voted for across the 2025 and 2026 General Assembly sessions in Richmond is officially part of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia."

Katie closed her eyes for a heartbeat, nodding with deep, quiet satisfaction. "Then every single oath I ever swore on the Constitution of Virginia was worth it."

"Wait—what's that red banner on the local municipal tab at the bottom?" Dad asked, pointing toward the lower right corner of my screen.

I scrolled down two inches to the local municipal referendum tally—the one-percent local retail sales tax dedicated strictly to public school construction and major facility modernization, which the General Assembly had authorized cities and counties to put before their voters tonight. Remembering the aging classrooms and accessibility hurdles at Northwood High School when our legs gave out in September 2001, Katie and I had both campaigned hard for a YES vote and marked YES on our own ballots in Kempsville.

“The local one-percent school construction sales tax referendum failed,” I said quietly, reading the certified precinct totals across the city. “The NO vote carried fifty-four to forty-six. Between grocery inflation and utility bills, working families just didn’t have the stomach for another one-percent sales tax at the cash register.”

Katie stared at the red NO tally for a long moment, her jaw setting with that familiar, unshakeable resolve I had known since we were children.

“I respect the voters’ decision—working families are stretched thin right now, and nobody likes paying higher sales tax,” Katie said evenly. “But the roofs on our public schools still leak, and disabled kids in wheelchairs still get stuck behind broken school elevators. If local taxpayers can’t shoulder that burden through a sales tax, then my job in the United States Senate starting in January is to bring federal school infrastructure and IDEA modernization grants straight home to Virginia.”

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 9:15 PM — The Ramp to the Podium & A Toast With Five Cups of Ginger Ale

At five minutes past nine, Katie’s smartphone vibrated on the table beside her cup of ginger ale.

It was Republican nominee Richard Sterling calling from his hotel suite in Henrico County to concede the race. The call lasted less than ninety seconds—stiff, formal, and clipped—and when Katie thanked him politely and tapped the red end-call button, the ballroom coordinator knocked on our door with a wide grin.

“Senator-Elect Prairie?” the coordinator beamed. “The crowd out there hasn’t stopped chanting for thirty minutes. Are all of you ready?”

“Every one of us,” Katie said, checking that the small gold Seal of Virginia pin was straight on her royal-blue blazer lapel before reaching her left hand across to take mine while Brittany checked that Chelsea’s ear defenders were snug and comfortable for the ballroom applause.

As the double doors swung open, the driving synthesizer pulse and soaring eighties rock chorus of our official campaign theme song—“The Accessibility Project” by The Paper Wall—blasted across the convention ballroom sound system: *We’re building a map, we’re sharing the key! Drawing the grid, unlocking the door, we’re leveling the playing field, settling the score!* Beneath the sweeping spotlight beams at the base of the wide, gently sloped aluminum stage ramp, Katie and I nudged our right thumbs forward on our SwiftChair joysticks and rolled side by side up onto the ballroom stage with Dad walking proudly on his own two feet right beside Katie’s chair while Brittany and Chelsea waved happily from our reserved quiet family bay at the top of the ramp.

Above our heads, a shower of blue and gold paper confetti drifted down under the stage lights while the giant projection screen behind us blazed with the GNN Decision Desk banner proclaiming Katie Prairie the newest United States Senator from Virginia.

Looking out across the cheering sea of faces—seeing the CVTA bus operators waving their caps in the front row, the CCHR students holding handmade signs, and the kids in power wheelchairs lined up along the accessible front aisle looking up at

a United States Senator whose chair looked just like theirs—Katie squeezed my hand tightly in front of the cameras before rolling two feet forward to the lowered podium microphone.

“Eighteen years ago, my twin brother Nate and I sat at the bus loop at the Community College of Hampton Roads waiting to see if a single candidate for local office would ride four buses across Virginia Beach with us,” Katie’s voice rang out clear and steady across the ballroom speakers. “We learned that day that if working people, transit riders, and disabled Virginians couldn’t even catch a bus home from a six o’clock City Council meeting before the last Route 12 left CCHR at 5:48 PM, nobody was going to hand us a seat at the table—we were going to have to roll up the ramp and build that table ourselves! Tonight, you proved that the Commonwealth of Virginia doesn’t belong to billionaire donors or Washington party gatekeepers. You enshrined reproductive freedom, marriage equality, and voting rights directly into the Constitution of Virginia, and on January third, Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I are taking the morning train up from Norfolk to bring your voices straight to the floor of the United States Senate!”

An hour later, after shaking every hand along the front Rope Line without a single drop of champagne anywhere near our stage, the five of us sat together in the quiet green room while the crew coiled the microphone cables outside.

Raising our five paper cups of ice-cold ginger ale—the exact same toast Katie and I had kept since New Year’s Eve when we were seventeen years old, compatible with the daily maintenance medication that kept Katie, Dad, and me alive and shared wholeheartedly by Brittany and Chelsea—all five of us tapped our rims together in the center of the room.

“To the Senator from Virginia,” Dad said softly.

“To our whole family,” Katie replied, smiling across at Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and me. “Now let’s go home to Kempsville and get some sleep—because tomorrow morning the real work starts.”

Part 2: The Morning After in Kempsville, The School Tax Referendum, & Jess’s Open Letter on The Grid

Date: 2026-11-04 at 08:30 America/New_York

Wednesday, November 4, 2026, 8:30 AM — Kempsville Morning, Morning Medications, & The Failed School Construction Referendum

“Pills first before anybody touches a keyboard or answers a press call,” Dad said cheerfully at eight-thirty on Wednesday morning, setting the fresh glass carafe of dark-roast coffee down beside the three amber prescription bottles lined up on the roll-under oak breakfast table of our Kempsville kitchen.

Sunlight streamed through the white-trimmed kitchen window onto the hardwood floor of the Virginia Beach house that Katie and I owned fifty-fifty—the house we had bought with the income from our PHP websites and desktop software, where both of our names sat side by side on the City of Virginia Beach deed, and where we

were registered to vote. On the warm cream wall right behind our breakfast table hung the framed watercolor print of a blue butterfly that had watched over our sibling sanctuary since childhood.

Wearing a soft lavender fleece zip pullover instead of her Senatorial suit jacket, forty-one-year-old United States Senator-Elect Katie Prairie unscrewed her amber pill bottle, tapped her morning maintenance tablet into her palm, and washed it down with half a glass of ice-cold ginger ale right as Dad and I took ours.

Across the bottom of every one of our three prescription bottles sat the bright red pharmacy auxiliary warning label reminding us that mixing the medication with alcohol or tobacco carried a known side effect of death. Even if Katie and I hadn't already sworn off alcohol for life behind a locked bedroom door during our cousin Brittany's drunken New Year's Eve party back on December 31, 2002—a memory made all the sweeter this morning because forty-one-year-old Brittany, ten years sober and running our household, was standing right at our counter toasting warm cinnamon-raisin bagels for forty-four-year-old Chelsea while setting Chelsea's two asthma inhalers beside her plate—those three amber bottles meant that on the morning after winning a United States Senate seat, our kitchen smelled like toasted bagels, hot black coffee, and cold ginger ale, with zero hangovers in sight.

As Dad stood beside the table pouring fresh black coffee into his ceramic mug while Katie and I had our cold glasses of ginger ale in front of us—since neither of us had ever liked the taste of coffee—Katie reached her right hand across the table corner to hold my left hand while we looked together at the screen of our open MagnaBook Pro laptop.

"I just pushed your official morning-after statement on the local one-percent school construction sales tax referendum to our press feed," I told her, glancing over the clean HTML markup before hitting publish.

On the screen sat the exact words Katie had dictated five minutes after rolling out of our bedroom:

I respect the voters' decision at the ballot box—working families are stretched thin, and nobody likes paying higher sales tax. But the roofs on our public schools still leak, and disabled students still face broken elevators. If local taxpayers can't shoulder that burden through a sales tax, then my job in the United States Senate is to bring federal infrastructure dollars home to Virginia so our kids have safe, modern, accessible schools without squeezing local families.

"The Republican campaign committee already put out a press release at eight o'clock claiming voters repudiated 'tax-and-spend Katie Prairie' because you voted YES on the school referendum," Dad noted, taking a sip from his coffee mug.

"Let them spin all they want, Dad," Katie replied calmly. "We just won the United States Senate race by nine points and passed all three Virginia Constitutional Amendments on the exact same ballot. Telling the truth about why I voted YES—and promising to fight for federal school modernization grants so local homeowners and grocery shoppers don't get squeezed—is why voters trust us in the first place."

“Speaking of people losing their minds over a nine-point landslide,” I said, tapping a key to unmute the small wall-mounted television screen in the corner of the kitchen where Beacon News was replaying a live six-thirty morning call-in from the Oval Office, “have you two seen what President Garrett Thorne has been posting and screaming since midnight?”

Even though Republican nominee Richard Sterling had called Katie at five minutes past nine the night before to formally concede the race after losing by more than three hundred and sixty thousand votes across the Commonwealth, President Garrett Thorne was having a full-blown, unhinged meltdown in Washington. Across the bottom of the Beacon News broadcast crawled a bright red quote graphic as Thorne’s gravelly voice blared through the studio speakerphone:

There is NO WAY “Broken Katie Prairie”—a total nobody in a wheelchair who doesn’t even have a campaign bus and rides around on city buses with her brother—could possibly beat our great candidate in Virginia! Where did those 8:20 PM votes in Alexandria, Bluewater, and Danville come from?! Rigged machines and her brother’s computer servers in Virginia Beach STOLE THE VOTE! Looking at a MASSIVE INVESTIGATION!

Sitting at our oak breakfast table with her glass of ginger ale in her hand, Katie stared at the television screen for three seconds—and then burst out laughing.

“A total nobody who came out of nowhere?” Katie laughed, shaking her head in disbelief. “Does the President of the United States not have a single staffer in the West Wing who knows how to use a search engine? I have been on the ballot in the Commonwealth of Virginia for sixteen years! I served three years on the Virginia Beach City Council, four years in the Virginia House of Delegates, and seven years in the Senate of Virginia! Last night was my seventh consecutive election victory since 2010! Just because Garrett Thorne thinks anyone in a wheelchair is invisible—and can’t fathom how a woman who rides the bus could beat his candidate by three hundred and sixty thousand votes—he’s pretending I materialized out of thin air to steal an election that his own candidate conceded twelve hours ago!”

“And look at what he just claimed about my laptop,” I added, grinning as I pulled up the Virginia Department of Elections technical specification page on my MagnaBook Pro. “He thinks our Kempsville PHP dashboard ‘hacked the voting machines’ at 8:20 PM—apparently unaware that under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-626, one hundred percent of votes in every precinct in the Commonwealth of Virginia are cast on paper optical-scan ballots that are completely air-gapped from the internet, and that all my script did was read the public JSON tally sheets after bipartisan precinct captains phoned them in!”

Before Katie could even dictate a press response, the split-screen on Beacon News cut live to the Danville bus shelter on U.S. Route 58—where retired Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway, standing in his coat and tie beside Aunt Marge Callaway while Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins held their morning transit folders behind him, looked straight into the camera lens on conservative television.

“Mr. President, I served twenty-four years as a Republican in the Virginia House of Delegates and as Republican House Majority Leader, and I am telling you right now to stop embarrassing yourself and our party,” Uncle Richard said bluntly on live national television, making the Beacon News anchor blink in sheer panic. “Nobody stole a single vote in Southside Virginia or anywhere else in this Commonwealth. Every ballot in Pittsylvania County, Henry County, Danville, and Martinsville is a

paper optical-scan ballot counted by bipartisan Republican and Democratic election officers whom Marge and I have known for thirty years. And Katie Prairie didn't come out of nowhere—she served three years on the Virginia Beach City Council, four years across the aisle from me in the House of Delegates, and seven years in the Senate of Virginia! She won by three hundred and sixty thousand votes because she rode regular public buses across all ninety-five counties and thirty-eight independent cities, hired my three autistic kids onto her Senate staff when they graduated high school, and kept every promise she ever made to working families."

Wednesday, November 4, 2026, 9:45 AM — Jess's Open Letter on The Grid & The Ironclad Prenup Mandate

At quarter to ten, while I was checking the morning analytics on our shared network of websites and monitoring the post-election commentary across The Grid, a text post shared by thousands of grassroots Virginia and national voters caught my eye at the top of our feed.

"Katie," I said, sliding the MagnaBook Pro two inches closer to the center of the table so she could read the screen clearly. "Look at this open letter to the national party that's going viral on The Grid this morning. Somebody named Jess posted it an hour ago, and forty thousand people have already shared it."

Katie leaned forward in her SwiftChair, her eyes moving down the paragraphs on the screen. After the third sentence, she began reading the post aloud across our kitchen table in a quiet, electric voice:

"She says: *Recognize that we did this largely despite the Establishment Dems, not because of them… Take the words 'compromise' and 'working with our friends across the aisle' out of your vocabulary. If the last ten years have taught us anything, it's that we have no friends across the aisle. This is what an actual referendum looks like. Use it. Don't just glue what they broke back together. Re-envision it. Re-engineer it. Don't try to take us back to where we were; take us where we always promised we could be.*"

Dad stopped by the counter with the coffee carafe in his hand while Brittany sat down beside Chelsea at the end of the oak table, all of them listening intently as Katie kept reading down the screen:

"*Codify all of it. Act like you're headed into your second marriage after a messy divorce and you're writing a pre-nup. Make it iron-clad. Irrefutable. Include every last detail down to who gets the coffee filters. I mean All of it. Release the trafficker files. If you or your friends or colleagues or benefactors are in them, too bad. You abuse children, you're done. That's how this works now. Prove that 'no' means 'no' again. That includes the 'no' in the sentence 'No one is above the law.'*"

Katie's fingertips tightened around the edge of the oak table as she read the final paragraphs aloud:

"*Remember that DEI stands for Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion and then DEI the crap out of the Capitol. No apologies, no excuses. The people leading this country should look like the country they serve, not the billionaires who own them. Trust that they will continue to play dirty. That when, come January, the repercussions of their so-called 'big beautiful bill' begin to rain down on the folks who were bamboozled into thinking that it would somehow make their lives better, they will blame you.*

Without logic, without rhyme nor reason, they will say it's your fault that their bill is hurting people. They will lie. Because that is what they do. Get ahead of it. Be proactive. Educate. Call out the lies. Bring receipts. Take questions, hold press conferences and town halls… And then get to work. Do EVERYTHING that we sent you there to do. All of it. Shy away from nothing. Blinders on, elbows out, unshakable principles leading the way."

For ten full seconds after Katie finished reading, the kitchen was completely quiet except for the morning birds outside in our Kempsville oak trees.

"I have no idea who Jess is," Katie said slowly, looking from the laptop screen up at Dad and me with a fire in her blue eyes that reminded me of the afternoon in January 2016 when she took the microphone in the House General Laws Subcommittee in Richmond and obliterated the bathroom bill in three minutes flat. "But she just wrote my entire six-year Senate playbook."

"Every single word of it," I agreed, opening a fresh Markdown document in Quantum Code right beside our browser window to save the text. "Look at what she said about not just gluing what they broke back together, but re-engineering it and codifying it like a prenup before a second marriage after a messy divorce—down to who gets the coffee filters. That is literally how we write software, Katie. Unwritten Washington 'norms' and gentlemen's agreements are just unpatched security vulnerabilities waiting for a bad actor to exploit."

"And as Virginia's new United States Senator, I am going to patch every single one of them into black-letter federal statute," Katie said firmly. "Because federal anti-nepotism law under Title 5, Section 3110 of the United States Code bars a Member of Congress from putting a sibling on a paid government payroll—and because neither of us would ever want you answering to a government bureaucracy anyway—you're staying a private citizen, earning our living through our fifty-fifty software business, and sitting right beside me in Dirksen as my unpaid chief data strategist while I hold the Senate seat and cast the votes on the floor. The national party establishment tried to block my candidacy in the June primary because they wanted a polite corporate insider who wouldn't rock the boat. I won this Senate seat despite them, not because of them. When we take the train up to Washington on January third, I am not going up there to water down my bills to appease bullies who voted to strip healthcare and disability rights from people on the bus."

She tapped her finger on the table beside her glass of ginger ale, counting off her Senatorial mandate right across our kitchen table.

"I will sponsor bills to codify reproductive freedom—because abortion and reproductive healthcare is a private medical decision between a woman and her doctor, and no politician or judge belongs in that exam room—alongside universal healthcare for every person in America, full federal civil rights protections for transgender Americans, marriage equality, voting rights, common-sense gun safety legislation, wheelchair right-to-repair, and repealing the SSI and Medicaid disability marriage penalty down to the last statutory comma—down to who gets the coffee filters," Katie declared. "The National Firearms Association up in Fairfax has given me an F grade on every scorecard since 2013 because I fight for universal background checks, red-flag laws, safe storage, and banning weapons of war, and I wear that F grade as a badge of honor right alongside the televangelists' outrage when I affirm my oath on the Constitution of the United States. I will use my vote in the Senate to demand the full, unredacted release of the federal child-trafficking files, and I don't care whose billionaire donors or political friends are named in them

—you abuse children, you're done, and no one is above the law. I will put Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility at the front door of my Senate office so Capitol Hill looks like the working people, transit riders, wheelchair users, and neurodivergent thinkers I was elected to serve. And before the delayed January fallout of the opposition's prior 'big beautiful bill' hits working families and they try to lie and blame us for their own law, you and I are going to build a live public receipts dashboard in PHP and ride local public transit to town halls across every corner of Virginia to show voters the exact roll-call votes and effective dates."

Dad smiled proudly, setting his coffee mug down on the counter. "Blinders on, elbows out?"

"Blinders on, elbows out, Dad," Katie grinned, squeezing my hand across our armrests. "Now let's look at the sixty-day transition calendar between today and January third—because we've got an orientation in Washington next week, a State Board of Elections certification on December seventh, a official Senate website vendor to audit, and a State Senate seat in Richmond I have to formally resign before we can board that five o'clock morning train to Alexandria."

Part 3: U.S. Senate New Member Orientation, Senator Tess Dunmore's Ramp, & Making the Vice President Swear Her In

Date: 2026-11-16 at 08:45 America/New_York

Monday, November 16, 2026, 8:45 AM — Rolling Past the Chartered VIP Motorcoach & Retiring Senator Martin Warren's Stare

"Hold the charter bus door—is Senator-Elect Prairie on this shuttle from the hotel?" a Senate Sergeant at Arms protocol officer called into his lapel radio outside the bronze doors of the Russell Senate Office Building on Monday morning as two black-and-silver Capitol Police escort vans idled at the curb along Constitution Avenue.

"Right behind you on the sidewalk, actually," Katie called out cheerfully as she and I steered our two compact black SwiftChair power wheelchairs down the concrete curb cut from First Street Southeast—right past the brown Capitol South station pylon striped with the Blue, Orange, and Silver lines—with our sixty-eight-year-old dad walking beside us carrying his leather briefcase.

The protocol officer spun around on the granite steps, blinking in disbelief as he looked from the chartered luxury motorcoach—where the other eleven members of the incoming freshman Senate class were stepping down the stairs in tailored overcoats—to the two forty-one-year-old twins who had just rolled up the public sidewalk from the Capitol South station elevator with CapitalPass transit cards tucked into their jacket pockets.

"You… you took the subway to New Member Orientation, Senator-Elect?" the officer stammered.

"The five o'clock morning ARTS train up from Norfolk, the mobile lift off the train at Alexandria so we could drop our suitcases with our cousins Brittany and Chelsea at our dad's house on Sunset Drive, the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge to L'Enfant Plaza, and the Blue Line two stops to

Capitol South," Katie smiled, holding up her blue plastic fare card before reaching across our armrests to squeeze my hand. "Why sit in downtown traffic on a charter bus when the train drops you off a block from the front door?"

Ten minutes later, when the three of us rolled through the tall double doors of the historic Kennedy Caucus Room on the third floor of the Russell Building—under the crystal chandeliers and towering Corinthian columns where the Senate Democratic Caucus was gathering for its post-election orientation breakfast—the hum of conversation near the coffee urns went noticeably quiet.

Standing near the center aisle with a saucer in his hand was retiring three-term United States Senator Martin Warren of Virginia, flanked by his departing chief of staff, Gregory, and two senior consultants from the Democratic Senatorial Campaign Committee.

Katie hadn't flipped a Republican seat in November; both of Virginia's United States Senate seats were already held by Democrats—Senior Senator Thomas Keane and retiring Senator Martin Warren. Back in the winter, when Senator Warren had announced he was retiring after eighteen years in Washington, he and the big-money K Street establishment had tried to stage a coronation. They had handpicked Preston Holloway—a polished McLean venture capitalist businessman with a contact list full of billionaire donors—to take over Warren's seat, pouring fourteen million dollars of Super PAC money into the June 16 Democratic primary while Gregory told the Washington newspapers that two autistic software developers in wheelchairs riding public transit buses were a "cute regional novelty" and a hopeless long shot who wouldn't break twenty percent statewide.

Instead, the voters of Virginia had blown their coronation to smithereens. Riding regular public buses across all ninety-five counties and thirty-eight independent cities without taking a dime of corporate PAC money, Katie had crushed Senator Warren's handpicked corporate stooge by eleven points in the June primary and then defeated Republican nominee Richard Sterling by nine points in the November general election—while across the rest of the map, Democrats had flipped seven Republican seats to capture a fifty-four-to-forty-six Senate majority for the incoming One Hundred Twentieth Congress.

And when the National Firearms Association—the massive gun lobby headquartered right up the road in Fairfax—had plastered television airwaves and mailboxes across the Commonwealth with glossy red-and-black attack mailers branding her *"F-Rated Radical Katie Prairie"* because she unapologetically called the MR-15 semiautomatic rifle a weapon of war and championed common-sense gun safety legislation, Katie had laughed out loud at our kitchen table, asked me to put their postcard in a black wooden frame on our transition office wall, and worn that F grade from the National Firearms Association on every debate stage like a badge of honor. She had never once hedged or hidden who she was: she ran unabashedly for universal healthcare so no family would ever face bankruptcy over a spinal cord injury or a chronic illness, she stood up fiercely for transgender rights and bodily autonomy against Restore the Republic smear campaigns claiming she wanted "men in women's sports and men in women's restrooms," and whenever anyone asked her about reproductive freedom, she looked straight into the camera and said in plain, unmistakable words that abortion was a private medical decision between a woman and her doctor—and that no politician, judge, or bureaucrat in Washington belonged in that exam room.

Before Senator Warren or his red-faced chief of staff could decide whether to look at the ceiling or walk over, our other Senator from Virginia, Thomas Keane, broke away from the front table with a wide, genuine grin and walked straight down the carpet to meet our wheelchairs.

“Make way for my new partner from the Commonwealth of Virginia!” Senator Keane beamed, shaking Katie’s hand warmly before shaking mine and Dad’s. “Katie, Nate, David—welcome to the United States Senate. Did you see the final certified turnout numbers out of Hampton Roads, the Shenandoah Valley, and Montgomery County? You two put together the biggest grassroots margin in Virginia in twelve years.”

A half-beat later, retiring Senator Martin Warren stepped over, clearing his throat as he offered Katie a stiff, polite handshake while Gregory stared fixedly at the carpet behind him.

“Congratulations on a well-run campaign, Katie,” Senator Warren said, trying to sound magnanimous. “My staff and I have prepared a transition binder of our donor and stakeholder contacts so your office can maintain continuity—”

“Thank you, Senator Warren, that won’t be necessary,” Katie said politely, her blue eyes calm and crystal clear as she looked up from her SwiftChair. “The transit riders, shipyard welders, teachers, and disabled Virginians who nominated me in June and elected me in November already gave my brother and me all the stakeholder contacts we need. Enjoy your retirement.”

Beside me, Dad had to disguise a grin behind a cough as Gregory’s ears turned crimson and Senator Warren nodded stiffly before retreating toward the buffet table.

Moments later, as Senate Democratic Leader Charles Schuman of New York called the new Democratic Senators-Elect together at the center of the ornate Oriental rug for the official freshman class photograph, another wheelchair rolled smoothly out of the circle of tailored suits to meet us.

Sitting in an ultralight black ApexLite manual wheelchair—dressed in a navy suit, white shirt, red tie, and brown dress shoes, with a neatly trimmed beard and the powerful shoulders of an athlete—was forty-seven-year-old Senator-Elect Joshua “Josh” Novak of Iowa. Born with spina bifida, Josh was a two-time Paralympic gold medalist in wheelchair basketball and a former Iowa State Representative from Council Bluffs who had just stunned the national pundits on Tuesday night by flipping Iowa’s open Republican Senate seat after scaling thousands of steep front-porch steps on his hands and backside to knock on doors across all ninety-nine Iowa counties.

“Senator-Elect Prairie—and you must be Nate and David,” Josh beamed, braking his manual chair beside our two motorized SwiftChairs and shaking hands with all three of us. “I’ve been watching your bus campaign across Virginia all autumn from out in Iowa. Do you realize the two of us just made Senate history before we even got sworn in? Not only are there two wheelchair users in the incoming Democratic freshman class at the exact same time, we’re about to triple the Senate’s wheelchair caucus!”

“From coastal city buses in Virginia to front porches in Iowa,” Katie grinned back at him as we positioned our chairs side by side at the front center of the incoming Democratic class for the photograph.

Monday, November 16, 2026, 11:15 AM — Senator Tess Dunmore of Illinois, Senator-Elect Josh Novak of Iowa, & Why the Senate Ramp Is Already Waiting

At quarter past eleven, while the lame-duck One Hundred Nineteenth Senate stood in morning recess, the Deputy Sergeant at Arms and two preservation architects from the Office of the Architect of the Capitol met Katie, Josh Novak, and me outside the double doors of the United States Senate Chamber on the second floor of the Capitol.

Out of pure habit from fifteen years in Virginia politics, both Katie and I had arrived ready for an architectural battle. In 2010, after Katie won her seat on the Virginia Beach City Council, we had had to fight city facilities managers to modify the Municipal Center dais. In January 2014, when Katie arrived in the Virginia House of Delegates, I had sat beside her with a twenty-five-foot steel tape measure forcing Capitol Facilities to fix non-compliant fifty-one-inch restroom stalls. And in December 2019, when she was elected to the Senate of Virginia, the master woodworkers in Richmond had had to build the chamber’s very first custom-milled mahogany wheelchair ramp from scratch because no wheelchair user had ever served in the upper house of the General Assembly.

As the brass-handled doors of the United States Senate Chamber swung open onto the blue carpet, however, a familiar voice called out from the center aisle:

“Put the steel tape measure away, Nate—none of you have to fight the building engineers from scratch this time!”

Rolling briskly up the blue carpet toward us in a sleek, ultralight black titanium wheelchair was forty-eight-year-old Senator Teresa “Tess” Dunmore of Illinois—the decorated former Army helicopter pilot who had lost both of her legs when her aircraft was hit by a rocket-propelled grenade in Iraq in 2004, and who had served in the United States Senate since January of 2017.

Katie’s face lit up in an instant as Senator Dunmore braked her titanium chair right in front of our two motorized SwiftChairs and Josh’s manual ApexLite chair, reaching out to clasp Katie’s hand, Josh’s hand, and mine.

“Senator Dunmore,” Katie said warmly.

“It’s Tess—we’re colleagues now, Katie, Josh,” Senator Dunmore grinned, looking back and forth across our wheelchairs with fierce camaraderie. “Do you have any idea how long I’ve been waiting for reinforcements on wheels in this chamber? For the last ten years I’ve been a one-woman wheelchair caucus on our side of the aisle. Now, with Virginia and Iowa showing up in the same freshman class, we’ve got a full fleet!”

For a full two seconds, neither Katie nor I spoke. Looking down the semicircular tiers of the one hundred historic mahogany Senate desks toward the marble rostrum at the front of the chamber, I realized that for the very first time in my sister’s public life, she wasn’t the only wheelchair user in the room—in fact, between Tess

Dunmore, Josh Novak, and Katie, three of the fifty-four Democratic Senators in the One Hundred Twentieth Congress would be rolling onto the Senate floor in wheelchairs.

“Come on down the aisle—let me show you both what we already built, and what the cabinetmakers are customizing for each of your desks before January third,” Tess said, wheeling alongside Katie, Josh, and me down the Democratic side of the chamber.

At the base of the front tiers, Tess pointed to the permanent, flush-mounted carpeted wheelchair ramp leading smoothly down into the well of the Senate, and then to the custom platform lift and ramp integrated into the white marble steps of the Presiding Officer’s rostrum.

“When I got sworn in back in 2017—following in the tire tracks of veterans like Dan Inouye, Bob Dole, and Max Cleland—we made sure the well of the Senate and the Presiding Officer’s rostrum were permanently accessible under the Congressional Accountability Act,” Tess explained. “What the Senate cabinetmakers had to figure out this week is the difference between manual titanium frames like mine and Josh’s and your two motorized SwiftChairs.”

She led us to the back-row aisle desks on the outer curve of the Democratic side, where two master Senate carpenters were kneeling with brass calipers and blocks of seasoned Honduras mahogany.

“Because the hundred desks on the Senate floor date back to 1819 and have bolted-down swivel chairs,” I noted, leaning over my left armrest to inspect the joinery, “for Senator-Elect Novak’s desk two aisles over—just like Senator Dunmore’s desk—unbolting the fixed chair pedestal gives his manual wheelchair plenty of clearance. And on Katie’s desk here, they unbolted the chair pedestal and milled one-and-a-half-inch solid mahogany riser blocks under the bottom of the desk legs so the upright joystick controller on Katie’s right armrest glides all the way under the writing surface without bumping the drawer apron.”

“You nailed it on the first look, Nate,” the lead carpenter smiled, standing up as Katie nudged her right thumb forward on her joystick and rolled her SwiftChair effortlessly beneath the historic mahogany desktop, testing the clearance with an inch and a half to spare. “And right behind Senator Prairie’s desk along the back leather staff bench, we’ve widened the staff bay by thirty-eight inches. Since Mr. Prairie holds permanent Chief Data Strategist floor privileges under your office allotment, his SwiftChair can park right behind the Senator’s left shoulder during floor debate without blocking the chamber door. We’re making the exact same dual-powerchair modification to the witness and staff bays in Dirksen Room 124 for the Appropriations Committee.”

Then Tess Dunmore gestured toward the high white marble rostrum at the front of the chamber, a wicked gleam in her dark eyes.

“Now come up the rostrum ramp with me for thirty seconds, Katie,” Tess said. “There’s one more perk of our new fifty-four-seat Democratic majority you need to test-drive before the Vice President shows up this afternoon.”

Katie and I followed Tess up the accessible rostrum ramp to the highest tier of the Senate dais, right behind the Presiding Officer's carved marble desk and the heavy ivory gavel block.

"Under Senate custom," Tess said, patting the leather arm of the Presiding Officer's space, "the Vice President of the United States almost never sits in this chair except on Opening Day or when the Senate is tied fifty-fifty. Instead, the freshman Senators of the majority party rotate in one-hour shifts every legislative day to preside over the Senate as Acting President pro tempore. And do you know what every single Senator on the floor—Democrat or Republican—is required by Senate Rule XIX to call you when you are sitting at this desk with that ivory gavel in your hand?"

Katie looked out across the hundred mahogany desks below us, a slow, electric smile spreading across her face.

"Madam President," Katie said softly.

"Madam President," Tess laughed aloud. "Every single Republican who cheered when Garrett Thorne stood on the South Lawn calling you 'Broken Katie Prairie' and 'a bitter little cripple on wheels' is going to have to stand at attention at their desk, look up at your SwiftChair at this rostrum, and say, *'Madam President, will the Chair recognize the Senator?'* before they're even allowed to speak!"

Tuesday, November 17, 2026, 2:00 PM — The Dirksen Room 511 Suite Lottery & Committee Assignments

On Tuesday afternoon, the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms convened the Freshman Office Suite Lottery in the Capitol Visitor Center congressional meeting rooms.

Under the rules of the United States Senate, newly elected Senators taking office on the same day are ranked in freshman seniority by prior federal service, prior service as a state governor, and then by the population of their state in the decennial census paired with prior state legislative service. With Virginia's population of nearly nine million people and Katie's twelve combined years in the Virginia House of Delegates and the Senate of Virginia, Katie drew the second pick in the entire twelve-member freshman class.

While the other incoming Senators fought over the high-ceilinged, chandeliered corner suites in the 1909 Russell Senate Office Building, Katie and I didn't even look at the Russell list. We had already audited the Sergeant at Arms CAD floor plans on my MagnaBook Pro the night before.

"Russell was built in 1909 with heavy brass-sill double doors, narrow interior staff hallways, and long detours to the accessible elevators," I said, pointing to our annotated blueprint as the Superintendent of the Senate Office Buildings leaned over our table. "Look at the fifth floor of the Dirksen Senate Office Building—specifically Suite 511."

"Dirksen Room 511 has forty-eight-inch interior doorways, flush marble-to-carpet thresholds, a wide reception corridor where two SwiftChairs can roll side by side in lockstep without turning sideways, and a private Senator's office large enough to place two custom-height mahogany desks side by side so Nate's workstation sits two feet from my left armrest," Katie told the Superintendent. "Plus, the elevator bank

right outside Room 511 drops straight down to the first-floor Appropriations Subcommittee hearing rooms in Dirksen 124 and 138 and the subterranean subway to the Capitol. We'll take Dirksen Room 511."

An hour later, when the Democratic Steering and Outreach Committee met with Katie and Senior Senator Thomas Keane to finalize committee slates for the One Hundred Twentieth Congress, the leadership didn't repeat Senator Martin Warren's mistake of underestimating her. With Naval Station Norfolk, Newport News Shipbuilding, and the Port of Virginia anchoring her home base—and Appropriations Chairman Arthur Harrington personally requesting her on his committee—Katie rolled out of the Steering meeting with three powerhouse assignments: the Senate Committee on Appropriations (including seats on the Labor, Health and Human Services, Education, and Related Agencies Subcommittee and the Transportation, Housing and Urban Development Subcommittee), the Senate Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs (which held one hundred percent Senate jurisdiction over the Federal Transit Administration and every public transit system in America), and the Senate Committee on Commerce, Science, and Transportation.

Because Katie had defeated retiring Senator Martin Warren's handpicked corporate successor in the June primary rather than inheriting a party machine, we weren't taking over a pre-packaged staff operation—we were building Senator Katie Prairie's personal office from the ground up. Following the model Senior Senator Thomas Keane used across the Commonwealth, Katie and I structured her incoming operation into two coordinated halves: a Washington legislative, administrative, scheduling, and communications staff in Dirksen Room 511, and a Virginia constituent-services operation staffed by caseworkers and geographically assigned regional directors across Hampton Roads, Richmond, the Shenandoah and New River Valleys, Northern Virginia, and a dedicated Southside and Eastern Shore Regional Director.

And before our transition team opened a single resume from Capitol Hill, Katie wrote three names at the very top of her Washington staffing chart:

"Sam, Mandy, and Sarah are coming with me."

In the United States Senate, unlike the Senate Page Program—where sixteen- and seventeen-year-old Pages are sponsored by Senators and employed by the Sergeant at Arms—every Senator's personal office is an independent equal-opportunity employer that sets its own positions, responsibilities, and professional salaries. At twenty-four years old, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah weren't children anymore, and Katie would never insult their intelligence or their autism by treating them as office mascots or handing them three generic, interchangeable make-work titles. Because Katie and I were autistic ourselves, we understood something that neurotypical managers almost always got backward: for Sam, Mandy, and Sarah, successful adulthood meant interdependence, not forced separation. They didn't need to be chained within a six-foot radius of one another every minute of the afternoon if Sam had to walk downstairs to a committee hearing room while Mandy stayed on a constituent phone call, yet they regulated and felt secure knowing they were based together in Dirksen Room 511, had workstations near one another, commuted together on Capital Transit, ate lunch together whenever they wanted, and would never have a supervisor arbitrarily split them across different cities to "teach them a lesson."

Even more importantly, during their years working for Katie in Richmond while earning their degrees at Central Virginia University, the three triplets had developed completely distinct professional strengths—inseparable as people, not interchangeable as professionals:

For twenty-four-year-old Sam Hawkins—who had turned into an unapologetic policy gremlin capable of happily reading a three-hundred-and-twelve-page Federal Transit Administration authorization bill at eleven o'clock at night—Katie created a full-time position as Legislative Correspondent covering Transportation, Infrastructure, Disability and Accessibility Policy, and Rural Development at a starting salary of sixty-two thousand dollars, bringing him full circle from the thirteen-year-old eighth-grade Page who had carried paper bills around the Virginia House floor in 2016 to a congressional staffer drafting federal transit legislation for a United States Senator.

For twenty-four-year-old Mandy Hawkins—who had discovered in Richmond that she loved the human-facing detective work of helping everyday Virginians who were stuck inside federal and state bureaucracies—Katie offered a sixty-six-thousand-dollar position as Constituent Services Representative and Federal Caseworker, designing a crystal-clear, predictable six-step casework protocol that suited Mandy's methodical mind down to the last checkbox: case received, Privacy Act consent paperwork, federal agency liaison contact, scheduled follow-up, constituent update, and resolution and closure.

And for twenty-four-year-old Sarah Hawkins—who had started at the front reception console handling phone lines, Capitol tour requests, visitor greeting, and mail triage before revealing a razor-sharp talent for digital accessibility and social-media graphics—Katie offered a fifty-eight-thousand-dollar position as Staff Assistant and Digital Accessibility Correspondent on a direct track into her press and legislative communications operation alongside me.

When Katie called the triplets from our transition room that Tuesday afternoon to offer all three of them the jobs in Washington, there was a ten-second stunned silence on the line before Mandy said earnestly, "Senator Katie, we want to come with you more than anything—we just told Uncle Richard and Aunt Marge we would talk to them first before we signed anything."

As Sam told us laughing the next morning, when the three of them walked into the kitchen in Danville that evening and said, *"Uncle Richard, Katie offered us jobs in Washington,"* their sixty-six-year-old uncle set his teacup down on the counter and looked at all three of them.

"All three of you?" Richard asked.

"All three," Sam told him, listing their three distinct positions and salaries in Dirksen Room 511.

"Well, of course she does," Richard said warmly. *"What did you tell her?"*

Mandy blinked. *"We said we needed to talk to you and Aunt Marge first."*

Richard stared at his twenty-four-year-old nephew and nieces for three full seconds.

"You're twenty-four years old," the former House Majority Leader said softly. *"Go call your senator."*

Because Uncle Richard was their maternal uncle—their mother's brother—and the triplets carried the surname Hawkins rather than Callaway, the Washington reporters scanning Senator-Elect Prairie's initial federal transition payroll filings for Sam Hawkins, Amanda Hawkins, and Sarah Hawkins didn't immediately realize who the three twenty-four-year-old hires from Danville were related to. Forty-eight hours later, however, when a veteran Capitol beat reporter at the Richmond newspaper recognized the three names from their years in the General Assembly and cross-referenced the filing, the headline ricocheted across every newsroom in the Commonwealth: *FORMER VIRGINIA GOP MAJORITY LEADER RICHARD CALLAWAY ENCOURAGES NEPHEW AND NIECES TO JOIN DEMOCRATIC SENATOR'S WASHINGTON STAFF.*

By noon, television cameras were back in Uncle Richard's front yard in Southside Virginia.

"Leader Callaway," a reporter asked, holding a microphone over the porch railing, "does it bother you that your nephew and nieces will be working in Washington for a Democratic United States Senator?"

"Which Democrat?" Uncle Richard asked dryly.

"Senator-Elect Prairie."

"Katie? Lord, no," Richard chuckled, before his expression grew steady and serious. "I spent twenty-four years in the House of Delegates. I know that a newly elected United States Senator doesn't have unlimited payroll slots to hand out as sentimental favors, I know something about legislative offices, and I know something about Katie Prairie. Eleven years ago, when Sam, Mandy, and Sarah were thirteen years old and had only been living safely with Marge and me for a year, I sent them up to Richmond as House Pages worrying about them every single hour of the day—and Katie Prairie and her brother Nate looked after those kids when nobody asked them to. So when those three came home on Tuesday night and told Marge and me that Katie wanted them on her United States Senate staff, I told them to take the jobs. They're adults. They're not Republicans because I'm a Republican, and they don't owe my political party anything. But if you're asking whether I'm comfortable with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah working for Katie Prairie? I couldn't tell you another Senator in America I'd trust more with those three."

Right beside the local reporters, a correspondent holding a Liberty First Network microphone pushed forward, repeating the talking point that Restore the Republic commentators had been screaming all morning:

"Mr. Majority Leader, Restore the Republic state chapters are calling you 'RINO Richard' and 'an Enemy of the Republic,' and they're asking how a lifelong conservative could be sending his own autistic nephew and nieces to Washington after they were manipulated by 'Broken Katie Prairie'!"

At the word *RINO*, Uncle Richard let out a short, dry laugh.

"Twenty-four years in the Virginia House of Delegates. Republican Majority Leader. And now I'm apparently a Republican In Name Only," Richard said wryly. "That's an awfully long time to maintain the disguise."

Then his smile vanished, and the iron voice that had commanded the floor of the Virginia House for a decade rolled across his front porch as he locked eyes with the Liberty First Network correspondent.

“Sending them?” Uncle Richard said, his voice dropping an octave as every trace of diplomacy disappeared. “Let me get something straight right now. My nephew and nieces are twenty-four years old. Katie Prairie offered them jobs in the United States Senate. They wanted those jobs. They asked Marge and me what we thought, and I told them to take the jobs. Nobody stole my kids. Nobody brainwashed my kids. Nobody sent my kids anywhere.”

He took one step closer to the porch railing, pointing a finger squarely at the Liberty First Network mic flag.

“And as for this ‘Broken Katie Prairie’ garbage?” Uncle Richard unloaded, his voice ringing like a gavel strike across the quiet Southside street. “Let me tell you something about your ‘Broken Katie Prairie.’ I knew Katie when my three kids were practically children. When my nephew and nieces were thirteen years old, that woman recognized when they were overwhelmed before half the adults in the Capitol did. She gave them instructions they could understand. She protected them when the House got too loud. She treated them with patience and dignity, and she never once screamed at my kids. If that’s what Restore the Republic calls broken, then perhaps somebody ought to take a long look at what Restore the Republic calls whole. And if you think autism makes Katie Prairie broken, you’re also talking about my nephew and my nieces—so choose your next words very carefully. You people didn’t inherit my Republican Party merely because you inherited its name. If my party thinks three adults taking good jobs working for the Commonwealth is a scandal, my party knows where to find me.”

That night—as Aunt Marge told Katie over the phone while laughing so hard she could barely catch her breath—Uncle Richard sat back in his recliner watching the eleven o’clock news replay his interview, rubbed his forehead, and muttered:

“Twenty-four years as a Republican in the House of Delegates. Republican Majority Leader. And somehow all three of my kids wound up working for the Democratic Senator from Virginia Beach.”

“You introduced them to Richmond,” Marge reminded him sweetly from the sofa.

Richard let out a long sigh. *“…I suppose this is my fault.”*

Wednesday, November 18, 2026, 4:30 PM — Face-to-Face With Vice President Conrad Drayton in the President’s Room

The final event of New Member Orientation took place at four-thirty on Wednesday afternoon inside Room S-216 of the United States Capitol—the ornate, frescoed President’s Room just off the Senate lobby—where Vice President Conrad Drayton, in his constitutional capacity as President of the Senate, was hosting the traditional ceremonial welcome reception for the Senators-Elect and their families.

To say that Katie hated Vice President Conrad Drayton—and his boss in the Oval Office, President Garrett Thorne—would have been an understatement.

For the past nine months, ever since it became clear that Katie was going to win the Virginia Senate seat, President Thorne had used every rally stage and South Lawn helicopter gaggle to mock my twin sister's disability—calling her *"Broken Katie Prairie,"* mimicking the way her hands rested on her wheelchair joystick, and jeering that *"a forty-one-year-old spinster on wheels who still lives with her crippled twin brother and rides city buses has no stamina for the United States Senate."* And Vice President Conrad Drayton had been even slimier: going on *Patriot Watch* on the Liberty First Network five nights a week to sneer with smug, sanctimonious condescension that because Katie and I were unmarried, childless, secular twins who relied on each other—ignoring the loving five-person household we shared every single day with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea—instead of a "traditional nuclear marriage," we had *"no moral or spiritual stake in the future of the American family."*

Now, beneath the gilded Renaissance-revival ceiling frescoes and crystal chandelier of the President's Room, Conrad Drayton stood in a charcoal suit with a forced, oily television smile plastered across his face, shaking hands with the incoming Senators one by one in front of the official Senate photographer.

When Katie and I rolled our two compact SwiftChairs side by side through the arched doorway with Dad walking right behind us, the chatter in the small room dropped to a hush.

"Well, well—look who made it all the way up from Virginia Beach," Vice President Drayton said smoothly, stepping across the patterned tile floor toward Katie's wheelchair with his right hand extended and his left hand reaching out automatically toward the rear push-handle bar behind her headrest to angle her chair toward the camera lens. "President Thorne and I were taking bets on whether you'd actually roll all the way up Interstate 95, Senator-Elect Prairie."

Katie nudged her joystick half an inch in reverse and pivoted twenty degrees to the left—just enough that Conrad Drayton's left hand closed on empty air six inches from her chair.

"First of all, Mr. Vice President, nobody touches my wheelchair or my brother's wheelchair without our permission," Katie said, her voice calm, crisp, and loud enough that every Senator-Elect in the room heard every syllable. "Second, we didn't drive up Interstate 95—we took the morning train from Norfolk and rode the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the river, which you'd know if anyone in your administration ever set foot on public transportation."

Conrad Drayton's jaw tightened, a flash of ugly crimson rising above his starched white collar as he pulled his hand back.

"I'm sure you'll find Washington very different from the Virginia Beach bus stops, Senator-Elect," Drayton said coldly, trying to recover his smirk in front of the photographer. "Enjoy the reception—I'll see you on January third when I administer the oath. I assume my protocol clerk can put you down for the standard King James Bible?"

Katie didn't flinch. Sitting tall in her royal-blue blazer between Dad and me, she looked straight up into the eyes of the man she despised and smiled—a bright, razor-sharp smile of pure constitutional triumph.

“Actually, Mr. Vice President, my transition counsel filed my formal oath notice with the Secretary of the Senate and your protocol office at nine o’clock this morning,” Katie said pleasantly. “Pursuant to Article VI, Clause 3 of the Constitution of the United States and Title 5, Section 3331 of the United States Code, I am not using a Bible, and I am not saying the words ‘So help me God.’ I am taking the solemn secular affirmation of office—*‘Do you solemnly affirm’*—with my left hand resting on a bound copy of the Constitution of the United States of America.”

For a full second, the polished television mask slipped right off Conrad Drayton’s face, replaced by a look of pure, seething hatred.

More than anything else, Drayton hated that she was swearing in on the Constitution of the United States. His entire political brand on the Liberty First Network depended on wrapping himself in sanctimonious religious theater and accusing anyone who disagreed with him of hating America—and by placing her left palm squarely on the United States Constitution under Article VI, Clause 3 while forcing him, as President of the Senate, to read the secular affirmation card aloud without “So help me God,” Katie was turning him into an involuntary participant in her secular oath in front of every camera in the country.

“You really think thumbing your nose at the Holy Bible is going to play well outside your little progressive bubble, Senator-Elect?” Drayton hissed, his voice dropping low and venomous. “Between refusing to touch a Bible, getting an F grade from the National Firearms Association down in Fairfax for calling the MR-15 a weapon of war, pushing government universal healthcare, wanting men in women’s sports and men in women’s restrooms, and pushing unrestricted abortion, you’re going to have every church and gun owner in the country marching outside your office.”

“Oh, I’m counting on it—in fact, I wear every single bit of their outrage, and that F grade from the National Firearms Association, as a badge of honor,” Katie replied without missing a beat, her voice ringing clear and unbothered across the room. “An MR-15 is a weapon of war designed for a battlefield, not a civilian neighborhood, and if calling an MR-15 a weapon of war and passing common-sense gun safety legislation—universal background checks, red-flag laws, safe storage, and keeping weapons of war out of Virginia classrooms and grocery stores so children come home alive from school—is why the gun lobby in Fairfax gave me an F, then I’ll frame that F and hang it right on the door of Dirksen Room 511. Healthcare should be a universal human right for every person in this country, transgender Americans deserve the exact same dignity and bodily autonomy as everyone else without your Restore the Republic talking points bullying kids or trying to station government bathroom police outside public restrooms like your party tried and failed to do in Virginia back in 2016, and abortion is a private medical decision between a woman and her doctor—where neither you, nor President Thorne, nor any senator belongs in the exam room.”

She tilted her chin up from her SwiftChair, her blue eyes gleaming as she delivered the final twist of the knife.

“And every time the televangelists at *The 777 Circle* down on Indian River Road in Virginia Beach tried to attack me in 2014 and 2020 for affirming my oath on the Constitution instead of a Bible, we won re-election by an even bigger margin,

because ordinary voters understand that a Senator is elected to defend the Constitution, not run a church," Katie said. "Do you know what the very best part of winning this election is, Mr. Vice President?"

Katie leaned an inch forward in her SwiftChair, her voice dropping to a clear, surgical purr that made three neighboring Senators-Elect bite the insides of their cheeks to keep from laughing aloud.

"For the last nine months, your boss has gone on television calling me 'Broken Katie Prairie,' and for the last two weeks since Election Night he's been screaming on cable news that a woman in a wheelchair couldn't possibly have won by three hundred and sixty thousand votes without 'stealing the vote'—ignoring the sixteen years I've served on the Virginia Beach City Council, in the Virginia House of Delegates, and in the Senate of Virginia, and ignoring the paper ballots that the State Board of Elections and your own party's city and county registrars already verified," Katie said. "And yet at twelve o'clock noon on Sunday, January third, Article I, Section 3, Clause 4 of the Constitution of the United States gives you zero choice. You have to stand right in front of my wheelchair in the Old Senate Chamber, hold the card with the secular affirmation printed on it, leave 'So help me God' out of your mouth, and personally swear 'Broken Katie Prairie' into the United States Senate while my hand rests on the Constitution. I've had January third circled on my calendar since Election Night, Mr. Vice President. See you at noon."

Nudging her joystick in tandem with mine, Katie didn't even wait for his reply. We spun our two SwiftChairs one hundred and eighty degrees in unison on the tiled floor of the President's Room and rolled side by side out into the marble Senate corridor with Dad grinning from ear to ear behind us, leaving the Vice President of the United States standing frozen under the chandelier.

Part 4: Opposing Leader Schuman, The 211–204 Lame-Duck False Dawn in the Dirksen Basement, & Home Across the Fenwick Bridge

Date: 2026-12-01 at 10:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 1, 2026, 10:30 AM — Objecting to Unanimous Acclamation & Publicly Opposing Senator Charles Schuman for Majority Leader

"Without objection, the Secretary of the Caucus will cast a single unanimous ballot by acclamation electing Senator Charles Schuman of New York as Majority Leader for the One Hundred Twentieth Congress—"

"Madam Chair, I object to unanimous acclamation and request a recorded ballot."

Every single fountain pen and coffee cup inside the closed mahogany doors of the Mansfield Room froze in midair.

Along the back aisle of the gilded caucus room—where the Sergeant at Arms had cleared a dual wheelchair bay beside Senator Tess Dunmore of Illinois and Senator-Elect Josh Novak of Iowa so my SwiftChair could park right alongside Katie's left wheel under her permanent sensory-and-mobility accommodation—fifty-three sitting and incoming Democratic Senators turned in their chairs at the exact same instant to stare at my forty-one-year-old twin sister.

Up at the front head table beneath the crystal chandelier, seventy-six-year-old Senator Charles Schuman of New York blinked over the rims of his half-moon reading glasses, his smile stiffening in disbelief. Having led the Senate Democratic Caucus and controlled its campaign checkbook for two decades, Senator Schuman had walked into the first Tuesday caucus meeting after the Thanksgiving break expecting a ninety-second coronation by applause.

“Does the Senator-Elect from Virginia wish to be heard before the clerks distribute paper ballots?” the Caucus Secretary asked carefully.

“Briefly, Madam Chair,” Katie said, keeping her hands resting calmly on the armrests of her compact SwiftChair as she looked straight up the center aisle at Senator Schuman without a trace of hostility or nerves. “Two weeks ago across the Capitol Rotunda, our colleagues in the House Democratic Caucus met a historic midterm mandate by electing fresh generational leadership in Speaker-Designate Clara Morales. My brother and I spent the last ten months riding public buses across all ninety-five counties and thirty-eight independent cities of Virginia, and the working people who delivered us a fifty-four-seat Senate majority didn’t send us here to run the exact same K Street consultant playbook for another decade. Nothing in this vote is personal toward Senator Schuman, and I intend to work shoulder to shoulder with every member of this caucus to pass our legislative calendar. However, new generational leadership is overdue in both Houses of Congress—and after the Democratic Senatorial Campaign Committee spent fourteen million dollars of Super PAC and corporate lobbyist money trying to defeat our grassroots campaign in Virginia’s June primary, nobody back home in Hampton Roads, Richmond, or Southwest Virginia sent me to Washington to rubber-stamp party leadership by voice acclamation.”

Beside Katie’s right wheel, Josh Novak gave a quiet, approving nod from his ultralight manual ApexLite chair, while two rows ahead of us, Senior Senator Thomas Keane of Virginia folded his arms with the faint, unmistakable trace of a proud half-smile.

Fifteen minutes later, after the caucus clerks collected the folded paper slips in a mahogany ballot box and tallied the count at the front table, the entrenched seniority machine held—but the myth of unanimous obedience did not. Senator Charles Schuman was re-elected incoming Senate Majority Leader by a vote of forty-three to eleven, with Katie, Josh Novak, and nine other reform-minded Senators casting their ballots for generational change.

Under the unwritten traditions of Capitol Hill, nine of those eleven dissenting Senators slipped quietly out the side corridor afterward, content to let their protest stay sealed behind closed caucus doors.

Katie didn’t do unwritten Washington traditions.

When the tall double doors of the Mansfield Room swung open onto the second-floor marble Senate corridor, forty boom microphones and television camera lenses surged forward against the velvet stanchion rope. Instead of wheeling past the press gaggle, Katie steered her SwiftChair right up to the brass microphone stand with me braking beside her left armrest.

“Senator-Elect Prairie!” a correspondent from *The Potomac Post* called out over the shutter clicks. “Word just came out of the room that someone objected to electing Leader Schuman by voice acclamation and forced a ballot—was that you, and how did you vote?”

“Yes, I objected to unanimous acclamation, and I voted No on Senator Schuman for Majority Leader,” Katie answered plainly into the microphones, her blue eyes steady and completely unbothered. “Voters across Virginia and across the country just asked for a new generation of leadership in both chambers of Congress, just as House Democrats recognized when they elevated Speaker-Designate Clara Morales. Senator Schuman won the caucus vote fairly, forty-three to eleven, and we’re going to work together to govern and protect working families starting at noon on January third. At the same time, Virginians deserve to know how their Senator votes in every room—not just when the television cameras are turned on—and the K Street donor apparatus that spent fourteen million dollars against us in June doesn’t own my voice in December.”

“Aren’t you worried about retaliation on your freshman committee assignments before you’re even sworn in?” an *Associated Wire* reporter shouted from the second row.

Before Katie even needed to answer, the double doors behind us parted again, and Appropriations Chairman Arthur Harrington walked straight up behind Katie’s right shoulder alongside Virginia’s Senior Senator, Thomas Keane.

“Senator-Elect Prairie’s seats on Appropriations, Banking, and Commerce are locked in solid granite,” Chairman Harrington rumbled dryly into the microphones, resting a brief, collegial hand on Senator Keane’s arm rather than touching Katie’s wheelchair. “In fact, half the voters in my state wish they’d thought of forcing a recorded vote first. Excuse us, folks—we have a transition budget to write.”

As Katie and I pivoted our SwiftChairs away from the stunned press pack toward the Capitol subway elevator, Senator Schuman himself emerged into the hallway twenty feet behind us—catching Katie’s eye over the heads of his aides with the sober, newly careful expression of a Majority Leader who had just learned on Day Zero that the incoming junior Senator from Virginia could neither be bought nor intimidated.

Tuesday, December 1, 2026, 2:15 PM — Basement Cubicle SD-B14, The 211–204 Motion to Refer, & The Pentagon’s Premature Victory Lap

Down in Room SD-B14 in the windowless basement level of the Dirksen Senate Office Building that afternoon, the overhead fluorescent tubes hummed softly above painted off-white cinderblock walls, six unpacked brown cardboard boxes of *Riddick’s Senate Procedure*, and two dented gray metal government desks borrowed from Sergeant at Arms surplus.

Outside Washington, most people assumed that the morning after you won a United States Senate election, somebody handed you the keys to a sunlit marble suite overlooking the Capitol dome. In reality, because the One Hundred Nineteenth Congress remained in constitutional session until twelve o’clock noon on January third—and retiring Senator Martin Warren’s staff was still occupying Dirksen Room 511 five floors above our heads while packing up eighteen years of files—every

newly elected Senator without prior Capitol office space spent November and December crammed into a basement transition “swing suite” barely wide enough for our two compact SwiftChairs to turn around beside the filing cabinets.

Not a single oil painting hung on our cinderblock walls. The only decoration in the entire room sat leaning against the concrete block at the back corner of Katie’s borrowed metal desk: the glossy red-and-black attack postcard from the National Firearms Association in Fairfax branding her *“F-Rated Radical Katie Prairie,”* sealed inside the ten-dollar black wooden frame we had brought up from Virginia Beach. Across the narrow aisle, twenty-four-year-old triplets Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins sat shoulder to shoulder at a folding laminate table sorting stacks of Virginia regional caseworker resumes from Hampton Roads, Roanoke, and the Shenandoah Valley alongside blank federal SF-86 background-investigation packets.

Up on the cinderblock wall ahead of Katie’s desk and mine, we had the forty-inch Capitol Network monitor switched on with the volume muted and closed captions scrolling across the bottom as the electronic voting clock above the House press gallery counted down to zero.

Less than twenty-four hours earlier, on Monday afternoon, an outgoing Republican congressman from Kentucky’s Ohio River valley named Thomas Mayfield—a fiercely independent constitutional stickler who had broken with President Garrett Thorne over unauthorized overseas military strikes and congressional war powers, only to lose his spring Republican primary to a challenger personally bankrolled by Thorne’s political machine and cheered on by Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson—had walked onto the House floor and shocked leadership in both parties by reading a privileged eight-article impeachment resolution against Secretary Halverson.

Under the rules of the House of Representatives, a privileged impeachment resolution called up from the floor forced leadership to act within two legislative days. Rather than risking an up-or-down vote on the merits of Halverson’s conduct, lame-duck House Speaker Paul Jennings of Louisiana—who had gone before the morning cameras dismissing Mayfield’s eight articles as a “political gambit for attention”—had pulled the only procedural emergency brake left in the rulebook: moving immediately to refer the entire impeachment resolution to the outgoing House Judiciary Committee, where the lame-duck chairman could lock it inside a desk drawer until the One Hundred Nineteenth Congress expired at noon on January third.

Katie reached her left hand across the two-inch gap between our SwiftChair armrests and laced her fingers through mine as the presiding officer’s gavel fell on the screen.

On the left half of the split-screen broadcast, the green and red numbers locked into place on the chamber tally board: 211 Yeas to 204 Nays.

“Seven votes,” Sam Hawkins murmured from the folding table behind us, adjusting his glasses as I refreshed the Clerk of the House roll-call XML feed on the unbranded matte-aluminum screen of my MagnaBook Pro. “Eighteen members missed the roll call—eleven Democrats, including a representative whose shuttle got trapped behind a Capitol Police bus escort on Independence Avenue right as the gavel came down, and seven lame-duck Republicans who didn’t want their names

anywhere near either column. Every single Democrat on the floor voted Nay against burying the articles, and Representative Mayfield crossed the aisle as the lone Republican Nay."

"Look at the floor podium replay from ten minutes before the roll opened," Sarah Hawkins said quietly, pointing toward the caption transcript scrolling down her tablet. "Representative Mayfield warned his own Republican conference right to their faces that burying his privileged resolution in the lame-duck Judiciary Committee was only temporary—he called his articles *'a much gentler version of what's coming'* once Speaker-Designate Clara Morales and the new majority take the gavels in January with full committee and subpoena power."

Within ten minutes, the right half of the muted basement television screen cut live across the Potomac to the Pentagon briefing room.

Stepping briskly up to the blue briefing podium beneath the Department of Defense seal—holding his first Pentagon press conference in more than six months—was Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, his hair freshly lacquered under the television lights from his decade hosting *Patriot Watch Weekend* on the Liberty First Network. Even with the volume muted, the swagger rolling off the screen was unmistakable as the closed-captioning stenographer struggled to keep pace with him. Gripping both edges of the lectern with a triumphant grin, Halverson declared "total victory," sneering that the eight impeachment articles were a "stunt" and a "circus" staged by a sore-loser congressman, insisting that every military operation cited in the resolution was lawful, ordered by President Garrett Thorne, and properly notified to Congress. Below him on the broadcast ticker, statements from the White House flashed in succession as President Thorne congratulated his Defense Secretary and Vice President Conrad Drayton posted online that critics were only targeting Halverson because he "took on the bureaucracy at the Pentagon."

"They actually think they beat it," Mandy Hawkins said softly from behind her stack of constituent casework binders. "He's standing at the Pentagon podium taking a victory lap over a seven-vote referral motion."

"Let him celebrate," I said, tapping two keys on my MagnaBook Pro to archive the certified Clerk roll-call sheet—where two hundred and eleven names were now etched permanently into the *Congressional Record* voting to bury eight articles of impeachment without a single witness or document request—right alongside the timestamped video capture of Halverson's Pentagon briefing inside our encrypted oversight directory. "A motion to refer doesn't acquit anybody of anything. Every pending committee referral in the One Hundred Nineteenth Congress evaporates into thin air when the clock strikes twelve o'clock noon on Sunday, January third."

Beside me, Katie didn't take her eyes off Halverson's smirking face on the muted basement monitor, and I could feel the quiet heat radiating off her fingers where her hand held mine.

"Three weeks ago on Veterans Day—less than two miles from our grandfather's World War II headstone at Arlington—that man and his entourage laughed and carried on so loudly on the steps at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier that an enlisted sentinel from The Old Guard had to stop his march and reprimand the Secretary of Defense's own party in front of the whole plaza," Katie said in a low, steel-edged voice that rarely came out unless somebody crossed a sacred line. "And when the video went viral, he hauled that young Specialist over to the Pentagon the very next afternoon to pin a medal on him for the cameras like a cheap damage-

control stunt. Back in January of last year, when I rolled into the well of the Senate of Virginia in Richmond and urged both of our Senators to vote No on confirming a weekend cable talk-show host to run the Pentagon, Bret Halverson went back on his old television network after Vice President Drayton broke the fifty-fifty tie and laughed that nobody in Washington cared what a little state senator on wheels thought. Had Representative Mayfield's snap resolution passed this afternoon in forty-eight hours without a single hearing record, Senators at a trial would have complained that the House rushed the evidence without depositions or subpoenas. Instead, thirty-three days from today, the new House Judiciary and Armed Services chairs get to pull those exact articles off the shelf with full federal subpoena power —and a man like Bret Halverson, convinced after today that he's untouchable, is going to spend the next five weeks acting like nobody can ever touch him."

Tuesday, December 1, 2026, 5:15 PM — Why We Avoid Union Station, State Senator Charles R. Fenwick's Bridge, & The West Side of the Tracks on Sunset Drive

By quarter past five, true December darkness was already settling over Capitol Hill beneath a clear indigo twilight sky as Katie and I said goodnight to Sam, Mandy, and Sarah—watching the triplets head cheerfully down the corridor together to catch their bus—and steered our two SwiftChairs out the accessible ground-level Dirksen exit onto the crisp winter sidewalk along First Street Southeast.

Half a block north toward Constitution and Massachusetts Avenues, a solid river of red brake lights stretched toward the white granite colonnade of Washington Union Station as town cars, black government SUVs, and taxicabs idled bumper to bumper in the evening rush.

Whenever Capitol Hill staffers or reporters learned that Katie and I rode ARTS trains up from Norfolk and commuted by rail every day, nine out of ten of them automatically assumed we used Washington Union Station. In truth, Katie and I avoided Union Station like the plague unless a specific western mountain train left us no other stop on the map. For two autistic forty-one-year-olds who had just spent ten straight hours absorbing caucus debates, camera flashes, and basement fluorescent glare, Union Station at five-thirty on a weekday evening was a cavernous sensory ambush: booming public-address speakers reverberating off ninety-foot barrel-vaulted ceilings, twenty tracks of screeching steel wheel flanges, surging retail food-court crowds, and cab horns blaring across Columbus Circle.

Here at the corner of First and C Streets Southeast, by contrast, the street-level glass elevator at Capitol South Station sat calm and uncrowded beside the brown Capital Transit pylon striped with Blue, Orange, and Silver.

Katie and I tapped our blue plastic CapitalPass cards against the circular target on the wide accessible faregate, rolled onto the mezzanine elevator down to the vaulted underground platform, and boarded a westbound Blue Line train with plenty of room to lock our wheelchair brakes side by side in the center bay. Three stops later at L'Enfant Plaza, we glided smoothly off the train, rode the center-island elevator up one level to the perpendicular upper-level tracks, and rolled straight onto a southbound Virginia-bound Yellow Line train just before the two-tone door chime sounded.

Two minutes after leaving L'Enfant Plaza, the dark concrete walls of the Seventh Street tunnel dropped away completely, and our Yellow Line car soared out into the open evening air high above the Potomac River on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge.

Outside the wide glass window beside our armrests, the dark winter river shimmered with reflections of the illuminated white marble Jefferson Memorial behind us and the amber runway approach lights of Washington National Airport ahead along the Virginia shoreline. Immediately to our right, across the narrow strip of dark water separating the twin rail tracks from the Fourteenth Street highway spans, three solid lanes of black sedans and commuter SUVs sat virtually motionless in bumper-to-bumper bridge traffic while our silver railcar glided past them at fifty miles an hour.

"I guarantee you not one in fifty Senators sitting in those town cars next door—and zero K Street lobbyists—could tell you the name of this bridge if you put a hundred-dollar bill on the table," I said to Katie, leaning my shoulder lightly toward the cool glass as the welded rail joints clicked rhythmically beneath our wheels.

Katie smiled, her reflection warm in the twilight window beside mine.

"They think all four spans across the river are just 'the Fourteenth Street Bridge,'" Katie agreed softly. "Almost nobody in Washington knows that on April thirtieth, 1983—the exact Saturday the first Yellow Line trains rolled across the Potomac into Northern Virginia—this rail bridge was officially named the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge, after Virginia State Senator Charles R. Fenwick of Arlington."

"A member of the Senate of Virginia," I grinned, squeezing her hand across our armrests. "Who stood up on Capitol Square in Richmond back in the nineteen-fifties and sixties, authored the legislation creating the Northern Virginia Transportation Commission, and negotiated the interstate compact that built this entire regional subway system so Virginians wouldn't be trapped in highway gridlock forever."

"From one Virginia State Senator's bridge to the next," Katie murmured, watching the Virginia shoreline rush up to meet our train.

Twelve minutes later, after gliding past National Airport, Potomac Yard, and Braddock Road, our Yellow Line train braked smoothly alongside the elevated concrete island platform of King Street–Old Town Station in Alexandria, right beneath the illuminated stepped stone tower of the George Washington Masonic National Memorial rising atop Shooter's Hill.

We took the platform elevator down to the quiet brick plaza, tapped our CapitalPass cards out through the wide gate, and rolled side by side past the red-brick 1905 depot of Alexandria Union Station toward the stone-and-steel railroad underpass spanning King Street.

For sixty feet underneath that railroad bridge, the low rumble of a northbound commuter train echoed overhead—and then the instant our front caster wheels rolled clear out the western side of the underpass onto the west side of the tracks, the bustle of Old Town restaurants and station buses vanished behind the embankment as if someone had turned down a studio fader.

One short, level brick-sidewalk block west of the tracks, we turned the corner onto Sunset Drive.

Up at the top of the gentle wooden wheelchair ramp leading to the front porch of our dad's paid-off two-story brick house, the brass coach lamp was already glowing amber in the December chill. Before my thumb even reached the doorbell button, our sixty-eight-year-old dad pulled the front oak door wide open in his wool cardigan while Brittany and Chelsea smiled warmly behind him in the hallway, letting the rich scent of Brittany's homemade chicken vegetable soup and fresh rosemary roll out onto the porch.

"Right on the five-fifty-two Yellow Line schedule," Dad beamed, stepping back across the foyer rug beside Brittany and Chelsea so Katie and I could wheel side by side into the warm hallway—right past our newly installed interior vertical platform wheelchair lift waiting quietly beside the stairs to carry us up to our three-desk study in Bedroom 4 after supper. "Wash up, Senator-Elect. How was Day One of the December lame duck?"

Katie clicked off her powerchair drive motor inside the warm foyer, unbuttoned her winter coat as Chelsea reached down to give my sleeve an affectionate pat, and looked back through the front window toward the quiet railroad embankment a block away—knowing that every single night the United States Senate stood in session for the next six years, she wouldn't be sleeping in a Georgetown salon or a Capitol Hill luxury condo across the river; she would cross underneath the tracks on Sunset Drive and sleep at home with our family in the Commonwealth of Virginia.

"Productive, Dad," Katie smiled, reaching over to pat my forearm as all five of us headed into the kitchen. "Everybody in Washington knows where we stand—and we're right on time for dinner."

The Minified ZIP File, The Raw HTML Takedown, & Resigning from Richmond

Part 1: The Minified ZIP Trick, Barely Commented Code, & The Live WCAG Takedown

Date: 2026-12-11 at 10:00 America/New_York

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:00 AM — Static MagnaPad Slides & The Minified ZIP Trick in Dirksen

"You don't need to worry your head about the technical weeds, Senator-Elect—our engineering team in Rosslyn handles all the magic behind the curtain! Just tell us if you like this shade of Senate navy blue on the banner!"

Sitting across the polished mahogany conference table in our temporary transition suite in the Dirksen Senate Office Building, Bradford Vance—the Senior Account Director for Capitol Digital Solutions, one of the beltway IT contractors approved by the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms to build official United States Senate constituent websites—beamed with patronizing self-satisfaction as he tapped a static PDF slide deck on his MagnaPad tablet. Beside him sat his junior project manager, Evan, while a black triangular conference speakerphone sat in the center of the table with their lead developers dialed in live from their Rosslyn office across the Potomac.

Four days earlier, on Monday, December 7, the Virginia State Board of Elections had met in Richmond under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-679 to formally certify the November 3 general election results, and the Governor had transmitted Katie's signed Certificate of Election to the Secretary of the United States Senate.

Now, on Friday morning, Katie and I had ridden the morning ARTS train up from Norfolk with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea, detrained on the mobile lift at Alexandria to drop our overnight bags with them at Dad's two-story brick house on Sunset Drive—where our newly installed interior vertical platform wheelchair lift was already humming smoothly between the first floor and our upstairs three-desk office in Bedroom 4—and taken the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge into the District for our ten o'clock website sign-off meeting.

Under United States Senate Internet Services rules, a Senator's official government constituent website had to be strictly separated from our campaign website, which Katie and I had coded ourselves in PHP, and hosted inside the Sergeant at Arms environment using an approved vendor template.

Watching Bradford talk down to my forty-one-year-old twin sister in the exact overly bright, sing-song voice that non-technical consultants often used when they saw two adults sitting in compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs, I didn't say a word. I just kept my hands resting lightly beside my closed MagnaBook Pro and waited for Katie to lower the boom.

"I don't approve websites from static PDF pictures on a MagnaPad, Bradford," Katie said evenly, folding her hands in the lap of her royal-blue blazer without even glancing at his tablet screen. "Before I put my name on a federal domain that sixty thousand disabled veterans, blind commuters, and working families across Virginia are going to use to request constituent casework, my brother Nate and I want to audit the raw HTML, CSS, and JavaScript source code. Please have your build team on the speakerphone drop the staging repository onto our transition VLAN share folder right now."

Bradford blinked twice, his rehearsed sales smile flickering as he exchanged an amused glance with Evan. Clearly, he assumed some twenty-two-year-old campaign intern had fed the incoming Senator a technical buzzword to sound tough.

"Well, Senator-Elect, normally congressional offices just sign the design approval form and let our certified engineers handle the code," Bradford chuckled condescendingly, leaning toward the triangular speakerphone in the center of the table. "Trevor, are you and the build team hearing this in Rosslyn? The Senator-Elect wants to see a copy of the code before she signs off. Go ahead and drop a ZIP file of the build into her transition share drive so we can check that box."

Over the speakerphone, we heard a muffled snicker from the Rosslyn engineering bullpen—the unmistakable sound of developers who thought a United States Senator wouldn't know an HTML tag from a spreadsheet macro—followed by Trevor's voice:

"Sure thing, Brad. Give me ten seconds… alright, I just dropped *prairie-senate-prod-bundle.zip* into the Dirksen transition share folder for her."

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:15 AM — "Why Is a U.S. Senator Speaking Our Exact Engineering Language?"

Katie and I opened the unbranded matte-aluminum lids of our two MagnaBook Pro laptops at the exact same second.

Without touching a mouse, I mounted the local Senate transition VLAN share in my MagnaOS terminal, unzipped *prairie-senate-prod-bundle.zip* into our shared workspace, and pushed the extracted directory straight across our local peer link to Katie's machine.

Beside me, Katie hit Command and Space, launched Quantum Code—QCode—and opened the extracted folder across two vertical editor panes.

Bradford's patronizing smile vanished the instant he saw the dark syntax-highlighted IDE panes snap open across both of our screens. "Wait… is that Quantum Code?"

Neither Katie nor I answered him, because both of us were staring at the three files Trevor had packed into the ZIP archive: *index.min.html*, *styles.min.css*, and *app.min.js*.

Every single file had been run through an aggressive production minifier. All line breaks, indentation, and whitespace had been stripped out, crushing thousands of lines of code into a single continuous horizontal wall of characters, with every JavaScript variable and function mangled into single-letter identifiers without a single source map in the directory.

Sitting in her SwiftChair, Katie's blue eyes narrowed to ice. She leaned six inches forward toward the black triangular speakerphone in the center of the mahogany table.

"Trevor," Katie said, her voice cutting through the speakerphone mesh with razor-sharp precision. "Did your build team seriously just send a United States Senator-Elect a webpack-minified production bundle with stripped whitespace, mangled single-letter AST identifiers, concatenated CSS rules, and zero source maps because you thought I wouldn't know the difference between compiled build artifacts and raw source code?"

Across the table, Bradford's jaw literally dropped open.

Over the speakerphone, the muffled background chatter in the Rosslyn engineering bullpen stopped dead. For four full seconds, the only sound coming through the speaker was stunned, ragged breathing.

"Uh… wait—who is this speaking?" Trevor stammered over the line, completely bewildered. "Brad, did the Senator-Elect bring an outside DevOps engineer from the Sergeant at Arms office into the room?"

"No, Trevor, this is Senator-Elect Katie Prairie speaking to you, and my twin brother Nate is sitting right beside me with the exact same minified garbage open in Quantum Code," Katie snapped. "I didn't ask for your minified production output. I asked for your raw, unminified source repository—the actual human-readable HTML templates, uncompiled stylesheets, and unminified JavaScript controllers

before your bundler strips the tree. Drop the raw unminified repository into the VLAN folder in the next sixty seconds, or I am calling the Senate Sergeant at Arms contract officer to cancel your task order before lunch."

"Yes, ma'am—right away, Senator-Elect! Exporting the raw source branch right now!" Trevor blurted out over the speakerphone, his voice pitching up an octave as frantic keyboard clacking echoed from Rosslyn.

Across the mahogany table, a bead of sweat rolled down Bradford Vance's temple as he stared in utter disbelief at a forty-one-year-old Senator in a power wheelchair who had just dismantled his lead engineer in fluent full-stack developer shop talk.

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:25 AM — Twin Fury Over Barely Commented Code & Every WCAG Failure in the Book

Forty seconds later, a new archive—*prairie-senate-raw-src.zip*—appeared in the network share.

I extracted the raw source tree in terminal, opened *header.html*, *casework-form.html*, *styles.css*, and *nav-controller.js* across my Quantum Code workspace, and glanced over at Katie as she opened the exact same files on her MagnaBook Pro.

The longer the two of us scrolled down those unminified files, the hotter our faces burned. Within two minutes, both Katie and I were flat-out furious.

"Nate, look at *nav-controller.js* and *casework-form.html*," Katie said, her voice vibrating with the cold, surgical fury of a senior software architect who had just uncovered fraud. "There are almost no code comments in this entire repository!"

"Four thousand two hundred lines of unminified HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, and I just ran a grep across the whole source tree," I said angrily, leaning toward the speakerphone so Trevor and his entire Rosslyn team could hear every word. "You have exactly three inline comment lines in the entire project—and one of them on line eighty-four of *nav-controller.js* literally says *TODO: fix keyboard trap later* dated four years ago! There isn't a single architectural block comment at the top of your files, zero function docblocks explaining your state logic, and zero inline comments documenting your DOM event listeners. How is any developer supposed to maintain taxpayer-funded code that isn't even commented?!"

"And the reason you tried to hide it behind a minified ZIP file is even worse," Katie said, pointing her finger straight at her laptop screen while Bradford and Evan shrank back into their leather chairs across the table. "This website as written fails almost every single WCAG accessibility pointer there is!"

Over the speakerphone, Trevor tried to stammer a defense: "S-Senator-Elect, I assure you our template passed our internal visual QA check—"

"Don't you dare talk to me about a visual QA check when I am looking at your raw DOM tree line by line!" Katie fired back. "Let's start at the top of *header.html*. You have no skip-navigation link anywhere in the header, which violates WCAG 2.4.1 Bypass Blocks and forces every keyboard and switch user to tab through forty-two navigation links on every single page load. Your heading hierarchy jumps straight

from an H1 banner title to an H4 subheader because your designer used heading tags for font sizing instead of semantic structure, violating WCAG 1.3.1 Info and Relationships. And look at line forty-seven of *header.html*!"

Katie read the offending markup aloud like a prosecutor reading an indictment into the federal record:

"You wrapped the entire *Help With a Federal Agency* constituent dropdown menu inside nested generic div tags with an inline *onclick* attribute—zero semantic button element, zero *aria-expanded* state, zero *aria-controls* binding, and no *tabindex*! Do you know what that means? It means a blind veteran using a screen reader, or a quadriplegic Virginian navigating with a Sip-and-Puff switch or a keyboard Tab key, cannot even open the menu to ask their United States Senator for help with the VA!"

"And look at line one hundred twelve of *styles.css*," I added fiercely, scrolling my right-hand pane down the stylesheet. "Somebody on your team wrote a global wildcard rule setting focus outlines to *none* with an *!important* flag across the entire website! You literally stripped the visible keyboard focus ring off every link and form control on the page—a blatant violation of WCAG 2.4.7 Focus Visible and federal Section 508 law!"

"Wait until you hear what happens on *casework-form.html* at line two hundred four," Katie said grimly.

That page was the Federal Casework Privacy Act Release Form—the most important page on any Senator's website, where disabled constituents, seniors, and military families submit requests for help with delayed Social Security checks, Medicare power-wheelchair prior authorizations, and veterans' benefits.

"Instead of associating explicit HTML label elements with your form inputs using a *for* attribute, your developers just typed instructions into light-gray *placeholder* attributes colored hex 999999 on a white background—a 2.6-to-1 contrast ratio that fails WCAG 1.4.3 Contrast Minimum AND fails WCAG 3.3.2 Labels or Instructions," Katie said. "And because you stripped the labels, listen to what a blind constituent actually hears when they try to fill out your form."

Katie pressed Command and F5 on her MagnaBook Pro keyboard to turn on MagnaVoice—the built-in MagnaOS screen reader—turned her laptop speakers up to maximum volume right beside the conference speakerphone, and hit the Tab key four times.

Across the mahogany table and straight through the open speakerphone line into the Rosslyn engineering bullpen, the synthesized MagnaVoice voice echoed in the dead-silent room:

"Edit text, blank. Edit text, blank. Image, hero-banner-final-v3.jpg. Unlabeled button."

Nobody on the other side of the table or on the speakerphone dared to breathe.

Katie pressed Command and F5 to silence MagnaVoice and looked straight across the table at Bradford before addressing the speakerphone.

“S-Senator-Elect…” Trevor whispered over the speakerphone, sounding completely shell-shocked. “How on earth do you and your brother know how to audit raw unminified HTML, CSS specificity, DOM accessibility trees, and WCAG pointers like senior software engineers?”

“Because my brother Nate and I learned how to write raw HTML in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School back in 1997—which is what inspired our dad to go back to school at the Community College of Hampton Roads to earn his computer science degree,” Katie said, her voice ringing with every year of our lives. “We learned Quantum Basic 6.0 alongside our dad in 2001, we rolled into the Web Applications Developer lab at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville in March 2007 after refusing to let their evaluators steer two associate-degree holders into being ValueMart door greeters, we copied the entire PHP and SQL curriculum onto our own laptops when VITA’s state computers were too locked down to run modern code, and we have spent the last nineteen years building and maintaining production websites and desktop applications from these two wheelchairs! Did your company actually sign a federal VPAT certifying to the Senate Sergeant at Arms that this uncommented, inaccessible garbage complies with Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, or did you just assume a Senator in a wheelchair wouldn’t know how to read your source code?”

Bradford swallowed hard, wiping his forehead with a linen handkerchief. “Senator-Elect, I… we will assign a remediation sprint immediately—”

“You don’t need to assign a remediation sprint, because Nate and I don’t trust your team to write clean code without supervision,” Katie said, her fingers already flying across her mechanical laptop keyboard in tandem with mine. “Sit quietly for twenty-five minutes while we show you how professional Web Applications Developers write and document accessible code.”

For the next twenty-five minutes, while Bradford and Evan sat frozen in their suits and the entire Rosslyn engineering bullpen watched our live screen-share in humbled silence, Katie and I refactored their core templates in Quantum Code. We replaced every non-semantic div dropdown with proper semantic HTML5 nav and button elements bound to clean ARIA state toggles, restored high-contrast focus-visible rings, bound explicit label elements and 4.5-to-1 contrast tokens to every single input on the constituent casework form, and padded the top of every file and every single logic block with comprehensive architectural block comments and inline WCAG explanations so any future developer could read and maintain it.

At 10:55 AM, I committed our changes to a clean Git patch file—*wcag-508-and-documentation-fixes.diff*—and pushed it straight back into the Rosslyn staging repository.

“Merge our pull request, apply that exact commenting and WCAG 2.2 AA standard to every remaining subpage in the repository, and have the unminified branch ready for our second inspection by Monday at noon,” Katie told the speakerphone as she closed the lid of her MagnaBook Pro.

By the time Katie and I unlocked our wheelchair brakes and rolled out into the Dirksen corridor toward the Capital Transit elevator, word was already ripping through every IT vendor and Senate chief of staff on Capitol Hill: *Whatever you do,*

never send minified code, uncommented spaghetti, or a fake accessibility report to Senator Prairie's office—she and her brother will demand your raw unminified repo, open it in Quantum Code, and debug you live on speakerphone.

Part 2: Article IV Section 4, Hand-Delivering Her Resignation in Richmond, & The Writ of Special Election

Date: 2026-12-15 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 15, 2026, 2:00 PM — The Clerk's Office of the Senate of Virginia & The Dual-Office Holding Ban

"It feels strange holding this envelope in my hand after twelve years in Capitol Square, Nate," Katie said quietly as our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs rolled side by side down the polished black-and-white marble corridor of the Virginia State Capitol in Richmond toward the mahogany doors of the Office of the Clerk of the Senate of Virginia.

Resting across my sister's lap on top of her leather portfolio was a heavy cream-parchment letter embossed with the gold seal of the Senate of Virginia and signed in her crisp blue fountain-pen script.

Under Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia—as well as Code of Virginia Section 2.2-2800 and the Incompatibility Clause of Article I, Section 6 of the Constitution of the United States—no person holding any office under the United States government is permitted to hold a seat in either house of the Virginia General Assembly. Even more importantly to Katie, the 2027 Session of the Virginia General Assembly was scheduled to gavel in at noon on the second Wednesday in January—Wednesday, January 13, 2027, just ten days after her federal swearing-in in Washington.

If Katie had waited until January 3 to vacate her State Senate seat, the citizens of Virginia Beach and Chesapeake in her district would have been left with an empty chair on the floor of the Senate of Virginia during the opening weeks of the legislative session. By formally submitting her resignation today, on Tuesday, December 15, 2026, she was giving the Lieutenant Governor and the Governor of Virginia the legal window required under the Code of Virginia to immediately issue a Writ of Special Election for early January so her successor could be elected and seated on Opening Day in Richmond.

When we rolled through the tall wooden doorway into the neoclassical Clerk's Office—where white marble Ionic columns framed the floor-to-ceiling bookshelves of Virginia Acts of Assembly dating back to Thomas Jefferson's design—the gray-haired Clerk of the Senate stepped out from behind his high podium and walked straight over to the lowered, wheelchair-accessible mahogany counter that had been built during Katie's very first term in the upper chamber.

"Madam Chair," the Clerk said softly, his voice thick with genuine affection as he looked from Katie to me beside the blue Flag of the Commonwealth of Virginia. "Or I suppose in nineteen days I have to start calling you Senator Prairie of the United States Senate."

“In this building, William, you can just call me Katie,” my sister smiled warmly, lifting the gold-sealed cream parchment letter from her lap and extending it across the accessible mahogany counter. “Pursuant to Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of Virginia, here is my formal signed letter resigning my seat in the Senate of Virginia, together with the duplicate copy for the Lieutenant Governor so the Writ of Special Election can be issued this afternoon.”

With a respectful bow of his head, the Clerk accepted the parchment letter in both hands, stamped the official time and date of receipt onto the ledger copy, and handed the stamped receipt back across the counter to Katie.

“Twelve years between the House of Delegates and the Senate of Virginia, Katie,” the Clerk said, resting his hand over the signed parchment. “When you and Nate first rolled through the Bell Tower entrance in January of 2014, half the historic committee rooms in this Capitol complex didn’t even have flush thresholds or accessible turning radiuses, and nobody in Richmond thought a first-term Delegate from Virginia Beach could force a subcommittee to table its own bill with a single three-minute speech. This Capitol is a vastly fairer, more accessible house of the people because the two of you were here.”

“And we’re holding you to keeping every single ramp and every single late-night transit grant intact while we’re up in Washington, William,” Katie said, her blue eyes shining as she shook his hand across the mahogany counter.

Tuesday, December 15, 2026, 3:15 PM — One Last Roll Down the Senate Ramp & The Bus to Main Street Station

After leaving the Clerk’s Office, Katie and I took the elevator to the second floor and rolled quietly into the empty gallery aisle of the Senate of Virginia Chamber.

The afternoon December sunlight slanted through the tall arched windows across the crimson carpet and the forty mahogany desks of the upper chamber. Up at the front aisle, right beside the Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services chair desk that Katie had occupied since January 2020, sat the permanent, custom-milled mahogany wheelchair ramp leading up to the Clerk’s well and the dais—installed so seamlessly into the historic woodwork that any visitor looking down from the Capitol gallery would assume it had always been there.

Sitting beside my sister in the quiet chamber, I reached across our armrests and took her left hand.

“Look at that ramp, Katie,” I said softly. “First the Virginia Beach City Council chamber at the Municipal Center in 2011. Then the House of Delegates subcommittees in 2014. Then the Senate of Virginia in 2020. And last month in Washington, after Senator Tess Dunmore showed us the chamber ramp she fought for back in 2017, the Senate carpenters finished raising your mahogany desk on riser blocks and widening the dual-chair bays so there are two women in wheelchairs on the floor of the United States Senate.”

Katie looked at the mahogany ramp in front of her old desk, then turned her head to smile at me.

“Every time we had to fight for a ramp, Nate, people in suits acted like we were asking for a personal favor,” Katie said quietly. “We weren’t building those ramps just for me. We were building them so the next kid in a SwiftChair who rides a bus to a field trip at the Virginia State Capitol—or the United States Capitol—never has to sit at the bottom of a staircase wondering if the law belongs to them too.”

Twenty minutes later, after carrying the last cardboard banker’s box from her constituent office—holding nothing more than our framed copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia and our twin blue hot-chocolate mugs—out the accessible basement entrance onto Bank Street, we didn’t call a state pool car or a limousine.

Just as we had done every winter session in Richmond for twelve years, United States Senator-Elect Katie Prairie and I rolled our two compact SwiftChairs half a block down the brick sidewalk alongside Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea to the regular JRTC public transit bus stop at Ninth and Main, waited alongside the four o’clock state office clerks and hospital workers, rolled up the front bus ramp into the dual wheelchair bays, and tapped our fare cards for the seven-minute ride down the hill to Richmond Main Street Station to catch the evening ARTS train home to Norfolk together.

First Train from Norfolk, Swearing In on the Constitution, & Strings Attached for RRC

Part 1: Five Business Class Tickets for Free Café Car Drinks & The Mobile Lift at Alexandria

Date: 2027-01-03 at 05:00 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 5:00 AM — Norfolk Station & Five Business Class Tickets for Free Café Car Drinks

“Make sure you keep your receipts folded in your wallets, everyone—those Business Class barcodes get the four of you unlimited free ginger ale and get me hot coffee out of the Café Car all the way up to Alexandria,” our sixty-eight-year-old dad said with a grin at five o’clock in the morning, holding his leather garment bag in one hand as forty-one-year-old Brittany guided forty-four-year-old Chelsea smoothly up the vestibule steps and the uniformed ARTS station attendant finished cranking our second compact SwiftChair power wheelchair up the yellow mobile lift into the warm stainless-steel vestibule at Norfolk Station.

Outside on the low-level brick platform beside Harbor Park, the January predawn wind off the Elizabeth River was cold enough to turn our breath into white plumes under the station lamps. Inside the front end of the combined ARTS Business Class and Café Car, the air smelled like fresh-brewed dark roast coffee, warm baseboard heat, and polished vinyl headrests.

It was Sunday, January 3, 2027—Opening Day of the One Hundred Twentieth Congress of the United States. In exactly seven hours, at twelve o'clock noon in the Chamber of the United States Senate in Washington, D.C., my forty-one-year-old twin sister was going to raise her right hand and be sworn in as the newest United States Senator from the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Four days earlier, on Wednesday afternoon, a polite young protocol liaison from the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms had called our transition office in Virginia Beach to ask which flight Senator-Elect Katie Prairie was taking into Washington National Airport, or whether Capitol Police needed to stage a black SUV motorcade at the VIP circular drive outside Washington Union Station.

Katie had looked across her desk at me, smiled, and given the young man the unvarnished truth.

"Neither," my sister had told him over the speakerphone. *"My brother Nate, my dad, my cousins Brittany and Chelsea, and I are taking the first morning ARTS Northeast Regional train out of Norfolk at five o'clock in the morning."*

Because almost nobody inside the Washington beltway bubble could imagine a newly elected United States Senator navigating rail and subway transfers in a power wheelchair without a dozen handlers, every single person in the Sergeant at Arms office—along with two dozen national television producers who caught wind of her travel plans—had automatically assumed she meant she was riding the train all the way to the end of the line at Washington Union Station.

They didn't know our dad, and they definitely didn't know our family.

Two weeks after Election Night, when Dad had sat down at his kitchen table with his reading glasses on to book our rail tickets for Swearing-In Day on his own credit card, he hadn't booked us to Washington Union Station at all. He had purchased five regular passenger Business Class tickets from Norfolk to Alexandria—station code ALX—on the first train of the morning.

And as Katie and I locked the brakes of our two compact silver-and-black SwiftChair power wheelchairs side by side in the dual accessible bays at the front of the Business Class cabin while Dad hung her pressed royal-blue Senatorial suit bag on the luggage hook and Brittany settled into the pair of plush leather seats right across the aisle beside Chelsea—tucking her canvas tote bag with Chelsea's plush green sea turtle beside their feet—none of us were thinking about VIP motorcades.

"First things first before we even cross the river into Suffolk," Katie said, her blue eyes crinkling with the exact same delight she had worn at sixteen on the aft deck of the *Sunward Tropics* with her souvenir soda tumbler as she held up her paper Business Class ticket stub toward Chelsea and me. "Nate, Chelsea, Brittany—are we getting our free Café Car ginger ales right now, or are we waiting until the conductor scans our tickets?"

"Free ginger ale now!" Chelsea beamed behind her glasses, clapping her hands softly together as Brittany laughed.

"The Café Car attendant just rolled the security grille up on the counter thirty feet behind us," I replied, reaching across the gap between our armrests to squeeze my twin sister's hand as the diesel locomotive gave two low horn blasts and the train

glided smoothly away from the Norfolk platform into the dark winter morning. “Brittany’s already walking back—let’s get four free ginger ales and Dad’s black coffee right now so we get our money’s worth before Petersburg.”

Besides the promise Katie and I had made to each other behind a locked bedroom door on New Year’s Eve when we were seventeen years old, all three of us—Katie, Dad, and I—took a daily prescription maintenance medication where mixing the drug with alcohol or tobacco carried a known, lethal side effect of death, while Brittany had proudly kept ten years of sobriety since moving home with us in 2016. Back in Richmond, and now in Washington, where lobbyists and senior lawmakers loved to clink glasses of expensive cabernet or pass around celebratory cigars in back rooms, that warning label on our pill bottles was our favorite conversational shield: nobody at a Capitol Hill reception ever tried to push a second glass of wine or a cocktail on a Senator after she cheerfully informed them that the known side effect of mixing it with her daily medication was dying on their carpet. For our family, cold ginger ale for Katie, Brittany, Chelsea, and me and hot black coffee for Dad from the ARTS Café Car were the only celebratory drinks we would ever need.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 9:12 AM — Detraining on the Mobile Lift at Alexandria Union Station

“Next stop, Alexandria—ALX!” the conductor announced over the passenger intercom at ten minutes past nine as our Northeast Regional train slowed past the brick rowhouses and bare winter trees of Northern Virginia. “Passengers detraining at Alexandria, please step toward the vestibule doors. After Alexandria, our final stop will be Washington Union Station in approximately twenty-five minutes.”

Up and down the aisle of the Business Class car, several lobbyists and congressional staffers in wool overcoats barely glanced up from their laptops, assuming every person dressed in a suit on a Sunday morning was staying aboard all the way into the cavernous concourse of Washington Union Station.

When Katie and I unlocked our wheelchair brakes, tucked our second round of complimentary Café Car paper cups into our armrest cupholders, and rolled toward the forward vestibule door with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking right behind us as the train brakes hissed to a stop beside the low-level red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station, two passengers in the front row did a sudden double-take over the rims of their coffee cups.

“Wait a second,” a woman in a camel wool coat whispered to her husband as the stainless-steel door slid open to the crisp forty-degree Virginia morning sunlight. “Isn’t that Senator-Elect Katie Prairie? Why on earth is she getting off here at Alexandria instead of riding into Union Station?”

Katie heard every word, and as she glanced back at me over her shoulder, the two of us shared a quiet, unmistakable twin grin.

There were two reasons we were getting off at Alexandria, and every single person who actually lived on the rails and buses of Virginia understood both of them by heart.

First, for two autistic forty-one-year-olds—and for our cousin Chelsea, who thrived on calm, predictable stations without echoing crowds—Washington Union Station was a cavernous sensory ambush: twenty tracks of screeching steel flanges under a

vaulted ceiling, booming public-address announcements bouncing off marble columns, and a slow, twenty-five-minute train crawl across the Long Bridge and through the dark First Street Tunnel before you even reached the platform.

Here at Alexandria Union Station, right beneath the grassy slope of Shooter's Hill and the stepped stone tower of the George Washington Masonic National Memorial, the 1905 Federal Revival red-brick depot was small, open-air, quiet, and calm.

Because Alexandria had a low-level red-brick platform rather than a high-level concrete deck, a uniformed ARTS station attendant was already waiting right beside the track, wheeling the yellow-and-silver portable ARTS Mobile Lift flush against the open Business Class doorway.

I rolled onto the steel platform of the mobile lift first. With a smooth hydraulic hum, the attendant lowered me three feet down from the train vestibule onto the herringbone red bricks of the Alexandria platform, where I backed clear and parked beside Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea, who had already stepped down the vestibule stairs onto the bricks together.

Then the attendant raised the lift platform back up to the open doorway for the new junior Senator from Virginia.

Standing in the open doorway between our ARTS Business Class coach and the adjacent ARTS Café Car, the attendant held the yellow safety rail steady as Katie steered her compact SwiftChair onto the elevated metal platform, her royal-blue Senatorial blazer gleaming beneath her open navy wool winter coat. Down on the red-brick platform, three morning commuters in winter jackets and knit caps stopped dead in their tracks, their eyes widening in disbelief as they recognized the woman descending on the hand-operated station lift.

"Morning, folks!" Katie called out warmly from the lift platform as the attendant lowered her smoothly down to the bricks beside my chair. "Beautiful morning for a train ride up from Norfolk, isn't it?"

"Senator-Elect Prairie!" a commuter in a puffy down jacket stammered, pulling his smartphone out of his pocket with a huge grin as Katie rolled off the yellow ramp lip onto the red-brick platform right beside me. "Are you taking the train to your own swearing-in?!"

"Every single week the Senate is in session," Katie replied cheerfully, reaching her left hand across the gap between our two wheelchairs to lace her fingers through mine while she held her plastic CapitalPass transit card ready in her right hand. "And my brother Nate, our dad, and our cousins Brittany and Chelsea wouldn't miss the first ride for the world."

As the ARTS train sounded its horn and pulled away northward toward the Potomac River—carrying twenty empty seats toward the television cameras and black government SUVs waiting in vain for us at Washington Union Station—Katie and I rolled side by side down the sunlit red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking right beside us, leaving the railroad depot behind and following the outdoor brick pedestrian walkway over to the completely separate entrance of King Street–Old Town Capital Transit Station.

Part 2: The Yellow Line Over the Fenwick Bridge, The Full-Chair Portrait, & Swearing In on the Constitution

Date: 2027-01-03 at 09:25 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 9:25 AM — King Street–Old Town & The Yellow Line Over the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge

“Excuse me—Senator-Elect Prairie!” a young man in a navy wool overcoat with a congressional staff ID lanyard around his neck called out as Katie and I rolled out of the platform elevator with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking right beside us onto the elevated concrete island platform at King Street–Old Town Station. “If you’re heading to the Capitol for noon, don’t get on that train—that’s a Yellow Line train! The Blue Line on the other track goes straight to Capitol South without having to transfer!”

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests and laughed—the exact laugh of two people who had spent twenty-five years memorizing every route map, transfer pulse, and rail bridge from Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 15 on Military Highway to the Washington metropolitan grid.

“Sure, you can take the Blue Line straight through to Capitol South,” Katie told the young staffer warmly as the silver Capital Transit Yellow Line train glided up to the platform edge and its pneumatic doors chimed open level with the concrete sill. “If you want to take the long way all the way around through Crystal City, Rosslyn, and Foggy Bottom! We’re taking the Yellow Line straight across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge to L’Enfant Plaza and hopping the Blue Line two stops to Capitol South. Come on—you’ll beat your Blue Line train to the Hill by twelve minutes!”

Blinking in surprise as he did the mental map calculation, the staffer grinned and stepped into the Yellow Line car right behind Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea as Katie and I rolled our two SwiftChairs into the center wheelchair bays.

Nine minutes later, right after our train sped past Washington National Airport and the Pentagon, the tunnel walls fell away and our Yellow Line car burst out into the brilliant January morning sunlight high above the Potomac River on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge.

Through the wide glass window beside our wheelchairs, the entire skyline of the capital opened up across the sparkling water: the white marble colonnade of the Jefferson Memorial in the foreground, the towering obelisk of the Washington Monument to the left, and straight ahead on Jenkins Hill, the cast-iron dome of the United States Capitol gleaming against the clear blue winter sky.

Right inside the middle of that span over the river, Katie’s phone buzzed inside her coat pocket.

She glanced at the caller ID—*Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms*—and tapped the speaker button just loud enough for Dad and me to hear over the rhythmic click of the welded rail joints beneath the bridge.

“Senator-Elect Prairie?” the protocol liaison’s voice came through the speaker, breathless and slightly panicked. “Ma’am, I’m standing here with the Capitol Police detail and the press pool at Gate D inside Washington Union Station! The five

o’clock ARTS train from Norfolk just pulled onto the track two minutes ago, and the conductor told us you got off the train back in Virginia! Are you alright? Do we need to send a car down the George Washington Parkway to pick you up?”

“Put your SUVs back in the garage, Marcus—we’re completely fine,” Katie said, her voice calm and ringing with good humor as she glanced forward through the cab window toward the Virginia-to-District shoreline, knowing from years of riding Capital Transit that the cell signal would drop out the second our train left the open-air bridge and plunged into the underground tunnel portal before reaching the station repeaters at L’Enfant Plaza. “Washington Union Station is way too loud and crowded for my brother and me, and the ARTS train takes twenty-five minutes just to crawl from Alexandria into the terminal. We got off on the mobile lift at Alexandria, crossed the plaza over to King Street–Old Town, and rode the Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge. I have to let you go before we hit the Seventh Street tunnel and lose signal—we’re transferring at L’Enfant Plaza to the Blue Line two stops to Capitol South, so we’ll see you at the First Street entrance in ten minutes!”

She tapped the screen to end the call right as the concrete retaining walls of the tunnel portal swallowed the morning sunlight outside our window. Beside us, our dad chuckled, shaking his head as he braced one hand on the stainless-steel grab pole.

“You two just outran a Capitol Police motorcade and twenty television vans on a three-dollar CapitalPass card,” Dad said proudly.

“And we’re going to keep doing it for the next six years, Dad,” Katie said, looking from Dad to me as the doors opened at L’Enfant Plaza and we rolled smoothly out onto the lower-level platform toward the elevator up to the Blue Line track. “When we started *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* back in 2008 and realized we couldn’t even stay past five-thirty at the Virginia Beach Municipal Center for a six o’clock City Council meeting because the last Route 12 left CCHR at 5:48 PM, I promised myself I would never turn into one of those politicians who only sees Virginia through the tinted window of a town car. Every single time I visit constituents anywhere in the Commonwealth as their United States Senator—whether it’s CVTA back home in Hampton Roads, Blue Ridge Transit down at CPI in Blacksburg, or Capital Transit up here in Northern Virginia—we are riding that community’s public transit system as part of the visit.”

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 10:45 AM — “Nobody Crops My Powerchair Out of My Senate Portrait”

Fifteen minutes after our Blue Line train let us off at Capitol South and we rode the street elevator up to the sunny sidewalk at First and C Streets Southeast, Katie and I rolled through the bronze doors of the Russell Senate Office Building with Dad walking alongside us and headed up to the third-floor corner suite overlooking the Capitol grounds for Katie’s official Senate photograph.

Inside the high-ceilinged room with its dark mahogany wainscot paneling and classical cream pilasters, the official Senate historical photographer had already positioned the United States Flag with its gold fringe to the left of the tall arched

window and the deep blue Flag of the Commonwealth of Virginia to the right, framing the white dome of the Capitol in the morning light directly behind the center mark on the marble floor.

As Katie unbuttoned her heavy winter wool coat and handed it to Dad—revealing her tailored royal-blue Senatorial suit blazer with the small gold circular United States Senate pin gleaming on her left lapel—she steered her compact SwiftChair onto the tape mark between the two flags and rested her right hand naturally on her joystick controller.

Behind the studio umbrella lights, the photographer squinted through the viewfinder of his camera and immediately reached for the crank on his heavy aluminum tripod, raising the lens higher and zooming the barrel inward.

“Alright, Senator-Elect, let’s bring the frame in nice and tight from the mid-chest up so we match the standard head-and-shoulders portraits down the corridor,” the photographer said briskly. “If you could just fold your hands slightly higher near your lapel so the armrests don’t—”

“Stop right there, please,” Katie said—not unkindly, but with the unmistakable, quiet authority that had once silenced committee rooms in Richmond and bullies in the hallways of Northwood High School.

The photographer’s hand froze on the zoom ring.

“Lower the tripod back down and step back six feet so the entire wheelchair is in the frame from my head down to the wheels and the footplate,” Katie instructed him, sitting tall and poised between the two flags. “My twin brother Nate and I have rolled in these compact SwiftChairs from the moment we woke up until we went to bed since the third Friday of September in 2001 when we were sixteen years old. I didn’t hide my wheelchair when I knocked on doors for Virginia Beach City Council, I didn’t hide it in the House of Delegates or the Senate of Virginia, and nobody is cropping my powerchair out of my United States Senate portrait.”

From the doorway beside Dad, I watched the photographer blink once, nod with genuine respect, lower his tripod to waist height, and step back across the marble floor until every inch of my sister’s silver-and-black SwiftChair was framed proudly between the Stars and Stripes and the Seal of Virginia.

When the studio strobes flashed against the mahogany walls and Katie smiled straight into the lens with her right hand resting on her joystick controller, my throat tightened with a pride so fierce I could barely swallow.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 12:00 PM — Swearing In on the Constitution of the United States of America

At two minutes before twelve o’clock noon—after riding the subterranean United States Capitol Subway together beneath Constitution Avenue—Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I took our places at the front brass railing of the Senate Family Gallery directly above the floor of the United States Senate Chamber.

Looking down from the gallery bay where my wheelchair brakes were locked beside Dad’s polished dress shoes and Brittany sat with her arm resting warmly around Chelsea’s shoulders, I could see the entire semicircle of one hundred mahogany

desks arranged across the blue carpet below us. On the far aisle of the Democratic side—three aisles over from Senator Tess Dunmore of Illinois in her ultralight titanium chair—the Sergeant at Arms carpenters had already modified Senator Katie Prairie's assigned mahogany desk, removing the fixed chair base and setting one-and-a-half-inch mahogany riser blocks beneath the legs so her compact SwiftChair and right-hand joystick controller rolled seamlessly beneath the desktop.

At precisely 12:00 PM, Vice President Conrad Drayton—serving in his constitutional capacity under Article I, Section 3, Clause 4 as President of the Senate—brought the heavy ivory gavel down on the marble rostrum, calling the One Hundred Twentieth Congress of the United States to order.

As the Reading Clerk began calling the Newly Elected Senators forward to the well in alphabetical groups of four—*"Ms. Prairie of Virginia…"*—and Senior Senator Thomas Keane stepped into the aisle to escort his new Virginia partner forward while Senator Tess Dunmore tapped her wheel rim in salute, Dad reached over and gripped my shoulder with a steady, calloused hand.

In the span of three heartbeats, forty-one years of our lives flashed behind my eyes: two nine-year-old twins whispering our *Journey to the Sunlit Valley* cartoon password before unlocking the front door after school; two twelve-year-olds wearing matching maroon shirts on Twins' Day when a sixth-grade boy broke my sister's heart; two sixteen-year-olds learning in Dr. Carter's exam room that the borrowed time in our legs was almost gone; two seventeen-year-olds wedging a fifty-pound power wheelchair against the inside of a locked bedroom door on New Year's Eve while we ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box to stay safe from a house full of drunks; and two twenty-three-year-olds holding a camcorder on a CVTA Route 15 bus crossing the Elizabeth River as we exposed why working people couldn't even catch a bus home from a six o'clock City Council meeting.

Down on the blue carpet of the Senate Chamber, Katie didn't need stairs. She nudged her right thumb forward on her joystick, rolled her compact SwiftChair smoothly down the permanent ramp along the chamber aisle into the well of the Senate, looked straight up at Vice President Conrad Drayton on the rostrum, and raised her right hand.

Fifteen minutes later, as the applause from the galleries echoed through the Capitol corridors—with Brittany slipping Chelsea's cushioned ear defenders gently back into her canvas tote once we stepped into the quiet hall—the elevator doors brought Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and me down to the historic Old Senate Chamber for the individual ceremonial swearing-in with Vice President Drayton.

Katie had been looking forward to this exact five-minute appointment for two full months.

All through the autumn campaign—and even after the networks projected her victory on Election Night—President Garrett Thorne had sneered at her from the South Lawn as *"Broken Katie Prairie"* and *"a bitter little cripple on wheels,"* while Vice President Conrad Drayton had gone on the Liberty First Network to mock her wheelchair, her unmarried life, and her bond with me. Ten days before Christmas, hoping to whip up a culture-war pressure campaign that would force her to back down, Drayton's ceremonial protocol office had leaked to Beacon News, LibertyMax, and Virginia Beach's own evangelical flagship broadcast *The 777 Circle* on the Covenant Broadcasting Network that Senator-Elect Prairie had

formally notified the Vice President she would be affirming her oath on the Constitution of the United States instead of a Christian Bible and omitting the words "So help me God."

Instead of backing down an inch, Katie had worn their evangelical outrage as a badge of honor. Every time Katie had ever taken an oath of office back home in Virginia—first on the Virginia Beach City Council, then in the Virginia House of Delegates, and then in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond—she had refused to pretend to believe in a religion or a god that neither she nor I believed in. To my sister's clear, literal, fiercely principled mind, Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution explicitly guaranteed that Senators were bound by Oath or Affirmation and prohibited any religious test for public office—meaning her left hand belonged on the exact secular Constitution she was promising to defend, not a single word of religious theater belonged in her mouth, and Vice President Conrad Drayton had zero constitutional choice but to stand in front of her wheelchair and administer every word of it himself.

Now, as Dad and I positioned ourselves right beside her in the center of the crimson-and-gold Old Senate Chamber while Vice President Drayton stepped up stiffly with the printed oath card in his hand, I held out the thick, gold-stamped navy leather volume Dad had bought for her at the National Archives gift shop that morning: *The Constitution of the United States of America*.

Looking down from his full height at the forty-one-year-old woman he and President Thorne had mocked as "Broken Katie Prairie"—and who had just helped strip him of his tie-breaking vote in a fifty-four-seat Democratic Senate—Conrad Drayton's jaw muscle twitched once as Katie placed her left palm squarely on the gold lettering of *We the People*, raised her right hand high, and locked her unblinking blue eyes on his face.

Reading from the secular affirmation card our transition counsel had required under Article VI, Clause 3 of the Constitution, Title 5, Section 3331, and Title 1, Section 1 of the United States Code—with the optional religious phrase conspicuously absent at the bottom—Vice President Drayton had to speak every syllable aloud:

"Do you solemnly affirm that you will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that you will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; that you take this obligation freely, without any mental reservation or purpose of evasion; and that you will well and faithfully discharge the duties of the office on which you are about to enter?"

Katie's voice rang out clear, steady, and unshakeable across the historic chamber, never breaking eye contact with the Vice President:

"I do solemnly affirm."

As the shutters of the Senate photographers clicked in a rapid burst of white light and Vice President Drayton forced a tight, wooden handshake—"Congratulations, Senator Prairie"—Katie gave him a cool, victorious smile:

"Thank you, Mr. President of the Senate. Keep that gavel warm—Senator Dunmore already showed me the ramp up to your rostrum."

Before Drayton's face could finish turning purple, Katie turned her head toward me first.

Right there on the floor of the Old Senate Chamber, with the Constitution of the United States resting between our two compact power wheelchairs and our father's hands resting proudly on both of our shoulders, United States Senator Katie Prairie slipped her left hand across our armrests and laced her fingers tightly through mine.

Twenty minutes later, when the three of us rolled out onto the East Front plaza of the Capitol toward the Capitol South Capital Transit entrance, a wall of national television cameras from Beacon News, LibertyMax, and Virginia Beach's own evangelical flagship program *The 777 Circle* on the Covenant Broadcasting Network came rushing across the flagstones—breathlessly demanding to know why the new junior Senator from Virginia had affirmed her oath on the Constitution instead of a Christian Bible and omitted "So help me God" on national television.

Katie didn't roll past them. She stopped her SwiftChair right in front of the live satellite microphones, rested her hand on the navy leather cover of the United States Constitution on my lap tray, and smiled brightly into the lenses.

"I'm glad you asked, because it sounds like Beacon News, LibertyMax, and the folks at *The 777 Circle* back home on Indian River Road in Virginia Beach still haven't read the document I'm holding in my hand," Katie said clearly into the live network feeds. "Article VI, Clause 3 of the Constitution of the United States says that all Senators shall be bound by Oath or Affirmation to support this Constitution, and that no religious test shall ever be required as a qualification to any office or public trust under the United States. Even the Presidential Oath written by the Founders in Article II, Section 1, Clause 8 says 'swear or affirm' and does not contain the words 'So help me God.' And before anyone on cable television repeats the myth that President George Washington added 'So help me God' in 1789—historians debunked that fable decades ago. Zero eyewitnesses at Federal Hall in 1789 recorded Washington saying it; a writer named Rufus Wilmot Griswold made it up sixty-five years later in an 1854 book, and no President is recorded saying it until Chester A. Arthur in 1881. I affirmed my oath on the Constitution of the United States because the Constitution is the supreme law of the land—and my brother, my dad, and I are going to spend every single day of this term defending it."

With the cable correspondents left speechless behind us on the Capitol plaza, Katie turned her SwiftChair toward the sidewalk curb cut, gave my hand a warm squeeze between our chairs, and rolled side by side with Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and me toward the Dirksen Senate Office Building for our swearing-in open house in Room 511—where three newly badged twenty-four-year-old Senate staffers and two very proud guests from Southside Virginia were already waiting for us inside the front reception doors.

Standing beside the three adjacent workstations in the front suite of Dirksen Room 511 were Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins, wearing their crisp new blue-lanyard United States Senate staff identification badges over their suits: Sam as Legislative Correspondent for Transportation, Infrastructure, and Accessibility Policy; Mandy as Constituent Services Representative; and Sarah as Staff Assistant and Digital Accessibility Correspondent. And standing right behind them in his Sunday suit with his arm around Aunt Marge Callaway's shoulders was their maternal uncle, retired

Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway, who had ridden the morning train up to Washington with Marge to watch their kids start their congressional careers.

As Katie rolled her SwiftChair across the threshold and handed Sam, Mandy, and Sarah their official gold-embossed Senate onboarding folders, I watched Uncle Richard's eyes move slowly from the bronze *MS. PRAIRIE — VIRGINIA* nameplate outside the door to the three beaming twenty-four-year-old adults standing together behind their desks.

You could see all eleven years written across the old Republican floor leader's face in a single glance: the memory of February 2016, when he had nervously entrusted three recently rescued, terrified thirteen-year-old autistic House Pages to the Virginia General Assembly, and the thirty-year-old Delegate in a wheelchair who had parked her chair around them in a noisy corridor and made Richmond safe enough for them to grow up whole.

Now Katie was a United States Senator, and those three frightened thirteen-year-old Pages were professional congressional staffers on the fifth floor of the Dirksen Building.

Uncle Richard didn't make a grand floor speech. He just looked down at Katie in her SwiftChair, his voice catching slightly in his throat.

"All three?" Richard asked softly.

Katie looked up at him, mildly offended.

"Richard," my sister said. "Of course all three."

For two full seconds, the former Republican Majority Leader of the Virginia House of Delegates couldn't say a word. He just took off his glasses, wiped the corner of his eye with his thumb while Aunt Marge hugged Katie's shoulders, and rested a steady, grateful hand on the back of Sam's chair—proving to everyone in that room what Katie and I had known since the day we were born: nobody in our family ever gets left behind.

Part 3: The First Invite to Cocktails, A Known Side Effect of Death, & Home to Sunset Drive

Date: 2027-01-03 at 16:30 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 4:30 PM — The First Invite to Cocktails & "A Known Side Effect of Death"

"There she is—the newest Senator from the Commonwealth of Virginia!" Senator Arthur Harrington, the silver-haired senior chairman of the Appropriations Committee, boomed warmly across the gilded chandeliers and marble fireplace of the Mansfield Room just off the Senate floor. "Katie, bring your brother and your father over here! Waiter—three flutes of the French champagne for Senator Prairie and her family, and then we're heading downstairs to my hideaway office for twenty-year single-malt scotch and celebratory cigars on the West Front terrace!"

A tuxedoed catering steward immediately stepped between our two compact SwiftChairs with a polished silver tray balanced on his palm, lowering three crystal flutes of bubbling gold champagne toward Katie, Dad, and me.

Across the crowded reception room, half a dozen senior Senators and committee chairs raised their wine glasses and crystal tumblers, waiting for the freshman Senator from Virginia to take a flute and join the oldest social ritual on Capitol Hill.

Sitting beside my sister in my powerchair, I didn't even have to glance at her to know what both of us were remembering beneath the polite clink of Capitol crystal: the sour stench of gin on our mother's breath on the boat deck of the *Sunward Tropics* in August 2001; the bass-heavy thump of our cousin Brittany's drunken New Year's Eve party rattling the walls of our brick ranch off Military Highway on December 31, 2002; and two seventeen-year-old twins wedging a fifty-pound wheelchair frame against the inside of a locked bedroom door while we ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box, clinked two cold cans of ginger ale together at midnight, and swore we would never touch a drop of alcohol for the rest of our lives.

In a room full of powerful Washington politicians, however, a personal promise made at age seventeen was the kind of thing back-slapping colleagues always tried to talk you into breaking *"just this once."*

Fortunately for the three of us, biology and pharmacology had given Katie, Dad, and me an answer that no Senator in the United States Capitol could ever argue with.

Katie raised her left hand—calm, poised, and completely unbothered—stopping the waiter's silver tray six inches above her armrest.

"Thank you so much, Arthur, and thank you, sir, but please keep the champagne on the tray," Katie said clearly enough for the entire circle of Senators to hear. "My twin brother Nate, my father David, and I can't touch a single drop of alcohol—or go anywhere near cigar smoke or tobacco—for medical reasons."

Senator Harrington's genial smile paused mid-toast as he lowered his crystal tumbler half an inch. "Oh—nothing serious, I hope?"

"All three of us take daily prescription medication where mixing it with alcohol or tobacco has a known side effect of death," Katie replied with matter-of-fact serenity, her blue eyes steady and bright beneath the crystal chandelier.

Across the circle of velvet ropes and gilded mirrors, the silence was instantaneous.

Two committee chairs instinctively took a half-step back with their wine glasses, and Senator Harrington's eyes widened before he immediately gestured for the waiter to pull the champagne tray away.

"Good Lord—say no more, Katie!" Senator Harrington said quickly, waving a second steward over from the refreshment bar across the room. "No alcohol and no cigars anywhere near your family—I'll make sure the whip's office and the cloakroom staff know that permanently! What can we get for you, Nate, David, and your cousins right now?"

“Five glasses of ice-cold ginger ale would be wonderful, Arthur,” Dad said with a warm, easy smile, resting his hand on the back of Katie’s powerchair while Brittany and Chelsea stood right beside him. “That’s been the Prairie family toast for twenty-four years.”

Thirty seconds later, when the steward returned with five tall highball glasses filled with crushed ice and golden ginger ale, Senator Harrington and the surrounding Senators raised their glasses right alongside ours.

As Katie, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I clinked our glasses of ginger ale together in the center of the United States Capitol, Katie caught my eye across our armrests with the smallest, most triumphant glint of amusement. In a single sentence, my twin sister had just permanently exempted our entire household from every late-night Washington cocktail hour, wine-soaked donor reception, and smoke-filled backroom on Capitol Hill for the next six years.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 6:15 PM — Across the Potomac & Through the King Street Tunnel to Sunset Drive

At quarter past six that evening, while the winter sky over the National Mall deepened to indigo and the other newly sworn-in Senators climbed into waiting black town cars bound for Georgetown townhouses or Capitol Hill condominiums, Katie and I rolled out of the Capitol South elevator with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking right beside us, our five CapitalPass cards in hand.

Riding the Blue Line two stops to L’Enfant Plaza and transferring up to the southbound Yellow Line platform took less than ten minutes. As our silver Yellow Line train glided back out onto the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge high above the dark, glass-smooth waters of the Potomac River, the illuminated white dome of the Capitol receded behind us and the lights of Alexandria rose ahead on the Virginia shore.

“How does it feel, Senator?” I asked quietly over the hum of the traction motors as the train banked south past Washington National Airport toward Old Town. “Leaving the District behind on your very first night?”

“Like I can finally breathe,” Katie said, leaning her head back against her wheelchair headrest and letting out a long, contented sigh as the Yellow Line glided onto the elevated platform at King Street–Old Town Station. “Washington is where I work, Nate. Virginia is who we are.”

Exiting the station street elevator into the crisp thirty-eight-degree night air, Katie and I rolled past the glowing destination signs of the King Street Station bus loop—where BOLT and Capital Transit buses were idling at the sawtooth curbs—and turned west along the wide, flat concrete sidewalk of King Street with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking alongside us.

Immediately ahead of us stood the heavy dark-green steel girders and white-painted concrete retaining walls of the King Street railroad underpass, carrying the elevated tracks of both Alexandria Union Station and the King Street–Old Town Capital Transit station directly over the street.

As Katie and I guided our two SwiftChairs side by side along the sidewalk beneath the short railroad bridge with Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea walking at our side and emerged into the quiet residential glow on the west side of the tunnel, Dad's two-story Alexandria house rose right on the left where Sunset Drive met the hill.

It was a classic two-story red-brick Virginia house with black louvered shutters framing the multi-pane sash windows, two manicured round boxwood shrubs flanking a white columned front portico topped with a small white Chippendale railing, and a broad green lawn bordered by a shade tree just steps from the railroad overpass. Looking straight back over my shoulder from the front walkway, I could see the illuminated canopy of King Street–Old Town Capital Transit Station and the upper-level rail embankment of Alexandria Union Station right across the bridge.

Back home in Hampton Roads, Katie and I owned our primary residence fifty-fifty in the Kempsville section of Virginia Beach—the house where we claimed legal residency, where we were registered to vote, and where we paid our property taxes to the City of Virginia Beach. Dad, however, had owned this house on Sunset Drive long before Katie ever ran for the Virginia Beach City Council in 2010. The house was one hundred percent paid off and titled one hundred percent in Dad's name, giving Katie and me a permanent family roof in Northern Virginia whenever the Senate was in session so she could take the train into Washington for day trips and truthfully say she slept in the Commonwealth of Virginia every single night. Even better, we never had to publish a street number for reporters or curiosity-seekers—to everyone who knew us, it was simply Dad's house on Sunset Drive, tucked right on the other side of the tunnel with buses and trains at our doorstep.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 7:30 PM — The Vertical Platform Lift & Coding in Bedroom 4

"Home sweet Virginia," Dad said as he unlocked the white front door beneath the columned portico and held it open for Katie and me to roll inside over the flush threshold ramp.

When the three of us had worked with our Alexandria contractor that autumn to adapt the two-story Sunset Drive house for two full-time powerchair users, we had designed every square foot around both our accessibility needs and our privacy.

Here at the front of the first floor, directly behind the shuttered windows facing the sidewalk and the street, sat a traditional Colonial living room and dining room with a central hallway leading back to an accessible kitchen with roll-under countertops and a curbless roll-in bathroom. Anyone walking past the house on the street at night saw only warm table lamps, bookshelves, and a dining room table through the front windows.

Right alongside the central staircase in the hallway stood the engineering centerpiece that made a two-story historic brick house work for Katie and me: a quiet, enclosed through-floor residential vertical platform wheelchair lift linking the first floor directly to the second-floor landing.

After all five of us heated up bowls of chicken noodle soup and toasted sourdough bread in the kitchen for supper—with Katie, Dad, and me taking our evening prescription tablets with tall glasses of cold water while Brittany checked Chelsea's evening asthma inhaler and brewed two warm mugs of caffeine-free chamomile tea

so she and Chelsea could work on Chelsea's wooden lighthouse jigsaw puzzle at the dining room table—Katie rolled her SwiftChair to the hall lift gate and pressed the illuminated call button.

"Come on, Nate," Katie said, grinning over her shoulder even after sixteen hours awake since our 4:00 AM alarm in Virginia Beach. "Before we turn in, we still have to push the January 3rd schema update to our shared site network—and I want to test the new build in Quantum Studio 2026 while the night ARTS train rolls past the window."

While Dad walked up the central carpeted staircase to meet us on the upper landing, Katie and I rode the vertical platform lift one at a time up through the ceiling opening to the second-floor hallway and rolled past the three upstairs doors that completed our four-bedroom layout.

The first door on the left was Bedroom 2: officially designated on paper as our upstairs guest and cousin suite whenever congressional staffers, plumbers, or contractors ever saw the floor plan, neatly furnished with two twin beds, a cherrywood dresser, and a nightstand lamp—even though those upstairs mattresses went completely untouched every single night because all four cousins slept together downstairs in the ground-floor back master suite.

Across the hall was Bedroom 3, Dad's upstairs bedroom with his full-sized bed and reading chair.

And at the east end of the upstairs hallway, with two wide sash windows looking directly out over the shade tree and the steel railroad bridge toward the glowing platforms of King Street–Old Town and Alexandria Union Station, was Bedroom 4: our three-desk family office.

Having already changed out of her royal-blue Senate blazer into her favorite soft navy fleece pullover, the newly sworn-in United States Senator from Virginia rolled her powerchair right up to her dual-monitor workstation beside mine, while Dad settled into his ergonomic chair at the third desk in the corner to check his Monday morning remote-work queue.

For the next two hours, the only sounds in that warm upstairs room were the familiar, rhythmic click of three mechanical keyboards, the soft hum of our desktop towers, and the occasional distant rumble of a Capital Transit Yellow Line train or an ARTS locomotive gliding across the King Street bridge outside our window.

Side by side at our desks—just as we had coded together since learning HTML in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School in 1997, studying Dad's *Quantum Basic 6.0* textbooks with him in 2001, and copying the Web Applications Developer PHP and SQL curriculum onto our laptops at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in March 2007 to master it alongside Tina, Sheila, and Jim—Katie and I had Quantum Studio 2026, Quantum Code, and our PHP backend templates open across our monitors, maintaining and deploying updates to the network of websites and desktop applications that the two of us shared.

"Look at line two hundred fourteen in the router controller, Nate," Katie said happily, pointing at her screen as a northbound ARTS train whistled softly across the elevated embankment beyond the glass. "Five hours ago I was holding my hand on

the Constitution of the United States in the Old Senate Chamber, and right now I'm fixing a trailing array comma in PHP with my twin brother. Tell me any other Senator on Capitol Hill is having a better Sunday night than this."

"Not a single one of them, Katie," I laughed, compiling the build in Quantum Studio 2026 and watching the green deployment checkmarks light up across our shared server dashboard. "Though wait until you see who just requested an appropriations meeting on your Class II Senate calendar for next month: the Virginia Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services and the leadership of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville. They're coming to Washington to ask Virginia's new United States Senator for federal discretionary funding."

Katie paused her fingers over her keyboard, and a slow, razor-sharp smile curved across her lips as twenty years of memory flashed in her blue eyes.

"Put them right on the calendar, Nate," Katie said softly. "I can't wait to ask DARS and the director of RRC whether they're still forcing twenty-one-year-old wheelchair users with associate degrees to tour the auto shop, the woodworking shop, and the nursing school before pitching them on a partnership with ValueMart to be a door greeter. And while they're sitting across from our wheelchairs asking for federal tax dollars, we're going to ask them under oath about aides grabbing clients' push-handles, locking twin siblings into separate Level 2 wings, accusing them of sneaking into a closet to have sex and then backing down the second they offer to go home because of the headcount funding formula I suspected back when we were twenty-one, and escorting the guy who attacked Natalie out to a van without calling the police."

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 10:30 PM — The Private Ground-Floor Back Bedroom Four-Person Cuddle Nest

At ten-thirty, Dad shut down his remote-work laptop at the third desk, stood up with a gentle stretch, and kissed the top of Katie's head before resting a warm hand on my shoulder.

"Goodnight, Senator. Goodnight, Nate—tell Brittany and Chelsea goodnight for me downstairs," Dad said softly from the doorway of Bedroom 3 across the upstairs hall. "Sleep well, all four of you."

"Goodnight, Dad—love you," Katie and I said together.

One after the other, my sister and I took the interior vertical platform lift back down to the quiet first floor and rolled past the darkened front living room toward the rear of the house, where Brittany and Chelsea had already finished brushing their teeth and turned on the two warm amber bedside lamps.

Tucked into the private back corner of the ground floor—looking out only onto our high-fenced backyard garden and tall evergreens behind drawn blackout curtains—was the Master Bedroom.

We had deliberately chosen this room at the very back of the ground floor so that no passerby, reporter, or neighbor walking along the front sidewalk could ever peer through a street-facing window into our family's private sanctuary. Inside those four quiet walls, right beneath the framed watercolor print of blue butterflies we had carried up from Tidewater, stood the exact twin of the bed we had built on Arvin

Road and Lord Nelson Drive back in Virginia Beach: a custom solid-oak, wheelchair-transfer-height four-person cuddle nest platform bed topped with deep orthopedic mattresses, soft flannel sheets, bolstered side rails, and an oversized patchwork navy-and-cream quilt.

Rolling our two compact SwiftChairs parallel to the smooth oak transfer rail, Katie and I plugged our magnetic charger leads into our joystick ports until both battery indicators glowed steady amber—and as I glanced past the foot of our chairs toward the open bifold closet door, where our retired navy-blue sleeping bags sat neatly rolled on the top wooden shelf beneath Katie's pressed royal-blue Senate blazer, my chest warmed at how far the four of us had come. Ten winters earlier, before Brittany had climbed right into our sleeping bag on the Arvin Road closet floor—with newly rescued Chelsea cramming into the closet beside us too out of fear of Group Home Two-Face while Brittany patiently led all four of us through twenty-minute herbal-tea tries until February 11, 2017—Katie and I would have spent tonight zipped onto hard closet carpet over plywood in the dark.

Instead, moving with easy, practiced upper-body coordination, I locked my brakes, slid smoothly across the polished oak edge onto the center of the patchwork quilt in my grey plaid flannel pajamas, and helped Katie transfer onto the plush pillows to my left in her soft lavender knit sleepwear. On my right, Brittany set Chelsea's maintenance and rescue asthma inhalers neatly on the oak headboard shelf within easy reach, helped forty-four-year-old Chelsea snuggle happily against my right shoulder in her cream thermal pajamas, and then climbed into the nest beside Katie in her burgundy flannel pajamas—smiling through her thin silver wire-rimmed oval glasses as she wrapped a warm arm around Katie's shoulders and reached across to squeeze my hand.

Outside in the night, a late-night southbound train glided quietly over the King Street bridge just beyond the evergreens—heading south through Virginia toward Richmond and Norfolk along the exact steel rails that tied our whole life together.

"Big train day, Katie," Chelsea murmured sleepily, resting her cheek contentedly against my right shoulder while Katie curled close against my left side and laced her fingers tightly through mine. "Soft bed."

"Best day and the softest bed in Virginia, Chelsea," United States Senator Katie Prairie whispered happily against my shoulder as Brittany switched off the bedside lamp.

"Goodnight, Katie. Goodnight, Brittany. Goodnight, Chelsea," I whispered back, holding my family close as all four of us drifted off to sleep together on Sunset Drive.

Part 4: The Constituent Line in Room 511, 'Is Nathaniel Still With You?', & What Really Happened to Natalie

Date: 2027-01-14 at 16:15 America/New_York

Thursday, January 14, 2027, 4:15 PM — "United States Senator Katie Prairie's Office, This Is Katie Speaking"

"Line Four in the front reception room has been blinking on hold for forty-five seconds while Mandy is on Line One walking a Norfolk shipyard veteran through a Privacy Act casework release and Sarah is tied up on Lines Two and Three triaging constituent calls while Sam is downstairs in Dirksen 124 dropping off our rural transit memo with the Appropriations clerk," Katie said at quarter past four on Thursday afternoon—just eleven days after she had placed her left palm on the Constitution of the United States in the Old Senate Chamber—glancing up from the appropriations briefing binder on her mahogany desk in Room 511 of the Dirksen Senate Office Building.

When Katie had built her Class II Senate office from scratch after the November election, the very first three federal staff appointments she had made—with Uncle Richard and Aunt Marge Callaway's enthusiastic blessing—were twenty-four-year-old Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins. All three triplets were based together here in Dirksen Room 511 with their workstations arranged near one another, commuting in together every morning on Capital Transit with their CapitalPass cards and eating lunch together whenever they wanted without any supervisor ever arbitrarily separating them, while each thrived in their own distinct professional role: Sam as Legislative Correspondent for Transportation, Infrastructure, Disability Policy, and Rural Development; Mandy as Constituent Services Representative running Katie's predictable six-step federal casework checklist; and Sarah as Staff Assistant and Digital Accessibility Correspondent. And whenever any of them walked over to the Capitol for floor votes, they mentored the sixteen- and seventeen-year-old high-school juniors serving as United States Senate Pages with the exact same color-coded sticky notes and calm, literal instructions that had made Katie and me their safe harbor in Richmond when they were thirteen-year-old eighth-grade House Pages in 2016.

Sitting in my compact black SwiftChair right beside my twin sister's left armrest with my MagnaBook Pro open in front of me, I watched Katie reach over and press the flashing amber rollover button on her multi-line desk console. Ever since her first week on the Virginia Beach City Council seventeen years earlier, Katie had kept the same rule: if a constituent phone line rolled over to her desk while she was in the room, she picked up the receiver herself.

"United States Senator Katie Prairie's office, this is Katie speaking," my sister said warmly as she lifted the handset to her ear. "How can I help you today?"

Through the earpiece, I heard a sudden, startled intake of breath on the other end of the line, followed by the voice of an older Virginia woman speaking from a quiet living room.

"Wait—oh, my goodness," the woman stammered softly. "Is this really Senator Katie Prairie herself answering the telephone?"

"It is, ma'am," Katie smiled, resting her right forearm on her wheelchair armrest. "Every phone in this suite belongs to the people of Virginia. Who do I have the pleasure of speaking with?"

There was a long pause on the line—the sound of a sixty-eight-year-old mother steadying her breath after carrying a weight in her chest for twenty years.

“Senator Prairie, my name is Evelyn Brooks, and I’m calling from home here in Virginia on behalf of my forty-one-year-old daughter, Natalie,” the woman said quietly. “I hold full court-ordered legal Guardianship and Conservatorship over Natalie. You may not remember my daughter’s name after twenty years, Senator, because my husband and I know that you and your twin brother dropped out of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville after only about a week and a half back in March of 2007.”

Sitting beside Katie, I saw my sister’s entire body go completely still in her wheelchair.

Her blue eyes widened, and her left hand immediately reached across the gap between our two SwiftChairs and gripped my fingers so tightly her knuckles turned white.

“Did she just say *Natalie*?” I whispered, my heart slamming against my ribs as the cold mountain air of Thursday morning, March 15, 2007—and the sight of our sweet classmate sobbing and rocking back and forth on the concrete bench outside the RRC cafeteria—rushed back into the room as sharply as if it had happened yesterday.

“Mrs. Brooks,” Katie said into the receiver, her voice dropping an octave as emotion thickened in her throat, “I remember Natalie. I have never forgotten your daughter for a single day in twenty years. How did you know my brother and I were at RRC in March of 2007? We rolled out after twelve days—we never graduated, and we’ve never listed Fishersville on a single biography or resume.”

“Natalie told me, Senator,” Mrs. Brooks replied softly. “Back in October, when you were running for the United States Senate and your campaign commercials came on our living-room television showing you and your brother rolling side by side in your wheelchairs, Natalie sat bolt upright on the sofa and pointed right at the screen. As you know, Natalie is forty-one years old—the exact same age as the two of you—though because of her developmental disability, she has always had the mind and understanding of a six- or seven-year-old child. When she saw your face on the television, she said to me, *‘Mommy, look! That’s Katie and her twin brother from the computer class at the dorms! They were only there for about a week, and she had a white bandage on her nose, and she held my hand by the cafeteria when my tummy hurt before they went away!’* When I looked up your old 2007 dates and called one of the other mothers from that semester, I found out that you and your brother had packed up and left RRC the very same Friday I drove up to Fishersville to bring Natalie home.”

Katie closed her eyes for a second, a single tear slipping down her cheek as she held my hand.

“Senator Prairie…” Mrs. Brooks hesitated on the line, her voice trembling slightly. “Is your twin brother Nathaniel still with you?”

“Yes, ma’am,” Katie answered immediately, looking straight into my eyes across our armrests. “Nate is my Chief of Staff, and he is sitting in his wheelchair right beside me.”

“If he is in the office with you right now,” Mrs. Brooks said, her voice steady and quiet with a mother’s resolve, “please put me on speakerphone, Senator. What I have to tell you is graphic and deeply disturbing, and I have cried over it every night for twenty years—but you and Nathaniel were there in Barton Hall that week, and I want Nathaniel to hear the whole story too.”

On Speakerphone With Evelyn Brooks — The Night of March 14, 2007 & How Fishersville Buried a Crime

“You’re on speakerphone now, Mrs. Brooks, and the door to our office is closed,” Katie said gently, setting the handset back into its cradle as the red speakerphone indicator glowed between our two wheelchairs. “I’m right here, and Nate is right beside me.”

“Hello, Mrs. Brooks,” I said softly toward the console, keeping both of my hands wrapped around Katie’s. “Katie and I are both listening. Please take all the time you need.”

“Thank you, Nathaniel,” Mrs. Brooks said over the speaker, and in the background we could hear the faint, quiet hum of a television turned down low in her Virginia living room. “Before I tell you what happened to my little girl after the two of you saw her outside the cafeteria that Thursday morning, I want you to know that when we sent Natalie to Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in early 2007 for the basic food-service and life-skills track, DARS promised my late husband and me on a stack of brochures that Barton Hall was a twenty-four-hour supervised, segregated sanctuary. They knew from Natalie’s medical and guardianship chart that cognitively she is a first-grader—she trusts adults who tell her they are supposed to be somewhere, she cannot consent to sexual contact under Virginia law, and she did not even have the adult vocabulary to know what sexual intercourse was.”

Beside me, Katie’s jaw clenched so hard a muscle jumped along her cheek.

“On the night of Wednesday, March 14, 2007,” Mrs. Brooks continued, her voice shaking as she spoke the words into the quiet Senate office, “Natalie was already in her cotton nightgown inside her room on the women’s wing of Barton Hall after the staff reassigned her former roommate to another hall. As you two saw firsthand that night, the Center’s housing database scrambled the male and female room assignments, and instead of stopping to check the gender roster, the front-desk staff blindly handed out active plastic room keycards that unlocked doors on the women’s wing to male students.”

“Including Chris,” I said quietly, my stomach knotting into cold iron as I remembered watching through my laptop webcam as Chris stood in Katie’s doorway waving a reassigned keycard just twenty-four hours after breaking Katie’s nose open and tearing her swimsuit top in the therapeutic pool.

“His full name was Christopher Vance, and he had already been written up twice for sexually aggressive behavior toward female students before Tuesday’s incident in the pool with you, Senator,” Mrs. Brooks said. “At nine o’clock that Wednesday night—ten minutes before he walked down the hall and used his keycard on your door, Katie—he used that Center-issued keycard to unlock the door to Natalie’s room.”

Katie pressed her free hand over her mouth, tears spilling over her eyelashes as Mrs. Brooks's voice cracked on the speakerphone.

"When the door clicked open, Natalie thought it was a dorm counselor checking the room," Mrs. Brooks whispered, fighting through tears. "When she asked him why a boy was in her room, he locked the deadbolt from the inside, told her the front desk had assigned him to her bed, and shoved her down onto the mattress. When she tried to scream for help, he clamped his hand over her mouth and nose until she couldn't breathe, tore her nightgown off, and violently raped my daughter on that dormitory bed. Because Natalie only has the mind of a little child, she didn't even understand what he was doing to her body—she only knew that he was crushing her chest, that she was bleeding, and that the part of his body he used to hurt her felt like she was being torn apart inside. Before he unlocked the door and walked down the hall toward your room, Senator, he told her that if she came out of her room before morning, he would come back with his keycard and kill her. So my terrified child lay curled in a ball on those blood-soaked sheets in the dark all night long without sleeping a single minute."

Across our armrests, Katie was crying silently, her fingers trembling inside mine while a cold, white-hot fury rose behind my eyes.

"On Thursday morning at six-fifteen, when the sun came up, Natalie finally limped out toward the cafeteria in her clothes to find her friends—which is when the two of you, Tina, and Sarah saw her sobbing on the concrete bench outside the dining hall," Mrs. Brooks said. "You remember what she kept repeating through her tears?"

"That thing… he pees from…" I whispered, the exact words from twenty years ago echoing verbatim in my ears.

"Yes, Nathaniel," Mrs. Brooks wept softly. "That was the only way her seven-year-old mind knew how to describe what had been done to her. Her friends led her straight from that bench to the campus clinic at seven o'clock in the morning because she was bleeding through her jeans and crying from severe internal pain. And what Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center's administration did over the next twenty-four hours is something I will never forgive as long as I live."

Mrs. Brooks drew a long, ragged breath on the speakerphone.

"When the clinic nurse saw the blood and bruising and heard what Natalie said, the nurse notified the Center Director's office at seven-fifteen," Mrs. Brooks said, her voice turning hard and clear through her grief. "Under any standard of basic human decency, they should have dialed 911 immediately, called the Virginia State Police and the Augusta County Sheriff's Office, called me and my husband, and transported Natalie two miles up Route 250 to the emergency room at Augusta Medical Center for emergency medical treatment and a forensic sexual assault examination. They did none of those things. Because the administrators realized immediately that if State Police troopers and a forensic ambulance rolled onto campus, an investigation would expose that their own staff had handed a known predator a keycard to the women's wing twenty-four hours after he broke your nose in the pool—and that a violent felony rape had occurred inside a state-run dormitory."

“So at seven-fifty that morning,” Katie said, her voice shaking with cold outrage as the pieces locked together, “while Nate, Tina, Sarah, and I were rolling from the cafeteria to Mr. Alderman’s classroom, we watched two RRC staffers escort Chris out to a passenger van by the front gate with his duffel bag—without a single police car in sight.”

“They drove him straight to the bus station in Staunton, bought him a one-way ticket out of Augusta County with petty cash, and logged his departure as a voluntary administrative withdrawal so his name wouldn’t trigger a state critical-incident audit,” Mrs. Brooks confirmed. “Meanwhile, while they were putting her rapist on a bus, they kept my bleeding, traumatized daughter locked inside a back observation room of the campus infirmary all day Thursday without calling a hospital or the police. While she was in the infirmary, residential housekeeping staff stripped her dormitory bed in Barton Hall and ran her bloodied sheets and nightgown through the industrial laundry with bleach. And at four-thirty on Thursday afternoon—nine and a half hours after Natalie walked into that clinic—a residential administrator finally called our house, lied to my face that Natalie was having a ‘severe behavioral adjustment episode and acute homesickness,’ and told me I needed to drive up to Fishersville on Friday morning to take her home.”

In Room 511, my knuckles were white around Katie’s hand. Neither of us could speak for a moment.

“When I arrived at Barton Hall at ten o’clock on Friday morning, March 16, 2007—just a few hours before you and Nathaniel left for Luray with your classmate Tina—staff rushed Natalie out the front doors with her suitcases already packed and didn’t hand me a single medical chart,” Mrs. Brooks continued. “Thirty-five minutes down Interstate 64, Natalie was whimpering and crying so badly in the passenger seat because it hurt her to sit down that I pulled off at a rest area, took her into the handicapped stall of the restroom, and saw that she was still bleeding through her clothes and covered in dark handprint bruises across her thighs and ribs. I drove straight to the nearest hospital emergency room.”

Mrs. Brooks’s voice broke again, and she paused for three seconds to steady herself.

“The emergency room physician and the forensic nurse examiner documented multiple internal lacerations and bruising consistent with a violent, forcible sexual assault roughly thirty-six to forty hours earlier,” Mrs. Brooks said quietly. “When the hospital called the police and detectives went to Fishersville on Saturday morning, the Center had already bleached the bedding, sanitized the dorm room, sent the perpetrator out of the county without recording a forwarding address, and referred the detectives to DARS legal counsel in Richmond—who immediately threw up Title 34, Section 361.38 of the Code of Federal Regulations, claiming federal Vocational Rehabilitation privacy rules barred them from turning over any student rosters or disciplinary files without a federal court order. By the time our attorney fought through six months of bureaucratic stonewalling, the Commonwealth’s Attorney told us that RRC’s thirty-six-hour cover-up and laundry bleach had destroyed the physical DNA evidence chain they needed to prosecute. For the last twenty years, Natalie has slept with a hallway light on inside my house, terrified whenever a door lock clicks shut.”

Katie wiped the tears from her cheeks with the back of her wrist, her blue eyes blazing like blue steel in the late-afternoon light of Dirksen Room 511.

“Mrs. Brooks,” Katie said, her voice steady, fierce, and absolute, “next month, the Commissioner of DARS and the new Director of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center are coming to this exact room—and then testifying before my Senate Appropriations Subcommittee—to ask for eighteen and a half million dollars in federal funding.”

“I know they are, Senator,” Mrs. Brooks said softly. “Our family attorney saw the Subcommittee schedule published in the federal register on Monday. This morning, in front of a notary public, I executed a formal constituent complaint to your office along with a complete HIPAA and Title 34, Section 361.38 privacy release under my court-ordered Guardianship and Conservatorship, attached to the certified March 16, 2007 hospital emergency room forensic report and the Augusta County Sheriff’s Office incident file. An overnight courier is delivering the sealed packet to Room 511 at nine o’clock tomorrow morning. For twenty years, those bureaucrats hid behind federal privacy laws to protect their funding and bury what they did to my daughter. Now the two students who walked out of Barton Hall that week are sitting in the United States Senate.”

Right then, a gentle, childlike forty-one-year-old voice spoke up from the sofa beside Mrs. Brooks on the other end of the line:

“Hi, Katie! Hi, Nate! Did your nose get all better from the swimming pool?”

My throat closed up completely, and beside me, a fresh tear rolled down Katie’s cheek even as she smiled warmly toward the speakerphone as if Natalie could see her through the wire.

“Hi, Natalie,” Katie said softly, her voice full of the gentlest warmth in the world. “Yes, sweetie, my nose got all better—and Nate is sitting right here holding my hand, just like he always does.”

“Hi, Natalie,” I said gently into the microphone. “It is so good to hear your voice.”

“Mrs. Brooks,” Katie said, her voice ringing with quiet, unbreakable steel, “when DARS and Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center walk into Room 511 on Tuesday, February sixteenth, they aren’t going to know that my brother and I are the two twelve-day March 2007 dropouts in their files—or that your signed guardianship waiver and hospital records are sitting right on my desk. And on Thursday morning, February eighteenth, at ten o’clock in Room 124 of the Dirksen Building, I want you and Natalie sitting right in the very front row of the Subcommittee hearing gallery when I put the truth into the permanent *Congressional Record* of the United States and freeze every single federal dollar they came to ask for.”

“We will be in the front row at ten o’clock sharp, Senator Prairie,” Evelyn Brooks whispered through her tears. “Thank you—both of you—for not forgetting my little girl.”

Friday, January 15, 2027, 9:00 AM — The Overnight Courier Package, The Redacted Pool Report, & Natalie's Drawing

At nine o'clock sharp the next morning, after clearing the Senate Sergeant at Arms off-site courier screening facility, a thick, tamper-sealed cardboard overnight envelope addressed to *The Honorable Katie Prairie, United States Senate — PERSONAL & CONFIDENTIAL CONSTITUENT CASEWORK* arrived at the front reception desk of Room 511.

Our legislative director, Sarah—who had sat right beside Katie, Tina, and me in Mr. Alderman's Web Applications Developer classroom at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in March of 2007, and had stood right beside our wheelchairs outside the cafeteria on that cold Thursday morning when Natalie was sobbing on the concrete bench—carried the sealed package into Katie's inner office and closed the heavy mahogany door behind her.

"It just came in from the courier room," Sarah said quietly, setting the package on the desk blotter in front of our two compact SwiftChairs.

Katie slid her letter opener under the tamper-evident tape, pulled out a thick stack of certified documents bound in a green constituent casework folder, and spread the pages across the mahogany desktop so that she, Sarah, and I could read them side by side.

Even after everything Mrs. Brooks had told us over the speakerphone the afternoon before, seeing the twenty-year-old paper trail in stark black and white made the air in the room feel like ice.

On top sat the certified Virginia Circuit Court order appointing Evelyn Brooks as full legal Guardian and Conservator over her adult daughter, Natalie Brooks, clipped directly to a freshly notarized HIPAA medical release and a Title 34, Section 361.38 Vocational Rehabilitation Confidentiality Waiver explicitly authorizing United States Senator Katie Prairie, her Chief of Staff Nathaniel Prairie, and the Senate Committee on Appropriations to inspect, disclose, and enter into the permanent *Congressional Record* every document relating to Natalie's residency at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center.

Beneath the waiver lay the certified hospital Emergency Department admission record and Sexual Assault Nurse Examiner forensic report dated Friday, March 16, 2007, at 12:15 PM—just two hours after Mrs. Brooks had picked Natalie up at Barton Hall and thirty-five minutes after she had pulled off Interstate 64 at the rest area.

In clinical, unsparing medical detail, the emergency room physician and the forensic nurse had charted the contusions on Natalie's jaw where a hand had been clamped over her mouth and nose, the dark handprint bruises across her ribs and inner thighs, and the acute internal lacerations suffered thirty-six to forty hours earlier on the night of Wednesday, March 14, 2007, while noting that the patient—a twenty-one-year-old woman with the cognitive age of a six-to-seven-year-old child—kept repeating through tears that a boy who unlocked her dorm room door with a plastic keycard had hurt her and threatened to kill her if she came out before morning.

I turned to the third tab in the folder: the supplemental investigative report filed by an Augusta County Sheriff's Office detective on Saturday, March 17, 2007, after the emergency room physician made the mandatory felony law-enforcement notification.

"Look at paragraph four of the detective's narrative," I said quietly, pointing my finger at the photocopied police report so Katie and Sarah could read the lines beside me.

When two Sheriff's Office detectives had driven out to Fishersville on Saturday morning to secure Dormitory Room 142 on the women's wing of Barton Hall, they had discovered that RRC housekeeping staff had stripped the bed on Thursday morning and washed the bloodied sheets and torn nightgown in industrial laundry bleach while Natalie was being held inside a back room of the campus infirmary all day Thursday without a single phone call to 911, the State Police, or Augusta Medical Center. Worse still, the detective noted that the suspect—identified by students as twenty-two-year-old residential client Christopher Vance—had been escorted by two Center staffers into an agency passenger van at 7:50 AM on Thursday, March 15, driven to the bus station in Staunton, and given a one-way bus ticket out of the county with no forwarding address logged in the front-desk ledger.

Then Sarah turned the page to the April 2007 correspondence from the Office of the General Counsel at the Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services in Richmond—and her breath caught in her throat.

"Katie… Nate, look at this attachment," Sarah whispered, her finger trembling against a heavily redacted single-page incident summary that DARS legal counsel had begrudgingly produced after six months of stonewalling the Brooks family's attorney behind Title 34, Section 361.38.

At the top of the page was a one-line log of prior campus behavioral complaints involving Christopher Vance before the night of Wednesday, March 14, 2007. Right above Wednesday night's entry was a heavily blacked-out line dated Tuesday, March 13, 2007, at 4:10 PM:

> Therapeutic Pool Incident: Client C. Vance involved in physical contact in natatorium with female Level 2 client [REDACTED UNDER 34 C.F.R. § 361.38 — STATUS 28 DROPOUT], resulting in nasal epistaxis and damaged swimwear; male sibling [REDACTED UNDER 34 C.F.R. § 361.38 — STATUS 28 DROPOUT] cited by pool staff for unauthorized physical contact and subsequently cited at 23:15 for unauthorized opposite-gender occupancy of locked seasonal storage closet.

Katie stared down at the two black magic-marker bars covering her name and mine.

"That's us," Katie whispered, her voice barely audible in the quiet office. "Under the two black bars on that page… that's you and me, Nate."

"They knew on Tuesday afternoon that he had just broken your nose open and ripped your swimsuit top off in the pool," I said, my voice shaking with cold fury as I looked at the blacked-out lines. "And instead of expelling him and calling the police on Tuesday, they wrote *us* up for covering your chest and for hiding in the seasonal storage closet in our street clothes so you wouldn't have to be separated from me—left him on campus, handed him a scrambled keycard to the women's wing on Wednesday night so he could unlock Natalie's door and rape her, and then

used the exact same federal privacy law to black out our names as Status 28 dropouts so Natalie's mother and the Sheriff's Office couldn't even contact us as witnesses!"

Sarah wiped a tear from the corner of her eye behind her glasses. "If the Brooks family's lawyer had known back in 2007 who the two redacted Status 28 dropouts under those black bars were, Katie, you and I and Nate and Tina would have testified in a heartbeat."

Then Katie lifted the final loose sheet tucked inside the front pocket of the green folder—and all three of us went completely quiet.

It was a single piece of heavy white drawing paper. Drawn across the center in bright wax crayons were two smiling stick-figure twins with yellow hair sitting side by side in black wheelchairs holding hands next to a smiling girl wearing a pink bow in her hair. Across the top of the page, written carefully in big purple crayon block letters by a forty-one-year-old woman whose mind had remained seven years old forever, were six words:

> THANK YOU KATIE AND NATE

Katie held that crayon drawing in both hands for a long moment, her shoulders trembling once before she carefully slipped it into a clear archival protector at the very front of the green constituent casework folder.

Then my twin sister unlocked her wheelchair brakes, turned her SwiftChair toward mine, reached across our armrests, and pulled me into a tight, fierce, two-arm hug—resting her forehead against my shoulder while I wrapped both arms around her back and held her with all the soothing deep pressure I had in me.

When Katie finally sat back and looked up at Sarah and me, every trace of tears was gone, replaced by the calm, surgical focus that had terrified unprepared bureaucrats from City Hall in Virginia Beach to the Capitol in Richmond.

"Sarah," Katie said quietly, resting her hand on top of the green constituent folder, "confirm the appointment with DARS Commissioner Marcus Sterling and RRC Director Evelyn Cross for Tuesday, February sixteenth, at two o'clock right here in Room 511—the afternoon before they testify on Wednesday morning in front of our Appropriations Subcommittee in Room 124."

"Do you want me to send them an advance agenda of the questions you're going to ask?" Sarah asked, uncapping her pen.

"Not a single word," Katie replied, locking the green constituent folder inside her top desk drawer and slipping the brass key into her blazer pocket as she took my hand across our wheelchair armrests. "Neither of them worked at Fishersville in 2007, and neither of them has any idea who the two redacted Status 28 dropouts on this page are. Let them walk in here with their glossy eighteen-point-five-million-dollar funding binder thinking they can deny everything and hide behind Title 34, Section 361.38—right before Nate and I introduce ourselves."

Part 5: 34 C.F.R. Section 361.38, Two Twelve-Day Dropouts in Room 511, & Strings Attached at the Subcommittee Hearing

Date: 2027-02-16 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, February 16, 2027, 2:00 PM — Making Them Squirm Behind 34 C.F.R. Section 361.38 in Dirksen Room 511

“Senator Prairie, on behalf of the Virginia Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services and the entire executive leadership team down in Fishersville, it is such an honor to welcome a champion of the disability community to the Senate Appropriations Committee,” Commissioner Marcus Sterling beamed across the polished mahogany desk of Room 511 in the Dirksen Senate Office Building, sliding a glossy spiral-bound presentation book toward Katie’s wheelchair while the new director of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center, Dr. Evelyn Cross, nodded eagerly beside him.

Sitting in my compact black SwiftChair right beside my twin sister’s left armrest with my MagnaBook Pro open on the corner of the desk and Katie’s legislative director, Sarah, seated with her legal pad to our right, I watched the two state agency executives settle back into their leather visitor chairs.

Neither Commissioner Sterling nor Director Cross had worked in Fishersville twenty years earlier in March of 2007; both were newly appointed career administrators who had taken over their roles within the past three years. Better still, neither of them had the faintest idea that the forty-one-year-old United States Senator sitting across from them—or her twin brother beside her—had ever set foot on the campus of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center.

Why would they? On every campaign biography, on our software company’s corporate profile, and in the official *Congressional Directory* of the One Hundred Twentieth Congress, both Katie and I listed the exact same two academic credentials we had actually earned: an Advanced Studies Diploma from Virginia Beach City Public Schools at Northwood High School in June 2003, and an Associate of Applied Science degree from the Community College of Hampton Roads in December 2006.

We never listed Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center on a resume because, technically, Katie and I were RRC dropouts. We had rolled out of Barton Hall after twelve days in March 2007 without completing the program, without sitting for an exit interview, and without earning a certificate—and not long after we had returned home to our house on Arvin Road in Virginia Beach and worked on a few of the copied classroom modules unofficially from home, we had decided to stop bothering with RRC’s rigid exercises altogether and start doing our own thing.

“As you’ll see on page four of our briefing packet, Senator,” Director Cross said smoothly, tapping a color photograph of the flat-roofed red-brick dormitories along Roosevelt Avenue in Fishersville, “we are asking your office to sponsor an eighteen-point-five-million-dollar Congressionally Directed Spending request in this week’s Labor, Health and Human Services, and Education Appropriations Subcommittee markup. The funds will support residential dormitory administration in Barton Hall and Cantor Hall, expand our two-week Vocational Evaluation intake division in the Bates-Harding Building, and fund our administrative compliance office.”

Katie didn't even open the glossy spiral binder. Resting her hands calmly on the armrests of her SwiftChair, she looked straight across the mahogany desk at Director Cross and Commissioner Sterling.

"Before we talk about eighteen and a half million federal tax dollars, Director Cross, I have a few specific operational questions about how Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center treats the adults who check into Barton Hall," Katie said in a mild, conversational tone. "Let's say a twenty-one-year-old twin brother and sister—both full-time wheelchair users with progressive neuromuscular weakness, and both already holding accredited Associate of Applied Science degrees in information technology from the Community College of Hampton Roads—arrive at your center specifically to take the Web Applications Developer course in server-side PHP and SQL."

Beside me, I saw Director Cross blink once, her polite smile freezing slightly at the corners.

"First," Katie continued evenly, "when those two twenty-one-year-old wheelchair users roll up to the Barton Hall counter or walk down the hallway of the Bates-Harding Building, do your residential aides and vocational evaluation staff still walk up behind them and grab the rear push-handles of their wheelchairs to shove them around without asking permission—and then threaten to write the clients up as aggressive when they tell the staff to take their hands off their chairs?"

"Well—Senator, certainly our staff are trained to assist mobility-impaired clients—" Director Cross began.

"Second," Katie pressed on without letting her pivot, "why would two twenty-one-year-old wheelchair users who already hold accredited associate degrees in computer science be forced to spend two weeks in Vocational Evaluation touring the auto mechanics shop, the woodworking shop, and the nursing assistant lab—and then be told by an evaluator that if software engineering proves too taxing, the Center has a wonderful partnership with the Waynesboro ValueMart to train a college-degreed woman in a wheelchair to sit by the sliding doors as a ValueMart door greeter?"

Across the desk, Commissioner Sterling shifted uncomfortably in his leather chair, glancing sideways at Director Cross.

"Third," Katie said, her blue eyes sharp and unblinking, "let's say those twins test out of your two-week Vocational Evaluation in a single week so they can start the Web Applications Developer class—where every student has to bring a personal laptop because VITA has locked the state desktop computers down so tightly on a seven-year-old operating system that nobody can even start a local web server. Because moving to Cantor Hall is part of earning Level 3, and they haven't been on campus long enough to earn Level 3, they remain stuck in Barton Hall on Level 2—forced to beg for signed yellow paper Hall Passes just to catch the local bus, and forced onto separate men's and women's wings every night at eleven o'clock."

Director Cross's cheeks flushed pink, and she cleared her throat. "Senator Prairie, if someone has shared an anecdote with your office—"

"I'm not finished, Director," Katie said calmly. "Suppose on their ninth afternoon on campus, a male classmate assaults the twin sister in the therapeutic pool—splitting the skin across the bony bridge of her nose, causing a heavy nosebleed, and tearing

her swimsuit top so that Student Health nurses have to pull the split bridge of her nose together with sterile MedStrip wound-closure strips and tape a white gauze bandage across her nose that she has to wear for seven straight days—and when her twin brother uses his hands on the pool deck to cover her bare chest until someone brings a towel, your poolside staffer writes him up for inappropriate contact. And when the traumatized sister—with fresh white tape and MedStrips across her swollen nose—doesn't want to be separated from her twin brother that night, so at ten-forty-five they slip down a darkened hallway from the Rec Hall in their street clothes and lock themselves inside a seasonal storage closet using lumpy bags of curtains as pillows, your night supervisor unlocks the door with a master key after the eleven-o'clock curfew check, automatically accuses a twin brother and sister in full street clothes of sneaking into a closet to have sex, and threatens to kick them out of the Center—until the twins call his bluff and dare him to call their father in Alexandria right then and there to come pick them up, at which point the supervisor backs down because losing two full-time residential students would hurt the Center's headcount funding, while the counseling staff prepares to slap them with a Level 1 restriction and a mandatory sibling separation contract."

In the quiet mahogany-paneled Senate office, you could have heard a pin drop.

Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross squirmed visibly in their chairs, exchanging a bewildered, increasingly uneasy look across the corner of the desk.

"Senator Prairie," Director Cross said slowly, her brow furrowing as she looked from Katie's face to mine and back again, "with all due respect… why are you being so oddly specific about a twenty-year-old incident? You're reciting the exact color of our Level 2 Hall Passes in Barton Hall, VITA's old desktop permissions in the computer lab, a Waynesboro ValueMart door-greeter pitch, MedStrip wound-closure strips under a seven-day nasal bandage from Student Health, and even plastic bags of curtains inside a seasonal storage closet at ten-forty-five at night. None of that would ever appear in a Senate briefing book—or even on a standard state incident form. How could you possibly know all of that?"

"And frankly, Senator," Commissioner Sterling jumped in, his voice tightening with a mixture of confusion and alarm as he tried to figure out who could have briefed her, "I don't understand why we are even talking about an oddly hyperspecific anecdote from March of 2007 when neither Dr. Cross nor I was employed at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center twenty years ago, and when our administration has no knowledge whatsoever of any twin siblings ever being treated in the manner you just described. Furthermore, even if someone claiming to be a former client from 2007 contacted your office with those allegations, you know our hands are tied by federal law. Under Title 34, Section 361.38 of the Code of Federal Regulations governing the State Vocational Rehabilitation Services Program, all personal client case files, disciplinary logs, and vocational evaluation records are strictly confidential. We are legally prohibited from confirming, denying, or discussing any individual client's personal file—even with a United States Senator—without an explicit written privacy release signed by the former clients themselves."

Katie let the silence hang across the mahogany desk for five full seconds, watching the two executives squirm behind their federal privacy statute while they thought they had successfully walled off the question.

Then Katie reached across our wheelchair armrests, laced her fingers through mine, and looked Director Cross and Commissioner Sterling dead in the eye.

“You don’t need to worry about violating Title 34, Section 361.38 of the Code of Federal Regulations, Commissioner Sterling,” Katie said softly. “Because the twenty-one-year-old twin brother and sister in those March 2007 Barton Hall files are sitting right across this desk from you.”

Every drop of color drained out of Director Cross’s face. Commissioner Sterling’s jaw literally dropped open.

“My twin brother Nathaniel and I checked into Barton Hall on Sunday, March 4, 2007, and we rolled out twelve days later after watching how your center operated,” Katie said, her voice steady and cold as steel. “We were never interested in the rehabilitation part of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center—we only came to Fishersville for the Web Applications Developer class, and we fully intended to treat your center like college: go to class, sleep in the dorm, and be done with it. We were not prepared for the juvenile rules, or the mandatory Vocational Evaluation, or being talked down to like children. In your DARS computer database in Richmond, the junior United States Senator from Virginia and her twin brother are officially coded as Status 28 unsuccessful rehabilitation dropouts—because after we rolled out of Barton Hall and spent a few days working on the copied PHP modules from our house in Virginia Beach, we decided to stop wasting our time on your modules and build our own software company instead of becoming a ValueMart door greeter. And right here, across this desk, Nathaniel and I waive our confidentiality.”

“S-Senator Prairie,” Commissioner Sterling stammered, his hand trembling against his briefing binder, “we had no idea—your official biography only lists the Community College of Hampton Roads—”

“Because we didn’t graduate from Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center—we dropped out after twelve days when we saw what a bureaucratic circus it was,” I said evenly from my wheelchair beside Katie. “And wait until you hear why our Thursday morning Level 1 restriction meeting with our counselor never happened on March 15, 2007.”

Katie reached to her right, picked up the thick manila constituent casework folder that had arrived by courier a month earlier after our January phone call with Evelyn Brooks, and laid it open directly on top of Director Cross’s glossy funding brochure.

“On Wednesday night, March 14, 2007,” Katie said, tapping the sworn affidavit clipped inside the folder, “your dorm database was scrambled, and your front-desk staff blindly followed the computer printout and handed out room keycards that put men into women’s rooms. The exact same male student who broke my nose in your therapeutic pool on Tuesday afternoon used a reassigned keycard to enter the women’s wing, where he raped our classmate Natalie—a chronologically adult woman who has the cognitive capacity of a young child. And on Thursday, March 15, 2007, while your counseling wing canceled our ten-o’clock closet write-up meeting because the housing roster was in chaos, your administration put Natalie’s rapist into a passenger van at seven-fifty in the morning and escorted him off the property without calling the police, held a bleeding, traumatized young woman inside your campus infirmary all day without a forensic exam while washing her dormitory bedsheets in the campus laundry, and lied to her mother that she was merely having a homesickness episode—sweeping a violent campus rape under the rug so it wouldn’t appear on a state incident report.”

“Senator,” Director Cross whispered, her voice shaking, “again, under federal confidentiality rules, we could never discuss another client’s—”

“Read the top page of that folder, Director Cross,” Katie said flatly. “Natalie’s mother, Evelyn Brooks, holds full legal Guardianship and Conservatorship over Natalie under the laws of the Commonwealth of Virginia. Last month, after Natalie recognized my brother and me on television from our week and a half in Fishersville and watched my swearing-in ceremony, Mrs. Brooks called this office directly and filed an official constituent complaint against Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center and DARS with her United States Senator—complete with the hospital emergency room records from March 16, 2007 and a notarized HIPAA and 34 C.F.R. Section 361.38 privacy waiver signed by Natalie’s mother as her legal guardian and conservator. And both Natalie and her mother will be sitting in the front row of Room 124 on Wednesday morning when the two of you testify under oath before the Appropriations Subcommittee.”

Neither Commissioner Sterling nor Director Cross said another word. Gathering up their briefcases with visibly shaking hands—and forgetting their glossy spiral-bound funding book on the corner of Katie’s desk—the two executives practically stumbled backward out of Room 511. Through the open doorway of our outer reception suite, Sarah, Katie, and I heard both of them frantically pulling out their phones before they even reached the fifth-floor elevators, speed-dialing their superiors in Richmond and the records office in Fishersville to beg for guidance.

Watching the heavy oak door click shut behind them, I looked over at Katie and Sarah. “Ten bucks says the two of them are already trying to figure out how to bail on Wednesday morning’s Subcommittee hearing and drive straight back to Richmond.”

Less than an hour later—while Katie, Sarah, and I were sitting around the mahogany desk finalizing our five-page statutory appropriations rider—the red light on Line One of Katie’s desk phone flashed.

Having served across Capitol Square from the Governor’s Mansion during her years in the General Assembly, the Governor’s Chief of Staff, Arthur Lawrence, knew exactly who Katie Prairie was, knew that I was always right beside her, and knew that she almost always answered her direct office line herself.

Katie reached over and pressed the speakerphone button. “Senator Katie Prairie.”

“Katie—Senator Prairie—it’s Arthur Lawrence in the Governor’s Office in Richmond,” the Chief of Staff’s voice came through the speaker grille in full, breathless damage-control mode. “Is Nate there at the desk with you?”

“I’m right here, Arthur,” I answered.

“Good,” Lawrence said grimly. “I have Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross conferenced in on this line from their parked car in Washington because I want them to hear every word of this directly. Forty minutes ago, after they walked out of your office and called the Secretary of Health and Human Resources in a panic, I personally ordered DARS General Counsel in Richmond and the records custodian in Fishersville to pull the unredacted March 2007 paper archive from the vault. Everything you and Nate told them—every single word about Barton Hall, the Tuesday afternoon pool assault, the two blacked-out Status 28 dropout lines on the April 2007 summary, and the Thursday morning van to the Staunton bus station—is

sitting on my desk right now in black and white. The Governor is livid, and on behalf of the Commonwealth, I cannot tell you how sorry we are for what happened to Natalie Brooks and for how the two of you were treated twenty years ago."

"Save the apology for Natalie and her mother in Room 124 tomorrow morning, Arthur," Katie said evenly. "Why are Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross sitting in a parked car instead of reading our statutory reform checklist?"

"Because ten minutes ago, Senator, both of them asked the Secretary and me for permission to pull out of tomorrow morning's Subcommittee witness panel and drive straight back to Richmond tonight," Lawrence admitted flatly—before his voice hardened into a thunderclap aimed straight at the two state executives on the conference line. "And as I just told both of you before we dialed the Senator's direct line—and as I am repeating right now in front of Senator Prairie and Nate—you are out of your minds if you think the Governor of Virginia is letting either of you run back to Richmond! Do you have any idea what happens if the Commissioner of DARS and the Director of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center pull a no-show in front of Virginia's own United States Senator on the Appropriations Subcommittee?! You won't just cost Fishersville eighteen and a half million dollars—you will jeopardize the Commonwealth's entire ninety-two-million-dollar share of federal Title I Rehabilitation Act matching funds! Neither of you is leaving Washington. I am ordering both of you right now: check into your hotel, walk into Dirksen Room 124 at ten o'clock on Wednesday morning, sit behind those microphones while Senator Prairie enters every page of the 2007 record into the Congressional Record, and agree under oath to every single reform her office puts in front of you without one word of pushback. Do both of you hear me?!"

Over the speakerphone, two small, hollow voices answered from the parked car:

"Yes, Mr. Lawrence," Commissioner Sterling said quietly.

"Yes, sir," Director Cross whispered.

Katie leaned forward over the armrests of her SwiftChair, looking straight down at the speakerphone grille.

"And let me make one promise to all three of you right now, Arthur," Katie said, her voice calm and cold as ice. "If Director Cross and Commissioner Sterling do not show up at that witness table for the Subcommittee hearing on Wednesday morning, they won't be hiding in Richmond or Fishersville—they will be facing compulsory subpoenas from the United States Senate."

She had chosen every word with surgical precision. An individual Senator couldn't unilaterally conjure a subpoena into existence on her own say-so—Senate committees and subcommittees operated under strict chamber and committee rules governing how compulsory process was authorized and issued—and Katie wasn't pretending otherwise. She was warning the Governor's Chief of Staff that the moment voluntary cooperation ended, she was prepared to walk straight to the Subcommittee Chair and the full Committee leadership to initiate formal compulsory congressional process.

And Arthur Lawrence, who knew Capitol politics inside and out, heard the unspoken final sentence behind her words loud and clear: *Arthur, get them into those chairs voluntarily, because neither you nor the Governor wants to find out what happens next.*

"They will be in their seats at nine-forty-five sharp, Senator," Lawrence said quickly. "You have my word."

Wednesday, February 17, 2027, 10:00 AM — The Subcommittee Hearing & Strings Attached on Every Federal Dollar

Less than twenty hours later, at ten o'clock on Wednesday morning inside Room 124 of the Dirksen Senate Office Building, the crystal chandeliers gleamed above the curved mahogany dais of the Senate Appropriations Subcommittee on Labor, Health and Human Services, Education, and Related Agencies.

Sitting in my SwiftChair in the staff bay immediately behind Katie's custom-ramped place on the Subcommittee dais, I looked out past the green-baize witness table—where Commissioner Marcus Sterling and Director Evelyn Cross sat stiffly behind their microphones—to the very first row of the public seating gallery.

Sitting side by side in the front row were forty-one-year-old Natalie and her sixty-eight-year-old mother Evelyn, holding hands as they looked up at Katie on the dais.

"The Chair recognizes the Senator from Virginia, Senator Prairie, for five minutes of questioning," the Subcommittee Chairman announced, tapping his gavel gently.

Katie leaned slightly toward her microphone from her SwiftChair, her royal-blue blazer crisp beneath the television lights.

"Thank you, Mr. Chairman," Katie said clearly. "Commissioner Sterling, Director Cross, before we begin, I ask unanimous consent to enter into the permanent hearing record the sworn constituent complaint, March 2007 hospital emergency room documentation, and signed guardianship privacy release submitted by Evelyn Brooks—a Virginia mother who holds legal Guardianship and Conservatorship over her daughter, Natalie—detailing the events of March 14 through March 16, 2007 at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville, Virginia. And for the public record, I will state in open session what I shared with both of you in my office on Tuesday: in March of 2007, my twin brother Nathaniel and I spent twelve days as residential Level 2 clients in Barton Hall at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center before dropping out."

A quiet murmur rippled across the press table and the staff benches along the wall as reporters scribbled furiously in their notebooks.

"During those twelve days in March 2007," Katie continued, her voice ringing with calm, forensic precision across the marble hearing room, "my brother and I—already holding Associate of Applied Science degrees from the Community College of Hampton Roads—had our wheelchair push-handles grabbed without our consent by Center staff, and were forced to tour auto mechanics, woodworking, and nursing shops before being pitched on a partnership with ValueMart to work as a door greeter. Then, on Tuesday, March 13, 2007, a male student assaulted me in the therapeutic pool—breaking my nose open and ripping my swimsuit top off, which forced my twin brother to use his hands to cover my exposed chest until someone

brought a towel. Instead of expelling the attacker, RRC staff wrote my brother up for covering my chest, and when my brother and I locked ourselves in a storage closet together that night in our street clothes because I was too traumatized to be separated onto different wings, staff accused us of having sex and threatened us with expulsion and a Level 1 dorm-grounding and sibling-separation contract—while leaving my attacker right there on campus, handing him a scrambled keycard to the women's wing the very next night so that the exact same perpetrator who broke my nose and ripped my swimsuit top off was able to unlock Natalie's door and rape her in the dormitories, before Center administration escorted him into a van on the morning of March 15, 2007 and sent him off campus without calling the police."

At the witness table, Commissioner Sterling swallowed hard into his microphone. "Senator Prairie, as we expressed to you on Tuesday, neither Dr. Cross nor I was with the agency in 2007, and we are horrified by what Natalie and her family—and you and your brother—experienced twenty years ago."

"Words don't reform institutions, Commissioner—appropriations language does," Katie replied evenly. "You have come to Washington asking this Subcommittee for eighteen point five million dollars in federal funding. As a United States Senator from Virginia sitting on this Committee, let me make my position crystal clear: I refuse to entertain a single federal dollar for Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center or the Virginia Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services until you carry out the specific institutional reforms my office has placed on this table."

Holding up the five-page statutory rider I had drafted with Sarah the night before, Katie read the strings attached into the *Congressional Record* one by one:

"First, DARS and Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center will issue a formal written institutional apology to Natalie and her mother, open their 2007 administrative files to an independent audit by the Virginia Office of the State Inspector General, and adopt an ironclad, zero-tolerance mandatory reporting policy requiring Center staff to notify the Virginia State Police and local law enforcement within one hour of any report of sexual or physical assault on campus—with immediate termination and criminal referral for any administrator who attempts to escort a suspect off property, tamper with physical evidence, or conceal a crime to protect campus statistics.

"Second, the Center handbook and staff training manual will be permanently amended to recognize that a wheelchair is an extension of the person sitting in it, prohibiting any staff member from grabbing or pushing a client's wheelchair or push-handles without explicit consent.

"Third, DARS will end the practice of forcing clients who already hold accredited college degrees or documented technical proficiencies through two-week manual-trade Vocational Evaluation tours or pitching them low-wage retail greeter placements just to pad evaluation rosters, and will ensure that vocational technology classrooms are equipped with modern, unlocked developer workstations rather than outdated VITA-locked desktops.

"Fourth, Residential Services will abolish forced daytime separation directives and punitive Level 1 isolation contracts against adult family members and siblings who rely on one another for disability and sensory support.

“And fifth, federal disbursement will be tied to independent audits of real educational and career outcomes—never to ‘butts-in-seats’ residential headcount quotas.”

Katie lowered the statutory rider onto her desk and looked squarely down from the dais at the two administrators.

“Until those five reforms are signed, implemented, and verified in Fishersville, Commissioner Sterling, my hold on your federal funding remains in place. Do we understand each other?”

At the witness table, Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross sat frozen under the television lights, the tiny red recording lamps glowing on the necks of their microphones while the stenographer’s fingers hovered over her stenotype machine.

“Yes, Senator Prairie,” Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross answered into their microphones in unison. “We will implement every single one of them.”

If Sterling and Cross had been hoping that a quick verbal surrender would run out the five-minute clock and allow them to slip out of Dirksen Room 124 before the national cameras zoomed in any closer, they had badly misjudged the United States Senate.

At the center of the curved mahogany dais, Senator Arthur Harrington—the silver-haired Chairman of the full Appropriations Committee—leaned forward and clicked on his microphone, exchanging a single grim nod with the Subcommittee’s Ranking Republican Member beside him.

“Before the Senator from Virginia’s initial five minutes expire, let the Chair state the position of this Committee so there is zero ambiguity down in Richmond or Fishersville,” Chairman Harrington said, his deep voice booming off the marble walls. “On the Senate Appropriations Committee, no home-state Congressionally Directed Spending request moves a single inch without the affirmative support of the home-state Senator. Senator Prairie’s hold on this eighteen-point-five-million-dollar line item is absolute. Furthermore, the Ranking Member and I have just instructed the Committee clerk to add both of our names as original bipartisan cosponsors to Senator Prairie’s five-point statutory rider—and this Subcommittee is transmitting today’s hearing transcript and exhibits directly to the Rehabilitation Services Administration at the Department of Education and the Office for Civil Rights at the Department of Health and Human Services for an immediate federal Title I compliance audit of the Virginia Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services. Without objection, the Chair yields an additional five minutes to Senator Prairie so these witnesses can answer her remaining questions under oath.”

At the green-baize witness table, Director Cross closed her eyes for a fraction of a second as the last of the color drained from her cheeks. A home-state Senator’s hold had just become a bipartisan Committee mandate backed by two federal oversight investigations.

“Thank you, Mr. Chairman,” Katie said, picking up the second folder I had set beside her armrest. “Commissioner Sterling, let’s talk about what happens between now and five o’clock this Friday afternoon. Under Section 19.2-8 of the Code of

Virginia, there is no statute of limitations on a felony in the Commonwealth of Virginia. Felony forcible rape under Section 18.2-61 can be indicted and prosecuted twenty days after the crime, or twenty years after the crime."

Along the press table, every reporter's pen stopped in midair as they looked up at the dais.

"For twenty years," Katie continued, her voice steady and unflinching, "Evelyn and Natalie Brooks have kept the March 16, 2007 hospital emergency room forensic examination report, the triage records, and the photographs of Natalie's injuries safe in their files—while Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center locked the perpetrator's full legal identity, counselor intake file, electronic keycard door-lock audit log from the night of Wednesday, March 14, 2007, campus infirmary admission chart, laundry bleaching work order, and Thursday morning van dispatch log inside your vault in Fishersville behind Title 34, Section 361.38 of the Code of Federal Regulations. Yesterday afternoon, after you left my office, your archives staff in Richmond and Fishersville pulled those unredacted March 2007 records out of storage. And as your General Counsel knows full well, Section 361.38(e)(5) explicitly authorizes the release of vocational rehabilitation records in connection with a law enforcement investigation of a criminal offense."

Katie leaned an inch closer to her microphone, locking her blue eyes on the Commissioner.

"Commissioner Sterling, Director Cross—will you commit on the record right now to turning over the complete, unredacted March 2007 administrative, security, keycard, infirmary, and transport records for the perpetrator who assaulted me in the therapeutic pool on March 13 and raped Natalie Brooks on March 14 to the Virginia State Police Bureau of Criminal Investigation and the Augusta County Commonwealth's Attorney before five o'clock this Friday afternoon?"

"Yes, Senator Prairie," Commissioner Sterling said hoarsely into his microphone. "I have already instructed our General Counsel to assemble the complete unredacted 2007 files. They will be hand-delivered to the Virginia State Police Bureau of Criminal Investigation and the Augusta County Commonwealth's Attorney before five o'clock this Friday."

"Good," Katie said. "Now let's address the falsified administrative coding in your agency's mainframe. When Evelyn Brooks drove to Fishersville on Friday, March 16, 2007 and rescued her traumatized, bleeding daughter from your campus infirmary, Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center didn't log a campus violent felony. Instead, your predecessors coded Natalie Brooks in the DARS mainframe as a voluntary 'homesickness' withdrawal and a Status 28 'Unsuccessful Rehabilitation' dropout—the exact same Status 28 failure code your system placed next to my name and my twin brother's name when we rolled out of Barton Hall that very same afternoon."

Behind Katie's wheelchair on the dais, I saw two Senate aides along the back wall shake their heads in disbelief at the sheer audacity of a state agency coding a sitting United States Senator—and a sexual assault survivor—as "unsuccessful rehabilitations."

"My brother and I don't care what code your computer in Richmond has next to our names, Dr. Cross—Nate and I wear being twelve-day RRC dropouts as a badge of honor," Katie said evenly. "But Natalie Brooks did not drop out of Roosevelt

Rehabilitation Center because she was homesick, and she did not fail rehabilitation. Your center failed her. Before this Subcommittee marks up your budget next week, you will formally expunge every falsified ‘homesickness’ and ‘Status 28’ entry from Natalie Brooks’s permanent record, replace them with an official administrative finding documenting the true reason she left Fishersville on March 16, 2007, and reimburse Evelyn Brooks in full for every dollar of out-of-pocket medical and trauma counseling care your agency refused to cover twenty years ago. Do I have your commitment?”

“Yes, Senator Prairie,” Director Cross answered, her voice trembling slightly into the microphone. “Her record will be expunged and corrected immediately, and our agency will provide full restitution for her medical and counseling care.”

Katie glanced at the amber digital countdown clock on the edge of the dais—ninety seconds remaining—and then looked out past the green-baize witness table toward the first row of the public seating gallery.

“I have one final requirement before I yield back to the Chairman,” Katie said softly, though the acoustics of Room 124 carried every syllable to the back corners of the chamber. “Twenty years ago on Roosevelt Avenue in Fishersville, the administrators sitting in your chairs kept a twenty-one-year-old woman with the sweet, trusting heart of a seven-year-old child locked inside your campus infirmary for thirty-two hours while housekeeping bleached her bedsheets, and when her mother arrived to take her home, they wouldn’t even look Evelyn Brooks in the eye when they lied to her face. Evelyn and Natalie Brooks took the early morning train up to Washington today, and they are sitting ten feet behind your backs in the very first row of this hearing room.”

Every camera lens in the room pivoted toward the front row of the gallery, where sixty-eight-year-old Evelyn Brooks sat with her arm around forty-one-year-old Natalie.

“Commissioner Sterling, Director Cross,” Katie said, “before you leave that table, I want both of you to turn around in your chairs, look Natalie and Evelyn Brooks in the eye, and give them the apology the Commonwealth of Virginia has owed them since March 15, 2007.”

For three long seconds, neither administrator moved. Then, slowly, under the silent, unblinking gaze of every Senator on the dais, Marcus Sterling and Evelyn Cross pushed their leather witness chairs back from the green-baize table, stood up, and turned completely around to face the front row of the public gallery.

Standing ten feet in front of Natalie and her mother with the press cameras clicking softly along the wall, both executives bowed their heads.

“Mrs. Brooks, Natalie,” Commissioner Sterling said, his voice carrying clearly across the quiet aisle without a microphone, “on behalf of the Commonwealth of Virginia and the Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services, I am deeply, profoundly sorry for the horrific harm done to you at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in March of 2007, and for the twenty years our agency spent hiding the truth instead of standing beside you.”

“We failed to protect you when you were in our care, Natalie, and what was done to you and your mother was inexcusable,” Director Cross added quietly, looking straight into Mrs. Brooks’s eyes. “We are so sorry.”

In the front row, Evelyn Brooks held her daughter’s hand tightly against her coat, tears spilling down her cheeks, and gave a single, solemn nod—not of easy forgiveness for an institution that still had to prove itself in action, but of a mother who had finally forced the state to speak the truth in the light of day.

“Thank you, Mr. Chairman,” Katie said into her microphone. “I yield back.”

Wednesday, February 17, 2027, 11:15 AM — Twenty Years Since the Barton Hall Cafeteria

The moment Chairman Harrington rapped his gavel to recess the morning witness panel, Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross hastily gathered their folders and slipped out the side corridor with their legal counsel to begin placing calls to the Virginia State Police and Richmond.

Up on the dais, Katie and I unlocked the brakes of our SwiftChairs at the exact same second. Steering down the custom carpeted side ramp off the Senate rostrum in tight parallel formation, we rolled out through the brass gate into the front aisle of Dirksen Room 124, stopping right in front of the first row of the gallery.

For the first time in twenty years—not since that grey March week in 2007 outside the noisy double doors of the Barton Hall cafeteria—we were looking at Natalie face-to-face.

At forty-one years old, Natalie wore a neat lavender cardigan over a floral dress, with a silver heart locket around her neck and a small canvas tote bag in her lap. The instant our two black motorized SwiftChairs glided to a stop in front of her row, Natalie’s eyes went wide with pure, radiant recognition.

“Katie! Nate!” Natalie gasped happily, standing up beside her mother and reaching both hands straight out toward our wheelchairs—the exact pose she had drawn with her purple and blue crayons on the piece of white construction paper that was now framed in brushed gold behind Katie’s desk upstairs in Room 511.

Katie and I both leaned forward over our armrests, Katie taking Natalie’s right hand in hers while I took Natalie’s left hand in mine.

“Hi, Natalie,” Katie said, her voice thick with emotion as a warm tear slipped down her cheek and she smiled up at her old classmate. “It is so good to see you again.”

“It’s really good to see you, Natalie,” I said warmly, giving her fingers a gentle squeeze. “We loved the picture you drew for us so much that Katie hung it up in a shiny gold frame right on the wall of her Senate office.”

Natalie beamed from ear to ear, looking back and forth between my wheelchair and Katie’s. Then she tilted her head, peering down curiously at the black motorized drive wheels and the compact joystick controllers mounted on our armrests.

“You got new chairs with little driving sticks!” Natalie marveled delightedly. “When we were at the school by the cafeteria, you had the push-wheelchairs with the big circles on the wheels, just like I drew in my picture! And Katie, you talked so loud and brave on the big microphone up there! You told those people they aren’t allowed to let mean boys have keys to the girls’ rooms ever again!”

“Never again, Natalie,” Katie promised softly, squeezing her hand with both of hers. “Not to you, and not to anyone else.”

Standing beside her daughter, sixty-eight-year-old Evelyn Brooks reached down and placed her hand over ours, her eyes shining through her tears as she looked at Katie and me sitting side by side in our wheelchairs.

“For twenty years, every door I knocked on in Virginia was slammed in my face with a federal code number,” Mrs. Brooks whispered. “It took the two kids who walked out of that place after twelve days to finally tear the wall down.”

Beside Katie’s wheelchair in the middle of the Senate hearing room, I looked at Natalie smiling brightly down at us, and then across at my twin sister—two twelve-day RRC dropouts who had gone home to do their own thing, and had just rewritten the rules for every disabled student who would ever roll through the doors of Fishersville again.

The Norfolk Carrier Leak, Suite 756 at Timberline Shopping Center, & Three Convictions in the Senate

Part 1: The South Lawn Tirade, The Norfolk Carrier Leak, & Why the Order of the Trials Matters

Date: 2027-03-18 at 10:15 America/New_York

Thursday, March 18, 2027, 10:15 AM — “He Thinks He’s Brandon Mercer” & The No Vote at Eleven-Fifteen

Inside Room 511 of the Dirksen Senate Office Building, the wall-mounted television was tuned to a live morning press availability on the South Lawn of the White House, where President Garrett Thorne was shouting over the helicopter rotor wash at a cluster of reporters.

“You want to know why my nominee for Deputy Secretary of Transportation is still stalled in committee?” Thorne barked into the microphones, jabbing a thick finger toward Capitol Hill. “Because Broken Katie Prairie—a nasty, bitter little cripple who can’t even walk up the steps of the Capitol without taxpayers building her a ramp—is running a personal vendetta from her wheelchair! Look at her! She’s slow, she has no stamina, forty-one years old, never married, couldn’t keep a real man when she was twenty, still living in her father’s house in Alexandria with her crippled twin brother writing little computer spreadsheets for her! She’s defective, folks—physically and mentally defective—and the Senate Commerce Committee shouldn’t be held hostage by a spinster on wheels!”

Across the private office, Katie's paid legislative director, Sarah, reached for the remote control to mute the screen, her face pale with anger.

"Leave the volume up, Sarah," Katie said calmly from behind her custom-height mahogany Senator's desk, not even looking up from the red-tabbed confirmation binder open across her lap.

Parked in my compact SwiftChair right beside my twin sister's left armrest, I didn't flinch either. My fingers didn't even pause on the mechanical keyboard of my MagnaBook Pro as I finished compiling the final cross-referenced PHP table of wire transfers between Thorne Global Holdings, an offshore maritime logistics shell company, and the nominee's former shipping lobby firm.

Because federal anti-nepotism law under Title 5, Section 3110 of the United States Code barred a Member of Congress from hiring a sibling onto a paid government payroll, I didn't take a single dime of taxpayer salary. I was a private citizen, earning our living through the fifty-fifty software business Katie and I had built from our wheelchairs, and serving in Dirksen Room 511 as my sister's unpaid chief data strategist—while Katie alone held the constitutional office of United States Senator from Virginia, chaired her subcommittee on the dais, and cast the official votes on the floor.

"He thinks he's Brandon Mercer," I said quietly, turning my laptop screen ten degrees toward Katie's SwiftChair so she could read the bottom wire-transfer totals. "He thinks if he stands over the back of our chairs and screams loud enough about how broken we are, we're going to flinch."

"Brandon found out twenty-two years ago what happens when you try to corner us, and so will Garrett Thorne," Katie said, closing the confirmation binder with a sharp snap. "Remember during the 2024 campaign when Thorne started walking out at his rallies and blasting the 1993 *Runebreaker Live* stadium version of *The Grand Decree* as his campaign theme song without asking permission—because nobody on his staff bothered to check that it was literally the villain song about a tyrant ruling by executive decree who gets taken down by a pair of fraternal twins?"

I couldn't help grinning at the memory. Engine Room Records maintained a strict, across-the-board policy prohibiting any song in its catalog from being used for political campaigns—having made a very rare exception only for our campaign's use of *The Accessibility Project*—so within forty-eight hours of Thorne's campaign uploading those rally videos in 2024, every single one of them had been hit with copyright claims by Mana Canvas, who held the original 1992 and 1993 copyrights, and Engine Room Records, who held the 2016 re-release rights, followed the next morning by a formal cease-and-desist order that forced his campaign to scrub the audio.

Right then, the multi-line console on her desk chirped once on Line One. In ninety-nine out of a hundred suites in the Dirksen Senate Office Building, a United States Senator never touched the main office telephone; a front-office bank of staff assistants and interns screened every incoming call before routing messages to the legislative staff. In Katie's literal autistic mind, however, the rule had never changed since her days as a Virginia Beach City Councilwoman, a Virginia State Delegate, and a Virginia State Senator: this was her office, her name was on the door, and

whenever she was sitting at her desk with a free hand, it was only polite to answer the phone herself so the caller knew she was actually there working for the people of Virginia.

Reaching over from her SwiftChair before Sarah could even step toward the console, Katie pressed the button and said clearly, “Senator Katie Prairie’s office, this is Katie speaking.”

“Katie, it’s Clara—I love that you still answer your own phone even in the United States Senate,” the voice of Speaker of the House Clara Morales came through the line from the other side of the Capitol Rotunda. “The House Judiciary and Armed Services investigative committees have just completed their final subpoena report on Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, Vice President Conrad Drayton, and President Thorne. We are voting on the Articles of Impeachment next week.”

“Thank you for letting me know directly, Madam Speaker,” Katie answered warmly, ending the call and nudging her joystick as she looked over at her legislative director. “What time is the floor roll call on Thorne’s transportation nominee, Sarah?”

“Eleven-fifteen,” Sarah answered, smiling as she held the office door open for our two wheelchairs.

“Good,” Katie said, steering her SwiftChair out into the marble corridor of Dirksen with me rolling in lockstep beside her left wheel toward the Capitol subway. “Then at eleven-fifteen, President Thorne gets my No vote on his nominee—and as soon as Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling swears in the Senate for their trials, all three of them get my Guilty vote too.”

The 2025 Warning from Richmond, Disrespecting the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier, & Bret Halverson’s Norfolk Carrier Leak

As our subway car glided through the subterranean tunnel between the Dirksen building and the Capitol, both Katie and I thought back two years earlier to January of 2025.

Back in that winter of 2025, Katie had still been serving as a State Senator in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond—living with me at Apartment 104 of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street—when newly inaugurated President Garrett Thorne, backed by a Republican trifecta controlling the White House, the House of Representatives, and a fifty-three-to-forty-seven Senate majority, nominated Bret Halverson to serve as United States Secretary of Defense.

Before Thorne plucked him off television to run the Pentagon, Halverson had spent a decade hosting *Patriot Watch Weekend* on the Liberty First Network—a slick, hair-sprayed weekend cable talk show where he ranted about “woke generals,” mocked disabled service members and ADA wheelchair accessibility standards as “weakness,” and hawked survivalist supplements and gold coins during commercial breaks. In 2024, Halverson had gone on the Liberty First Network and sneered that military bases shouldn’t waste taxpayer money on “wheelchair ramps for bureaucrats.”

For anyone representing Hampton Roads—home to Naval Station Norfolk, the largest naval base on earth, alongside Naval Air Station Oceana, Joint Expeditionary Base Little Creek, Newport News Shipbuilding, and tens of thousands of active-duty sailors and military families—putting a cable television talk-show host in charge of three million service members and an eight-hundred-and-fifty-billion-dollar defense budget was an insult to every sailor in uniform.

Because Katie was still a State Senator in Richmond in January 2025 and hadn't yet run for the United States Senate, she didn't have a confirmation vote in Washington. Instead, she and I had stayed up past midnight in our West Broad Street apartment compiling a fourteen-page forensic dossier on Halverson's financial conflicts and erratic record. The next morning, State Senator Katie Prairie had rolled to the well of the Senate of Virginia in Richmond, publicly urged both of Virginia's United States Senators to vote No on Halverson's confirmation, and sent our dossier straight up Interstate 95 to Capitol Hill.

Virginia's retiring senior U.S. Senator had read Katie's letter into the *Congressional Record* and voted No alongside Virginia's other Senator, just as she had urged. Yet because Thorne's party controlled the chamber in January 2025, the majority conference had rammed Halverson's confirmation through on a razor-thin fifty-fifty tie broken by Vice President Conrad Drayton. That weekend, Secretary Halverson had gone back on his old cable network for a victory lap, laughing with his former co-hosts about *"that little wheelchair state senator down in Richmond who thought she could stop the Pentagon."*

It hadn't taken two years for every single warning Katie had issued from Richmond to come true. First, on Veterans Day—November 11, 2026, barely eight days after Virginia voters elected Katie to the United States Senate—Secretary Halverson, his wife, and a pack of his senior aides and former cable-news staffers had walked down to the marble plaza of the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier at Arlington National Cemetery right after the official wreath ceremony, snapping posed photos on the steps and laughing and talking so loudly across the sacred ground that an enlisted Army Tomb Sentinel from the 3rd U.S. Infantry Regiment, The Old Guard—Specialist Caleb Navarro—had broken his twenty-one-step march, snapped to attention facing the Secretary of Defense's own entourage, and publicly reprimanded them across the hushed amphitheater: *"All visitors will maintain an atmosphere of silence and respect at all times."* Worse yet, when bystander video of the Old Guard sentinel dressing down the Secretary of Defense's party went viral across every military base in Hampton Roads that evening, Halverson had scrambled the very next afternoon into shameless, camera-lit damage control—summoning Specialist Navarro and members of The Old Guard across the river to the Pentagon to pin a Joint Service Commendation Medal on the young soldier's chest and post a smug caption online reading *"We love soldiers. We love standards. Well done, Specialist. Carry on, patriots."* Watching Halverson use the enlisted sentinel who had been forced to reprimand him as a Pentagon photo-op prop had made Katie's blood boil to a degree I had rarely seen in our forty-one years together—because our paternal grandfather, Grandpa Walter Prairie, Grandma Ruth's late husband, was a World War II Navy veteran buried beneath a white marble headstone right there on those green hills at Arlington, and in our family, you did not disrespect the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier and then hand out a medal for the cameras to wash your hands of it.

Three weeks after Arlington, on December first during the lame-duck session—after escaping an outgoing Kentucky congressman's eight privileged impeachment articles by seven votes on a two-hundred-and-eleven-to-two-hundred-and-four

motion to bury the resolution in committee—Halverson had marched up to the Pentagon briefing room podium to declare “total victory,” sneering that the impeachment push was a “circus” and convincing himself he was untouchable. Instead, when the November 2026 midterm wave’s new two-hundred-and-fifty-three-seat Democratic House majority and fifty-four-seat Senate majority convened with full subpoena power in January 2027 alongside United States Senator Katie Prairie of Virginia, Halverson’s holiday hubris blew straight up in his face.

Within sixty days of the One Hundred Twentieth Congress taking power in January 2027, joint House and Senate subpoenas uncovered a staggering dual crime at the top of the administration:

First, Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson had used an unsecured commercial messaging app on his personal cell phone—on a group chat that included Vice President Conrad Drayton, two of Halverson’s old cable-news producers, and a foreign-linked shipping broker—to text classified Fifth Fleet deployment schedules and transit coordinates for an aircraft carrier strike group homeported right at Naval Station Norfolk, putting six thousand Hampton Roads sailors in mortal danger.

Second, when I wrote a custom PHP financial cross-indexing script in Dirksen Room 511 to audit the subpoenaed Pentagon logistics ledgers against Treasury wire records, the data proved beyond a shadow of a doubt that Halverson had fired the Department of Defense Inspector General to cover up four hundred million dollars in no-bid Naval Station Norfolk fleet-supply contracts steered to an offshore shell fund co-owned by Thorne Global Holdings—using Domestic Emoluments and national-security tariff waivers personally signed by both Vice President Conrad Drayton and President Garrett Thorne.

Thursday Afternoon, March 25, 2027 — Why the Vice President Must Be Convicted Before the President

One week later, on Thursday afternoon, March 25, 2027—minutes after the United States House of Representatives voted two hundred and sixty-eight to one hundred and sixty-seven to impeach Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, Vice President Conrad Drayton, and President Garrett Thorne for high crimes and misdemeanors—Speaker of the House Clara Morales and the House impeachment managers met with Katie and the Senate leadership inside the Capitol while I sat beside Katie’s wheelchair with our constitutional succession timeline open on my laptop.

“Alexander Hamilton wrote in *Federalist Number 65* that impeachment is designed for those offenses which proceed from the misconduct of public men, or, in other words, from the abuse or violation of some public trust,” Katie said evenly around the conference table. “And Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. reminded this country that the time is always right to do what is right. All three of these men betrayed the sailors of Naval Station Norfolk and sold out the public trust for four hundred million dollars in offshore kickbacks. None of them—not Thorne, not Drayton, and not Halverson—can be allowed to remain in power.”

“Which brings us to the exact sequence of the three Senate trials,” Speaker Clara Morales said, looking across the table at Katie and Senate Majority Leader Charles Schuman. “Because under Article II, Section 1, Clause 6 of the Constitution and Section 1 of the Twenty-Fifth Amendment, the order in which the Senate calls the final roll determines who becomes President of the United States.”

Katie nodded, tapping the statutory flow chart I had coded on my screen.

“If the Senate convicts and removes President Garrett Thorne first,” Katie explained with crystal-clear constitutional precision, “then the exact microsecond Chief Justice Sterling bangs his gavel on the sixty-seventh Guilty vote, Vice President Conrad Drayton—the man who broke the tie to put Bret Halverson in the Pentagon and co-signed the offshore Norfolk contract waivers—automatically ascends to the Presidency. Even if we impeached him the next day, he would already be sitting in the Oval Office with the pardon pen in his hand.”

“Whereas if we try and convict them in ascending order of their conspiracy,” I added from my chair beside Katie, pointing to the three numbered boxes on my screen, “watch what the Constitution and the United States Code do automatically:

“First, on Wednesday, the Senate votes on Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson—convicting and removing him by a two-thirds supermajority under Article I, Section 3, followed immediately by the simple-majority vote permanently disqualifying him from ever holding federal office again.

“Second, on Thursday, while Garrett Thorne is still President, the Senate votes on Vice President Conrad Drayton. The moment sixty-seven Senators vote Guilty to convict and remove Conrad Drayton, the office of Vice President of the United States becomes completely vacant. Under Section 2 of the Twenty-Fifth Amendment, a replacement Vice President cannot take office unless confirmed by a majority vote of both Houses of Congress—meaning our majorities in the House and the Senate simply decline to consider any nominee, keeping the Vice Presidency empty overnight.

“And third, on Friday afternoon, with the Vice Presidency vacant, the Senate votes to convict, remove, and permanently disqualify President Garrett Thorne. Under the Presidential Succession Act of 1947—Title 3, Section 19 of the United States Code—with both the Presidency and the Vice Presidency vacant at the same time, the line of succession skips straight across the Capitol Rotunda to the Speaker of the House.”

Across the mahogany table, Speaker Clara Morales looked at the forty-one-year-old Senator from Virginia Beach and her twin brother in quiet awe.

“Wednesday for Halverson, Thursday for Drayton, and Friday for Thorne,” Majority Leader Schuman said, writing the three dates onto the official Senate trial calendar. “And Senator Prairie—because Naval Station Norfolk is your home turf, we want you delivering the final floor speech before the roll is called.”

Part 2: Route 36 to Timberline Shopping Center, Lunch at Don Miller Subs, Retro Games at Neat Stuff, & Suite 756

Date: 2027-04-03 at 12:05 America/New_York

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 12:05 PM — Riding CVTA Route 36 to Timberline Shopping Center & Family Lunch at Don Miller Subs

“Approaching State Route four-ten, Holland Road and Timberlake Road—Timberline Shopping Center,” the automated chime announced over the interior speakers of our forty-foot Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 36 bus as the driver signaled right and eased into the curb lane just east of where State Route 225 split off toward South Independence Boulevard and the Silverleaf commuter lot.

Up near the front wheel well, my twin brother Nate reached up from his compact SwiftChair and pressed the yellow request-to-stop strip along the wall, while our sixty-eight-year-old dad stood up from the forward-facing bench seat across the aisle beside our cousins Brittany and Chelsea, tucking his sunglasses into the breast pocket of his polo shirt as Brittany slipped her canvas tote bag—carrying Chelsea’s asthma inhalers and green plush sea turtle Shelly—over her shoulder.

Unlike the part-time Virginia General Assembly up in Richmond—which met for forty-five or sixty winter days and then sent us home for the rest of the year—the United States Senate stayed in session almost year-round from January 3rd right up to Christmas. Even so, the Senate’s weekly floor voting calendar almost always wrapped up around two o’clock on Thursday afternoon, allowing Nate, Brittany, Chelsea, Dad, and me to ride south from Alexandria to Tidewater so all five of us could spend every long weekend together at home in Virginia Beach. Better yet, this first full week of April fell during the Senate’s scheduled Spring State Work Period, giving the House impeachment managers and the White House defense counsel ten days to file their pre-trial briefs before the Senate impeachment trials of Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, Vice President Conrad Drayton, and President Garrett Thorne gaveled in on Wednesday, April 14th.

“Have a great Saturday, Senator Prairie, Nate, Mr. Prairie, Brittany, Chelsea!” the CVTA driver called out warmly as he kneeled the front air suspension, flipped the hydraulic fold-out ramp onto the concrete sidewalk of Holland Road, and waved as all five of us—having tapped our regular fare cards when we boarded—thanked him and stepped or rolled out into the bright sixty-eight-degree April sunshine.

Across the six lanes of State Route 410 on the south side of the highway stood Holland Square, anchored by the green signage of the Market Square grocery store. Here on the north side of Holland Road, however, we had just rolled into the parking lot of Timberline Shopping Center—a weathered, familiar 1980s neighborhood strip center anchored at its far end by a General Dollar discount store.

For our whole household, Timberline Shopping Center was one of our favorite Saturday afternoon stops along the Route 36 bus line between Buckner Boulevard and the Silverleaf transfer hub—and today was a special occasion. In five days, on Thursday, April 8th, Nate and I would turn forty-two years old. Every spring on the Saturday before our April 8th birthday, Dad rode the bus over here with us—and ever since 2016, with Brittany and Chelsea right alongside us—to treat everybody to our traditional birthday lunch at Don Miller Subs and buy Nate and me a pair of vintage video game cartridges next door at Neat Stuff.

Steering our two SwiftChairs side by side along the covered concrete walkway toward the far-left bay of the five-storefront row while Chelsea walked happily between Dad and Brittany, we rolled straight through the propped-open glass door of Don Miller Subs, where the warm, savory aroma of grilled ribeye steak, caramelized onions, and freshly baked sub rolls greeted us like an old friend.

“Well, look who’s back from Washington—and happy early birthday to the April eighth twins!” Marcus, the counter manager who had been grilling subs for our family since my years in the Virginia House of Delegates, beamed from behind the stainless-steel prep line. “The birthday usual for the Prairie crew? Two six-inch grilled steak-and-cheese subs with everything, two turkey-and-provolones for Mr. Prairie and Brittany, a toasted four-cheese melt for Miss Chelsea, two large baskets of hot french fries to share, and five tall cups of ginger ale?”

“You know us by heart, Marcus—and the birthday lunch is on Dad today,” Dad laughed, stepping up to the register to tap his debit card before I could reach for my wallet.

For the next thirty-five minutes, gathered around our usual accessible corner table where Nate and I could pull our wheelchairs right up to the laminate end while Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea slid onto the bench beside us, the five of us ate piping-hot subs and crispy french fries out of wax-paper baskets and clinked our tall cups of ice-cold ginger ale together in an early forty-second birthday toast. Nobody in the sub shop bothered us for speeches or talking points; a retired Navy chief at the next booth simply nodded with a quiet *“Proud of you up there on Capitol Hill, Senator,”* before letting our family enjoy our Saturday lunch in peace.

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 12:50 PM — Hunting for Forty-Second Birthday Retro Cartridges at Neat Stuff in Suite 732

At ten minutes to one, after wiping our hands with napkins and tossing our paper baskets into the trash bin by the door, we rolled out of Don Miller Subs and turned one door to the right into Suite 732: Neat Stuff.

While everyone in Hampton Roads knew Pixel Haven as our region’s premier retro and modern video game store, Neat Stuff here in Suite 732 of Timberline Shopping Center was Pixel Haven’s sister store—a floor-to-ceiling treasure cavern packed with vintage console cartridges, classic handheld games, eight-bit and sixteen-bit hardware, comic books, and retro sci-fi collectibles. Ever since we were kids playing our Super Kinoka and Nova 64 consoles in our bedroom on Delaney Street—and trading PlayBrick cartridges in the back of Dad’s car—Nate and I had never outgrown our love for retro video games.

“Katie! Nate! Mr. Prairie, Brittany, Chelsea—happy early birthday!” Devon, the bearded thirty-something clerk behind the glass cartridge counter, lit up the moment our two SwiftChairs rolled down the wide center aisle while Brittany guided Chelsea gently over to admire a shelf of cheerful sixteen-bit plush stars and sea turtles near the front comic rack. “You folks picked the exact right Saturday to ride the 36 over here. Hold on—I put two cartridges in the lockbox under the register yesterday afternoon because I knew Mr. Prairie would be bringing you two in for your April eighth birthday!”

Devon unlocked the sliding glass door at the back of the counter and set two pristine, gray plastic cartridges on the felt mat in front of our wheelchairs: an original 1994 *Gorilla King '94* cartridge for the PlayBrick with an unblemished holographic label, and a complete-in-box sixteen-bit *Super Kinoka* strategy role-playing game we had been hunting for since 2024.

Nate's blue eyes lit up like he was twelve years old again. Picking up the sixteen-bit cartridge, he tilted the bottom edge toward the overhead fluorescent light to inspect the gold copper contact pins.

"Look at the board pins, Katie—not a single trace of oxidation, and the battery-backed save chip was just soldered fresh," Nate said happily, handing me the cardboard box so I could admire the manual. "We can dump the ROM onto our local emulator in Bedroom 4 to preserve the save states and play the original cartridge on the CRT television in the living room with Brittany and Chelsea cheering us on tonight."

"Happy forty-second birthday, you two," Dad smiled, stepping up to the counter to pay for both games—along with a soft pixel-art dolphin keychain Chelsea had fallen in love with on the plush rack—while Devon slipped everything into a sturdy paper bag and hung the handles over my right armrest.

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 1:15 PM — The Banners at Suite 756 & Senatorial Curiosity

Rolling back out of Suite 732 onto the covered concrete sidewalk of Timberline Shopping Center with our paper bag of retro games tucked beside my armrest, Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I turned right along the storefront walkway toward the Route 36 bus stop out on Holland Road.

For years, the five-bay strip along this end of Timberline Shopping Center had followed the exact same left-to-right rhythm: Don Miller Subs on the left, Neat Stuff in Suite 732, the quiet pink neon sign of Halo Nails & Spa in the middle, the busy tables of Pho 79 Vietnamese Kitchen in the fourth bay, and then Suite 756 on the far right—a narrow eleven-hundred-square-foot storefront that had sat completely empty behind dusty brown butcher paper since the spring of 2023.

As we rolled past Halo Nails & Spa and reached the front windows of Pho 79 Vietnamese Kitchen—where the rich, mouthwatering scent of simmering star anise, charred ginger, cinnamon bark, and slow-cooked beef pho broth drifted out through the exhaust vent into the April air—all five of us stopped in our tracks.

Suite 756 right next door to the Vietnamese restaurant wasn't empty anymore.

Every square inch of its plate-glass facade had been plastered floor-to-ceiling with glaring crimson, white, and gold vinyl banners that read:

THE TIDEWATER THORNE & RTR SUPERSTORE — OFFICIAL RESTORE THE REPUBLIC CAMPAIGN HEADQUARTERS!

Behind the glass stood a six-foot cardboard cutout of President Garrett Thorne giving a grinning double thumbs-up, flanked by neon-red posters reading *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED — IMPEACH THIS!* and *THORNE 2028: THE REVENGE TOUR!*

"Good grief," Dad muttered, staring at the giant vinyl banner taped right up against the brick pillar separating Suite 756 from Pho 79. "An 'America First' Garrett Thorne shrine sharing a party wall with a Vietnamese pho restaurant. You couldn't make that up if you tried."

Sitting in my SwiftChair on the sidewalk twenty feet from the door of Suite 756, I frowned thoughtfully at the words *OFFICIAL RESTORE THE REPUBLIC CAMPAIGN HEADQUARTERS* printed across the banner.

Over the past six weeks, our constituent caseworkers in Virginia Beach and Norfolk —along with my colleagues on the Senate Commerce Committee's Consumer Protection Subcommittee—had fielded dozens of inquiries about a sudden rash of brick-and-mortar "Thorne Stores" popping up in strip malls across Virginia. Every constituent who called our office believed the exact same rumor: that these storefronts were officially vetted, licensed, and authorized by President Garrett Thorne, Thorne Global Holdings, or his national campaign committee, and that buying forty-dollar hats and sixty-dollar flags inside them went directly to fund the President's impeachment defense.

None of the five of us had any idea who had leased Suite 756. As far as we knew, it was just another out-of-state novelty vendor looking to make a quick buck off Holland Road traffic before the next Route 36 bus arrived at one-thirty-five.

Curiosity got the better of the Senator in me.

"Wait a second, everybody," I said, resting my right hand on my joystick. "We still have twenty minutes before the one-thirty-five bus pulls up. People keep asking our Commerce Committee staff whether these 'Thorne Superstores' are actually vetted and licensed by Garrett Thorne, his company, or his campaign—or if they're unlicensed bootleggers tricking voters into thinking retail purchases are campaign contributions. Let's roll inside for sixty seconds and look at the merchandise tags and the business license by the register."

"Want to stay right with me by the front window while they check the tags, Chels?" Brittany asked gently, adjusting her thin wire-rimmed glasses as she held Chelsea's hand.

"Stay together," Chelsea nodded happily.

"Sixty seconds of consumer protection fieldwork," Nate agreed, glancing at his watch with a dry smile. "Lead the way, Senator."

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 1:18 PM — Inside Suite 756: Sharron Connects the Dots & Twenty-Four Years of Truth

When Dad pulled open the aluminum-framed glass door of Suite 756 and held it for Nate and me to roll our two SwiftChairs across the threshold while Brittany stepped in right behind us with her arm resting warmly around Chelsea's shoulders near the front display window, a cheap brass bell taped above the door frame jangled loudly.

The first thing that hit us inside the narrow storefront was the sensory clash: the sharp chemical smell of fresh overseas vinyl ink mixing with the unmistakable, delicious aroma of Vietnamese beef pho broth and star anise seeping straight through the thin drywall partition from Pho 79 next door.

Every wall was covered in pegboard hooks and wire racks overflowing with crimson Restore the Republic baseball caps, polyester three-by-five flags showing Garrett Thorne's head superimposed onto a bodybuilder holding an eagle, gold-foil novelty *"One Thousand Dollar Thorne Notes,"* and freshly unpacked shipping cartons stenciled *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED — ACQUITTED IN THE SENATE!*

Up at the glass checkout counter near the back wall—where a small tabletop television was tuned to a shouting panel on LibertyMax—an older husband and wife in matching red RTR windbreakers were handing a crisp hundred-dollar bill across the counter, while three sixty-something women wearing crimson Restore the Republic lapel pins stood near the back flag rack sipping iced coffees and browsing the shelves.

"We drove over from Kempsville as soon as we saw the sign on Holland Road," the husband was saying earnestly to the woman behind the cash register, whose back was half-turned as she priced a box of white ceramic *THORNE 2028* coffee mugs with a handheld sticker gun. "We bought two flags and two of the '3-0 Undefeated' hats because we want every dollar going straight to President Thorne's Senate trial defense fund!"

"Oh, bless your hearts, patriots—President Thorne appreciates every single bit of your support, and those Senate Democrats don't stand a prayer of getting sixty-seven votes next week!" the woman behind the register replied in a syrupy, familiar voice, never once correcting the couple's false belief that her store was connected to the President's defense fund.

While the couple zipped their new hats into a plastic shopping bag and walked past us out the front door, I reached out from my wheelchair and flipped over the neck tag of a *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED* t-shirt hanging on the nearest circular rack.

"Look at the collar tag, Nate," I murmured quietly. "Manufactured in Guangdong Province for Wholesale Novelty Imports LLC. Zero union bug, zero Federal Election Commission disclaimer, and zero licensing mark from Thorne Global Holdings."

Nate rolled his SwiftChair three feet closer to the glass checkout counter and pointed past a large plastic jar of five-dollar buttons that had been deliberately positioned at the corner of the register to block the counter mat. Taped flat beneath the jar in tiny eight-point font was a two-sentence notice:

Privately owned and operated retail establishment. Not authorized by, vetted by, licensed by, or affiliated with Garrett Thorne, Thorne Global Holdings, or any candidate or political committee.

"Every dime goes straight into the store owner's pocket," Nate said softly, his eyes lifting from the hidden disclaimer to the framed City of Virginia Beach Commissioner of the Revenue Business License hanging on the pegboard wall behind the cash register.

I followed my brother's gaze up to the typed name on the municipal business license.

PROPRIETOR: BRENDA WALSH.

Across the narrow aisle beside my right wheel, I heard Dad draw in a sharp, silent breath.

Behind the counter, the sixty-five-year-old woman with dyed blonde hair finished sticking a twenty-four-ninety-nine price tag onto the bottom of a *THORNE 2028* mug, set her pricing gun down on the glass, and turned around with a practiced retail smile on her face.

"Welcome to the Tidewater Thorne Superstore!" she began brightly. "Everything in the store goes to—"

Her voice died in her throat.

The ceramic coffee mug slipped halfway out of her fingers and clattered upright onto the glass countertop.

Standing—and sitting—six feet in front of her cash register were her ex-husband David Prairie, her forty-one-year-old son Nathaniel Prairie, and her forty-one-year-old daughter, United States Senator Katie Prairie, with her own estranged sister Karen's daughter Brittany Fletcher standing calmly near the front glass keeping a gentle, protective arm around David's niece Chelsea.

Neither Nate, nor Dad, nor I had laid eyes on our mother since the afternoon of Saturday, July 12, 2003—twenty-four years ago—when eighteen-year-old Nate and I had rolled our wheelchairs out the front door of the brick house on Delaney Street with Dad to move into Greenway Court Apartment A6, and Brittany hadn't seen her maternal Aunt Brenda since Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven cut ties with her over how she had treated us in high school.

For five full seconds, the only sound inside Suite 756 was the drone of the LibertyMax anchor on the corner television and the muffled clatter of soup spoons coming through the drywall from Pho 79 next door.

Brenda's face drained to chalk white, and then flushed a deep, blotchy crimson from her collar up to her roots. Her eyes darted in sheer panic from our two wheelchairs to Brittany and back toward the three women from her Restore the Republic chapter standing ten feet away by the back flag rack.

“What—what are you doing in here?!” Brenda hissed, her voice dropping from its syrupy customer-service lilt to the sharp, defensive snap Nate and I still remembered from the hallways of our childhood. “Are you following me?! Did David tell you to come in here to harass me?!”

Near the front rack behind us, Brittany didn’t flinch; she simply slipped Shelly out of her canvas tote bag into Chelsea’s hands and murmured softly, “You’re safe right here with me, Chels—nobody is yelling at you,” before looking calmly through her wire-rimmed glasses at her estranged aunt.

“Nobody knew you worked here, Brenda,” Dad said, his voice completely calm, level, and devoid of anger as he stood with one hand resting steadily on the back push-handle of my wheelchair and the other near Nate’s shoulder. “Your children turn forty-two on Thursday, April eighth. Just like we’ve done every spring for the past fifteen years, we rode the Route 36 bus over here with Katie, Nate, Brittany, and Chelsea to treat the twins to their birthday lunch at Don Miller Subs and their birthday video games at Neat Stuff three doors down. We didn’t even know Suite 756 had been leased until we rolled out onto the sidewalk two minutes ago.”

At the mention of April 8th, Brenda’s eyes flickered toward the wall calendar hanging beside her cash register—making it unmistakably clear that until Dad said the date out loud, the woman who had given birth to us forty-two years ago hadn’t even remembered that our birthday was five days away.

Before Brenda could utter another word, one of the three women standing by the flag rack stepped forward into the center aisle, lowering her iced coffee cup as she stared in stunned recognition at Dad, then at Nate, and then at me.

It was Sharron—a former neighbor from two streets over in our old Kempsville subdivision who had known our family back in the nineties when Nate and I were growing up on Delaney Street, long before our neuromuscular diagnosis in 2001.

“David?!” Sharron gasped, her eyes widening as she looked from Dad’s silver hair down to our two wheelchairs, and then straight across the counter at Brenda. “David Prairie?! Wait a minute… Katie and Nathaniel Prairie! I remember watching you two ride your bikes down Delaney Street when you were kids!”

Sharron spun around toward Brenda, her voice echoing across the narrow storefront as the other two Restore the Republic women—Donna and Carol—froze beside her.

“Brenda, wait a second!” Sharron demanded, pointing from the framed *Brenda Walsh* business license on the wall to my wheelchair. “When you joined our Restore the Republic chapter under the name Brenda Walsh, you told us you didn’t even know the Prairie family! For two straight years you’ve sat at our kitchen tables trashing ‘that Prairie woman’ on television like she was a total stranger! Wait—your daughter is *our* United States Senator?! *And* their birthdays are coming up on Thursday, and you didn’t even remember?! Brenda, it’s time for you to come clean!”

Beside Sharron, Donna and Carol stared at Brenda as if the floor had just opened beneath their feet.

“What is she talking about, Brenda?!” Donna asked, her voice rising in disbelief. “United States Senator Katie Prairie is your biological daughter?! You looked us dead in the eye at church coffee hour on Tuesday and swore you weren’t related to her!”

Behind the glass counter, Brenda’s hands trembled violently as her carefully constructed double life collapsed in front of her own friends.

“I—I went back to my maiden name Walsh because David and the woke universities brainwashed them against their own mother!” Brenda stammered, her face turning a blotchy, furious purple as she tried to fall back on the talking points that usually worked in her chapter meetings. “They turned their backs on me and became godless Washington liberals!”

Sharron didn’t buy a single word of it. She took a step closer to the counter, her face tightening with maternal disgust as she did the math out loud in front of Donna and Carol.

“Woke universities?!” Sharron shot back. “Brenda, I lived two streets over from you on Delaney Street in two thousand and one! Katie and Nathaniel weren’t at a university when you and David divorced—they were sixteen years old at Northwood High School, right after the doctors diagnosed their muscle condition and put both of them in wheelchairs! Every mother in the neighborhood heard how you threw a fit because you were embarrassed to be seen pushing wheelchairs in public!”

Beside my left wheel, Nate’s voice was quiet, steady, and devastatingly clear.

“Dad didn’t turn us against you, Brenda,” Nate said, looking straight across the counter. “You did that yourself in August of 2001 when we were sixteen years old and our legs were failing—when you maxed out the credit card to drag us onto a cruise ship against our will, screamed at us that we were ruining your vacation because we couldn’t walk up the gangway, and tried to force two high school juniors into a toddler character meet-and-greet line so you could take a fake photo for the neighbors. And when the doctors put us in wheelchairs that September, Dad built ramps and carried us up the stairs, while you locked yourself in the kitchen with a bottle of gin.”

“And the reason your name is Brenda Walsh on that business license behind you,” Dad added calmly, “is because in October of 2001, sixteen-year-old Katie and Nate asked me and my attorney to make restoring your maiden name a condition of paying off your cruise debt in the divorce decree—because neither of your children wanted you carrying the Prairie name ever again.”

Sitting in my SwiftChair with Dad’s forty-second-birthday gift bag from Neat Stuff hanging beside my armrest, I looked from the six-foot cardboard cutout of Garrett Thorne grinning beside the register to Brenda, and then to Sharron, Donna, and Carol.

“Sixteen days ago, on the morning of March eighteenth,” I said evenly, “the man on that cardboard cutout stood on the South Lawn of the White House on live national television and called me a ‘nasty, bitter little cripple,’ said I was ‘slow’ and had ‘no stamina,’ called us ‘defective,’ and mocked your son Nate as my ‘crippled twin

brother.' Not only did you build a shrine to the man who hurled derogatory slurs at your own children's wheelchairs on national television, Brenda—you're also deceiving your own friends and customers right here in Suite 756."

I pointed past the plastic jar of five-dollar buttons on the counter to the hidden eight-point disclaimer taped flat against the glass.

"Constituents have been calling my Senate Commerce Committee office all month asking if the rumors are true that these 'Thorne Superstores'—or the local Restore the Republic chapters—are officially vetted, endorsed, and licensed by Garrett Thorne, his company, or his campaign," I said, looking directly at Sharron, Donna, and Carol. "Look behind that button jar on the counter, ladies, and look at the Guangdong wholesale tags inside the collars. Just like the local chapters, this store has zero authorization or endorsement from Garrett Thorne or his campaign. When that couple from Kempsville just handed Brenda a hundred dollars thinking it was going to the President's Senate trial defense fund, every single dime went straight into Brenda's personal bank account."

Donna and Carol stepped up to the glass counter, peered behind the button jar at the tiny eight-point disclaimer, and looked from Brenda's blotchy face to the grinning cardboard cutout of Garrett Thorne.

As mothers and grandmothers themselves, the three women looked at what Brenda had done to make her own two children cut her off—forcing two sixteen-year-old teenagers with failing legs onto a cruise ship, screaming at them when they couldn't walk, retreating to a bottle of gin when they went into wheelchairs, forgetting their forty-second birthday, and then cheering on a man who mocked her own son and daughter on national television while she fleeced her own chapter friends behind a button jar.

In that quiet strip-mall storefront, the entire illusion of the movement they had been pouring their lives into shattered at once.

Sharron stared at the cardboard cutout of Garrett Thorne, and then looked straight across the counter at Brenda in horror.

"Wait—we worshipped a man who has said derogatory things about your own daughter?!" Sharron said, her voice trembling with maternal outrage. "Calling her a cripple, and slow, and saying she has no stamina?! No, Brenda, we can't support this anymore!"

Sharron set the two flags and the coffee mug she had been holding flat down onto the glass counter with a sharp thud—and then reached up to the collar of her cardigan, unpinned her gold-bordered crimson *Restore the Republic — Chapter President* badge, and dropped it onto the glass right in front of Brenda.

"I started our Virginia Beach Restore the Republic chapter three years ago—and just like your phony store, Brenda, President Thorne never endorsed or cared about a single one of us either," Sharron said, her voice shaking with disgust. "I am a mother and a grandmother. Hearing what you did to your own sixteen-year-old twins when they went into wheelchairs—and watching you stand here worshipping a man who calls your own daughter a cripple and slow on national television while you use our members as your personal piggy bank—makes me sick to my stomach."

Beside her, Donna and Carol reached up to their own lapels, unpinned their crimson Restore the Republic pins, and dropped them onto the glass countertop with two sharp metallic clicks.

“We’re done with you, Brenda, and we’re done with Restore the Republic,” Donna said firmly.

“I’m shutting the chapter down tonight,” Sharron told Brenda flatly, before turning around in the narrow aisle with Donna and Carol to face Dad, Nate, and me. All three women had tears shining in their eyes.

“David… Katie… Nathaniel… Brittany,” Sharron said softly, her voice thick with genuine remorse as she looked down at our two wheelchairs and nodded kindly toward Brittany and Chelsea by the door. “We owe all of you an apology. We bought into ugly lies on television about a family we should have been proud of all along. What your father did for you two—and the loving home all of you have built together after what she put you through—is extraordinary.”

“We’re so sorry, Senator Prairie,” Carol said, wiping her cheek with the back of her hand. “Every single one of us—and our husbands—are voting Democrat in the next election, and you have our votes for as long as you run.”

“And happy forty-second birthday on Thursday, Katie and Nathaniel,” Donna added warmly as the three women stepped to the front door and held it open for us.

“Thank you, Sharron. Thank you, Donna, Carol,” I said, genuinely touched as Nate and Dad nodded warmly to all three of them.

Behind the glass counter, Brenda stood frozen in total, trembling silence—abandoned by the family she had mistreated twenty-six years ago and just walked out on by the friends and movement she had traded us for—inside an empty storefront that smelled of cheap vinyl ink and Pho 79’s simmering beef broth.

Out on Holland Road beyond the plate-glass window, the amber LED destination sign of the one-thirty-five CVTA Route 36 bus glided into view as it approached the Timberline Shopping Center stop—a bus route that only ran on Saturday afternoons because Nate, Dad, and I had fought to save and expand it sixteen years ago when I first took my seat on the Virginia Beach City Council.

I glanced once more at the stacks of newly delivered cardboard shipping cartons piled behind Brenda’s register—every single box stenciled *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED* and *THORNE 2028*.

“Goodbye, Brenda,” I said quietly, turning my SwiftChair smoothly in the narrow aisle alongside Nate’s chair as Dad walked beside us toward the open doorway. “And as your United States Senator—I hope you kept the wholesale receipts for those ‘3-0 Undefeated’ and ‘2028’ boxes before the Senate reconvenes on April fourteenth.”

The cheap brass bell above the door jangled once more behind us as Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I rolled and stepped out of Suite 756 into the warm, clean Virginia Beach sunshine—waving goodbye to Sharron, Donna, and Carol on the sidewalk while the Route 36 bus kneeled at the curb to take all five of us home to Kempsville.

Part 3: The Words of Mason, Madison, and Lincoln, Three Guilty Votes, & From Capitol Police Protection Back to Normal Life at Pleasure House Road

Date: 2027-07-17 at 13:30 America/New_York

Wednesday & Thursday, April 14–15, 2027 — Convicting Secretary Halverson and Vice President Drayton

Two years earlier, in January of 2025, I had been sitting at my desk in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond when President Garrett Thorne nominated Bret Halverson—the slick, hair-sprayed weekend host of *Patriot Watch Weekend* on the Liberty First Network—to serve as United States Secretary of Defense, and when Vice President Conrad Drayton cast the tie-breaking fiftieth vote to put him in charge of the Pentagon over the objections of every military family in Hampton Roads.

That weekend in 2025, Halverson had gone back on his old cable network for a victory lap, laughing with his former co-hosts about *"that little wheelchair state senator down in Richmond who thought she could stop the Pentagon."*

He wasn't laughing anymore.

On Wednesday afternoon, April 14, 2027, Bret Halverson sat pale and sweating at the respondent's table in the well of the United States Senate Chamber while Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling presided from the marble rostrum and the Reading Clerk called the final roll on Article One and Article Two of his impeachment.

Up on the top tier of the Senate Floor beside the accessible upper doorway, I sat alone at my custom-height mahogany Senator's desk in my compact SwiftChair with my electromagnetic drive brakes locked firm and my red-tabbed impeachment evidence binder resting flat across my lap. Because Senate rules strictly limit the chamber floor during an impeachment trial to sworn United States Senators and officers of the court, my twin brother Nate sat in his matching SwiftChair beside our dad, Brittany, and Chelsea at the brass railing of the Senate Family Gallery directly across the chamber, his blue eyes locked steadily on mine while Brittany kept a quiet, reassuring arm around Chelsea's shoulders.

Down in the well, Halverson's defense attorneys didn't even look up toward my desk. After the House managers had displayed the screenshots of Halverson texting classified Naval Station Norfolk carrier strike group deployment schedules over a commercial phone app alongside the four-hundred-million-dollar Thorne Global Holdings kickback ledger Nate's scripts had uncovered, seventeen institutional Republican Senators from defense and coastal states had announced they were crossing the aisle.

"Mr. Mendoza," the Reading Clerk called out.

"Guilty," Senator Mendoza answered from across the aisle.

The clerk's eyes moved down the alphabetical tally sheet and looked up toward my mahogany desk at the top of the chamber.

"Ms. Prairie."

For half a second, the entire Senate Chamber went dead silent. Down at the respondent's table, Bret Halverson finally raised his head, looking up the tiered steps of the chamber straight at the wheelchair he had mocked on national television two years ago.

I didn't raise my voice, and I didn't take my hands off my armrests—even though beneath the calm wool lapel of my navy blazer, my blood was boiling hot enough to blister paint.

Looking down at Bret Halverson in the well, I wasn't only seeing the cable-television fraud who had texted classified Fifth Fleet deployment coordinates for six thousand Naval Station Norfolk sailors over a commercial phone app and buried four hundred million dollars in offshore kickbacks. I was looking two miles across the Potomac River to the quiet green slopes of Arlington National Cemetery, where my grandfather—Grandpa Walter Prairie, Grandma Ruth's husband, who had served aboard a United States Navy destroyer in the North Atlantic during World War II—slept beneath a plain white marble headstone that Dad, Grandma Ruth, Nate, and I had stood beside in silence since we were little kids.

I was remembering Veterans Day five months ago, watching Halverson and his grinning entourage treat the sacred marble steps at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier like a television green room—laughing and carrying on so loudly over hallowed ground that young Specialist Caleb Navarro of The Old Guard had been forced to halt his twenty-one-step march on the mat, snap to attention, and bark across the plaza at the Secretary of Defense's own party to maintain an atmosphere of silence and respect at all times. *You do not do that.* You do not disrespect the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier—not if you are a tourist off a tour bus, and ten thousand times less if you hold the seal of the Department of Defense. And then, when cell-phone video of an enlisted sentinel reprimanding his group went viral, watching Halverson stage that stomach-turning Pentagon photo-op the very next afternoon—hauling Specialist Navarro across the river in front of press cameras to pin a Joint Service Commendation Medal on his chest and post smug, chest-thumping slogans online—hadn't fooled me for half a second. That medal wasn't honor; it was pure, cynical damage control, turning a disciplined young soldier who had simply defended the dignity of the fallen into a human shield for his own disgrace.

Looking straight down into Halverson's eyes on behalf of Naval Station Norfolk, The Old Guard, and Grandpa Walter resting across the river, I gave him the vote I had promised from Richmond in 2025.

"Guilty," I said clearly across the quiet chamber.

By a vote of seventy-one to twenty-nine—four votes above the two-thirds constitutional threshold required under Article I, Section 3 of the Constitution—the Senate convicted and removed Bret Halverson from office. Ten minutes later, when Majority Leader Charles Schuman moved the second resolution permanently barring Bret Halverson from ever holding any office of honor, trust, or profit under the United States again—ensuring he would never again stand in a chain of command over Arlington National Cemetery or use an American soldier as a damage-control prop—the Reading Clerk called *"Ms. Prairie"* a second time, and with my pulse still blazing behind my ribs, I answered just as clearly:

"Aye."

Twenty-four hours later, on Thursday afternoon, April 15, 2027, the second domino fell.

Confronted with the unredacted Treasury wire tables proving that Vice President Conrad Drayton had personally co-signed the offshore routing waivers for the Naval Station Norfolk logistics kickbacks and sat on the exact same unsecured messaging thread while our Fifth Fleet sailors' movements were compromised, sixty-eight Senators—including me—voted Guilty at four-thirty on Thursday afternoon to convict and remove Conrad Drayton from the Vice Presidency, followed immediately by a second vote permanently disqualifying him from future federal office.

With the Democratic majority in the House of Representatives and our fifty-four-seat majority in the Senate refusing to entertain any Twenty-Fifth Amendment replacement nominee from a disgraced White House, the office of Vice President of the United States stood completely vacant as Thursday night fell over Washington.

Friday, April 16, 2027, 1:30 PM — The Words of George Mason, James Madison, and Abraham Lincoln

At three o'clock on Friday morning—less than eleven hours before the final Senate deliberation and roll-call vote on the Articles of Impeachment against President Garrett Thorne—the President had gone online from the residence of the White House to unleash one final, desperate tirade against Nate and me.

In all-capital letters, Thorne had called me a *"defective, bitter little cripple on wheels"* and a *"spinster who couldn't keep a man in her twenties and is trying to steal the Presidency from her wheelchair with her shut-in twin brother."*

Even at the very end, Garrett Thorne still didn't understand that every ugly, ableist insult he hurled at my wheelchair and my brother only disgusted more institutional Senators in his own party and cemented the two-thirds coalition against him.

At one-thirty on Friday afternoon, April 16, 2027, inside the closed marble chamber of the United States Senate during the final hour of deliberations before the roll call, I engaged the drive lock on my SwiftChair beside my top-tier mahogany desk, pressed my microphone button, and rested my hands on the edge of my lectern as all ninety-nine of my fellow Senators turned toward my seat.

"Mr. Chief Justice, and my colleagues of the Senate," I said evenly across the silent chamber. "Two hundred and forty years ago, right down the road from where my brother Nate and I grew up in Virginia, George Mason stood at the Constitutional Convention in Philadelphia and warned that no man who holds the executive power should ever be placed above the reach of the law when he corrupts his office, asking the delegates: *Shall any man be above justice? Above all, shall that man be above it, who can commit the most extensive injustice?*"

Up in the Family Gallery above the marble columns, Dad rested his hand on Nate's shoulder while Brittany squeezed Chelsea's hand beside them as Nate looked down at me from his SwiftChair.

"And when another Virginian, James Madison, wrote *Federalist Number 51*," I continued, my voice calm and unhurried, "he didn't tell us to trust the personal goodwill of a President or a Cabinet Secretary. Madison wrote: *If men were angels,*

no government would be necessary. If angels were to govern men, neither external nor internal controls on government would be necessary. In framing a government which is to be administered by men over men, the great difficulty lies in this: you must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place oblige it to control itself. Madison and the framers gave this Senate the sole power to try all impeachments specifically to guard the republic against men who treat a public trust as a private business."

I looked down into the well toward the respondent's table where President Garrett Thorne's defense lawyers sat staring down at their legal pads.

"Abraham Lincoln once said that nearly all men can stand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power—and at Gettysburg, he charged every generation of Americans to ensure that government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth," I said. "We gave Garrett Thorne, Conrad Drayton, and Bret Halverson the highest powers under this Constitution. They used that power to trade tariff waivers and Naval Station Norfolk fleet contracts for four hundred million dollars in offshore kickbacks, to leak the movements of six thousand Virginia sailors on commercial phones, and to mock the disabled citizens they swore an oath to serve. Mason, Madison, and Lincoln left us an exact constitutional remedy for men who fail that test—and when the Clerk calls the roll, I will vote Guilty."

Friday, April 16, 2027, 2:15 PM — Sixty-Eight Guilty Votes, Permanent Disqualification, & President Clara Morales

At two o'clock, the gallery doors were unlocked to the public and the press corps, and Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling rose in his black judicial robe at the marble rostrum.

"The Secretary will call the roll on Article One of the Articles of Impeachment exhibited by the House of Representatives against Garrett Thorne, President of the United States," Chief Justice Sterling announced.

This was the third time in American history that the House of Representatives had impeached Garrett Thorne—and during his first two impeachments back in his first term, he had escaped removal only because the Senate tally had fallen short of the two-thirds constitutional wall.

This third time, the wall broke.

One by one, as the Reading Clerk called the alphabetical roll, fourteen Republican Senators who had voted to acquit Thorne in his earlier impeachment trials rose from their mahogany desks and answered *"Guilty."*

"Mr. Mendoza," the Reading Clerk called out.

"Guilty," Senator Mendoza answered.

"Ms. Prairie."

I kept my hands resting calmly on the armrests of my SwiftChair, my electromagnetic drive brakes locked tight against the blue Senate carpet. Twenty-two years after Brandon Mercer had bruised my wrist behind closed doors in

Williamsburg and ordered Nate and me to wait outside the train station while he bought tickets inside, never dreaming two nineteen-year-olds in powerchairs would roll onto a Newport News bus together without him—and thirteen days after rolling into Suite 756 at Timberline Shopping Center on Holland Road and seeing the shrines and unopened crates of *"3-0 UNDEFEATED"* and *"THORNE 2028"* merchandise my own estranged mother had chosen over her children—I looked straight down into the well of the United States Senate.

"Guilty," I said clearly.

Twenty minutes later, when the Reading Clerk handed the certified tally sheet up to the rostrum showing that sixty-eight Senators had voted Guilty on both Articles of Impeachment—exceeding the sixty-seven-vote two-thirds constitutional threshold required under Article I, Section 3—Chief Justice Sterling struck the marble rostrum once with his ivory gavel.

"The Senate having tried Garrett Thorne, President of the United States, upon two Articles of Impeachment exhibited against him by the House of Representatives, and two-thirds of the Senators present having found him guilty of high crimes and misdemeanors," Chief Justice Sterling declared across the hushed chamber, "it is therefore ordered and adjudged that the said Garrett Thorne be, and he is hereby, removed from office."

Before the defense table could even close their briefcases, Senate Majority Leader Charles Schuman rose and moved the second resolution under Article I, Section 3, Clause 7: permanent disqualification from ever holding any federal office again, which under settled Senate precedent required only a simple majority of fifty-one votes. When the clerk called *"Ms. Prairie"* on the permanent disqualification roll call, I delivered my second vote of the hour just as evenly as the first:

"Aye."

The disqualification resolution passed sixty-eight to thirty-two. With that gavel strike, Garrett Thorne, Conrad Drayton, and Bret Halverson were not only stripped of their offices—they were barred for the rest of their natural lives from ever putting their names on a federal ballot or holding any office of honor, trust, or profit under the United States again.

Looking up across the marble columns at Nate in the Family Gallery as he smiled down at me from his SwiftChair, both of us were thinking the exact same thing: if Garrett Thorne had wanted Mana Canvas's *The Grand Decree* as his unauthorized 2024 theme song so badly before Mana Canvas and Engine Room Records hit his campaign with copyright claims and a cease-and-desist order, the Senate had just given him the broken-music-box reprise from the end of the *Runebreaker* soundtrack.

And because we had convicted and removed Vice President Conrad Drayton on Thursday afternoon and left the Vice Presidency vacant, the Presidential Succession Act of 1947—Title 3, Section 19 of the United States Code—took immediate constitutional effect.

Fifteen minutes after the Senate doors swung open, Nate, Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea took the elevator down from the Family Gallery and rolled or walked down the marble corridor beside my wheelchair into the Mansfield Room just off the Senate Floor.

Standing beneath the crystal chandelier—having just signed her formal resignation as Speaker and Representative from the House—was Clara Morales, her left hand resting on a bound copy of the Constitution and her family Bible while she raised her right hand before Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling to take the constitutional oath of office as the new President of the United States.

Nate locked his SwiftChair brakes right alongside mine at the front of the room and reached across the two-inch gap between our armrests to squeeze my hand while Dad rested his hands proudly on our shoulders.

"Clean sweep, Senator," Nate whispered against my ear as the room erupted into applause for President Clara Morales. "All three of them gone for good."

"Every single one, Nate," I whispered back, squeezing my twin brother's hand just as tight.

Twenty minutes later, when Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I rode the subway car back under Constitution Avenue and rolled into Dirksen Room 511, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins were standing side by side around the reception television with tears in their eyes and smiles from ear to ear.

On the screen, live from his front porch in Danville with Aunt Marge Callaway standing beside him, former Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway was looking straight into a row of Roanoke and Richmond television cameras.

"Every conservative in the Commonwealth of Virginia who still believes in the United States Constitution owes Senator Katie Prairie and the sixty-seven Senators who stood with her today a debt of gratitude," Uncle Richard declared in his steady Southside baritone as the news chyron beneath him flashed *FORMER VA GOP MAJORITY LEADER RICHARD CALLAWAY ENDORSES SEN. PRAIRIE'S 'GUILTY' & 'AYE' IMPEACHMENT VOTES*. "When Senator Prairie voted Guilty to convict Garrett Thorne, Conrad Drayton, and Bret Halverson for selling out our Naval Station Norfolk sailors, and when she voted Aye to bar all three of those men from ever holding federal office again, she didn't cast a partisan vote. She cast the exact vote that George Mason and James Madison wrote into the Constitution to protect this Republic."

Before the television anchor could ask a follow-up question, the private direct line on Sarah's front desk chimed.

"It's Uncle Richard and Aunt Marge calling from the porch!" Sarah beamed, tapping the speakerphone button as Sam and Mandy leaned in beside our wheelchairs.

"Katie! Nate! David! Brittany, Chelsea!" Uncle Richard's voice boomed warmly through the speakerphone once the television crew in his front yard had lowered their microphones. "Marge and I just watched President Clara Morales take the oath of office, and we wanted to tell all five of you ourselves how proud we are of this family."

“Thank you, Richard—and thank you for going on the air in Danville to back both the Guilty vote and the Aye vote to bar them from office,” I said warmly from my SwiftChair.

“Easiest endorsement of my life, Senator,” Uncle Richard chuckled, before his voice took on the quiet, determined resolve of the old Majority Leader. “And now that President Morales has been sworn in and Garrett Thorne is barred from ever putting his name on a ballot again, the fever can finally break. Starting tomorrow morning, I’m rolling up my sleeves with every institutional conservative left in Virginia to clean up the Republican Party and bring it back to the honorable, problem-solving party I remembered when I served in the House of Delegates—so that one of these days, Marge and I can finally go back to voting for Republicans again.”

Beside my wheelchair, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah exchanged a grin.

“Every Republican, Uncle Richard?” Mandy asked playfully.

Over the speakerphone from Danville, Uncle Richard let out a rich, warm laugh.

“Well, every Republican except one,” the old lion of Southside Virginia corrected himself gently. “I already warned the state party committee this afternoon: I’m going back to voting Republican down the line—except when Katie Prairie runs for re-election to the United States Senate. As long as Katie’s name is on that ballot, she has Marge’s vote and mine.”

Seconds after we thanked Uncle Richard and Aunt Marge and hung up the speakerphone, the breaking-news banner across the bottom of the reception television flashed bright red.

Down in Florida—stripped of the Presidency, stripped of his Secret Service successor authority, and barred for the rest of his life from ever putting his name on a ballot again—private citizen Garrett Thorne had just stormed out onto the driveway of his resort club in front of the cable cameras.

Even though sixty-eight United States Senators—including fourteen members of his own party—had just voted to convict and disqualify him, Garrett Thorne’s narcissistic, ableist ego could not bear the humiliation that a forty-two-year-old autistic woman in a wheelchair and her twin brother had uncovered his four-hundred-million-dollar Naval Station Norfolk kickback scheme and delivered the closing constitutional case that ended his political life.

On live national television, his face purple with rage, Garrett Thorne launched a full-blown personal vendetta—blaming *“Broken Katie Prairie”* for his removal from office.

“Broken Katie Prairie did this to me!” Thorne screamed into the microphones, his voice cracking as he jabbed a finger toward the camera lenses. *“Sixty-eight weak, spineless cowards let Broken Katie Prairie in her little wheelchair and her shut-in brother’s rigged computers in Virginia Beach steal my Presidency and ban me from running in 2028! Broken Katie Prairie is the reason I was removed from office—she destroyed our movement, and no real patriot in Restore the Republic should ever give Broken Katie Prairie a single moment of peace!”*

Uncle Richard hadn’t even reached his front door in Danville before the impact of Thorne’s tirade hit our fifth-floor suite.

Within sixty seconds, all eight external trunk lines on Sarah's front reception console began blinking frantic red at once as furious Restore the Republic extremists—incited by their deposed leader's live meltdown—started flooding our office switchboard.

Sarah's hand hovered over the receiver, her shoulders tensing, when Nate rolled his SwiftChair forward and gently rested his hand over the mute bar.

"Don't pick that up, Sarah," Nate said calmly.

Before the console could ring a third time, the double mahogany doors of Dirksen Room 511 swung open.

Stepping briskly into our reception room was the Senate Sergeant at Arms, flanked by Inspector Marcus Vance of the United States Capitol Police Threat Assessment Section and four plainclothes special agents wearing the gold lapel pins of the Capitol Police Dignitary Protection Division.

"Leave the phones on mute, Ms. Sarah—our telecom unit in the Capitol Police Command Center is cutting in on your external trunk lines right now," Inspector Vance said with calm, professional authority as two Senate telecommunications technicians stepped behind Sarah's desk and plugged a hardware trap-and-trace filter into the switchboard wall jack. "Every incoming call, voicemail, and IP packet threatening Senator Prairie, her family, or her staff is being routed directly to the Capitol Police Threat Assessment Section and the FBI Washington Field Office for felony prosecution under Title 18, Section 115 of the United States Code. None of the three of you will have to listen to a single one of those calls."

Sam, Mandy, and Sarah let out a collective breath as the blinking red lights on the console shifted to silent blue law-enforcement recording indicators.

Inspector Vance turned toward Dad, Nate, Brittany, Chelsea, and me, his expression grave.

"Senator Prairie, we monitored former President Thorne's broadcast from Florida in real time," the Capitol Police Inspector said. "Because he singled you out by name and blamed you personally for his conviction and disqualification, our Threat Assessment Section has elevated your protective posture to Tier One. Uniformed Capitol Police officers are now posted outside Room 511 around the clock, and we've already coordinated twenty-four-hour residential patrols with the Alexandria Police Department on Sunset Drive and the Virginia Beach Police Department at your Virginia Beach residences. In addition, the Capitol Police Board has assigned a full-time plainclothes Dignitary Protection detail to accompany you and your household everywhere you travel—and we have an armored Capitol Police van waiting downstairs in the Dirksen courtyard to drive you, Nate, Mr. Prairie, Ms. Fletcher, and Ms. Chelsea home to Alexandria right now."

Inside Dirksen Room 511, the room went quiet.

Dad looked down at Nate and me, a knowing smile tugging at the corner of his mouth, while Brittany kept her arm gently around Chelsea on the sofa and Sam, Mandy, and Sarah watched my wheelchair.

I kept my hands resting evenly on the armrests of my SwiftChair and looked up at Inspector Vance.

I wasn't the slightest bit afraid of Garrett Thorne—not after surviving Brandon Mercer in Williamsburg twenty-two years ago and escaping him across six buses side by side with Nate, and not after staring Thorne's lawyers down from the top tier of the Senate floor—but I took the protection of the United States Capitol Police very seriously, especially when it came to keeping Dad, Nate, Brittany, Chelsea, and my staff safe.

"Inspector Vance, thank you—first and foremost for stepping in immediately to protect Sam, Mandy, and Sarah at the front desk, and for coordinating residential patrols in Alexandria and Virginia Beach so Brittany and Chelsea never have to worry at home," I said clearly. "We take your Threat Assessment team's protocols very seriously, and our office will follow every security procedure you set for Room 511 and our travel schedules. We will gladly accept your plainclothes Capitol Police Dignitary Protection detail, subject to two non-negotiable rules."

"Name them, Senator," Inspector Vance said.

"Rule one: nobody on the detail ever touches the push-handles of my wheelchair or my brother's wheelchair without asking our permission first," I said.

"Understood and already briefed to every agent on the team," Vance nodded. "And rule two?"

I glanced toward the framed purple-and-blue crayon drawing from Natalie Brooks hanging on our office wall, then over at Sam's desk—where Sam, Nate, and I had spent every spare hour between impeachment trial sessions drafting the federal transit appropriations rider to fund a public bus link across the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel—and finally at my twin brother Nate sitting in his SwiftChair beside me.

"Rule two, Inspector, is that you can send the armored van back to the garage," I said calmly. "Garrett Thorne is a disgraced private citizen who just got fired from the Presidency and permanently barred from ever holding public office again. I respect your officers' mission, and we will give your detail our exact train and bus times in advance so your agents can position themselves safely around us—but if I let Garrett Thorne's temper tantrum scare our family off public transportation and lock us inside an armored truck, then Garrett Thorne wins. Plus, Sam, Nate, and I still have an hour of work left on our federal transit grant connecting Cape Charles on the Eastern Shore across the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel to the CVTA transfer point at Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road. At five-fifteen, Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, and I—along with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah—are rolling down the elevator and out the accessible door to Capitol South Station to ride the Blue Line home to Alexandria, and tomorrow morning we are catching the ARTS train and the CVTA Route 24 bus home to Virginia Beach."

Nate grinned from his SwiftChair and held up his blue plastic transit card between two fingers.

"Your Dignitary Protection agents are more than welcome to ride with us, Inspector," my twin brother added cheerfully. "Just make sure every agent brings a loaded CapitalPass card—because on Senator Prairie's detail, everybody pays their fare and everybody rides the bus."

Saturday, July 17, 2027, 9:40 AM — How Thorne's Vendetta Heat Died Down & Rolling Off Route 913 at Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road

For the next ten weeks, we followed every protocol the United States Capitol Police put in place—and while the cable pundits wondered how long Garrett Thorne's post-conviction vendetta against *"Broken Katie Prairie"* would last, we kept our heads down and did the legislative work the people of Virginia had sent us to Washington to do.

When reporters outside the Capitol South elevator asked me to respond to Thorne's latest rant from his Florida driveway, I didn't give his ego a single drop of the oxygen he was starving for.

"I'm grateful to the United States Capitol Police officers riding the Blue Line with us today, and I have complete confidence in federal law enforcement," I told the cameras without looking up from my committee folder. "Mr. Thorne is an unemployed private citizen in Florida with a federal court date. Right now my brother Nate, my Legislative Correspondent Sam, and I are marking up the federal funding to connect ShoreLine Transit in Cape Charles across the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel to the CVTA transfer point at Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road —because working families on the Eastern Shore and in Hampton Roads still have to get to work and the hospital tomorrow morning."

Watched closely by Inspector Vance's Threat Assessment team, the heat of Garrett Thorne's vendetta collapsed faster than anyone in Washington had predicted—extinguished by five cold, unmistakable realities.

First, within seventy-two hours of Thorne's April sixteenth outburst, the United States Capitol Police Threat Assessment Section and the FBI used the hardware trap-and-trace logs from Dirksen Room 511 to arrest the first fourteen Restore the Republic extremists who had called our switchboard with threats. When those callers were led into federal courthouses in handcuffs on the six o'clock news facing ten-year felony sentences under Title 18, Section 115 of the United States Code—and suddenly realized that Garrett Thorne was no longer President of the United States, possessed zero constitutional pardon power to save them, and wasn't paying a single dime toward their defense lawyers—the nerve of the online mob shattered overnight. Within two weeks, the threatening calls to our office dropped to zero.

Second, under Article I, Section 3, Clause 7 of the United States Constitution, removal by the Senate stripped Garrett Thorne of every shred of presidential immunity and left him, as a private citizen, *"liable and subject to Indictment, Trial, Judgment and Punishment, according to Law."* On May 12, 2027, a federal grand jury returned a thirty-four-count felony indictment against Garrett Thorne, Conrad Drayton, and Bret Halverson for federal bribery, wire fraud, money laundering, and Espionage Act violations over the four-hundred-million-dollar Naval Station Norfolk kickback scheme, while the Department of Justice froze Thorne Global Holdings' offshore accounts. At Thorne's federal arraignment that afternoon, as a strict condition of pre-trial release under Title 18, Section 3142 so he wouldn't await trial behind bars, the United States District Judge imposed an ironclad gag and no-harassment order: if Garrett Thorne uttered or posted the name of Senator Katie Prairie, her family, her staff, or any congressional witness on television or online, his bail would be revoked immediately and United States Marshals would remand him straight into a federal detention cell. Terrified of spending a single night in a jail cell, Thorne shut his mouth on the spot.

Third, our sixty-eight-vote *Aye* tally permanently barring Thorne from ever holding federal office again drained every ounce of his political leverage. A movement built on personal fealty to one man cannot survive once that man is legally barred from ever appearing on a ballot again. Within a month, the cable cameras at LibertyMax and the Liberty First Network stopped cutting to his driveway in Florida, ambitious politicians started fighting over the wide-open 2028 nomination as if Thorne were already ancient history, and back home in Virginia, Uncle Richard and a coalition of institutional conservatives began methodically cleaning out the state Republican party apparatus.

By Monday, July 12, 2027—after sixty consecutive days without a single credible threat logged against our office or our homes—Inspector Marcus Vance walked into Dirksen Room 511 with a warm smile, unplugged the trap-and-trace unit from Sarah's reception console, and informed Dad, Nate, Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me that the Capitol Police Threat Assessment Section had officially downgraded our posture back to routine baseline and stood down our round-the-clock protective detail.

Five days later—on Saturday morning, July 17, 2027—all eight of us celebrated getting our normal, quiet everyday lives back in the only way that felt right.

Having seen President Clara Morales sign our bipartisan Federal Rural & Bridge-Tunnel Transit Connectivity appropriation into law the month before—establishing dedicated Federal Transit Administration Section 5311(f) intercity operating funds to cover the seventeen-point-six-mile cross-bay span and the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel District's nominal Class 8 public-transit toll of one dollar per crossing via each agency's fleet transponder, together with a mandatory statutory stipulation requiring complete reciprocal cross-honoring of all fares and passes between CVTA and ShoreLine Transit—the two transit agencies had pooled one vehicle apiece from opposite shores into a joint hourly express numbered Route 913 along U.S. Route 13: one forty-foot low-floor CVTA Stalwart Advantage coach pulling out northbound from Virginia Beach on the even hours and southbound from Cape Charles on the odd hours, paired with one highway-geared ShoreLine Transit dual-rear-wheel cutaway bus departing southbound on the even hours and northbound on the odd hours. Even smarter, rather than forcing forty-foot transit coaches and through-riders on a five-mile detour off the highway into historic downtown Cape Charles, the planners terminated Route 913 right on U.S. Route 13 and State Route 184 at the Cape Center Market Square plaza—timed to arrive at forty minutes past every hour so riders heading north to Eastville, Exmore, or Onley could step right across the plaza curb onto ShoreLine Transit's northbound Red Route cutaway van at forty-five minutes past the hour as it came out of downtown Cape Charles, while the Purple and Red cutaway loops handled the short shuttle into town.

At nine o'clock sharp that morning, having just transferred across the Market Square plaza curb on U.S. Route 13 without an armored van or protective detail anywhere in sight, Nate, Dad, Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and I boarded the nine o'clock southbound Route 913 departure aboard CVTA Coach 2514, its full-width amber LED headsign showing a giant *913* beside the two-line split *VA BEACH / SHORE & PLEAS HSE* and *VA BEACH / via CBBT*. Gliding through the electronic Class 8 lane at the North Toll Plaza for a single dollar, our forty-foot coach rolled out across the sun-drenched concrete trestles with Chelsea beaming out the wide tinted window beside Brittany. At nine-twenty, halfway across the open water between Fisherman Island and the Thimble Shoal channel, our driver tapped a friendly two-note horn salute as ShoreLine Transit's northbound cutaway bus hummed past us in the opposite lane—its narrow single-line amber LED forehead

sign above the cab windshield flipping crisply between *CAPE CHARLES* and *913 via CBBT* on its way to meet the nine forty-five northbound Onley connection—before we plunged through the two mile-long underwater tunnels where the silver-green waves of the Chesapeake Bay met the open Atlantic Ocean, climbed onto the south toll plaza at Wise Point, and turned west onto tree-lined Shore Drive into Virginia Beach.

"Approaching Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road—Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Transfer Point," the automated interior chime announced at nine-forty in the morning as our driver pulled smoothly up to the right-hand concrete curb just past the Pleasure House Road mast-arm traffic signals, across the four-lane divided suburban corridor from the brick Bayside Pharmacy beneath tall Virginia loblolly pines and blooming pink crape myrtles, and tapped his overhead keypad so Coach 2514's front amber LED destination sign flipped cleanly to *913 CAPE CHARLES* and *913 via CBBT* ahead of its ten o'clock northbound run.

As the driver kneeled the air suspension and deployed the front yellow hydraulic ramp onto the sunny Virginia Beach sidewalk at Pleasure House Road, Dad, Brittany—setting her canvas tote bag with Chelsea's green plush sea turtle Shelly beside the shelter—Chelsea, and twenty-five-year-old Sam, Mandy, and Sarah Hawkins stepped down onto the concrete, turning back to smile as Nate and I rolled our two SwiftChairs side by side down the ramp into the warm Bayside breeze.

Up at the glass CVTA bus shelter, commuters in navy shipyard shirts, Eastern Shore hospital nurses, and summer riders with backpacks were already stepping off our coach and walking across the sidewalk toward the connecting local stop—where, thanks to the cross-honoring stipulation in our bill, CVTA fareboxes accepted their ShoreLine Transit passes and transfers without charging them a single extra dime to continue across Virginia Beach and Norfolk, while early passengers bound for Onley and the Eastern Shore lined up with their CVTA passes ready for ten o'clock.

Dad rested a proud hand behind my chair beside Brittany and Chelsea, glancing east down tree-lined Shore Drive toward the Wise Point approach we had just rolled in from as everyday Saturday traffic hummed past the brick median.

"No cameras, no guards, and a public bus running all the way across the Bay to Shore Drive and Pleasure House Road," Dad said softly. "How does it feel to have your normal Saturday back, Senator?"

I looked over at Sam, Mandy, and Sarah smiling by the glass shelter, then up at Dad, Brittany, and a beaming Chelsea behind us, and finally across the two inches between our armrests at my twin brother Nate.

"It feels like home, Dad," I smiled, holding up my cross-honored transit pass right alongside Nate's in the warm July sunshine. "Come on, everybody—let's catch our connection."

Street Clothes on the Route 250 Connector, Unannounced in Fishersville, & Calling the Governor

ARTS Train 51 to Staunton, Street Clothes on the Route 250 Connector, & Calling Governor Langford From Fishersville

Date: 2027-07-21 at 11:57 America/New_York

Wednesday, July 21, 2027, 11:57 AM — ARTS Train 51 Out of Alexandria & Eighty-Four Pages of Bureaucratic Smoke

“Watch the yellow lip plate there, folks—you’re clear right into the coach vestibule,” the uniformed ARTS conductor called out over the warm July breeze along Platform 2 at Alexandria Station, unlatching the safety chain on the blue hand-cranked mobile wheelchair lift at eleven-fifty-two on Wednesday morning so Katie and I could glide our SwiftChairs one behind the other into the accessible end of the *Cardinal*.

Neither the conductor nor a single passenger boarding westbound Train 51 gave the two of us a second glance, which was the entire point.

Nine days after Inspector Marcus Vance had stood down our round-the-clock Capitol Police protective detail—and while Dad and Brittany stayed home on Sunset Drive with Chelsea so her peaceful weekday routine wouldn’t be disrupted by an unannounced oversight confrontation—Katie and I had hugged all three of them goodbye on the front porch and rolled one short block east beneath the stone-and-steel King Street railroad overpass instead of backtracking across the Potomac into Washington Union Station. We were traveling the way we had traveled our whole adult lives whenever an unannounced field check called for just the two of us—side by side, booked under my personal credit card as two regular disabled passengers requiring occupied power-wheelchair spaces, with zero advance staff, zero press advisories, and not a suit jacket or Senate lapel pin in sight. Katie wore a plain navy cotton V-neck polo shirt, dark jeans, and white sneakers; I wore a heather-grey crew-neck t-shirt, jeans, and canvas sneakers, with our two everyday overnight daypacks clipped neatly to the rear uprights of our SwiftChairs.

At eleven-fifty-seven sharp, the twin air horns sounded past the brick station house beneath the George Washington Masonic Memorial, the couplers gave a gentle metallic tug, and Train 51 eased southwestward away from Alexandria toward Manassas and the Piedmont foothills.

Once the train cleared Bull Run and picked up speed across Prince William County, I reached into my backpack, pulled out an eighty-four-page glossy white comb-bound report stamped with the seal of the Virginia Department for Aging and Rehabilitative Services, and laid it flat across the wide drop-down accessible table in front of our locked wheelchairs.

“Listen to how Commissioner Sterling and Director Cross phrased Section Three on page twenty-nine,” I murmured, angling the pages so Katie could read right alongside me without anyone two rows ahead overhearing. “In bold type at the top of the page, they certify to the Senate Appropriations Subcommittee that all five of

your February seventeenth mandates have reached *Substantial Phase-One Implementation* ahead of next Thursday's full fiscal year 2028 markup, and formally ask your office to release the eighteen-point-five-million-dollar hold."

Katie rested her chin on two fingers, her blue eyes scanning down the dense paragraphs below the heading. "Now read the actual sentences underneath the bold header, Nate."

"On wheelchair bodily autonomy and client handbooks," I read quietly, tracing the lines with my index finger, "*Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center has convened an interdisciplinary Stakeholder Policy Revision Working Group scheduled to circulate draft handbook language for administrative comment during the first quarter of 2028.* On ending mandatory two-week manual-shop Vocational Evaluation tours for college-degreed students and unlocking the developer workstations in the Bates-Harding computer lab: *DARS Vocational Services has initiated a pilot waiver scoping study, and VITA has logged an Enterprise Architecture Exception Request pending quarterly security board review.* And on abolishing yellow Level 2 off-campus passes and adult sibling separation contracts in Barton Hall: *Residential Operations is evaluating modernized community-sign-out workflows.*"

Katie closed the white plastic comb binder with a crisp, quiet snap.

"Twenty years ago, DARS closed our files in Richmond as Code 28—*Unsuccessful Rehabilitation*—because we refused to stay in Barton Hall after twelve days and went home to Virginia Beach to build our own software company," she said softly, looking out the wide coach window as green Piedmont pastures flashed past the glass. "Nobody in Congress needs to explain to you and me how an agency's official paperwork can be properly signed and stamped while telling the exact opposite of what disabled adults are living through on the ground. Five months since Marcus Sterling and Evelyn Cross promised under oath—in front of Natalie and Mrs. Brooks—that they would carry out every single one of those five reforms, and everything affecting how disabled Virginians are treated inside Fishersville was buried in fake 2028 subcommittees, hoping nobody in Washington would check before next Thursday's markup."

"And if Sarah or Sam had called Richmond yesterday to schedule an official Senate oversight visit," I said, resting my right hand over Katie's across the two-inch gap between our armrests, "Sterling and Cross would have spent forty-eight hours hiding every yellow pass clipboard in a locked filing cabinet, taping temporary notices over the lobby racks, parking two VITA technicians in the computer lab with unlocked loaner laptops, and lining up five rehearsed administrators at the visitor sign-in desk."

"Which is why nobody in Richmond, nobody at DARS, and nobody in Fishersville knows we got on this train," Katie replied evenly, lacing her fingers through mine. "And tomorrow morning at the Bates-Harding reception window, my Senate ID stays zipped inside my bag. Both of us medically cannot drive, and both of our Virginia DMV State ID cards carry our real Virginia Beach home address. When we roll off the eight-thirty Route 250 Connector bus at eight-fifty-two and slide two Virginia Beach State IDs under that glass, I want to see firsthand how Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center treats everyday Virginians with disabilities who walk or roll through those front doors when nobody behind the desk has the slightest idea I'm a United States Senator."

All afternoon, as Wednesday's *Cardinal* wound past Culpeper, Orange, and Charlottesville before climbing the steep eastern grade of Afton Mountain and plunging through the dark stone bore of the Blue Ridge Tunnel into the Shenandoah Valley, Katie and I worked quietly side by side on my MagnaBook Pro—cross-checking every page of DARS's glossy compliance binder against the verbatim *Congressional Record* transcript from February seventeenth.

At three-thirty-four in the afternoon, the station brakes hissed gently beside the historic red-brick platform at Staunton Station in the Wharf district, one short block uphill from the Staunton Hub on Lewis Street. Because the *Cardinal* runs only three days a week—Wednesdays, Fridays, and Sundays—through Staunton, I had booked our ground-floor accessible king room at the historic brick hotel beside the tracks for two nights under my own credit card without mentioning the United States Senate once. After the station agent cranked us down the mobile lift onto the warm sunlit bricks, Katie and I rolled across the quiet cobblestone crossing, checked in like any other pair of forty-two-year-old travelers from Tidewater, shared a quiet supper of grilled chicken sandwiches and two ice-cold bottles of ginger ale, and video-called Sunset Drive so Chelsea could wave Shelly at the screen while Dad and Brittany wished us luck for the morning. Plugging our two SwiftChairs into the wall outlet beside the transfer-height accessible king bed—silently grateful all over again to Brittany and Chelsea for gently coaxing the two of us out of sleeping in closets ten years earlier so we could actually stretch out comfortably on a real hotel mattress—we curled up under the crisp cotton quilt with Katie's head tucked under my chin and slept nine uninterrupted hours before the morning bus.

Thursday, July 22, 2027, 8:30 AM — Fifty Cents on the Route 250 Connector & Two Virginia DMV State IDs at the Window

The air suspension of the white-and-green Shenandoah Valley Transit cutaway coach knelt with a soft pneumatic sigh against the concrete curb of the Staunton Hub on Lewis Street at eight-twenty-six on Thursday morning, and the driver stepped out in his short-sleeved uniform shirt to unfold the front wheelchair ramp.

"Morning, y'all—heading out toward Fishersville, the rehab center, or Waynesboro?" the operator asked cheerfully as Katie and I rolled up the aluminum incline one after the other.

"Roosevelt Avenue in Fishersville, please," Katie smiled, dropping a single shiny quarter into the farebox coin slot for the twenty-five-cent half-fare disability rate on the fifty-cent valley route right before I dropped my own quarter in behind her.

Once the operator clicked the four retracting SafeLock floor straps onto our black SwiftChair frames and pulled away from Lewis Street at eight-thirty sharp onto U.S. Route 250 East, we didn't even have to wait until we reached the front visitor desk to find out how much of Commissioner Sterling's eighty-four-page binder was fiction.

Sitting directly across the center aisle from our wheelchairs were two twenty-something Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center residents riding back from an early-morning pharmacy run in downtown Staunton: a twenty-three-year-old woman named Kayla with dark curly hair, a plastic resident photo keycard hanging on a lanyard around her neck, and silver forearm crutches propped neatly between her

knees; and a twenty-four-year-old guy named Trevor wearing his own resident keycard lanyard over a faded Blue Ridge Community College sweatshirt with a sketch tube across his lap.

Clipped right next to Kayla's plastic door badge—flapping lightly in the cool air-conditioning vent every time the bus crested a rolling valley hill—was a crisp, freshly signed, canary-yellow rectangular slip of cardstock stamped across the top in heavy black ink: *BARTON HALL — LEVEL 2 OFF-CAMPUS HALL PASS*.

Beside me, Katie didn't stiffen or stare; she just gave my pinky finger the tiniest tap across our inner armrests and smiled warmly across the aisle when Kayla glanced over at our powerchairs.

"Those compact black chairs turn way tighter than the loaner clunkers they've got down at the center," Kayla remarked appreciatively, nodding toward our SwiftChair joysticks. "Are you two heading in for a nine-o'clock intake appointment at Fishersville today?"

"Just stopping by the front desk this morning to check on a few things," Katie said gently, without a single untruth. "My brother Nate and I actually spent twelve days in Barton Hall twenty years ago before we went home and started our own software business. Don't tell me they're still making grown adults carry signed yellow paper Hall Passes just to ride a fifty-cent bus into Staunton."

Trevor let out a bark of dry, incredulous laughter while Kayla rolled her eyes toward the ceiling of the bus.

"Oh, they upgraded the outer doors with new electronic badge readers after that big Senate hearing back in February so visitors can't get past the front lobby without signing in," Kayla said, flicking the corner of the canary-yellow paper with her thumb, "but for us residents? Not a single rule changed. We still have to beg the morning tech in Barton Hall to sign a yellow Level 2 slip before we step off campus, and the second we get off this bus we have to get it time-stamped at the front lobby window before nine o'clock—otherwise the dorm supervisor threatens to drop us down to a two-week Level 1 restriction where you aren't allowed past the courtyard benches."

"Wait until you hear the best part," Trevor chimed in, leaning forward on his elbows as the green pastures of Augusta County rolled past the windows. "Back in February, when Virginia's U.S. Senator tore the DARS bosses apart on television over grabbing wheelchair handles, locking down the computers, and forcing college graduates into manual trade shops, everybody in the dorms watched the clip on their phones and thought things were finally going to change."

"And did anything change inside the classrooms?" I asked evenly.

"Not a thing," Trevor snorted. "I graduated in May with an Associate of Applied Science in graphic and web design—three-point-eight GPA, full portfolio—and enrolled here strictly for an assistive-screen-magnifier accommodation setup and advanced front-end certification. Instead, Vocational Evaluation in the Bates-Harding Building forced me to spend all last week sorting lug nuts in the auto bay and folding hospital corners in the nursing lab. Yesterday afternoon—literally at three-fifteen yesterday—my evaluator looked across her desk at my college

transcript and told me that if coding stylesheets strained my eyes too much, the center still has its wonderful retail-readiness partnership down the road in Waynesboro training clients to stand by the automatic doors as a ValueMart greeter."

Across the two inches between our wheelchairs, I felt the muscles in Katie's forearm go dead still against her armrest, though her voice stayed warm and steady for the two students across the aisle.

"What about the Web and Software classroom in Bates-Harding?" I asked. "Did VITA finally unlock local developer permissions on the state desktop computers?"

"Are you kidding?" Trevor laughed, shaking his head. "My roommate's in that class right now. Every student still has to haul their own personal laptop from home and daisy-chain orange surge strips across the floor because VITA still has every state desktop locked down tighter than a bank vault. When the instructor asked administration about it on Monday, the Assistant Director told him Richmond parked all of the Senator's Washington demands inside a *2028 Strategic Transition Task Force* until after Congress passes their budget next week."

"And heaven help anybody in a wheelchair who tells staff not to shove their chair," Kayla added quietly as the green highway sign for Fishersville came into view ahead. "Last Thursday morning right inside the Bates-Harding visitor lobby, an intake supervisor walked up behind our friend Marcus, grabbed his push-handles without asking, and yanked him backward so a tour group could pass. When Marcus told him to take his hands off his chair, the guy threatened him with an aggression write-up and pointed straight at the old 2019 handbook rack in the lobby."

At eight-fifty-two in the morning, the automated chime dinged above the windshield, and the SVT Route 250 Connector pulled onto the concrete bus pad along Roosevelt Avenue outside the sprawling red-brick campus of Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center.

"Thanks for the ride—and good luck in class today, Kayla and Trevor," Katie said warmly as the driver unclipped our SafeLock straps and lowered the ramp onto the sunlit sidewalk.

"Nice meeting you guys!" Kayla smiled, swinging her crutches briskly up the paved front walk ahead of us toward the main entrance of the Bates-Harding Building without the faintest idea that she had just handed a live field briefing to the sitting United States Senator holding an eighteen-point-five-million-dollar padlock over the entire facility.

Side by side in our jeans and casual shirts, Katie and I rolled up the gentle concrete approach and glided through the aluminum-framed glass front entrance doors into the public visitor sign-in lobby.

Just as Kayla had told us on the bus, nobody could wander unbadged into the campus corridors anymore: twenty feet past the red-brick lobby pillar stood a raised security podium beside a set of badge-locked interior doors manned by a uniformed security attendant.

Yet RRC didn't even bother hiding its foot-dragging behind the locked doors—it was sitting right out in the open inside the front entrance lobby.

Directly ahead of us at the sliding glass reception window, Kayla handed her canary-yellow *Barton Hall Level 2 Off-Campus Hall Pass* under the glass so the receptionist could thump it with a mechanical time-stamp clock—right beside a tall, four-inch-thick stack of blank canary-yellow Level 2 pass pads—before Kayla and Trevor tapped their resident lanyards at the inner security podium and disappeared through the locked hallway doors toward class. And mounted to the cinder-block wall beside the visitor sign-in counter was the public intake rack stuffed with crisp blue client handbooks stamped *REVISED OCTOBER 2019* across the bottom corner, right underneath a laminated sign taped to the reception glass warning incoming clients and visiting relatives that Level 2 off-campus pass sign-outs and eleven-o'clock opposite-gender dorm lockouts were enforced without exception for adult siblings and family members.

Katie and I rolled quietly up to the glass visitor sign-in counter and paused so I could pull one of the blue October 2019 handbooks off the public rack, flipping straight to the residential conduct pages—not an addendum sheet, sticker, or wheelchair bodily-autonomy clause anywhere inside it. Beside me, looking from Kayla's time-stamped canary-yellow slip to the unamended 2019 handbook in my hand, Katie's jaw set hard, her blue eyes turning to pure ice.

"Good morning—if the two of you are signing in as visitors or checking on admissions, I just need you to print your names on the log and slide a government photo ID under the window," the receptionist behind the glass said pleasantly without looking up from her keyboard.

Without saying a word about Washington or the United States Senate, Katie picked up the chained ballpoint pen on the accessible lower ledge, printed *Katie Prairie* neatly on the paper visitor log, and handed the pen across our armrests so I could print *Nathaniel Prairie* right underneath her line. Because neither of us medically could drive, neither of us carried a driver's license; instead, Katie reached into her wallet and slid her horizontal Virginia DMV State Identification Card under the stainless-steel slot right beside mine—two ordinary Commonwealth photo IDs listing *KATIE PRAIRIE* and *NATHANIEL PRAIRIE* above our real permanent home address in Virginia Beach.

Behind the reception glass, the young woman — who, like everyone working the front desk in 2027, had never worked at Fishersville twenty years earlier and hadn't been anywhere near Capitol Hill in February — picked up both Virginia Beach State IDs, glanced from the small DMV portraits to the two forty-two-year-old wheelchair riders in jeans and sneakers holding an intake handbook, and didn't show a flicker of recognition.

"All right, Katie and Nathaniel—all the way up from Virginia Beach," she said casually, reaching into her desk drawer for two plastic clip-on *VISITOR — ESCORT REQUIRED* badges while copying our DMV numbers onto her clipboard. "Just so you know before we call back to Admissions, walk-in visitors aren't permitted past the lobby doors without a staff escort, and if the two of you are looking into residential enrollment here at Fishersville, your Tidewater DARS counselor has to send an intake referral packet first. Every new Barton Hall resident starts on Level 2 off-campus sign-out passes and separate-wing room assignments—even adult relatives—so you'll want to read pages fourteen through nineteen in that blue handbook before applying."

Katie didn't interrupt her by so much as a syllable. In sixty quiet seconds with a Virginia DMV State ID card, she had already gotten the exact unvarnished answer she had ridden down from Alexandria to find: to any disabled Virginian rolling off the morning bus without a title in front of their name, Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center was still enforcing every word of the 2019 regime right at the front window.

Just as the receptionist held our two Virginia State ID cards in one hand and reached toward the window slot with the plastic visitor badges in the other, the aluminum-framed outer front entrance doors swung open behind our wheelchairs, letting in a gust of warm July air from the staff parking lot.

Thursday, July 22, 2027, 9:00 AM — Director Cross Recognizes Them, Wearing Visitor Badges, & Calling Governor Langford Directly

Walking briskly through the front entrance doors with her leather work tote over one shoulder and a travel mug of coffee in her hand—arriving right on the dot of nine o'clock to start her workday alongside Assistant Director Greg Saunders in his crisp light-grey button-down shirt—was Director Evelyn Cross.

"Did Richmond confirm whether Dirksen Room 511 cleared our hold memo yet, Greg?" Dr. Cross was asking cheerfully as the glass door hissed shut behind her heels.

Then Dr. Cross glanced toward the front visitor sign-in window—and stopped dead in her tracks on the green-and-white terrazzo floor.

Unlike her front-desk receptionist, Evelyn Cross had sat five feet across Katie's mahogany desk in Dirksen Room 511 and testified under oath before us in Dirksen Room 124 five months earlier. For three full seconds, she stared at our two matching black motorized SwiftChairs in casual jeans, sneakers, a navy polo, and a grey t-shirt as if her eyes were playing a cruel trick on her. Slowly, Katie and I pivoted our wheelchairs forty-five degrees from the sign-in counter to look straight at her—and one single look at the cold, silent fury written across Katie's face drained every drop of color from Evelyn Cross's cheeks.

"S-Senator Prairie?" Dr. Cross breathed nervously, her voice catching in her throat as Saunders froze solid beside her with his clipboard clutched against his chest. "… Nate?"

"Good morning, Dr. Cross," Katie said, her voice quiet, level, and cold as iron—without a trace of polite small talk.

Behind the reception glass, the young woman at the counter froze with her hand halfway to the slot. Looking down in horror at the ordinary horizontal Virginia DMV State ID card reading *KATIE PRAIRIE — VIRGINIA BEACH, VA* in her fingers—realizing she had just lectured the sitting United States Senator holding an eighteen-point-five-million-dollar hold over the facility about Level 2 Hall Passes and separate-wing Barton Hall dorm rules—she went nearly as pale as her boss.

Neither Katie nor I skipped a single line of the building's security procedure, and Katie never reached into her bag for a Senate credential. Turning calmly back to the mortified receptionist, Katie held out her hand as the woman slid both of our Virginia DMV State ID cards and the two cheap plastic *VISITOR — ESCORT REQUIRED* badges under the glass with trembling fingers.

"W-we had no idea—nobody in Richmond told us your office was coming to Fishersville today, Senator!" Dr. Cross stammered, taking a nervous half-step toward the counter.

"That's why we rode the morning bus and signed in with our Virginia State IDs like any other disabled Virginians, Dr. Cross," I said evenly, slipping my DMV card back into my wallet and clipping my *VISITOR — ESCORT REQUIRED* badge to the collar of my grey t-shirt right as Katie calmly clipped hers to the placket of her navy polo. "If Katie expects a state institution to follow its own rules, we follow yours too. Now that we're signed in and wearing your visitor badges, we'd like a brief fifteen-minute look behind your security doors—escorted by you and Mr. Saunders in full compliance with your lobby policy—starting at the Web and Software Applications classroom window and the Vocational Evaluation suite."

With zero minutes of lead time to send a runner ahead or hide a single extension cord, a visibly shaken Dr. Cross tapped her director's master badge against the security reader beside the guard podium and led our two wheelchairs down the interior corridor—while behind us in the front lobby, the reception staff didn't wait five seconds after the security door clicked shut before snatching up the office telephone to call DARS headquarters in Richmond in a full-blown panic.

Fifteen minutes behind the badge doors was five minutes more than we needed.

Through the wire-reinforced observation glass of the Web and Software Applications lab, Dr. Cross had to stand in mortified silence right beside our wheelchairs as Katie and I counted seven disabled adult students huddled over personal laptops plugged into daisy-chained orange floor surge strips while twelve state-issued desktop towers sat dark and unusable along the cinder-block wall beneath blue VITA asset tags. Two doors down in the Vocational Evaluation intake suite, sitting in a neat wire tray right beside the evaluator sign-in desk, was a freshly printed stack of glossy recruitment flyers for the Waynesboro ValueMart *Retail Greeter Readiness Partnership* alongside mandatory two-week manual-shop rotation checklists for incoming degree-holders.

At nine-twenty, Katie didn't ask to see another room. Without a word, she and I turned our SwiftChairs around in tight parallel formation and rolled right back out through the security podium into the public front entrance lobby.

Behind the glass reception window—right beside the four-inch stack of canary-yellow Level 2 passes—one staffer was clutching the beige office handset tightly to her ear on hold with DARS executive offices in Richmond while a second alarmed staffer stood beside the filing cabinets clutching two manila compliance folders to her chest.

"Senator Prairie, please," Dr. Cross pleaded breathlessly, hurrying out into the terrazzo front lobby beside a pale, silent Greg Saunders as we locked our wheelchair brakes near the red-brick reception pillar. "If your office had just let Commissioner Sterling know you were coming, we could have walked you through the timeline! Our stakeholder working groups are meeting biweekly on the 2019 handbook, VITA

has our classroom exception ticket queued for next quarter's security board, and Commissioner Sterling's office in Richmond is pulling the Secretary onto the phone right now—"

"Stop talking, Dr. Cross," Katie said quietly.

She didn't raise her voice by a single decibel, yet the ice-cold fury behind those four words froze everyone in the front lobby where they stood.

Sitting straight in her SwiftChair in her navy cotton polo, dark jeans, and cheap plastic visitor badge while I flipped open my MagnaBook Pro across my knees to our timestamped morning notes, Katie looked straight across the terrazzo floor at Dr. Cross and Assistant Director Saunders.

"Forty-eight hours ago, you and Commissioner Sterling delivered an eighty-four-page signed certification to my office on the Senate Appropriations Committee claiming that Phase One of all five statutory reforms you promised under oath on February seventeenth was substantially implemented—asking me to release eighteen and a half million federal tax dollars in next Thursday's markup," Katie said, every word landing like cold steel. "Yesterday afternoon, Nate and I boarded ARTS Train 51 in Alexandria in our regular clothes, stayed overnight in Staunton, paid twenty-five cents apiece on the eight-thirty Route 250 Connector bus, and slid our Virginia Beach DMV State IDs under your window this morning. Before you walked through that door and recognized us, your own front desk looked at two disabled Virginians from Virginia Beach and informed us that Barton Hall still places incoming adult relatives in separate wings on Level 2 off-campus sign-out passes under pages fourteen through nineteen of your 2019 handbook."

Dr. Cross swallowed hard, unable to speak.

"You upgraded your outer door locks because February's cameras shamed you into it," Katie continued evenly, "and then you parked every single reform protecting the dignity and education of disabled adults inside fake 2028 task forces while telling your staff you only had to wait until Congress passed your budget."

Behind the glass window, the receptionist cupped her hand anxiously over the telephone mouthpiece and leaned toward the slot: "Dr. Cross—DARS Richmond has Commissioner Sterling's deputy on the line asking what he should tell the Secretary —"

"Tell your receptionist she can hang up on DARS, Dr. Cross," Katie said flatly, sliding her dark mPhone out of her jeans pocket. "If Commissioner Sterling thinks five months of foot-dragging and a dishonest binder to the United States Senate is how state agencies treat an Appropriations hold, Nate and I aren't wasting another breath on DARS."

Ever since serving together in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond—and campaigning shoulder to shoulder across the Commonwealth after Virginia voters elected fellow Democrat Rebecca Langford to the Governor's Mansion—Katie and Governor Langford had maintained an unspoken private protocol: ordinary government business went through official staff channels, whereas a weekday call to the other woman's personal cell phone meant something serious had happened and needed immediate attention without ten seconds of small talk.

Right there in the front visitor lobby in front of Dr. Cross, Assistant Director Saunders, and the panicked staff behind the glass window, Katie tapped *Rebecca Langford* on her screen and held the phone up on speakerphone.

The line rang once. Halfway through the second ring, it clicked open.

"Katie," Governor Rebecca Langford's crisp, focused voice answered immediately—zero pleasantries, all business. "What's happened?"

"Good morning, Rebecca," Katie said clearly, holding the matte-black phone steady near her chin while I kept our audit log open on my laptop beside her. "Nate is right here beside me, and I want to let you know up front that you're on speakerphone—because Nate and I aren't in Washington. Yesterday afternoon we took the ARTS train down from Alexandria to Staunton, and at eight-fifty-two this morning we rolled off the Route 250 Connector bus in street clothes and signed in with our Virginia State IDs at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville, where Dr. Evelyn Cross, her Assistant Director Greg Saunders, and her front-desk staff are standing in front of us right now."

Over the speaker grille, the shift in atmospheric pressure from Richmond was instantaneous.

"Hold five seconds while I shut my office door and conference Arthur Lawrence onto this line with us, Katie," Governor Langford said briskly. Two crisp clicks sounded over the speaker, followed immediately by Chief of Staff Arthur Lawrence's voice joining from Capitol Square:

"Senator Prairie, Nate—I'm on with the Governor. Go ahead. Commissioner Sterling sent the Governor's Office a signed memo on Tuesday afternoon swearing up and down that Fishersville had completed Phase One of every single mandate from your February hearing ahead of next week's markup."

"Commissioner Sterling's certification does not match what is operating on the ground in Fishersville today, Arthur," Katie replied evenly, keeping her evidentiary boundaries razor-sharp even in the middle of the front lobby. "Let me separate what Nate and I personally observed and documented over the past forty minutes from what two current residents reported to us on the bus so your investigators can verify each item independently."

Without raising her voice or blurring a single fact with an unverified assumption, Katie walked Governor Langford and Chief of Staff Lawrence through our direct personal observations and physical records first—watching a badged Barton Hall student get a canary-yellow Level 2 Off-Campus Hall Pass mechanically time-stamped at the front window beside a four-inch stack of blank yellow pads; pulling an unamended October 2019 client handbook off the lobby rack beneath a laminated eleven-o'clock adult-sibling lockout sign; hearing the front desk tell two Virginia Beach State ID holders at eight-fifty-nine that Level 2 passes and separate-wing assignments remain mandatory; and counting seven Web and Software students coding on personal laptops over daisy-chained orange floor surge strips beside twelve dark VITA-tagged desktop towers and a fresh wire tray of Waynesboro ValueMart greeter flyers and mandatory manual-shop checklists. Only after I finished reading out the exact form stamps and asset counts from my screen did Katie calmly relay the two contemporaneous student reports we had heard on the Route 250 bus—that an intake supervisor right here in the Bates-Harding lobby had reportedly grabbed a resident named Marcus's wheelchair push-handles without

consent last Thursday and threatened an aggression write-up, and that an evaluator had reportedly pitched a three-point-eight GPA web-design graduate named Trevor yesterday afternoon on becoming a ValueMart door greeter—noting explicitly that both student accounts had not yet been independently verified and should be checked directly against lobby video, procurement logs, and confidential resident interviews.

Behind the reception glass to Katie's left, the receptionist quietly lowered the DARS Richmond telephone receiver onto her shoulder, staring out through the window in stunned silence. There was no point begging DARS headquarters for talking points when the Governor of Virginia and her Chief of Staff were speaking live into the front lobby.

When Katie finished, two seconds of icy silence came over the line from Richmond.

"Dr. Cross," Governor Langford's voice cut across the front lobby like a gavel strike. "I assume you can hear Arthur and me clearly?"

Dr. Cross swallowed visibly, staring at the phone in Katie's hand as her fingers trembled at her sides. "Y-yes, Governor Langford. Yes, Mr. Lawrence."

"Listen to me very carefully, Dr. Cross," the Governor said, her tone clinical and utterly implacable. "Your front desk can hang up with DARS headquarters in Richmond, because Arthur just summoned Commissioner Marcus Sterling and the Secretary of Health and Human Resources across Capitol Square to my office in ten minutes to explain to me face-to-face why an agency of my administration submitted a false compliance certification to Virginia's United States Senator—and anyone whose signature is on a false representation to Congress will have their resignation on my desk before five o'clock today."

Across the terrazzo floor, Dr. Cross went ashen, while beside her Assistant Director Saunders stared straight ahead at the brick column without moving a muscle.

"Second," Chief of Staff Arthur Lawrence cut in on the conference line, his voice just as hard as he had sounded in February, "the State Inspector General, the Chief Information Officer of VITA, and I are getting into a state car at Capitol Square within thirty minutes and driving straight up Interstate 64 to Fishersville. We will be walking through those front lobby doors behind you before one o'clock this afternoon—and don't bother trying to hide a single clipboard before we get there, because we already have Nate's inventory list."

"By noon tomorrow," Governor Langford added firmly, "an emergency executive directive under my signature will permanently abolish off-campus paper pass restrictions and adult family lockout rules across Fishersville, pull every 2019 handbook from circulation, require signed acknowledgment of wheelchair bodily autonomy from every employee on your payroll, end mandatory manual-shop Vocational Evaluation rotations and retail-greeter pitches for college-degreed or credentialed adults, and keep VITA's engineering strike team physically on site in that classroom until every developer workstation is unlocked on an isolated instructional network. Do you understand me, Dr. Cross?"

"Yes, Governor," Dr. Cross whispered hoarsely.

“Katie, Nate,” Governor Langford said, her voice steadying with unmistakable respect as she addressed us directly, “thank you for calling me straight away instead of letting Sterling’s binder sit until markup. Will the two of you still be on campus when Arthur and the Inspector General arrive?”

“No, Rebecca—Nate and I are signing out and catching the next Route 250 bus back to Staunton right now,” Katie answered calmly, drawing the exact institutional boundary between her federal Appropriations oversight role and the Commonwealth’s executive branch. “Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center answers to your administration, Nate is a private citizen rather than a state investigator, and the strongest record either of us can put before Congress is having the State Inspector General and VITA establish every fact independently without a Senator standing over their shoulders.”

“Smart as always,” Governor Langford said crisply. “Arthur and the Inspector General will transmit a full written readout to Dirksen Room 511 tonight.”

“Thank you, Rebecca, and thank you, Arthur,” Katie said, looking squarely across the lobby at Dr. Cross and Saunders so everyone in Fishersville heard the federal standard in plain English at the exact same moment Richmond did. “And so there is zero confusion between Richmond, Fishersville, and Washington about what proof my office needs before I lift my hold on that eighteen-point-five-million-dollar appropriation: I do not lift holds for task forces, tickets, or promises. My hold remains locked next Thursday in Subcommittee markup, and it stays locked through full Committee conference until the Virginia Office of the State Inspector General and federal Rehabilitation Services Administration auditors certify to my office in writing—backed by live unlocked classroom developer logins, published updated handbooks, signed employee training rosters, electronic keycard security logs, and confidential, unmonitored interviews with current Barton Hall residents—that all five reforms are operating in real life every day when nobody expects a Senator to walk through the door.”

Katie paused for half a beat, glancing toward the sunny bus stop out on Roosevelt Avenue beyond the glass entrance doors.

“And Rebecca?” Katie added calmly. “Tell whoever is sitting in the Director’s chair next month not to bother staging a VIP tour for us—because Nate and I still have quarters left in our pockets, and we know the Route 250 bus schedule by heart.”

Over the speakerphone, Governor Langford answered without a fraction of a second’s hesitation:

“Loud and clear, Senator. Enjoy Staunton with Nate—Arthur and I have Fishersville and Richmond from here.”

Thursday, July 22 – Friday, July 23, 2027 — Signing Out at 9:48 AM, Thursday Night’s Readout in Staunton, & Friday’s ARTS Train 50 Home

Katie tapped the screen to end the call, slipped her mPhone back into her jeans pocket, and rolled calmly up to the reception slot alongside me so both of us could unclip our plastic *VISITOR — ESCORT REQUIRED* badges, slide them back under the glass, and write *9:48 AM* beside our signatures on the front-lobby visitor log.

“You folks have a busy morning ahead of you before the Governor’s Chief of Staff and the Inspector General pull into the front lot,” I said mildly as Katie and I unlocked our joysticks and steered past the frozen Director and Assistant Director toward the glass entrance doors. “We can find our own way out to the bus stop.”

Gliding side by side out through the automatic front doors into the warm Shenandoah Valley sunshine more than two and a half hours before the Richmond SUVs rolled up Interstate 64, we caught the westbound SVT Route 250 Connector back into historic downtown Staunton for an unhurried lunch together on Beverley Street and spent a quiet Thursday afternoon back at our ground-floor brick hotel room beside the Wharf tracks. That evening at eight-fifteen—while Katie and I sat side by side with two cold ginger ales before video-calling Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea back on Sunset Drive and settling into our accessible king bed for our second night in Staunton—Arthur Lawrence and State Inspector General Kenneth Dalton’s official audit readout arrived in Katie’s Senate briefing inbox: confirming that independent video, procurement, and network logs had corroborated every word from our morning visit, that VITA engineers had unlocked all twelve classroom developer workstations onto an isolated instructional fiber network by four-fifteen that afternoon, and that Commissioner Sterling, Director Cross, and Assistant Director Saunders had all tendered their resignations effective five o’clock.

The next afternoon—Friday, July 23, 2027, when the three-day-a-week eastbound *Cardinal* made its scheduled run through the Shenandoah Valley—Katie and I checked out of our hotel, rolled across the warm cobblestones onto the red-brick platform at Staunton Station fifteen minutes before ARTS Train 50 glided around the curve beneath the Sears Hill pedestrian bridge at two-twenty-eight, and rode the hand-cranked mobile lift back up into the cool, quiet coach vestibule.

Once Train 50 eased eastward out of Staunton toward the Blue Ridge Mountains on the ride back to Alexandria and Dad’s house on Sunset Drive, Katie locked her brakes right beside mine, leaned her shoulder gently against my arm, and laced her fingers through my left hand across our armrests.

“Worth leaving the Senate ID in the bag?” I asked softly, watching the green valley farms slip past the train window.

Katie smiled, resting her head briefly against my shoulder as the rhythm of the welded rail hummed beneath our wheels all the way toward Alexandria.

“Every single quarter, Nate,” my twin sister murmured. “Every single quarter.”

Joint Base Andrews to Chambers Field: Flying Home on Air Force One

Chambers Field, Four Hundred Million Restored on Pier 12, & Tapping In at King Street the Next Morning

Date: 2027-10-13 at 15:15 America/New_York

Wednesday, October 13, 2027, 3:15 PM — Dirksen Room 511: "Chambers Field" & Five Practical Questions Before Saying Yes

"Senator—the White House Office of Legislative Affairs and the White House Military Office are holding together on Line One," Sarah Hawkins said from the open mahogany doorway of Katie's inner office at three-fifteen on Wednesday afternoon, holding her notepad against her cardigan with an expression none of us had ever seen on her face before. "President Morales is flying down to Hampton Roads tomorrow morning, and the President asked personally if Senator Prairie—and Nate—would accompany the presidential delegation aboard Air Force One."

Inside Dirksen Room 511, the hum of the HVAC vent suddenly sounded very loud.

Katie's hand paused halfway to her glass of ginger ale. Slowly, she turned her head across the two-inch gap between our SwiftChair armrests and looked at me.

I looked right back at Katie.

"Are you going?" I asked quietly.

"I'm thinking," my twin sister said.

For the first three and a half months of Katie's Senate term, the question of whether Virginia's junior Senator would ever set wheel aboard Air Force One had been completely academic. Garrett Thorne—who had spent an entire autumn jeering at *"Broken Katie Prairie"* on television before we uncovered the four-hundred-million-dollar Naval Station Norfolk fleet-supply kickback scheme that ended his presidency—would never in a million years have invited Katie onto his aircraft. And if the Thorne White House had ever lost its mind and extended an optional invitation for a photo op, Katie wouldn't have made a theatrical speech on cable news; she simply would have told Sarah to thank the White House and reply that she would not be traveling with the President, while continuing to carry out every constitutional duty her oath required.

Clara Morales was another world entirely.

In the six months since Chief Justice Sterling had sworn her in inside the Mansfield Room, President Morales had governed like an institutional adult—signing our Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel public-transit link in June, backing our Appropriations firewalls, and working late into the night alongside Senior Senator Thomas Keane and Katie to pass the bipartisan Naval Station Norfolk Fleet Readiness, Enlisted Housing, and Military Family Restoration Act, putting back every stolen dollar Bret Halverson and Garrett Thorne had siphoned away from Atlantic Fleet pier maintenance, enlisted sailor barracks, military-family childcare, and base-gate public transit access.

Even so, Katie didn't say yes just because someone on Pennsylvania Avenue had said the words *Air Force One*. Reaching across her desk, she tapped the speaker button beside Sam Hawkins's chair so Sam and Mandy could take notes from the side table.

“Good afternoon—this is Senator Katie Prairie, with my brother Nate and my legislative staff in the room,” Katie said evenly. “Thank the President for thinking of both of us. Before I confirm our manifest, I have five practical questions—starting with the simplest one. Where in Hampton Roads are we landing?”

“Wheels up from Joint Base Andrews at eight-thirty tomorrow morning, Senator, landing at Chambers Field at nine-twenty,” the White House Legislative Affairs director answered warmly.

Katie gave a single, immediate nod across the desk to Sam. Nobody in Washington ever had to explain Tidewater airfield geography to a forty-two-year-old United States Senator who had grown up in Virginia Beach. If a President flew into Norfolk International Airport, the itinerary was heading out into civilian Norfolk or Virginia Beach; if the aircraft crossed the water into Newport News/Williamsburg International, the day belonged to the Peninsula. Touching down at Chambers Field meant the mission stayed squarely inside the fenceline of Naval Station Norfolk—eliminating an unnecessary sixteen-car interstate motorcade shutdown for tens of thousands of morning Hampton Roads commuters and putting the President straight onto the waterfront piers where the Navy’s two-hundred-and-fifty-second birthday week belonged.

“Good—landing directly inside the base keeps the morning rush hour open on Interstate 64 and Hampton Boulevard,” Katie said approvingly. “Second: why does the President want me on the manifest rather than meeting her down on the pier?”

“Because she’s signing your and Senator Keane’s Naval Station Norfolk Restoration Act on Pier Twelve in front of two thousand Fifth Fleet sailors and military spouses at eleven-fifteen, Senator,” the director replied, “and the President told us this morning that the Virginia Senators who wrote the lockbox—and the twin brother whose forensic accounting scripts caught the four-hundred-million-dollar theft from those sailors in the first place—belong in the cabin with her when that bill comes down to Norfolk.”

Across our armrests, I felt my ears turn slightly warm while Mandy grinned behind her hand.

“Third and fourth,” Katie continued without missing a beat, all calm engineering precision, “my brother Nate and I both use full-time motorized SwiftChair power wheelchairs, and neither of us transfers out of our chairs onto airstairs or lets anyone lift or push our frames by the handles. How is the Eighty-Ninth Airlift Wing handling boarding at Joint Base Andrews and deplaning at Chambers Field, and how are we getting onto the secure flightline at Andrews?”

“The White House Military Office is already on the line with your dimensions on file from the Capitol Architect’s office, Senator,” a crisp Air Force lieutenant colonel chimed in over the speaker. “Because Joint Base Andrews has no passenger rail gate to the restricted flightline, a White House Military Office dual-wheelchair mobility van with four-point floor track securement will pick you and Mr. Prairie up on Sunset Drive in Alexandria at seven-fifteen tomorrow morning. On the apron at Andrews—and waiting on the tarmac at Chambers Field—our aerial port crew stages an enclosed scissor-lift passenger boarding platform flush with the wide mid-cabin main-deck doorway, zero threshold straight into the forward congressional cabin where floor-track tie-downs lock both SwiftChairs beside the conference table.”

“And fifth,” Katie asked carefully, protecting the institutional boundary she never blurred even for me, “Nate accompanies me as my twin and disability-support companion, not as cleared Senate staff. Are there any classified segments on the base itinerary between wheels-down and the Pier Twelve signing?”

“Just one twenty-minute operational carrier-readiness update inside the Fleet Forces secure facility at ten-fifteen with the President, Admiral Vance, Senator Keane, and you, Senator,” the colonel replied promptly. “Navy protocol has already set a height-adjustable briefing station inside the room for your SwiftChair, and the Fleet Family Ombudsman has invited Mr. Prairie to chat pierside with Navy spouses and a Coastal Virginia Transit Authority service planner until you roll back out at ten-thirty-five.”

Katie looked over at me. Everything made institutional sense, every security rule was respected, not a commuter lane in Norfolk was being closed for vanity, and nobody was touching our chairs.

“Tell the President that Nate and I would be honored to join her and Senator Keane tomorrow morning,” Katie said calmly. “Sam will email the exact wheelbase and weight sheets for both SwiftChairs in five minutes.”

Once the line clicked off and Sam, Mandy, and Sarah hurried back to the outer suite buzzing quietly with excitement to print our flightline credentials, I kept my hands folded on my MagnaBook Pro and looked sideways at my twin sister.

“Are we going home to our house on Lord Nelson Drive afterward?” I asked.

“No, Nate,” Katie said, signing an Appropriations letter without looking up. “Air Force One flies the delegation back to Joint Base Andrews at three-thirty so Senator Keane and I make the five-thirty floor vote.”

“Katie, Chambers Field is fifteen miles from our house,” I pointed out evenly.

“We’re traveling with the President of the United States, Nate.”

“Our own beds are fifteen miles away.”

Katie’s lips twitched despite herself as she handed the signed folder across her desk. “You’ll survive sleeping in Alexandria on a Thursday night, Nate.”

Thursday, October 14, 2027, 8:10 AM — Joint Base Andrews, First Time Inside the Secret Service Bubble, & Six Checks Over the Chesapeake Bay

Katie had never confused rejecting unnecessary VIP theater with rejecting legitimate security and accessibility logistics, and rolling onto the restricted tarmac of Joint Base Andrews at eight-ten on Thursday morning beside Senior Senator Thomas Keane—an hour after Dad, Brittany, and a wide-eyed Chelsea holding Shelly in her cozy robe had waved the two of us into the White House Military Office mobility van on our Sunset Drive porch—proved the difference, while also giving my twin sister and me our very first look from the inside at the presidential Secret Service bubble.

Twenty years earlier, when Dad had taken Katie and me on a constituent tour of the White House State Floor for our twenty-second birthday, we had simply rolled through a visitor magnetometer while the President was miles away in Fairfax; and during the ten-week impeachment aftermath in the spring, our Capitol Police detail had stood down the moment the threat passed. Stepping inside the moving protective perimeter of the Presidential Protective Division was another universe altogether. Before our mobility van even cleared the interior flightline gate at Andrews, two Secret Service canine handlers swept the undercarriage of the vehicle and paused politely beside our footrests while a calm Belgian Malinois sniffed past our SwiftChair battery boxes, every hangar door along the apron stood sealed under watchful roof spotters, and dark-suited agents with clear coiled earpieces and sleeve microphones formed a silent geometry around every ramp and doorway.

Towering above the sunlit Maryland concrete in gleaming Robin's-egg blue, crisp white, and polished silver—with *UNITED STATES OF AMERICA* painted bold across the upper fuselage and the Presidential Seal gleaming beside the forward door—stood the four-engine widebody jet of the Eighty-Ninth Airlift Wing.

While press pool reporters and West Wing aides climbed the rear and forward airstairs, two uniformed Air Force loadmasters greeted Katie and me beside a spotless white scissor-lift boarding truck parked parallel to the wide mid-cabin doorway. Nobody reached for our push-handles; nobody hovered nervously. At the touch of a hydraulic control switch, the railed platform lifted both of our SwiftChairs smoothly twenty feet into the crisp October breeze until the rubber bridge lip rested dead-level with the cabin threshold.

Eighty-two years after military engineers had hidden a battery-powered fuselage elevator in the belly of Franklin Delano Roosevelt's *Sacred Cow* so nobody on an airfield would see a President in a wheelchair, my twin sister and I rolled side by side in broad morning daylight straight into the wood-paneled congressional cabin of Air Force One.

"Right here beside the forward conference table, Senator Prairie, Mr. Prairie," the loadmaster smiled, kneeling cleanly to click four aviation floor-track tie-down straps onto the reinforced steel anchor loops beneath Katie's black-and-silver frame and mine, leaving us positioned shoulder-to-shoulder beside two wide oval windows with two chilled crystal tumblers of ginger ale embossed with the Presidential Seal resting in the recessed cup holders in front of us.

At eight-thirty sharp, the four massive engines spooled to a deep, muffled turbine roar, the runway fell away beneath our wheels without so much as a rattle in our armrests, and Joint Base Andrews banked away into autumn gold and green below.

Five minutes after the chime sounded at cruising altitude, the forward pocket door slid open, and President Clara Morales stepped into the cabin in her tailored navy pantsuit, taking the leather chair directly across the polished mahogany table from Senator Keane, Katie, and me.

"Good morning, Tom—good morning, Katie, Nate," President Morales said warmly, sliding her briefing folder onto the table without a shred of ceremony. "How was the boarding lift at Andrews?"

“Flawless, Madam President,” Katie answered with genuine appreciation. “Level threshold, four-point floor locks, and your loadmasters didn’t try to grab a single push-handle.”

“Good—because I warned the Military Office that if anybody touched your chairs, they’d answer to me before they answered to Senate Appropriations,” Clara Morales said with a dry smile before her dark eyes grew serious, looking from Katie to me. “I wanted both of you on this flight going home to Norfolk today. Six months ago, sailors and young Navy families down at Naval Station Norfolk found out on television that the people running the Pentagon had treated four hundred million dollars of their pier safety, barracks repairs, and childcare funds like a private slush fund while leaking their carrier schedules on a commercial phone app. When I put my signature on your Restoration Act on Pier Twelve this morning, those sailors deserve to see that their Senators—and the Virginian who traced every stolen wire—came straight down from Washington to make them whole.”

“Thank you, Madam President,” Katie said quietly, glancing toward Senator Keane before lacing her fingers briefly with mine. “And thank you for keeping our defense-community transit operating rider intact in conference. Ever since Coastal Virginia Transit Authority discontinued Route 3 Chesapeake Boulevard service along First View Street, Gate 4, Bellinger Boulevard, and the Navy Exchange, car-free sailors and Ocean View families have been stranded behind long two-bus transfers just to reach the base or get groceries. Putting dedicated federal operating dollars behind restoring that First View Street and Gate 4 corridor—alongside cross-honored commuter passes for junior enlisted sailors and spouses heading to Virginia Dominion University and the Community College of Hampton Roads—fixes a cut people in Norfolk have felt every single morning.”

When President Morales and Senator Keane stepped forward for ten minutes to review the final remarks with the Navy Secretary, the sunlit sweep of eastern Virginia unfolded five miles below our right-hand window—the silver ribbon of the Rappahannock giving way to the York River, the Peninsula, the curving white thread of the Chesapeake Bay Bridge-Tunnel where our new Route 913 buses were running right that minute, and the vast blue harbor where we had ridden transit together since we were kids holding Dad’s hand.

Slowly, I leaned an inch toward my twin sister’s shoulder.

“You know we’re on Air Force One,” I murmured.

“Yes, Nate,” Katie said softly, watching the Elizabeth River glint ahead as the aircraft began its gentle descent toward Norfolk.

“Just checking.”

“You’ve checked six times.”

Even so, Katie didn’t let go of my hand all the way down through the coastal clouds until the landing gear touched Runway Ten at Chambers Field with a soft chirp of rubber.

Thursday, October 14, 2027, 9:22 AM — Touchdown at Chambers Field, Respecting the SCIF Door, & Four Hundred Million Restored on Pier 12

When the mid-cabin hatch swung open at nine-twenty-two, the unmistakable salt-tang breeze of Hampton Roads—brisk October Atlantic air mixed with warm tarmac and Elizabeth River tidewater—washed straight into the cabin.

Riding the white scissor-lift platform smoothly down to the concrete apron and rolling side by side off the aluminum ramp, Katie and I paused for five quiet seconds on the sunny tarmac of Chambers Field while President Morales and Senator Keane walked down the forward airstairs behind us past the saluting cordon of Navy officers in crisp dress blues.

Directly ahead of our wheelchairs stretched the enormous naval installation that had framed the horizon of our entire lives—grey aircraft carrier superstructures, radar masts, and towering shipyard cranes gleaming under the Virginia sky, fifteen miles west of our own front door in Kempsville. We hadn't flown aboard the presidential aircraft to some distant foreign capital.

"Katie," I said quietly.

"What?"

"We just flew home on Air Force One."

Katie looked out across the vast Norfolk airfield toward the carrier piers, a slow, wondering smile touching the corner of her mouth.

"…Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea are never going to let us hear the end of this," she murmured.

Riding the two-mile internal base route from Chambers Field to Pier Twelve inside the presidential motorcade package, however, showed Katie and me the other half of what living inside the Secret Service bubble actually meant. Even behind the guarded gates of Naval Station Norfolk, every single cross-street along Gilbert Street and Dillingham Boulevard had been frozen completely motionless thirty minutes ahead of our bumper—sailors in utility uniforms waiting silently behind yellow barricades, forklift drivers halted in their tracks, black Secret Service Counter-Assault SUVs idling at every corner, and countersnipers scanning the pier rooftops through binoculars. As our van rolled past the Navy Exchange food court plaza, we watched through the forward windshield as Clara Morales glanced wistfully from the armored presidential limousine ahead toward a walk-up coffee kiosk where a handful of petty officers stood behind steel bike racks—unable to take ten unscripted steps off a pre-swept carpet to buy a cup of coffee or say hello to an unscreened sailor without twenty earpieces murmuring in unison.

Beside me in the floor-track locks, Katie watched the frozen intersections slide past our window and reached across the two-inch gap to touch the back of my hand.

"She's a really good President, Nate," Katie said very quietly beneath the hum of the tires. "And she can't even roll down to the corner store for a cold drink by herself."

"Glass jar with flashing lights," I murmured back, and Katie gave a tiny, thoughtful nod that stayed with both of us for the rest of the morning.

At Pier Twelve itself, every piece of the event ran with crisp Navy precision. At ten-fifteen, when Admiral Vance escorted President Morales, Senator Keane, and Katie up the flush ramp into the Fleet Forces secure facility for the twenty-minute classified carrier readiness briefing, neither Katie nor I hesitated for half a second at the boundary. Inside that door sat a pre-positioned accessible briefing station for Virginia's United States Senator; outside under the sunny Pier Twelve canopy, I spent a thoroughly enjoyable twenty minutes drinking canned ginger ale alongside the base Fleet Family Ombudsman, two Ocean View Navy spouses in wheelchairs, and a Coastal Virginia Transit Authority service planner mapping out the restored Route 3 Chesapeake Boulevard stops across First View Street, Gate 4, Bellinger Boulevard, and the Navy Exchange that our bill's federal operating grant was finally bringing back.

At ten-thirty-eight, Katie rolled right back out into the sunshine beside Senator Keane, reclaimed her spot two inches to my left, and glided up the wide blue-carpeted stage ramp onto the Pier Twelve platform beneath the towering grey hull of an Atlantic Fleet carrier while I locked my brakes in the front-row accessible bay directly facing her.

At eleven-twenty-six, to a roar of applause from two thousand uniformed sailors and military families lining the pier, President Clara Morales signed her name across the parchment of the Naval Station Norfolk Fleet Readiness, Enlisted Housing, and Military Family Restoration Act—turning immediately in her chair to hand the first ceremonial fountain pen straight across the desk into Katie's hand, and nodding warmly down toward my wheelchair in the front row before handing the second pen to Senator Keane.

Friday, October 15, 2027, 8:35 AM — Two Plastic Fare Cards at King Street–Old Town & Mt. Vernon Square Across the Fenwick Bridge

Dad, Brittany, and Chelsea, exactly as Katie had predicted on the tarmac, did not let us hear the end of it.

When the White House Military Office mobility van dropped us back off on Sunset Drive at four-forty-five Thursday afternoon—giving Katie plenty of time to ride the Yellow Line in for the five-thirty Senate roll call before coming home for supper—sixty-eight-year-old David Prairie already had a brass picture frame waiting on the kitchen table for our embossed Air Force One passenger manifest cards while Brittany ladled out steaming bowls of homemade chicken-and-rice soup and Chelsea clapped happily, gently tracing the raised gold Presidential Seal with her fingertip as we recounted every minute from Andrews to Pier Twelve.

Twelve hours later, at eight-thirty-five on Friday morning, the brass frame was hanging neatly in Dad's hallway, and Friday was just another Senate workday.

Dressed in her everyday navy work blazer with her canvas daypack clipped behind her upright and mine clipped behind mine, Katie rolled alongside me underneath the stone-and-steel King Street railroad overpass into the brick entrance plaza of King Street–Old Town Station.

Beep.

Katie tapped her blue plastic CapitalPass fare card against the round sensor pad on the wide accessible faregate, and the clear acrylic paddles swung open.

Beep.

I tapped my card right behind hers—no bomb-sniffing dogs at our footrests, no frozen intersections, no sleeve microphones clearing the sidewalk—followed her into the glass traction elevator up to the elevated island platform, and glanced up at the amber platform arrival board. On the Capital Transit Yellow Line, every other northbound train terminated at Mt. Vernon Square while alternating trains ran all the way up to Greenbelt—and since either one carried us straight across the river to our L'Enfant Plaza transfer, Katie and I rolled side by side across the gap into the front accessible bay of a sleek brushed-stainless-steel Yellow Line train with *MT VERNON SQ* glowing beside the yellow circle on its headsign.

As the doors chimed shut and the railcar glided northward out of Alexandria onto the sunlit concrete-piered span of the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge—surrounded by sleepy federal commuters in trench coats, college students with earbuds, and scuffed rubber floor mats—I glanced around the fluorescent subway car and looked two inches to my left at my twin sister.

"This is somewhat less impressive than yesterday," I remarked dryly.

Katie didn't even look up from the Appropriations Subcommittee markup packet open across her lap, though the unmistakable corner of a smile tugged at her lips as the Potomac sparkled beneath the tracks.

"This one actually goes to Capitol South," Senator Katie Prairie replied.

Three Senate Terms, Refusing the 2044 Nomination, & The Stop #0812 Four-Seat Presidential Endorsement Loop

Part 1: Refusing the 2045 Presidency From Home, Five Statutory Shields Against the Bubble, & Out of the Closet Into Our Four-Person Nest

Date: 2043-10-24 at 16:30 America/New_York

Saturday, October 24, 2043, 4:30 PM — Our Living Room on Arvin Road: Quietly Recording Our Refusal Surrounded by Family & Signing Five Shields Against the Bubble

"They asked if the four of you could meet eleven governors and the national party chair at the Military Highway bus shelter on Monday morning with a live satellite truck," forty-one-year-old Sam Hawkins said from our dining room table on Arvin Road, resting his hand atop five thick manila folders stacked neatly beside Mandy's notary seal and Sarah's express-mail labels. "I told them no satellite trucks, no bus-stop press scrums, and nobody coming near your house."

“Thank you, Sam,” fifty-eight-year-old Katie said softly from her brushed-silver and black SwiftChair, glancing warmly over her shoulder toward our living room sofa.

Seated side by side on the deep cushions in warm autumn sweaters were the other two halves of our four-person household: our fifty-eight-year-old maternal cousin Brittany Fletcher, adjusting her thin silver wire-rimmed glasses as she tucked a soft fleece throw across her lap and her cousin’s knees, and our sixty-one-year-old paternal cousin Chelsea, whose silver-streaked chestnut hair rested happily against Brittany’s shoulder while she held her stuffed plush sea turtle in one hand and kept her maintenance and rescue asthma inhalers tucked safely in her cardigan pocket.

“Nate?” Chelsea asked in her thickly slurred voice, looking up anxiously when she heard the words *satellite truck*. “N-no loud people come here, right?”

Rolling my SwiftChair right up beside the end of the sofa so Chelsea could immediately reach out and hold my forearm with both hands, I smiled reassuringly at her as Brittany reached warmly across Chelsea’s shoulder to give my wrist an affectionate squeeze too.

“Nobody loud is coming anywhere near our door, Chelsea,” I promised gently. “Just Sam, Mandy, and Sarah—and the four of us.”

Chelsea let out a happy sigh and leaned her cheek against my sleeve, while Brittany smiled across at Katie and me with quiet gratitude shining behind her wire-rimmed lenses.

If anybody had told seventeen-year-old Katie and me behind our locked bedroom door on New Year’s Eve of 2002—or told nineteen-year-old Katie and me shivering side by side outside the weathered public-housing buildings on Dirty Old Tonomy Hill in Newport, Rhode Island on Christmas Eve of 2004—that at fifty-eight years old all four of us would be living together full-time as one inseparable family, split seamlessly between Arvin Road here in Virginia Beach and Sunset Drive up in Alexandria whenever the Senate was in session, neither of us would have dared to believe it.

First, in February of 2016—fourteen years after the drunken New Year’s Eve betrayal that had barred Brittany from our house, even though her parents, our beloved Aunt Karen and Uncle Steven Fletcher, had remained warmly in our corner all along and Aunt Karen had even helped Dad and us out financially whenever things were tight—Brittany found her way home. Living across the James River in Hillside Court public housing in South Richmond and watching the Thursday evening news air thirty-year-old Katie fearlessly ripping apart House Bill 663 on the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates had shattered the fog Brittany had been trapped inside for years, right as abusive, controlling Tyler—whom Brittany had started dating four years earlier with no idea he was the exact same Northwood High senior who had maliciously lied to Heather Collins about me after that drunken New Year’s Eve, otherwise she never would have dated him in the first place—was forcing her toward a Saturday afternoon wedding in a bleak South Richmond church she didn’t even want to set foot in. After Brittany rode a JRTC bus across the river without an appointment on Friday, held open the General Assembly Building elevator when I shouted *“Hold the elevator!”*, and wept inside Room 518 begging us to help her get out—and after it dawned on Brittany on Saturday wedding morning that Tyler was the exact guy who had lied to Heather about me, becoming the straw that broke the camel’s back—Katie and I figured out who he was the instant we saw him step out at the church, where Katie sat beside me in complete

silence during Saturday's February 6, 2016 ceremony so no tabloid could claim she had pulled a stunt as a Delegate while I spoke up—*"I object!"*—at *"Speak now or forever hold your peace."* Once Brittany bravely showed the minister and church coordinator the bruises Tyler had left on her in the side room, we brought her back to our Richmond apartment for Saturday night—where terrified Brittany climbed right into our latched walk-in closet with Katie and me and showed us her bruises before climbing into the sleeping bag, horrifying both of us and finalizing our decision on the spot to take her someplace Tyler would never think to look by bringing her all the way up to Washington on Sunday's *Meet the Nation* train so Aunt Karen, Uncle Steven, and Dad could meet her right outside the King Street–Old Town faregates. The very next afternoon—after a raging Tyler turned left off Earlton Court down the Macgregory Street dead end at two o'clock Monday dismissal, plowed through the fence into the steel frame rail of a departing Northwood High School bus so the bus driver and all fifty-four students escaped with bumps and bruises to get checked out at the hospital while Tyler was rushed under armed guard to the Level 1 Trauma Center at Tidewater General Hospital, left severely disabled for life and bound for a state medical prison—Brittany enrolled at the Coastal Adult Learning Center off Virginia Beach Boulevard to earn her HSE, got her life back together, and moved in to live with Katie and me on Arvin Road the moment the 2016 legislative session adjourned in March, just as she had promised us back in high school.

Then, in July of 2016—once Brittany had earned her HSE, joined Prairie Twin Interactive, and settled safely under our roof while our dad David was still alive to drive his wheelchair van straight up Interstate 95 with us and help bring her home—we rescued our thirty-four-year-old paternal cousin Chelsea from Braxton, Rhode Island. After Aunt Elizabeth and Grandma Ruth died in 2004 and Newport demolished the old World War II public housing on Tonomy Hill, Chelsea had tried living on her own in a private apartment, and because of her developmental delays it had fallen apart. Contracted out to Regalis Community House—a bleak brick group home tucked beside the dumpsters at the bottom of Mount Regalis on the campus of elitist King's College, where wealthy undergraduates looked down their noses from the upper stone balustrade while staff rode BTA Route 99 up the hill—Chelsea had spent eight miserable years under a two-faced male director whom she called Group Home Two-Face, who locked away her rescue inhaler, confiscated Shelly Turtle, worked residents at unpaid campus mailers, and hid behind a falsified 2008 probate form claiming Chelsea had no living next of kin. Armed with Aunt Liz's certified birth records and an emergency release order Dad, Katie, Brittany, and I won the next morning in the Braxton Municipal Probate Court, we rolled right back through King's College's main gate with a sheriff's deputy and brought a weeping, relieved Chelsea home to Virginia Beach so nobody would ever mistreat or abandon her again.

Twenty-seven years later, save for an occasional overnight Senate oversight trip, the four of us had shared one inseparable home every single week. Compensated privately through our software company, Prairie Twin Interactive, LLC—never a dime of taxpayer Senate payroll—Brittany lovingly ran our household and cared for Chelsea alongside us so that even after Dad passed away before the 2032 election, Chelsea never once had to deal with rotating strangers from an outside care agency whenever Katie and I were at the Capitol, and all four of us traveled together between our Virginia Beach home and Sunset Drive so Chelsea's routine never broke. Dragging Chelsea out to a noisy intersection full of shouting political reporters just so Katie could turn down a presidential draft movement she had never asked for was out of the question.

Even more than that, Katie and I knew firsthand what winning the 2044 presidential election and taking the oath on January 20, 2045 would actually do to the four of us.

“Mandy, is the tripod level?” Katie asked, rolling her SwiftChair into position right beside mine directly in front of the living room sofa so Brittany could rest her left hand warmly on Katie’s shoulder while Chelsea held tight to my left arm from the cushion behind me.

“Dead level, Senator,” Mandy said softly, checking the frame on my mPhone mounted beside the dining table. “Just the four of you in your own living room—zero campaign banners, zero podiums.”

“Before we hit record,” Katie said, turning her head slightly toward Sam, Mandy, and Sarah with the thorough legislative caution that had defined all eighteen years of her three Senate terms, “walk Nate and Brittany and me through the five folders one last time. If we upload this video tonight, who has to receive formal legal notice on Monday morning so that no draft committee, no state primary ballot, and no federal agency can ever wrap the four of us into the Secret Service bubble during the 2044 election?”

Sam picked up the five folders in order, ticking each one off cleanly.

“Folder One goes by courier Monday morning to the Secretary of Homeland Security and all five congressional leaders on the candidate-protection advisory committee under Title 18, Section 3056(a)(7),” Sam explained. “While a sitting President or Vice President is barred by statute from refusing Secret Service protection, Section 3056(a) explicitly provides that major-candidate protection may be declined. Your signed letter puts Homeland Security and the Senate and House leadership on formal advance notice that you are not a candidate for President or Vice President in 2044—and that even if anyone ever tried to designate you, you formally exercise your statutory right in advance to decline any Secret Service detail.”

“Folder Two is the fifty-state ballot shield,” Mandy continued, tapping a stack of crisp pages stamped with her Virginia notary seal. “Fifteen states—including Michigan, Wisconsin, Maryland, Oregon, Florida, Georgia, North Carolina, Tennessee, and Nebraska—have automatic media-recognition laws requiring their Secretaries of State to print on the presidential primary ballot every national figure discussed in the press unless that person files a sworn, notarized Affidavit of Non-Candidacy. We prepared notarized Affidavits of Non-Candidacy for every automatic-ballot Secretary of State and State Board of Elections in the country, swearing under oath that you are not and will not become a candidate in 2044.”

“Folder Three goes to the Federal Election Commission under 11 C.F.R. Section 100.3,” Sarah said, holding up the third packet, “formally disavowing every unauthorized ‘Draft Katie Prairie’ committee within the statutory thirty-day window so none of their fundraising can trigger federal candidate status. Folder Four goes to the Chair and the Secretary of the Democratic National Committee—your irrevocable Sherman declaration instructing the party that you refuse to participate in any debate, refuse the seating of any draft delegates, and will not accept a nomination from the convention floor and would not serve if elected. And Folder Five goes to the Virginia Department of Elections in Richmond confirming that you are retiring at the conclusion of your third Senate term on January 3, 2045.”

Katie looked at the five folders, looked up at Brittany and Chelsea behind us, and let out a long, relieved breath. Rolling over to the dining table first, she signed her clear, steady signature—*Katie Prairie*—across every notarized affidavit and statutory notice while Mandy pressed her embossed seal onto the final sheet, and then rolled right back beside my wheelchair in front of the sofa.

"Ready when you are, Nate," Katie said quietly, lacing the fingers of her left hand through my right hand while Brittany squeezed Katie's shoulder and Chelsea rested her chin happily against mine.

I tapped the wireless shutter remote in my palm, and the small red recording light glowed on my mPhone.

"Good evening from our home here in Virginia Beach," fifty-eight-year-old Katie said calmly into the quiet living room, her voice warm, unscripted, and crystal clear. "I am sitting here tonight with the three people who share every day of my life: my twin brother Nate, our cousin Brittany, and our cousin Chelsea. Over the past few months, governors, colleagues, and kind citizens across the country have asked me to enter the 2044 presidential race for the term beginning in January of 2045, and draft committees have begun circulating petitions in primary states. I am deeply grateful for your trust—and tonight, surrounded by my family, I want to tell you plainly why my answer is an irrevocable no."

Beside me, Katie gave my hand a gentle squeeze.

"Sixteen Octobers ago, Nate and I flew down to Chambers Field at Naval Station Norfolk aboard Air Force One with President Clara Morales," Katie continued evenly. "Clara Morales was an honorable President, and restoring our sailors' stolen housing and pier funds that day is one of the proudest memories of my Senate career. That Thursday was also the very first time Nate and I ever stepped inside the presidential Secret Service bubble. Even behind the gates of a military base, we watched every cross-street freeze thirty minutes ahead of our wheels, and we watched a good President realize she couldn't even take ten unscripted steps off a pre-swept carpet to buy a cold drink for herself. Under federal law, once you become President of the United States, you can never decline that bubble. Armed agents and armored motorcades shut down every street you touch, pull public buses out of service, and move permanently into your family's home."

Katie glanced affectionately back at Chelsea—who smiled shyly at the mention of home—and at Brittany beside her.

"Our cousin Chelsea survived an abusive group home before Nate and I brought her home to live with us, and she deserves a quiet, peaceful house where strangers and cameras never intrude," Katie said softly. "Our cousin Brittany, Nate, and I waited half a lifetime to keep our high-school promise to live together under one roof. And Nate and I fought our entire lives for the simple freedom to roll down to our corner bus stop on Military Highway, tap our fare passes alongside our neighbors, and go wherever we please unannounced. Monday morning, my staff is filing notarized Affidavits of Non-Candidacy with state election officials nationwide, disavowal notices with the Federal Election Commission, an irrevocable refusal of nomination with the Democratic National Committee, and formal declination notices under federal statute so I am never placed on a 2044 ballot or wrapped inside a Secret Service detail. When my third Senate term ends on January 3, 2045, I will retire

from elected office—though anyone seeking my endorsement in next spring's primary should be ready to talk to everyday Virginians without a motorcade. Thank you for eighteen wonderful years, and good night from all four of us."

"Good night!" Chelsea chimed in happily over my shoulder, giving a little wave with her free hand before I clicked the remote to stop the recording.

Saturday, October 24, 2043, 9:45 PM — Out of the Closet & Safe Together in Our Four-Person Nest

By quarter to ten that night, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah had walked back to their ranch house two streets over with the five sealed express-mail packets tucked safely in Sam's messenger bag, the unedited four-minute refusal video was quietly live on StreamCast, The Grid, and Chirp with comments turned off, and the brick ranch house on Arvin Road belonged completely to the four of us again. Before heading down the hall for bed, we had spent a quiet half hour piled together on the deep living-room sofa under our soft fleece throw—Chelsea curled contentedly against my right side, Brittany tucked right up against my left shoulder with her wire-rimmed glasses set on the end table as she hugged my arm, and Katie nestled right against Brittany and reaching across to hold my hand while the autumn wind rustled the oak leaves outside.

Now, down the widened hallway, the warm amber glow of two bedside lamps lit the spacious master bedroom sanctuary we had built both here on Arvin Road and up at Sunset Drive in Alexandria: a custom wall-to-wall, wheelchair-transfer-height four-person cuddle nest platform bed topped with deep orthopedic mattresses, soft flannel sheets, bolstered side rails, and an oversized patchwork navy-and-cream quilt.

For more than thirteen years after our estranged mother Brenda had bang-searched the back alley outside Apartment A6 at Greenway Court in August of 2003, Katie and I had been so conditioned by trauma and autism that the only place on earth we felt safe enough to fall asleep was zipped inside a single sleeping bag on a hard carpeted closet floor behind a latched door. Even though terrified Brittany had gratefully squeezed right into that windowless walk-in closet with us on her very first night rescued from the wedding in Richmond, once Brittany moved in with us on Arvin Road after session adjourned in March 2016 she had insisted on climbing right into our sleeping bag and pillows inside the bedroom closet so we never felt rushed—and when we rescued Chelsea from Regalis Community House that July, Chelsea had been so terrified that Group Home Two-Face might snatch her back through the window that she crammed right into the closet with the three of us too, leaving all four grown cousins wedged wall to wall inside two zipped-together sleeping bags on the closet carpet.

It had taken months of gentle, patient teamwork—first building our custom oak platform bed in September 2016, and then Brittany leading all four of us through zero-pressure twenty-minute chamomile-tea tries that stretched from twelve minutes in October to forty-five minutes on Thanksgiving night and a sunlit Sunday afternoon nap in January—before all four of us had finally felt safe enough on the night of February 11, 2017 to roll up our closet sleeping bags and come out of the closet for good.

Rolling my SwiftChair parallel to the smooth wooden transfer edge beside Katie's frame tonight, I locked my brakes, slid smoothly across onto the navy-and-cream patchwork quilt in my grey plaid flannel pajamas, and helped Katie settle onto the plush pillows to my left in her soft lavender knit sleepwear—Katie and Brittany happily trading off that inner spot next to my left shoulder from night to night so all three of them got their turn tucked right against my side—while Brittany set Chelsea's maintenance and rescue inhalers on the wooden headboard shelf within easy reach, helped Chelsea curl up cozily against my right shoulder in her warm cream thermal pajamas, and climbed in right beside Katie in her burgundy flannel pajamas, smiling through her thin silver wire-rimmed glasses as she wrapped one arm around Katie's shoulder and reached her other hand warmly across to clasp my forearm.

Katie let out a long, blissful groan as the thick mattress cradled her shoulders and lower back, lacing the fingers of her right hand through my left hand across my lap.

"Remember when we used to insist the hall closet carpet was perfectly comfortable?" my fifty-eight-year-old twin sister murmured sleepily.

Brittany laughed softly, leaning across Katie's shoulder to give my arm an affectionate squeeze before resting her cheek gently against Katie's hair. "It only took eleven months on that closet plywood—and four sets of knees wedged between the drywall studs—to get all of us onto a real mattress."

"Okay, fine," I admitted with a sheepish grin in the warm lamplight as Katie nodded in complete agreement against my shoulder. "Sleeping on carpeted closet floors really did hurt."

"Bed is soft," Chelsea murmured contentedly, snuggling closer against my right arm and resting her silver-streaked head right in the crook of my shoulder where nobody in a group home could ever yell at her again. "Just us four."

"Just us four, Chelsea," Brittany whispered affectionately across the pillows, her fingers still resting warmly over mine and Katie's.

Lying right there in the warm center of our four-person nest—with my sweet paternal cousin Chelsea breathing evenly and safely against my right shoulder, my twin sister Katie nestled against my left shoulder holding my hand, and my maternal cousin Brittany tucked right into our embrace just like that snowy evening in the Blizzard of '96 and all those afternoons on Earlton Court—I looked toward the two quiet SwiftChairs parked side by side in the soft glow and felt my whole chest relax.

Out in Washington and across fifty state capitals, politicians were spending hundreds of millions of dollars tonight fighting each other for the privilege of getting locked inside an armored limousine for the rest of their lives. Lying here cuddling directly with the three women I loved most in the world—my sister Katie, my cousin Brittany, and my cousin Chelsea—I already had the best spot on earth.

Part 2: The Biggest Prize in the Primary: Sam, Mandy, & Sarah's Bus-Loop Plan & Stop #0812

Date: 2044-01-29 at 13:15 America/New_York

Friday, January 29, 2044, 1:15 PM — Our Dining Room Table on Arvin Road

“That was the fifth presidential campaign manager since nine o’clock this morning,” forty-one-year-old Sarah Hawkins said, setting her tablet down on our wooden dining room table on Arvin Road as she took a seat beside her identical twin sister Mandy and their fraternal triplet brother Sam. “Governor Caldwell’s political director called twice, Senator Vance’s chief of staff called from New York, Congressman Pierce’s scheduler emailed three times, Governor Whitman’s team wants Thursday morning, and Governor Delgado’s chief of staff asked if you had twenty minutes on your Virginia Beach calendar next month.”

Sitting side by side in our brushed-silver and black motorized SwiftChair power wheelchairs across the dining table—just after our cousin Brittany had set out turkey sandwiches and ginger ales for all of us before settling onto the living room sofa behind us to work a jigsaw puzzle with our older cousin Chelsea—my fifty-eight-year-old twin sister Katie and I looked up from our plates.

“Why are they all calling on the same Friday afternoon?” Katie asked, taking a sip of her ginger ale.

Mandy turned her laptop screen toward our side of the table so Katie and I could read the lead story on the national political wire.

“Because the national primary tracking poll came out at noon,” Mandy said. “Ever since you uploaded your October refusal video from the living room with Nate, Brittany, and Chelsea—turning down the 2045 Presidency, filing all fifty state non-candidacy affidavits, and confirming you’re retiring from the Senate in January after three terms—forty-one percent of likely Democratic primary voters nationwide say their single top criterion for choosing a candidate is whoever Senator Katie Prairie endorses. The article literally calls your endorsement ‘the single biggest prize in the 2044 Presidential Primary.’”

“And every single one of those campaign managers expects the standard Washington endorsement routine,” Sam added, adjusting his sweater vest as he leaned his elbows on the table between his two sisters. “Senator Vance’s chief of staff asked me which private dining room at the downtown hotel in Norfolk he should reserve so the Senator can bring his policy binders and talk about offering you Secretary of Transportation or Health and Human Services. And Former Vice President Sterling’s advance team called asking if the Secret Service could sweep The Atlantic Grand Hotel down at the Oceanfront next week.”

Katie shook her head immediately. “Former Vice President Sterling is an automatic no. Ever since that very first day Nate and I spent inside President Morales’s Secret Service bubble flying into Chambers Field back in October of twenty-seven—watching every cross-street on the base get frozen solid and realizing Clara couldn’t even roll down to a corner store for a cold drink by herself—we knew we never wanted to live inside that glass jar. That’s a big reason I declined to run for President this year, I am not letting a motorcade pull public buses out of service in Hampton Roads, and I certainly don’t want a Cabinet job that puts Nate and me inside a government SUV.”

“We told them that,” Sarah grinned.

Looking across the dining table at Sam, Mandy, and Sarah, I couldn't help smiling at how little had changed between the five of us over the past twenty-eight years. We had first met them in January of 2016 when they were thirteen-year-old eighth-grade House Pages in Richmond who had just been rescued by their maternal uncle—former Republican House Majority Leader Richard Callaway—and Aunt Marge. They had worked for Katie through college in Richmond, moved up to Washington with us when Katie won her first Senate term in 2026, and stood beside our wheelchairs in Danville when we wept together at Uncle Richard's funeral after he passed away before Katie's 2038 re-election campaign, just a few years after Katie and I had lost our own dad, David Prairie.

Now forty-one years old, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah were still together every single day—sharing a townhouse a few blocks from our place on Sunset Drive in Alexandria when all four of us traveled up for Senate sessions and a ranch house two streets over from us here in Kempsville when we were home on Arvin Road. None of the three had ever married, none of them had ever had kids, and after learning years ago about the 2004 and 2005 Williamsburg and Ocean View nightmares Katie and I had survived together with Brandon Mercer and Tiffany Sloan, the triplets had never even gone looking for romantic partners. Just like Katie, Brittany, Chelsea, and me under our roof, the three of them knew that their safest, happiest life was the one they had built together.

Suddenly, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah exchanged a look across the dining table—the exact synchronous triplet glance we had seen a thousand times in Dirksen Room 511 whenever the three of them had cooked up a legislative ambush.

"Wait a minute," I said, setting my sandwich down. "I know that look. What did the three of you come up with?"

Sam reached into his canvas messenger bag, pulled out a folded paper Coastal Virginia Transit Authority system map, and spread it flat across the center of the dining room table.

"All of these presidential candidates think they're coming down to Virginia Beach to sit in a quiet office or a hotel conference room, read you talking points out of a three-ring binder, and leave after thirty minutes without ever meeting a single person who actually lives here," Sam said, tapping his index finger on the intersection of Military Highway and Indian River Road—just around the corner from our front door on Arvin Road. "What if we don't meet them in an office at all?"

"Look at the bus stop number right on the northeast corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road," Mandy said, pointing to the tiny blue rectangle printed on the CVTA map. "Your home bus stop is Stop #0812."

"And right behind Stop #0812 is the shopping center at Military Highway and Indian River Road," Sarah chimed in, her eyes sparkling. "If Nate sends their campaign schedulers a two-line calendar invite that just says *Military Highway and Indian River Road, Northeast Corner — #0812*, every single campaign advance team in Washington is going to assume #0812 is Suite 812 in that corner shopping plaza!"

Katie's blue eyes went wide, and a slow, delighted smile spread across her face. "They'll show up in their suits carrying their briefing binders looking for Suite 812—and find the five of us waiting at Bus Stop #0812!"

“And look at the schedule from Stop #0812 on Tuesday and Thursday mornings,” Sam said, tracing his finger north up Military Highway on the map. “We don’t notify CVTA ahead of time—because if CVTA management knows you’re interviewing presidential candidates on their buses, they’ll panic and send a brand-new bus with a road supervisor. Instead, the candidate gets the exact length of a four-seat regularly scheduled transit trip with the five of us to seek your endorsement:

“First, we catch the nine-eighteen northbound Route 15 right at Stop #0812 and ride it up Military Highway to Military Highway Station,” Sam continued. “Second, we roll up onto the platform for Route 800—The Surge Light Rail—and ride it one stop east from Military Highway Station to Newtown Road Station. Third, we transfer at Newtown Road Station to the ten o’clock Route 25 down Newtown Road and Princess Anne Road to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus. And fourth, after waiting out the twenty-nine-minute hourly transfer window at the CCHR campus bus loop, we catch the ten-fifty-three inbound Route 12 back along Lynnhaven Parkway, Kempsville Road, and Indian River Road right back to Stop #0812!”

“And because it’s regularly scheduled transit service,” Mandy added, “not only do you let the passengers and the bus operators ask the candidate questions—you actively encourage them to ask questions!”

“And what if a candidate gets on the bus and earns my endorsement?” Katie asked, looking around the table at the four of us.

“We don’t tell them at the bus stop,” I said, picking up the thread immediately as Katie and the triplets nodded. “When we get off the Route 12 back at Stop #0812, we say a polite goodbye, wheel ourselves right around the corner back home here to Arvin Road, and you and I talk it over quietly between the two of us. If the candidate doesn’t earn your endorsement, the video from my mPhone stays on our offline hard drive and never sees the light of day. And once we decide who you are endorsing, I simply upload the video of their bus ride quietly with no fanfare—and title the video so it’s clear to the whole country that this is the person you’re endorsing for President of the United States.”

Katie looked across the dining table at Sam, Mandy, and Sarah, and then over at me.

“Sam, Mandy, Sarah—that is the single best idea I have heard in eighteen years in the Senate,” Katie beamed, glancing fondly toward the living room where Brittany gave a thumbs-up behind her wire-rimmed glasses—happy to stay right here at home on Arvin Road with Chelsea during the two-hour morning loops so Chelsea’s quiet morning routine never changed. “And all three of you are riding every single loop right alongside Nate and me. Send the calendar invites for Stop #0812, Nate!”

Tuesday, February 2, 2044, 9:08 AM — Stop #0812 at Military Highway & Indian River Road

“Which door is your suite, Nate?” Senator Julian Vance of New York asked, adjusting the collar of his camel-hair overcoat as he stepped onto the concrete sidewalk at the northeast corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road at eight minutes past nine on Tuesday morning, February 2, 2044. He glanced past our two SwiftChair power wheelchairs—and past Sam, Mandy, and Sarah standing in their winter coats right beside us—toward the brick shopping center behind the sidewalk,

cradling a gold-embossed leather briefing binder titled *THE VANCE-PRAIRIE PARTNERSHIP FOR AMERICA* under his arm. “My advance team saw *Military Highway and Indian River Road — #0812* on your calendar invite and assumed #0812 was a professional office suite, and all I see is a Market Square grocery store, a dry cleaner, and a tax storefront.”

“There is no office suite, Julian,” Katie said pleasantly from her wheelchair, reaching up to tap the blue-and-white metal sign bolted to the steel pole beside her left wheel: *CVTA STOP #0812 — MILITARY HWY & INDIAN RIVER RD (ROUTES 12, 15)*. “You’re standing at it. Stop number zero-eight-one-two. This is Nate’s and my home bus stop.”

Senator Vance blinked down at the five of us as four lanes of morning traffic hummed past the intersection.

“I beg your pardon?” Vance said.

Down the right-hand curb lane of northbound Military Highway, the forty-foot blue-and-silver nine-eighteen CVTA Route 15 coach clicked on its right turn signal and eased toward the sidewalk behind two hospital housekeepers in teal scrubs and a young shipyard apprentice carrying a metal lunchbox.

“You’re joking, Katie,” Vance said, lowering his voice and glancing at the commuters stepping up to the curb as the air brakes hissed and the front suspension kneeled. “I flew down from LaGuardia at six-thirty this morning to sit down with you in private and offer you your choice of Transportation or Health and Human Services in a Vance Administration. Have Nate or one of your staffers call a ride-share van for your chairs—my people reserved a quiet boardroom at the downtown hotel in Norfolk.”

“I don’t want a Cabinet post, Julian,” Katie replied calmly as the aluminum wheelchair ramp folded out onto the concrete with three warning beeps. “We didn’t notify CVTA that we were riding today, so this is the regular nine-eighteen northbound Route 15. The five of us are riding it with you up to Military Highway Station, taking Route 800—The Surge Light Rail—one stop to Newtown Road Station, transferring to the ten o’clock Route 25 down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, and catching the ten-fifty-three inbound Route 12 back along Indian River Road to Stop #0812. You have the length of that trip to make your case—and because this is public transit, I encourage the passengers and operators to ask you questions while Nate records on his mPhone.”

Vance stared at the rubber flooring of the Route 15 entry vestibule, then at the two hospital housekeepers waiting behind him, and finally at Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me.

“Katie, be serious,” Vance said, his voice tightening. “I am a United States Senator running for President of the United States. I do not ride a city bus with random commuters for two hours, and I certainly don’t sit at a community-college bus shelter taking unvetted questions on a cell phone camera.”

“Then you don’t need to get on the bus, Julian,” Katie said evenly, keeping her wheelchair on the sidewalk and waving to our driver Darnell that the five of us weren’t boarding this run after all so he could pull the ramp back in and stay on schedule. “Have a safe flight back to New York.”

Vance stood on the concrete pad for three seconds, tucked his leather binder tightly under his arm, turned on his heel, and walked briskly back across the Indian River Road crosswalk toward his idling black luxury SUV.

As the Route 15 bus pulled back into traffic up Military Highway, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah looked down at Katie and me and burst out laughing in the crisp morning air.

“That took less than four minutes,” Sam grinned.

“And since Stop #0812 is our home bus stop,” Katie smiled, turning her SwiftChair around on the wide concrete sidewalk toward the shopping center right behind us, “we don’t even have to take a bus home. Let’s roll into the Market Square grocery store right here in the plaza, grab seven cold drinks so Brittany and Chelsea get theirs too, and wheel ourselves back around the corner to Arvin Road.”

That night at ten-fifteen, while Katie, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and I were finishing a late-evening transit markup in our living room on Arvin Road before the triplets walked back to their house two streets over, my mPhone buzzed on the end table.

It was the campaign manager for Governor Gary Whitman of Colorado—the moderate governor backed by three large private-equity hospital networks who was scheduled to meet us at Stop #0812 on Thursday morning.

“Nate, I’m calling with terrible news,” the campaign manager said breathlessly over the speaker. “Governor Whitman has to fly back to Denver tonight for an urgent state budget consultation, so we’re going to have to pass on Thursday morning’s meeting in Virginia Beach.”

“Understood,” I said politely. “Good luck with the budget.”

As soon as I tapped the red end-call icon, Mandy looked around the living room at the four of us.

“Julian Vance’s campaign manager called Whitman’s team and told them Marker #0812 is a city bus stop where nurses and college students get to ask questions on camera,” Mandy said.

“And Whitman’s healthcare donors would pull his funding in ten minutes if a Tidewater Health nurse pinned him down on private-equity hospital staffing ratios,” Sam agreed, picking up his coat as he and his sisters got ready to head home for the night. “See you both Tuesday morning for Governor Caldwell!”

Part 3: The First Tuesday on the Loop: Governor Harrison Caldwell on Routes 15, 800, 25, & 12

Date: 2044-02-09 at 09:10 America/New_York

Tuesday, February 9, 2044, 9:10 AM — Stop #0812 & Leg 1 Aboard CVTA Route 15 With Governor Harrison Caldwell

“Wait—a *bus*? Huh?!”

At ten minutes past nine on Tuesday morning, February 9, 2044, sixty-one-year-old Governor Harrison Caldwell of Illinois stood on the concrete sidewalk at Stop #0812 at Military Highway and Indian River Road in a tailored navy pinstripe suit, crimson silk tie, and dark wool overcoat, staring from the blue metal bus stop pole to the forty-foot CVTA Route 15 coach pulling into the curb lane behind a nurse in gray scrubs and a construction worker in a heavy canvas jacket. Across the street in the shopping plaza parking lot, four of Caldwell's campaign aides stood beside two rented black SUVs holding three-ring policy binders and silver thermal coffee carafes.

"Senator Prairie, you conduct your presidential endorsement interviews on board a regularly scheduled city bus—and the passengers and the bus driver get to ask me questions too?!" Caldwell asked, looking from our two SwiftChairs to Sam, Mandy, and Sarah standing in their coats right behind our wheelchairs.

"Every candidate gets the exact same route with the five of us, Governor," Katie said warmly from her SwiftChair. "We start right here at Stop #0812—which is Nate's and my home bus stop—on the nine-eighteen northbound Route 15 up to Military Highway Station, ride Route 800—The Surge Light Rail—one stop east to Newtown Road Station, catch the ten o'clock Route 25 down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, and transfer to the ten-fifty-three inbound Route 12 back along Indian River Road to Stop #0812. Your staff stays across the street. You have the length of that transit loop to tell us why you should be the next President of the United States."

Caldwell glanced back across the intersection at his aides, straightened his silk tie, and forced a broad campaign smile onto his face.

"Well! Nobody can say Harrison Caldwell doesn't love public transportation!" he declared, gesturing for one of his aides to run across the crosswalk and take his thick leather binder back to the SUV. "After you, Senator!"

Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: ramp is deploying!

Katie and I rolled up the aluminum ramp first, greeted Darnell in the driver's seat, tapped our passes against the reader, and backed our two SwiftChairs into the front securement bays while Sam, Mandy, and Sarah tapped their passes and took the row of seats immediately behind my wheelchair.

On the front steps beside the farebox, Caldwell pulled a crisp twenty-dollar bill out of his leather billfold and tried to slide it into the dollar-bill slot.

The machine beeped twice and spat the twenty back into his hand.

"Your farebox is jammed, driver," Caldwell said loudly, trying to push the twenty-dollar bill in a second time while three commuters waiting on the steps behind him shifted their weight in the cold air. "Just hand me four ones and two quarters out of your drawer."

Darnell looked up into his overhead mirror. "Sir, bus fareboxes don't make change. Exact fare only—four dollars and fifty cents for an all-day GoPass, or two dollars for a single ride."

“Who carries singles and quarters in 2044?” Caldwell muttered, patting his suit pockets until a sixty-year-old woman in a cafeteria coat standing behind him sighed, reached past his elbow, and fed two crumpled one-dollar bills and two quarters of her own into the slot so Darnell could print the pass and close the doors.

“Thank you, ma’am—I’ll have my staff reimburse you!” Caldwell told her hurriedly as the bus pulled away from Stop #0812.

Once Caldwell sat down on the sideways perimeter bench across the aisle from our wheelchairs, Katie turned her head toward the passengers filling the center rows and introduced him with genuine warmth.

“Good morning, everybody on the nine-eighteen northbound Route 15!” Katie called out clearly over the hum of the diesel engine as we crossed Indian River Road. “This is Governor Harrison Caldwell of Illinois, and he’s running for President of the United States. He’s riding with Nate, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me up to Military Highway Station, over on The Surge to Newtown Road, down Route 25 to CCHR, and back on the Route 12 to ask for my endorsement. Nobody gave him any questions in advance—so if you have a question for somebody who wants to be your next President, raise your hand and ask away!”

Two seats down the bench from Caldwell, the construction worker in the canvas jacket raised his hand.

“Governor,” the man said, “my dad worked thirty-four years at Norfolk Naval Shipyard, and my mom needs thirty hours a week of in-home Medicaid personal care here in Virginia Beach so she doesn’t get forced into a nursing home. Last month on a Sunday morning interview show, you said Congress needs a ‘bipartisan commission to rein in mandatory healthcare entitlements.’ When you say ‘entitlements,’ do you mean my mother’s home-care nurse?”

Instead of looking at the worker sitting two feet to his left, Caldwell angled his shoulders toward the front of the bus so he was speaking straight into the lens of my mPhone mounted on my laptop screen.

“What I have proposed is a commonsense, data-driven fiscal modernization framework that empowers state-level flexibility while preserving the safety net for the truly needy,” Caldwell said in his polished debate-stage baritone.

“Sir, I’m sitting right here to your left,” the worker said evenly. “And I asked whether ‘state-level flexibility’ means cutting my mom’s thirty hours a week.”

“Well, every state’s actuarial tables and block-grant formulas are going to look a little different,” Caldwell replied, tapping his knee as the bus slowed for the turn into Military Highway Station.

Tuesday, February 9, 2044, 9:34 AM — Route 800 (*The Surge* Light Rail), Route 25 to CCHR, Route 12, & Our Decision at Home on Arvin Road

At Military Highway Station, we rolled off the Route 15 ramp and up the sloped concrete walkway with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah onto the center platform for Leg 2: CVTA Route 800, *The Surge* Light Rail.

When the sleek silver-and-blue two-car electric train glided up to the level boarding strip and the double doors chimed open, Katie and I rolled straight into the mobility bay inside the vestibule with Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and Caldwell stepping in beside us for the three-minute, one-stop ride eastbound to the terminus at Newtown Road Station.

Looking around the light-rail car as the train accelerated along the interstate sound wall, Caldwell chuckled and shook his head.

“Now this is a cute little three-minute trolley ride, Senator,” Caldwell said, loud enough for the entire vestibule to hear. “Though as a chief executive, I have to ask—why are we taking a train for one single stop just to wait nineteen minutes at the next station for a bus? In the business world, we’d call that a massive scheduling inefficiency.”

Across the vestibule, a thirty-something respiratory therapist in Tidewater Health scrubs with a stethoscope around her neck looked up from her phone.

“We’re only riding it one stop because suburban politicians spent thirty years blocking this light-rail line from crossing Newtown Road into Virginia Beach to reach the hospital and the community college,” she told him flatly. “And we wait nineteen minutes at Newtown Road Station because Washington cut transit operating aid. By the way, Governor—since that lady on the first bus had to pay your fare, do you even know what a single bus ride costs without looking at the sign?”

Caldwell hesitated, caught without a briefing card. “A single ride—what, ten or twelve dollars depending on the zone?”

Two commuters by the rear doors laughed out loud as the train glided into Newtown Road Station, while behind my shoulder Sam, Mandy, and Sarah exchanged a quiet glance.

During our nineteen-minute wait at the Newtown Road Station bus loop, Caldwell paced back and forth beside the brick shelter checking his gold wristwatch four separate times. When the ten o’clock outbound CVTA Route 25 coach pulled in and carried us down Newtown Road and Princess Anne Road toward the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, a twenty-year-old CCHR student in a manual wheelchair asked Caldwell whether he supported Katie’s federal Wheelchair Right-to-Repair bill; Caldwell spent three minutes talking about “protecting medical-device intellectual property incentives” before cutting the student off to ask Sam how much longer the ride to the college took.

When we rolled down the Route 25 ramp at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus loop at ten-twenty-three and Sam reminded him that the inbound Route 12 ran on an hourly headway—meaning our next bus back to Stop #0812 didn’t depart until ten-fifty-three—Caldwell spent almost the entire twenty-nine-minute layover standing twenty feet away from the bus shelter with his phone pressed to his ear, talking to his campaign manager in Chicago while Katie, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and I chatted with the CCHR students waiting on the bench.

On the ten-fifty-three inbound CVTA Route 12 back along Lynnhaven Parkway, Kempsville Road, and Indian River Road, Caldwell barely answered the two retired shipyard electricians who asked him about Social Security, keeping his eyes fixed on the front windshield until I pressed the yellow stop-request strip approaching Military Highway.

At eleven-twenty, the Route 12 driver deployed the ramp right in front of the blue sign at Stop #0812.

As we rolled onto the sidewalk and Caldwell's four aides came hurrying across the Indian River Road crosswalk from the parking lot with his leather binder, the Governor of Illinois beamed as if he had just aced a Sunday morning talk show.

"Well, Senator Prairie, Nate—what a fantastic morning out here with the good people of Virginia Beach!" Caldwell said, shaking Katie's hand and mine warmly. "My political director will follow up with your office tomorrow on the rollout timing for the endorsement!"

"Thank you for riding the loop with us, Governor Caldwell," Katie said politely from her wheelchair, giving nothing away on the sidewalk. "Have a safe flight back to Illinois."

We waited until Caldwell climbed into his black SUV, and then Katie and I—with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah walking right beside our SwiftChairs—turned around the corner onto Indian River Road and wheeled ourselves home to our brick ranch house on Arvin Road.

Inside our house, after Chelsea gave my shoulder a happy hug at the doorway and went into the kitchen with Brittany, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah to put a big pot of soup on the stove, Katie and I rolled into the living room and parked our wheelchairs facing each other to make our decision privately between the two of us.

"Well, Nate?" Katie asked quietly, looking across at me. "What do you think?"

"He didn't know how a bus farebox works, he guessed a single ride costs twelve dollars, he talked into my camera lens instead of looking a shipyard worker in the eye, and he told a CCHR student in a wheelchair that manufacturer software locks are 'intellectual property incentives,'" I said evenly. "And during the twenty-nine-minute transfer wait at CCHR, he stood twenty feet away on his phone instead of talking to a single student at the shelter."

"He treated the bus and the passengers like an inconvenience he had to endure for two hours to get a press release," Katie agreed, shaking her head slowly. She reached across our armrests and placed her hand over mine. "Are we agreed? No endorsement for Governor Caldwell?"

"Agreed," I said.

Opening the video folder on my MagnaBook Pro, I dragged the two-hour recording from February 9 into our offline archive drive—never to be uploaded—before Katie and I rolled into the dining room to eat hot soup with Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah.

Part 4: The Second Tuesday on the Loop: Representative Devon Pierce on Routes 15, 800, 25, & 12

Date: 2044-02-16 at 09:10 America/New_York

Tuesday, February 16, 2044, 9:10 AM — Stop #0812, Leg 1 on CVTA Route 15, & Leg 2 on Route 800 (*The Surge* Light Rail)

“Wait—you mean we’re actually getting *on* the bus? For two hours?”

At nine-ten on Tuesday morning, February 16, 2044, forty-four-year-old Representative Devon Pierce of California stood on the concrete pad at the northeast corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road with a glossy briefing folder in one hand and a paper cup of espresso in the other, looking up from our two brushed-silver and black SwiftChair power wheelchairs—and from Sam, Mandy, and Sarah standing beside us—to the blue metal sign marked *CVTA STOP #0812 — MILITARY HWY & INDIAN RIVER RD (ROUTES 12, 15)*.

“We thought *Military Highway and Indian River Road — #0812* was an office suite in the plaza behind you,” Pierce said, glancing over his shoulder at his press secretary waiting near the crosswalk.

“No office suite, Congressman,” Katie smiled from her wheelchair as the forty-foot blue-and-silver nine-eighteen northbound CVTA Route 15 coach signaled into the right-hand curb lane behind three morning commuters. “Stop #0812 is our home bus stop, and every candidate gets the exact same route with the five of us: we board the nine-eighteen Route 15 right here up to Military Highway Station, ride Route 800—The Surge Light Rail—one stop east to Newtown Road Station, transfer to the ten o’clock Route 25 down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, wait twenty-nine minutes at the campus bus loop, and catch the ten-fifty-three inbound Route 12 back along Indian River Road to Stop #0812. Your press secretary stays here, and every passenger and operator on board is invited to ask you questions.”

Pierce stared at the approaching bus for a second, then looked down at my mPhone clipped to the top bezel of my MagnaBook Pro. Suddenly, a wide grin spread across his face.

“I love it! Working-class transit with the folks who build America!” Pierce declared, tossing his espresso cup into the curbside trash can, handing his briefing folder back to his press secretary, and unbuttoning the top two buttons of his dress shirt under his tailored charcoal jacket as the Route 15 bus kneeled at the curb. “Let’s roll, Senator!”

Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: ramp is deploying!

After Katie and I rolled up the aluminum ramp, greeted Darnell at the wheel, tapped our passes, and backed our wheelchairs into the opposing front ADA securement bays while Sam, Mandy, and Sarah tapped their passes and took the row of seats behind my chair, Pierce stepped aboard, fed a five-dollar bill into the farebox without asking for the fifty cents difference on the four-dollar-and-fifty-cent 1-Day GoPass, and took a seat on the perimeter bench across from us.

As the bus pulled away from Stop #0812 and accelerated north up Military Highway, Katie turned her head toward the center aisle and introduced him with the same open warmth she gave every contender.

“Good morning, everybody on the nine-eighteen northbound Route 15!” Katie called out clearly. “This is Congressman Devon Pierce of California, and he’s running for President of the United States. He’s riding with Nate, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me up to Military Highway Station, over on The Surge to Newtown Road, down Route 25 to CCHR, and back on the Route 12 to ask for my endorsement. Nobody gave him any questions in advance—so if you have a question for somebody who wants to be your next President, raise your hand and ask away!”

Two rows behind the front wheel well, a sixty-two-year-old retired shipyard machinist named Mr. Henderson—wearing a navy windbreaker with a Veteran’s Medical Center appointment slip in his breast pocket—raised his hand.

“Congressman,” Mr. Henderson said, “I put in thirty-six years as a marine machinist down at the shipyard before my knees gave out. Every few years somebody in Washington proposes switching the Social Security and federal retirement cost-of-living formula to the chained consumer price index, which cuts thousands of dollars out of a retiree’s check over ten years. Where do you stand on that?”

Instead of answering from his seat, Pierce stood up in the moving aisle, walked two steps back to Mr. Henderson’s row, dropped onto one knee beside the aisle seat, and turned his face three-quarters of the way back toward the front of the bus so he was looking straight into the lens of my mPhone rather than at Mr. Henderson.

“Folks, look at the calluses on this working man’s hands!” Pierce boomed toward my camera, gesturing at Mr. Henderson’s knuckles set on the armrest. “When I look into the eyes of a Virginia shipyard patriot like you, sir, I see my own grandfather’s lunchpail—”

“Son,” Mr. Henderson interrupted calmly, pulling his hand back onto his lap, “you aren’t looking into my eyes. You’re looking at the phone on that young man’s laptop up front. Sit down before the driver hits the brakes for the interstate ramp, and tell me whether you’re voting for or against the chained-CPI cut.”

In the row behind me, Sarah hid a quiet cough behind her hand as Pierce’s smile flickered. Standing back up as Darnell braked for the red light at Corporate Boulevard, Pierce stepped quickly back to the front perimeter bench.

“I oppose any reduction in promised retirement benefits, sir,” Pierce said, smoothing his jacket lapels before glancing at my camera lens again.

At nine-thirty-one, Darnell pulled the Route 15 bus into the transit loop at Military Highway Station. We rolled down the ramp and up the sloped concrete walkway with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah onto the covered island platform for Leg 2: CVTA Route 800, *The Surge* Light Rail.

Two minutes later, the silver-and-blue two-car electric train glided up to the level boarding strip. Katie and I rolled straight through the wide sliding doors into the vestibule mobility bay with the triplets right beside us and locked our brakes as the doors chimed shut for the three-minute, one-stop ride eastbound to Newtown Road Station.

We had barely cleared the station platform when Pierce reached into his jacket pocket, pulled out his own mPhone, switched the screen to the front-facing selfie camera, and stepped directly behind the gap between Katie's wheelchair and mine—leaning down between our shoulders with a thumbs-up grin to snap a photo of himself with our two wheelchairs without asking either of us.

Katie didn't raise her voice, and she didn't turn her head.

"Put your phone in your pocket, Congressman," Katie said evenly over the quiet hum of the electric traction motors. "Our wheelchairs are how my brother and I move through the world. They are not props for your campaign feed."

Across the vestibule, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and four morning commuters watched in silence as Pierce lowered his arm, clicked his screen off, and slipped the phone back into his coat pocket just as the train glided into Newtown Road Station.

Tuesday, February 16, 2044, 9:58 AM — Leg 3 on CVTA Route 25 to CCHR, Leg 4 on Route 12, & Our Decision at Home on Arvin Road

After waiting out the nineteen-minute transfer window at the Newtown Road Station bus loop, we rolled up the front ramp of the ten o'clock outbound CVTA Route 25 coach—*GLENROCK / NEWTOWN RD STATION / CCHR VIRGINIA BEACH / PRINCESS ANNE HOSPITAL*—and clicked our floor straps tight while Sam, Mandy, and Sarah took the bench behind us for the twenty-three-minute run down Newtown Road and Princess Anne Road toward the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus.

Seated across the aisle just behind the front wheel housing were two siblings who rode Route 25 to campus every Tuesday and Thursday morning: twenty-two-year-old Jasmine, wearing her royal-blue CCHR Nursing polo shirt, and her nineteen-year-old brother Marcus, a sophomore CCHR computer-science student whose collapsible manual wheelchair was fitted with a clamping power-assist joystick mount very much like the backup chairs our dad had bought Katie and me after Hurricane Isabel.

As the bus turned onto Princess Anne Road, Katie smiled down the aisle and introduced Pierce to the Route 25 riders, inviting anyone on board to ask him a question before we reached the college.

Marcus raised his left hand clearly.

"Congressman Pierce," Marcus said, his voice steady over the hum of the air conditioning, "when the control module on my wheelchair joystick shorted out last semester, the manufacturer refused to sell the replacement part to our local repair shop here in Virginia Beach and locked the diagnostic calibration behind a proprietary dealer code, leaving me waiting eleven weeks for a five-minute repair. And when I finish my software engineering degree next year, if I save more than

two thousand dollars in the bank, federal SSI and Medicaid rules threaten to strip the home-care waiver I use every morning. Will you sign Senator Prairie's Wheelchair Right-to-Repair Act and her SSI Asset Cap Elimination Act?"

Pierce stood up from the perimeter bench with a broad, sympathetic smile, stepped over to their row, patted Marcus once on the shoulder, and looked right over the top of Marcus's head to speak directly to his able-bodied sister Jasmine—while angling his torso back toward my camera.

"First of all, young lady, let me just say how deeply inspiring it is that you bring your brother to campus with you every morning so he can be around the college environment," Pierce said in a loud, warm stage voice addressed entirely to Jasmine. "Caregivers like you are the unsung angels of our healthcare system. What's your brother's name, sweetheart, and how long have you been taking care of him?"

Inside the front half of CVTA Route 25, every conversation stopped dead.

Across from me, Katie sat perfectly still in her SwiftChair, while behind my shoulder Sam, Mandy, and Sarah stiffened in unison.

Jasmine didn't say a word. Keeping her hands folded calmly in her lap on the blue vinyl bus seat, she pointed her right index finger six inches to her side—straight at her brother.

Marcus looked up at the forty-four-year-old Congressman with a level, matter-of-fact expression.

"My name is Marcus, Congressman," Marcus said clearly into the quiet bus. "I'm a second-year computer-science major at CCHR with a three-point-nine GPA, my sister isn't 'bringing me around the college environment,' and I asked you the question myself. Why are you talking to my sister over my head like I can't speak?"

Pierce froze in the center aisle, his mouth opening slightly as he looked down at Marcus, then at Jasmine, and then back at Katie, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me.

"I—of course, Marcus, I was just—I was acknowledging your family's support network," Pierce stammered, his face flushing red as he backed awkwardly into his perimeter seat. "On the—on the repair question, I strongly support bringing medical-device innovators and consumer advocates to the table to streamline warranty turnarounds…"

At ten-twenty-three, the Route 25 coach pulled into the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus transit loop on College Crescent. As Marcus and Jasmine rolled down the ramp ahead of us toward the Science and Technology building, Katie called out warmly, "Good luck on your data-structures midterm, Marcus! See you Thursday, Jasmine!"

"Thanks, Senator Prairie! See you Thursday, Nate!" Marcus called back over his shoulder.

During our twenty-nine-minute transfer wait at the CCHR campus shelter before the ten-fifty-three inbound CVTA Route 12 arrived, Pierce paced back and forth beside the bike racks in the chilly breeze, walking over twice to ask me whether I edited the videos before posting them.

“We don’t edit anything, Congressman,” I told him politely.

On the twenty-seven-minute inbound Route 12 ride back along Lynnhaven Parkway, Kempsville Road, and Indian River Road, Pierce stayed seated quietly on the perimeter bench, answering a retired postal clerk’s question about prescription drug prices in two short sentences before looking out the window the rest of the way to Military Highway.

When the Route 12 ramp deployed back at Stop #0812 at eleven-twenty, Pierce shook Katie’s hand and mine on the sidewalk.

“Senator, Nate—thank you for taking me out on the routes today,” Pierce said earnestly. “I hope you know my heart is in the right place for working families and the disability community, and I’d be honored to have your support.”

“Thank you for riding the loop with us, Congressman,” Katie replied evenly. “Have a safe flight back to California.”

Once Pierce walked across the Indian River Road crosswalk to meet his press secretary, Katie and I—with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah walking right beside us—turned our SwiftChairs down the sidewalk from our home bus stop and wheeled ourselves back around the corner to our house on Arvin Road.

While Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah set out sandwiches and apple slices in the dining room, Katie and I parked our wheelchairs side by side in the living room to talk over the interview quietly between the two of us.

“He looked right over Marcus’s head and asked Jasmine what his name was,” Katie said softly, her voice tight with the shared memory of every stranger who had ever patted our heads or talked over our wheelchairs to Dad when we were growing up. “And on The Surge, he tried to take a selfie with our chairs without even asking us.”

“And on Route 15, he knelt in the aisle and talked to my camera lens instead of looking Mr. Henderson in the eye,” I added. “Are we agreed on Congressman Pierce?”

“We’re agreed,” Katie nodded firmly. “No endorsement.”

I moved the February 16 video file into our offline archive drive and closed my laptop lid. Only one appointment remained on our calendar for Thursday morning at nine-ten: Governor Elena Delgado of Michigan.

Part 5: The Thursday Morning Loop: Governor Elena Delgado & The Six O’Clock Upload

Date: 2044-02-18 at 09:10 America/New_York

Thursday, February 18, 2044, 9:10 AM — Stop #0812 & Leg 1 Aboard CVTA Route 15 to Military Highway Station

“Good morning, Senator Prairie! Good morning, Nate! Good morning, everyone! Are we meeting in the corner office behind the dry cleaner, or is the entrance around back?”

At ten minutes past nine on a crisp, forty-six-degree Thursday morning—February 18, 2044—fifty-four-year-old Governor Elena Delgado of Michigan stepped onto the concrete sidewalk at the northeast corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road wearing a sensible navy wool peacoat, flat walking shoes, and a knit scarf, carrying a black leather briefing binder tucked under one arm and a worn canvas tote bag over her shoulder as she greeted Katie, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me.

"Neither one, Governor Delgado," fifty-eight-year-old Katie smiled from her SwiftChair, reaching up to tap the blue-and-white metal bus stop sign bolted to the pole beside her wheel: *CVTA STOP #0812 — MILITARY HWY & INDIAN RIVER RD (ROUTES 12, 15)*. "This is Marker #0812—Nate's and my home bus stop. Our nine-eighteen northbound Route 15 bus is pulling up to the signal right now. The five of us are riding the 15 with you up to Military Highway Station, taking Route 800—The Surge Light Rail—one stop to Newtown Road Station, catching the ten o'clock Route 25 down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus, waiting twenty-nine minutes at the campus bus loop, and transferring to the ten-fifty-three Route 12 back here to Stop #0812. You have the length of that trip to ask for my endorsement, your chief of staff stays here, and every passenger on the buses and the train is invited to ask you questions."

For two full seconds, Elena Delgado stood motionless on the Virginia Beach sidewalk, looking from the blue metal bus stop pole to our two wheelchairs, to Sam, Mandy, and Sarah, and then down Military Highway at the forty-foot blue-and-silver CVTA Route 15 coach signaling into the right-hand curb lane behind a postal worker and two hospital aides.

Then, right there on the corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road, she threw her head back and laughed—a warm, genuine, delighted laugh that made all five of us smile.

"A two-hour city bus and light-rail loop with the regular morning riders instead of a stuffy conference room?" Delgado grinned, turning on her heel to hand her thick leather briefing binder straight back to her wide-eyed chief of staff waiting at the edge of the crosswalk. "Hold my binder, Carla, and go grab yourself some breakfast—I won't need talking points where we're going! Tell the hotel I'll be back around noon!"

Turning back toward the curb as the Route 15 bus hissed to a stop and kneeled its front air suspension, Delgado unsnapped her wallet inside her canvas tote bag, pulled out four one-dollar bills and two quarters, and stepped aside so the postal worker, the hospital aides, our two wheelchairs, and Sam, Mandy, and Sarah could board ahead of her.

Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: ramp is deploying!

Our driver Darnell raised both eyebrows when he saw the Governor of Michigan step up to his farebox behind our group, feed four singles and two quarters cleanly into the slot for a four-dollar-and-fifty-cent 1-Day CVTA GoPass card, and say, "Good morning, sir—thank you for driving."

Once Katie and I backed our SwiftChairs into the two opposing front ADA securement bays and clicked our SafeLock floor straps tight while Sam, Mandy, and Sarah took the row of seats immediately behind my wheelchair, Katie looked down the center aisle as the bus pulled away from Stop #0812 and accelerated north up Military Highway toward the Interstate 264 interchange.

“Good morning, everybody on the nine-eighteen northbound Route 15!” Katie called out warmly. “This is Governor Elena Delgado of Michigan, and she’s running for President of the United States. She’s riding with Nate, Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and me up to Military Highway Station, over on The Surge to Newtown Road, down Route 25 to CCHR, and back on the Route 12 to ask for my endorsement. Nobody gave her any questions in advance—so if you have a question for somebody who wants to be your next President, raise your hand and ask away!”

Halfway down the bus, a forty-five-year-old marine pipefitter in a heavy canvas jacket with a shipyard badge clipped to his collar raised his hand before we even passed Elizabeth River Way.

“I’ll go first, Senator!” the pipefitter called out over the diesel hum as Governor Delgado sat down in the sideways perimeter seat across from our wheelchairs, tucked her canvas tote bag between her flat shoes, and turned to look directly at the pipefitter—never once glancing at the mPhone mounted on my MagnaBook Pro. “Governor, my wife works at Lake Taylor Transitional Care Hospital and I work the early shift in the yards. Back in twenty-seven, Garrett Thorne and Bret Halverson treated defense workers and sailors in Hampton Roads like stage props while steering four hundred million dollars to offshore shell companies—and then corporate Democrats come down here and talk about cutting transit operating aid to balance the budget. If you’re President, what happens to the shipyard workforce and the buses my wife rides to the hospital?”

Leaning forward with her hands clasped loosely over her knees as the bus rolled past the car dealerships on Military Highway, Delgado answered him directly:

“First, not a single shipyard contract leaves public accountability on my watch—every dollar of Navy fleet maintenance and submarine construction stays tied to union prevailing-wage standards and domestic audit trails like the ones Senator Prairie and Nate wrote into the 2028 Defense Logistics Transparency Act,” Delgado said clearly. “And second, a bus without a driver and fuel is just a paperweight. For forty years Washington loved cutting ribbons on capital projects while starving local transit agencies of the day-to-day operating money required to pay operators like our driver up front and run buses every fifteen minutes instead of once an hour. If Senator Prairie puts the Universal Transit Operating Partnership Act on my desk in the Oval Office, I’ll sign it the same afternoon.”

Up in the driver’s seat, Darnell tapped his horn button once in approval and called back over his shoulder in the rearview mirror, “Tell her to put overtime tax relief for night-shift bus operators in that bill too, Governor!”

“Sam’s already writing that down in his notebook, Darnell!” Delgado laughed as Sam grinned and jotted the note onto his legal pad in the seat behind me.

Thursday, February 18, 2044, 9:34 AM — Leg 2 on Route 800 (*The Surge* Light Rail) & Leg 3 on CVTA Route 25 to CCHR

At nine-thirty-one, Darnell pulled the Route 15 bus into the transit loop beside the interstate embankment at Military Highway Station, kneeled the suspension, and deployed the front ramp.

“Thank you, Darnell!” Katie and I called out as we rolled off the ramp with Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and Governor Delgado walking right beside us up the gently sloped concrete access ramp onto the covered center island platform of CVTA Route 800: *The Surge* Light Rail.

Two minutes later, the dual overhead catenary wires hummed, a bell chimed twice, and a sleek silver-and-blue articulated two-car light-rail train glided to a smooth halt along the level boarding tactile strip with its amber destination display reading *800 THE SURGE — NEWTOWN ROAD STATION*.

Because the platform height matched the train floor to the millimeter, Katie and I rolled straight through the wide double sliding doors without needing a lift or ramp, locking our SwiftChair brakes in the open mobility bay just inside the vestibule as Sam, Mandy, Sarah, and Delgado stepped aboard and the electric traction motors hummed eastbound along the rail right-of-way.

Standing by the window handhold beside Mandy and Sarah, Elena Delgado looked south across the interstate sound wall toward the Norfolk–Virginia Beach city line.

“Look out that window, Elena,” Katie said as the train glided smoothly at forty-five miles an hour. “This light-rail line opened in 2011 and stops dead right here at Newtown Road on the city line because for decades suburban politicians used coded fearmongering about ‘who rides public transit’ to block regional rail from crossing into Virginia Beach cleanly. Every time a working mother or a wheelchair user has to get from Norfolk to the community college or the hospital in Virginia Beach, they have to roll off this train at Newtown Road Station and wait in the weather for an hourly bus.”

Sitting across from our chairs in the vestibule, a twenty-nine-year-old paralegal in a trench coat nodded vigorously.

“I do this transfer every morning, Governor,” the paralegal chimed in. “Three minutes on the train, and then if the Route 25 or Route 27 is running late, you’re standing in the wind for forty minutes.”

“We fought the exact same regional transit boundary wars between Detroit, Oakland County, and Macomb County in Michigan,” Delgado answered, looking directly at the paralegal as the train eased into the concrete platform at Newtown Road Station. “When I’m President, Federal Transit Administration New Starts and Small Starts capital matching grants are going to carry a statutory anti-balkanization bonus: municipalities that tear down artificial city-line transfer walls and run seamless, high-frequency cross-border rail and bus rapid transit get an eighty-five-percent federal match.”

Stepping off *The Surge* at Newtown Road Station at nine-forty-one, we rolled across the brick bus loop to the Route 25 shelter for our nineteen-minute transfer wait.

Delgado sat right down on the perforated metal bus bench beside our two SwiftChairs and the triplets, pulled a small spiral notebook out of her canvas tote bag, and spent all nineteen minutes talking with a retired Navy hull technician waiting for the bus and asking Sarah and me how our PHP and SQL accessibility auditing scripts tested federal agency websites for screen-reader and keyboard-navigation compliance.

At nine-fifty-eight, the forty-foot CVTA Route 25 coach—*GLENROCK / NEWTOWN RD STATION / CCHR VIRGINIA BEACH / PRINCESS ANNE HOSPITAL*—pulled into the bay and kneeled.

Because CVTA had zero advance notice that we were riding, the bus that pulled up on Route 25 was a twelve-year-old coach whose hydraulic front wheelchair ramp gave a stubborn metallic click halfway out and stalled two inches above the concrete curb.

While the operator—a veteran driver named Terrance—flipped the ramp reset switch to cycle the hydraulic arm a second time, Delgado stepped smoothly to the side of the open front doorway beside Sam to block the cold crosswind for an elderly woman seated near the farebox until the ramp settled flat against the concrete on the second cycle and Katie and I rolled aboard.

Sitting right across the aisle behind the front wheel well—on their regular Tuesday-Thursday morning commute to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus—were twenty-two-year-old Jasmine in her royal-blue CCHR Nursing polo shirt and her nineteen-year-old brother Marcus in his manual wheelchair with its clamping power-assist joystick attachment.

When Katie introduced Governor Delgado to the Route 25 riders and invited questions as the bus turned onto Princess Anne Road, Marcus raised his hand.

“Governor Delgado,” Marcus said clearly, “when the controller module on my wheelchair joystick broke last autumn, the manufacturer locked the diagnostic software behind a proprietary dealer code and made me wait eleven weeks for a five-minute repair—and if I earn more than two thousand dollars in my summer software-engineering internship, Medicaid and SSI threaten to cut off my home-and-community-based personal-care waiver. What are you going to do about both of those?”

Delgado stayed seated on the perimeter bench across the aisle so she was looking straight into Marcus’s eyes on a level plane, speaking directly to him.

“Marcus, locking a person’s mobility hardware behind proprietary software DRM so an independent repair shop in Virginia Beach can’t swap out a controller module should be illegal under federal law,” Delgado said, her voice steady and clear. “Senator Prairie and Nate have been fighting the durable-medical-equipment lobby for six years to pass the National Wheelchair Right-to-Repair and 48-Hour Loaner Mandate Act. As President, I won’t even wait for the lobbyists to stall in committee: on Day One, my Center for Medicare and Medicaid Services Administrator will issue a binding national procurement rule prohibiting Medicare and Medicaid from reimbursing any wheelchair manufacturer that refuses to provide open diagnostic codes, schematics, and at-cost replacement parts to wheelchair users and independent repair techs.”

Marcus's eyebrows went up, and beside him, Jasmine smiled warmly.

"And on your second question," Delgado continued, keeping her eyes locked with Marcus's as the Route 25 bus crossed Lynnhaven Parkway toward the CCHR campus, "forcing disabled Americans to stay trapped in enforced poverty with less than two thousand dollars in the bank just to keep the Medicaid personal-care waivers or SSI benefits you need to get dressed and go to work is cruel and backwards. When Jasmine finishes her nursing degree and you finish your software engineering degree, you should be able to take that internship, save for a home, and get married one day without ever losing a single hour of your personal-care waiver. Send me Senator Prairie's SSI and Medicaid Waiver Freedom to Work and Marry Act, and I will sign it."

"Thank you, Governor," Marcus said, nodding as the front half of the Route 25 bus applauded. "That's the first straight answer I've heard all week."

Thursday, February 18, 2044, 10:53 AM — Leg 4 on Route 12 Back to Stop #0812, Our Decision at Home on Arvin Road, & The Quiet Upload

At ten-twenty-three, the Route 25 coach pulled into the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus transit loop on College Crescent.

Because CVTA Route 12 (*South Norfolk / CCHR Virginia Beach*) operated on a sixty-minute headway, the next inbound Route 12 bus back toward Military Highway and Indian River Road wasn't scheduled to depart the campus loop until ten-fifty-three—twenty-nine minutes away.

Walking inside the student center lobby with Mandy and Sarah, Elena Delgado bought eight bags of salted pretzels and eight bottles of cold ginger ale from the vending machines with her own dollar bills—insisting on sending two bags and two cold bottles home in Mandy's tote bag for Brittany and Chelsea once Mandy mentioned our cousins waiting for us back on Arvin Road—and came right back outside to the CCHR bus shelter. For the next twenty-five minutes, sitting on the bench beside our two SwiftChairs and the triplets with a pretzel in her hand while students walked past between classes, she asked Katie and me about our 2003–2005 classes in the Information Systems lab across the quad, listened to how our dad had gone back to college right here at CCHR after seeing our seventh-grade HTML homework at Morrison Middle School, and chatted with a fifty-year-old custodial worker waiting for the ten-fifty-three bus.

At ten-fifty-three on the dot, all six of us boarded the inbound CVTA Route 12 coach and rode the final twenty-seven minutes west along Princess Anne Road, up Lynnhaven Parkway and Kempsville Road, and onto Indian River Road—where Delgado fielded three more unscripted questions from a preschool teacher, a retired Navy electrician, and a grocery clerk before I reached up from my SwiftChair and pressed the yellow stop-request strip just past Kempsville Plaza.

At eleven-twenty, the Route 12 bus pulled to the curb right in front of the blue metal sign at Stop #0812 at Military Highway and Indian River Road, completing our two-hour-and-two-minute four-seat circle.

As we rolled down the front ramp onto the concrete sidewalk with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah and the Route 12 bus merged back into traffic, Elena Delgado shook Katie's hand, mine, and each of the triplets' hands warmly.

"Thank you all for taking me on your loop today," Delgado said as she spotted her chief of staff Carla walking over from the coffee shop across the intersection with her leather binder. "Whatever you decide, those two hours on the 15, The Surge, the 25, and the 12—and meeting Marcus and Jasmine at CCHR—were the best two hours I've spent on this entire campaign."

"Thank you for riding with us, Elena," Katie smiled from her wheelchair, giving nothing away on the sidewalk. "Have a safe flight back to Michigan."

Once Elena Delgado and her chief of staff walked back across the crosswalk toward their sedan, Katie and I—with Sam, Mandy, and Sarah walking alongside our SwiftChairs—turned down the sidewalk from Stop #0812, rounded the corner onto Indian River Road, and wheeled ourselves home to our brick ranch house on Arvin Road.

Inside, while Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah toasted grilled cheese sandwiches and heated tomato soup in the kitchen—Chelsea beaming over the cold bottle of ginger ale and salted pretzels Elena had sent home for her—Katie and I rolled into the living room and parked our wheelchairs facing each other to make our decision quietly between the two of us.

"Well, Nate?" Katie asked softly. "What do you think?"

"She handed her briefing binder back to her chief of staff without blinking, paid her own four-dollar-and-fifty-cent fare at the box, stood beside Sam to block the cold wind for an older passenger while Terrance cycled the sticky ramp on Route 25, and looked Marcus straight in the eye as an equal," I said, smiling across at my twin sister. "And she never once looked at my camera lens the entire two hours."

"Not once," Katie beamed, her blue eyes shining as she reached across our armrests to lace her fingers through mine. "She's the one, Nate. Are we agreed?"

"One hundred percent agreed," I said.

When we rolled into the dining room and told Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah what the two of us had decided, everyone around the table broke into wide grins.

We didn't call a press conference, we didn't send a media advisory to the cable networks, and we didn't even call Elena Delgado's campaign manager to give them a heads-up.

Instead, sitting right there beside Katie at our dining room table on Arvin Road with Brittany, Chelsea, Sam, Mandy, and Sarah gathered warmly behind our shoulders, I transferred the raw, unedited two-hour-and-two-minute video file from my mPhone onto my MagnaBook Pro, logged into our channel on StreamCast, The Grid, and Chirp, and quietly uploaded the entire bus ride with zero fanfare—typing a single plain-text video title so that the title itself told the world who Katie was endorsing for President of the United States:

Why I Am Endorsing Elena Delgado for President of the United States — A Two-Hour Ride on CVTA Routes 15, 800 (The Surge), 25, & 12 from Stop #0812

Katie leaned her wheelchair in beside mine, rested her cheek against my left shoulder while Chelsea hugged my right shoulder and Brittany rested her hand across Katie's back—all four of us safe at home where we belonged—and watched as I clicked *Publish*.